DISCOVERING THE TRUTH

A Guide to the Study of the Holy Scriptures



41 BIBLE STUDY CHAPTERS

English Edition | King James Version (KJV)

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A Guide to the Study of the Holy Scriptures for All Nations

English Edition — King James Version (KJV)

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EDITORIAL NOTE

This edition presents the full 41-chapter English manuscript. Scripture quotations are identified as King James Version (KJV). Biblical interpretation reflects a Seventh-day Adventist doctrinal perspective; historical facts, biblical statements, and theological interpretations should be distinguished when reading.

This is an assembled review edition. A full independent verification of every biblical reference and embedded quotation has not yet been certified.

PREFACE

Why study the Holy Scriptures? Because the great questions of human existence—our origin, the meaning of life, the problem of evil, salvation, and our destiny—deserve a careful examination of the Word of God.

This book offers a progressive journey through forty-one Bible studies. It begins with the nature and authority of Scripture, presents God's character and His creative work, and then examines the human condition, sin, grace, and the salvation offered through Jesus Christ. It goes on to address Christian life, God's commandments, the seventh-day Sabbath, the Church and its mission, before exploring death, resurrection, Christ's return, judgment, and the great biblical prophecies.

Each chapter follows a question-and-answer approach, accompanied by biblical references, contextual explanations, and doctrinal notes. Summaries, reflection questions, and suggested prayers invite readers to move beyond intellectual knowledge alone and examine their faith and conduct.

The doctrinal orientation of this book is that of Seventh-day Adventist faith. It affirms, among other teachings, the supreme authority of the Bible, salvation by grace through faith in Jesus Christ, the continuing validity of the Ten Commandments, the biblical seventh-day Sabbath—Saturday—the resurrection of the dead, and the hope of the Savior's visible return. When prophetic texts receive differing interpretations among Christian traditions, the book seeks to distinguish what a passage explicitly says from the theological interpretation proposed.

Readers are invited to check references in context, compare related passages, and exercise respectful discernment. No human commentary should replace Scripture. Doctrinal conviction does not exclude humility, charity, or freedom of conscience.

May these studies lead each reader to know more deeply the God revealed in the Holy Scriptures, to place their trust in Jesus Christ, and to live in the hope of His return.

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CHAPTER 1 — THE HOLY SCRIPTURES: THE WORD OF GOD

A Thematic Bible Study — King James Version (KJV)

Chapter Objective

To discover what the Bible is, understand its divine origin, inspiration, authority, and purpose, and establish sound principles for studying and interpreting the Scriptures.

Central Teaching: The Bible is the inspired Word of God and the supreme authority for Christian faith, doctrine, and conduct. Every religious teaching must be examined in the light of Scripture.

Question 1 — What Is the Bible?

Answer:

The Bible is the collection of sacred writings through which God reveals His character, His works, His will, and His plan of salvation for humanity.

It consists of two major divisions:

- The Old Testament.
- The New Testament.

The Old Testament records Creation, the history of Israel, God's covenant promises, the ministry of the prophets, and the expectation of the coming Messiah.

The New Testament presents the life and ministry of Jesus Christ, His death and resurrection, the establishment of the apostolic Church, and the promise of His glorious return.

These two Testaments form one unified revelation of God's redemptive purpose.

The Bible is therefore more than a historical record, a collection of moral principles, or a work of religious literature.

It is the inspired testimony through which God makes known the way of salvation.

Bible References:

- Luke 24:27
- John 20:30–31
- 2 Timothy 3:15–17

Explanatory Note:

The Old and New Testaments must not be treated as opposing revelations. They testify to the same God and reveal the progressive unfolding of His plan of redemption, centered upon Jesus Christ.

Question 2 — Who Is the Author of the Holy Scriptures?

Answer:

God is the ultimate source of the Holy Scriptures.

He communicated His message through human authors inspired by the Holy Spirit.

The biblical writers lived in different periods, belonged to different communities, and wrote within different historical circumstances.

They expressed God's message through their own language, literary abilities, experiences, and personalities.

Nevertheless, Scripture affirms that the Holy Spirit guided their testimony.

The apostle Paul declares:

> “All scripture is given by inspiration of God, and is profitable for doctrine, for reproof, for correction, for instruction in righteousness:”

2 Timothy 3:16 — KJV

The divine origin of Scripture establishes its authority.

Its human authorship explains the diversity of literary forms, historical settings, and expressions found throughout the Bible.

Bible References:

- 2 Timothy 3:16
- 2 Peter 1:20–21
- 2 Samuel 23:1–2

Doctrinal Note:

Biblical inspiration should not be reduced to the idea that every writer mechanically received a word-for-word dictation. In the Seventh-day Adventist understanding, the Holy Spirit inspired the biblical writers, who communicated God's message through genuine human language.

Question 3 — Is the Bible Trustworthy?

Answer:

Yes. The Bible presents the Word of God as true, trustworthy, and enduring.

Jesus Himself identified God's Word with truth.

In His prayer to the Father, He declared:

> “Sanctify them through thy truth: thy word is truth.”

John 17:17 — KJV

The believer's confidence in Scripture rests upon its divine origin and the testimony it gives concerning God's character and saving work.

This confidence should lead to serious study rather than careless interpretation.

The authority of Scripture does not mean that every human explanation of Scripture is automatically correct.

A teacher, preacher, religious organization, or individual believer may misunderstand a passage.

Therefore, interpretations must continually be tested against the biblical text.

Bible References:

- John 17:17
- Psalm 119:160
- Matthew 24:35

Explanatory Note:

The Bible is the authority; human interpretations are accountable to it. Recognizing this distinction protects believers from confusing divine revelation with human opinion.

Question 4 — Why Did God Give Us the Scriptures?

Answer:

God gave the Scriptures so that humanity could know Him, understand His plan of salvation, and learn to live according to His will.

The Bible reveals the seriousness of sin, the love of God, and the salvation offered through Jesus Christ.

It also instructs believers in righteousness, corrects wrongdoing, and prepares them for a life of faithful service.

The apostle Paul explains that Scripture is profitable for doctrine, reproof, correction, and instruction in righteousness.

The purpose of Bible study is therefore not merely the accumulation of religious information.

God's Word is intended to shape our understanding, character, decisions, and relationship with Him.

Bible References:

- 2 Timothy 3:15–17
- John 20:31

- Romans 15:4

Explanatory Note:

Biblical knowledge becomes spiritually fruitful when it leads to faith in Jesus Christ and a life transformed by God's grace.

Question 5 — Did Jesus Christ Recognize the Authority of Scripture?

Answer:

Yes. Jesus Christ repeatedly appealed to the Holy Scriptures as authoritative.

When Satan tempted Him in the wilderness, Jesus answered by quoting the written Word of God.

In His teaching, He used Scripture to explain God's will, correct false interpretations, and reveal the meaning of His mission.

After His resurrection, He explained to His disciples the passages concerning Himself in Moses and the prophets.

Jesus also affirmed that Scripture cannot be broken.

His example establishes an essential principle for Christian discipleship: God's Word must govern our beliefs and decisions.

A doctrine cannot become true merely because it is popular, ancient, or supported by an influential religious authority.

It must agree with Scripture.

Bible References:

- Matthew 4:1–11
- Luke 24:25–27
- John 10:35

Explanatory Note:

Jesus' use of Scripture demonstrates that believers should approach the Bible with reverence, confidence, and a willingness to obey its teachings.

Question 6 — How Should We Interpret the Bible Correctly?

Answer:

The Bible must be studied carefully, respecting the context of each passage and the teaching of Scripture as a whole.

A verse should not be separated from its setting and used to support an idea that the passage does not actually teach.

Sound biblical interpretation requires several essential practices:

1. Read the verses before and after the passage being studied.

2. Identify the speaker, audience, and circumstances.

3. Recognize the literary form, whether historical narrative, poetry, prophecy, parable, or instruction.

4. Compare passages that address the same subject.

5. Distinguish direct biblical statements from conclusions drawn through interpretation.

6. Allow clear biblical teachings to guide the understanding of more difficult passages.

7. Seek the guidance of the Holy Spirit with humility and sincerity.

The account of the Bereans provides a valuable example. They examined the Scriptures to determine whether the teachings they heard were true.

Bible References:

- Nehemiah 8:8
- Acts 17:11
- Luke 24:27

- 2 Timothy 2:15

Explanatory Note:

Isaiah 28:9–10 is sometimes used to establish a method of comparing isolated biblical phrases. However, its immediate context concerns a prophetic confrontation with the leaders of Judah. The broader practice of comparing Scripture is better demonstrated by Jesus' teaching and the Bereans' examination of the Word.

Question 7 — Can Human Traditions Replace the Word of God?

Answer:

No. Human traditions must never be placed above the commandments and teachings of God.

Jesus condemned religious practices that caused people to disregard God's Word.

Traditions may preserve useful historical memories or cultural customs, but they do not possess authority to overturn divine instruction.

The decisive question is not whether a teaching has been practiced for many centuries.

The decisive question is whether it agrees with the Holy Scriptures.

This principle applies to every Christian community, including our own.

For example, the fourth commandment identifies the seventh day as the Sabbath of the LORD.

The existence of a later religious tradition concerning Sunday does not change the biblical identity of the seventh day.

Bible References:

- Mark 7:6–13

- Colossians 2:8
- Isaiah 8:20
- Exodus 20:8–11

Doctrinal Note:

Scripture must remain the supreme standard for evaluating religious doctrines, customs, and practices. No human authority may legitimately cancel a divine commandment.

Question 8 — Why Is It Important to Compare Biblical Passages?

Answer:

Comparing biblical passages helps believers understand the full teaching of Scripture concerning a particular subject.

One passage may introduce a truth that another explains more fully.

For example, Genesis presents God's creative work and His rest on the seventh day.

Exodus 20 connects the Sabbath commandment with Creation.

The Gospels record Jesus' teaching concerning the proper observance of the Sabbath.

Studying these passages together provides a fuller understanding than reading only one verse.

The same principle applies to salvation, faith, grace, the law, baptism, the state of the dead, the resurrection, and the return of Jesus Christ.

However, comparison must respect the original context of each passage.

The goal is not to collect isolated phrases that appear to support a predetermined conclusion.

The goal is to discover the consistent teaching of God's Word.

Bible References:

- Luke 24:27
- Acts 17:11
- 1 Corinthians 2:12–13
- 2 Timothy 3:16–17

Explanatory Note:

A sound biblical doctrine must rest upon the careful examination of relevant passages rather than upon an isolated expression detached from its meaning.

Question 9 — Is the Message of the Bible Intended for Only One Nation?

Answer:

No. God's plan of salvation is intended for people of every nation, language, and background.

God called Abraham and promised that all families of the earth would be blessed through him.

Israel received a special role in the history of divine revelation, but God's purpose was never limited to one ethnic or national community.

After His resurrection, Jesus commanded His disciples to make disciples of all nations.

The Book of Revelation also presents the everlasting Gospel as a message proclaimed to every nation, kindred, tongue, and people.

The Bible therefore contains a universal invitation.

Every person is called to know the Creator, receive salvation through Jesus Christ, and respond to His Word.

Bible References:

- Genesis 12:3
- Matthew 28:18–20

- Revelation 14:6
- Galatians 3:26–29

Explanatory Note:

No nationality, language, or cultural background excludes a person from the invitation of the Gospel.

Question 10 — Does the Bible Reveal Everything Human Beings Might Want to Know?

Answer:

No. The Bible reveals what God has chosen to communicate concerning His character, His will, His plan of salvation, and the destiny of humanity.

It does not claim to answer every possible question about the universe or divine mysteries.

Moses declared that the secret things belong to the LORD, while the things revealed belong to His people.

This distinction establishes an important principle.

Where Scripture speaks clearly, believers should accept its teaching.

Where Scripture does not provide sufficient information, human speculation must not be presented as divine certainty.

The limitations of our knowledge do not weaken the authority of God's revelation.

They remind us that human understanding is finite.

Bible References:

- Deuteronomy 29:29
- John 21:25
- 2 Peter 3:15–16

Explanatory Note:

A clear doctrinal conclusion should be stated firmly when supported by Scripture. Questions that Scripture does not answer should not be settled through unsupported assertions.

Question 11 — Why Are Some Biblical Passages Difficult to Understand?

Answer:

Some passages are difficult because they were written in historical, cultural, linguistic, and literary circumstances different from our own.

Others contain symbolic language, prophecy, poetry, or expressions whose meaning requires careful examination.

The apostle Peter acknowledged that certain things in Paul's letters are difficult to understand.

Such difficulties call for patience, prayer, and disciplined study.

Believers should examine the context, compare related passages, and avoid interpretations that contradict the clear teaching of Scripture.

A difficult passage should not be used to overturn a doctrine firmly established through other biblical texts without a careful examination of the evidence.

At the same time, we must never force a passage to say something it does not say.

Bible References:

- 2 Peter 3:15–16
- Luke 24:44–45
- Proverbs 18:13
- Acts 17:11

Explanatory Note:

Faithfulness to Scripture requires both confidence in divine revelation and honesty about the limits of human interpretation.

Question 12 — What Attitude Should We Have When Studying the Bible?

Answer:

We should study the Bible with humility, sincerity, reverence, patience, and a willingness to obey God.

The purpose of Bible study is not to win arguments or demonstrate intellectual superiority.

It is to understand the truth revealed by God and allow that truth to transform our lives.

The psalmist prayed for God to open his eyes so that he might behold wonderful things from the divine law.

Jesus taught that willingness to do God's will is connected with recognizing the truth of His teaching.

James instructed believers to become doers of the Word rather than hearers only.

A sincere student of Scripture must therefore be prepared to abandon an error when God's Word reveals the truth.

Bible References:

- Psalm 119:18
- John 7:17
- James 1:22–25

Explanatory Note:

True humility does not require uncertainty about every biblical doctrine. It requires submission to God's Word and openness to correction when our understanding is mistaken.

Question 13 — Who Is at the Center of the Bible's Message?

Answer:

Jesus Christ stands at the center of the biblical plan of salvation.

The Scriptures reveal His identity, His mission, His sacrifice, His resurrection, His heavenly ministry, and the promise of His return.

After His resurrection, Jesus explained how the Scriptures testified concerning Him.

He also taught that the Scriptures bear witness to His person and mission.

The Bible should therefore not be treated as a collection of religious rules disconnected from the Savior.

God's commandments reveal His will, but salvation is found through Jesus Christ.

His life reveals the character of the Father.

His death demonstrates the seriousness of sin and the depth of divine love.

His resurrection establishes the believer's hope.

His promised return points toward the final fulfillment of God's plan of redemption.

Bible References:

- Luke 24:27
- John 5:39
- John 14:6
- Colossians 1:15–20
- Hebrews 1:1–3

Doctrinal Note:

Placing Jesus Christ at the center of Scripture does not diminish the importance of the law, the prophets, or biblical prophecy. It enables believers to understand their place within God's unified plan of salvation.

Question 14 — What Should We Do After Discovering a Biblical Teaching?

Answer:

When we discover a biblical teaching, we are called to receive it with faith, examine it carefully, and put it into practice.

Knowledge of God's Word brings responsibility.

Jesus taught that those who hear the Word of God and keep it are blessed.

He also connected love for Him with obedience to His teaching.

James warned against hearing the Word without putting it into practice.

Biblical truth is therefore not intended to remain merely theoretical.

It should influence our worship, our decisions, our conduct, and our relationship with God and other people.

However, obedience must never be understood as a means of purchasing salvation.

Salvation is the gift of God's grace through Jesus Christ.

Genuine obedience is the fruit of faith and love.

Bible References:

- Luke 11:28
- John 14:23
- James 1:22
- Ephesians 2:8–10

Explanatory Note:

The believer's responsibility is not merely to recognize biblical truth but to respond to it faithfully, trusting in the grace and power of Jesus Christ.

Chapter Summary

The Bible is the inspired Word of God, communicated through human writers guided by the Holy Spirit.

It reveals God's character, explains the problem of sin, and presents the plan of salvation through Jesus Christ.

It is the supreme standard for Christian faith, doctrine, and conduct.

Our study establishes the following fourteen teachings:

1. The Bible consists of the Old and New Testaments, which form a unified revelation.

2. God is the ultimate source of Scripture, and the Holy Spirit guided its human writers.

3. God's Word is trustworthy and true.

4. Scripture teaches, corrects, instructs, and leads humanity toward salvation.

5. Jesus Christ recognized and affirmed the authority of Scripture.

6. The Bible must be interpreted according to context and its overall teaching.

7. Human traditions cannot legitimately replace God's commandments.

8. Comparing related passages helps establish sound biblical doctrine.

9. The message of salvation is intended for all nations.

10. Scripture reveals what God has chosen to make known, not every possible mystery.

11. Difficult passages require patient and careful examination.

12. Bible study must be approached with humility, faith, and a willingness to obey.

13. Jesus Christ stands at the center of the biblical plan of salvation.

14. Biblical truth must be received and practiced through faith and love.

Doctrinal Conclusion

The Holy Scriptures are the inspired Word of God and the supreme authority for Christian faith and doctrine.

The Bible does not derive its authority from human tradition, ecclesiastical decisions, or the opinions of religious leaders.

Its authority rests upon its divine origin.

Every doctrine must therefore be examined in the light of Scripture.

This principle applies to all subjects addressed in this book, including Creation, salvation, the law of God, the seventh-day Sabbath, baptism, the state of the dead, the resurrection, divine judgment, and the second coming of Jesus Christ.

The believer must distinguish between what Scripture explicitly teaches and what human beings conclude through interpretation.

Sound doctrine requires faithful study, careful comparison of passages, and submission to God's revealed Word.

The Essential Message:

The Bible is God's inspired Word. It is the supreme authority for faith and Christian life. Its teachings must be studied in context, accepted with faith, and practiced through the grace of Jesus Christ.

Personal Reflection Questions

1. Do I base my beliefs upon the Bible or primarily upon traditions I have received?

2. Do I take time to examine the teachings I hear in the light of Scripture?

3. Am I willing to correct my convictions when God's Word reveals that I have misunderstood something?

4. What place does the Bible truly occupy in my daily decisions?

Suggested Prayer

Lord God,

Open my understanding so that I may comprehend Your Word.

Give me a humble, sincere heart that is willing to receive the truth.

Help me not to follow human opinions blindly, but to examine the Holy Scriptures carefully.

Teach me to distinguish Your revealed will from human traditions and interpretations.

Give me courage to accept Your truth and put it into practice.

May Your Word guide my steps, transform my character, and lead me continually closer to Jesus Christ.

In His holy name.

Amen.

Remember

The Bible does not merely invite us to hear about the truth. It calls us to seek it, examine it, believe it, and put it into practice.

CHAPTER 2 — WHO IS GOD?

His Nature, Character, and Revelation

A Thematic Bible Study — King James Version (KJV)

Chapter Objective

To discover, through the Holy Scriptures, who God is, what His essential attributes are, how He reveals His character to humanity, and why knowing Him is fundamental to Christian faith.

Central Teaching: There is one eternal God—Father, Son, and Holy Spirit—who created all things, whose character is perfectly loving, holy, just, and merciful, and who reveals Himself most fully through Jesus Christ.

Question 1 — Does God Really Exist?

Answer:

Yes. The Holy Scriptures affirm the existence of God as the eternal Creator of heaven and earth.

The Bible begins with this declaration:

> “In the beginning God created the heaven and the earth.”

Genesis 1:1 — KJV

Scripture does not begin by presenting a philosophical demonstration of God's existence. It declares Him to be the source of Creation.

The natural world bears witness to His power, wisdom, and divine authority.

The psalmist declares that the heavens proclaim the glory of God.

The apostle Paul likewise teaches that God's invisible attributes are revealed through the things He has made.

Faith in God is therefore founded upon His revelation and His works.

However, observing Creation alone does not provide a complete knowledge of God's character or His plan of salvation.

For that knowledge, humanity needs the revelation of the Holy Scriptures and, above all, Jesus Christ.

Bible References:

- Genesis 1:1
- Psalm 19:1
- Romans 1:19–20
- Hebrews 11:6

Explanatory Note:

The Bible presents God's existence as a foundational truth. Creation bears witness to its Creator, while Scripture reveals His identity, character, and saving purpose.

Question 2 — Did God Have a Beginning?

Answer:

No. God is eternal.

He was not created, and His existence does not depend upon any power outside Himself.

Everything in the created universe depends upon Him, but He depends upon nothing created.

Human beings experience time through beginnings, changes, and endings.

God, however, is presented in Scripture as existing from everlasting to everlasting.

The psalmist declares:

> “Before the mountains were brought forth, or ever thou hadst formed the earth and the world, even from everlasting to everlasting, thou art God.”

Psalm 90:2 — KJV

God's eternity distinguishes Him from all created beings.

He is the source of life and existence.

He has neither a created origin nor an end.

Bible References:

- Psalm 90:2
- Isaiah 40:28
- Revelation 1:8
- 1 Timothy 1:17

Doctrinal Note:

God's eternity is not simply an extremely long period of existence. It means that He is uncreated and is not dependent upon the created order for His life.

Question 3 — Is God the Creator of All Things?

Answer:

Yes. The Bible teaches that God created heaven, earth, and everything that exists.

He is not a created being who received His power from another source.

He is the origin of all created existence.

The Scriptures also reveal the participation of Jesus Christ in Creation.

John 1 teaches that all things were made through the Word.

Colossians 1 declares that all things were created through Christ and for Him.

Creation therefore reveals God's sovereignty, wisdom, and authority.

It also establishes humanity's responsibility toward the Creator.

The world does not belong to humanity independently of God.

Human beings are creatures entrusted with the responsibility of caring for what He has made.

Bible References:

- Genesis 1:1
- Psalm 33:6, 9
- John 1:1–3
- Colossians 1:16–17
- Revelation 4:11

Doctrinal Note:

God's identity as Creator provides the foundation for the biblical Sabbath. Genesis 2:1–3 records that God blessed and sanctified the seventh day, and Exodus 20:8–11 connects the Sabbath commandment with His creative work.

Question 4 — Can Human Beings Truly Know God?

Answer:

Yes. God desires to make Himself known to humanity.

Although human understanding is limited, Scripture teaches that a genuine knowledge of God is possible.

God reveals Himself through Creation, His Word, His actions in history, and especially through Jesus Christ.

The prophet Jeremiah teaches that true glory is found in knowing and understanding the LORD.

Jesus also connects eternal life with knowing the only true God and Jesus Christ whom He has sent.

Knowing God therefore means more than acknowledging His existence.

It includes understanding His character, trusting His promises, accepting His salvation, and developing a personal relationship with

Him.

Human beings cannot comprehend every dimension of God's infinite nature.

Nevertheless, they can truly know Him through the revelation He has given.

Bible References:

- Jeremiah 9:23–24
- John 17:3
- Romans 1:19–20
- John 1:18

Explanatory Note:

The distinction is between knowing God truly and knowing Him exhaustively. Scripture makes genuine knowledge possible without claiming that finite human beings can fully comprehend the infinite Creator.

Question 5 — What Is the Character of God?

Answer:

The Bible reveals God as holy, righteous, merciful, compassionate, patient, faithful, and loving.

These attributes are not competing characteristics.

They belong together in His perfect character.

God's love does not cancel His justice.

His justice does not eliminate His mercy.

His holiness does not make Him indifferent to human suffering.

When God revealed Himself to Moses, He proclaimed His mercy, patience, goodness, and faithfulness.

The same revelation also affirmed that God does not treat guilt and evil as insignificant.

God's character is therefore perfectly balanced.

He is compassionate toward sinners while remaining opposed to sin.

His judgments are righteous, and His mercy expresses His desire to restore those who turn to Him.

Bible References:

- Exodus 34:6–7
- Deuteronomy 32:4
- Psalm 145:8–9
- 1 Peter 1:15–16

Doctrinal Note:

God's love and justice must never be presented as contradictory. Both are essential to understanding His character and His plan of salvation.

Question 6 — Is God Love?

Answer:

Yes. The Bible explicitly declares that God is love.

The apostle John writes:

> “He that loveth not knoweth not God; for God is love.”

1 John 4:8 — KJV

Love is not merely an occasional action performed by God.

It belongs to His very character.

God's love is revealed through His patience toward humanity, His compassion for sinners, and His desire to save those who are lost.

Its greatest manifestation is the gift of Jesus Christ.

God did not wait for humanity to become righteous before demonstrating His love.

Christ died for sinners.

However, divine love does not mean that God approves every human action.

Because God loves humanity, He desires to deliver people from sin and its destructive consequences.

His love seeks restoration, forgiveness, and transformation.

Bible References:

- 1 John 4:8–10
- John 3:16
- Romans 5:8
- Ephesians 2:4–5

Explanatory Note:

God loves sinners and offers them salvation through Jesus Christ. His love does not remove the distinction between righteousness and sin.

Question 7 — Is God Just When He Judges Evil?

Answer:

Yes. God is perfectly just.

He never acts with injustice, partiality, or moral corruption.

His judgments are consistent with His holy character.

The Bible teaches that righteousness and justice are the foundation of His throne.

When Abraham interceded concerning Sodom, he appealed to the righteousness of the Judge of all the earth.

God's justice means that evil will not remain forever without judgment.

At the same time, Scripture reveals His patience and mercy.

God calls sinners to repentance and offers them the opportunity to receive salvation.

His judgment is therefore neither arbitrary cruelty nor indifference toward wrongdoing.

It is the righteous response of a holy God to sin.

Bible References:

- Psalm 89:14
- Genesis 18:25
- Romans 2:5–11
- 2 Peter 3:9

Doctrinal Note:

God's final judgment must be understood in harmony with His love, righteousness, mercy, and holiness. The definitive destruction of evil will be examined in later chapters.

Question 8 — Is God All-Powerful, All-Knowing, and Present Everywhere?

Answer:

Yes. The Scriptures reveal God as omnipotent, omniscient, and omnipresent.

God is omnipotent.

He possesses unlimited divine power and sovereign authority over Creation.

Nothing can defeat His ultimate purpose.

God is omniscient.

He knows all things, including human thoughts, motives, actions, and the course of history.

Nothing is hidden from His knowledge.

God is omnipresent.

His presence is not confined to one geographical location.

No place in Creation lies beyond His knowledge and sustaining presence.

Psalm 139 describes God's intimate knowledge of the human person and His presence wherever one may go.

These attributes distinguish the Creator from all created beings.

Bible References:

- Jeremiah 32:17
- Psalm 139:1–12
- Isaiah 46:9–10
- Matthew 19:26

Theological Note:

The terms omnipotence, omniscience, and omnipresence summarize biblical teachings. They are useful theological expressions, but their meaning must remain grounded in Scripture.

Question 9 — Does God Change With Time?

Answer:

God does not change in His essential character, righteousness, love, truth, or faithfulness.

His promises are trustworthy because He is not subject to the moral instability that characterizes human beings.

The prophet Malachi records God's declaration that He does not change.

James likewise describes God as the One with whom there is no variableness or shadow of turning.

This divine constancy does not mean that God is inactive.

Scripture records that He responds to prayer, intervenes in history, warns sinners, shows mercy, and acts according to His righteous purposes.

These actions do not represent changes in His holy character.

They reveal His consistent dealings with human beings in different circumstances.

Bible References:

- Malachi 3:6
- James 1:17
- Numbers 23:19
- Hebrews 13:8

Explanatory Note:

God's unchanging character must not be confused with an absence of personal relationship or historical action. He remains faithful to His nature while interacting with His creatures.

Question 10 — Is There One God or Many Gods?

Answer:

There is only one true God.

The Bible consistently rejects the worship of multiple gods and the worship of idols.

Israel was commanded to recognize the LORD as the only true God.

The prophet Isaiah records God's declaration that there is no other God besides Him.

The New Testament maintains this same truth.

Christian faith is therefore monotheistic.

The biblical revelation of the Father, the Son, and the Holy Spirit does not establish three separate gods.

In the Seventh-day Adventist understanding, the one God is revealed as Father, Son, and Holy Spirit.

These three divine Persons share the unity of the Godhead.

The distinction between them does not divide the divine nature into three independent deities.

Bible References:

- Deuteronomy 6:4
- Isaiah 45:5–6
- 1 Corinthians 8:4–6
- Ephesians 4:4–6
- Matthew 28:19

Doctrinal Note:

The Christian doctrine of the Trinity affirms one God, not three gods. The relationship between the Father, the Son, and the Holy Spirit will be examined more fully in the chapter devoted to the Trinity.

Question 11 — Does the Bible Distinguish the Father, the Son, and the Holy Spirit?

Answer:

Yes. The Bible distinguishes the Father, the Son, and the Holy Spirit while revealing their unity in the divine work.

At the baptism of Jesus, the Son is baptized, the Spirit descends, and the Father's voice is heard from heaven.

These are not presented as three names for one Person performing different roles.

The Gospel account distinguishes them.

Jesus also speaks of the Father sending another Comforter.

In the Great Commission, He commands His disciples to baptize in the name of the Father, the Son, and the Holy Ghost.

The apostle Paul likewise refers to the Lord Jesus Christ, God, and the Holy Spirit in his concluding blessing.

Taken together, these passages provide the biblical foundation for the Christian understanding of the Trinity.

Bible References:

- Matthew 3:16–17
- Matthew 28:19
- John 14:16–17
- 2 Corinthians 13:14

Doctrinal Note:

The Seventh-day Adventist Church affirms one God—Father, Son, and Holy Spirit—a unity of three coeternal Persons.

The word Trinity does not appear in Scripture. It is a theological term used to express the biblical teaching concerning the unity and distinction of the Father, the Son, and the Holy Spirit.

The doctrine does not teach the existence of three gods.

Question 12 — Why Is Jesus Christ Essential for Knowing God?

Answer:

Jesus Christ reveals the Father perfectly.

Through His life, teachings, compassion, miracles, sacrifice, and resurrection, He makes known the character of God.

He is not merely a prophet or a messenger who speaks about God.

The New Testament presents Him as the eternal Word who was with God and was God.

John declares:

> “And the Word was made flesh, and dwelt among us, (and we beheld his glory, the glory as of the only begotten of the Father,)

full of grace and truth.”

John 1:14 — KJV

Jesus Christ participated in Creation.

The fullness of the Godhead is revealed in Him.

He is the perfect revelation of the Father's character.

His compassion toward the suffering demonstrates divine mercy.

His opposition to hypocrisy and sin reveals divine holiness and righteousness.

His sacrifice upon the cross reveals the depth of God's saving love.

To know Jesus Christ is therefore essential to understanding who God is.

Bible References:

- John 1:1–3, 14
- John 14:9
- Colossians 1:15–19
- Colossians 2:9
- Hebrews 1:1–3

Doctrinal Note:

In the Seventh-day Adventist understanding, Jesus Christ is fully divine and eternally one with the Father in the unity of the Godhead. His incarnation did not make Him a created being.

Question 13 — What Is the Role of the Holy Spirit in Our Relationship With God?

Answer:

The Holy Spirit is the third Person of the Godhead.

He is not merely an impersonal influence or an invisible force.

Scripture attributes personal actions to Him.

He teaches, speaks, guides, convicts, comforts, and can be grieved.

Jesus promised that the Holy Spirit would teach His disciples and remind them of His words.

He also declared that the Spirit would guide them into truth.

In the Book of Acts, the Holy Spirit speaks and directs the mission of the Church.

The apostle Paul warns believers not to grieve the Holy Spirit.

These passages reveal His personal activity.

The Holy Spirit works in the human heart to bring conviction of sin, lead people to Jesus Christ, and transform their character.

His work is always consistent with God's revealed truth.

Bible References:

- John 14:26
- John 16:7–13
- Acts 13:2
- Ephesians 4:30
- Romans 8:9–16

Doctrinal Note:

The Holy Spirit is fully divine and personally active in the plan of salvation. His identity and ministry will be studied in greater detail in Chapter 23.

Question 14 — How Should We Respond to God's Revelation?

Answer:

A true knowledge of God should lead to faith, worship, love, trust, humility, and obedience.

God does not seek merely intellectual acknowledgment of His existence.

He invites humanity into a living relationship with Him.

Jesus taught that the Father seeks worshipers who worship in spirit and in truth.

The prophet Micah declared that God requires justice, mercy, and humility.

Jesus also connected love for Him with obedience to His commandments.

The apostle Paul urged believers to present their lives to God and to be transformed through the renewing of their minds.

A genuine relationship with God therefore affects the whole life.

It influences worship, moral choices, relationships, service, and personal character.

However, obedience must never be understood as a means of earning salvation.

Salvation is the gift of divine grace through Jesus Christ.

Faithful obedience is the response of a heart transformed by that grace.

Bible References:

- John 4:23–24
- Micah 6:8
- John 14:15
- Romans 12:1–2
- Ephesians 2:8–10

Explanatory Note:

True knowledge of God should produce humility rather than religious pride. The more deeply believers understand His holiness, love, and righteousness, the more clearly they recognize their dependence upon His grace.

Chapter Summary

The Holy Scriptures reveal God as the eternal Creator, sovereign over all things, perfectly holy, righteous, merciful, faithful, and loving.

He has no beginning and no created origin.

He is the source of all existence.

His power, knowledge, and presence are not limited by the conditions of the created universe.

His character is unchanging.

The Bible affirms that there is only one true God.

In the Seventh-day Adventist understanding, this one God is revealed as Father, Son, and Holy Spirit—three coeternal divine Persons united in the Godhead.

Jesus Christ perfectly reveals the Father's character.

The Holy Spirit leads believers into truth and accomplishes the work of spiritual renewal.

Our study establishes fourteen essential teachings:

1. God truly exists and is revealed as the Creator of heaven and earth.

2. God is eternal, uncreated, and without beginning or end.

3. All created existence depends upon Him.

4. Human beings can truly know God through His revelation.

5. God's character is perfectly holy, righteous, merciful, faithful, and loving.

6. God is love, and His love is revealed supremely through Jesus Christ.

7. God's judgments are perfectly righteous.

8. God is omnipotent, omniscient, and omnipresent.

9. God's essential character and faithfulness never change.

10. There is only one true God.

11. The Father, the Son, and the Holy Spirit are three distinct, coeternal divine Persons united in one Godhead.

12. Jesus Christ is fully divine and reveals the Father perfectly.

13. The Holy Spirit is fully divine and personally active in the believer's life.

14. Knowing God should lead to worship, faith, love, humility, and obedience.

Doctrinal Conclusion

There is one eternal God—Father, Son, and Holy Spirit—who created all things and reveals Himself through the Holy Scriptures.

God is not a created being.

He is the eternal source of life and existence.

His character is perfectly loving, holy, just, merciful, and faithful.

His divine attributes are not contradictory.

His justice expresses His righteousness, and His mercy reveals His desire to save sinners.

Jesus Christ is the full and perfect revelation of the Father's character.

The Holy Spirit is the divine Person who leads believers into truth and transforms their lives.

The Christian faith does not teach the worship of three gods.

It affirms the unity of the one true God, revealed as Father, Son, and Holy Spirit.

The Essential Message:

God is eternal, uncreated, all-powerful, all-knowing, perfectly holy, just, merciful, and loving. There is only one true God—Father, Son, and Holy Spirit. Through Jesus Christ, we discover the character of the

Father, and through the Holy Spirit, we are led into truth and transformed by divine grace.

Personal Reflection Questions

1. What understanding of God have I developed throughout my life?

2. Does that understanding truly correspond to what the Holy Scriptures teach?

3. Do I consider God only as a Judge, or do I also recognize His love and mercy?

4. Does my knowledge of Jesus Christ help me understand the Father's character more clearly?

5. Is my relationship with God reflected in my daily decisions and conduct?

Suggested Prayer

Heavenly Father,

I desire to know You more deeply.

Help me discover Your character through Your Holy Word.

Teach me to understand Your love as revealed in Jesus Christ.

Remove from my mind every belief that contradicts Your truth.

Help me recognize Your holiness, righteousness, mercy, and faithfulness.

May Your Holy Spirit guide me into a deeper knowledge of You.

Teach me to love You, trust You, and walk humbly according to Your will.

Let my faith be founded upon Your Word and my life be transformed by Your grace.

May I reflect Your character in my thoughts, words, and actions.

In the name of Jesus Christ, my Savior and Lord.

Amen.

Remember

We cannot fully understand God's plan without first seeking to know the God who established it. His Word reveals His character, Jesus Christ makes the Father known, and the Holy Spirit leads us into truth.

CHAPTER 3 — CREATION: THE ORIGIN OF THE WORLD AND HUMANITY

A Thematic Bible Study — King James Version (KJV)

Chapter Objective

To discover what the Holy Scriptures teach concerning the origin of the universe, the creation of the earth, the origin and dignity of humanity, the responsibilities entrusted to human beings, and the divine purpose of life.

This chapter also establishes the biblical foundation of the seventh-day Sabbath as the memorial of Creation.

Central Teaching: God is the Creator of heaven, earth, and all living things. According to the Seventh-day Adventist understanding of Genesis, He accomplished the creation of earthly life in six literal days and blessed and sanctified the seventh day—Saturday—as the Sabbath, an enduring memorial of His creative work.

Question 1 — Who Is the Originator of the Universe?

Answer:

The Holy Scriptures affirm that God is the Creator of the universe.

The Bible begins with the declaration:

> “In the beginning God created the heaven and the earth.”

Genesis 1:1 — KJV

This statement establishes God as the source of all created existence.

The universe is not presented as independent of Him.

Everything that exists owes its origin to the Creator.

The psalmist declares that the heavens were made by the word of the LORD.

The Gospel of John reveals that all things were made through the divine Word, identified in John 1:14 as Jesus Christ incarnate.

The Book of Revelation likewise declares that God is worthy of worship because He created all things.

Creation therefore reveals God's sovereignty, power, wisdom, and authority.

Humanity does not exist independently of the Creator.

Our life, existence, and ultimate purpose are grounded in Him.

Bible References:

- Genesis 1:1
- Psalm 33:6
- John 1:1–3
- Revelation 4:11

Doctrinal Note:

The Bible identifies God as the Creator of all things. This foundational teaching distinguishes the eternal Creator from the universe He brought into existence.

Question 2 — Did God Create the World Without a Purpose?

Answer:

No. The Bible presents Creation as a deliberate work of divine wisdom and will.

God did not create the earth without purpose.

He formed it to be inhabited and prepared it as a dwelling place for living creatures.

The prophet Isaiah declares that God formed the earth and established it to be inhabited.

The psalmist teaches that Creation declares God's glory.

The apostle Paul also reveals that all things were created through Jesus Christ and for Him.

Creation therefore has meaning because it originates in the will of God.

Human beings are not the absolute owners of the world.

They are creatures entrusted with responsibilities toward the Creator and His works.

The purpose of life is not limited to material existence or personal achievement.

It includes knowing God, glorifying Him, and living in harmony with His will.

Bible References:

- Isaiah 45:18
- Psalm 19:1
- Revelation 4:11
- Colossians 1:16

Explanatory Note:

The biblical account presents Creation as intentional and meaningful. This theological claim concerns the origin and purpose of existence; it should not be confused with a complete scientific description of physical processes.

Question 3 — How Does the Bible Describe the Creation of the World?

Answer:

Genesis 1 describes God's creative activity in six successive days.

Genesis 2:1–3 records the completion of His work and His rest on the seventh day.

The biblical account presents the following sequence:

The First Day — Light

God commanded light to appear and separated the light from the darkness.

The Second Day — The Firmament

God established the firmament and separated the waters.

The Third Day — Dry Land and Vegetation

God caused the dry land to appear and brought forth vegetation.

The Fourth Day — The Heavenly Lights

God appointed the heavenly lights to distinguish day from night and to mark seasons, days, and years.

The Fifth Day — Aquatic Creatures and Birds

God created living creatures in the waters and birds to fly above the earth.

The Sixth Day — Land Animals and Humanity

God created land animals and human beings, making mankind in His own image.

The Seventh Day — Divine Rest and Blessing

God rested from His completed creative work, blessed the seventh day, and sanctified it.

The Seventh-day Adventist Church understands the six days of Creation as six literal days, followed by the seventh-day Sabbath.

This understanding is supported within Adventist theology by the repeated evening-and-morning structure of Genesis 1 and by the fourth commandment, which connects the weekly Sabbath with God's creative work.

Bible References:

- Genesis 1:1–31
- Genesis 2:1–3
- Exodus 20:8–11
- Psalm 104:24

Doctrinal Note:

The Seventh-day Adventist understanding affirms a literal six-day Creation and a literal seventh-day Sabbath. This interpretation is presented as the doctrinal position of the book and will be examined further in Chapter 17.

Question 4 — Why Does Light Appear Before the Heavenly Luminaries in Genesis?

Answer:

Genesis 1 records the appearance of light on the first day.

The sun, moon, and stars are introduced in the account of the fourth day.

The narrative therefore distinguishes the appearance of light from the appointment of the heavenly luminaries to govern the day and night.

The biblical text emphasizes God's authority over light and the heavenly bodies.

The sun, moon, and stars are not presented as divine beings worthy of worship.

They are part of the created order.

Genesis identifies their functions in relation to the distinction between day and night and the marking of seasons, days, and years.

The passage does not provide a detailed scientific explanation of every physical process involved.

It is therefore inappropriate to claim that the text explicitly explains mechanisms that it does not describe.

Bible References:

- Genesis 1:3–5
- Genesis 1:14–19
- Psalm 136:7–9

Explanatory Note:

The order described in Genesis must be represented faithfully. Where the text does not specify a physical mechanism, the reader should avoid presenting speculation as an explicit biblical statement.

Question 5 — Did God Originally Create an Evil World?

Answer:

No. The Bible teaches that God's original Creation was good.

Throughout Genesis 1, God repeatedly declares His works to be good.

At the conclusion of the sixth day, Scripture states:

> “And God saw every thing that he had made, and, behold, it was very good. And the evening and the morning were the sixth day.”

Genesis 1:31 — KJV

The original created world is therefore not presented as evil or morally corrupt.

God's creative purpose was good.

Sin, suffering, and death as consequences of human rebellion must be understood in relation to the later biblical account of the Fall.

The goodness of Creation is essential to understanding the origin of evil.

It also demonstrates that evil does not originate from a defect in God's moral character.

Bible References:

- Genesis 1:4
- Genesis 1:10, 12, 18, 21, 25
- Genesis 1:31
- James 1:17
- Romans 5:12

Doctrinal Note:

In the Seventh-day Adventist understanding, God created a good world, and human sin brought death and corruption into humanity's experience. The origin of evil and the Fall will be examined in subsequent chapters.

Question 6 — How Did God Create Human Beings?

Answer:

The Bible teaches that God personally created humanity.

Genesis 1 declares that human beings were made in the image of God.

Genesis 2 describes the formation of the first man from the dust of the ground.

God then breathed into him the breath of life.

Scripture declares:

> “And the LORD God formed man of the dust of the ground, and breathed into his nostrils the breath of life; and man became a living soul.”

Genesis 2:7 — KJV

This passage establishes that human life depends upon God.

The man did not receive existence independently of his Creator.

He became a living soul through the union of the body formed from dust and the breath of life given by God.

In Seventh-day Adventist biblical anthropology, a human being is understood as a living, unified person rather than an inherently immortal soul temporarily inhabiting a body.

This teaching provides an important foundation for understanding the nature of death and the future resurrection.

Bible References:

- Genesis 1:26–27
- Genesis 2:7
- Job 33:4
- Psalm 100:3

Doctrinal Note:

Genesis 2:7 states that man became a living soul. The Adventist understanding does not interpret this verse as teaching that God placed an inherently immortal, independently conscious entity inside the human body.

The nature of humanity and the state of the dead will be examined more fully in Chapters 4 and 30.

Question 7 — What Does It Mean to Be Created in the Image of God?

Answer:

Being created in the image of God means that human beings possess a unique dignity and responsibility within Creation.

God created humanity with the capacity for moral understanding, meaningful relationships, love, reason, and responsible action.

Human beings were also entrusted with a representative role in caring for the created world.

The image of God establishes the sacred value of human life.

This dignity does not depend upon wealth, social position, nationality, physical ability, or personal achievement.

Every human being possesses worth because humanity was created in God's image.

Sin has profoundly affected human character and relationships.

Nevertheless, Scripture continues to recognize the dignity of human life after the Fall.

Through Jesus Christ, believers are called to experience spiritual renewal and reflect God's character more faithfully.

Bible References:

- Genesis 1:26–28
- Genesis 9:6
- James 3:9
- Colossians 3:10

Explanatory Note:

The image of God should not be reduced to physical resemblance. The biblical teaching includes human dignity, moral responsibility, and the calling to represent the Creator.

Question 8 — Why Did God Create Man and Woman?

Answer:

God created man and woman to live in relationship with Him, participate in His purposes, and exercise responsibility within Creation.

Genesis declares that God created humanity in His own image, male and female.

Both share the dignity of being created by God.

Genesis 2 describes God's declaration that it was not good for the man to be alone.

God then created the woman as a suitable companion.

The biblical account presents human relationships as part of God's good creative purpose.

It also establishes the foundation of marriage and family life.

Man and woman were created to live in fellowship with God and to exercise their responsibilities in a spirit of mutual respect.

The equality of their human dignity must never be denied.

Biblical teachings concerning marriage and complementary responsibilities must not be used to justify contempt, violence, exploitation, or abuse.

Bible References:

- Genesis 1:27–28
- Genesis 2:18–24
- Ecclesiastes 12:13
- Ephesians 2:10

Doctrinal Note:

The Seventh-day Adventist understanding affirms the divine creation of man and woman, their shared dignity before God, and the establishment of marriage in the Creation account.

Question 9 — What Responsibility Did God Give Humanity Over Creation?

Answer:

God entrusted humanity with the responsibility of cultivating, protecting, and responsibly governing the created world.

Genesis 1 describes the authority given to human beings over the living creatures of the earth.

Genesis 2 records that Adam was placed in the Garden of Eden to dress it and keep it.

This responsibility does not give humanity unlimited permission to exploit or destroy Creation.

Human authority is delegated by God.

It must therefore be exercised with wisdom, care, and accountability.

The Bible also recognizes the importance of treating animals responsibly.

Human beings are stewards of Creation rather than its absolute owners.

The way we use natural resources should reflect gratitude toward the Creator and respect for His works.

Bible References:

- Genesis 1:28
- Genesis 2:15
- Psalm 8:4–8
- Proverbs 12:10

Explanatory Note:

The biblical concept of dominion should be understood in the context of responsibility before God. It is not a justification for cruelty or careless destruction.

Question 10 — What Role Does Marriage Play in the Creation Account?

Answer:

Genesis 2 presents marriage as an institution established by God.

The man and woman are brought together in a relationship characterized by unity, commitment, and mutual responsibility.

The biblical account describes a man leaving his father and mother and cleaving to his wife, with the two becoming one flesh.

Jesus Christ reaffirmed this Creation foundation when teaching about marriage.

He referred to the original union of male and female and emphasized the seriousness of the marital bond.

The apostle Paul also described the importance of sacrificial love within marriage.

In Seventh-day Adventist teaching, marriage is understood as a lifelong union between a man and a woman, established by God at Creation.

This relationship is intended to reflect faithfulness, love, respect, and mutual care.

Bible References:

- Genesis 2:18–24
- Matthew 19:4–6
- Ephesians 5:25–33

Doctrinal Note:

The biblical teaching concerning marriage must be presented with faithfulness to Scripture and with compassion and respect toward every person. No interpretation of marriage provides justification for abuse, coercion, or the denial of human dignity.

Question 11 — Why Did God Bless the Seventh Day?

Answer:

God blessed and sanctified the seventh day because He completed His creative work and rested on that day.

Genesis declares:

> “And God blessed the seventh day, and sanctified it: because that in it he had rested from all his work which God created and made.”

Genesis 2:3 — KJV

God did not rest because He was physically exhausted.

His rest marked the completion of His creative work.

By blessing and sanctifying the seventh day, God set it apart from the other six days.

This distinction was established at Creation, before the existence of the nation of Israel.

The fourth commandment later identifies the seventh day as the Sabbath of the LORD and connects its observance directly with Creation.

The seventh-day Sabbath is Saturday, not Sunday.

In biblical reckoning, the Sabbath extends from Friday sunset to Saturday sunset.

The first day of the week is Sunday.

The two days must not be confused.

No biblical statement in Genesis 2 or Exodus 20 transfers the sanctity of the seventh day to the first day.

Jesus also affirmed that the Sabbath was made for man and declared Himself Lord of the Sabbath.

The Seventh-day Adventist Church therefore observes Saturday as the biblical Sabbath.

Bible References:

- Genesis 2:1–3
- Exodus 20:8–11
- Mark 2:27–28
- Luke 23:54–56
- Leviticus 23:32

Doctrinal Note:

The seventh-day Sabbath is the memorial of God's creative work. The biblical identification of the seventh day remains Saturday.

The detailed study of the Sabbath, its observance, and its relationship to Christian life is presented in Chapter 17.

Question 12 — What Does Creation Teach Us About the Value of Human Life?

Answer:

Creation teaches that every human being possesses inherent dignity because humanity was created in the image of God.

Human worth does not depend upon social status, wealth, ethnicity, physical strength, intelligence, or cultural background.

Every person is a creature of God.

Genesis 9 reinforces the dignity of human life by connecting it with the image of God.

The psalmist also celebrates God's knowledge and care in the formation of human life.

Jesus commands His followers to love their neighbors.

The biblical teaching of Creation therefore provides a foundation for respecting human life and treating others with justice, compassion, and dignity.

This responsibility extends especially to those who are vulnerable, neglected, or mistreated.

Bible References:

- Genesis 1:26–27
- Genesis 9:6
- Psalm 139:13–16
- Matthew 22:39

Explanatory Note:

Human dignity belongs to every person. It must be reflected in our words, decisions, relationships, and treatment of others.

Question 13 — Does Creation Teach Us to Worship God?

Answer:

Yes. The Bible directly connects Creation with worship.

God is worthy of worship because He is the Creator of heaven, earth, and all living things.

The psalmist calls humanity to bow before the LORD who made us.

The Book of Revelation presents the everlasting Gospel as a message addressed to every nation, kindred, tongue, and people.

The first angel's message includes a call to worship the Creator.

The apostle Paul warns against worshiping and serving the creature rather than the Creator.

True biblical worship therefore belongs to God alone.

The fourth commandment also connects the Sabbath with God's creative work.

By observing the seventh-day Sabbath, believers acknowledge God's authority as Creator and honor the day He blessed and sanctified.

Bible References:

- Psalm 95:3–6
- Revelation 14:6–7
- Romans 1:25
- Exodus 20:8–11

Doctrinal Note:

The connection between Creation, worship, and the seventh-day Sabbath is especially significant in Seventh-day Adventist theology.

The call to worship the Creator in Revelation 14:7 is understood in harmony with the fourth commandment and the biblical account of Creation.

Question 14 — What Does Creation Teach Us About the Purpose of Human Life?

Answer:

Creation reveals that human life possesses meaning and purpose because it originates in God.

Human beings were not created merely to pursue material possessions, personal success, or temporary satisfaction.

They were created to know God, glorify Him, live according to His will, and reflect His character.

The prophet Isaiah speaks of those whom God created for His glory.

Ecclesiastes teaches that humanity is called to fear God and keep His commandments.

Jesus instructed His disciples to let their light shine before others so that the Father might be glorified.

The apostle Paul likewise teaches that whatever believers do should be done to the glory of God.

The purpose of life is therefore inseparable from our relationship with the Creator.

A meaningful life is one lived in faith, love, obedience, and service.

Bible References:

- Isaiah 43:7
- Ecclesiastes 12:13
- Matthew 5:16
- 1 Corinthians 10:31

Explanatory Note:

The biblical purpose of life extends beyond personal achievement. It involves a living relationship with God and a commitment to reflect His character in everyday conduct.

Chapter Summary

The Bible teaches that God is the Creator of the universe and everything that exists.

He created a good and ordered world and gave humanity a unique place within Creation.

Man and woman were created in the image of God and entrusted with responsibility for the earth.

The Creation account also establishes the biblical foundations of marriage and the seventh-day Sabbath.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, the six days of Creation were literal days, and the seventh day—Saturday—was blessed and sanctified by God as the Sabbath.

Our study establishes fourteen essential teachings:

1. God is the Creator of the universe.

2. Creation is the result of God's deliberate will and wisdom.

3. Genesis describes six days of creative activity followed by God's rest on the seventh day.

4. The biblical narrative places the appearance of light before the appointment of the heavenly luminaries.

5. God's original Creation was good.

6. Human beings were personally created by God and depend upon Him for life.

7. Humanity was created in the image of God.

8. Man and woman share the dignity of being created by God.

9. Humanity received responsibility for caring for the created world.

10. Marriage was established by God in the Creation account.

11. God blessed and sanctified the seventh day, Saturday, as the Sabbath.

12. Every human life possesses dignity because humanity was created in God's image.

13. Creation establishes the foundation of worship directed toward the Creator.

14. Human life possesses meaning and purpose through a relationship with God.

Doctrinal Conclusion

God is the Creator of heaven, earth, and all living things.

The Bible presents Creation as the deliberate work of the eternal God.

In the Seventh-day Adventist understanding, the earthly Creation described in Genesis occurred during six literal days.

God then rested on the seventh day, blessed it, and sanctified it.

That seventh day is Saturday, the biblical Sabbath.

Its sanctity was established at Creation and reaffirmed in the fourth commandment.

Sunday, the first day of the week, is not identified in the Creation account as the day God blessed and sanctified.

Humanity was created in God's image and given responsibility over the earth.

Man and woman possess equal human dignity before their Creator.

Marriage was established as part of God's original design.

The created world was declared very good.

Human existence is therefore neither independent of God nor without purpose.

We are called to know the Creator, worship Him, obey His Word, care for His works, and reflect His character.

The Essential Message:

God created the world with purpose and goodness. He created humanity in His image, established marriage, and sanctified the seventh day—Saturday—as the Sabbath. Our lives belong to the Creator, and our highest calling is to know Him, worship Him, and live according to His will.

Personal Reflection Questions

1. Do I recognize God as the Creator and ultimate Lord of my life?

2. Do I respect the dignity of every human being?

3. Do I care responsibly for the Creation God has entrusted to humanity?

4. Do I understand that my life has a spiritual purpose?

5. What place does the Creator occupy in my daily decisions?

Suggested Prayer

Lord God, Creator of heaven and earth,

I thank You for the gift of life and the beauty of Your Creation.

Help me recognize Your wisdom, power, and goodness in the works of Your hands.

Teach me to respect the dignity You have given to every human being.

Help me care responsibly for the world You have entrusted to humanity.

Give me a deeper understanding of Your purpose for my life.

Teach me to honor You as my Creator and to respect the day You blessed and sanctified.

May my worship, decisions, and conduct reflect my love for You.

Guide me through Your Holy Word and transform my character through Your grace.

May my life bring glory to Your name and bear witness to Your love.

In the name of Jesus Christ, my Savior and Lord.

Amen.

Remember

We are not independent beings without purpose. We are creatures of God, made in His image, called to know Him, love Him, worship Him, and live according to His will.

CHAPTER 4 — HUMAN NATURE: WHO ARE WE REALLY?

A Thematic Bible Study — King James Version (KJV)

Chapter Objective

To understand, through the Holy Scriptures, how human beings were created, what it means to be a living soul, the relationship between the body and the breath of life, and the place of freedom, conscience, and moral responsibility in human existence.

This chapter establishes the biblical foundations necessary for understanding sin, death, the state of the dead, and the resurrection.

Central Teaching: Human beings were created by God as unified living persons. They are not naturally immortal. Life is a gift from the Creator, and the believer's hope of immortality rests upon Jesus Christ and the resurrection.

Opening Scripture

> “And the LORD God formed man of the dust of the ground, and breathed into his nostrils the breath of life; and man became a living soul.”

Genesis 2:7 — KJV

Introduction

Who are we? Where does our life come from? What is the relationship between the body, the soul, and the spirit? Are human beings naturally immortal? What happens when a person dies?

These questions have occupied humanity for centuries.

Different philosophical and religious traditions have proposed various explanations concerning human nature and the destiny of the soul.

However, our purpose in this chapter is to examine what the Holy Scriptures teach.

Genesis presents humanity as the result of God's creative action.

The Creator formed the first man from the dust of the ground, breathed into him the breath of life, and the man became a living soul.

This account provides the foundation for the Seventh-day Adventist understanding of human nature.

Human beings are unified living persons whose existence depends entirely upon God.

They do not possess inherent immortality.

According to the biblical understanding adopted in this book, immortality is a gift God will bestow upon the redeemed at the resurrection.

We will examine thirteen questions to understand this teaching and its implications for Christian life.

Question 1 — Where Do Human Beings Come From?

Answer:

The Bible teaches that human beings were created by God.

Humanity is not presented as self-created or independent of the Creator.

Genesis 1 declares that God created man and woman in His own image.

Genesis 2 describes the formation of the first man from the dust of the ground.

God then gave him the breath of life.

Through this divine action, the man became a living being.

The apostle Paul also teaches that God gives life and breath to all.

Human existence therefore depends upon the Creator.

Life is not an autonomous possession that human beings generate or sustain independently of God.

It is a gift received from Him.

This truth establishes both human dignity and human responsibility.

Because our life comes from God, we are accountable to the One who gave it.

Bible References:

- Genesis 1:26–27
- Genesis 2:7
- Psalm 100:3
- Acts 17:24–25

Doctrinal Note:

The biblical account establishes God as the Creator and source of human life. Humanity's existence is dependent upon Him from its beginning.

Question 2 — What Does It Mean to Be a Living Soul?

Answer:

Genesis 2:7 explains that God formed the man from the dust of the ground and breathed into him the breath of life.

The result was that the man became a living soul.

The text does not say that God placed an already existing, naturally immortal soul inside the man.

It describes the creation of a living person.

The Hebrew word nephesh, translated as “soul” in Genesis 2:7, can refer to a living being, a person, or life, depending upon its context.

Related expressions are also used in Genesis for living animals.

The apostle Paul refers to the first Adam as a living soul when discussing the resurrection.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, the human being is therefore a unified living person.

The body formed from the dust and the breath of life received from God together constitute the living human being.

The soul is not understood as an inherently immortal entity that continues conscious existence independently of the body after death.

Bible References:

- Genesis 2:7
- Genesis 1:20–21
- Genesis 1:24
- 1 Corinthians 15:45

Linguistic Note:

The Hebrew term nephesh has a range of meanings. Its use must be understood in context rather than reduced to one definition in every passage.

Genesis 2:7 establishes that man became a living soul; it does not explicitly teach the natural immortality of a separate soul.

Question 3 — Are the Body and Soul Two Separate Beings?

Answer:

The Bible presents the human being as a unified person rather than two independent beings enclosed within one another.

Genesis 2:7 describes the formation of the body and the gift of the breath of life as the divine actions through which the man became alive.

Other biblical passages speak of the heart, soul, spirit, mind, and body.

These expressions describe dimensions of human existence, experience, and relationship with God.

They do not automatically establish that each term represents an independently existing substance.

For example, Jesus commanded His followers to love God with all their heart, soul, mind, and strength.

The purpose of this teaching is to call for complete devotion to God.

Likewise, when Paul refers to spirit, soul, and body in 1 Thessalonians 5:23, he expresses his desire that believers be preserved entirely in holiness.

The passage emphasizes the whole person.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, human beings possess physical, mental, emotional, moral, and spiritual dimensions that form one integrated life.

Bible References:

- Genesis 2:7
- Deuteronomy 6:5
- Mark 12:30
- 1 Thessalonians 5:23

Explanatory Note:

The use of the terms spirit, soul, and body does not by itself prove that human beings consist of three independently conscious substances.

Biblical language must be interpreted according to its context and purpose.

Question 4 — What Is the Breath of Life Given by God?

Answer:

The breath of life is the life-giving gift that God communicates to His creatures.

Without this gift, human beings cannot live.

Genesis 2:7 describes God breathing into the first man's nostrils the breath of life.

Other passages teach that life continues through God's sustaining power.

Job declares that the Spirit of God made him and that the breath of the Almighty gave him life.

Psalm 104 describes creatures dying when God takes away their breath and life being renewed through His creative power.

These passages establish that life depends upon God.

The breath of life should not automatically be identified with an immortal, independently conscious person living inside the body.

The biblical terms translated as breath and spirit have different meanings according to context.

Their meaning must be established by careful examination of the passages in which they occur.

Bible References:

- Genesis 2:7
- Job 33:4
- Job 34:14–15
- Psalm 104:29–30

Linguistic Note:

The Hebrew words ruach and neshamah can refer to breath, wind, or spirit in different contexts.

These terms do not, merely by their appearance, establish the existence of an inherently immortal and independently conscious human soul.

Question 5 — Were Human Beings Created Naturally Immortal?

Answer:

No. Human beings do not possess immortality by nature.

The Bible presents God as the One who possesses immortality in Himself.

Human beings depend upon Him for their existence.

After the Fall, God prevented Adam and Eve from continuing to have access to the tree of life.

This demonstrates that their continued life was not independent of God.

The New Testament presents immortality as something believers seek and will receive through God's saving work.

The apostle Paul teaches that the redeemed will put on immortality at the resurrection.

He declares:

> “For this corruptible must put on incorruption, and this mortal must put on immortality.”

1 Corinthians 15:53 — KJV

The verse identifies humanity's present condition as mortal.

Immortality is something to be received, not an inherent quality already possessed by every person.

The Seventh-day Adventist understanding therefore rejects the doctrine of the natural immortality of the human soul.

Eternal life is God's gift through Jesus Christ.

Bible References:

- 1 Timothy 6:15–16

- Genesis 3:22–24
- Romans 2:7
- 1 Corinthians 15:51–54

Doctrinal Note:

Natural immortality and the biblical promise of immortality are not the same teaching.

In the Seventh-day Adventist understanding, immortality is bestowed upon the redeemed at the resurrection, not possessed independently of God from birth.

Question 6 — Did God Give Human Beings Freedom of Choice?

Answer:

Yes. The Bible presents human beings as morally responsible creatures capable of making meaningful choices.

In the Garden of Eden, God gave Adam and Eve instructions concerning the trees of the garden.

He permitted them to eat from the trees but prohibited them from eating from the tree of the knowledge of good and evil.

This command established a moral responsibility.

Obedience was not presented as a meaningless mechanical action.

Human beings were called to trust and obey their Creator.

Later, Moses called Israel to choose life by loving and obeying God.

Joshua likewise challenged the people to choose whom they would serve.

The New Testament teaches that Christian freedom must not become an excuse for sinful conduct.

Human freedom therefore carries responsibility.

It does not mean absolute independence from God or freedom from the consequences of our decisions.

Bible References:

- Genesis 2:16–17
- Deuteronomy 30:19–20
- Joshua 24:15
- Galatians 5:13

Explanatory Note:

Human freedom is real, but it is not unlimited. Scripture also teaches that sin weakens human moral life and that divine grace is necessary for spiritual renewal.

Question 7 — Why Do Human Beings Need a Relationship With God?

Answer:

Human beings were created to live in relationship with their Creator.

This relationship provides the foundation of spiritual life and gives meaning to human existence.

The Bible presents God as One who seeks humanity and calls people to know Him.

After Adam's disobedience, God called to him in the garden.

The prophet Jeremiah teaches that true glory consists in understanding and knowing the LORD.

Jesus connects eternal life with knowing the Father and Jesus Christ whom He has sent.

The apostle Paul also teaches that God desires human beings to seek Him.

A genuine relationship with God is therefore more than outward religious observance.

It includes faith, trust, prayer, love, obedience, and attention to His Word.

Through Jesus Christ, sinners are invited to return to communion with the Creator.

Bible References:

- Genesis 3:8–9
- Jeremiah 9:23–24
- John 17:3
- Acts 17:26–27

Explanatory Note:

Knowing God involves more than religious information. It is a living relationship established through faith and sustained by His grace.

Question 8 — Were Human Beings Created to Live in Isolation?

Answer:

No. The Creation account reveals that human beings were made with the capacity and need for meaningful relationships.

Genesis 2:18 records God's declaration that it was not good for the man to be alone.

God then created the woman and established a special relationship between them.

More broadly, Scripture emphasizes fellowship, cooperation, mutual support, and love for others.

Ecclesiastes teaches that two are better than one because they can help each other.

The apostle Paul calls believers to show brotherly affection.

The Letter to the Hebrews encourages Christians to meet together and strengthen one another.

Human relationships are therefore an important part of God's purpose.

However, solitude itself is not necessarily sinful or spiritually harmful.

Jesus sometimes withdrew to pray.

The biblical principle is that human beings are relational creatures who benefit from love, fellowship, and mutual care.

Bible References:

- Genesis 2:18–24
- Ecclesiastes 4:9–10
- Romans 12:10
- Hebrews 10:24–25

Explanatory Note:

The biblical value of community should not be confused with the idea that every person must marry or constantly remain in the company of others.

Question 9 — Were Human Beings Created Good or Evil?

Answer:

Human beings were originally created good.

At the conclusion of Creation, God declared that everything He had made was very good.

Humanity was not created morally corrupt.

However, the disobedience of Adam and Eve introduced sin into human experience.

The Fall affected humanity's relationship with God, with other people, and with the created world.

The apostle Paul teaches that sin entered the world through one man and that death came through sin.

He also describes the universal reality of human sinfulness.

The Bible therefore distinguishes between humanity's original created condition and its fallen condition.

Human beings retain the dignity associated with the image of God, but their nature has been affected by sin.

They need forgiveness, spiritual renewal, and salvation through Jesus Christ.

Bible References:

- Genesis 1:31
- Genesis 3:1–19
- Romans 3:10–12
- Romans 5:12

Doctrinal Note:

The Seventh-day Adventist understanding affirms that humanity was created good but became subject to sin and death through the Fall.

Human beings cannot overcome the problem of sin through their own unaided efforts. They need divine grace.

Question 10 — What Responsibility Do Human Beings Have Toward Their Bodies?

Answer:

The Bible teaches that the human body must be treated with respect and care.

The body is not an evil object to be despised.

It is an essential part of human existence and of the believer's service to God.

The apostle Paul teaches that the believer's body is the temple of the Holy Spirit.

He also calls Christians to present their bodies as living sacrifices to God.

These teachings establish that spiritual life cannot be separated from physical conduct.

The way we treat our bodies, develop our habits, and care for our health has moral and spiritual significance.

Christians are called to glorify God in every aspect of life.

This includes the responsible care of physical health, the practice of self-control, and the avoidance of habits that unnecessarily damage the body.

Bible References:

- 1 Corinthians 6:19–20
- Romans 12:1
- 1 Corinthians 10:31
- 3 John 1:2

Explanatory Note:

The biblical understanding of human nature is holistic.

Physical, mental, moral, and spiritual life are interconnected.

The principles of health and self-control will be examined in greater detail in later chapters.

Question 11 — Are Human Beings Responsible for Their Actions?

Answer:

Yes. The Bible teaches that every person is morally responsible before God.

Human beings are accountable for their choices, actions, and conduct.

Ecclesiastes declares that God will bring every work into judgment.

The apostle Paul teaches that each person will give an account to God.

He also declares that all must appear before the judgment seat of Christ.

This responsibility is connected with the moral freedom God has given humanity.

Our choices have real consequences.

However, personal responsibility must not be confused with the ability to earn salvation through human works.

The Bible teaches that salvation is a gift of divine grace.

At the same time, God's grace does not make human decisions meaningless.

Faith produces a transformed life, and believers are called to live in obedience to God.

Bible References:

- Ecclesiastes 12:14
- Romans 14:12
- 2 Corinthians 5:10
- Galatians 6:7–8
- Ephesians 2:8–10

Doctrinal Note:

Divine judgment and salvation by grace are not contradictory teachings.

Salvation is found in Jesus Christ, while human conduct reveals the reality of one's response to God.

Question 12 — Why Do Human Beings Die?

Answer:

The Bible presents death as a consequence of the entrance of sin into the world.

God warned Adam that disobedience would bring death.

After the Fall, God declared that the man would return to the dust from which he had been taken.

The apostle Paul teaches that sin entered the world through one man and that death came through sin.

He also declares:

> “For the wages of sin is death; but the gift of God is eternal life through Jesus Christ our Lord.”

Romans 6:23 — KJV

Death is therefore not presented as the original purpose of God's Creation for humanity.

It is an enemy associated with sin.

In the Seventh-day Adventist understanding, death involves the cessation of conscious human life.

The body returns to the dust, and the life-giving breath returns to God.

This does not mean that an independently conscious, naturally immortal soul continues living apart from the body.

The Bible presents the resurrection as the believer's hope beyond death.

Bible References:

- Genesis 2:16–17
- Genesis 3:19
- Ecclesiastes 9:5–6, 10
- Ecclesiastes 12:7
- Romans 5:12
- Romans 6:23

Doctrinal Note:

The Seventh-day Adventist doctrine of the state of the dead teaches that the dead remain unconscious until the resurrection.

This conclusion is developed through the comparison of biblical passages and will be examined in detail in Chapter 30.

Question 13 — What Hope Does God Offer Humanity Beyond Death?

Answer:

Despite sin and death, God offers humanity the hope of eternal life through Jesus Christ.

This hope is not founded upon the natural immortality of the human soul.

It rests upon the resurrection of Jesus Christ and His promise to raise the dead.

Jesus declared:

> “Jesus said unto her, I am the resurrection, and the life: he that believeth in me, though he were dead, yet shall he live:”

John 11:25 — KJV

The apostle Paul presents Christ as the firstfruits of those who have fallen asleep.

He teaches that those who belong to Christ will be raised at His coming.

He also declares that mortal believers will receive immortality.

The Christian hope is therefore not that human beings possess an indestructible life independently of God.

It is that Jesus Christ has conquered death and will grant eternal life to the redeemed.

The resurrection is the fulfillment of this promise.

Bible References:

- John 11:25–26
- John 3:16
- 1 Corinthians 15:20–23
- 1 Corinthians 15:51–54
- 1 Thessalonians 4:13–18

Doctrinal Note:

The believer's hope beyond death is centered upon Jesus Christ, His resurrection, His second coming, and the resurrection of those who belong to Him.

Chapter Summary

The Holy Scriptures teach that human beings were created by God and depend entirely upon Him for life.

Genesis 2:7 presents the first man as becoming a living soul when God gave him the breath of life.

Humanity is therefore understood as a unified living existence.

The Bible does not establish that human beings possess immortality by nature.

Immortality is presented as a gift God will bestow upon the redeemed at the resurrection.

Human beings possess dignity because they were created in the image of God.

They are called to develop a relationship with their Creator, respect others, care for their bodies, and exercise moral responsibility.

Our study establishes thirteen essential teachings:

1. Human beings were created by God.

2. A living soul is a living being whose existence depends upon God's life-giving power.

3. The Bible presents human beings as unified persons.

4. The breath of life is a gift from God and should not automatically be identified with an immortal conscious soul.

5. Human beings do not possess immortality by nature.

6. God gave humanity moral freedom and responsibility.

7. Human beings were created to live in relationship with their Creator.

8. Human relationships and mutual care are part of God's purpose.

9. Humanity was created good but became affected by sin through the Fall.

10. The human body deserves respect and responsible care.

11. Every person is accountable before God for their conduct.

12. Death entered human experience through sin and involves the cessation of conscious human life.

13. Eternal life and immortality are gifts of God through Jesus Christ and the resurrection.

Doctrinal Conclusion

Human beings are mortal, unified living persons whose existence depends entirely upon God.

Genesis 2:7 teaches that the man became a living soul when God gave him the breath of life.

It does not teach that an inherently immortal soul was placed inside a mortal body.

The Bible presents God as the source of life and immortality.

Human beings do not possess an independent power to live forever.

Death entered the world through sin.

In the Seventh-day Adventist understanding, the dead are unconscious until the resurrection.

The Christian hope is therefore not founded upon the natural immortality of the soul.

It rests upon the victory of Jesus Christ over death.

At His return, those who belong to Him will be raised and receive immortality.

This teaching is essential for understanding the biblical doctrines of death, resurrection, judgment, and eternal life.

The Essential Message:

Human beings were created by God as unified living persons. They are mortal and depend upon Him for life. Death is the consequence of sin, and the hope of eternal life rests upon Jesus Christ, who will raise the redeemed and grant them immortality at the resurrection.

Personal Reflection Questions

1. Do I recognize that my life is a gift from God?

2. Do I treat my body as a responsibility entrusted to me by the Creator?

3. Do my decisions reflect the freedom and moral responsibility God has given me?

4. Am I seeking to develop a genuine relationship with God?

5. Does my hope beyond death rest upon Jesus Christ and His promise of resurrection?

Suggested Prayer

Lord God,

Thank You for giving me life.

Help me understand the value of my existence and the responsibility You have entrusted to me.

Teach me to respect my body, love my neighbor, and live according to Your will.

Give me wisdom to make decisions that honor You.

Strengthen my faith in Jesus Christ.

Help me remember that my life depends entirely upon Your sustaining power.

Remove from my heart every false confidence in human strength or natural immortality.

May my hope rest upon the victory of Jesus Christ over sin and death.

When I face the reality of death, help me trust in Your promise of resurrection and eternal life.

Guide me through Your Holy Spirit and prepare me for the glorious return of Jesus Christ.

In His holy name.

Amen.

Remember

Human beings do not possess life independently of God. Our true hope does not rest upon natural immortality, but upon the promise of resurrection and eternal life through Jesus Christ.

CHAPTER 5 — THE ORIGIN OF SIN: WHY DOES EVIL EXIST?

A Thematic Bible Study — King James Version (KJV)

Chapter Objective

To understand the biblical origin of moral evil, the rebellion of Satan, the entrance of sin into human experience, the consequences of disobedience, and God's response to the problem of evil.

This chapter introduces the Seventh-day Adventist understanding of the great controversy between Christ and Satan while carefully distinguishing explicit biblical statements from broader theological interpretation.

Central Teaching: God is not the author of sin. Moral evil arose through rebellion against His righteous authority. Satan is the adversary of God, and sin entered human experience through the disobedience of Adam and Eve. Through Jesus Christ, God has provided salvation and will ultimately destroy sin, Satan, and death.

Opening Scripture

> “Whosoever committeth sin transgresseth also the law: for sin is the transgression of the law.”

1 John 3:4 — KJV

Introduction

When we look at the world, we encounter suffering, violence, injustice, disease, and death.

These realities raise a difficult question: If God is loving, righteous, and all-powerful, why does evil exist?

The Bible does not answer every philosophical question concerning the origin of evil.

Nevertheless, it reveals essential truths about God's character, the rebellion of Satan, the entrance of sin into the human world, and the divine plan to overcome evil.

Genesis teaches that God's original Creation was very good.

The Scriptures also identify Satan as the enemy of God and describe his opposition to divine truth.

Humanity became involved in this rebellion when Adam and Eve disobeyed God's command.

The consequences affected human nature, relationships, and the created world.

Yet God did not abandon humanity.

From the beginning, He revealed His intention to overcome evil through the saving work of Jesus Christ.

The Seventh-day Adventist understanding of the great controversy places these biblical events within the larger conflict between Christ and Satan concerning God's character, His law, and His government.

This study will examine fourteen questions to understand the problem of sin and the certainty of God's final victory.

Question 1 — Did God Create Evil?

Answer:

No. God is not the author of moral evil or sin.

The Bible teaches that God's original Creation was good.

At the conclusion of the Creation account, Scripture declares:

> “And God saw every thing that he had made, and, behold, it was very good. And the evening and the morning were the sixth day.”

Genesis 1:31 — KJV

God's character is perfectly holy, righteous, and truthful.

The apostle James teaches that God does not tempt anyone to commit evil.

The apostle John declares that God is light and that there is no darkness in Him.

Moral evil is therefore not presented as a defect in God's character or as something He originally created within humanity.

It arose through rebellion against His will.

God created beings capable of meaningful moral choices.

Sin entered when created beings misused their freedom and rejected His righteous authority.

Bible References:

- Genesis 1:31
- Deuteronomy 32:4
- James 1:13
- 1 John 1:5

Doctrinal Note:

The distinction between God permitting evil and God being the author of moral evil is essential.

The Bible presents God as holy and righteous. His permission for rebellion to occur does not make Him morally responsible for the sinful choices of His creatures.

Question 2 — What Is Sin, and Where Does It Come From?

Answer:

The Bible describes sin as transgression of God's law, disobedience to His will, and rebellion against His righteous authority.

Sin is not limited to outward acts.

It also involves sinful desires, attitudes, motives, and the rejection of divine truth.

The apostle John identifies sin as the transgression of the law.

The apostle James explains how sinful desire, when embraced and developed, leads to sin and ultimately to death.

Isaiah teaches that human iniquities separate people from God.

Sin therefore damages the relationship between the creature and the Creator.

Its origin cannot be attributed to God's holy character.

It arises when a moral creature turns away from God's will.

The Bible presents this rebellion as the fundamental problem underlying humanity's fallen condition.

Bible References:

- 1 John 3:4
- Romans 5:12
- James 1:14–15
- Isaiah 59:2

Explanatory Note:

Sin includes more than violations of individual commandments.

It also involves unbelief, selfishness, injustice, and resistance to God's authority.

Nevertheless, the biblical definition of sin as transgression of the law remains fundamental to understanding the moral seriousness of disobedience.

Question 3 — Who Is Satan According to the Bible?

Answer:

Satan is the adversary of God and the enemy of humanity.

The Bible identifies him as the devil, the tempter, the ancient serpent, and the accuser.

Jesus describes the devil as a liar and the father of lies.

Revelation identifies the great dragon as the ancient serpent, called the Devil and Satan, who deceives the whole world.

The apostle Peter warns believers that the devil seeks to destroy them.

The Gospels also describe Satan tempting Jesus in the wilderness.

These passages establish that Satan is a real personal adversary within the biblical account.

He opposes God's truth, deceives humanity, and seeks to lead people into disobedience.

However, Satan is not equal to God.

He is neither eternal nor all-powerful.

In the Seventh-day Adventist understanding, Satan is a fallen created angel whose rebellion placed him in opposition to the Creator.

Bible References:

- John 8:44
- Revelation 12:9
- 1 Peter 5:8
- Matthew 4:1–11

Doctrinal Note:

The Bible does not present two equal eternal powers struggling for control of the universe.

God alone is the eternal Creator.

Satan is a rebellious creature whose power is limited and whose final defeat is certain.

Question 4 — Was Satan Created Evil?

Answer:

No. In the Seventh-day Adventist understanding, Satan was originally created good and later became evil through rebellion.

The Bible affirms the goodness of God's creative work.

It also describes Satan as a being who opposes truth and righteousness.

Two prophetic passages are traditionally examined when studying the origin of his rebellion.

Ezekiel 28:12–17 describes the pride and downfall of the king of Tyre.

Isaiah 14:12–15 describes the humiliation of the king of Babylon.

In their immediate historical contexts, these passages address earthly rulers.

However, Seventh-day Adventist theology also understands their imagery as illuminating the deeper principles of Satan's rebellion: pride, self-exaltation, and opposition to God's authority.

This broader application must not be confused with the immediate historical meaning of the passages.

Jesus speaks of Satan falling from heaven.

The Book of Revelation describes a conflict in heaven involving Michael and His angels against the dragon and his angels.

Together, these passages contribute to the Adventist understanding of Satan's fall.

Bible References:

- Ezekiel 28:12–17
- Isaiah 14:12–15
- Luke 10:18
- Revelation 12:7–9

- John 8:44

Historical and Doctrinal Note:

Ezekiel 28 directly addresses the ruler of Tyre, while Isaiah 14 directly concerns the king of Babylon.

Their application to Satan belongs to a broader theological interpretation.

The biblical teaching concerning Satan's rebellion must therefore be established through the combined testimony of Scripture rather than by claiming that these passages exclusively describe Satan.

Question 5 — Why Did Satan Rebel Against God?

Answer:

The Seventh-day Adventist understanding associates Satan's rebellion with pride, self-exaltation, and the desire to reject God's authority.

The prophetic descriptions of the rulers of Babylon and Tyre portray arrogance and the desire for exaltation.

When these passages are considered alongside the New Testament's teaching concerning the devil, they provide theological insight into the character of rebellion.

The apostle Paul warns against pride leading to the condemnation associated with the devil.

Revelation describes a war in heaven and the defeat of the dragon and his angels.

The rebellion against God was therefore not simply a disagreement between equal powers.

It involved the rejection of divine truth and authority.

Nevertheless, Scripture does not provide a complete chronological account of every event preceding Satan's fall.

We should not invent details concerning conversations, motives, or events that the Bible does not explicitly reveal.

Bible References:

- Isaiah 14:13–14
- Ezekiel 28:17
- 1 Timothy 3:6
- Revelation 12:7–9

Doctrinal Note:

Pride and self-exaltation are central themes in the Adventist explanation of Satan's rebellion.

However, the precise sequence of events before the heavenly conflict is not fully described in Scripture.

Question 6 — Why Did God Not Immediately Destroy Satan?

Answer:

The Bible does not provide a single passage explaining every reason God permitted Satan's rebellion to continue.

Nevertheless, Scripture reveals that God is righteous, patient, truthful, and sovereign.

The Seventh-day Adventist understanding of the great controversy teaches that God has permitted the conflict to unfold so that the character of His government and the true consequences of rebellion may become evident.

In this interpretation, the controversy concerns God's character, His law, and the accusations raised against His government.

God's response demonstrates that His authority is righteous and that sin leads to destruction.

The Book of Revelation describes the conflict in heaven and the eventual defeat of Satan.

Other biblical passages reveal God's patience and His desire to save sinners.

However, these passages must be used carefully.

For example, 2 Peter 3:9 directly concerns God's patience toward humanity, not a detailed explanation of His original treatment of Satan.

The doctrine of the great controversy is therefore developed by bringing together several biblical teachings.

Bible References:

- Romans 3:4
- Revelation 12:7–12
- 2 Peter 3:9
- 1 Corinthians 4:9

Doctrinal Note:

The explanation that God allowed the controversy to develop in order to reveal the true character of sin is part of Seventh-day Adventist theological interpretation.

It should not be presented as a direct quotation from a single biblical passage.

The Bible clearly teaches that God remains sovereign and that evil will ultimately be defeated.

Question 7 — How Did Sin Enter the Human World?

Answer:

Genesis 3 describes the entrance of sin into human experience through the disobedience of Adam and Eve.

The serpent approached Eve and questioned God's command.

He contradicted the divine warning concerning death and encouraged distrust of God's Word.

Eve accepted the deception and ate the forbidden fruit.

Adam also ate, disobeying God's instruction.

The narrative reveals that temptation involved several elements:

1. Questioning God's Word.

2. Distorting the divine command.

3. Contradicting God's warning.

4. Awakening sinful desire.

5. Choosing disobedience.

The apostle Paul teaches that sin entered the world through one man and death through sin.

He also refers to the serpent's deception of Eve.

The Fall therefore marks humanity's departure from its original relationship of trust and obedience toward God.

Bible References:

- Genesis 3:1–6
- Genesis 3:11–13
- Romans 5:12
- 2 Corinthians 11:3

Explanatory Note:

The serpent's deception did not remove human responsibility.

Adam and Eve were accountable for their choices.

The account also demonstrates the danger of accepting teachings that contradict God's revealed Word.

Question 8 — What Were the Immediate Consequences of Sin?

Answer:

The disobedience of Adam and Eve brought serious consequences.

The first was a rupture in their relationship with God.

After sinning, they experienced shame, fear, and the desire to hide.

Their relationship with one another was also affected.

Instead of accepting responsibility, they attempted to shift blame.

The consequences of sin extended to human suffering, labor, and mortality.

Genesis 3 describes the difficulties that would characterize life in a fallen world.

Sin therefore affected more than individual behavior.

It damaged the relationship between humanity and God, distorted human relationships, and introduced suffering into human experience.

The prophet Isaiah teaches that iniquities separate human beings from God.

The biblical account presents sin as a destructive power whose consequences reach far beyond the original act of disobedience.

Bible References:

- Genesis 3:7–10
- Genesis 3:12–13
- Genesis 3:16–19
- Isaiah 59:2

Doctrinal Note:

Sin affects the whole of human life.

Its consequences include spiritual alienation, moral corruption, damaged relationships, suffering, and death.

Question 9 — Are All Human Beings Affected by Sin?

Answer:

Yes. The Bible teaches that sin affects all humanity.

The apostle Paul declares:

> “For all have sinned, and come short of the glory of God;”

Romans 3:23 — KJV

No person can claim to possess perfect righteousness before God through personal merit.

Ecclesiastes teaches that no righteous person on earth continually does good without sinning.

The apostle John warns that those who claim to have no sin deceive themselves.

The universal problem of sin does not mean that every person commits identical actions or bears the same degree of responsibility for every wrongdoing.

It means that humanity as a whole is fallen and needs divine grace.

Every person requires the salvation offered through Jesus Christ.

Bible References:

- Romans 3:9–12
- Romans 3:23
- Ecclesiastes 7:20
- 1 John 1:8–10

Explanatory Note:

The universality of sin establishes humanity's universal need for salvation.

It does not eliminate the biblical distinction between personal choices, individual accountability, and the inherited consequences of the Fall.

Question 10 — Has Sin Affected Human Nature?

Answer:

Yes. Sin has profoundly affected human nature.

The Bible describes the human heart as vulnerable to deception and corruption.

The apostle Paul explains the conflict between sinful desires and the desire to do what is right.

He also contrasts the mind governed by the flesh with the mind directed by the Spirit.

Human beings therefore need more than outward moral improvement.

They need spiritual renewal through the grace and power of God.

In Seventh-day Adventist theology, the Fall affected the entire human family.

Human beings inherit a fallen, weakened condition and a tendency toward sin.

However, the inherited consequences of Adam's sin must not automatically be equated with personal guilt for an act an individual did not commit.

Scripture teaches personal accountability while also affirming humanity's universal need for salvation.

Bible References:

- Jeremiah 17:9
- Romans 7:18–25
- Romans 8:5–8
- Psalm 51:5
- Ezekiel 18:20

Doctrinal Note:

The Seventh-day Adventist understanding distinguishes the fallen condition inherited by humanity from personal responsibility for sinful choices.

Human beings cannot save themselves, but God's grace makes repentance, conversion, and spiritual transformation possible.

Question 11 — Can Sin Exist Without Consequences?

Answer:

No. The Bible teaches that sin has serious consequences.

The apostle Paul declares:

> “For the wages of sin is death; but the gift of God is eternal life through Jesus Christ our Lord.”

Romans 6:23 — KJV

Sin damages the relationship between humanity and God.

It corrupts character, destroys trust, produces suffering, and ultimately leads to death.

James teaches that sinful desire, when embraced, gives birth to sin, and sin brings forth death.

The principle of sowing and reaping also demonstrates that human choices have consequences.

Some consequences appear immediately.

Others become evident over time.

However, Scripture does not teach that every instance of suffering is the direct punishment for a particular personal sin.

Jesus rejected such simplistic explanations when discussing human suffering.

The Bible also reveals that forgiveness and restoration are available through Jesus Christ.

Bible References:

- Romans 6:23
- James 1:14–15
- Galatians 6:7–8
- Ezekiel 18:4
- John 9:1–3

Explanatory Note:

The consequences of sin may be spiritual, moral, relational, and physical.

Nevertheless, believers must not automatically attribute another person's illness, suffering, or misfortune to a specific personal sin.

Question 12 — Did God Abandon Humanity After the Fall?

Answer:

No. God did not abandon humanity after Adam and Eve disobeyed Him.

Genesis 3 records that God sought them and addressed their disobedience.

Within the account of judgment, God also announced a conflict between the serpent and the woman and between their descendants.

Genesis 3:15 has traditionally been understood by Christians as the first announcement of the Gospel.

In this interpretation, the promised offspring points toward Jesus Christ, who would ultimately defeat Satan.

The New Testament reveals that God gave His Son for the salvation of the world.

The apostle John declares that the Son of God appeared to destroy the works of the devil.

God's response to sin was therefore not abandonment.

It was the unfolding of His redemptive purpose.

Bible References:

- Genesis 3:15
- John 3:16
- Romans 16:20
- 1 John 3:8

Doctrinal Note:

Genesis 3:15 does not explicitly name Jesus Christ.

Its identification as the first Gospel promise is a Christian theological interpretation grounded in the broader biblical revelation of Christ's victory over Satan.

Question 13 — Why Did Jesus Christ Come Into the World?

Answer:

Jesus Christ came to reveal the Father, save sinners, give His life as a sacrifice, and destroy the works of the devil.

The angel announced that Jesus would save His people from their sins.

Jesus Himself declared that the Son of Man came to seek and save the lost.

John the Baptist identified Him as the Lamb of God who takes away the sin of the world.

The apostle Paul affirmed that Christ Jesus came into the world to save sinners.

The Letter to the Hebrews teaches that Christ shared in human nature so that through death He might defeat the one who held the power of death and deliver those enslaved by fear.

The mission of Jesus Christ therefore addresses the central problem introduced by sin.

His death is not merely an illustration of love.

It is the saving sacrifice through which forgiveness and reconciliation with God become possible.

His resurrection demonstrates His victory over death.

His return will bring the final fulfillment of God's redemptive purpose.

Bible References:

- Matthew 1:21
- Luke 19:10
- John 1:29
- 1 Timothy 1:15
- Hebrews 2:14–15
- Romans 5:8–11

Doctrinal Note:

The cross reveals both divine love and divine justice.

Jesus Christ provides the foundation of salvation, reconciliation, and victory over sin.

Question 14 — Will Evil and Sin Eventually Come to an End?

Answer:

Yes. The Bible teaches that God will ultimately bring sin, evil, Satan, suffering, and death to an end.

Evil will not exist forever as an eternal rival to God's kingdom.

The Book of Revelation describes the final judgment and the defeat of Satan.

It also promises a new heaven and a new earth in which death, sorrow, crying, and pain will no longer exist.

The apostle Paul teaches that the last enemy to be destroyed is death.

These promises establish that God's plan of salvation includes more than the forgiveness of individual sinners.

It also includes the final removal of evil and the restoration of Creation.

In the Seventh-day Adventist understanding, the wicked will ultimately be destroyed in the final judgment rather than preserved forever in a state of conscious torment.

This teaching will be examined in the chapters concerning judgment, the millennium, and the final destruction of evil.

Bible References:

- Revelation 20:7–15
- Revelation 21:1–4
- Nahum 1:9
- 1 Corinthians 15:24–26
- Malachi 4:1–3

Doctrinal Note:

The Bible promises the definitive end of evil.

The Seventh-day Adventist doctrine of final destruction affirms that sin and its consequences will be completely eliminated, allowing God's restored Creation to exist in lasting peace and righteousness.

Chapter Summary

God created a good world and moral beings capable of meaningful choices.

Moral evil did not originate in God's holy character.

It arose through rebellion against His authority.

The Bible identifies Satan as the adversary of God and humanity.

The Seventh-day Adventist understanding places his rebellion within the great controversy between Christ and Satan.

Humanity became involved in this conflict when Adam and Eve disobeyed God's command.

Sin damaged the relationship between humanity and God, affected human nature, introduced suffering, and brought death into human experience.

However, God did not abandon His creatures.

He revealed His saving purpose and provided salvation through Jesus Christ.

Our study establishes fourteen essential teachings:

1. God is not the author of moral evil.

2. Sin involves transgression of God's law and rebellion against His authority.

3. Satan is a real adversary, but he is not equal to God.

4. In the Adventist understanding, Satan was originally created good and later became rebellious.

5. Pride and self-exaltation characterize the theological explanation of Satan's rebellion.

6. The great controversy helps explain God's response to the rebellion of Satan.

7. Sin entered human experience through the disobedience of Adam and Eve.

8. Sin damaged humanity's relationship with God and with Creation.

9. All humanity is affected by sin and needs divine grace.

10. Human nature has been weakened and corrupted by the Fall.

11. Sin has serious consequences, ultimately leading to death.

12. God did not abandon humanity but revealed a promise of redemption.

13. Jesus Christ came to save sinners and destroy the works of the devil.

14. God will ultimately eliminate sin, Satan, suffering, and death.

Doctrinal Conclusion

God is not the author of sin, and evil will not have the final victory.

The Bible teaches that God's original Creation was good.

Sin arose through rebellion against His righteous authority.

Satan is the adversary of God, but he is not an eternal power equal to the Creator.

The Seventh-day Adventist understanding of the great controversy explains the conflict between Christ and Satan as involving God's character, His law, and His government.

This interpretation must be grounded in Scripture and distinguished from historical passages whose immediate subjects are earthly rulers.

Humanity entered the conflict through the disobedience of Adam and Eve.

The Fall introduced sin, suffering, and death into human experience.

Every human being now needs salvation.

However, God did not abandon humanity.

Through Jesus Christ, He has provided forgiveness, reconciliation, spiritual renewal, and the promise of eternal life.

The cross reveals God's love and justice.

The resurrection of Jesus Christ establishes the certainty of His victory over death.

At the conclusion of God's redemptive work, Satan and evil will be destroyed, and Creation will be restored.

The Essential Message:

God created a good world. Sin arose through rebellion against His righteous authority and entered human experience through the Fall. Jesus Christ came to save sinners and defeat the works of Satan. God will ultimately destroy evil, abolish death, and restore His Creation.

Personal Reflection Questions

1. Do I recognize the consequences of sin in my own life?

2. Do I take the warnings of God's Word seriously?

3. Do I attempt to justify my wrongdoing, or am I willing to acknowledge it before God?

4. Do I understand why I need salvation through Jesus Christ?

5. Do I live with confidence in God's promised final victory over evil?

Suggested Prayer

Heavenly Father,

I recognize that sin has profoundly affected humanity and my own life.

Forgive my wrongdoing and deliver me from everything that separates me from You.

Help me recognize the deception of the enemy and remain faithful to Your Word.

Give me a humble heart that is willing to acknowledge sin and turn away from it.

Strengthen my faith in Jesus Christ, who came to save sinners and destroy the works of the devil.

Teach me to trust Your love, justice, mercy, and faithfulness.

Help me live according to Your will through the power of the Holy Spirit.

Thank You for the promise that evil and death will not last forever.

May my hope remain fixed upon the victory of Jesus Christ and the restoration of Your Creation.

In His holy name.

Amen.

Remember

Evil will not have the final word. Sin brought suffering and death into the world, but Jesus Christ came to provide salvation, and God has promised the complete restoration of His Creation.

CHAPTER 6 — THE LOVE OF GOD: WHY DOES GOD WANT TO SAVE HUMANITY?

A Thematic Bible Study — King James Version (KJV)

Chapter Objective

To understand why God seeks to save fallen humanity, how His love is revealed through Jesus Christ, and why salvation is a gift of grace rather than a reward for human merit.

This chapter also explains the relationship between divine love, justice, repentance, faith, forgiveness, and obedience.

Central Teaching: God loves humanity and has taken the initiative to provide salvation through Jesus Christ. His love does not excuse sin but offers forgiveness, reconciliation, and transformation. Salvation is received by grace through faith, and genuine faith produces a life of loving obedience.

Opening Scripture

> “But God commendeth his love toward us, in that, while we were yet sinners, Christ died for us.”

Romans 5:8 — KJV

Introduction

In the previous chapter, we examined the origin of sin and its consequences.

Humanity's rebellion brought separation from God, suffering, and death.

A fundamental question now arises: Why would a holy and righteous God seek to save human beings who have disobeyed Him?

The Bible provides a profound answer: God is love.

His love does not mean that He ignores sin or approves of evil.

Rather, it means that He has taken the initiative to provide a way of reconciliation.

The plan of salvation originates in God's gracious character.

Human beings cannot earn forgiveness or eternal life through their own efforts.

God offers salvation through Jesus Christ, who gave His life for sinners.

Through the Holy Spirit, divine grace also leads believers to repentance, faith, and a transformed life.

This chapter examines fourteen questions that reveal the depth of God's love and its place in the plan of redemption.

Question 1 — Why Is God's Love Essential to the Plan of Salvation?

Answer:

God's love is the foundation of His plan to save humanity.

The Bible teaches that God does not seek to save sinners because they have earned His favor.

He acts because love belongs to His character.

The apostle John declares:

> “He that loveth not knoweth not God; for God is love.”

1 John 4:8 — KJV

After humanity's rebellion, God did not abandon His creatures.

He initiated a plan of redemption through Jesus Christ.

The prophet Jeremiah describes God's enduring love toward His people.

The apostle Paul teaches that Christ died for us while we were still sinners.

These passages reveal that divine love precedes human merit.

God does not wait for sinners to become righteous before offering His grace.

His love seeks to rescue them from sin and restore their relationship with Him.

Bible References:

- 1 John 4:8–10
- Jeremiah 31:3
- Romans 5:8
- Ephesians 2:4–5

Doctrinal Note:

God's love must not be confused with approval of sin.

He loves sinners and desires to save them, but His saving purpose includes deliverance from evil and transformation of character.

Question 2 — Does God Love Only Certain People?

Answer:

No. God's love extends to the entire human family.

The Bible teaches that God's invitation to salvation is not restricted to one nationality, ethnicity, social class, or historical background.

Jesus declared:

> “For God so loved the world, that he gave his only begotten Son, that whosoever believeth in him should not perish, but have everlasting life.”

John 3:16 — KJV

The word world emphasizes the breadth of God's saving love.

The apostle Peter declared that God is no respecter of persons.

Paul teaches that God desires all people to be saved and to come to the knowledge of the truth.

Peter likewise emphasizes God's patience and His desire that people come to repentance.

The Gospel is therefore a universal invitation.

Every person may respond to God's call through Jesus Christ.

However, the universal offer of salvation does not mean that all people will automatically be saved.

Scripture calls individuals to faith, repentance, and acceptance of Christ.

Bible References:

- John 3:16
- Acts 10:34–35
- 1 Timothy 2:3–4
- 2 Peter 3:9

Explanatory Note:

The universal scope of God's love must be distinguished from the doctrine of universal salvation.

God offers salvation to all, but Scripture also teaches the necessity of a personal response to His grace.

Question 3 — Did God Wait for Humanity to Return Before Taking Action?

Answer:

No. God took the initiative to seek fallen humanity.

After Adam and Eve disobeyed Him, they hid themselves.

Genesis records that God called to Adam.

This account reveals an important principle: God seeks human beings even when they have turned away from Him.

Jesus declared that the Son of Man came to seek and save the lost.

The apostle Paul teaches that Christ died for the ungodly and that God demonstrated His love while humanity was still in sin.

The Letter to the Ephesians describes salvation as an expression of God's great mercy and love.

These passages establish that salvation begins with divine grace.

Human beings do not initiate redemption through their own goodness.

God calls, convicts, and invites them to return.

The human response of faith and repentance is made possible through His gracious work.

Bible References:

- Genesis 3:8–9
- Luke 19:10
- Romans 5:6–8
- Ephesians 2:4–5

Doctrinal Note:

God's grace precedes human response.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, divine grace enables people to respond freely to God's invitation without making salvation a human achievement.

Question 4 — Why Did God Provide a Sacrifice Instead of Simply Ignoring Sin?

Answer:

The Bible teaches that sin is a serious moral reality.

It is not merely an insignificant mistake that can be dismissed without regard for justice.

Sin damages the relationship between humanity and God and leads to death.

In the plan of salvation, Jesus Christ offered Himself for sinners.

His death reveals both the seriousness of sin and the depth of divine love.

Isaiah 53 describes the suffering servant who bears the iniquities of others.

The apostle Paul teaches that God presented Christ in connection with the demonstration of His righteousness.

Peter declares that Christ bore our sins in His own body on the tree.

Through His sacrifice, Jesus provides the foundation for forgiveness and reconciliation.

However, the Bible does not give a complete philosophical explanation of every possible way God might have dealt with sin.

Its central teaching is that God chose to accomplish salvation through the sacrificial death of Jesus Christ.

The cross is therefore essential to the revealed plan of redemption.

Bible References:

- Isaiah 53:4–6
- Romans 3:23–26
- Romans 5:8–9
- 1 Peter 2:24
- Hebrews 9:22–28

Doctrinal Note:

The sacrifice of Jesus does not mean that the Father was unwilling to forgive until the Son persuaded Him.

The New Testament teaches that the Father Himself loved the world and gave His Son.

God was acting in Christ to reconcile the world unto Himself.

See John 3:16 and 2 Corinthians 5:19.

Question 5 — How Can God Be Both Just and Merciful?

Answer:

God's justice and mercy are not contradictory.

Both belong to His perfect character.

God is righteous and does not regard evil as insignificant.

At the same time, He is compassionate and desires to forgive sinners.

When God revealed His character to Moses, He proclaimed His mercy, patience, goodness, and faithfulness while also affirming His righteousness.

The psalmist declares that righteousness and judgment are the foundation of God's throne.

The prophet Micah celebrates God's willingness to pardon iniquity.

At the cross, divine justice and mercy are revealed together.

Jesus Christ bears the consequences of sin and provides a way for sinners to be reconciled to God.

The apostle Paul teaches that God is both just and the justifier of the one who believes in Jesus.

Salvation therefore does not require God to abandon His righteousness.

It reveals His righteousness and grace.

Bible References:

- Exodus 34:6–7
- Psalm 89:14

- Romans 3:25–26
- Micah 7:18–19

Explanatory Note:

God's love and justice must never be presented as competing characteristics.

The biblical plan of salvation reveals their harmony in the person and saving work of Jesus Christ.

Question 6 — Can We Earn Salvation Through Good Works?

Answer:

No. Salvation cannot be earned through human merit or good works.

The Bible teaches that forgiveness and eternal life are gifts of divine grace.

The apostle Paul declares:

> “For by grace are ye saved through faith; and that not of yourselves: it is the gift of God:”

Ephesians 2:8 — KJV

The following verse teaches that salvation is not the result of works, so that no one may boast.

Human obedience, religious activities, charitable actions, and personal discipline cannot purchase forgiveness.

The foundation of salvation is the saving work of Jesus Christ.

Nevertheless, good works have an important place in Christian life.

Ephesians 2:10 teaches that believers are created in Christ Jesus unto good works.

Good works are therefore the fruit of a transformed life.

They are not the meritorious cause of salvation.

Bible References:

- Ephesians 2:8–10
- Romans 3:20–24
- Titus 3:4–7
- Romans 11:6

Doctrinal Note:

The Seventh-day Adventist understanding affirms salvation by grace through faith in Jesus Christ.

Obedience to God's commandments is not a means of earning salvation.

It is the response of faith and love in a life transformed by divine grace.

Question 7 — What Role Does Jesus Christ Play in Revealing God's Love?

Answer:

Jesus Christ stands at the center of the plan of salvation.

Through His life, teachings, compassion, sacrifice, and resurrection, He reveals the character and love of the Father.

He is not merely a moral teacher or an example of kindness.

The New Testament presents Him as the eternal Word made flesh, the Son of God, and the Savior of humanity.

Jesus declared that whoever had seen Him had seen the Father.

He also described Himself as the good shepherd who gives His life for the sheep.

The apostles proclaimed that salvation is found through Him.

Paul identifies Jesus Christ as the one mediator between God and humanity.

The saving love of God is therefore inseparable from the person and work of Jesus Christ.

His sacrifice provides reconciliation.

His resurrection establishes the certainty of victory over death.

His continuing ministry assures believers that their salvation rests upon Him.

Bible References:

- John 1:14
- John 14:9
- John 10:11
- Acts 4:10–12
- 1 Timothy 2:5–6
- Hebrews 7:25

Doctrinal Note:

Christian salvation is founded upon who Jesus Christ is and what He has accomplished.

It is not achieved merely by imitating His moral teachings.

Question 8 — What Does It Mean to Repent?

Answer:

Repentance is a genuine turning away from sin and toward God.

It involves a change of mind, attitude, and direction.

True repentance includes recognizing wrongdoing, acknowledging the seriousness of sin, and desiring reconciliation with God.

On the Day of Pentecost, Peter called his hearers to repent and be baptized.

He later called people to repent and be converted.

The apostle Paul distinguished godly sorrow, which leads to repentance, from sorrow that produces no lasting spiritual change.

The apostle John teaches that God is faithful and just to forgive those who confess their sins.

Repentance is therefore more than fear of punishment.

It is a sincere response to God's grace that leads to a changed relationship with Him.

Bible References:

- Acts 2:37–38
- Acts 3:19
- 2 Corinthians 7:9–10
- 1 John 1:9
- Romans 2:4

Explanatory Note:

Repentance does not purchase God's forgiveness.

It is a response to divine grace.

Romans 2:4 teaches that God's goodness leads people toward repentance.

Question 9 — Can God Forgive Even the Most Serious Sins?

Answer:

The Bible reveals the extraordinary depth of God's mercy.

No repentant sinner should assume that a sinful past automatically places them beyond the reach of divine grace.

The prophet Isaiah calls sinners to return to God and presents the possibility of cleansing from sin.

The psalmist celebrates God's compassion and His willingness to remove transgressions.

The apostle John teaches that God forgives and cleanses those who confess their sins.

Paul reminds the Corinthian believers that some of them had previously lived in serious sin but had been washed, sanctified, and justified in the name of Jesus Christ.

These passages reveal the transforming power of divine grace.

However, forgiveness must not be treated as permission to continue deliberately in wrongdoing.

God forgives sinners and calls them to a renewed life.

The consequences of sinful actions may also remain in human relationships, civil responsibilities, or other circumstances.

Bible References:

- Isaiah 1:18
- Psalm 103:8–12
- 1 John 1:9
- 1 Corinthians 6:9–11
- Romans 6:1–2

Doctrinal Note:

God's forgiveness restores the sinner's relationship with Him through Jesus Christ.

It does not necessarily eliminate every earthly consequence of past actions.

Question 10 — Why Does God Not Force Everyone to Accept Salvation?

Answer:

God invites human beings to respond to His love and grace.

The Bible repeatedly presents calls to choose, repent, believe, and follow Him.

Moses urged Israel to choose life.

Joshua challenged the people to decide whom they would serve.

Jesus lamented over Jerusalem because its inhabitants were unwilling to respond to His appeal.

The Book of Revelation concludes with an invitation to receive the water of life freely.

These passages reveal that God calls for a genuine response.

The relationship He desires is one of love and trust, not merely outward submission produced by force.

At the same time, Scripture teaches that human beings cannot save themselves without divine grace.

God's Spirit convicts, draws, and enables people to respond to His invitation.

Bible References:

- Deuteronomy 30:19–20
- Joshua 24:15
- Matthew 23:37
- Revelation 22:17
- John 16:8

Doctrinal Note:

Seventh-day Adventist theology emphasizes both the initiative of divine grace and the responsibility of human beings to respond.

God's invitation is genuine, and human choices have eternal significance.

Question 11 — If God Loves Us, Why Does He Ask Us to Turn Away From Sin?

Answer:

God calls human beings to turn away from sin because sin destroys their relationship with Him and damages human life.

Divine love does not leave people unchanged.

It seeks their restoration.

Jesus taught that love for Him is expressed through obedience to His commandments.

The apostle Paul instructed believers not to allow sin to reign in their mortal bodies.

He also taught that God's grace trains Christians to reject ungodliness and live righteously.

The apostle John declares that God's commandments are not grievous.

These passages demonstrate that obedience and love belong together.

However, obedience must never be understood as the price of salvation.

Believers are saved by grace through faith.

Their obedience is the response of a heart renewed by God's love and empowered by the Holy Spirit.

Bible References:

- John 14:15
- Romans 6:11–14
- Titus 2:11–14
- 1 John 5:3
- Galatians 5:22–23

Doctrinal Note:

God's commandments reveal His moral will.

Grace does not abolish the importance of obedience; it transforms the believer's relationship with God and enables a life of loving faithfulness.

Question 12 — Does God's Love Mean That Everyone Will Automatically Be Saved?

Answer:

No. The Bible does not teach that every person will automatically receive eternal life regardless of their response to God.

God loves humanity and offers salvation through Jesus Christ.

However, Scripture also calls individuals to believe, repent, and receive Him.

John 3 teaches that those who believe in the Son receive eternal life, while unbelief carries serious consequences.

Jesus described a narrow way that leads to life and a broad way that leads to destruction.

Paul teaches that salvation is available to those who confess Jesus as Lord and believe in His resurrection.

The Book of Revelation also describes a final judgment.

These passages distinguish God's desire to save humanity from the claim that all people will necessarily be saved.

The offer of salvation is universal.

Its acceptance requires a genuine response of faith.

Bible References:

- John 3:16–18
- John 3:36
- Matthew 7:13–14

- Romans 10:9–13
- Revelation 20:11–15

Doctrinal Note:

The Seventh-day Adventist understanding rejects automatic universal salvation.

God offers salvation freely through Jesus Christ, but Scripture also teaches judgment and the final destruction of those who persistently reject His grace.

Question 13 — How Should We Respond to God's Love?

Answer:

We respond to God's love by placing our faith in Jesus Christ, accepting His forgiveness, and allowing His grace to transform our lives.

The apostle John declares:

> “We love him, because he first loved us.”

1 John 4:19 — KJV

Our love for God is therefore a response to His prior love.

Jesus commanded His disciples to remain in His love and to love one another.

The apostle Paul urged believers to present their lives to God and experience the renewing of their minds.

He also taught that faith works through love.

A genuine response to divine love includes faith, repentance, worship, prayer, obedience, and service.

It also involves compassion, justice, and mercy toward others.

We cannot earn God's love through our conduct.

However, those who receive His love are called to reflect it.

Bible References:

- 1 John 4:19
- John 15:9–12
- Romans 12:1–2
- Galatians 5:6
- Micah 6:8

Explanatory Note:

Christian life is not an attempt to persuade God to love us.

It is a grateful response to the love He has already revealed through Jesus Christ.

Question 14 — Will God's Love Ever Come to an End?

Answer:

God's love is enduring and faithful.

The psalmist repeatedly declares that His mercy endures forever.

The apostle Paul teaches that nothing can separate believers from the love of God revealed in Christ Jesus.

The Book of Revelation describes God's final purpose: a new heaven and a new earth in which sin, suffering, and death will no longer exist.

God will dwell with His people.

The redeemed will enjoy eternal fellowship with Him.

The final victory of God's love does not mean that evil will simply be ignored.

It means that sin and its consequences will be definitively removed.

In the Seventh-day Adventist understanding, God's final judgment will bring evil to an end and prepare the way for the complete restoration of Creation.

The future promised to the redeemed is therefore one of lasting peace, righteousness, and communion with God.

Bible References:

- Psalm 136:1
- Romans 8:38–39
- Revelation 21:1–4
- Revelation 22:3–5
- 1 Corinthians 15:24–26

Doctrinal Note:

God's love is eternal.

His plan of salvation will culminate in the complete elimination of evil and the restoration of Creation.

The redeemed will live forever in His presence.

Chapter Summary

God's love is the foundation of the plan of salvation.

After sin entered the world, God did not abandon humanity.

He took the initiative to seek sinners and provide reconciliation through Jesus Christ.

The Bible teaches that salvation is a gift of grace, received through faith.

It cannot be earned through good works.

Repentance and forgiveness restore the relationship between sinners and God.

Good works and obedience are the fruit of salvation, not its price.

God's love is offered to all humanity, but Scripture calls each person to respond through faith and repentance.

The plan of redemption will culminate in the final defeat of sin and death.

Our study establishes fourteen essential teachings:

1. God's love is the foundation of the plan of salvation.

2. His love extends to all humanity without discrimination.

3. God took the initiative to seek and save fallen humanity.

4. The sacrifice of Jesus Christ reveals the seriousness of sin and the depth of divine love.

5. God's justice and mercy are perfectly harmonious.

6. Salvation is a gift of grace and cannot be earned through good works.

7. Jesus Christ is the Savior and Mediator through whom reconciliation is possible.

8. Repentance is a sincere turning away from sin and toward God.

9. God offers forgiveness and spiritual renewal to repentant sinners.

10. God invites a genuine human response rather than merely forced outward submission.

11. Divine love calls believers to turn away from sin and live in obedience.

12. God's universal offer of salvation does not mean automatic universal salvation.

13. Faith, repentance, love, and obedience are appropriate responses to divine grace.

14. God's eternal love will be revealed in the final restoration of Creation.

Doctrinal Conclusion

God's love is the foundation of salvation, and Jesus Christ is the supreme revelation of that love.

Humanity cannot save itself.

Sin has separated human beings from God, and no amount of human effort can purchase forgiveness.

Yet God has taken the initiative to provide salvation.

Through the life, death, and resurrection of Jesus Christ, He offers forgiveness, reconciliation, and eternal life.

The cross reveals both divine love and divine justice.

The Father and the Son are not opposed in the plan of salvation.

The sacrifice of Jesus Christ expresses God's own saving purpose.

Salvation is received by grace through faith.

Repentance is a response to God's gracious invitation.

Obedience is not the price of salvation but the fruit of a transformed life.

God's love extends to all people, yet the Bible calls each person to respond to His grace.

The final fulfillment of divine love will be seen when sin and death are destroyed and God's redeemed people live eternally in His restored Creation.

The Essential Message:

God does not ask us to earn His love before coming to Him. He invites us to come because He already loves us. Through Jesus Christ, He offers forgiveness, salvation, and a transformed life. His grace saves us, and His love teaches us to live in obedience to His Word.

Personal Reflection Questions

1. Have I understood that salvation is a gift from God rather than a reward I can earn?

2. Do I truly believe that God loves me despite my past?

3. Have I accepted Jesus Christ as my personal Savior?

4. Is my repentance producing a genuine change in the way I live?

5. Does my obedience come from love for God or merely from fear?

6. How can I demonstrate God's love toward the people around me?

Suggested Prayer

Heavenly Father,

Thank You for Your love and for the grace You offer through Jesus Christ.

I recognize that I cannot save myself and that I need Your forgiveness.

Help me understand more deeply the greatness of Your love.

Give me a sincerely repentant heart, genuine faith, and the desire to live according to Your Word.

Teach me not to regard obedience as a way of purchasing Your love, but as a grateful response to what You have already done for me.

Help me reflect Your compassion, mercy, justice, and faithfulness in my relationships with others.

Guide me each day through Your Holy Spirit.

Strengthen my trust in Jesus Christ and prepare me to live eternally in Your presence.

In the name of Jesus Christ, my Savior and Lord.

Amen.

Remember

God's love is not a reward for human goodness. It is the foundation of His saving grace. Through Jesus Christ, He forgives sinners, transforms their lives, and offers the promise of eternal life.

CHAPTER 7 — JESUS CHRIST: WHO IS HE AND WHAT IS HIS MISSION?

A Thematic Bible Study — King James Version (KJV)

Chapter Objective

To discover the identity of Jesus Christ through the Holy Scriptures, understand His eternal divinity and genuine humanity, and examine His mission as Creator, Redeemer, risen Lord, heavenly High Priest, and coming King.

This chapter establishes the biblical foundations for understanding the saving work of Jesus Christ and the unique relationship between the Father, the Son, and the Holy Spirit.

Central Teaching: Jesus Christ is the eternal Son of God, fully divine and fully human. He is the Creator and Savior of humanity. He lived without sin, died for our sins, rose bodily from the dead, ministers in heaven on behalf of believers, and will return personally and gloriously to gather His redeemed people.

Opening Scripture

> “And the Word was made flesh, and dwelt among us, (and we beheld his glory, the glory as of the only begotten of the Father,) full of grace and truth.”

John 1:14 — KJV

Introduction

In the previous chapter, we discovered that God's love is the foundation of the plan of salvation.

Although humanity rebelled against its Creator, God did not abandon the human family.

He took the initiative to provide a way of reconciliation through Jesus Christ.

But a fundamental question remains: Who is Jesus Christ, the One through whom God has accomplished this salvation?

Some consider Jesus a prophet, a great teacher, or a moral reformer.

Yet the Holy Scriptures attribute to Him an identity and mission far greater than those of an ordinary human being.

The Bible presents Jesus Christ as the Son of God, the eternal Word made flesh, the Creator, the Savior of the world, and the only Mediator between God and humanity.

Understanding His identity is essential to understanding His work.

The meaning of His birth, life, death, resurrection, heavenly ministry, and second coming depends upon the answer to this question:

Who is Jesus Christ?

We will examine fifteen questions, comparing biblical passages and respecting their historical and literary contexts.

Question 1 — Who Is Jesus Christ According to the Holy Scriptures?

Answer:

The Bible presents Jesus Christ as the Son of God, the promised Messiah, and the Savior of the world.

The name Jesus is derived from a Hebrew name associated with the meaning that the LORD saves.

The title Christ comes from the Greek word Christos, meaning Anointed One, corresponding to the Hebrew title Messiah.

The Old Testament contains promises concerning a coming deliverer.

The New Testament identifies Jesus of Nazareth as the fulfillment of God's messianic promises.

When Jesus asked His disciples who they believed Him to be, Peter answered:

> “And Simon Peter answered and said, Thou art the Christ, the Son of the living God.”

Matthew 16:16 — KJV

Jesus is therefore not presented merely as a spiritual teacher.

His identity is inseparable from His relationship with the Father and His mission of redemption.

The Gospel of John explains that its testimony concerning Jesus was written so that readers might believe that He is the Christ, the Son of God, and have life through His name.

Bible References:

- Matthew 1:21
- Matthew 16:13–17
- John 1:29–34
- John 20:30–31
- Acts 4:10–12

Explanatory Note:

The title Son of God must be understood through the whole biblical testimony.

It should not be interpreted as proof that Jesus began to exist at a particular moment.

John 1:1–3 and John 17:5 reveal His preexistence and unique relationship with the Father.

Question 2 — Did Jesus Christ Exist Before His Birth in Bethlehem?

Answer:

Yes. The New Testament teaches that Jesus Christ existed before His incarnation.

His birth in Bethlehem marked His entrance into human history as a human being.

It did not mark the beginning of His existence.

The Gospel of John begins:

> “In the beginning was the Word, and the Word was with God, and the Word was God.”

John 1:1 — KJV

The Word already existed at the beginning.

John later identifies the Word as the One who became flesh.

Jesus also spoke of the glory He had with the Father before the world existed.

In John 8:58, He used language that points to His existence before Abraham.

Paul likewise describes Christ's existence before His voluntary humiliation and incarnation.

These passages establish that Jesus Christ did not originate at Bethlehem.

He is the eternal Son who entered human history to accomplish the plan of salvation.

Bible References:

- John 1:1–3
- John 8:58
- John 17:5

- Colossians 1:16–17
- Philippians 2:5–7

Doctrinal Note:

The Seventh-day Adventist Church affirms the eternal preexistence of Jesus Christ.

His incarnation must be distinguished from His divine existence.

The Son became human without ceasing to be divine.

Question 3 — Is Jesus Christ Truly God?

Answer:

Yes. The New Testament affirms the full divinity of Jesus Christ.

Several passages directly attribute divine identity, authority, and works to Him.

John 1:1 declares that the Word was God.

John 1:14 identifies this Word as the One who became flesh.

After the resurrection, Thomas addressed Jesus with these words:

> “And Thomas answered and said unto him, My Lord and my God.”

John 20:28 — KJV

Jesus did not reject Thomas's declaration.

Instead, He spoke of the blessedness of those who would believe without having seen Him.

Colossians 2:9 teaches that the fullness of the Godhead dwells in Christ bodily.

Hebrews 1 applies divine language to the Son.

Jesus is also associated with divine works and authority, including Creation, judgment, and the giving of life.

These passages provide the biblical foundation for affirming His full divinity.

However, affirming that Jesus is God does not mean that He is the same Person as the Father.

The New Testament distinguishes the Father and the Son while affirming their divine unity.

Bible References:

- John 1:1, 14
- John 20:28–29
- Colossians 2:9
- Hebrews 1:8–10
- John 5:21–23

Doctrinal Note:

The Seventh-day Adventist Church affirms that Jesus Christ is fully divine and eternally one with the Father and the Holy Spirit in the unity of the Godhead.

The doctrine does not identify the Father and the Son as one Person.

The relationship among the three divine Persons will be examined more fully in Chapter 24.

Question 4 — Did Jesus Christ Participate in the Creation of the Universe?

Answer:

Yes. The New Testament teaches that Jesus Christ participated fully in the divine work of Creation.

John declares:

> “All things were made by him; and without him was not any thing made that was made.”

John 1:3 — KJV

In the context of John 1, the expression him refers to the Word, who is identified as Jesus Christ in verse 14.

Colossians 1:16–17 likewise teaches that all things were created through Christ and for Him.

The Letter to the Hebrews also presents the Son as the One through whom God made the worlds.

Jesus Christ is therefore not merely part of the created order.

He is the divine Creator through whom all created things came into existence.

This truth establishes a profound connection between Creation and redemption.

The One who came to save humanity is also the One through whom humanity was created.

Bible References:

- John 1:1–3, 14
- Colossians 1:15–17
- Hebrews 1:1–3
- 1 Corinthians 8:6

Doctrinal Note:

Colossians 1:15 describes Christ as the “firstborn of every creature.”

This expression must be interpreted within its context.

The following verses affirm that all things were created by Him and for Him and that He is before all things.

In the Seventh-day Adventist understanding, firstborn emphasizes Christ's supremacy and preeminence over Creation.

It does not mean that He was the first being created.

Question 5 — Why Did Jesus Christ Become a Human Being?

Answer:

Jesus Christ became human to accomplish the plan of salvation, reveal the Father's character, and identify with the human condition.

Sin had separated humanity from God.

To provide reconciliation, the eternal Son entered human history.

The Gospel of John declares that the Word became flesh.

Philippians 2 describes Christ's voluntary humility and His assumption of the form of a servant.

The Letter to the Hebrews teaches that He shared in human flesh and blood so that through death He might defeat the one who held the power of death.

His incarnation also enabled Him to become a merciful and faithful High Priest.

Jesus did not remain distant from human suffering.

He entered the human condition and experienced its difficulties.

His incarnation reveals the depth of divine love and the seriousness of God's commitment to human salvation.

Bible References:

- John 1:14
- Matthew 1:21–23
- Philippians 2:5–8
- Hebrews 2:14–18
- Galatians 4:4–5

Doctrinal Note:

The term incarnation refers to the eternal Son of God assuming genuine human nature.

It does not mean that Jesus ceased to be divine.

The biblical teaching affirms both His full divinity and His genuine humanity.

Question 6 — Was Jesus Christ Fully Human?

Answer:

Yes. Jesus Christ possessed genuine human nature.

The Gospels present Him as a real human being who was born, grew, became tired, experienced hunger and thirst, suffered, and died.

Luke describes His physical and intellectual growth.

John records that Jesus became weary during His journey.

The Gospels also reveal His compassion, grief, and tears.

When Lazarus died, Jesus wept.

His humanity was therefore not merely an appearance.

It was real.

The Letter to the Hebrews teaches that He shared in human experience and was tempted as human beings are, yet without sin.

Because He experienced human suffering and temptation, He understands the difficulties faced by His followers.

He is therefore a compassionate and merciful High Priest.

Bible References:

- Luke 2:40, 52
- John 4:6–7
- John 11:33–35
- Hebrews 2:17–18
- Hebrews 4:14–16

Doctrinal Note:

The full humanity of Christ must not be confused with personal participation in sin.

The New Testament affirms both His genuine human experience and His sinlessness.

Question 7 — Did Jesus Christ Commit Sin During His Earthly Life?

Answer:

No. The Holy Scriptures present Jesus Christ as having lived without sin.

Although He experienced genuine temptation, He never yielded to disobedience.

The Letter to the Hebrews declares:

> “For we have not an high priest which cannot be touched with the feeling of our infirmities; but was in all points tempted like as we are, yet without sin.”

Hebrews 4:15 — KJV

The apostle Peter teaches that Christ committed no sin and that no deceit was found in His mouth.

Paul declares that Christ knew no sin.

Jesus Himself challenged His opponents to convict Him of sin.

His sinless life is essential to His saving mission.

He offered Himself for the sins of others, not for sins of His own.

His perfect obedience reveals His faithfulness to the Father.

Bible References:

- Hebrews 4:15
- 1 Peter 2:21–22
- 2 Corinthians 5:21
- John 8:46
- 1 John 3:5

Doctrinal Note:

The temptations of Jesus must not be treated as a mere performance.

Scripture presents them as genuine.

At the same time, it clearly affirms that He remained without sin.

Question 8 — What Was the Primary Mission of Jesus Christ on Earth?

Answer:

The primary mission of Jesus Christ was to save humanity from sin and restore the broken relationship between God and human beings.

During His earthly ministry, Jesus taught divine truth, healed the sick, comforted the suffering, and demonstrated compassion.

However, these works belonged to a greater mission: redemption.

Jesus declared:

> "For the Son of man is come to seek and to save that which was lost."

Luke 19:10 — KJV

This statement appears in the account of Zacchaeus, whose encounter with Jesus produced a visible transformation in his life.

Jesus did not come merely to improve human living conditions.

He came to deliver sinners from condemnation, reconcile them to God, and provide the hope of eternal life.

His mission includes forgiveness, spiritual renewal, and the final restoration of the redeemed.

Bible References:

- Matthew 1:21
- Luke 4:18–19
- Luke 19:1–10

- John 3:16–17
- 1 Timothy 1:15

Explanatory Note:

Biblical salvation includes forgiveness, transformation of life, resurrection, and final restoration.

These dimensions must be understood as parts of God's unified redemptive purpose.

Question 9 — Why Did Jesus Christ Have to Die to Save Humanity?

Answer:

The death of Jesus Christ occupies a central place in the plan of salvation because sin brought guilt, separation from God, and death.

The Bible teaches that all human beings have sinned and cannot obtain salvation through their own merits.

Jesus voluntarily offered Himself to bear our sins and make reconciliation with God possible.

Isaiah 53 describes the suffering servant who bears the iniquities of others.

The New Testament applies this prophetic testimony to Jesus Christ.

Jesus also declared that He came to give His life as a ransom for many.

The apostle Paul teaches that Christ died for sinners and that God demonstrated His righteousness through the saving work of Jesus.

Peter declares that Christ bore our sins in His own body on the tree.

The cross therefore reveals the seriousness of sin, the righteousness of God, and the depth of divine love.

Bible References:

- Isaiah 53:4–6

- Mark 10:45
- Romans 3:23–26
- Romans 5:6–10
- 1 Peter 2:24

Doctrinal Note:

The death of Jesus must not be presented as an attempt by the Son to persuade an unwilling Father to forgive humanity.

John 3:16 and 2 Corinthians 5:19 reveal that the Father Himself acts in love through the work of reconciliation.

Chapter 8 will examine the meaning and consequences of Christ's sacrificial death in greater detail.

Question 10 — Did Jesus Christ Truly Rise From the Dead?

Answer:

Yes. The New Testament affirms the bodily resurrection of Jesus Christ.

The Gospels record the discovery of the empty tomb and the appearances of the risen Jesus to His disciples.

Luke describes Jesus showing His disciples that He was not merely a spirit.

The Gospel of John records His appearance to Thomas.

In 1 Corinthians 15, the apostle Paul identifies Christ's death, burial, and resurrection as essential elements of the Gospel.

He also teaches that if Christ had not risen, Christian faith would be empty.

The resurrection therefore establishes the certainty of Christ's victory over death.

It is also the foundation of the believer's future resurrection.

Jesus Christ is not merely remembered through His teachings.

He is proclaimed as the living Savior who conquered death.

Bible References:

- Matthew 28:1–10
- Luke 24:36–43
- John 20:24–29
- Acts 2:22–32
- 1 Corinthians 15:3–8, 12–22

Doctrinal Note:

The New Testament does not present Christ's resurrection as merely the continuation of His influence or teachings.

It affirms that He truly rose from the dead.

His resurrection body is real and glorified.

Question 11 — What Is Jesus Christ Doing for Believers Today?

Answer:

The Bible teaches that Jesus Christ continues His ministry in heaven following His resurrection and ascension.

He is presented as the believer's High Priest, Intercessor, and Advocate.

Hebrews 7:25 teaches that He is able to save completely those who come to God through Him because He always lives to make intercession for them.

His heavenly ministry does not mean that His sacrifice on the cross was insufficient.

Rather, He ministers on the basis of His once-for-all sacrifice.

The Letter to the Hebrews draws a relationship between the earthly sanctuary and Christ's ministry in the heavenly sanctuary.

It presents Jesus as the great High Priest who has entered heaven itself.

Believers may therefore approach God with confidence through Him.

His intercession is an expression of His continuing saving ministry.

Bible References:

- Hebrews 4:14–16
- Hebrews 7:24–27
- Hebrews 8:1–2
- Hebrews 9:11–14, 24–28
- 1 John 2:1–2

Doctrinal Note:

The Seventh-day Adventist understanding of Christ's heavenly sanctuary ministry is developed particularly from Hebrews and Daniel.

Its relationship to the investigative judgment and the prophetic interpretation of Daniel 8:14 requires careful contextual study.

These subjects will be examined in the chapter concerning divine judgment.

Question 12 — Why Is Jesus Christ Called the Only Mediator Between God and Humanity?

Answer:

A mediator acts to restore or establish a relationship between parties.

Because sin has separated humanity from God, reconciliation is necessary.

Jesus Christ accomplishes this work of reconciliation.

The apostle Paul declares:

> “For there is one God, and one mediator between God and men, the man Christ Jesus;”

1 Timothy 2:5 — KJV

Jesus Christ is uniquely qualified to mediate because He is truly divine and truly human.

He fully reveals the Father and genuinely represents humanity.

His mediation demonstrates that salvation rests upon His person and work rather than upon the merits of human intermediaries.

Through Him, believers have access to God.

His mediatorial ministry is grounded in His sacrifice and His continuing intercession.

Bible References:

- 1 Timothy 2:5–6
- John 14:6
- Hebrews 8:6
- Hebrews 9:15
- 2 Corinthians 5:18–21

Explanatory Note:

Christ's mediation does not mean that the Father is hostile or unwilling to receive believers.

Jesus Himself teaches that the Father loves His disciples.

See John 16:26–27.

Question 13 — Why Is Jesus Christ the Only Way of Salvation?

Answer:

According to the New Testament, Jesus Christ occupies a unique place in the plan of salvation.

He is the One through whom God has accomplished reconciliation.

Jesus declared:

> “Jesus saith unto him, I am the way, the truth, and the life: no man cometh unto the Father, but by me.”

John 14:6 — KJV

This statement appears in Jesus' farewell discourse, where He prepares His disciples for His departure.

He assures them that He is the way to the Father.

The Book of Acts also teaches that salvation is found through Jesus Christ.

The apostle John declares that eternal life is found in the Son.

The Christian claim that Jesus is the only Savior concerns His unique identity and saving work.

It must never become an excuse for contempt toward people of other cultures or religions.

The Bible also teaches that God desires all people to be saved and that He judges with perfect righteousness.

Believers should therefore proclaim Christ faithfully while avoiding unsupported judgments concerning the eternal destiny of particular individuals.

Bible References:

- John 3:16–18
- John 14:1–6
- Acts 4:10–12
- 1 Timothy 2:3–6
- 1 John 5:11–12

Doctrinal Note:

The Bible presents Jesus Christ as the only Savior.

However, believers must distinguish this teaching from speculation concerning the final judgment of individuals whose hearts and circumstances are fully known only to God.

Question 14 — Will Jesus Christ Personally Return to Earth?

Answer:

Yes. The second coming of Jesus Christ is one of the central promises of the New Testament.

Before His crucifixion, Jesus promised that He would return to receive His followers.

In John 14:1–3, He assured His disciples that He would prepare a place for them and come again.

After His ascension, angels declared that Jesus would return in the manner in which the disciples had seen Him ascend into heaven.

The New Testament describes His return as a real, personal, visible, and glorious event.

It will be associated with the resurrection of believers who died in Christ and the gathering of the redeemed.

The apostle Paul teaches that the Lord Himself will descend from heaven and that the dead in Christ will rise.

The Book of Revelation declares that every eye will see Him.

The second coming is therefore not merely a symbol of spiritual progress or a private religious experience.

It is the promised return of the living Savior.

Bible References:

- John 14:1–3
- Acts 1:9–11
- Matthew 24:30–31
- 1 Thessalonians 4:16–17

- Revelation 1:7

Doctrinal Note:

The Seventh-day Adventist understanding affirms that Christ's return will be personal, visible, glorious, and worldwide.

Scripture teaches the certainty of His return but does not authorize believers to determine its exact date.

See Matthew 24:36.

Question 15 — What Personal Relationship Should We Have With Jesus Christ?

Answer:

The Bible does not present Jesus Christ merely as a historical figure or a subject of theological study.

It invites every person to establish a living relationship with Him through faith, love, and trust.

Jesus calls those who are weary and burdened to come to Him.

He invites His followers to hear His Word and follow Him.

In John 15, Jesus uses the image of the vine and its branches to illustrate the believer's dependence upon Him.

Just as a branch cannot bear fruit apart from the vine, spiritual life cannot flourish apart from communion with Christ.

This relationship is expressed through prayer, study of Scripture, trust in His promises, love for others, and obedience to His teachings.

However, these practices must not be regarded as ways of purchasing His love.

They are the response of a heart transformed by grace.

A genuine relationship with Jesus Christ changes the believer's priorities, attitudes, decisions, and conduct.

Bible References:

- Matthew 11:28–30
- John 15:1–10
- John 17:3
- Galatians 2:20
- 1 John 2:3–6

Explanatory Note:

Communion with Jesus Christ is more than a passing emotion or intellectual knowledge.

It involves enduring faith, trust, love, and a life increasingly shaped by His Word.

Chapter Summary

The Holy Scriptures reveal that Jesus Christ occupies a unique place in God's plan of salvation.

He is the eternal Son of God, fully divine and fully human.

He existed before His birth in Bethlehem and participated in the creation of all things.

He became human to reveal the Father's character and accomplish redemption.

He lived without sin, gave His life for sinners, and rose bodily from the dead.

He now ministers in heaven as High Priest and Intercessor.

He is the only Mediator between God and humanity and the only Savior.

He will return personally and gloriously to gather His redeemed people.

Our study establishes fifteen essential teachings:

1. Jesus is the Christ, the Son of God, and the Savior of the world.

2. He existed before His birth in Bethlehem.

3. He possesses full divine nature.

4. He participated in the creation of all things.

5. He became human to accomplish the plan of salvation.

6. He assumed genuine human nature.

7. He lived without committing sin.

8. He came to seek and save lost humanity.

9. His death is the redeeming sacrifice offered for our sins.

10. His bodily resurrection demonstrates His victory over death.

11. He presently exercises a heavenly ministry on behalf of believers.

12. He is the only Mediator between God and humanity.

13. Salvation is found through Him.

14. He will return personally and gloriously.

15. He invites every human being into a living relationship with Him.

Doctrinal Conclusion

Jesus Christ is the eternal Son of God, fully divine and fully human, the Creator, Redeemer, and coming King.

His birth in Bethlehem did not mark the beginning of His existence.

He is the eternal Word who became flesh.

He participated in Creation and entered human history to accomplish the plan of salvation.

His humanity was genuine.

He experienced suffering, temptation, and death, yet remained without sin.

Through His sacrificial death, He provided the foundation for forgiveness and reconciliation with God.

Through His bodily resurrection, He conquered death and established the certainty of the believer's future resurrection.

He now ministers in heaven as High Priest, Intercessor, and Advocate.

His heavenly ministry rests upon His complete and sufficient sacrifice.

He is the only Mediator between God and humanity.

He will return personally, visibly, and gloriously to gather the redeemed.

The Essential Message:

Jesus Christ is not merely a teacher who shows humanity the way to God. He is Himself the Way, the eternal Son of God, the Savior who reconciles us to the Father, the risen Lord who intercedes for us, and the King who will return to receive His people.

Personal Reflection Questions

1. What place does Jesus Christ truly occupy in my life?

2. Do I understand why the Bible affirms both His divinity and His humanity?

3. What does it mean to me that the Creator willingly became human?

4. Do I regard the death and resurrection of Jesus as the foundation of my hope?

5. Do I trust in His heavenly ministry of intercession on my behalf?

6. Is my relationship with Jesus merely intellectual, or is it transforming the way I live?

7. Am I spiritually preparing for His return?

Suggested Prayer

Lord Jesus Christ,

I thank You for Your love and for the wonderful plan of salvation You have accomplished for humanity.

You entered our world, shared our human condition, and gave Your life to open the way of reconciliation with God.

Help me understand more deeply who You truly are.

Enlighten my mind through Your Word and strengthen my faith.

Teach me to trust You, follow Your teachings, and live each day in communion with You.

Thank You for Your victory over sin and death, for Your continuing ministry on behalf of Your people, and for the promise of Your return.

Prepare my heart to meet You when You come again in glory.

May my life bear witness to Your love, truth, and transforming power.

In Your holy name.

Amen.

Remember

Jesus Christ is the eternal Son of God, the Creator who became human, the Savior who died and rose again, the High Priest who intercedes for His people, and the King who will return in glory.

CHAPTER 8 — THE DEATH OF JESUS CHRIST: WHY DID THE SAVIOR GIVE HIS LIFE?

A Thematic Bible Study — King James Version (KJV)

Chapter Objective

To understand why Jesus Christ died for humanity, how His sacrifice fulfills the promises and symbols of the Old Testament, and what His death reveals about God's love, justice, and plan of redemption.

This chapter also examines the meaning of atonement, the blood of Christ, the relationship between law and grace, Christ's victory over Satan, and the believer's response to the cross.

Central Teaching: Jesus Christ voluntarily gave His sinless life for the salvation of humanity. His sacrifice is complete, sufficient, and effective. Through His death, He provided the foundation for forgiveness and reconciliation with God, fulfilled the sacrificial symbols of the Old Testament, and won a decisive victory over sin and Satan.

Opening Scripture

> “But God commendeth his love toward us, in that, while we were yet sinners, Christ died for us.”

Romans 5:8 — KJV

Introduction

In the previous chapter, we studied the identity of Jesus Christ, His divine nature, His genuine humanity, His saving mission, and the promise of His glorious return.

We discovered that Jesus is not merely a prophet or a spiritual teacher.

He is the eternal Son of God, who entered our world to accomplish the plan of salvation.

His mission leads us to an extraordinary event: the death of the Son of God upon the cross.

Why did the One who had never committed sin willingly suffer and die?

Why did God provide salvation through the sacrifice of Jesus Christ?

How can an event that occurred nearly two thousand years ago determine the eternal destiny of humanity?

To answer these questions, we must examine the nature of sin, divine justice, the sacrifices of the Old Testament, and the fulfillment of these symbols in Jesus Christ.

The Bible presents the cross as a supreme revelation of God's love.

It also reveals the seriousness of sin, the value of divine grace, and the cost of our redemption.

We will examine fifteen questions to understand why Jesus Christ died and what His sacrifice means for humanity.

Question 1 — Why Is the Death of Jesus Christ Central to the Plan of Salvation?

Answer:

The death of Jesus Christ is central to the plan of salvation because it provides the foundation for the reconciliation of sinful humanity with God.

Since sin entered the world, human beings have faced guilt, moral corruption, separation from God, and death.

The Bible teaches that sin is not merely a temporary weakness or an insignificant human mistake.

It is a violation of God's will and a rupture in the relationship between humanity and its Creator.

The apostle Paul declares:

> “For all have sinned, and come short of the glory of God;”

Romans 3:23 — KJV

No human being can overcome this condition through personal merit.

Jesus Christ came to accomplish what humanity could not accomplish for itself.

He lived without sin and voluntarily offered His life for sinners.

His death provides the basis of redemption, while His resurrection confirms His victory over death.

The New Testament therefore presents the death and resurrection of Christ as essential elements of the Gospel.

Bible References:

- Romans 3:23–26
- Romans 5:6–10
- 1 Corinthians 15:3–4
- 1 Peter 3:18
- Hebrews 9:26–28

Doctrinal Note:

The death of Jesus must not be separated from His sinless life, bodily resurrection, and heavenly ministry.

The New Testament presents these as complementary dimensions of His one saving work.

Question 2 — Was the Death of Jesus Christ Announced in the Old Testament?

Answer:

Yes. Several Old Testament passages announce or foreshadow the suffering and redemptive work of the Messiah.

After the disobedience of Adam and Eve, Genesis 3:15 announces hostility between the serpent and the woman's offspring.

In Christian interpretation, this passage is understood as the first promise of the conflict that would find its decisive fulfillment in Jesus Christ.

Isaiah 53 describes a suffering servant who is rejected, wounded, and burdened with the iniquities of others.

The New Testament explicitly connects this passage with Jesus Christ.

In Acts 8, Philip explains the prophecy of Isaiah to the Ethiopian official and proclaims Jesus.

Psalm 22 also contains descriptions of suffering that the New Testament associates with the crucifixion.

Jesus Himself taught that the Scriptures testified concerning His suffering and glory.

These passages demonstrate that Christ's death was not an unexpected interruption of God's saving purpose.

It belonged to the divine plan of redemption.

Bible References:

- Genesis 3:15
- Psalm 22:1–18
- Isaiah 52:13–53:12
- Luke 24:25–27
- Acts 8:32–35

- 1 Peter 1:18–20

Historical and Doctrinal Note:

A distinction must be made between passages explicitly applied to Jesus by the New Testament and passages understood as messianic foreshadowings within Christian theology.

The original literary and historical context of each passage must be respected.

Question 3 — Why Did God Establish Animal Sacrifices in the Old Testament?

Answer:

Animal sacrifices occupied an important place in the worship and sanctuary system of ancient Israel.

They taught several spiritual truths concerning sin, atonement, forgiveness, dedication, and reconciliation with God.

The Book of Leviticus connects certain sacrifices with confession, atonement, and forgiveness.

However, the New Testament teaches that the blood of animals could not, by itself, permanently remove sin.

The sacrifices served an instructional and symbolic purpose.

They directed attention toward the greater redemption that would be accomplished through Jesus Christ.

The Letter to the Hebrews explains that the sacrifices of the old covenant were unable to provide the final and complete solution to sin.

Jesus Christ, by contrast, offered Himself as the perfect sacrifice.

John the Baptist identified Him as the Lamb of God who takes away the sin of the world.

The sacrificial system therefore helps believers understand the seriousness of sin and the significance of Christ's death.

Bible References:

- Leviticus 4:27–35
- Leviticus 17:11
- John 1:29
- Hebrews 9:11–14
- Hebrews 10:1–4

Explanatory Note:

Not every Old Testament sacrifice served exactly the same purpose.

Some expressed thanksgiving, fellowship, or consecration.

Others were associated more directly with sin and atonement.

The different sacrifices must be interpreted according to their specific biblical contexts.

Question 4 — Why Is Jesus Christ Called the Lamb of God?

Answer:

Jesus Christ is called the Lamb of God because His sacrifice fulfills the redemptive meaning anticipated by the biblical sacrificial system.

When John the Baptist saw Jesus approaching, he declared:

> “The next day John seeth Jesus coming unto him, and saith, Behold the Lamb of God, which taketh away the sin of the world.”

John 1:29 — KJV

The lamb held a significant place in Israel's religious history.

In Exodus 12, the Passover lamb was associated with the deliverance of the Israelites from Egypt.

The apostle Paul later identifies Christ with the Passover sacrifice.

Peter describes the redeeming blood of Christ using the imagery of a lamb without blemish.

The Book of Revelation repeatedly presents Jesus as the Lamb who was slain and is worthy of worship.

These passages reveal that Jesus fulfills the deeper redemptive meaning of the sacrificial imagery.

His sacrifice concerns deliverance not merely from political oppression, but from sin and death.

Bible References:

- Exodus 12:1–14
- John 1:29, 36
- 1 Corinthians 5:7
- 1 Peter 1:18–19
- Revelation 5:6–10

Doctrinal Note:

The title Lamb of God brings together several biblical themes, including Passover, the sanctuary sacrifices, and the suffering servant of Isaiah 53.

Its full meaning is understood through the combined testimony of Scripture.

Question 5 — Was Jesus Christ Forced to Die, or Did He Voluntarily Give His Life?

Answer:

Jesus Christ voluntarily gave His life for humanity.

The New Testament does not present Him merely as a powerless victim of political and religious circumstances.

Although He was arrested, condemned, and executed by human authorities, He willingly accepted His saving mission.

Jesus declared that He laid down His life of His own accord.

He also affirmed His authority to take it again.

His willingness to obey the Father is especially evident in Gethsemane.

Facing the suffering before Him, Jesus expressed deep anguish while submitting to the Father's will.

His death therefore reveals His love, obedience, and voluntary participation in the divine plan of salvation.

The apostle Paul describes Christ's humility and obedience unto death, even the death of the cross.

The Letter to the Hebrews likewise emphasizes His willing obedience.

Bible References:

- John 10:11, 17–18
- Matthew 26:36–46
- Philippians 2:5–8
- Hebrews 10:5–10
- Galatians 2:20

Explanatory Note:

The voluntary nature of Christ's sacrifice does not remove the responsibility of those who participated in His condemnation and execution.

Acts 2:23 brings together the divine purpose of redemption and human responsibility for wrongdoing.

Question 6 — What Does It Mean That Jesus Christ Died for Our Sins?

Answer:

The expression means that the death of Jesus Christ was directly connected with humanity's sinful condition and was accomplished on our behalf.

Sin brings guilt, separation from God, and death.

Jesus Christ, who committed no sin, offered Himself to bear our sins and provide reconciliation.

The apostle Paul summarizes the Gospel by declaring:

> “For I delivered unto you first of all that which I also received, how that Christ died for our sins according to the scriptures;”

1 Corinthians 15:3 — KJV

This declaration has a substitutionary meaning.

Jesus assumed, on our behalf, the burden and consequences of sin that we could not overcome through our own merit.

Isaiah 53 describes the suffering servant bearing the iniquities of others.

Peter teaches that Christ bore our sins in His own body on the tree.

Paul also presents the saving work of Christ as the foundation of reconciliation.

However, Christ's sacrifice has more than a legal significance.

It also calls believers to a transformed life.

Those who receive His salvation are no longer to live under the dominion of sin.

Bible References:

- Isaiah 53:4–6
- Romans 4:25
- 1 Corinthians 15:3
- 2 Corinthians 5:21
- 1 Peter 2:24
- 1 Peter 3:18

Doctrinal Note:

The biblical language of substitution does not mean that Jesus personally committed our sins.

He remained sinless while bearing their consequences in His redemptive sacrifice.

Question 7 — Why Is the Blood of Jesus Christ So Important in the New Testament?

Answer:

In biblical language, blood is closely associated with life.

Leviticus 17:11 connects blood, life, and atonement within the sacrificial system.

When the New Testament speaks of the blood of Jesus Christ, it refers to His life given in sacrificial death for our redemption.

The blood of Christ is not presented as a magical substance possessing saving power independently of His person and work.

Rather, the expression emphasizes the value of His sacrificial death.

Through His sacrifice, Jesus provides forgiveness, cleansing, and reconciliation.

At the Last Supper, He associated His blood with the new covenant and the remission of sins.

Paul teaches that believers have redemption through His blood.

The Letter to the Hebrews explains that Christ's sacrifice is superior to the sacrifices of animals.

His offering possesses an effectiveness that the earlier sacrifices could not achieve.

Bible References:

- Leviticus 17:11
- Matthew 26:27–28
- Ephesians 1:7
- Hebrews 9:11–14, 22
- 1 John 1:7

- Revelation 1:5

Explanatory Note:

The biblical language of cleansing includes spiritual and sanctuary-related meanings.

It must not be confused with the idea of a literal physical washing of the human body by Christ's blood.

Question 8 — How Does Christ's Death Reveal Both God's Justice and His Love?

Answer:

The cross reveals that God takes sin seriously while demonstrating His desire to save humanity.

Divine justice means that God does not treat evil as insignificant.

Divine love means that He does not abandon sinners without providing a way of reconciliation.

Romans 3:25–26 presents Jesus Christ as the One through whom God demonstrates His righteousness while justifying those who believe.

The cross therefore reveals the harmony between God's justice and mercy.

It does not place the Father in opposition to the Son.

The New Testament teaches that God Himself took the initiative to provide salvation.

John 3:16 declares that the Father gave His Son because He loved the world.

Paul teaches that God was in Christ reconciling the world unto Himself.

The sacrifice of Jesus reveals the unity of the divine purpose: to confront sin, provide forgiveness, and restore the relationship between God and humanity.

Bible References:

- John 3:16–17
- Romans 3:23–26
- Romans 5:8–10
- 2 Corinthians 5:18–21
- 1 John 4:9–10

Doctrinal Note:

The Bible affirms both God's justice and His mercy.

However, it does not answer every philosophical question concerning all possible ways God might have dealt with sin.

Theological explanations should therefore not be presented as exhausting the mystery of redemption.

Question 9 — Did Jesus Christ Bear the Curse Associated With Sin?

Answer:

Yes. The apostle Paul teaches that Jesus Christ redeemed believers from the curse of the law by becoming a curse for them.

In Galatians 3:13, Paul draws upon Deuteronomy 21:23, which associates a curse with one who is hanged upon a tree.

Paul applies this language to the crucifixion of Jesus Christ.

His argument concerns redemption from the condemnation associated with sin and the law.

This does not mean that Jesus became morally sinful.

He remained without sin.

Rather, He bore the curse on behalf of sinners through His sacrificial death.

Through His saving work, believers may receive the blessing promised through Abraham.

The passage therefore emphasizes both the seriousness of sin and the gracious provision of redemption.

Bible References:

- Deuteronomy 21:22–23
- Galatians 3:10–14
- Isaiah 53:5–6
- 2 Corinthians 5:21
- 1 Peter 2:24

Doctrinal Note:

Galatians 3 must be interpreted in the context of Paul's teaching concerning justification, faith, and the promise given to Abraham.

The expression curse of the law does not mean that God's moral principles became evil or worthless.

Question 10 — Did the Death of Jesus Christ Abolish God's Law?

Answer:

No. In the Seventh-day Adventist understanding, the death of Jesus Christ did not abolish the moral principles of God's law.

Jesus declared that He did not come to destroy the law or the prophets, but to fulfill them.

The apostle Paul teaches that justification is received through faith rather than through the works of the law.

However, he also declares that faith does not make the law void.

The New Testament distinguishes between the moral responsibilities of Christian life and the sacrificial system fulfilled through Christ.

The animal sacrifices of the old covenant are no longer necessary because Jesus offered the complete and sufficient sacrifice.

The Letter to the Hebrews explains that the repeated sacrifices could not permanently remove sin.

Christ's offering fulfills their redemptive purpose.

The moral will of God remains important for believers.

Christian obedience, however, is not a means of earning salvation.

It is the response of faith and love to divine grace.

Bible References:

- Matthew 5:17–19
- Romans 3:20–31
- Romans 6:14–15
- Hebrews 9:11–14
- Hebrews 10:1–18
- James 2:8–12

Doctrinal Note:

The distinction between moral law and ceremonial regulations is a theological synthesis drawn from multiple biblical passages.

Christian traditions differ in their understanding of the continuing application of Old Testament commandments.

The Seventh-day Adventist position will be developed in the chapters concerning God's law, the Ten Commandments, and the seventh-day Sabbath.

Question 11 — Did the Death of Jesus Christ Bring Victory Over Satan?

Answer:

Yes. The New Testament presents the death and resurrection of Jesus Christ as a decisive victory over sin, death, and the powers of evil.

Hebrews 2:14–15 teaches that Jesus shared in human flesh and blood so that through death He might defeat the devil and deliver those

enslaved by the fear of death.

Colossians 2:15 also describes Christ's triumph over hostile spiritual powers.

Jesus Himself connected His approaching death with the judgment of this world and the defeat of its ruler.

The cross therefore occupies a central place in the biblical conflict between Christ and Satan.

However, this victory does not mean that Satan has already ceased all activity.

The New Testament continues to warn believers concerning the devil's opposition.

Scripture teaches that evil will remain active until God's final judgment.

Nevertheless, Christ's victory guarantees that sin, Satan, and death will not have the final word.

Bible References:

- Genesis 3:15
- John 12:31–33
- Hebrews 2:14–15
- Colossians 2:13–15
- 1 John 3:8
- Revelation 12:10–12

Doctrinal Note:

The decisive victory of Christ at the cross and the final destruction of Satan are distinct events within the biblical presentation of redemption.

Their relationship will be examined in the chapters concerning Satan, the millennium, and the final destruction of evil.

Question 12 — Why Did Jesus Christ Declare, “It Is Finished”?

Answer:

According to John 19:30, Jesus spoke these words shortly before His death.

The King James Version records:

> “When Jesus therefore had received the vinegar, he said, It is finished: and he bowed his head, and gave up the ghost.”

John 19:30 — KJV

The declaration expresses the completion of the earthly mission entrusted to Him by the Father, culminating in His sacrificial death.

Jesus had lived in perfect obedience, revealed the Father's character, and willingly offered His life for sinners.

His sacrificial work was now accomplished.

However, these words do not mean that every event within the plan of salvation had already occurred.

The New Testament subsequently describes His resurrection, ascension, heavenly ministry, second coming, judgment, and the final restoration of Creation.

The declaration must therefore be understood in relation to the completion of His earthly sacrificial mission.

His sacrifice is complete and sufficient.

Its saving benefits are applied through His continuing ministry, and the final fulfillment of redemption remains future.

Bible References:

- John 17:4
- John 19:28–30
- Hebrews 9:24–28

- Hebrews 10:10–14
- 1 Corinthians 15:20–28

Doctrinal Note:

The complete effectiveness of Christ's sacrifice must be distinguished from the historical unfolding and final fulfillment of all the consequences of salvation.

This distinction helps explain why Scripture speaks of redemption as both accomplished and awaiting its final consummation.

Question 13 — Why Did Jesus Christ Die If He Was Going to Rise Again?

Answer:

The resurrection of Jesus does not diminish the reality or importance of His death.

The New Testament teaches that Jesus truly suffered and truly died.

His resurrection does not transform the crucifixion into a symbolic event or an appearance of sacrifice.

Instead, it confirms His victory and reveals God's power over death.

In 1 Corinthians 15, Paul presents Christ's death and resurrection as inseparable elements of the Gospel.

His death is central to the atonement for sin.

His resurrection establishes His victory over death and provides the foundation for the future resurrection of believers.

Romans 4:25 connects Christ's death and resurrection with the work of justification.

Romans 6 explains that believers are united with Christ in His death and resurrection.

Christian salvation therefore does not rest upon a cross without a resurrection.

Neither does it rest upon a resurrection separated from Christ's sacrifice.

Both are essential to the saving work of Jesus Christ.

Bible References:

- Romans 4:25
- Romans 6:3–11
- 1 Corinthians 15:3–4, 12–22
- 1 Peter 1:3–5
- Revelation 1:17–18

Explanatory Note:

The New Testament presents the resurrection of Jesus as a real event.

It must not be reduced to a metaphor for spiritual renewal or the continuation of His influence.

Question 14 — Is the Sacrifice of Jesus Christ Sufficient for the Salvation of All Humanity?

Answer:

Yes. The sacrifice of Jesus Christ is fully sufficient for the salvation of humanity.

Its value is not limited to one nation, ethnic group, social class, or historical period.

John 3:16 declares that God loved the world.

The apostle John also presents Jesus Christ as the atoning sacrifice for the sins of the whole world.

The apostle Paul teaches that God desires all people to be saved.

The Letter to the Hebrews affirms Christ's ability to save completely those who come to God through Him.

However, the universal sufficiency of Christ's sacrifice must be distinguished from its personal reception.

The New Testament calls people to believe in Jesus Christ, repent, and receive divine grace.

The sacrifice of Christ is sufficient for all.

This does not mean that every person will automatically be saved.

Salvation is offered freely, but Scripture also teaches the responsibility of responding to God's invitation.

Bible References:

- John 3:16–18
- Romans 5:15–19
- 1 Timothy 2:3–6
- Hebrews 7:25
- 1 John 2:1–2
- Revelation 22:17

Doctrinal Note:

The universal scope of God's saving love must not be confused with automatic universal salvation.

The Bible teaches both the universal offer of salvation and the necessity of responding to divine grace.

Question 15 — How Should We Personally Respond to the Sacrifice of Jesus Christ?

Answer:

The biblical response to Christ's sacrifice is faith, accompanied by sincere repentance and a life transformed by grace.

God does not invite human beings to purchase salvation through their good works.

He calls them to acknowledge their need for forgiveness, place their trust in Jesus Christ, and receive His saving work.

Genuine faith is more than intellectual agreement that Jesus died.

It involves personal trust in Him and a willingness to allow His Word to transform one's life.

Jesus called people to repent and believe the Gospel.

On the Day of Pentecost, Peter called his hearers to repentance and baptism.

The apostle Paul teaches that those who live through Christ should no longer live merely for themselves.

He also declares that salvation is by grace through faith and that believers are created in Christ Jesus for good works.

The appropriate response to the cross therefore includes love, gratitude, obedience, and service toward others.

Bible References:

- Mark 1:14–15
- Acts 2:37–38
- Romans 10:9–13
- 2 Corinthians 5:14–15
- Galatians 2:20
- Ephesians 2:8–10

Doctrinal Note:

Faith, repentance, and obedience must not be presented as three independent ways of obtaining salvation.

The Bible teaches that salvation is given by grace, received through faith, and expressed through a transformed life.

Chapter Summary

The death of Jesus Christ is a central event in God's plan of salvation.

It reveals the depth of divine love, the seriousness of sin, and the possibility of reconciliation between the Creator and humanity.

The Old Testament sacrificial system anticipated different aspects of Christ's saving work.

Jesus voluntarily offered Himself as the Lamb of God.

His sacrifice provides atonement for sin, demonstrates divine justice and mercy, and establishes the foundation for forgiveness.

His death brought a decisive victory over Satan and the powers of evil.

His resurrection confirms His victory over death.

The saving work of Jesus Christ is sufficient for all humanity, and every person is invited to respond through faith.

Our study establishes fifteen essential teachings:

1. Sin separated humanity from God and brought condemnation and death.

2. The Scriptures announced the suffering and redemptive work of the Messiah.

3. The sacrifices of the Old Testament foreshadowed different aspects of Christ's saving work.

4. Jesus is the Lamb of God who takes away the sin of the world.

5. He voluntarily gave His life for humanity.

6. His death possesses substitutionary and redemptive significance.

7. His blood represents His life offered for our redemption.

8. The cross reveals both God's justice and His love.

9. Jesus bore the curse associated with sin without becoming personally sinful.

10. His sacrifice fulfilled the sacrificial symbols of the old covenant without abolishing God's moral principles.

11. The cross marked a decisive victory over Satan and the powers of evil.

12. Christ's earthly sacrificial work is complete and fully effective.

13. His resurrection confirms His victory over death.

14. Salvation is offered to all nations and peoples through His sacrifice.

15. Every person is invited to respond to divine grace through faith and a renewed life.

Doctrinal Conclusion

Jesus Christ voluntarily gave His life to redeem humanity from sin and reconcile sinners with God.

The cross reveals the seriousness of sin and the depth of divine love.

Christ's sacrifice was not an attempt to persuade an unwilling Father to forgive.

The Father and the Son acted in unity within the plan of salvation.

Jesus Christ remained without sin while bearing the consequences of humanity's wrongdoing.

His death fulfills the redemptive meaning of the Old Testament sacrificial system.

The animal sacrifices pointed toward a greater sacrifice that only Jesus could provide.

His blood represents His life given for our redemption.

His sacrifice is complete, sufficient, and effective.

His death does not abolish God's moral principles.

Rather, salvation by grace establishes a new relationship in which believers respond to divine love through faith and obedience.

At the cross, Christ won a decisive victory over Satan and the powers of evil.

His bodily resurrection confirms His victory over death.

He now ministers in heaven on the basis of His completed sacrifice.

His saving work will reach its final fulfillment when He returns, raises the redeemed, and brings sin and death to an end.

The Essential Message:

Jesus Christ did not die because God had ceased to love humanity. He died precisely because God loves us and provided, through His sacrifice, the way of forgiveness, reconciliation, and eternal life. His sacrifice is sufficient for all, and every person is invited to receive this gift through faith.

Personal Reflection Questions

1. Have I understood why the Bible presents the death of Jesus as essential to our redemption?

2. Do I regard Christ's sacrifice as something that concerns me personally?

3. What does the cross teach me about the seriousness of sin?

4. How does the sacrifice of Jesus reveal both God's love and His justice?

5. Have I personally accepted the forgiveness God offers through Jesus Christ?

6. Does my way of life demonstrate gratitude for His sacrifice?

7. Am I willing to abandon practices that separate me from God?

8. What hope do the death and resurrection of Jesus give me in the face of suffering and death?

Suggested Prayer

Heavenly Father,

I thank You for Your infinite love and for the wonderful gift of Your Son, Jesus Christ.

I recognize that sin has separated humanity from You and that I cannot obtain salvation through my own merits.

Thank You for opening the way of forgiveness and reconciliation through the sacrifice of Jesus.

Lord Jesus, You willingly accepted suffering and gave Your life for sinners.

Help me understand more deeply the meaning of Your sacrifice.

Give me sincere faith, a repentant heart, and the desire to live according to Your Word.

Teach me never to regard Your grace as permission to continue deliberately in sin, but as the power that leads me toward a renewed life.

May the cross remain a constant reminder of Your love, justice, and victory.

Strengthen my hope in Your resurrection and prepare me for the glorious day of Your return.

In the name of Jesus Christ, my Savior and Lord.

Amen.

Remember

The cross reveals both the seriousness of sin and the greatness of God's love. Jesus Christ gave His life for our redemption, rose victorious over death, and offers forgiveness and eternal life to all who come to Him in faith.

CHAPTER 9 — GRACE: HOW DOES GOD OFFER US SALVATION?

A Thematic Bible Study — King James Version (KJV)

Chapter Objective

To understand the biblical meaning of divine grace, why humanity needs it, and how salvation is offered through Jesus Christ.

This chapter also examines the relationship between grace, faith, justification, good works, God's law, repentance, and the transformation of Christian life.

Central Teaching: Salvation is a free gift of God's grace, received through faith in Jesus Christ. No human being can earn forgiveness or eternal life through personal merit. However, the grace that saves also teaches believers to reject sin, grow in holiness, and live in loving obedience to God.

Opening Scripture

> “For by grace are ye saved through faith; and that not of yourselves: it is the gift of God:

Not of works, lest any man should boast.”

Ephesians 2:8–9 — KJV

Introduction

In the previous chapters, we discovered that God's love is the foundation of the plan of salvation and that Jesus Christ voluntarily gave His life to reconcile humanity with its Creator.

But an essential question remains: How can a sinful person receive the salvation made possible through Jesus Christ?

Some believe that people must perform enough good works to obtain God's favor.

Others assume that divine grace removes every obligation to obey God's commandments.

Both ideas raise serious difficulties when examined in the light of the whole biblical testimony.

The Bible teaches that salvation is a gift from God.

No human being can purchase it, earn it, or obtain it through personal effort.

Yet this grace does not leave the believer unchanged.

It calls the recipient to a new life characterized by faith, love, and obedience.

The apostle Paul teaches that we are saved by grace, while James declares that faith without works is dead.

Are these teachings contradictory?

What is the relationship between grace, faith, God's law, good works, and sanctification?

We will examine fifteen biblical questions to understand the nature and transforming power of divine grace.

Question 1 — What Is the Grace of God?

Answer:

The grace of God is His favor freely extended to human beings who cannot claim it as a deserved reward.

In the context of salvation, grace refers to God's gracious initiative through which He offers forgiveness, reconciliation, and eternal life in Jesus Christ.

Grace originates in God's loving and merciful character.

It is not a reward given to people who have attained a sufficient level of personal righteousness.

The apostle Paul declares:

> “But God commendeth his love toward us, in that, while we were yet sinners, Christ died for us.”

Romans 5:8 — KJV

This passage demonstrates that God acted on humanity's behalf while human beings were still sinners.

Grace is therefore an expression of divine love toward people who cannot save themselves.

It reveals God's willingness to forgive, restore, and transform those who respond to His invitation.

Bible References:

- Romans 3:23–24
- Romans 5:6–8
- Ephesians 2:4–9
- Titus 2:11
- Titus 3:4–7

Explanatory Note:

The Greek word charis, commonly translated as grace, may refer to favor, generosity, or a gracious gift.

Its precise meaning depends upon the context.

In passages concerning salvation, it particularly emphasizes God's generous initiative toward humanity.

Question 2 — Why Does Humanity Need God's Grace?

Answer:

Human beings need divine grace because sin has damaged their relationship with God, and they cannot restore that relationship through personal merit.

The Bible teaches that all human beings have sinned.

Sin is not merely a lack of knowledge or an imperfection that education alone can completely correct.

It affects human conduct, thoughts, motives, and relationships.

The apostle Paul teaches that no one can be justified before God through the works of the law.

The law reveals sin, but it cannot, by itself, erase guilt or provide redemption.

The consequence of sin is death.

Humanity therefore needs more than moral instruction.

It needs forgiveness, reconciliation, and spiritual renewal.

These blessings are offered through God's grace in Jesus Christ.

Bible References:

- Psalm 51:5
- Isaiah 64:6
- Romans 3:9–24
- Romans 6:23
- Ephesians 2:1–5

Explanatory Note:

The universal need for grace does not mean that all human beings commit identical sins or bear precisely the same degree of personal responsibility.

Scripture affirms the universality of sin while recognizing individual accountability.

Question 3 — Did God's Grace Exist Before the Birth of Jesus Christ?

Answer:

Yes. God's grace did not begin with the birth of Jesus in Bethlehem.

From the earliest biblical accounts, God reveals mercy toward fallen humanity.

After Adam and Eve disobeyed Him, God took the initiative to seek them and announced hope for victory over evil.

Genesis 6:8 declares that Noah found grace in the eyes of the LORD.

Abraham received God's promises and responded through faith.

David celebrated the forgiveness God grants to repentant sinners.

These examples demonstrate that God's saving favor was already active during Old Testament times.

The coming of Jesus Christ was the decisive historical manifestation of the salvation God had promised.

The apostle Paul teaches that God's saving purpose was established in Christ before the world began and was manifested through the appearing of the Savior.

The grace revealed in the New Testament therefore fulfills, rather than contradicts, God's earlier promises.

Bible References:

- Genesis 3:8–15
- Genesis 6:8
- Genesis 15:6
- Psalm 32:1–5
- Romans 4:1–8

- 2 Timothy 1:9–10

Doctrinal Note:

It would be incorrect to describe the Old Testament as a system of salvation exclusively by works and the New Testament as a system exclusively by grace.

Both Testaments testify to God's mercy and the necessity of faith.

Question 4 — Why Is Salvation Called a Free Gift?

Answer:

Salvation is called a free gift because it cannot be obtained through human merit.

The apostle Paul distinguishes between wages, which are earned through work, and God's gift, which comes from His generosity.

He declares:

> “For the wages of sin is death; but the gift of God is eternal life through Jesus Christ our Lord.”

Romans 6:23 — KJV

Eternal life is therefore not a payment that God owes human beings in exchange for good deeds.

It is offered through the saving work of Jesus Christ.

Paul also teaches that justification is granted freely through God's grace.

However, salvation being free to the believer does not mean that redemption involved no sacrifice.

The New Testament teaches that believers were redeemed through the precious blood of Christ.

Salvation is freely offered because Jesus Christ has accomplished the work that humanity could not accomplish for itself.

Bible References:

- Romans 3:23–24
- Romans 4:4–5
- Romans 6:23
- Ephesians 2:8–9
- 1 Peter 1:18–19

Explanatory Note:

The expression free gift does not mean that salvation has no consequences for Christian life.

It means that forgiveness and eternal life cannot be purchased or earned.

Question 5 — What Role Does Jesus Christ Play in the Revelation of Grace?

Answer:

Jesus Christ stands at the center of the revelation of divine grace.

Through His incarnation, sinless life, sacrificial death, and resurrection, He accomplished the work that makes reconciliation with God possible.

The Gospel of John teaches that grace and truth came through Jesus Christ.

This does not mean that God lacked grace before Christ's incarnation.

Rather, divine grace was revealed decisively through the person and saving work of the Savior.

In Jesus Christ, God did more than announce the possibility of forgiveness.

He provided the redemptive foundation upon which forgiveness rests.

Paul teaches that believers are justified freely through the redemption found in Christ Jesus.

He also describes the riches of God's grace manifested through redemption and forgiveness.

Christian grace therefore cannot be separated from the person and work of Jesus Christ.

Bible References:

- John 1:14–17
- Romans 3:24–26
- Romans 5:15–21
- 2 Corinthians 8:9
- Ephesians 1:6–7
- Titus 3:4–7

Doctrinal Note:

Grace is not an independent power operating apart from God.

It expresses His gracious favor and saving action, supremely revealed through Jesus Christ.

Question 6 — What Is the Relationship Between Grace and Faith?

Answer:

Grace is the divine source of salvation, while faith is the means through which human beings receive this gift.

The apostle Paul teaches that believers are saved by grace through faith.

Faith does not create salvation.

It receives what God offers.

To believe in Jesus Christ means to recognize who He is, trust His redemptive work, and rely upon His promises.

Genuine faith does not rest upon the moral worthiness of the believer.

It rests upon God's faithfulness and the sufficiency of Christ's saving work.

Paul uses Abraham as an example of a person who believed God's promise and was counted righteous.

Thus, grace excludes every human claim to earn salvation.

Faith expresses the believer's trust in God's gracious initiative.

Bible References:

- John 3:16
- Romans 3:21–28
- Romans 4:1–5
- Romans 5:1–2
- Ephesians 2:8–9
- Hebrews 11:6

Explanatory Note:

Faith is not a meritorious work that obligates God to save.

It is a trusting response to His initiative.

The next chapter will examine the nature and manifestations of biblical faith in greater detail.

Question 7 — Can Good Works Help Us Earn Salvation?

Answer:

No. Good works do not constitute the meritorious foundation of salvation.

The Bible teaches that human beings cannot obtain justification before God by accumulating acts of righteousness.

Even the best human actions cannot erase sins already committed.

The apostle Paul declares that salvation is not the result of works, so that no one may boast.

However, he immediately adds that believers are created in Christ Jesus for good works.

Ephesians 2:8–10 therefore presents salvation by grace and the importance of good works together.

The relationship between them must be properly understood.

Good works are not the cause of salvation.

They are the fruit of a life transformed by divine grace.

The apostle James also teaches that genuine faith becomes visible through actions.

A living faith does not remain merely a verbal profession.

Bible References:

- Romans 3:20–28
- Romans 11:6
- Ephesians 2:8–10
- Titus 3:4–8
- James 2:14–18

Doctrinal Note:

Distinguishing the foundation of salvation from its fruits helps avoid two errors: believing that obedience purchases salvation and believing that salvation has no consequences for human conduct.

Question 8 — Do Paul and James Contradict Each Other Concerning Faith and Works?

Answer:

No. When their teachings are examined in their respective contexts, Paul and James address different problems.

Paul opposes the idea that human beings can establish their righteousness before God through their own works.

James opposes a profession of faith that produces no practical transformation.

Paul explains the foundation of justification: God's grace received through faith.

James emphasizes that genuine faith is demonstrated through action.

Both writers refer to Abraham.

Paul emphasizes Abraham's faith in God's promise, drawing upon Genesis 15:6.

James considers Abraham's obedience in Genesis 22, showing how his faith was expressed through action.

Their arguments are therefore complementary rather than contradictory.

Paul rejects works as the meritorious basis of salvation.

James rejects an empty profession of faith that has no corresponding conduct.

The biblical conclusion is that good works do not replace faith, but living faith produces good works.

Bible References:

- Genesis 15:6
- Genesis 22:1–18
- Romans 4:1–5
- Galatians 5:6
- Ephesians 2:8–10
- James 2:14–26

Doctrinal Note:

The expressions justified by faith and justified by works must be interpreted within each writer's argument.

Paul emphasizes how sinners are accepted before God.

James emphasizes how genuine faith is demonstrated and brought to maturity through obedience.

Question 9 — Does God's Grace Release Us From Obeying His Commandments?

Answer:

No. Grace must not be understood as permission to disobey God deliberately.

In Romans 6, Paul directly addresses the question of whether believers should continue in sin so that grace may increase.

His answer is emphatically negative.

He teaches that those united with Jesus Christ are called to walk in newness of life.

Grace delivers believers from the condemnation of sin and calls them to freedom from its dominion.

Jesus also teaches that love for Him is expressed through obedience to His commandments.

The apostle John likewise connects the knowledge of God with keeping His commandments.

Christian obedience is therefore not opposed to grace when it is understood as a response of faith and love.

Believers do not obey in order to purchase salvation.

They obey because God's grace has begun to transform their hearts and lives.

Bible References:

- John 14:15
- Romans 6:1–15
- Romans 8:1–4
- Titus 2:11–14

- 1 John 2:3–6
- 1 John 5:2–3

Doctrinal Note:

Being under grace does not mean having permission to sin.

In Romans 6, the expression appears within Paul's teaching concerning liberation from the dominion of sin.

Question 10 — What Is the Relationship Between Grace and God's Law?

Answer:

Grace and God's law fulfill different functions within the plan of salvation.

The law reveals God's will, identifies sin, and shows human beings their need for redemption.

Grace provides the forgiveness and restoration that obedience to the law cannot produce.

The apostle Paul teaches that the knowledge of sin comes through the law.

He also teaches that justification is received through faith in Jesus Christ.

In Romans 3:31, Paul explains that faith does not make the law void.

According to Seventh-day Adventist understanding, grace does not abolish the moral principles expressed in God's commandments.

Rather, grace enables believers to respond to God's will through love and the work of the Holy Spirit.

The new covenant includes God's promise to write His law in the hearts and minds of His people.

Thus, grace and obedience are not competing means of salvation.

Grace saves; obedience expresses the believer's transformed relationship with God.

Bible References:

- Matthew 5:17–19
- Romans 3:19–31
- Romans 7:7, 12
- Romans 8:3–4
- Galatians 3:21–25
- Hebrews 8:10

Doctrinal Note:

Paul uses the word law in several contexts, including the Mosaic law, God's commandments, and principles operating within human experience.

Each passage must be examined in context.

The distinction between the moral and ceremonial dimensions of the law will be studied in Chapters 15–17.

Question 11 — Does God's Grace Truly Transform the Believer's Life?

Answer:

Yes. Divine grace not only provides forgiveness but also calls believers to genuine transformation.

The apostle Paul teaches that God's grace instructs believers to reject ungodliness and worldly desires.

It leads them toward a life characterized by self-control, righteousness, and godliness.

The Christian life is therefore more than the cancellation of past guilt.

It involves spiritual renewal.

Paul teaches that believers are called to walk in newness of life.

He also describes the transformation of the mind and the development of the fruit of the Spirit.

This transformation is not presented as the achievement of human willpower acting independently of God.

It is connected with the work of the Holy Spirit and continued communion with Jesus Christ.

Believers are called to turn away from practices contrary to God's will and develop a character increasingly reflecting Christ.

Bible References:

- Romans 6:4–14
- Romans 12:1–2
- 2 Corinthians 5:17
- Galatians 5:16–25
- Titus 2:11–14
- Titus 3:5–7

Explanatory Note:

Christian transformation does not mean that believers immediately become incapable of sinning.

It describes a new life in which God works to produce spiritual growth, repentance, and obedience.

Question 12 — What Should Believers Do When They Fall Into Sin Again?

Answer:

The Bible invites believers who have sinned to acknowledge their wrongdoing, repent, and return to God with confidence in His mercy.

Salvation by grace does not mean that Christians will never experience weakness or failure.

The apostle John writes to believers so that they may avoid sin.

However, he also teaches that if anyone sins, Jesus Christ is the believer's Advocate with the Father.

John further declares:

> “If we confess our sins, he is faithful and just to forgive us our sins, and to cleanse us from all unrighteousness.”

1 John 1:9 — KJV

Believers should therefore neither minimize sin nor despair of God's mercy.

They are called to confess their sins sincerely and seek a renewed life.

The parable of the prodigal son illustrates the Father's willingness to receive the repentant sinner.

Grace encourages repentance and restoration.

It must never become an excuse for deliberately maintaining sinful practices.

Bible References:

- Psalm 51:1–12
- Proverbs 28:13
- Luke 15:11–24
- 1 John 1:8–9
- 1 John 2:1–2
- Hebrews 4:14–16

Doctrinal Note:

A fall followed by sincere repentance must be distinguished from a persistent attitude of defending or deliberately maintaining sin.

God calls believers to return to Him and persevere in faith.

Question 13 — Can God's Grace Be Misused?

Answer:

Yes. The Bible warns against distorting the teaching of divine grace.

Some may regard God's forgiveness as permission to continue deliberately in conduct contrary to His will.

The Letter of Jude warns against people who turn God's grace into an excuse for immoral behavior.

Paul also rejects the suggestion that believers should continue sinning so that grace may abound.

The New Testament does not present grace as the abolition of holiness.

Instead, grace reveals God's love and teaches believers to live with gratitude, purity, and obedience.

The Letter to the Hebrews contains serious warnings concerning the deliberate and persistent rejection of Christ's sacrifice.

These warnings should be understood within their context.

They emphasize the seriousness of rejecting God's saving provision.

They should not be used to convince sincerely repentant believers that one failure has automatically placed them beyond divine forgiveness.

Bible References:

- Romans 6:1–2, 15
- Galatians 5:13
- Titus 2:11–14
- Jude 1:4
- Hebrews 10:26–29

Explanatory Note:

Hebrews 10:26–29 warns against deliberate and persistent rejection of the sacrifice of Christ.

It must not be interpreted as teaching that a genuinely repentant person is automatically excluded from forgiveness after committing a sin.

Question 14 — Is God's Grace Offered to Every Nation and People?

Answer:

Yes. God's grace is offered to humanity without discrimination based on ethnicity, nationality, or social position.

The New Testament teaches that God desires all people to be saved and to come to the knowledge of the truth.

The apostle Paul declares that the grace of God bringing salvation has appeared to all people.

The Gospel is therefore to be proclaimed to every nation.

Peter also declares that God is no respecter of persons.

The Book of Revelation presents the everlasting Gospel as a message addressed to every nation, kindred, tongue, and people.

This universal offer of grace reflects God's love for the entire human family.

However, the universality of the invitation does not mean that every person will automatically be saved.

The Bible presents salvation as freely offered while emphasizing the importance of responding to God's call.

Bible References:

- John 3:16–17
- Acts 10:34–35
- Romans 10:11–13
- 1 Timothy 2:3–6
- Titus 2:11

- Revelation 14:6–7

Doctrinal Note:

The universal offer of grace must be distinguished from universalism, the belief that all people will necessarily be saved.

Scripture presents both God's universal invitation and the responsibility of responding to His grace.

Question 15 — How Can We Continue to Live in God's Grace?

Answer:

To continue in God's grace means to keep placing our trust in Jesus Christ and live in an ongoing relationship of faith with Him.

Believers should not regard grace merely as an isolated event in their past.

They are called to persevere in faith, rely upon God's promises, and grow in the knowledge of the Lord.

In John 15, Jesus uses the image of the vine and its branches to illustrate the believer's dependence upon Him.

A branch cannot bear fruit independently of the vine.

Likewise, spiritual life depends upon continued communion with Christ.

Prayer, Bible study, repentance, love, and obedience are important expressions of this living relationship.

However, these practices do not purchase grace.

They express the believer's response to God's love.

The apostle Peter calls Christians to grow in grace and in the knowledge of Jesus Christ.

Christian perseverance therefore rests upon continued dependence on God's gracious power.

Bible References:

- John 15:1–10
- Romans 5:1–2
- Colossians 2:6–7
- Hebrews 4:14–16
- 2 Peter 3:17–18
- Jude 1:20–21

Doctrinal Note:

Perseverance must not be understood as an attempt to maintain salvation through independent human effort.

It rests upon continuing faith in God's grace and the transforming work of the Holy Spirit.

Chapter Summary

Grace is one of the most important teachings in the biblical plan of salvation.

It reveals that God does not require human beings to become righteous through their own efforts before they may approach Him.

God takes the initiative to save, forgive, and transform.

The Bible teaches that salvation is freely given through Jesus Christ and received by faith.

Good works and obedience have an important place in Christian life, but they do not purchase salvation.

They are the fruits of God's transforming grace.

Our study establishes fifteen essential teachings:

1. Grace is God's undeserved favor toward humanity.

2. All human beings need grace because of sin.

3. Divine grace was already revealed in the Old Testament.

4. Salvation is a free gift, not an earned reward.

5. Jesus Christ is the foundation of our redemption.

6. Faith is the means through which we receive salvation offered by grace.

7. Good works are the fruits of salvation, not its price.

8. Paul and James present complementary teachings concerning faith and works.

9. Grace does not give permission to disobey God deliberately.

10. The law reveals sin, while grace provides forgiveness and restoration.

11. Grace produces genuine transformation in the believer's life.

12. Believers who fall into sin are invited to return to God through repentance.

13. Grace must not become an excuse for continuing in sin.

14. God's offer of grace extends to all nations.

15. Believers are called to persevere in a living relationship with Jesus Christ.

Doctrinal Conclusion

Salvation is entirely a gift of God's grace, received through faith in Jesus Christ.

No human being can earn salvation through personal righteousness.

God took the initiative to provide redemption through the life, death, and resurrection of Jesus Christ.

Grace is not a reward for obedience.

It is the expression of God's love and mercy toward sinners.

Faith receives the gift that grace provides.

Good works do not constitute the foundation of justification before God.

However, genuine faith produces visible consequences in Christian life.

The teachings of Paul and James are therefore complementary when interpreted in their proper contexts.

Grace does not abolish the importance of God's moral will.

It leads believers to love Him, reject sin, and live in obedience through the power of the Holy Spirit.

When believers fall, they are invited to repent and return to God.

Grace must never be misused as an excuse for deliberate wrongdoing.

The offer of salvation extends to every nation and people.

Those who receive this gift are called to continue trusting in Jesus Christ and growing in His grace.

The Essential Message:

We are not saved because we have obeyed God sufficiently. We are saved by His grace through faith in Jesus Christ. And that same grace teaches us to love God, reject sin, and live according to His will.

Personal Reflection Questions

1. Have I truly understood that salvation is a gift from God rather than a reward I can earn?

2. Do I place greater confidence in my good works or in the saving work of Jesus Christ?

3. How has God's grace been revealed in my life?

4. Do I sometimes regard grace as permission to neglect God's commandments?

5. Is my faith producing practical changes in the way I live?

6. When I commit a wrong, do I return to God with sincere repentance?

7. How can I demonstrate grace and mercy toward the people around me?

8. Am I willing to grow each day in the grace and knowledge of Jesus Christ?

Suggested Prayer

Heavenly Father,

I thank You for Your wonderful grace and for the love You have revealed to humanity through Jesus Christ.

I recognize that I cannot earn salvation through my own efforts.

Thank You for freely offering forgiveness and eternal life through the sacrifice of Your Son.

Teach me to place all my confidence in Jesus Christ rather than in my personal merits.

May Your grace transform my thoughts, words, and actions.

Give me a humble and grateful heart, willing to obey Your Word.

When I fall, help me return sincerely to You without attempting to justify my wrongdoing.

Protect me from treating Your grace as permission to sin.

Strengthen my faith and guide me each day in Your truth.

May my life bear witness to Your love before everyone You place along my path.

Prepare me to remain faithful until the glorious return of Jesus Christ.

In the name of Jesus Christ, my Savior and Lord.

Amen.

Remember

Grace is God's undeserved gift of salvation through Jesus Christ. It forgives the repentant sinner, strengthens faith, and transforms the believer's life. Good works are not the price of salvation; they are the fruit of a heart renewed by divine grace.

CHAPTER 10 — FAITH: WHAT DOES IT TRULY MEAN TO BELIEVE IN GOD?

A Thematic Bible Study — King James Version (KJV)

Chapter Objective

To understand the biblical definition of faith, its origin, its development, and its essential place in salvation and Christian life.

This chapter examines the examples of Abraham and other biblical witnesses, the relationship between faith and works, the difference between faith and presumption, the experience of doubt, the purpose of trials, prayer, perseverance, and preparation for the return of Jesus Christ.

Central Teaching: Biblical faith is a living trust in God, founded upon His character, His Word, and His promises. Through faith, believers receive salvation offered by grace in Jesus Christ. Genuine faith produces love, obedience, perseverance, and a transformed life, but it does not guarantee that every personal desire will be fulfilled.

Opening Scripture

> “Now faith is the substance of things hoped for, the evidence of things not seen.”

Hebrews 11:1 — KJV

Introduction

In the previous chapter, we discovered that salvation is a gift from God, granted through His grace rather than through human merit.

The apostle Paul teaches that we are saved by grace through faith.

This declaration leads us to a fundamental question: What is genuine biblical faith?

For some people, faith simply means believing that God exists.

For others, it means expecting a favorable outcome even when circumstances appear unfavorable.

But the Bible presents a deeper understanding.

Biblical faith involves trusting God, receiving His Word, and maintaining a living relationship with Jesus Christ.

It is not limited to intellectual conviction or religious emotion.

Abraham left his homeland because he trusted God's promise.

Moses chose to identify with God's people rather than enjoy the privileges of Egypt.

The disciples left their former occupations to follow Jesus.

These examples show that genuine faith influences decisions and conduct.

Nevertheless, faith must not be confused with good works.

Neither is it a guarantee that every personal expectation will be fulfilled.

How does faith begin?

How does it grow?

Can it coexist with doubt?

What role does it play in salvation, prayer, trials, obedience, and perseverance?

We will examine fifteen biblical questions to understand these essential teachings.

Question 1 — What Is Faith According to the Bible?

Answer:

Biblical faith is trust founded upon God's character, faithfulness, and promises.

Hebrews 11:1 presents faith as assurance concerning what is hoped for and conviction regarding realities that are not yet seen.

This does not mean that faith consists of believing without any reason or accepting every claim without examination.

In Scripture, faith rests upon God's revelation, His actions in history, and confidence in His character.

It enables believers to rely upon divine promises even when their fulfillment is not yet visible.

The apostle Paul describes Abraham as trusting God's promise despite circumstances that appeared humanly impossible.

The Book of Proverbs likewise calls believers to trust the LORD rather than depend entirely upon their own understanding.

Faith therefore has an intellectual dimension because it involves knowledge of what God has revealed.

It also has a personal dimension because it engages trust, commitment, and the will.

Bible References:

- Hebrews 11:1–3
- Romans 4:18–21
- 2 Corinthians 5:7
- Psalm 9:10
- Proverbs 3:5–6

Explanatory Note:

Hebrews 11 does not present faith as a power by which human thoughts create reality.

Rather, it describes men and women who trusted God and acted according to His promises.

Question 2 — Is Believing That God Exists Enough to Have Genuine Faith?

Answer:

No. Intellectual acknowledgment of God's existence does not, by itself, constitute saving faith.

The Letter of James declares:

> “Thou believest that there is one God; thou doest well: the devils also believe, and tremble.”

James 2:19 — KJV

This passage demonstrates that it is possible to acknowledge certain truths about God without having a relationship of trust and obedience with Him.

Biblical faith therefore goes beyond accepting the existence of God.

It involves recognizing Him as trustworthy, receiving His Word, and relying upon Jesus Christ for salvation.

In the New Testament, believing in Jesus means much more than admitting that He existed historically.

It means trusting Him as Savior and Lord.

John explains that his Gospel was written so that readers might believe Jesus is the Christ, the Son of God, and receive life through His name.

Bible References:

- James 2:14–20

- John 1:12
- John 3:16–18
- John 20:30–31
- Romans 10:9–10

Explanatory Note:

Religious knowledge must be distinguished from personal trust.

A person may know many biblical doctrines without allowing that knowledge to transform their relationship with God.

Question 3 — Where Does Faith Come From?

Answer:

Faith arises through God's gracious initiative, the revelation of His Word, and the human response to His invitation.

The apostle Paul declares:

> “So then faith cometh by hearing, and hearing by the word of God.”

Romans 10:17 — KJV

In its context, Paul explains the importance of proclaiming the Gospel so that people may hear the message of salvation and believe.

Faith is therefore not presented merely as a psychological ability produced independently of divine revelation.

God works through His Word and His Spirit to lead human beings toward Jesus Christ.

The Gospel of John teaches that the Father draws people to the Son.

The Book of Acts describes how the Lord opened Lydia's heart to respond to Paul's message.

However, hearing the biblical message does not automatically produce genuine faith.

People are called to receive the truth and respond to God's gracious invitation.

Bible References:

- Romans 10:14–17
- John 6:44–45
- John 16:8–14
- Acts 16:14
- Ephesians 2:8–10
- Philippians 1:29

Doctrinal Note:

Romans 10:17 particularly emphasizes the role of Gospel proclamation.

It should not be reduced to the idea that mechanically repeating biblical words will automatically produce faith.

Question 4 — Why Is Abraham Presented as a Model of Faith?

Answer:

Abraham is presented as a model of faith because he trusted God and His promises even when their fulfillment appeared humanly improbable.

In Genesis 12, God called Abraham to leave his country and relatives and travel to a land that He would show him.

Abraham obeyed without knowing every detail of his future.

Later, God promised him numerous descendants, even though Abraham and Sarah were advanced in age.

Genesis 15:6 teaches that Abraham believed the LORD and that his faith was counted to him for righteousness.

Paul uses this passage in Romans 4 to demonstrate that justification rests upon faith rather than human merit.

The Letter to the Hebrews likewise presents Abraham as an example of trusting obedience.

James refers to Abraham's later obedience to demonstrate how genuine faith becomes visible through actions.

Abraham's experience therefore illustrates both justification by faith and the practical consequences of living faith.

Bible References:

- Genesis 12:1–4
- Genesis 15:1–6
- Genesis 22:1–18
- Romans 4:1–22
- Hebrews 11:8–19
- James 2:21–23

Explanatory Note:

Abraham was not a man without weaknesses.

The accounts in Genesis 12, 16, and 20 reveal some of his mistakes.

His example teaches that genuine faith does not depend upon prior human perfection but upon trust in God.

Question 5 — What Is the Relationship Between Faith and Salvation?

Answer:

Faith is the means through which human beings receive the salvation that God freely offers by His grace.

The Bible teaches that no one can obtain justification before God through personal merit.

Jesus Christ accomplished the redemptive work necessary for salvation.

Faith means placing confidence in His person, sacrifice, and promises.

The apostle Paul declares:

> “Therefore being justified by faith, we have peace with God through our Lord Jesus Christ:”

Romans 5:1 — KJV

This means that faith does not replace the work of the Savior.

It enables believers to receive what God has accomplished on their behalf.

The foundation of salvation remains divine grace revealed through Jesus Christ.

Faith is not a payment offered to God.

It is the trusting response of the sinner to God's gracious provision.

Bible References:

- John 3:16
- Romans 3:21–28
- Romans 5:1–2
- Galatians 2:16
- Ephesians 2:8–9
- Philippians 3:8–9

Doctrinal Note:

Faith is not the price of salvation.

It is not a meritorious work that obligates God to grant eternal life.

Salvation rests entirely upon God's grace and the saving work of Jesus Christ.

Question 6 — Must Genuine Faith Produce Good Works?

Answer:

Yes. The Bible teaches that genuine faith expresses itself through actions consistent with God's will.

However, these actions do not constitute the meritorious foundation of salvation.

In James 2, the writer describes a person who claims to have faith but refuses to help a brother or sister in need.

James demonstrates that a profession of faith without practical love is insufficient.

The apostle Paul also teaches that believers are created in Christ Jesus for good works.

Faith and works must therefore not be regarded as competing methods of obtaining salvation.

Faith receives divine grace.

Good works testify to the transforming activity of that grace.

Jesus taught that a tree is known by its fruit.

Likewise, the authenticity of Christian faith becomes visible through love, compassion, honesty, and obedience.

Bible References:

- James 2:14–26
- Ephesians 2:8–10
- Galatians 5:6
- Titus 3:5–8
- Matthew 7:16–20

Doctrinal Note:

It is essential to distinguish works performed in an attempt to earn salvation from works that result from living faith.

This distinction helps explain the harmony between the teachings of Paul and James.

Question 7 — What Is the Difference Between Faith and Presumption?

Answer:

Faith means trusting God and acting according to His will.

Presumption means expecting God to fulfill our wishes even when we act contrary to His Word.

This distinction appears clearly in the account of Jesus' temptation.

Satan challenged Jesus to throw Himself down from the pinnacle of the temple while appealing to a biblical promise of divine protection.

Jesus refused.

He answered by citing the command not to tempt the Lord.

His response demonstrates that genuine faith does not deliberately create danger in order to force God to intervene.

Faith does not manipulate divine promises.

It trusts God's character while respecting His will and instructions.

The Bible also teaches that believers should seek God's wisdom rather than rely arrogantly upon their own understanding.

Bible References:

- Deuteronomy 6:16
- Matthew 4:5–7
- Psalm 91:1–16
- Proverbs 3:5–7
- 1 John 5:14–15

Explanatory Note:

Biblical promises must be interpreted in context.

They do not guarantee that God will protect people from every consequence of deliberately reckless behavior.

Question 8 — Can Someone Have Faith While Experiencing Doubt?

Answer:

Yes. The Bible shows that sincere believers sometimes experience uncertainty, fear, or difficulty understanding.

In Mark 9, a father asked Jesus to help his suffering child.

He expressed both his faith and his need for help with unbelief.

The King James Version records his words:

> “Lord, I believe; help thou mine unbelief.”

Mark 9:24 — KJV, words of the father (excerpt)

Thomas also struggled to believe the testimony of the other disciples after Jesus' resurrection.

These accounts demonstrate that faith may be confronted by questions and hesitation.

However, Scripture also warns against deliberately rejecting truth.

Sincere doubt may become an opportunity to seek God more deeply when approached with humility and a willingness to learn.

Jesus responded patiently to people who sincerely sought understanding.

Faith does not require pretending that difficult questions do not exist.

It calls believers to bring those questions before God and continue seeking truth.

Bible References:

- Mark 9:17–24
- John 20:24–29

- Matthew 14:28–31
- Luke 24:36–43
- Jude 1:22

Explanatory Note:

Sincere doubt that seeks understanding should be distinguished from deliberate unbelief that persistently rejects truth.

The Bible presents God as patient toward those who seek Him honestly.

Question 9 — How Can Faith Grow?

Answer:

Faith grows as believers deepen their knowledge of God and learn to trust Him in different circumstances.

Studying Scripture helps them discover God's character, His promises, and the testimony of His faithfulness.

Prayer strengthens personal communion with Him.

Obedience provides opportunities to put biblical understanding into practice.

Fellowship with other believers also encourages perseverance and mutual support.

The disciples themselves asked Jesus to increase their faith.

Paul teaches that faith is connected with hearing God's Word.

Peter calls believers to grow in spiritual qualities that reflect an active relationship with God.

However, spiritual growth does not depend merely upon accumulating religious information.

It requires living communion with Jesus Christ.

Faith matures as believers continue trusting Him, including during difficult circumstances.

Bible References:

- Romans 10:17
- Luke 17:5
- John 15:4–7
- Colossians 2:6–7
- Hebrews 10:23–25
- 2 Peter 1:5–8

Explanatory Note:

Spiritual growth does not always follow a smooth or visibly continuous progression.

Periods of difficulty may accompany genuine faith.

What matters is continuing to seek God and rely upon His faithfulness.

Question 10 — Why Does God Allow Faith to Be Tested?

Answer:

The Bible teaches that trials can contribute to the development of perseverance, patience, and spiritual maturity.

James explains that the testing of faith produces patience.

Peter compares tested faith to gold refined by fire.

These images emphasize the possibility of spiritual growth through adversity.

However, we should not conclude that every experience of suffering is directly sent by God to punish or test a person.

Scripture also recognizes suffering resulting from sin, human injustice, the broken condition of the world, and circumstances whose full causes remain unknown.

The Book of Job warns against assuming that suffering always proves personal wrongdoing.

God can sustain believers amid difficulties and use painful experiences to strengthen their trust.

The Christian response to suffering is therefore not to assign a simplistic explanation to every hardship.

It is to seek God's presence, wisdom, and sustaining grace.

Bible References:

- Job 1:6–22
- Romans 5:3–5
- James 1:2–4, 12–13
- 1 Peter 1:6–7
- 2 Corinthians 4:16–18

Doctrinal Note:

James 1:13 teaches that God does not tempt people to evil.

A distinction must therefore be made between trials that test faith and temptations that seek to lead people into sin.

Question 11 — Does Faith Guarantee That Every Prayer Will Be Answered Exactly as We Wish?

Answer:

No. Genuine faith rests upon trust in God, not upon certainty that every personal preference will be fulfilled.

Jesus encouraged His disciples to pray with faith.

However, He also taught them to seek the Father's will.

In 1 John 5:14–15, confidence in prayer is connected with asking according to God's will.

The apostle Paul described a difficulty that he called a thorn in the flesh.

He prayed repeatedly for its removal.

God did not grant precisely the deliverance Paul requested.

Instead, He assured Paul that divine grace was sufficient for him.

Faith therefore does not mean imposing our will upon God.

It means presenting our needs with confidence while trusting His wisdom.

Jesus Himself prayed in Gethsemane with submission to the Father's will.

The believer's confidence rests in God's faithfulness, even when the answer differs from personal expectations.

Bible References:

- Matthew 6:9–13
- Matthew 26:39
- Mark 11:22–24
- 2 Corinthians 12:7–10
- Philippians 4:6–7
- 1 John 5:14–15

Explanatory Note:

Biblical promises concerning prayer must be interpreted alongside the whole testimony of Scripture.

A prayer not answered according to our expectations does not automatically prove a lack of faith.

Question 12 — Why Does the Bible Say That the Just Shall Live by Faith?

Answer:

This declaration appears in Habakkuk 2:4 and is repeated several times in the New Testament.

In the Book of Habakkuk, the prophet struggles with questions concerning injustice and God's action in history.

The divine response emphasizes faithfulness and trust in God despite difficult circumstances.

The apostle Paul applies this declaration to the teaching that righteousness before God is received through faith.

The Letter to the Hebrews uses the same passage to encourage believers to persevere.

The expression therefore has both a saving and a practical dimension.

To live by faith means depending upon God for salvation and continuing to trust Him throughout life.

It involves confidence in His promises and faithfulness to His Word.

Faith is not merely the beginning of Christian experience.

It is the continuing foundation of the believer's relationship with God.

Bible References:

- Habakkuk 2:1–4
- Romans 1:16–17
- Galatians 3:11
- Hebrews 10:35–39
- 2 Corinthians 5:7

Explanatory Note:

The Hebrew language of Habakkuk 2:4 includes the idea of faithfulness and steadfastness.

In the New Testament, the passage is applied to faith that receives God's righteousness and perseveres in trust.

Question 13 — Can Faith Be Lost or Abandoned?

Answer:

The Bible warns believers against the danger of deliberately turning away from God and abandoning trust in Jesus Christ.

In the parable of the sower, Jesus describes people who receive the Word with joy but fall away during a time of testing.

The apostle Paul also refers to individuals who have departed from the faith.

The Letter to the Hebrews repeatedly encourages believers to remain steadfast.

These warnings demonstrate that perseverance is an important dimension of Christian life.

However, Scripture also emphasizes God's faithfulness and His power to sustain those who trust Him.

Jude concludes his letter by praising God, who is able to keep believers from falling.

Christians are therefore not called to live in constant terror of losing salvation.

They are called to remain in a living relationship with Jesus Christ, trusting His grace and responding faithfully to His Word.

Bible References:

- Luke 8:11–15
- John 15:1–6
- 1 Timothy 1:18–20
- Hebrews 3:12–14
- Hebrews 10:35–39

- Jude 1:24–25

Doctrinal Note:

Christian traditions differ concerning perseverance and the possibility of abandoning salvation.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, Scripture calls believers to remain freely and faithfully in Christ while emphasizing that God provides the grace necessary for perseverance.

Question 14 — What Role Does Faith Play While We Await the Return of Jesus Christ?

Answer:

Faith enables believers to live in hope of Jesus Christ's return even though the promise has not yet been fulfilled.

The New Testament presents the second coming as certain while teaching that its exact date remains unknown.

Faith therefore encourages watchfulness, patience, and faithfulness.

It should not produce constant speculation concerning prophetic dates.

Instead, Jesus calls His followers to be prepared by living according to His will.

The apostle Paul describes the blessed hope of Christ's glorious appearing.

Peter connects the expectation of God's future promises with holy conduct.

The Letter to the Hebrews calls believers to persevere while awaiting the fulfillment of God's promises.

Faith in Christ's return should therefore inspire a life of holiness, love, service, and hope.

Bible References:

- Matthew 24:36–44
- Luke 12:35–40
- Titus 2:11–13
- Hebrews 10:35–39
- 2 Peter 3:11–14
- Revelation 22:12, 20

Doctrinal Note:

The certainty of Jesus' return does not authorize believers to determine its exact date.

Biblical faith rests upon the reliability of God's promise rather than speculative calculations.

Question 15 — How Can We Demonstrate Genuine Faith in Everyday Life?

Answer:

Genuine faith is demonstrated through continuing trust in God and conduct shaped by His teachings.

It influences decisions, relationships, work, stewardship of resources, and attitudes toward others.

A person who lives by faith seeks to be honest, just, compassionate, and faithful to commitments.

Faith also teaches believers to depend upon God during both favorable and difficult circumstances.

Christian obedience is not regarded as a way of purchasing salvation.

It is a response to divine love.

Jesus calls His followers to be the light of the world through lives that glorify the Father.

The apostle Paul teaches that faith works through love.

James emphasizes that genuine faith becomes visible through practical acts of compassion.

Christian faith is therefore expressed not merely through religious declarations but through the character and actions of the believer.

It also includes witness, service, and hope in God's promises.

Bible References:

- Matthew 5:13–16
- John 15:4–10
- Romans 12:1–2
- Galatians 5:6, 22–23
- Colossians 3:12–17
- James 2:14–18

Explanatory Note:

Genuine faith should not be measured exclusively by outward displays of religiosity.

Scripture places particular importance upon the motives of the heart, love, and faithfulness toward God.

Chapter Summary

Faith is an essential dimension of the plan of salvation and Christian life.

Through faith, human beings receive God's grace, rely upon His promises, and persevere in hope.

Biblical faith is not merely an intellectual conviction or an expectation that personal wishes will be fulfilled.

It is a living trust in God that influences decisions and conduct.

Our study establishes fifteen essential teachings:

1. Faith is trust founded upon God, His Word, and His promises.

2. Intellectual acknowledgment of God's existence is not sufficient for saving faith.

3. Faith arises through God's action and the reception of His Word.

4. Abraham provides a remarkable example of trust in God.

5. Salvation is received through faith rather than human merit.

6. Genuine faith produces works consistent with God's will.

7. Faith must be distinguished from presumption.

8. Sincere believers may experience periods of doubt.

9. Faith grows through communion with God and the study of Scripture.

10. Trials can contribute to spiritual perseverance.

11. Faith does not guarantee the fulfillment of every personal expectation.

12. The righteous are called to live continually in trust toward God.

13. Scripture encourages perseverance and warns against abandoning faith.

14. Faith sustains hope in the return of Jesus Christ.

15. Genuine faith progressively transforms everyday life.

Doctrinal Conclusion

Biblical faith is a living relationship of trust in God, founded upon His Word and centered upon Jesus Christ.

Faith does not merely mean believing that God exists.

It means trusting His character, receiving His promises, and relying upon the saving work of Jesus Christ.

Salvation is given by grace and received through faith.

Faith does not earn salvation.

It receives what God freely provides.

Genuine faith also produces practical consequences.

It leads believers toward love, compassion, honesty, obedience, and service.

However, faith must not be confused with presumption.

It does not authorize reckless behavior or guarantee that God will fulfill every personal desire.

The Bible recognizes that believers may experience doubt, suffering, and difficult circumstances.

Such experiences do not automatically prove the absence of faith.

God calls His people to seek Him sincerely, grow in trust, and persevere.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, faith also sustains the believer's hope in the personal, visible, and glorious return of Jesus Christ.

The Essential Message:

Faith is not simply believing that God exists. It means trusting Him, receiving His salvation through Jesus Christ, and living each day according to His Word, even when we do not fully understand the circumstances of life.

Personal Reflection Questions

1. Is my faith founded upon a personal knowledge of God or merely upon religious traditions?

2. Do I genuinely trust God's promises?

3. How does my faith influence my daily decisions?

4. Do I sometimes confuse faith with certainty that God will fulfill all my wishes?

5. How do I respond when my prayers are not answered as expected?

6. What experiences have strengthened my trust in God?

7. Is my faith expressed through love, compassion, and obedience?

8. Am I willing to persevere in faith until the return of Jesus Christ?

Suggested Prayer

Heavenly Father,

I thank You for Your Word and for the grace You offer me through Jesus Christ.

I recognize that I cannot save myself and that I need to place my complete trust in You.

Strengthen my faith and help me know Your character, promises, and will more deeply.

When I experience doubt, enlighten my understanding and guide me into Your truth.

When difficulties arise, give me the patience and perseverance necessary to remain faithful.

Teach me not to confuse faith with presumption, but to seek Your will humbly.

May my trust in You transform my thoughts, words, and actions.

Help me demonstrate living faith through love, justice, and compassion toward others.

Protect me from spiritual pride and remind me that my salvation rests entirely upon Your grace.

Lord Jesus, keep my heart close to You and prepare me for the glorious day of Your return.

In the name of Jesus Christ, my Savior and Lord.

Amen.

Remember

Genuine faith is more than intellectual belief. It is a living trust in God, expressed through love, obedience, perseverance, and confidence in His promises. Faith receives salvation by grace and continues to depend upon Jesus Christ throughout life.

CHAPTER 11 — REPENTANCE AND CONVERSION: HOW CAN WE RETURN TO GOD AND BEGIN A NEW LIFE?

A Thematic Bible Study — King James Version (KJV)

Chapter Objective

To understand repentance and conversion in the light of Scripture, distinguish genuine repentance from mere regret, and explain how God's grace leads sinners toward forgiveness and a transformed life.

This chapter also examines the work of the Holy Spirit, confession, restitution, faith, baptism, and perseverance in the Christian experience.

Central Teaching: Biblical repentance is a sincere change of heart and attitude toward sin and God. Conversion means turning away from the former direction of life and turning toward God through faith in Jesus Christ. Neither repentance nor conversion earns salvation; both are responses to divine grace and produce visible fruits in the believer's life.

Opening Scripture

> “Repent ye therefore, and be converted, that your sins may be blotted out,”

Acts 3:19 — KJV, opening portion

Introduction

In the previous chapters, we studied God's love, the sacrifice of Jesus Christ, divine grace, and biblical faith.

We discovered that salvation is not a reward for human goodness.

It is God's gracious gift, received through faith in Jesus Christ.

But another essential question remains: What happens when a person recognizes their sins and sincerely desires to return to God?

The Bible teaches that salvation involves more than acknowledging God's existence or accepting religious doctrines intellectually.

It brings a fundamental change in the relationship between human beings and their Creator.

This change involves recognizing our spiritual condition and responding to God's gracious invitation.

Scripture uses two closely related concepts to describe this response: repentance and conversion.

Repentance concerns a change of mind, disposition, and attitude toward sin and God.

Conversion describes turning away from a former course of life and turning toward the Lord.

These realities are closely connected.

However, several questions arise.

Is feeling sorry for wrongdoing enough?

Must sins be confessed?

Can serious sins be forgiven?

How can genuine conversion be recognized?

What role does the Holy Spirit play?

Does conversion mean that believers will never sin again?

We will examine fifteen biblical questions to understand these teachings.

Question 1 — What Is Repentance According to the Bible?

Answer:

Biblical repentance is a sincere change of attitude toward sin and toward God.

It includes recognizing wrongdoing, acknowledging personal responsibility, desiring to turn away from evil, and returning to God.

The Greek word metanoia, commonly translated as repentance, is associated with a change of mind or disposition.

However, its full biblical meaning must be understood through the passages in which it appears.

Jesus called people to repent and believe the Gospel.

Peter called his hearers to repentance after proclaiming the death and resurrection of Jesus Christ.

The apostles therefore presented repentance as a necessary response to the message of salvation.

Repentance is more than feeling guilty.

It involves a changed attitude that leads toward a changed direction of life.

Nevertheless, repentance does not make sinners worthy of salvation through their own merit.

It is a response to God's gracious initiative.

Bible References:

- Mark 1:14–15
- Acts 2:37–38
- Acts 3:19
- 2 Peter 3:9

Explanatory Note:

The meaning of repentance should not be reduced to a dictionary definition of one Greek word.

The broader biblical teaching includes recognition of sin, turning toward God, and the practical fruits of a changed heart.

Question 2 — Why Did Jesus Call People to Repent?

Answer:

Jesus called people to repentance because He proclaimed the arrival of God's kingdom and invited them to respond to the Gospel.

His message required more than passive agreement.

It called for a personal response.

Jesus declared:

> "The time is fulfilled, and the kingdom of God is at hand: repent ye, and believe the gospel."

Mark 1:15 — KJV, words of Jesus (excerpt)

Repentance and faith appear together in this proclamation.

Jesus came to call sinners to repentance.

He compared His mission to that of a physician who comes to those who need healing.

His invitation was therefore an expression of divine mercy.

In Luke 13, Jesus also called His hearers to repent while discussing tragic events.

He rejected the assumption that those who had suffered were necessarily more sinful than others.

Instead, He directed His audience toward the universal need for repentance.

Bible References:

- Mark 1:14–15
- Luke 5:31–32
- Luke 13:1–5

Doctrinal Note:

Luke 13 does not authorize believers to conclude that victims of tragedy are more guilty than other people.

Jesus explicitly challenges that assumption.

His teaching calls everyone to examine their own relationship with God.

Question 3 — What Is the Difference Between Remorse and Repentance?

Answer:

Remorse may involve sorrow, regret, shame, or distress concerning the consequences of wrongdoing.

Repentance goes further.

It involves recognizing the wrong itself and turning toward God with a desire for change.

The apostle Paul distinguishes godly sorrow from sorrow that does not lead to life.

In 2 Corinthians 7, he explains that godly sorrow produces repentance.

The psalmist David provides an example of confession and recognition of sin in Psalm 51.

By contrast, the account of Judas illustrates the tragedy of remorse that did not lead him to seek restoration through faith in Christ.

These passages teach that emotional distress alone does not establish genuine repentance.

A person may deeply regret being exposed or experiencing consequences without sincerely rejecting the wrongdoing.

Genuine repentance includes honesty, humility, and a willingness to change.

Bible References:

- 2 Corinthians 7:8–11
- Matthew 27:3–5
- Psalm 51:1–6
- Proverbs 28:13

Explanatory Note:

The sincerity of repentance must not be judged solely by visible emotional intensity.

Some people express deep emotion, while others demonstrate repentance more quietly through confession and changed conduct.

Question 4 — Who Leads Human Beings to Repentance?

Answer:

God takes the initiative in leading sinners toward repentance.

The apostle Paul teaches that God's goodness leads people to repentance.

The Holy Spirit convicts the world concerning sin, righteousness, and judgment.

Jesus also promised that the Spirit would guide His followers into truth.

The Book of Acts presents repentance as a blessing granted through the exalted Christ.

These passages reveal that repentance is not merely an achievement of human moral determination.

God acts through His Word, His goodness, and His Spirit to awaken the conscience and invite sinners to return.

Human responsibility remains real.

People are called to respond sincerely to the divine invitation.

However, this response is preceded and made possible by God's gracious work.

Bible References:

- Romans 2:4
- John 16:7–11
- Acts 5:30–31
- 2 Timothy 2:24–26

Doctrinal Note:

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, divine grace enables human beings to respond to God's call.

Repentance must not be presented as a moral accomplishment performed independently of grace.

Question 5 — What Does It Mean to Be Converted?

Answer:

Conversion means turning toward God and entering a new direction of life through faith in Jesus Christ.

It involves turning away from the former course of wrongdoing and responding to God's invitation.

In Acts 3:19, Peter connects repentance with conversion.

In Acts 26, Paul describes his mission as calling people to turn from darkness to light and from the power of Satan to God.

He also teaches that those who repent should demonstrate their repentance through their actions.

The Thessalonian believers provide another example.

Paul describes how they turned from idols to serve the living and true God.

Conversion therefore involves a new relationship with God.

It influences beliefs, priorities, choices, and conduct.

However, conversion does not always occur through identical outward experiences.

Some people can identify a dramatic turning point.

Others recognize a gradual process through which they came to trust Christ.

Bible References:

- Acts 3:19
- Acts 26:17–20
- 1 Thessalonians 1:9–10
- 2 Corinthians 5:17

Explanatory Note:

Conversion may involve a clearly identifiable decision, but spiritual experience does not always follow the same emotional pattern or timetable.

The essential issue is the person's genuine turning toward God.

Question 6 — Is Repentance Necessary for Receiving Forgiveness?

Answer:

The New Testament closely associates repentance with the forgiveness of sins.

After His resurrection, Jesus instructed His disciples that repentance and remission of sins should be preached in His name among all nations.

Peter likewise called his hearers to repent.

The apostle John teaches that those who confess their sins may rely upon God's faithfulness and justice to forgive and cleanse them.

These passages show that repentance belongs to the sincere reception of divine forgiveness.

However, repentance must not be understood as a payment for forgiveness.

Human beings do not purchase God's mercy by producing sufficient sorrow.

Forgiveness rests upon the saving work of Jesus Christ.

Repentance is the response of a person who recognizes sin and turns toward God's gracious provision.

Bible References:

- Luke 24:46–47
- Acts 2:38
- Acts 3:19
- 1 John 1:8–9
- Romans 2:4

Doctrinal Note:

Salvation rests upon the merits of Jesus Christ, not upon the prior moral perfection of the repentant person.

Repentance and faith are responses to grace rather than competing foundations of salvation.

Question 7 — How Can Genuine Repentance Be Recognized?

Answer:

Genuine repentance produces fruits that become visible in a person's conduct.

These fruits may include acknowledging wrongdoing, abandoning dishonest practices, seeking reconciliation, making restitution when possible, and treating others with greater justice and compassion.

John the Baptist called his hearers to produce fruits worthy of repentance.

When different groups asked him what they should do, he gave practical instructions concerning generosity, honesty, and fairness.

The apostle Paul likewise taught that people should repent, turn to God, and perform works appropriate to repentance.

These actions do not earn salvation.

They reveal that God's grace is transforming the person's attitudes and priorities.

However, the presence of genuine repentance does not mean that every weakness immediately disappears.

Christian growth is a continuing process.

Bible References:

- Luke 3:7–14
- Acts 26:20
- Ephesians 4:25–32
- James 2:14–17
- Galatians 5:22–23

Explanatory Note:

The fruits of repentance should not be confused with immediate freedom from every struggle or weakness.

They indicate a genuine change of direction rather than instant human perfection.

Question 8 — What Role Does Confession Play in Repentance?

Answer:

Confession means honestly acknowledging sin before God.

It involves accepting responsibility rather than minimizing wrongdoing, shifting blame, or attempting to conceal the truth.

The psalmist describes the blessing of acknowledging sin before the LORD.

The Book of Proverbs teaches that concealing transgressions does not lead to spiritual prosperity, while confession and abandonment of sin are associated with mercy.

The apostle John declares:

> "If we confess our sins, he is faithful and just to forgive us our sins, and to cleanse us from all unrighteousness."

1 John 1:9 — KJV

Confession may also involve acknowledging wrongdoing to people who have been harmed.

James encourages believers to confess faults and pray for one another.

However, confession must be practiced responsibly.

It should not be used to pressure injured people into unwanted contact or to evade appropriate accountability.

Bible References:

- Psalm 32:1–5
- Proverbs 28:13
- 1 John 1:9
- James 5:16

Doctrinal Note:

Confession before God is central to repentance.

Where others have been harmed, appropriate acknowledgment and accountability may also be necessary.

Such actions should respect the safety, dignity, and rights of those affected, as well as applicable legal obligations.

Question 9 — Should We Repair the Harm We Have Caused Whenever Possible?

Answer:

Yes. Genuine repentance may lead a person to restore property, acknowledge injustice, repay what was taken, or seek appropriate reconciliation.

The account of Zacchaeus provides a significant example.

After encountering Jesus, Zacchaeus declared his intention to give generously to the poor and restore what he had wrongfully obtained.

Jesus connected this transformation with the arrival of salvation in his household.

The Old Testament also contains instructions concerning restitution for certain wrongs.

Jesus taught the importance of reconciliation when a person becomes aware that someone has a grievance against them.

These passages demonstrate that repentance concerns more than inward feelings.

It can produce practical responsibility.

However, restitution does not replace God's grace.

It is one of the possible fruits of a changed heart.

Bible References:

- Luke 19:1–10
- Leviticus 6:1–5
- Matthew 5:23–24

- Ephesians 4:28

Explanatory Note:

Some consequences of wrongdoing cannot be completely reversed.

Repentance does not automatically remove civil, family, or criminal responsibilities.

Neither does it entitle the wrongdoer to immediate forgiveness, restored trust, or renewed contact with someone who has been harmed.

Question 10 — What Is the Relationship Between Faith and Repentance?

Answer:

Faith and repentance are closely connected in the biblical response to the Gospel.

Jesus called people to repent and believe the good news.

Faith turns toward Jesus Christ in trust.

Repentance turns away from sin and the former direction of life.

These two responses belong together.

A person cannot genuinely trust Christ as Savior while deliberately treating sin as unimportant.

At the same time, repentance without faith in God's mercy may become mere despair or an attempt at self-improvement.

The apostle Paul described his ministry as calling people to repentance toward God and faith toward the Lord Jesus Christ.

Both repentance and faith are made possible through divine grace.

They do not constitute two separate payments required to obtain salvation.

Bible References:

- Mark 1:15
- Acts 20:20–21
- Acts 26:20
- Ephesians 2:8–10

Doctrinal Note:

Faith and repentance are complementary aspects of responding to God's saving invitation.

Neither should be presented as a meritorious work that obligates God to grant forgiveness.

Question 11 — Does Conversion Mean That a Believer Will Never Sin Again?

Answer:

No. Conversion begins a new life in Christ, but it does not mean that believers immediately become incapable of sinning.

The New Testament calls Christians to grow in holiness and acknowledges that they may still experience weakness and failure.

The apostle John warns believers against claiming to be without sin.

He also teaches that Jesus Christ is their Advocate with the Father if they sin.

Paul describes Christian life as a continuing pursuit of spiritual maturity.

He acknowledges that he has not already attained perfection.

The Letter to the Galatians presents a conflict between the desires of the flesh and the work of the Spirit.

These passages show that conversion introduces a new direction of life.

Sanctification involves continuing growth through the power of the Holy Spirit.

When believers fall, they are called to confess their sins, repent, and return to God.

Bible References:

- 1 John 1:8–2:2
- Philippians 3:12–14
- Galatians 5:16–25
- Romans 6:11–14

Doctrinal Note:

A sincere struggle against sin must be distinguished from a persistent determination to justify or defend wrongdoing.

God's grace offers both forgiveness and the power for continued transformation.

Question 12 — How Does God Receive Someone Who Returns to Him?

Answer:

The Bible presents God as merciful and willing to receive repentant sinners.

In the parable of the lost son, Jesus describes a father who welcomes his returning son with compassion.

The son recognizes his wrongdoing and returns home.

The father receives him with joy.

This parable reveals the gracious character of God and the joy associated with the return of a sinner.

The prophet Isaiah likewise calls the wicked to forsake their ways and return to the LORD, who abundantly pardons.

Micah celebrates God's mercy and His willingness to forgive iniquity.

These passages encourage sinners to return to God rather than remain trapped in despair.

The way back to God is opened through His grace.

Bible References:

- Luke 15:11–32
- Isaiah 55:6–7
- Micah 7:18–19
- Psalm 103:8–13

Explanatory Note:

The parable of the lost son reveals divine mercy.

It should not be used to deny the importance of justice, accountability, or protection for people who have suffered harm.

Question 13 — What Role Does the Word of God Play in Conversion?

Answer:

The Word of God plays an essential role in leading people toward faith and conversion.

The proclamation of the Gospel makes Jesus Christ and His saving work known.

The Scriptures reveal God's character, expose sin, announce divine grace, and communicate His promises.

The apostle Paul teaches that faith comes through hearing God's Word.

He also explains that the Scriptures are able to make a person wise unto salvation through faith in Christ Jesus.

James describes the Word as something that must not merely be heard but also practiced.

Peter connects the new birth with the enduring Word of God.

Through the Scriptures, the Holy Spirit convicts, teaches, and guides human beings toward truth.

However, reading the Bible must not become merely a mechanical religious exercise.

Its message calls for personal trust and a sincere response.

Bible References:

- Romans 10:14–17
- 2 Timothy 3:14–17
- James 1:18–25
- 1 Peter 1:23–25
- John 16:13

Doctrinal Note:

Scripture and the Holy Spirit must not be placed in opposition.

The Spirit inspired the biblical message and works through it to lead people toward Jesus Christ.

Question 14 — What Is the Relationship Between Conversion and Baptism?

Answer:

In the New Testament, the proclamation of the Gospel leads people toward faith, repentance, and baptism.

After Peter's sermon on the Day of Pentecost, many of his hearers responded to the message and were baptized.

In Acts 8, Philip explained the Gospel to the Ethiopian official, who then requested baptism.

Jesus commanded His disciples to make disciples of all nations and baptize them.

The apostle Paul connects baptism with participation in the death and resurrection of Jesus Christ.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, baptism by immersion is the public expression of a personal decision to follow Jesus Christ.

It symbolizes death to the former life and the beginning of a new life in Him.

However, baptism does not replace inward faith and repentance.

The outward act must correspond to a sincere response to God's grace.

Bible References:

- Matthew 28:18–20
- Acts 2:37–41
- Acts 8:35–39
- Romans 6:3–4
- Colossians 2:12

Doctrinal Note:

Christian traditions differ concerning the subjects and modes of baptism.

The Seventh-day Adventist position emphasizes personal faith, repentance, and baptism by immersion.

This subject will be studied more fully in Chapter 18.

Question 15 — How Can Believers Persevere After Conversion?

Answer:

Believers are called to remain in a living relationship with Jesus Christ.

Perseverance involves continued trust in His grace, prayer, study of Scripture, fellowship with other believers, and a life characterized by love and obedience.

In John 15, Jesus uses the image of the vine and its branches to explain the necessity of remaining connected to Him.

The early Christians devoted themselves to the apostles' teaching, fellowship, prayer, and shared worship.

Paul encouraged believers to continue walking in Christ as they had received Him.

The Letter to the Hebrews calls Christians to hold firmly to their hope and encourage one another.

These practices do not earn salvation.

They support the believer's continued relationship with God.

The apostle Paul also expresses confidence that God will continue the good work He has begun in His people.

Christian perseverance therefore rests upon divine faithfulness and is expressed through a renewed response of faith.

Bible References:

- John 15:1–10
- Acts 2:42
- Colossians 2:6–7
- Hebrews 10:23–25
- Philippians 1:6
- Jude 1:20–21

Doctrinal Note:

Spiritual growth is not a competition.

It involves trust, patience, humility, and mutual support.

Believers should encourage one another without confusing different rates of growth with different degrees of worth before God.

Chapter Summary

Repentance and conversion are essential aspects of the biblical response to God's saving invitation.

Repentance involves a sincere change of attitude toward sin and toward God.

It goes beyond remorse and leads toward a changed direction of life.

Conversion means turning toward God and beginning a life centered upon Jesus Christ.

These realities are closely related to grace, faith, forgiveness, and the work of the Holy Spirit.

Their authenticity becomes visible through confession, changed conduct, love, and responsibility toward others.

Our study establishes fifteen essential teachings:

1. Repentance is a sincere change of attitude toward sin and God.

2. Jesus called people to repent and believe the Gospel.

3. Remorse must be distinguished from genuine repentance.

4. God's goodness and the Holy Spirit lead sinners toward repentance.

5. Conversion means turning toward God and beginning a new direction of life.

6. Repentance is associated with receiving forgiveness but does not purchase it.

7. Genuine repentance produces visible fruits.

8. Confession involves honestly acknowledging wrongdoing.

9. Repentance may require restitution and appropriate accountability.

10. Faith and repentance are closely connected responses to the Gospel.

11. Conversion does not immediately eliminate every possibility of sin.

12. God welcomes those who sincerely return to Him.

13. Scripture plays an essential role in conversion.

14. Baptism publicly expresses faith and repentance.

15. Perseverance involves remaining in communion with Jesus Christ.

Doctrinal Conclusion

Repentance and conversion are responses to God's grace, not methods of earning salvation.

God takes the initiative to seek sinners.

Through His Word and the Holy Spirit, He reveals their need for forgiveness and invites them to return.

Repentance involves recognizing sin, accepting responsibility, and turning toward God.

Conversion describes the beginning of a new direction of life through faith in Jesus Christ.

These experiences are closely connected.

They do not replace the sacrifice of Christ or add human merit to His saving work.

Rather, they express the sincere reception of divine grace.

Genuine repentance produces practical consequences.

It leads believers toward confession, honesty, justice, restitution when possible, and a transformed relationship with others.

Conversion does not mean immediate freedom from every weakness.

Christian growth continues through the sanctifying work of the Holy Spirit.

Believers who fall are invited to return to God with sincere repentance.

Through faith, prayer, Scripture, and Christian fellowship, they are called to persevere in their relationship with Jesus Christ.

The Essential Message:

Repentance does not save us through its own merit. It leads us to receive the salvation God offers through Jesus Christ. Conversion begins a renewed relationship with God, and His grace progressively transforms our lives.

Personal Reflection Questions

1. Do I distinguish regret over the consequences of wrongdoing from a genuine desire to change?

2. What attitudes or actions do I need to acknowledge honestly before God?

3. Am I willing to repair an injustice when doing so is possible and appropriate?

4. How does my faith in Jesus Christ influence my daily decisions?

5. Do I understand that God's grace precedes and accompanies my spiritual transformation?

6. How do I respond when I recognize that I have sinned?

7. What place do prayer and Scripture occupy in my life?

8. How can I demonstrate the fruits of repentance through practical actions?

Suggested Prayer

Heavenly Father,

I thank You for Your goodness and mercy, which invite me to return to You.

Give me the courage to recognize my sins without excusing or minimizing them.

Lead me toward sincere repentance, nourished by faith in Jesus Christ.

Help me acknowledge the harm I have caused and make restitution whenever it is possible and appropriate.

May Your Holy Spirit transform my thoughts, words, and actions.

When I fall, teach me to return to You with confidence, without despair or presumption.

Give me a heart willing to receive Your Word and follow Your will.

Help me demonstrate the grace I have received through honesty, love, justice, and compassion toward others.

Keep me in a living relationship with Jesus Christ and strengthen me to persevere in faith.

In the name of Jesus Christ, my Savior and Lord.

Amen.

Remember

Repentance is more than regret, and conversion is more than a change of religious affiliation. Together, they express a sincere turning toward God through faith in Jesus Christ. They do not purchase salvation; they are responses to His grace and bear fruit in a transformed life.

Transition to Chapter 12

After repentance and conversion, another question remains: How does God declare the believing sinner righteous, and how does He progressively transform that person's life?

The next chapter examines justification and sanctification, two closely related but distinct dimensions of God's saving work.

CHAPTER 12 — JUSTIFICATION AND SANCTIFICATION: HOW DOES GOD DECLARE US RIGHTEOUS AND TRANSFORM OUR LIVES?

A Thematic Bible Study — King James Version (KJV)

Chapter Objective

To understand the biblical meaning of justification and sanctification, their relationship to the saving work of Jesus Christ, and their essential place in Christian life.

This chapter examines forgiveness, the righteousness of Christ, justification by faith, the work of the Holy Spirit, spiritual growth, obedience, and the believer's preparation for eternal life.

Central Teaching: God justifies repentant sinners through His grace, on the basis of the saving work of Jesus Christ and through faith in Him. The same God sanctifies believers, setting them apart for Himself and transforming their lives through the Holy Spirit. Justification and sanctification are distinct but closely connected dimensions of salvation.

Opening Scripture

> “Therefore being justified by faith, we have peace with God through our Lord Jesus Christ:”

Romans 5:1 — KJV

Introduction

In the previous chapter, we studied repentance and conversion.

We discovered that God calls human beings to recognize their sins, turn away from evil, and sincerely return to Him.

But an essential question remains: What happens when a repentant sinner places faith in Jesus Christ?

The Bible teaches that God grants forgiveness and accepts the believer as righteous on the basis of Christ's redemptive work.

This reality is called justification.

However, God's plan of salvation does not end with the forgiveness of past sins.

He also desires to renew the believer's thoughts, transform the character, and lead the person into a life consistent with His will.

This work is called sanctification.

These teachings are closely connected, but they must not be confused.

Justification particularly concerns our acceptance before God through Jesus Christ.

Sanctification concerns our consecration to God and the transformation of our lives through the Holy Spirit.

Some people believe they must become perfectly holy before God can accept them.

Others assume that divine forgiveness makes moral transformation unnecessary.

The Bible invites us to avoid both errors.

In this chapter, we will examine fifteen fundamental questions to understand how God justifies, sanctifies, and prepares believers for eternal life.

Question 1 — What Does It Mean to Be Justified According to the Bible?

Answer:

In the context of salvation, to be justified means to be accepted as righteous before God through the saving work of Jesus Christ.

The biblical language of justification frequently has a judicial dimension.

It concerns a person's standing before divine judgment.

However, Christian justification does not mean that God pretends the sinner has never committed wrongdoing.

Rather, God grants forgiveness and accepts the believer on the basis of the redemption accomplished through Jesus Christ.

The apostle Paul declares:

> “Being justified freely by his grace through the redemption that is in Christ Jesus:”

Romans 3:24 — KJV

Justification is therefore an act of divine grace.

It does not rest upon the sinner's personal merits.

Through Christ, God provides the righteousness and reconciliation that human beings cannot obtain independently.

Bible References:

- Romans 3:21–26
- Romans 4:4–8
- Romans 5:1
- Galatians 2:16
- Titus 3:5–7

Explanatory Note:

The Greek verb dikaioō, often translated as justify, frequently carries a judicial meaning in Paul's writings.

However, biblical language concerning righteousness has several uses. Each passage must be interpreted within its literary and theological context.

Question 2 — Why Do Human Beings Need Justification?

Answer:

Human beings need justification because sin has placed them in a condition of guilt before God.

Scripture teaches that all have sinned and fallen short of God's glory.

The divine law reveals sin, but it cannot, by itself, erase transgressions already committed.

Even when a person begins to practice what is right, those good actions do not automatically remove previous guilt.

Humanity therefore needs forgiveness that does not depend upon personal moral perfection.

God provides this forgiveness through Jesus Christ.

Justification restores the believer to a relationship of peace with God.

The psalmist recognized that no living person could be justified before God by appealing to personal righteousness.

Paul develops the same principle in Romans, where he demonstrates humanity's universal need for redemption.

Bible References:

- Psalm 143:2
- Isaiah 64:6
- Romans 3:9–24
- Romans 5:6–10

- Galatians 3:10–14

Explanatory Note:

The universal need for justification does not mean that every person commits identical sins or bears identical responsibility.

It means that no one can claim a righteousness sufficient to establish acceptance before God independently of His grace.

Question 3 — How Can God Justify Sinners While Remaining Just?

Answer:

God can justify sinners because Jesus Christ accomplished the redemptive work necessary for humanity's reconciliation with Him.

In Romans 3:25–26, Paul explains that God demonstrated His righteousness through Jesus Christ.

The cross reveals both the seriousness of sin and the depth of divine love.

God does not treat evil as insignificant.

Instead, He provides forgiveness through the sacrifice of His Son.

Justification therefore does not require God to abandon His justice.

It reveals how His justice and mercy are expressed through the saving work of Jesus Christ.

The apostle Paul teaches that God reconciled humanity to Himself through Christ.

Peter likewise declares that Christ suffered for sins, the just for the unjust, to bring us to God.

The initiative belongs to God, whose purpose is to save sinners while remaining faithful to His righteous and holy character.

Bible References:

- Isaiah 53:4–6
- Romans 3:23–26
- Romans 5:8–10
- 2 Corinthians 5:18–21
- 1 Peter 3:18

Doctrinal Note:

Christian traditions have developed different theological explanations of the atonement.

It is important to distinguish explicit biblical affirmations about Christ's saving death from theological models used to explain how His sacrifice accomplishes reconciliation.

Question 4 — Is Justification Received by Faith or Earned Through Works?

Answer:

The Bible teaches that justification before God is received through faith in Jesus Christ, not earned through human works.

Paul explains that no person can establish righteousness before God by relying upon personal observance of the law.

Believers are accepted because they trust in the saving work of Jesus Christ.

However, this teaching does not mean that good works are unimportant.

Good works are essential expressions of living faith.

They demonstrate the transformation produced by divine grace.

Paul teaches that believers are saved by grace through faith and are created in Christ Jesus for good works.

James likewise teaches that genuine faith is expressed through action.

Thus, faith receives salvation, while good works reveal the transforming influence of grace.

Bible References:

- Romans 3:20–28
- Romans 4:1–5
- Galatians 2:15–16
- Ephesians 2:8–10
- James 2:14–26

Doctrinal Note:

Paul and James address different problems.

Paul rejects the attempt to earn justification through works.

James rejects a profession of faith that produces no practical fruit.

Their teachings should be interpreted within their respective contexts.

Question 5 — What Role Does the Righteousness of Jesus Christ Play in Our Justification?

Answer:

The righteousness of Jesus Christ is the foundation of the believer's acceptance before God.

Unlike sinful humanity, Jesus lived in perfect faithfulness to the Father's will.

He committed no sin and voluntarily gave His life for humanity's redemption.

In Romans 5, Paul contrasts Adam's disobedience with the obedience of Jesus Christ.

He explains that Christ's saving work makes justification possible.

In Philippians 3, Paul rejects confidence in his own religious merits and places his trust in the righteousness that comes from God through

faith.

The believer therefore does not approach God by claiming personal perfection.

Instead, the believer relies upon Jesus Christ.

The New Testament also teaches that Christ became the source of righteousness and redemption for His people.

His sinless life and sacrificial death reveal the sufficiency of God's saving provision.

Bible References:

- Romans 5:18–19
- 1 Corinthians 1:30
- 2 Corinthians 5:21
- Philippians 3:7–9
- Hebrews 4:15
- 1 Peter 2:22–24

Doctrinal Note:

In Protestant and Seventh-day Adventist understanding, the righteousness of Christ is fundamental to justification.

Christian traditions differ concerning certain formulations of imputed righteousness and inward renewal.

Such theological formulations should not be presented as though they were direct quotations from Scripture.

Question 6 — What Are the Immediate Results of Justification?

Answer:

Justification brings several important spiritual blessings to the believer.

First, it establishes peace with God through Jesus Christ.

Second, it allows believers to live in the assurance of divine grace rather than under the condemnation associated with sin.

Third, it opens a future hope founded upon God's promises.

Romans 5:1–2 connects justification by faith with peace with God, access to grace, and hope of divine glory.

The apostle Paul also teaches that there is no condemnation for those who are in Christ Jesus.

These blessings do not mean that believers will immediately be free from every difficulty, temptation, or emotional struggle.

Peace with God primarily describes a restored relationship with Him.

It is grounded in Christ's work rather than in the changing emotions of the believer.

Bible References:

- Romans 5:1–2
- Romans 8:1–4
- Colossians 1:19–23
- Ephesians 1:6–7
- Titus 3:5–7

Explanatory Note:

Peace with God should be distinguished from the emotional feeling of peace.

A believer may experience anxiety or sorrow while still being invited to rely upon God's promises and the reconciliation accomplished through Jesus Christ.

Question 7 — What Is Sanctification According to the Holy Scriptures?

Answer:

Sanctification means being consecrated to God and living a life increasingly transformed according to His will.

In Scripture, holiness fundamentally concerns belonging to God and being set apart for His purposes.

This consecration also has moral and spiritual implications.

Believers are called to abandon practices contrary to God's will and develop a character marked by love, righteousness, and faithfulness.

Jesus prayed for His disciples:

> “Sanctify them through thy truth: thy word is truth.”

John 17:17 — KJV

This passage connects sanctification with divine truth.

Paul also teaches that God's will includes the sanctification of His people.

Peter calls believers to holiness because God Himself is holy.

Sanctification therefore involves both belonging to God and living in a manner consistent with His character.

Bible References:

- John 17:15–19
- 1 Corinthians 1:2
- 1 Thessalonians 4:3–8
- 1 Thessalonians 5:23
- Hebrews 12:14
- 1 Peter 1:14–16

Explanatory Note:

Biblical words associated with holiness primarily express consecration and belonging to God.

They also include the call to moral conduct that reflects His character.

Question 8 — What Is the Difference Between Justification and Sanctification?

Answer:

Justification and sanctification are closely related dimensions of salvation, but they emphasize different realities.

Justification concerns our acceptance before God on the basis of Jesus Christ's redemptive work.

Sanctification concerns our consecration to God and the transformation of our lives through the Holy Spirit.

Justification particularly addresses the problem of guilt.

Sanctification particularly addresses the need for renewed life and freedom from the dominion of sin.

However, Scripture does not present them as completely independent works.

Both belong to God's saving action.

Paul teaches that believers have been washed, sanctified, and justified in the name of Jesus Christ and by the Spirit of God.

This passage demonstrates the close relationship between these realities.

Bible References:

- Romans 5:1
- Romans 6:1–14
- 1 Corinthians 6:11
- 2 Corinthians 3:18

- Hebrews 10:10–14

Comparison:

Justification Sanctification

Emphasizes acceptance before God Emphasizes consecration and transformation

Rests upon Christ's redemptive work Rests upon divine grace and the Holy Spirit's work

Particularly addresses guilt Particularly addresses spiritual renewal and growth

Is received through faith Is expressed through continuing faith and obedience

Cannot be earned through human merit Cannot be accomplished independently of God

Explanatory Note:

This comparison is a teaching aid.

In the New Testament, sanctification can also describe a consecration already accomplished in Christ.

Therefore, it should not always be restricted to a gradual process.

Question 9 — Is Sanctification Immediate or Progressive?

Answer:

The Bible presents sanctification under two complementary aspects.

First, believers are described as sanctified in Jesus Christ, meaning that they have been set apart for God.

Second, they are called to continue growing in holiness.

In 1 Corinthians 6:11, Paul speaks of believers who have been washed, sanctified, and justified.

Yet in 1 Thessalonians 4, he calls Christians to progress in conduct consistent with God's will.

The Letter to the Hebrews also speaks of believers being sanctified through Christ's offering.

At the same time, Paul describes spiritual transformation as an ongoing process.

Sanctification therefore includes an initial consecration and continuing spiritual growth.

The believer belongs to God and is called to reflect His character increasingly throughout Christian life.

Bible References:

- 1 Corinthians 1:2
- 1 Corinthians 6:11
- 2 Corinthians 3:18
- Philippians 3:12–16
- 1 Thessalonians 4:1–8
- Hebrews 10:10–14

Doctrinal Note:

It is inaccurate to describe sanctification as exclusively instantaneous or exclusively progressive.

Scripture uses the language of sanctification to describe both consecration to God and continuing growth in holiness.

Question 10 — What Role Does the Holy Spirit Play in Sanctification?

Answer:

The Holy Spirit plays an essential role in the sanctification of believers.

He guides them into truth, convicts them concerning sin, and works to transform their inner lives.

Paul teaches that believers should walk according to the Spirit rather than fulfill the desires of the flesh.

In Galatians 5, he describes the fruit of the Spirit, including love, joy, peace, longsuffering, gentleness, goodness, faith, meekness, and temperance.

These qualities are not merely the results of outward religious discipline.

They express God's transforming work in those who remain in communion with Him.

The Spirit also helps believers develop a new orientation toward God's will.

Christian sanctification therefore requires more than human determination.

It depends upon God's gracious power.

Believers are called to respond through faith, obedience, and continued dependence upon the Spirit.

Bible References:

- John 16:13
- Romans 8:1–14
- Galatians 5:16–25
- 2 Thessalonians 2:13
- 1 Peter 1:2

Doctrinal Note:

Sanctification should not be presented as a transformation that human beings can accomplish through independent willpower.

It rests upon divine grace and the work of the Holy Spirit.

Question 11 — What Role Does the Word of God Play in Sanctification?

Answer:

The Word of God is essential to sanctification because it reveals truth, enlightens the conscience, and teaches God's will.

Jesus prayed that His disciples would be sanctified through divine truth.

He identified the Father's Word as truth.

Paul teaches that Scripture is useful for doctrine, reproof, correction, and instruction in righteousness.

Through Bible study, believers discover God's character and learn to recognize attitudes contrary to His will.

The psalmist also connects purity of life with attention to God's Word.

However, sanctification does not result merely from accumulating religious knowledge.

Scripture must be received with faith and put into practice.

James warns against hearing the Word without becoming a doer of it.

The purpose of biblical knowledge is therefore not simply intellectual achievement.

It is a growing relationship with God that transforms the believer's conduct.

Bible References:

- Psalm 119:9–11
- John 17:17
- Romans 12:1–2
- 2 Timothy 3:16–17
- James 1:21–25
- 1 Peter 2:1–2

Explanatory Note:

Knowledge of Scripture is important for Christian growth, but biblical study must not become merely an intellectual exercise.

The Bible calls believers to understand the truth and live according to it.

Question 12 — Does Sanctification Mean That Believers Can No Longer Sin?

Answer:

No. Sanctification must not be confused with the claim that believers have become incapable of committing sin.

The Bible calls Christians to pursue holiness and reject the dominion of sin.

However, it also recognizes that believers may experience weaknesses and failures.

The apostle John warns that claiming to be without sin is self-deception.

He simultaneously encourages believers not to sin and reminds them that Jesus Christ is their Advocate with the Father.

Paul also describes Christian life as a continuing pursuit of spiritual maturity.

Sanctification therefore involves a real struggle against sin and growth in faithfulness.

It must not become a claim of personal perfection independent of grace.

When believers recognize wrongdoing, they are called to repent, confess, and return to God.

The Christian life depends continually upon Jesus Christ.

Bible References:

- Romans 6:11–14
- Philippians 3:12–14
- 1 John 1:8–10
- 1 John 2:1–2
- James 3:2
- Hebrews 12:1–2

Doctrinal Note:

Christian traditions differ concerning the meaning of Christian perfection.

Scripture clearly calls believers to holiness while also emphasizing the continuing necessity of remaining in Jesus Christ.

Question 13 — What Is the Relationship Between Sanctification and Obedience to God's Commandments?

Answer:

Sanctification leads believers to seek a life consistent with God's will.

Obedience is not the price of salvation.

It is an expression of love and trust toward the Lord.

Jesus taught that love for Him is demonstrated through keeping His commandments.

Paul also explains that divine grace teaches believers to reject ungodliness and live righteously.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, the moral principles of God's law remain important in the sanctified life.

However, obedience must never be separated from grace and the work of the Holy Spirit.

Merely outward obedience without love and faith does not represent the biblical ideal.

The Christian life involves a transformation of the heart, not simply conformity to external rules.

Bible References:

- John 14:15
- Romans 8:3–4
- Romans 12:1–2
- Titus 2:11–14
- 1 John 2:3–6
- 1 John 5:2–3

Doctrinal Note:

The relationship between law, grace, and sanctification will be examined more fully in the chapters concerning God's law, the Ten Commandments, and the Sabbath.

Christian traditions differ concerning the continuing application of various Old Testament prescriptions.

Question 14 — How Can Believers Grow in Sanctification?

Answer:

Believers grow in sanctification by remaining in a living relationship with Jesus Christ and responding to the work of the Holy Spirit.

Prayer, Bible study, obedience, Christian fellowship, and service contribute to this growth.

Jesus uses the image of the vine and its branches to teach that His disciples must remain in Him to bear fruit.

This comparison demonstrates that spiritual life depends upon continued communion with the Savior.

Believers should therefore not attempt to become holy independently of Jesus Christ.

They are called to trust Him and allow His grace to transform their character.

Paul teaches that God works in believers both to will and to do according to His good pleasure.

Spiritual growth involves an active response to divine grace.

It does not involve replacing God's work with human self-sufficiency.

Bible References:

- John 15:1–10
- Romans 12:1–2
- Galatians 5:16–25
- Philippians 2:12–13
- Colossians 2:6–7
- 2 Peter 1:5–8

Explanatory Note:

Spiritual practices should not be regarded as methods of purchasing divine favor.

They are opportunities to cultivate communion with God and respond to His transforming work.

Question 15 — What Is the Relationship Between Justification, Sanctification, and Eternal Life?

Answer:

Justification and sanctification both belong to God's plan of salvation, which reaches its final fulfillment in eternal life.

Justification allows believers to live in a reconciled relationship with God through Jesus Christ.

Sanctification concerns their consecration and transformation.

Eternal life remains a gift from God.

It is not a reward that human beings can demand on the basis of personal perfection.

Nevertheless, Scripture teaches that those who belong to Jesus Christ are called to persevere in faith and live according to His will.

Christian hope also includes the resurrection and final transformation of believers at the return of Jesus Christ.

Paul teaches that Christ will transform the bodies of His people to be like His glorious body.

Thus, salvation has both present and future dimensions.

Believers experience forgiveness and spiritual renewal now while awaiting the final fulfillment of God's promises.

Bible References:

- Romans 5:1–2
- Romans 6:22–23
- Romans 8:28–30
- Philippians 1:6
- Philippians 3:20–21
- 1 Thessalonians 5:23–24
- 1 John 3:1–3

Doctrinal Note:

Justification, sanctification, and glorification are often described as dimensions of salvation.

However, they should not be treated as mechanical stages completely separated from the believer's living relationship with Jesus Christ.

Chapter Summary

Justification and sanctification are two essential dimensions of God's saving work.

Justification addresses the problem of guilt by granting believers a righteous standing before God through Jesus Christ.

Sanctification concerns consecration to the Lord and transformation of character through the Holy Spirit.

Our study establishes fifteen essential teachings:

1. Justification means being accepted as righteous before God through Jesus Christ.

2. All human beings need justification because of sin.

3. God justifies sinners on the basis of Christ's redemptive work.

4. Justification is received through faith, not earned through works.

5. The righteousness of Jesus Christ is the foundation of the believer's acceptance.

6. Justification brings peace with God and hope of salvation.

7. Sanctification means being consecrated to God and living according to His will.

8. Justification and sanctification are distinct but closely connected.

9. Sanctification includes both initial consecration and progressive growth.

10. The Holy Spirit performs an essential work in transforming believers.

11. God's Word enlightens and nourishes sanctification.

12. Sanctification does not mean that believers become incapable of sin.

13. Obedience expresses love and faith toward God.

14. Spiritual growth depends upon continuing communion with Jesus Christ.

15. Justification and sanctification belong to the plan of salvation that will be fully realized in eternal life.

Doctrinal Conclusion

Justification and sanctification are inseparable expressions of God's saving grace, but they should not be confused.

Through justification, God forgives and accepts sinners who place their faith in Jesus Christ.

This acceptance rests upon Christ's righteousness and redemptive work rather than upon human merit.

Through sanctification, God consecrates believers to Himself and transforms their lives through the Holy Spirit.

Sanctification does not purchase salvation.

It reveals the continuing work of divine grace.

The Bible presents sanctification as both a consecration already accomplished in Christ and an ongoing process of spiritual growth.

Believers are called to love God's Word, reject sin, obey His will, and remain in communion with Jesus Christ.

However, they must not place their confidence in personal perfection.

Their hope rests upon the faithfulness of God.

The final fulfillment of salvation includes the resurrection and glorification of believers at the return of Jesus Christ.

The Essential Message:

God does not require us to become perfectly righteous through our own efforts before He accepts us. He receives us by His grace through Jesus Christ and then works within us to transform our lives progressively into His likeness.

Personal Reflection Questions

1. Have I understood that my justification rests upon the work of Jesus Christ rather than my personal merits?

2. Do I live in confidence in God's forgiveness, or in constant fear that I am not righteous enough?

3. What distinction do I make between justification and sanctification?

4. Am I allowing the Holy Spirit to transform my thoughts and habits?

5. What place does Bible study occupy in my spiritual growth?

6. Does my obedience to God arise from love or from the desire to earn His acceptance?

7. How do I respond when I recognize a weakness or wrongdoing in my life?

8. What practical changes demonstrate my spiritual growth?

9. Am I willing to remain faithful to Jesus Christ until His return?

Suggested Prayer

Lord my God,

I thank You for Your love, righteousness, and mercy.

I recognize that I cannot be justified before You through my own merits.

Thank You for offering me forgiveness and reconciliation through Jesus Christ, my Savior.

Teach me to place all my confidence in His redemptive work.

Free me from spiritual pride and from the temptation to believe that my good actions can purchase salvation.

Lord, I also desire to be transformed by Your grace.

May Your Holy Spirit renew my thoughts, purify my motives, and guide my decisions.

Help me love Your Word, seek Your will, and live in sincere obedience.

When I fall, give me the humility to acknowledge my wrongdoing and return to You.

Teach me to grow each day in faith, patience, love, and holiness.

May my life bear witness to the righteousness and grace of Jesus Christ.

Prepare me for the glorious day of His return and for eternal life in Your kingdom.

In the name of Jesus Christ, my Savior and Lord.

Amen.

Remember

Justification means being accepted as righteous before God through faith in Jesus Christ. Sanctification means being consecrated to God and transformed through the Holy Spirit. Both are gifts of divine grace, and both belong to a living relationship with the Savior.

CHAPTER 13 — SALVATION: CAN IT BE LOST AFTER BEING RECEIVED?

A Thematic Bible Study — King James Version (KJV)

Chapter Objective

To examine the biblical teaching concerning assurance of salvation, perseverance in faith, and the warnings against apostasy.

This chapter considers God's promises of protection, the believer's responsibility to remain in Christ, the distinction between spiritual failure and deliberate rejection of faith, and the hope of restoration through repentance.

Central Teaching: Salvation is God's gracious gift, received through faith in Jesus Christ. Believers may enjoy genuine assurance because of Christ's faithfulness and saving work. Scripture also calls them to persevere and warns against abandoning the faith. In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, God's grace does not remove the human capacity to reject Him voluntarily.

Opening Scripture

> “But he that shall endure unto the end, the same shall be saved.”

Matthew 24:13 — KJV

Introduction

In the preceding chapters, we studied God's love, the sacrifice of Jesus Christ, grace, faith, repentance, justification, and sanctification.

We discovered that salvation is a free gift from God, received through faith in Jesus Christ. No human being can purchase or earn it through good works.

Yet an important question remains: Can someone who has genuinely accepted Jesus Christ subsequently lose the salvation received?

This question has generated considerable discussion throughout Christian history.

Some Christians teach that everyone who has truly been saved will necessarily remain saved until the end. Others believe that a genuine believer may later abandon faith voluntarily and separate from Christ.

Both positions appeal to biblical passages that deserve careful examination.

On one hand, Jesus declares that no one can snatch His sheep from His hand. Paul teaches that nothing can separate believers from God's love in Jesus Christ.

On the other hand, Scripture contains serious warnings against unbelief, hardness of heart, and departure from the faith.

How should these declarations be understood without artificially placing them in opposition?

It is essential to distinguish spiritual weakness, a fall followed by repentance, and the deliberate, persistent rejection of the Savior.

The Bible does not invite believers to live in constant fear of losing salvation. Neither does it present grace as permission to turn away from God deliberately.

Instead, Scripture calls Christians to remain in Jesus Christ, trust His faithfulness, and persevere in faith.

We will examine fifteen fundamental questions concerning assurance of salvation, Christian perseverance, and biblical warnings about apostasy.

Question 1 — What Is Salvation According to the Holy Scriptures?

Answer:

Salvation is God's work of delivering human beings from sin, its condemnation, and ultimately eternal death through Jesus Christ.

It is not limited to the forgiveness of past wrongdoing.

It also includes reconciliation with God, transformation in the present life, and the hope of resurrection and eternal life.

The New Testament presents salvation in several related temporal dimensions.

Believers can speak of having been saved by God's grace.

They can also describe God's continuing work in their lives and look forward to the final fulfillment of salvation at the return of Jesus Christ.

These dimensions do not represent three different salvations.

They are complementary aspects of the same divine work.

Paul teaches that believers are saved by grace through faith. Elsewhere, he speaks of salvation as drawing nearer.

Peter likewise describes an inheritance reserved for believers and a salvation to be revealed in the last time.

Bible References:

- Ephesians 2:4–10
- Romans 5:1–11
- 1 Corinthians 1:18
- Romans 13:11
- 1 Peter 1:3–9
- Hebrews 9:28

Explanatory Note:

The New Testament describes salvation both as a reality already received and as a future hope.

This distinction is important when examining biblical teachings about perseverance.

Question 2 — Can Believers Have Assurance of Salvation Now?

Answer:

Yes. Scripture teaches that believers may possess genuine assurance of salvation through faith in Jesus Christ.

This assurance does not rest upon personal moral perfection.

It rests upon God's promises, Christ's redemptive work, and divine faithfulness.

The apostle John writes:

> “These things have I written unto you that believe on the name of the Son of God; that ye may know that ye have eternal life,”

1 John 5:13 — KJV, opening portion

John's declaration shows that Christian assurance is not intended to depend upon continual uncertainty concerning God's love and forgiveness.

Jesus also promises eternal life to those who hear His Word and believe in the One who sent Him.

Paul teaches that justification by faith brings peace with God.

These passages provide a foundation for confidence in the Savior.

However, biblical assurance must not be confused with excessive confidence in oneself.

Its foundation remains Jesus Christ.

Bible References:

- John 3:16–18
- John 5:24
- Romans 5:1–2
- Romans 8:15–17
- 1 John 5:11–13

Explanatory Note:

Assurance of salvation rests upon confidence in divine promises.

It does not mean that believers possess advance knowledge of every decision they will make in the future.

Question 3 — What Does Jesus Mean When He Says That No One Can Snatch His Sheep From His Hand?

Answer:

In John 10:27–29, Jesus describes His disciples as sheep who hear His voice and follow Him.

He promises them eternal life and declares that no one can snatch them from His hand.

This is a powerful assurance of divine protection.

It teaches that no external power can overcome the faithfulness and strength of Jesus Christ.

However, the context deserves careful attention.

Jesus describes His sheep as people who hear His voice and follow Him.

The passage therefore emphasizes both the security provided by the Savior and the living relationship between Him and His disciples.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, this promise does not mean that believers permanently lose all freedom to turn away from Christ voluntarily.

Rather, it emphasizes that no one can forcibly remove them from their Savior's protection.

Bible References:

- John 10:22–30
- John 6:37–40
- Romans 8:31–39
- 1 Peter 1:3–5
- Jude 1:24–25

Doctrinal Note:

Christian traditions interpret John 10:28–29 differently.

Some understand it as a guarantee of the final perseverance of all genuine believers.

Others understand it as a promise of security within a continuing relationship of faith.

The text clearly affirms Christ's protecting power. The question of voluntary apostasy should also be examined through other biblical passages.

Question 4 — What Does It Mean That Nothing Can Separate Us From God's Love?

Answer:

In Romans 8:35–39, Paul declares that no suffering, persecution, spiritual power, or created reality can separate believers from the love of God revealed in Jesus Christ.

His words emphasize the strength and faithfulness of divine love.

Hardship, poverty, persecution, and even death cannot defeat God's love for those who belong to Christ.

The passage was written to encourage believers facing suffering and opposition.

It directs their attention away from threatening circumstances and toward the certainty of God's faithfulness.

However, Romans 8 does not directly address every question concerning deliberate apostasy.

Its primary purpose is to reassure believers that external suffering and hostile powers cannot overcome God's saving love.

The passage should therefore be allowed to speak within its intended context.

Bible References:

- Romans 8:31–39
- John 16:33
- 2 Corinthians 4:7–18
- 2 Timothy 1:12
- Hebrews 13:5–6

Explanatory Note:

God's love remains faithful.

However, the question of whether a human being may ultimately reject that love requires examination of other passages, particularly those concerning unbelief and departure from faith.

Question 5 — Why Does Jesus Emphasize the Need to Abide in Him?

Answer:

In John 15, Jesus uses the image of the vine and its branches to explain His relationship with His disciples.

The vine represents Jesus Christ, while the branches represent those connected to Him.

A branch cannot bear fruit independently of the vine.

Likewise, believers cannot sustain genuine spiritual life independently of Jesus Christ.

Jesus therefore calls His disciples to abide in Him.

This expression describes continuing communion characterized by faith, love, and obedience.

The passage also contains a warning concerning branches that do not remain in the vine.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, this image emphasizes that the believer's saving relationship with Christ should not be treated as independent of continuing faith.

Christ is the source of spiritual life.

Remaining connected to Him is essential for bearing fruit.

Bible References:

- John 15:1–10
- Colossians 2:6–7
- Hebrews 3:12–14
- 1 John 2:24–28
- Jude 1:20–21

Explanatory Note:

The vine and branches constitute a spiritual illustration.

Its principal message should be understood without assigning a separate doctrinal meaning to every detail of the image.

Question 6 — Does the Bible Teach That a Believer Can Abandon the Faith?

Answer:

The New Testament contains explicit warnings against departing from the faith.

Paul refers to people who have turned away from faith.

In 1 Timothy 4:1, he warns that some will depart from the faith and follow deceptive teachings.

Hebrews likewise warns against an evil heart of unbelief that leads a person away from the living God.

These warnings must be taken seriously.

They demonstrate that Christian life includes a continuing call to faithfulness and perseverance.

However, Christian traditions differ concerning how to understand the previous spiritual condition of people who finally abandon the faith.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, a person who genuinely received salvation may subsequently choose to reject Jesus Christ.

Other traditions teach that final apostasy reveals that saving faith was never genuinely present.

The biblical passages should be examined with this distinction in mind.

Bible References:

- Luke 8:11–15
- 1 Timothy 1:18–20
- 1 Timothy 4:1
- Hebrews 3:12–14
- 2 Peter 2:20–22
- 1 John 2:18–19

Doctrinal Note:

The existence of biblical warnings against apostasy is clear.

The theological question of whether genuine salvation can finally be lost remains disputed among Christian traditions.

The Seventh-day Adventist position affirms the possibility of voluntarily abandoning a previously genuine relationship with Christ.

Question 7 — What Is Apostasy According to Scripture?

Answer:

Apostasy means abandoning or rejecting a faith that was previously professed.

In biblical contexts, it may involve rejecting Jesus Christ, embracing teachings contrary to the Gospel, or persistently turning away from the truth previously received.

However, apostasy must be distinguished from periods of doubt, spiritual weakness, or occasional failure.

Someone experiencing a crisis of faith should not automatically be described as apostate.

Likewise, a believer who recognizes wrongdoing and sincerely desires to return to God demonstrates an attitude different from that of someone deliberately rejecting the Savior.

The Bible calls believers to guard their faith while showing patience toward those experiencing spiritual difficulties.

Jude encourages compassionate concern for people struggling with doubt.

Christian faithfulness should therefore be accompanied by humility, discernment, and love.

Bible References:

- Matthew 24:9–13
- 1 Timothy 4:1
- Hebrews 3:12–14
- Hebrews 6:4–8
- 2 Peter 2:20–22
- Jude 1:22–23

Explanatory Note:

The word apostasy should not be used indiscriminately to condemn everyone who asks difficult questions, expresses doubt, or leaves a religious community.

Biblical examination primarily concerns the person's relationship to God and the truth of the Gospel.

Question 8 — How Should We Understand the Warnings in Hebrews 6:4–6?

Answer:

Hebrews 6:4–6 is one of the New Testament's most serious passages concerning departure from faith.

The writer describes people who have experienced significant spiritual privileges and subsequently fallen away.

The passage emphasizes the gravity of rejecting Christ after exposure to the truth of the Gospel.

However, it must be read within the context of the entire letter.

The author urges believers to move toward spiritual maturity and not abandon their confidence in Jesus Christ.

In the following verses, he also expresses hope concerning his readers and their perseverance.

Hebrews 10 contains further warnings, but it also calls believers to maintain their confidence.

These passages should not be used carelessly to convince a sincerely repentant person that divine forgiveness has become permanently unavailable.

Scripture repeatedly invites sinners to return to God and trust His mercy.

Bible References:

- Hebrews 5:11–14
- Hebrews 6:1–12
- Hebrews 10:26–39
- Hebrews 12:1–3
- 1 John 1:9
- 1 John 2:1–2

Doctrinal Note:

Hebrews 6:4–6 has received several Christian interpretations.

Some regard it as evidence that salvation may genuinely be lost.

Others understand it as a hypothetical warning or as describing people who never possessed saving faith.

The passage clearly emphasizes the seriousness of apostasy, but it should not be isolated from biblical invitations to repentance and hope.

Question 9 — What Is the Difference Between Falling Into Sin and Deliberately Abandoning Jesus Christ?

Answer:

Falling into sin means committing wrongdoing or yielding to temptation.

Deliberately abandoning Jesus Christ involves a deeper rupture with the faith and relationship previously professed.

The Bible presents several believers who experienced serious failures.

Peter denied Jesus three times.

Yet after his failure, he experienced deep sorrow and was later restored in his relationship with the Lord.

In John 21, Jesus entrusted Peter with renewed responsibility.

Peter's experience demonstrates that a serious failure does not necessarily mean the permanent end of a person's relationship with God.

The distinction involves the person's response to truth, wrongdoing, and God's invitation to repentance.

Scripture encourages believers who have fallen to confess their sins and return to Christ.

Bible References:

- Luke 22:31–34, 54–62
- John 21:15–19
- Psalm 51:1–14
- Proverbs 24:16
- 1 John 1:8–9
- 1 John 2:1–2

Explanatory Note:

Believers should avoid constructing a mechanical classification of sins that supposedly reveals with certainty who is saved or lost.

God knows the heart.

Christians are called to encourage repentance, restoration, and responsible conduct.

Question 10 — Can a Christian Who Has Sinned Be Restored to Fellowship With God?

Answer:

Yes. The Bible teaches that God welcomes sinners who sincerely return to Him.

The parable of the lost son illustrates this truth.

The younger son leaves his father, wastes his inheritance, and experiences profound distress.

When he decides to return, his father receives him with compassion.

This parable reveals God's mercy toward repentant sinners.

The apostle John likewise teaches that God is faithful and just to forgive those who confess their sins.

Peter's restoration provides another example of divine mercy following serious failure.

Believers who have fallen should therefore not automatically conclude that all hope is lost.

They are invited to return to God through faith and repentance.

Bible References:

- Psalm 32:1–5
- Isaiah 55:6–7
- Luke 15:11–32
- John 21:15–19
- 1 John 1:9
- James 5:19–20

Explanatory Note:

Divine forgiveness does not necessarily remove every human consequence of wrongdoing.

Genuine repentance may involve acknowledging harm, making appropriate restitution, and accepting responsibility.

Question 11 — Does Human Freedom Play a Role in Christian Perseverance?

Answer:

The Bible presents human beings as responsible for responding to God's invitation.

In the Old Testament, God calls His people to choose life and remain faithful to His covenant.

In the New Testament, Jesus invites people to come to Him, believe, and follow Him.

These appeals emphasize personal responsibility.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, God does not force a person to remain in a relationship with Him against that person's will.

Salvation rests entirely upon divine grace.

However, grace does not eliminate the human capacity to respond to or resist God's invitation.

Christian perseverance therefore involves continuing trust in the Lord.

This trust is not an independent human achievement.

It is sustained by God's gracious work.

Bible References:

- Deuteronomy 30:15–20
- Joshua 24:14–15
- Matthew 23:37
- John 5:39–40
- John 15:4–10
- Hebrews 3:12–14

Doctrinal Note:

Christian traditions differ concerning free will, grace, election, and final perseverance.

The Seventh-day Adventist position emphasizes the freedom of human response while affirming that salvation and the power to persevere come from God.

Question 12 — Does God Give Believers the Strength Necessary to Persevere?

Answer:

Yes. Scripture teaches that God sustains those who place their trust in Him.

Perseverance does not rest solely upon human moral strength or determination.

Paul teaches that God works in believers both to will and to do according to His good pleasure.

Jesus promises His presence and calls His disciples to remain connected to Him.

Jude concludes his letter by praising the God who is able to keep believers from falling.

These promises provide genuine encouragement.

Believers are not called to struggle against sin, temptation, and hardship in isolation.

They may depend upon divine grace, the work of the Holy Spirit, and the intercession of Jesus Christ.

The Christian life therefore combines active faith with continuing dependence upon God's power.

Bible References:

- John 15:4–5
- 1 Corinthians 10:12–13
- Philippians 1:6
- Philippians 2:12–13
- Hebrews 7:25
- 1 Peter 1:3–5
- Jude 1:24–25

Explanatory Note:

Promises concerning God's power should not be interpreted as invitations to neglect spiritual vigilance.

Scripture consistently connects trust in God with the call to remain faithful.

Question 13 — Why Does Jesus Say That Those Who Endure to the End Will Be Saved?

Answer:

In Matthew 24, Jesus warns His disciples about difficulties, persecution, deception, and trials.

Within this context, He emphasizes the necessity of enduring to the end.

Perseverance means remaining faithful to Jesus Christ despite hardship.

It does not mean earning salvation by accumulating personal achievements or suffering.

Instead, perseverance expresses the continuity of living faith.

The New Testament repeatedly encourages believers not to abandon their confidence when circumstances become difficult.

The Letter to the Hebrews calls Christians to endurance.

James describes the blessing associated with remaining steadfast under trial.

Revelation also presents the faithful people of God as those who persevere in obedience and faith in Jesus.

Bible References:

- Matthew 24:9–14
- Luke 8:11–15
- Romans 5:3–5

- Hebrews 10:35–39
- James 1:12
- Revelation 14:12

Explanatory Note:

Matthew 24:13 must be interpreted within its context of persecution and faithfulness amid trials.

The verse does not teach that believers can purchase salvation through their own suffering.

Question 14 — How Can We Maintain Assurance of Salvation Without Falling Into Presumption?

Answer:

Biblical assurance rests upon Jesus Christ.

Presumption rests upon excessive confidence in oneself or a distorted understanding of divine promises.

Believers may be assured of God's love, forgiveness, and faithfulness.

However, this assurance should not be treated as permission to live deliberately in sin.

Paul encourages believers to remain steadfast while warning against spiritual pride.

John likewise connects genuine knowledge of God with a life characterized by obedience to His commandments.

Christian assurance does not mean declaring that personal choices no longer matter because salvation is automatically guaranteed.

Rather, it means trusting Jesus Christ, who has accomplished salvation and provides the grace necessary to remain faithful.

The believer's confidence is therefore centered upon Christ rather than personal achievement.

Bible References:

- John 10:27–29
- Romans 8:1–4
- 1 Corinthians 10:12–13
- Philippians 2:12–13
- 1 John 2:3–6
- 1 John 5:11–13

Explanatory Note:

Assurance of salvation should not be measured exclusively through emotions.

A believer may experience uncertainty or spiritual struggle while remaining invited to trust God's promises.

Question 15 — What Attitude Should Christians Adopt to Remain Faithful Until Jesus Christ Returns?

Answer:

Christians are called to remain in a living relationship with Jesus Christ, nourish their faith through God's Word, and walk according to the Holy Spirit.

This faithfulness is expressed through prayer, obedience, repentance, love for others, and perseverance amid trials.

It also involves vigilance concerning teachings and practices that lead people away from God.

However, Christian faithfulness should not be founded upon constant fear of losing salvation.

It should arise from love for God and gratitude for His grace.

Paul compares Christian life to a race requiring endurance.

Hebrews encourages believers to keep their eyes fixed upon Jesus, the author and finisher of faith.

Thus, the believer's spiritual security is not found in personal strength.

It is found in continuing communion with the Savior.

Bible References:

- John 15:4–10
- Galatians 5:16–25
- Colossians 2:6–7
- Hebrews 12:1–3
- 2 Peter 1:5–11
- Revelation 2:10
- Revelation 14:12

Explanatory Note:

Faithfulness until the end is not a religious performance intended to purchase salvation.

It is the expression of faith that continues to depend upon Jesus Christ.

Chapter Summary

The question of salvation's security must be studied in light of two important groups of biblical teachings: God's promises of protection and faithfulness, and Scripture's warnings against unbelief and departure from faith.

Neither dimension should be neglected.

Our study establishes fifteen essential teachings:

1. Salvation is God's work, including forgiveness, transformation, and the hope of eternal life.

2. Believers may enjoy genuine assurance of salvation through Jesus Christ.

3. Jesus promises to protect His sheep from every power seeking to snatch them from His hand.

4. No external suffering or hostile power can defeat God's faithful love in Christ.

5. Disciples are called to remain in a living relationship with the Savior.

6. Scripture contains serious warnings against abandoning faith.

7. Apostasy means turning away from previously professed faith.

8. Hebrews 6 emphasizes the gravity of rejecting Christ after receiving knowledge of the Gospel.

9. Falling into sin should not automatically be confused with apostasy.

10. God welcomes sinners who sincerely return to Him.

11. Responding to divine grace involves personal responsibility.

12. God provides the strength necessary for perseverance.

13. Jesus calls His disciples to remain faithful until the end.

14. Assurance of salvation must be distinguished from presumption.

15. Christian faithfulness rests upon continuing communion with Jesus Christ.

Doctrinal Conclusion

In Seventh-day Adventist biblical understanding, salvation is freely offered through God's grace, received by faith in Jesus Christ, and experienced within a continuing relationship with Him.

Believers may possess genuine assurance of salvation without claiming that their future decisions are irrelevant.

Scripture teaches that God remains faithful, sustains His children, and protects them against powers that seek to separate them from Him.

It also warns against the deliberate and persistent abandonment of faith.

These teachings should not produce constant fear.

Neither should they encourage presumption or the misuse of grace as permission to reject God's will.

A serious spiritual failure is not necessarily equivalent to final apostasy.

The Bible offers hope and restoration to those who sincerely return to the Savior.

Christian perseverance is therefore neither an attempt to earn salvation nor a demonstration of human self-sufficiency.

It is a continuing response to God's grace.

The Essential Message:

Our security does not rest upon our ability to save ourselves. It rests upon Jesus Christ. As we abide in Him through faith, we may live with confidence, hope, and peace, trusting His grace to sustain us until the end.

Personal Reflection Questions

1. Does my assurance of salvation rest upon Jesus Christ or upon my personal merits?

2. Do I understand the difference between spiritual failure and deliberately abandoning faith?

3. Do I tend to live in constant fear of losing salvation?

4. Conversely, do I sometimes treat grace as permission to disobey God?

5. What place does communion with Jesus Christ occupy in my daily life?

6. How do I respond when I experience doubt or spiritual weakness?

7. Am I relying upon God's power to persevere?

8. Am I willing to remain faithful to Jesus Christ despite difficulties?

9. How can I lovingly encourage someone who has moved away from faith?

Suggested Prayer

Lord my God,

I thank You for the wonderful salvation You offer me through Jesus Christ.

Thank You for Your faithful love, Your forgiveness, and the promises of Your Word.

I recognize that I cannot save myself and that my spiritual security rests entirely upon Your Son.

Help me abide in Him each day.

When I experience weakness, strengthen my faith.

When I fall, give me a repentant heart and the courage to return to You.

Protect me from spiritual pride and presumption.

Do not allow me to treat Your grace as permission to live deliberately in sin.

May Your Holy Spirit guide my thoughts, words, and actions.

Teach me to love Your Word, seek Your will, and persevere despite difficulties.

Grant me assurance of salvation founded upon Your promises rather than my emotions or personal merits.

Help me also encourage with patience and compassion those who experience spiritual difficulties.

Lord Jesus, keep my eyes fixed upon You and prepare me for the glorious day of Your return.

In the name of Jesus Christ, my Savior and Lord.

Amen.

Remember

Salvation is God's gift of grace through Jesus Christ. Genuine assurance rests upon His faithfulness, not human perfection. Scripture calls believers to remain in Christ, persevere in faith, and trust His power to sustain them.

PART THREE — THE CHRISTIAN LIFE

CHAPTER 14 — THE NEW BIRTH: HOW CAN WE BECOME A NEW CREATION IN JESUS CHRIST?

A Thematic Bible Study — King James Version (KJV)

Chapter Objective

To understand the meaning and necessity of the new birth according to Scripture, particularly through Jesus' conversation with Nicodemus.

This chapter examines the work of the Holy Spirit, the relationship between regeneration, faith and repentance, the renewal of the heart, baptism, spiritual growth, Christian conduct, and the hope of eternal life.

Central Teaching: The new birth is the spiritual renewal accomplished by God through the Holy Spirit. It brings a person into a new relationship with Jesus Christ and begins a transformed life characterized by faith, love, obedience, and spiritual growth. It cannot be produced by religious affiliation, human merit, or outward ceremonies alone.

Opening Scripture

> “Jesus answered and said unto him, Verily, verily, I say unto thee, Except a man be born again, he cannot see the kingdom of God.”

John 3:3 — KJV

Introduction

In the second part of our study, we examined God's wonderful plan for the salvation of humanity.

We considered divine love, the mission of Jesus Christ, His sacrifice on the cross, grace, faith, repentance, justification, sanctification, and Christian perseverance.

These teachings demonstrated that salvation cannot be obtained through human merit.

It is freely offered by God and received through faith in Jesus Christ.

However, an essential question remains: How does this salvation transform a person's life?

Is acknowledging Jesus as Savior sufficient?

Can someone belong to a religious community, know the Scriptures, observe certain practices, and nevertheless remain spiritually unchanged?

Jesus addressed this question during a conversation with Nicodemus, a Jewish religious leader recognized for his knowledge of the law.

Nicodemus knew the Scriptures, belonged to the covenant people, and held an important position in the religious society of his time.

Yet Jesus told him that he needed to be born again.

This declaration reveals that religious knowledge, community membership, and moral effort cannot replace the inward transformation God desires to accomplish.

The new birth is therefore one of the foundational teachings of Christian life.

But what does being born again actually mean?

How does a person experience spiritual renewal?

What role does the Holy Spirit play?

What changes should appear in the believer's life?

We will examine fifteen biblical questions to understand what it means to become a new creation in Jesus Christ.

Question 1 — What Is the New Birth According to the Bible?

Answer:

The new birth is the spiritual renewal through which God brings a person into a new life in Jesus Christ.

It does not refer to a second physical birth.

Rather, it describes an inward transformation accomplished through the work of the Holy Spirit.

In John 3, Jesus teaches Nicodemus that entering the kingdom of God requires a new birth.

This birth cannot be produced solely through religious education, family traditions, or personal effort.

It is connected with God's work in the human heart.

The apostle Paul describes this reality by teaching that anyone who is in Christ is a new creation.

Titus likewise connects salvation with the washing of regeneration and the renewing of the Holy Spirit.

The new birth therefore marks a fundamental change in the person's relationship with God.

Bible References:

- John 3:1–8
- 2 Corinthians 5:17
- Titus 3:4–7
- 1 Peter 1:22–23
- 1 John 5:1

Explanatory Note:

In John 3:3, the Greek word anōthen can mean again or from above.

This double meaning illuminates the conversation.

Nicodemus initially understands Jesus' words in a physical sense, while Jesus speaks of a birth whose origin is divine.

Question 2 — Why Did Jesus Tell Nicodemus That He Must Be Born Again?

Answer:

Jesus taught Nicodemus the necessity of the new birth to demonstrate that genuine spiritual life does not depend merely upon religious position or biblical knowledge.

Nicodemus was a Pharisee and a ruler of the Jews.

He recognized that Jesus was a teacher who had come from God because of the signs He performed.

However, Jesus immediately directed the conversation toward a deeper issue: the necessity of spiritual transformation.

His response demonstrates that even a religiously educated and respected person needs inward renewal.

Membership in a religious tradition does not automatically guarantee a living relationship with God.

Paul makes a related distinction when he teaches that true spiritual identity involves the heart and the work of the Spirit.

The Old Testament also anticipates the need for inward renewal through God's promise to give His people a new heart.

Bible References:

- John 3:1–10
- Matthew 15:7–9
- Romans 2:28–29
- Philippians 3:4–9
- Ezekiel 36:25–27

Historical Note:

Nicodemus appears again in John 7:50–52, where he intervenes during a discussion concerning Jesus, and in John 19:39–42, where he participates in preparations for Jesus' burial.

These passages allow readers to follow his development within John's narrative, without claiming knowledge of every detail of his spiritual experience.

Question 3 — What Is the Difference Between Physical Birth and Spiritual Birth?

Answer:

Physical birth marks the beginning of human life in this world.

Spiritual birth describes the beginning of a life renewed through the Spirit of God.

Nicodemus did not immediately understand this distinction.

He asked how an elderly man could be born a second time.

Jesus explained that what is born of the flesh is flesh, while what is born of the Spirit is spirit.

He was not teaching that the human body is inherently evil.

Rather, He was emphasizing that new spiritual life cannot be produced through human abilities alone.

It requires divine action.

The Gospel of John also teaches that becoming a child of God is connected with receiving Christ and believing in His name.

This spiritual birth originates in God.

It is therefore different from natural human descent or biological existence.

Bible References:

- John 3:3–8

- John 1:12–13
- Romans 8:5–11
- 1 Corinthians 2:12–14
- Titus 3:5

Explanatory Note:

In this context, the distinction between flesh and Spirit primarily emphasizes the difference between the human and divine origins of life.

It should not be interpreted as a condemnation of bodily existence.

Question 4 — What Does It Mean to Be Born of Water and of the Spirit?

Answer:

In John 3:5, Jesus teaches that a person must be born of water and of the Spirit to enter the kingdom of God.

This expression connects the necessity of spiritual cleansing with the work of the Holy Spirit.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, water is associated particularly with baptism, the visible expression of repentance, faith, and commitment to Jesus Christ.

However, baptism must not be regarded as a ceremony that automatically produces inward transformation.

It is the Holy Spirit who renews the heart.

Ezekiel 36:25–27 provides an important Old Testament background for Jesus' teaching.

In that passage, God promises to cleanse His people, give them a new heart, and place His Spirit within them.

The new birth therefore involves divine cleansing and renewal rather than merely external religious observance.

Bible References:

- Ezekiel 36:25–27
- John 3:5–8
- Acts 2:37–41
- Romans 6:3–4
- Titus 3:5–7

Doctrinal Note:

Christians offer several interpretations of the expression born of water and of the Spirit.

Some emphasize baptism, while others emphasize the cleansing promised in the Old Testament.

These differences should not obscure the central message: entry into new spiritual life depends upon God's work, not merely upon an outward rite.

Question 5 — What Role Does the Holy Spirit Play in the New Birth?

Answer:

The Holy Spirit is the divine agent of inward renewal.

He convicts human beings concerning sin, directs them toward Jesus Christ, and accomplishes a transforming work within their hearts.

Jesus compares the action of the Spirit to the wind.

The wind itself cannot be seen directly, but its effects can be observed.

Likewise, the inward work of the Holy Spirit is not always visible in its operation.

However, its influence becomes evident through changing thoughts, motives, and conduct.

The new birth therefore cannot be reduced to a religious emotion or a purely human decision.

It results from God's action, to which the person responds through faith.

Paul teaches that the Spirit bears witness with believers that they are children of God.

He also connects salvation with the renewing work of the Holy Spirit.

Bible References:

- John 3:5–8
- John 16:7–14
- Romans 8:9–16
- 1 Corinthians 6:11
- Titus 3:5–6

Explanatory Note:

The Holy Spirit may produce profound conviction, but Scripture does not identify one particular emotional experience as the mandatory proof of the new birth.

Question 6 — What Is the Relationship Between the New Birth, Repentance, and Faith?

Answer:

The new birth, repentance, and faith are closely connected in the experience of salvation.

Repentance involves recognizing sin and turning away from evil.

Faith means trusting Jesus Christ and receiving His grace.

The new birth describes the spiritual renewal accomplished by God.

These realities should not be treated as three completely independent experiences.

They describe related aspects of entering a new relationship with the Lord.

In Acts 2, Peter calls his hearers to repent and be baptized in the name of Jesus Christ.

In John 1, those who receive Christ and believe in His name are described as becoming children of God.

Paul teaches that salvation is received by grace through faith and is followed by a life prepared for good works.

Thus, divine initiative and human response belong together in the biblical account of salvation.

Bible References:

- John 1:12–13
- John 3:3–8, 16
- Acts 2:37–41
- Acts 16:30–34
- Ephesians 2:8–10
- Titus 3:4–7

Explanatory Note:

The Bible does not provide one technical chronology that rigorously separates faith, repentance, and regeneration in every person's experience.

Each passage should be interpreted according to the way it presents God's work and the human response.

Question 7 — What Does It Mean to Become a New Creation in Jesus Christ?

Answer:

Becoming a new creation means entering a renewed existence through a relationship with Jesus Christ.

The apostle Paul declares:

> “Therefore if any man be in Christ, he is a new creature: old things are passed away; behold, all things are become new.”

2 Corinthians 5:17 — KJV

In its context, Paul speaks about the reconciliation accomplished by God through Jesus Christ.

The new creation does not mean that believers lose their personal identity, memories, or every consequence of their past.

Rather, it means that a new relationship with God now transforms the fundamental direction of their lives.

Believers are no longer called to live under the dominion of sin.

They are called to walk according to the Spirit.

Paul also describes Christian transformation as putting off the old manner of life and putting on the new.

This language emphasizes a renewed identity and conduct centered upon Christ.

Bible References:

- Romans 6:4–11
- 2 Corinthians 5:14–21
- Galatians 2:20
- Galatians 6:15
- Ephesians 4:20–24
- Colossians 3:9–11

Explanatory Note:

The declaration that all things have become new should be understood within the context of new creation and reconciliation with God.

It does not promise the immediate disappearance of every personal difficulty.

Question 8 — How Does God Transform the Human Heart?

Answer:

God transforms the human heart through His grace, His Word, and the work of the Holy Spirit.

In Scripture, the heart frequently represents the center of thoughts, motives, desires, and decisions.

The prophet Ezekiel announces that God will give His people a new heart and place a new spirit within them.

This promise reveals that the transformation God desires is not limited to outward conformity to religious rules.

It concerns the deepest dispositions of the human person.

God desires to replace rebellion with an attitude of trust and obedience.

The promise of the new covenant also includes God's law being written in the hearts of His people.

Paul calls believers to be transformed through the renewing of their minds.

The transformation of the heart subsequently becomes visible in words, decisions, and relationships.

Bible References:

- Psalm 51:10
- Jeremiah 31:31–34
- Ezekiel 11:19–20
- Ezekiel 36:25–27
- Romans 12:1–2
- Hebrews 8:10

Explanatory Note:

The expression new heart is a biblical image of inward transformation.

It does not describe an anatomical change, but the renewal of moral and spiritual dispositions.

Question 9 — What Are the Signs of Genuine New Birth?

Answer:

The Bible presents several characteristics of a life renewed by God.

These include love for God, faith in Jesus Christ, a desire to practice righteousness, love for fellow believers, and rejection of sin.

In his first letter, John connects being born of God with faith in Jesus Christ and love for God's children.

Paul also presents the fruit of the Spirit as evidence of Christian life.

These fruits include love, joy, peace, patience, kindness, goodness, faithfulness, gentleness, and self-control.

However, believers should avoid turning these characteristics into a rigid checklist for determining another person's final spiritual condition.

Christian growth may be progressive.

The fruits of the new birth should be considered within the broader direction of a life centered upon Jesus Christ.

Bible References:

- Matthew 7:16–20
- John 13:34–35
- Galatians 5:22–25
- 1 John 2:3–6
- 1 John 3:14–18
- 1 John 5:1–5

Explanatory Note:

Intense emotion, dramatic testimony, or extensive religious activity do not independently establish the reality of the new birth.

Scripture places particular importance upon faith, love, and the fruit of the Spirit.

Question 10 — Can Someone Who Has Been Born Again Still Commit Sin?

Answer:

Yes. The new birth does not mean that believers immediately become incapable of sinning.

It marks the beginning of a new relationship with God and a life directed toward His will.

Scripture calls believers to reject sin and pursue holiness.

However, the apostle John acknowledges that Christians may still commit wrongdoing.

He reminds them that Jesus Christ is their Advocate with the Father.

A distinction must therefore be made between a fall followed by repentance and an attitude that deliberately defends sin as a continuing way of life.

The person who has been born again is called to resist sin through dependence upon divine grace.

Paul likewise teaches that believers should not allow sin to reign in their lives.

Christian growth involves continuing trust in Christ and the transforming work of the Holy Spirit.

Bible References:

- Romans 6:1–14
- Galatians 5:16–17
- Philippians 3:12–14
- 1 John 1:8–10
- 1 John 2:1–2

- 1 John 3:4–10

Explanatory Note:

Certain passages in 1 John strongly affirm that those born of God do not practice sin.

These declarations should be interpreted alongside 1 John 1:8–10 and 2:1–2.

John contrasts life characterized by communion with God with conduct dominated by sin.

The nuances of his entire letter must be considered.

Question 11 — Does the New Birth Change Our Relationship With God's Law?

Answer:

The new birth leads believers to regard God's will not merely as a collection of external obligations, but as an expression of their loving relationship with the Creator.

In Jeremiah 31, God promises to write His law in the hearts of His people.

This promise is repeated in the Letter to the Hebrews.

It demonstrates God's desire for sincere, inward obedience.

Paul also teaches that the Spirit leads believers toward a life consistent with God's will.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, the new birth does not abolish the moral principles of God's law.

Rather, it transforms the believer's motives so that obedience arises from faith and love.

Jesus teaches that love for Him is expressed through keeping His commandments.

The new birth therefore changes not only outward conduct but also the heart's attitude toward God's will.

Bible References:

- Jeremiah 31:31–34
- Ezekiel 36:26–27
- John 14:15
- Romans 8:3–4
- Hebrews 8:8–12
- 1 John 5:2–3

Doctrinal Note:

Christian traditions differ in their understanding of the relationship between the new covenant, the Mosaic law, and God's moral commandments.

These questions will be examined more fully in the chapters concerning God's law and the Ten Commandments.

Question 12 — What Is the Relationship Between the New Birth and Baptism?

Answer:

In the New Testament, baptism is a visible expression of faith in Jesus Christ and commitment to a new life.

In Romans 6, Paul explains that baptism represents the believer's union with the death and resurrection of Jesus Christ.

Immersion in water symbolizes burial with Christ.

Emerging from the water represents the beginning of a new life.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, baptism is administered by immersion to someone who has personally responded to the Gospel through faith and repentance.

However, the outward ceremony must not be separated from the inward work of the Holy Spirit.

Baptism testifies to new life in Christ.

It does not replace genuine faith.

Peter also connects baptism with an appeal to God for a good conscience through the resurrection of Jesus Christ.

Bible References:

- Matthew 28:19–20
- John 3:5
- Acts 2:37–41
- Acts 8:35–39
- Romans 6:3–4
- Colossians 2:12
- 1 Peter 3:21

Doctrinal Note:

Christian traditions differ concerning the mode of baptism, the age of those baptized, and baptism's relationship to regeneration.

The Seventh-day Adventist approach emphasizes baptism by immersion following a personal profession of faith.

Chapter 18 will examine these questions in greater detail.

Question 13 — How Does the New Birth Transform Our Relationships With Others?

Answer:

The new birth should influence how believers treat other people.

Scripture teaches that brotherly love is an important characteristic of Christian life.

A person renewed by God is called to abandon hatred, revenge, dishonesty, injustice, and destructive speech.

Instead, believers should seek truth, compassion, forgiveness, and reconciliation.

Paul encourages Christians to put on kindness, humility, meekness, and patience.

Jesus teaches His followers to love one another as He has loved them.

Such conduct demonstrates that Christian transformation concerns more than private religious practices.

It affects family relationships, friendships, work, and interactions with the wider community.

However, these teachings do not mean that Christians must accept abuse or abandon the pursuit of justice.

They describe a manner of living that seeks to reflect the character of Jesus Christ.

Bible References:

- Matthew 5:43–48
- John 13:34–35
- Romans 12:9–21
- Ephesians 4:25–32
- Colossians 3:12–15
- 1 John 3:14–18

Explanatory Note:

Christian forgiveness does not necessarily require the immediate restoration of trust after serious wrongdoing.

Safety, justice, acknowledgment of harm, and personal responsibility remain important.

Question 14 — How Can We Grow After Experiencing the New Birth?

Answer:

The new birth marks the beginning of spiritual life, which is intended to develop and mature.

Just as a child needs nourishment and care to grow, believers need continuing communion with God.

Studying Scripture helps them understand His character and will.

Prayer nourishes trust and dependence upon Him.

Fellowship with other believers provides encouragement and support.

Obedience and service allow faith to be expressed in practical ways.

Jesus teaches that branches must remain connected to the vine to bear fruit.

Likewise, spiritual growth depends upon continuing communion with Christ.

However, these practices should not be regarded as ways of earning salvation.

They contribute to the growth of a relationship already founded upon God's grace.

Bible References:

- John 15:1–10
- Acts 2:42–47
- Colossians 2:6–7
- Hebrews 10:23–25
- 1 Peter 2:1–3
- 2 Peter 3:18

Explanatory Note:

Spiritual growth should not be measured solely by the amount of time devoted to religious practices.

Transformation of character, love, faithfulness, and maturity in relationships are also essential dimensions of Christian growth.

Question 15 — What Hope Does the New Birth Provide for Eternal Life?

Answer:

The new birth brings believers into a relationship with God that carries an eternal hope.

Peter connects the new birth with a living hope founded upon the resurrection of Jesus Christ.

This hope extends beyond the limitations of present earthly existence.

It includes the promise of resurrection, the return of Christ, and eternal life in God's kingdom.

However, the new birth does not mean that all consequences of sin disappear immediately.

Believers continue to live in a world marked by suffering, illness, and death.

They await the final fulfillment of God's promises.

Paul describes creation and believers as awaiting the future redemption of the body.

The new birth is therefore the beginning of a renewed life whose full realization belongs to the future God has prepared.

Bible References:

- John 3:3–16
- Romans 8:18–25
- 1 Corinthians 15:51–57

- 1 Peter 1:3–5
- 1 John 3:1–3
- Revelation 21:1–5

Explanatory Note:

Spiritual new birth and the final transformation of the body are not identical.

The first concerns present renewal in Christ.

The second is associated with the resurrection and the final fulfillment of salvation.

Chapter Summary

The new birth is an essential reality of Christian experience.

It demonstrates that salvation involves more than receiving forgiveness for past sins.

It also brings a person into a new relationship with God.

This transformation is made possible by divine grace and accomplished through the Holy Spirit.

Our study establishes fifteen essential teachings:

1. The new birth is a spiritual renewal accomplished by God.

2. Jesus taught Nicodemus that religious knowledge cannot replace inward transformation.

3. Spiritual birth is different from physical birth.

4. Being born of water and the Spirit emphasizes divine cleansing and renewal.

5. The Holy Spirit is the essential agent of the new birth.

6. The new birth is closely connected with repentance and faith.

7. Those who are in Christ enter a renewed existence.

8. God desires to transform the thoughts, motives, and desires of the heart.

9. The new birth is expressed through faith, love, and the fruit of the Spirit.

10. Believers who are born again are still called to resist sin.

11. The new birth transforms the believer's relationship with God's will.

12. Baptism is a visible expression of commitment to new life.

13. The new birth influences relationships with others.

14. Spiritual growth should continue after conversion.

15. The new birth brings a living hope founded upon Jesus Christ and His resurrection.

Doctrinal Conclusion

The new birth is not simply a change of religion, the adoption of new habits, or an outward improvement in conduct.

It is fundamentally God's work within the human heart.

This work progressively transforms thoughts, motives, decisions, and relationships.

The person who has been born again is not presented as immediately perfect or incapable of sin.

Rather, believers are called to remain in Jesus Christ, walk according to the Spirit, and grow in holiness.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, this renewed life is expressed particularly through faith in Jesus Christ, repentance, obedience to God's will, baptism, and Christian perseverance.

However, none of these responses should be confused with the meritorious foundation of salvation.

The new birth remains a work of divine grace.

Its fruits become visible in a life increasingly centered upon Christ.

The Essential Message:

To be born again means to receive a new spiritual life from God through the Holy Spirit, so that we may live in communion with Jesus Christ and progressively reflect His character.

Personal Reflection Questions

1. Have I understood why Jesus taught Nicodemus the necessity of being born again?

2. Is my relationship with God based only upon religious traditions, or upon personal faith in Jesus Christ?

3. Have I sincerely desired the Holy Spirit to transform my heart?

4. What changes have appeared in my thoughts and conduct since I began following Jesus?

5. Do I regard baptism merely as a ceremony, or as an expression of spiritual commitment?

6. How does my faith influence my relationships with family, friends, and others?

7. Do I nourish my spiritual life through prayer, Scripture study, and communion with God?

8. Am I willing to abandon habits that lead me away from God's will?

9. Does my hope of eternal life rest upon Jesus Christ and His promises?

Suggested Prayer

Lord my God,

I thank You for Your love and for the salvation You freely offer me through Jesus Christ.

I recognize that I cannot transform my heart through my own strength.

I need Your grace and the work of Your Holy Spirit.

Lord, renew my thoughts, desires, and motives.

Give me a heart willing to listen to Your Word and follow Your will.

Free me from habits and attitudes that lead me away from You.

Teach me to love truth, practice justice, and show compassion toward others.

May my faith be more than a religious profession.

May it become a living relationship with Jesus Christ.

Help me grow each day in patience, kindness, humility, and faithfulness.

When I fall, lead me to repentance and restore me through Your grace.

May my renewed life testify to the power of Your love.

Prepare me for the glorious return of Jesus Christ and for eternal life in Your kingdom.

In the name of Jesus Christ, my Savior and Lord.

Amen.

Remember

The new birth is God's work of spiritual renewal through the Holy Spirit. It begins a new relationship with Jesus Christ and leads to a life progressively transformed through faith, love, obedience, and spiritual growth.

CHAPTER 15 — THE LAW OF GOD: WHY DID GOD GIVE HIS COMMANDMENTS?

A Thematic Bible Study — King James Version (KJV)

Chapter Objective

To understand the origin, nature, and purpose of God's law, its relationship to sin and salvation, and its place in the Christian life.

This chapter examines the meaning of biblical law, the principles of God's will before Sinai, the law given to Israel, the teachings of Jesus Christ, the distinction between moral, ceremonial, and civil laws, and the relationship between law, grace, faith, and obedience.

Central Teaching: God's law reveals His will and teaches principles of justice, love, and faithfulness. It exposes sin but cannot save sinners. Salvation rests entirely upon God's grace through Jesus Christ. Genuine obedience is a response to divine love, made possible through the transforming work of the Holy Spirit.

Opening Scripture

> “The law of the LORD is perfect, converting the soul: the testimony of the LORD is sure, making wise the simple.”

Psalm 19:7 — KJV

Introduction

In the previous chapter, we discovered that the new birth is an inward transformation accomplished through the Holy Spirit.

This transformation leads believers to love God, seek His will, and live in a relationship characterized by trust and obedience.

But a fundamental question arises: How can we know God's will and distinguish right from wrong?

From the opening pages of Scripture, God reveals Himself as a just, holy, and loving Creator.

He establishes principles intended to guide His creatures and preserve their relationship with Him.

These principles are expressed through His commandments.

However, the question of divine law occupies an important place in Christian theological discussions.

Some Christians understand the coming of Jesus Christ as bringing the Mosaic law to its fulfillment in a way that changes the believer's relationship to its commandments.

Others emphasize the continuing application of the moral principles expressed in God's law.

Some people associate law primarily with restrictions.

Others see it as an expression of God's love and justice.

The Bible itself uses the word law in several ways.

It may refer to the first five books of Moses, the body of divine instruction, commandments given to Israel, or a principle operating within human experience.

It is therefore essential to understand each passage within its context.

We will examine fifteen fundamental questions to discover the origin, nature, functions, and place of God's law in the plan of salvation.

Question 1 — What Is the Law of God According to the Holy Scriptures?

Answer:

In its broadest sense, the law of God refers to the instructions, commandments, and principles through which God reveals His will to humanity.

In the Old Testament, the Hebrew word torah, often translated as law, can mean instruction or teaching.

It is therefore not always limited to a collection of legal regulations.

It may refer to divine teaching intended to guide God's people in their relationship with the Creator and with one another.

In the New Testament, the Greek word nomos also has several uses.

Depending upon the context, it may refer to the Law of Moses, the Scriptures, particular commandments, or a governing principle.

For example, Paul sometimes discusses the Mosaic law, while elsewhere he uses the language of law in connection with the operation of sin or the Spirit.

It is therefore necessary to determine precisely what a biblical author means by law before drawing a doctrinal conclusion.

Bible References:

- Psalm 19:7–11
- Psalm 119:1–16
- Deuteronomy 4:5–8
- Matthew 5:17–19
- Luke 24:44
- Romans 7:7–12

Linguistic Note:

The Hebrew word torah is related to the idea of instruction or direction.

It may designate a particular teaching or, in some contexts, the first five books of the Bible.

The Greek word nomos likewise requires contextual interpretation.

Question 2 — Did God's Law Exist Before Mount Sinai?

Answer:

The Bible indicates that principles of God's moral will were known before the proclamation of the Ten Commandments at Mount Sinai.

In the Garden of Eden, God gave Adam and Eve an instruction concerning the tree of the knowledge of good and evil.

The account of Cain and Abel presents murder as a serious wrongdoing.

Later, Joseph refused to commit adultery with Potiphar's wife because he regarded such conduct as sin against God.

In Genesis 26:5, God refers to Abraham's obedience to His commandments, statutes, and laws.

These passages demonstrate that God's moral will did not begin to exist at Sinai.

However, they do not independently establish that every later prescription given to Israel was already known in its final written form.

The biblical evidence must therefore be interpreted carefully.

Bible References:

- Genesis 2:16–17
- Genesis 4:6–11
- Genesis 18:19
- Genesis 26:5
- Genesis 39:7–9
- Exodus 16:22–30

Doctrinal Note:

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, the moral principles expressed in the Ten Commandments precede their formal proclamation at Sinai.

However, this continuity should be distinguished from the claim that every commandment was explicitly formulated in precisely the same manner from the beginning of creation.

Question 3 — Why Did God Give His Law to the People of Israel?

Answer:

God gave His law to Israel to reveal His will and teach the people how to live within their covenant relationship with Him.

After delivering the Israelites from slavery in Egypt, God led them to Mount Sinai.

He first reminded them of His saving action before proclaiming the Ten Commandments.

This order is important.

God did not ask Israel to earn its liberation through obedience.

He gave His commandments after delivering the people.

The law was intended to guide Israel in worshiping the true God, practicing justice, respecting human life, maintaining family faithfulness, and ordering social relationships.

It also distinguished Israel from the idolatrous and unjust practices of surrounding nations.

The commandments therefore belonged to a covenant relationship established by God's gracious initiative.

Bible References:

- Exodus 19:3–6
- Exodus 20:1–17
- Deuteronomy 4:5–8
- Deuteronomy 6:1–9
- Deuteronomy 10:12–13

Historical Note:

The proclamation of the Ten Commandments occurs within the context of the covenant between God and Israel.

The opening declaration in Exodus 20 recalls God's deliverance from Egypt before introducing the commandments.

Question 4 — What Is the Relationship Between God's Law and His Character?

Answer:

Divine law reveals important aspects of God's character.

Scripture presents God as holy, just, good, faithful, and loving.

It also attributes qualities such as righteousness, goodness, and truth to His law.

The apostle Paul declares:

> “Wherefore the law is holy, and the commandment holy, and just, and good.”

Romans 7:12 — KJV

This correspondence demonstrates that divine commandments are not presented as arbitrary demands.

They express principles consistent with God's moral character.

However, the law does not reveal the entire depth of God's character by itself.

The supreme revelation of divine love and justice is found in Jesus Christ.

Through His life, teachings, death, and resurrection, Christ reveals God's character in a unique and decisive way.

Bible References:

- Exodus 34:6–7

- Psalm 19:7–11
- Psalm 119:137–142
- Romans 7:12
- 1 John 4:7–10
- Hebrews 1:1–3

Explanatory Note:

Saying that the law reflects God's character does not mean that every prescription of the old covenant necessarily has an identical application in every historical period.

Different laws must be understood according to their biblical function and context.

Question 5 — What Is the Principal Moral Purpose of God's Law?

Answer:

One of the fundamental purposes of divine law is to teach human beings how to love God and their neighbors.

Jesus summarizes the greatest commandments in two principles.

The first is to love God with all one's heart, soul, and mind.

The second is to love one's neighbor as oneself.

These commandments come from Deuteronomy 6:5 and Leviticus 19:18.

Jesus teaches that the law and the prophets depend upon these two principles.

Love is therefore essential to genuine obedience.

It does not necessarily replace concrete moral requirements.

Rather, it gives them their fundamental direction.

Paul likewise teaches that love fulfills the law because it does no harm to one's neighbor.

Bible References:

- Deuteronomy 6:4–5
- Leviticus 19:18
- Matthew 22:34–40
- Romans 13:8–10
- Galatians 5:13–14
- 1 John 5:2–3

Explanatory Note:

Biblical love is not limited to an emotion.

It is expressed through practical attitudes and actions involving faithfulness, justice, compassion, and respect for others.

Question 6 — How Does the Law Help Us Recognize Sin?

Answer:

The law reveals God's moral requirements and enables human beings to recognize their transgressions.

The apostle Paul declares:

> “What shall we say then? Is the law sin? God forbid. Nay, I had not known sin, but by the law: for I had not known lust, except the law had said, Thou shalt not covet.”

Romans 7:7 — KJV

In this passage, Paul cites the commandment against coveting.

He demonstrates that the law identifies sin, but does not itself possess the power to transform the human heart.

The law therefore has a revealing function.

It helps people recognize their need for forgiveness and spiritual renewal.

Paul also teaches that knowledge of sin comes through the law.

However, he distinguishes the goodness of the law from the destructive power of sin.

Bible References:

- Romans 3:19–20
- Romans 7:7–13
- Galatians 3:19–24
- James 1:22–25
- 1 John 3:4

Explanatory Note:

Romans 7 contains a complex discussion of the law, sin, and the human condition.

Individual verses should not be isolated from Paul's broader argument, which distinguishes the goodness of the law from the destructive activity of sin.

Question 7 — Can God's Law Save a Sinner?

Answer:

No. Scripture teaches that the law cannot, by itself, justify or save a sinner.

The law reveals sin and expresses God's will, but it cannot erase transgressions already committed.

A guilty person does not automatically become innocent simply by deciding to behave better in the future.

Salvation requires God's intervention.

Jesus Christ accomplished the redemptive work that humanity could not accomplish.

Paul teaches that no one will be justified before God through the works of the law.

Justification is received through faith in Jesus Christ.

The law therefore has an important role, but that role must not be confused with the saving work of the Savior.

Bible References:

- Romans 3:19–28
- Romans 8:1–4
- Galatians 2:16
- Galatians 3:10–14
- Ephesians 2:8–10
- Titus 3:4–7

Explanatory Note:

Saying that the law cannot save does not mean that the law is evil.

It means that accomplishing redemption is not the law's function.

Scripture attributes that work to Jesus Christ.

Question 8 — Did Jesus Christ Come to Abolish God's Law?

Answer:

In the Sermon on the Mount, Jesus declares:

> “Think not that I am come to destroy the law, or the prophets: I am not come to destroy, but to fulfil.”

Matthew 5:17 — KJV

This statement must be understood within its context.

The expression the law, or the prophets broadly refers to the Scriptures of the Old Testament.

Jesus affirms that He did not come to destroy their testimony, but to bring to fulfillment what they reveal and announce.

In the following verses, He deepens the understanding of several commandments by showing that genuine righteousness also concerns the intentions of the heart.

For example, He addresses anger and lust as serious moral matters.

However, the New Testament also teaches that certain prescriptions of the old covenant find their fulfillment in Jesus Christ.

It is therefore necessary to distinguish enduring moral principles from provisions associated with particular functions of the Mosaic covenant.

Bible References:

- Matthew 5:17–48
- Matthew 22:34–40
- Luke 24:44–47
- Romans 3:31
- Colossians 2:16–17
- Hebrews 10:1–10

Doctrinal Note:

The Greek verb plēroō, translated as fulfil, can express the idea of bringing something to completion or accomplishing it fully.

Christians differ concerning the precise implications of this fulfillment for particular Old Testament prescriptions.

Matthew 5:17 should therefore not be interpreted in isolation.

Question 9 — What Is the Difference Between Moral, Ceremonial, and Civil Laws?

Answer:

To understand the laws of the Old Testament, Christian theologians often distinguish three broad categories.

The first concerns moral prescriptions, which express principles of justice, faithfulness, and love.

The second concerns ceremonial prescriptions, particularly those associated with sacrifices, the sanctuary, and purification rites.

The third concerns civil or judicial prescriptions, which regulated the social and legal life of ancient Israel.

This classification can be useful for study.

However, Scripture does not always present these categories as a formally separated legal system.

Within the Law of Moses, religious, moral, and social prescriptions are frequently interconnected.

The New Testament teaches that the sacrifices of the old covenant find their fulfillment in Jesus Christ.

It also calls believers to live according to God's moral principles.

Bible References:

- Exodus 20:1–17
- Leviticus 1:1–9
- Leviticus 19:1–18
- Deuteronomy 16:18–20
- Colossians 2:13–17
- Hebrews 9:1–14
- Hebrews 10:1–18

Theological Comparison:

Category Principal Function Biblical Examples

Moral law Teaching principles of right and wrong Exodus 20:1–17

Ceremonial laws Regulating worship, sacrifices, and rituals Leviticus 1–7; 16

Civil or judicial laws Regulating the social life of ancient Israel Exodus 21–23

Doctrinal Note:

This distinction is particularly important in Seventh-day Adventist theology.

Adventists understand the Ten Commandments as an enduring expression of God's moral law, while sacrifices and rituals that pointed forward to Christ find their fulfillment in Him.

Other Christian traditions use different classifications or draw different conclusions concerning their application.

Question 10 — What Does It Mean to Be Under Grace and Not Under the Law?

Answer:

In Romans 6:14, Paul teaches that believers are not under the law, but under grace.

This declaration must be read within its context.

Paul explains that Christians should no longer allow sin to dominate their lives.

He then raises an important question: Does living under grace give believers permission to sin?

His answer is clearly negative.

Being under grace therefore does not mean receiving authorization to disobey God deliberately.

Within Paul's argument, the expression emphasizes that believers now live under the reign of divine grace rather than the dominion of sin and condemnation.

However, Paul's broader writings also address the relationship between the Mosaic law and the new covenant.

These dimensions should be studied together.

Bible References:

- Romans 6:1–23
- Romans 7:4–6
- Romans 8:1–4
- Galatians 3:23–29
- Galatians 5:1–6
- Titus 2:11–14

Explanatory Note:

It would be incorrect to use Romans 6:14 to conclude that grace authorizes sin.

Paul explicitly rejects this conclusion in Romans 6:15.

Question 11 — What Is the Relationship Between Faith and Obedience to God's Law?

Answer:

Genuine faith leads believers to seek God's will.

Obedience is not a means of purchasing salvation.

It is a response to divine love and an expression of trust in the Lord.

In Romans 3:31, Paul teaches that faith does not make the law meaningless in the sense of eliminating every moral requirement.

However, his teachings concerning justification by faith and the believer's changed relationship to the Mosaic law must also be considered.

Christian obedience should therefore be understood in the light of Jesus Christ and the work of the Holy Spirit.

It does not consist merely of mechanically reproducing every prescription given to ancient Israel.

Paul teaches that faith works through love.

James likewise emphasizes that genuine faith produces practical action.

Bible References:

- Romans 3:28–31
- Romans 8:3–4
- Galatians 5:6, 13–14
- Ephesians 2:8–10
- James 2:14–26
- 1 John 5:2–3

Explanatory Note:

Faith and obedience are not two competing methods of justification.

Faith receives salvation by grace.

Obedience expresses the new life that results from a relationship with God.

Question 12 — Why Does the New Testament Speak of the Law of Christ?

Answer:

In Galatians 6:2, Paul calls believers to bear one another's burdens and thereby fulfill the law of Christ.

This expression emphasizes the authority of Jesus Christ and the central importance of love in Christian life.

Jesus gives His disciples a new commandment: to love one another as He has loved them.

This commandment does not mean that love was absent from the Old Testament.

Rather, it gives brotherly love a distinctive measure: the example of Jesus Christ and His self-sacrificing love.

The law of Christ therefore emphasizes a life directed by His teachings, His example, and the work of the Holy Spirit.

Paul also speaks of being under the law to Christ in the context of his missionary service.

Bible References:

- Matthew 22:34–40
- John 13:34–35
- John 15:12–17
- 1 Corinthians 9:19–23
- Galatians 6:1–2
- James 2:8

Doctrinal Note:

Christian traditions differ in how they relate the law of Christ to the Mosaic law.

The Seventh-day Adventist approach emphasizes continuity in divine moral principles.

Other approaches place greater emphasis upon the distinctive form of obedience under the covenant inaugurated by Jesus Christ.

Question 13 — Does the New Covenant Mean That God No Longer Has a Law?

Answer:

No. The new covenant does not mean that God ceases to have a moral will for His people.

In Jeremiah 31:31–34, God announces a new covenant characterized by a renewed relationship with His people, knowledge of the Lord, and forgiveness of sins.

He also promises to place His law within them and write it upon their hearts.

The Letter to the Hebrews repeats this promise.

The new covenant therefore emphasizes inward transformation rather than merely the external imposition of rules.

However, it also includes the fulfillment of the priestly and sacrificial work of the old covenant in Jesus Christ.

Moral continuity and the changes associated with Christ's saving work must therefore be studied together.

The Holy Spirit enables believers to live in a manner consistent with God's will.

Bible References:

- Jeremiah 31:31–34
- Ezekiel 36:25–27
- Luke 22:20
- Romans 8:3–4
- Hebrews 8:6–13
- Hebrews 10:15–18

Explanatory Note:

The promise of a law written in the heart must be understood within the context of the new covenant.

It does not necessarily mean that every provision of the old covenant continues in an identical form.

Question 14 — How Should God's Law Influence Our Daily Lives?

Answer:

Divine law should help believers live in a relationship of love, faithfulness, and responsibility toward God and their neighbors.

It reminds them of the importance of worshiping the true God, respecting human life, maintaining marital faithfulness, practicing

honesty, and rejecting covetousness.

However, Jesus demonstrates that genuine obedience goes beyond outward conduct.

It also concerns the intentions of the heart.

Christians should therefore not be satisfied merely with avoiding certain prohibited actions.

They are called to develop attitudes of justice, compassion, truthfulness, and service.

The Holy Spirit enables believers to grow in this direction.

James likewise encourages Christians to become doers of the Word rather than hearers only.

Bible References:

- Psalm 119:9–16
- Matthew 5:21–48
- Matthew 7:12
- Romans 12:9–21
- Romans 13:8–10
- Galatians 5:22–25
- James 1:22–25

Explanatory Note:

Biblical obedience should not become a means of controlling or condemning others.

Jesus denounces religious hypocrisy and calls His disciples to practice justice with humility and mercy.

Question 15 — What Place Does God's Law Have in Preparing His People for the Return of Jesus Christ?

Answer:

The New Testament calls believers to remain faithful to Jesus Christ until His return.

This faithfulness includes faith, love, perseverance, and obedience to God's will.

In Revelation 14:12, God's faithful people are described through their perseverance, their keeping of God's commandments, and their faith in Jesus.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, this passage emphasizes the importance of faithfulness to divine commandments in the context of the last days.

However, the passage must be interpreted within the wider Book of Revelation.

Revelation presents a conflict between the worship of the true God and powers seeking to turn humanity away from Him.

Obedience is not the foundation of salvation.

It expresses the faithfulness of those who have placed their trust in Jesus Christ.

Bible References:

- Matthew 24:12–14
- John 14:15
- 1 John 5:2–3
- Revelation 12:17
- Revelation 14:6–12
- Revelation 22:12–14

Doctrinal Note:

The Seventh-day Adventist interpretation of Revelation 12:17 and 14:12 places particular importance upon the Ten Commandments, including the Sabbath.

Other Christian traditions understand these passages more broadly as calls to faithfulness toward God and Jesus Christ.

The Sabbath will be examined separately in Chapter 17.

Chapter Summary

God's law occupies an important place in biblical revelation.

It expresses the divine will, reveals principles of justice, and enables human beings to recognize sin.

However, the law cannot save sinners.

Salvation rests entirely upon God's grace revealed through Jesus Christ.

Our study establishes fifteen essential teachings:

1. God's law refers to the instructions and commandments through which He reveals His will.

2. Divine moral principles were known before their proclamation at Sinai.

3. God gave His law to Israel within the covenant relationship established after deliverance from Egypt.

4. The law reveals aspects of God's just, holy, and loving character.

5. Love for God and neighbor is a fundamental principle of divine law.

6. The law enables human beings to recognize sin.

7. The law cannot justify or save sinners.

8. Jesus Christ came to fulfill the law and the prophets, not to destroy their testimony.

9. Distinguishing moral, ceremonial, and civil laws helps explain Old Testament prescriptions.

10. Living under grace does not mean receiving permission to sin.

11. Genuine faith leads to a life characterized by obedience and love.

12. The law of Christ emphasizes the teaching and example of Jesus.

13. The new covenant includes inward transformation and God's will written upon the heart.

14. God's law should influence daily decisions, relationships, and conduct.

15. Faithfulness to God and His commandments remains important in Christian hope concerning the return of Jesus Christ.

Doctrinal Conclusion

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, God's moral law, expressed particularly in the Ten Commandments, remains an important guide for Christian life.

However, this affirmation requires several essential qualifications.

First, the law is not a means of earning salvation.

Justification is received through faith in Jesus Christ.

Second, the prescriptions of the old covenant do not all have identical functions or applications under the new covenant.

Third, the sacrifices and rituals that foreshadowed Christ's redemptive work find their fulfillment in Him.

Finally, genuine obedience must be motivated by love and made possible through grace and the work of the Holy Spirit.

The believer's relationship with God's law must therefore be understood within the wider plan of salvation.

The law reveals divine principles, exposes sin, and guides conduct.

Jesus Christ provides forgiveness, reconciliation, and the power for spiritual renewal.

The Essential Message:

God does not give His commandments so that we may purchase salvation through obedience. He reveals His will so that, saved by His grace, we may learn to live in love, justice, and faithfulness toward Him.

Personal Reflection Questions

1. Have I understood the different meanings of the word law in Scripture?

2. Do I regard God's commandments as expressions of His justice and love?

3. Do I sometimes believe that my good works can make me righteous before God?

4. What distinction do I make between obedience motivated by love and obedience intended to earn salvation?

5. How do the teachings of Jesus deepen my understanding of God's law?

6. Do I seek to understand biblical passages within their contexts before drawing doctrinal conclusions?

7. Is my faith expressed through justice, honesty, and compassion toward others?

8. Am I willing to allow the Holy Spirit to write God's will upon my heart?

9. How can I testify to God's grace while respecting His teachings?

Suggested Prayer

Lord my God,

I thank You for Your Word and for the teachings You have given us.

You are a just, holy, faithful, and loving God.

Help me understand Your will more deeply and recognize the wisdom of Your commandments.

Protect me from the mistaken belief that I can earn salvation through my own works.

I acknowledge that only Jesus Christ can save me and reconcile me to You.

May Your grace transform my heart, and may Your Holy Spirit guide my thoughts, words, and actions.

Teach me to love You with all my heart and to love my neighbor as myself.

Give me the courage to practice justice, speak the truth, and live faithfully.

As I study Scripture, grant me the humility to respect its context and sincerely seek the truth.

Protect me from religious pride, hypocrisy, and obedience without love.

May my life testify to Your grace and character.

Prepare me to remain faithful to Jesus Christ until His return.

In the name of Jesus Christ, my Savior and Lord.

Amen.

Remember

God's law reveals His will and teaches principles of love, justice, and faithfulness. It exposes sin but cannot save. Salvation comes through Jesus Christ alone, and genuine obedience is a response to the grace received through faith.

Transition to Chapter 16

Having examined the origin, functions, and purpose of divine law, we are now prepared to study the Ten Commandments individually.

The next chapter will consider their proclamation at Sinai, their meaning, their relationship with the teachings of Jesus Christ, and their place in Christian life under the new covenant.

CHAPTER 16 — THE TEN COMMANDMENTS: WHAT DO THEY MEAN, AND ARE THEY STILL VALID TODAY?

A Thematic Bible Study — King James Version (KJV)

Chapter Objective

To examine the origin, structure, meaning, and continuing significance of the Ten Commandments according to Scripture.

This chapter considers their proclamation at Mount Sinai, their inscription on two tablets of stone, the different numbering traditions, the moral principles expressed in each commandment, and their relationship to the teachings of Jesus Christ and the new covenant.

Central Teaching: The Ten Commandments reveal fundamental principles concerning love for God and responsibility toward others. In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, they remain an enduring expression of God's moral law. However, obedience does not earn salvation; it is a response to God's grace through faith in Jesus Christ.

Opening Scripture

> “Jesus said unto him, Thou shalt love the Lord thy God with all thy heart, and with all thy soul, and with all thy mind. This is the first and great commandment. And the second is like unto it, Thou shalt love thy neighbour as thyself.”

Matthew 22:37–39 — KJV

Introduction

In the previous chapter, we studied God's law, its origin, its functions, and its relationship to salvation.

We discovered that divine law reveals God's will, helps human beings recognize sin, and teaches essential principles for a life consistent with His character.

However, among the many instructions contained in Scripture, one collection occupies a distinctive place: the Ten Commandments, also known as the Decalogue.

According to the biblical account, God proclaimed these commandments at Mount Sinai amid extraordinary manifestations of His presence and wrote them upon two tablets of stone.

The commandments concern humanity's relationship with God and with other people.

They address worship, idolatry, reverence for God's name, the Sabbath, family relationships, human life, marital faithfulness, honesty, truthfulness, and covetousness.

Several important questions deserve careful examination.

Why did God proclaim these commandments so solemnly?

Why were they written upon stone?

What does each commandment actually mean?

Did Jesus Christ confirm or replace them?

Are they still applicable to Christians living under the new covenant?

We must also examine an important historical question: Why do different religious traditions number the Ten Commandments differently?

In this chapter, we will study fifteen biblical questions, considering their historical, literary, and doctrinal contexts.

Question 1 — What Are the Ten Commandments, and Where Are They Found in the Bible?

Answer:

The Ten Commandments are a collection of foundational instructions given by God to the people of Israel within the covenant established at Mount Sinai.

They are recorded primarily in two Old Testament passages: Exodus 20:1–17 and Deuteronomy 5:6–21.

The first passage presents their proclamation at Sinai following Israel's deliverance from slavery in Egypt.

The second recalls the commandments as Moses addresses the Israelites before their entrance into the Promised Land.

The biblical expression commonly translated as Ten Commandments literally means ten words or ten sayings.

These commandments occupy a distinctive place in the covenant narrative, particularly because they were associated with the stone tablets preserved in the ark.

They should therefore be studied as part of God's covenant relationship with Israel and within the wider revelation of Scripture.

Bible References:

- Exodus 20:1–17
- Exodus 24:12
- Exodus 31:18
- Exodus 34:28
- Deuteronomy 4:13
- Deuteronomy 5:6–21

Linguistic Note:

The term Decalogue comes from Greek words meaning ten and word or statement.

It refers to the ten covenant declarations traditionally identified as the Ten Commandments.

Question 2 — Why Did God Give the Ten Commandments After the Exodus From Egypt?

Answer:

God gave the Ten Commandments to Israel after delivering the people from slavery.

This historical setting is essential for understanding their meaning.

Before proclaiming the commandments, God reminds Israel that He brought them out of Egypt, the house of bondage.

The opening declaration establishes the identity of the God who speaks and recalls His saving action.

Obedience is therefore presented within a relationship already established through divine intervention.

Israel did not receive the commandments in order to earn its previous liberation.

The people received them to learn how to live as a nation belonging to God.

The commandments were intended to guide their faithfulness toward the Lord and their responsibilities toward one another.

This sequence illustrates an important biblical principle: God's gracious action precedes the call to covenant obedience.

Bible References:

- Exodus 19:3–6
- Exodus 20:1–2
- Deuteronomy 4:5–8
- Deuteronomy 5:1–6
- Deuteronomy 6:20–25

Explanatory Note:

The preamble to the Ten Commandments emphasizes divine deliverance before the statement of covenant obligations.

This helps prevent the mistaken idea that salvation can be purchased through obedience.

Question 3 — Why Were the Ten Commandments Written on Two Tablets of Stone?

Answer:

According to Scripture, God wrote the words of the covenant upon two tablets of stone.

The biblical account emphasizes that these tablets were written by God.

Stone provided a durable medium and gave the event a particularly solemn character.

The tablets were subsequently associated with the ark of the covenant in Israel's sanctuary.

They served as a central testimony of the covenant between God and His people.

However, the Bible does not explicitly state that the first tablet necessarily contained four commandments and the second contained six.

This arrangement is commonly used in religious instruction, but it should not be presented as a detail directly supplied by Scripture.

The biblical emphasis rests upon the divine origin of the tablets and their covenant significance.

Bible References:

- Exodus 24:12
- Exodus 31:18

- Exodus 32:15–16
- Exodus 34:1
- Deuteronomy 4:13
- Deuteronomy 10:1–5

Historical Note:

In the ancient Near East, covenant documents could be preserved as testimony to agreements and obligations.

However, the Bible does not provide every material detail concerning the arrangement of the text on the two tablets.

Question 4 — Why Do Religious Traditions Number the Ten Commandments Differently?

Answer:

Jewish and Christian traditions recognize the ten covenant declarations, but they do not all divide the biblical text in the same way.

Exodus 20 presents a sequence of divine statements without explicitly numbering each commandment from one to ten.

Different traditions therefore developed different systems of division.

In Seventh-day Adventist teaching, as in several Protestant traditions, the prohibition against other gods is the first commandment, while the prohibition concerning images used in worship is the second.

In Catholic and Lutheran traditions, these elements are generally grouped together, while the prohibition against coveting is divided into two commandments.

Rabbinic Jewish tradition also has a distinctive numbering system.

These differences do not necessarily mean that the traditions use completely different biblical texts.

They primarily concern how the same passage is divided and taught.

Bible References:

- Exodus 20:1–17
- Deuteronomy 5:6–21
- Exodus 34:28
- Deuteronomy 4:13

Comparison of Numbering Traditions:

Tradition Characteristic Division

Seventh-day Adventist and several Protestant traditions Distinguish other gods from images used in worship; combine the prohibitions against coveting

Catholic and Lutheran traditions Group the prohibitions concerning other gods and images; divide coveting into two commandments

Rabbinic Jewish tradition Counts God's introductory declaration as the first word

Historical Note:

The numbering of the commandments is a matter of interpretive tradition.

For careful study, readers should compare the complete texts of Exodus 20 and Deuteronomy 5 rather than relying exclusively upon abbreviated catechetical versions.

Question 5 — What Does the First Commandment Mean: You Shall Have No Other Gods?

Answer:

The first commandment calls Israel to recognize the Lord as its God and give Him exclusive allegiance.

In the historical setting of the ancient Near East, many surrounding peoples worshiped multiple deities.

Israel was called to reject such practices and remain faithful to the God who had delivered the nation from Egypt.

This commandment involves more than intellectual belief in God's existence.

It concerns worship, trust, loyalty, and the fundamental direction of life.

In the New Testament, Jesus teaches that God alone is to be worshiped and served.

For Christians, the commandment therefore calls for refusing to give any person, power, or created reality the place that belongs to God.

Scripture also warns against forms of idolatry in which wealth or other earthly concerns become objects of ultimate devotion.

Bible References:

- Exodus 20:2–3
- Deuteronomy 6:4–5
- Joshua 24:14–15
- Matthew 4:8–10
- 1 Corinthians 8:4–6
- 1 John 5:21

Explanatory Note:

The commandment's original context concerns the worship of other deities.

Its wider moral application may include misplaced devotion to wealth, power, or other created things, but this application should not obscure its historical meaning.

Question 6 — What Does the Second Commandment Mean Concerning Graven Images?

Answer:

The second commandment prohibits making images for the purpose of worshiping them and bowing down to them as objects of religious devotion.

In the biblical world, surrounding nations frequently used statues and representations of their deities.

God prohibited Israel from worshiping Him in this manner.

The commandment emphasizes that the Creator must not be reduced to a material representation.

However, Scripture also records occasions when God commanded the creation of artistic figures, including the cherubim associated with the sanctuary.

A distinction must therefore be made between the existence of artistic representations and their use as objects of worship.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, the commandment rejects the cultic veneration of religious images.

The wider question of Christian religious art and devotional practices has received different interpretations across Christian history.

Bible References:

- Exodus 20:4–6
- Exodus 25:18–22
- Deuteronomy 4:15–19
- Isaiah 44:9–20
- Acts 17:24–29
- Romans 1:22–25

Doctrinal Note:

Christian traditions differ concerning the religious use of images.

The Seventh-day Adventist approach rejects their veneration in worship.

Other traditions distinguish forms of honor or veneration from the worship reserved for God.

These distinctions should be presented accurately rather than assuming that all Christians understand or practice religious imagery in the same way.

Question 7 — What Does the Third Commandment Mean: You Shall Not Take God's Name in Vain?

Answer:

The third commandment teaches reverence for God's name.

In biblical thought, a name frequently represents more than a verbal designation.

It may express a person's identity, reputation, authority, and character.

Taking God's name in vain may involve using it deceitfully, disrespectfully, or falsely.

Scripture condemns false oaths and the invocation of God's name to support unjust actions.

Jesus also teaches His disciples to regard the Father's name as holy.

Reverence for God's name therefore concerns speech as well as sincerity in religious conduct.

Believers should not use divine authority to justify dishonesty, manipulation, or injustice.

Bible References:

- Exodus 20:7
- Leviticus 19:12
- Psalm 111:9

- Matthew 5:33–37
- Matthew 6:9
- James 5:12

Explanatory Note:

This commandment should not be reduced to the prohibition of particular casual expressions.

Its biblical context also includes deceptive use of the divine name, especially in oaths and solemn commitments.

Question 8 — What Does the Fourth Commandment Mean Concerning the Sabbath?

Answer:

The fourth commandment calls the people of Israel to remember the Sabbath day and keep it holy.

In Exodus 20, the Sabbath is connected with creation.

God recalls that He made heaven, earth, and sea in six days and rested on the seventh day.

In Deuteronomy 5, the commandment is also connected with Israel's deliverance from slavery.

The Sabbath therefore has spiritual, social, and communal dimensions.

It involves rest, consecration to God, and cessation from ordinary labor.

It also includes concern for servants, foreigners, and animals.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, the seventh-day Sabbath remains an important commandment for Christians.

However, its application under the new covenant is disputed among Christian traditions.

Bible References:

- Genesis 2:1–3
- Exodus 20:8–11
- Deuteronomy 5:12–15
- Isaiah 58:13–14
- Mark 2:27–28
- Luke 4:16
- Hebrews 4:1–11

Doctrinal Note:

Seventh-day Adventists observe the Sabbath from Friday sunset to Saturday sunset.

Other Christians observe Sunday as their principal day of worship or interpret Sabbath rest in light of its fulfillment in Christ.

Chapter 17 examines these positions in greater detail.

Question 9 — What Does the Fifth Commandment Mean: Honor Your Father and Mother?

Answer:

The fifth commandment teaches respect for parents.

It emphasizes the importance of family relationships and the responsibility of children toward those who have cared for them.

In the New Testament, Paul repeats this commandment and recalls its accompanying promise.

However, honoring one's parents does not mean approving every decision they make or obeying requests contrary to God's will.

Biblical respect must be understood within the broader framework of justice, love, and responsibility.

Parents also have obligations toward their children.

Paul instructs them not to provoke their children to anger, but to bring them up in the nurture and admonition of the Lord.

The commandment therefore belongs within a wider biblical vision of responsible family relationships.

Bible References:

- Exodus 20:12
- Deuteronomy 5:16
- Proverbs 1:8–9
- Matthew 15:3–6
- Ephesians 6:1–4
- Colossians 3:20–21

Explanatory Note:

Respect for parents does not require a person to accept violence, abuse, or destructive conduct.

Protecting human life and dignity remains essential.

Question 10 — What Does the Sixth Commandment Mean: You Shall Not Kill?

Answer:

The sixth commandment protects human life by prohibiting murder.

Within its biblical context, it primarily concerns wrongful homicide.

The Hebrew verb used in Exodus 20:13 is generally associated with unlawful killing rather than every possible instance of taking life.

However, Jesus deepens the commandment's moral significance.

In Matthew 5, He teaches that destructive anger, insults, and contempt toward others are also contrary to the spirit of God's law.

Respect for life therefore involves more than refraining from murder.

It calls for reconciliation, self-control, and recognition of human dignity.

The New Testament connects love for others with rejection of hatred.

Bible References:

- Genesis 9:5–6
- Exodus 20:13
- Matthew 5:21–26
- Romans 13:8–10
- 1 John 3:14–15

Linguistic Note:

The Hebrew verb ratsach appears in contexts involving homicide.

Distinctions among murder, accidental killing, and other circumstances should be examined through the wider biblical legislation, particularly Numbers 35.

Question 11 — What Does the Seventh Commandment Mean: You Shall Not Commit Adultery?

Answer:

The seventh commandment protects faithfulness within marriage.

Adultery violates the covenant of marital commitment.

Scripture presents marriage as a union involving faithfulness, responsibility, and mutual respect.

Jesus deepens this commandment by teaching that deliberately cultivating lustful desire also has moral significance.

He demonstrates that faithfulness concerns not only outward actions but also the intentions of the heart.

Christian teaching therefore calls believers to integrity, respect for others, and responsible conduct in emotional and sexual relationships.

The commandment should be interpreted within the wider biblical teaching concerning marriage and human dignity.

Bible References:

- Genesis 2:24
- Exodus 20:14
- Proverbs 5:15–23
- Matthew 5:27–30
- Matthew 19:3–9
- Hebrews 13:4

Explanatory Note:

Marital faithfulness must never be used to justify violence or coercion within a relationship.

Questions concerning separation, divorce, and remarriage require careful study of the relevant biblical passages.

Question 12 — What Does the Eighth Commandment Mean: You Shall Not Steal?

Answer:

The eighth commandment prohibits unjustly taking what belongs to another person.

It protects property, labor, and the rights of others.

However, its moral application extends beyond direct theft.

Scripture also condemns fraud, dishonest commercial practices, exploitation, and withholding fair payment from workers.

Paul instructs those who previously stole to stop stealing and work honestly so that they may share with people in need.

The commandment therefore includes more than a prohibition.

It encourages integrity, honest labor, generosity, and respect for others.

Its principles can be applied to contemporary forms of dishonesty, including financial fraud, misappropriation of resources, and plagiarism.

Bible References:

- Exodus 20:15
- Leviticus 19:11–13
- Proverbs 11:1
- Ephesians 4:28
- James 5:1–6

Explanatory Note:

The biblical principle of honesty applies to modern economic practices, including deceptive transactions, misuse of entrusted resources, and unfair treatment of workers.

Question 13 — What Does the Ninth Commandment Mean: You Shall Not Bear False Witness?

Answer:

The ninth commandment prohibits bearing false witness against another person.

Its original context particularly concerns justice and dishonest accusations.

False testimony could have serious consequences for an innocent person.

However, Scripture also condemns lying, slander, and deceptive speech in ordinary relationships.

Paul encourages believers to abandon falsehood and speak truthfully with their neighbors.

This commandment therefore calls Christians to respect the reputation, dignity, and rights of others.

It also requires care not to circulate unfounded accusations.

Truthfulness should be practiced with fairness and responsibility.

Bible References:

- Exodus 20:16
- Exodus 23:1–3
- Proverbs 6:16–19
- Proverbs 12:17–22
- Ephesians 4:25
- Colossians 3:9–10

Explanatory Note:

Today, this principle also applies to misinformation, unverified accusations, and intentionally deceptive statements, including those shared through digital media.

Question 14 — What Does the Tenth Commandment Mean: You Shall Not Covet?

Answer:

The tenth commandment prohibits coveting what belongs to another person.

Unlike commandments that directly concern outward actions, this commandment particularly reveals the moral significance of inward desires.

Covetousness involves an excessive or unjust desire for something belonging to someone else.

It can lead to jealousy, deception, theft, or other forms of injustice.

Paul uses this commandment to explain how the law revealed the reality of sin to him.

Scripture encourages gratitude, contentment, and trust in God instead of covetousness.

The commandment therefore demonstrates that God's moral concern includes not only conduct but also the motives of the heart.

Bible References:

- Exodus 20:17
- Deuteronomy 5:21
- Luke 12:15
- Romans 7:7–8
- Philippians 4:11–13
- Hebrews 13:5

Explanatory Note:

This commandment does not condemn every aspiration to improve one's circumstances.

It concerns unjust or disordered desires, especially those involving the wish to possess what belongs to others.

Question 15 — Are the Ten Commandments Still Valid for Christians Today?

Answer:

The place of the Ten Commandments in Christian life must be examined in light of the whole of Scripture.

In the New Testament, Jesus and the apostles repeat several commandments from the Decalogue and emphasize the importance of love, faithfulness, justice, and obedience to God.

Jesus teaches that love for God and love for one's neighbor summarize the great requirements of the law.

Paul cites several commandments concerning human relationships and connects them with the principle of love.

James also refers to the prohibitions against adultery and murder.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, the Ten Commandments constitute an enduring expression of God's moral law and remain applicable to Christians, including the Sabbath commandment.

However, other Christian traditions understand the Decalogue through the new covenant in ways that lead to different conclusions, particularly concerning Sabbath observance.

It is therefore important to distinguish explicit biblical statements from the theological conclusions drawn by different traditions.

Bible References:

- Matthew 5:17–20
- Matthew 19:16–19
- Matthew 22:34–40
- Romans 3:31
- Romans 13:8–10
- James 2:8–12
- 1 John 5:2–3
- Revelation 14:12

Doctrinal Note:

The Seventh-day Adventist position affirms the continuity of the Ten Commandments as moral law.

However, the way Christians should understand and observe the fourth commandment has been the subject of historical and theological debate.

This question will be examined more fully in the next chapter.

Chapter Summary

The Ten Commandments occupy a distinctive place in Scripture.

They were proclaimed to Israel within the covenant established at Sinai and written upon tablets of stone.

They express essential principles concerning humanity's relationship with God and with others.

Our study establishes fifteen essential teachings:

1. The Ten Commandments are recorded in Exodus 20 and Deuteronomy 5.

2. They were given to Israel after deliverance from slavery.

3. Their inscription upon stone tablets emphasizes their distinctive place in the covenant.

4. Religious traditions use different systems for numbering the commandments.

5. The first commandment calls for worshiping God alone.

6. The second condemns idolatry and the worship of images.

7. The third requires reverence for God's name.

8. The fourth calls for keeping the Sabbath holy.

9. The fifth teaches respect for parents.

10. The sixth protects human life.

11. The seventh protects marital faithfulness.

12. The eighth condemns theft and encourages honesty.

13. The ninth prohibits false witness and calls for truthfulness.

14. The tenth condemns covetousness and reveals the importance of the heart's intentions.

15. The place of the Ten Commandments under the new covenant must be understood in light of the teachings of Jesus Christ and the apostles.

Doctrinal Conclusion

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, the Ten Commandments constitute an enduring expression of God's moral law.

They reveal essential principles concerning love, justice, faithfulness, and holiness.

However, observing them is not a means of earning salvation.

Believers are justified by grace through faith in Jesus Christ.

Genuine obedience results from this relationship with the Savior and from the work of the Holy Spirit.

The Ten Commandments should therefore not be viewed merely as a list of prohibitions.

They call believers to love God sincerely and respect the lives, dignity, possessions, and rights of others.

Their moral significance is best understood within the broader revelation of God's character and the saving work of Jesus Christ.

The Essential Message:

The Ten Commandments reveal fundamental principles of God's will. They do not replace the grace of Jesus Christ, but call believers to live faithfully through love.

Personal Reflection Questions

1. Have I understood the historical context in which the Ten Commandments were given?

2. Do I recognize the difference between obedience motivated by love and obedience intended to earn salvation?

3. What place does God truly occupy in my life?

4. Do my words and attitudes demonstrate reverence for God's name?

5. How do I understand the commandment concerning the Sabbath?

6. Do I treat my parents and other family members with respect?

7. Do my thoughts and actions demonstrate respect for human life and dignity?

8. Am I honest in my words, activities, and relationships?

9. Am I resisting jealousy and covetousness?

10. Am I willing to examine my beliefs in light of the whole of Scripture?

Suggested Prayer

Lord my God,

I thank You for Your Word and for the teachings You have given Your people.

You are a holy, just, faithful, and loving God.

Help me understand Your commandments within their true context and recognize the principles they reveal.

Protect me from the mistaken belief that I can purchase salvation through my good works.

I acknowledge that my salvation rests entirely upon Your grace revealed in Jesus Christ.

May Your Holy Spirit transform my heart and teach me to love You sincerely.

Help me honor Your name, seek Your will, and give You first place in my life.

Teach me to honor my parents, respect human life, practice faithfulness, act honestly, and speak the truth.

Free my heart from jealousy, pride, and covetousness.

Give me a living faith expressed through love and obedience.

As I study Scripture, grant me the humility to recognize the truth and the courage to follow it.

Prepare me to remain faithful to Jesus Christ until His return.

In the name of Jesus Christ, my Savior and Lord.

Amen.

Remember

The Ten Commandments reveal fundamental principles concerning love for God and responsibility toward others. They cannot save sinners, but they guide a life of faithfulness motivated by God's grace and the transforming work of the Holy Spirit.

Transition to Chapter 17

The fourth commandment raises a particularly important question concerning Christian worship and the relationship between the old and new covenants.

Which day did God make holy?

How did Jesus and the apostles understand the Sabbath?

What is the historical relationship between Sabbath observance and Sunday worship?

The next chapter will examine these questions through biblical, historical, and doctrinal study.

CHAPTER 17 — THE SABBATH: GOD'S HOLY SEVENTH DAY

Which Day Did God Sanctify, and Why Does It Matter for Christians?

A Thematic Bible Study — King James Version (KJV)

Opening Scripture

> “And God blessed the seventh day, and sanctified it: because that in it he had rested from all his work which God created and made.”

Genesis 2:3 — KJV

Introduction

In the previous chapter, we studied the Ten Commandments, their origin, their meaning, and their place in Christian life.

Among these commandments, the fourth occupies a special place because it identifies a particular day that God blessed and sanctified.

The Bible does not leave the identity of that day uncertain.

The Sabbath is the seventh day of the week, commonly called Saturday. Sunday is the first day of the week.

These are two distinct days.

The question is therefore not whether the biblical Sabbath is Saturday or Sunday. Scripture identifies the Sabbath as the seventh day.

The important questions are these: Why did God sanctify the seventh day? What does the Sabbath teach us about Creation, redemption, and holiness? How did Jesus observe it? What did the apostles teach? And what is its significance for Christians today?

The Bible records that Jesus rose from the dead on the first day of the week. It also records Christian gatherings on that day.

However, neither Christ's resurrection nor the existence of Sunday worship changes the identity of the seventh day.

No New Testament passage explicitly declares that God transferred the sanctity of the seventh day to the first.

In this chapter, we will examine fifteen questions concerning the origin, identity, meaning, and observance of the biblical Sabbath.

Our approach will be founded upon the Holy Scriptures, with historical explanations used to clarify the distinction between God's seventh-day Sabbath and the later development of Sunday worship.

Question 1 — What Does the Word “Sabbath” Mean in the Bible?

Answer:

The word Sabbath comes from the Hebrew shabbat, associated with ceasing an activity or resting.

In the weekly cycle established in Scripture, the Sabbath is the seventh day.

It is not Sunday, the first day of the week.

The Sabbath is more than a day of physical rest. It is a sacred period set apart for communion with God, worship, and the recognition of His authority as Creator.

It also possesses a social dimension, providing rest for families, workers, strangers, and animals.

The Sabbath reminds humanity that life is not defined exclusively by labor and material concerns.

Bible References:

- Genesis 2:1–3
- Exodus 16:22–30
- Exodus 20:8–11

- Deuteronomy 5:12–15
- Isaiah 58:13–14
- Mark 2:27–28

Linguistic Note:

The Hebrew word shabbat is related to shavat, meaning to cease or stop. The Sabbath therefore involves ceasing ordinary work, while also carrying a spiritual meaning established by God's blessing and sanctification.

Question 2 — When Did God Establish the Seventh Day as Holy?

Answer:

The first biblical reference to the sanctification of the seventh day appears in Genesis 2:1–3.

After completing His work of Creation, God rested on the seventh day.

Scripture declares that He blessed this day and sanctified it.

These actions distinguish the seventh day from the six preceding days.

God did not bless the first day as a replacement for the seventh. Nor does Genesis describe the sanctification of two different weekly days.

The seventh day alone is identified in this account as the day God blessed and sanctified.

This event took place at Creation, before the formation of the nation of Israel.

In Seventh-day Adventist biblical understanding, the Sabbath therefore originates in God's creative work and is not merely a later national custom.

The fourth commandment explicitly connects Sabbath observance with this original divine rest.

Bible References:

- Genesis 1:26–31
- Genesis 2:1–3
- Exodus 20:8–11
- Exodus 31:16–17
- Mark 2:27

Explanatory Note:

Genesis 2 directly states that God blessed and sanctified the seventh day. The later commandment in Exodus 20 identifies God's rest at Creation as the foundation for Israel's Sabbath observance.

Question 3 — Why Did God Rest on the Seventh Day?

Answer:

God did not rest because He was exhausted.

Scripture teaches that the Creator does not become weary as human beings do.

His rest signified the completion of His creative work.

For six days, God carried out the work of Creation. On the seventh day, He ceased that work.

By blessing and sanctifying this day, He gave it a distinctive place within the weekly cycle.

The Sabbath therefore commemorates the completed work of the Creator.

When believers rest on the seventh day, they acknowledge that their existence and the world around them depend upon God.

Bible References:

- Genesis 2:1–3
- Exodus 20:8–11
- Exodus 31:17

- Isaiah 40:28
- Hebrews 4:3–4

Explanatory Note:

Divine rest in Genesis describes the completion of Creation, not a recovery from physical fatigue.

Question 4 — Was the Sabbath Known Before the Ten Commandments Were Proclaimed at Sinai?

Answer:

Yes.

Exodus 16 records Sabbath instructions before the proclamation of the Ten Commandments in Exodus 20.

God provided manna to the Israelites during their journey through the wilderness.

They were instructed to gather manna for six days.

On the sixth day, they gathered a double portion because the seventh day was the Sabbath.

On that day, they were not to go out to gather manna.

This account demonstrates that the Sabbath was already known to Israel before the public proclamation of the Decalogue at Sinai.

The commandment did not introduce a different day.

It confirmed the seventh day as the Sabbath.

Bible References:

- Exodus 16:4–5
- Exodus 16:22–30
- Exodus 19:1–6
- Exodus 20:8–11

Explanatory Note:

Exodus 16 directly establishes Sabbath observance among the Israelites before Exodus 20. Genesis 2 provides the earlier foundation for the sanctity of the seventh day.

Question 5 — What Exactly Does the Fourth Commandment Require?

Answer:

The fourth commandment states:

> "Remember the sabbath day, to keep it holy."

Exodus 20:8 — KJV

The commandment identifies six days for ordinary labor and the seventh day as the Sabbath of the LORD.

It calls for the cessation of ordinary work and the sanctification of the day.

This rest extends beyond the individual believer.

It includes children, servants, strangers, and animals.

The Sabbath therefore protects both spiritual communion with God and the dignity of those who labor.

The commandment also gives the reason for Sabbath observance: God created heaven, earth, and sea in six days and rested on the seventh.

The day identified by the commandment is Saturday, the seventh day—not Sunday, the first.

Bible References:

- Exodus 20:8–11
- Exodus 23:12
- Deuteronomy 5:12–15
- Isaiah 58:13–14

Explanatory Note:

Exodus 20 connects the Sabbath with Creation. Deuteronomy 5 also connects it with Israel's deliverance from Egypt. Both passages identify the seventh day.

Question 6 — Why Is the Sabbath a Sign Between God and His People?

Answer:

In Exodus 31:12–17, God presents the Sabbath as a sign between Himself and the children of Israel.

It reminds them that He is the LORD who sanctifies them.

Ezekiel 20 likewise connects the Sabbath with the knowledge of the true God and faithfulness to Him.

The Sabbath therefore bears witness to God's identity, authority, and sanctifying work.

In Seventh-day Adventist theology, its significance continues for believers who recognize the Creator and seek to remain faithful to His commandments.

The Sabbath is not a means of earning salvation.

It is a sign of belonging to and trusting the God who creates, redeems, and sanctifies.

Bible References:

- Exodus 31:12–17
- Ezekiel 20:12
- Ezekiel 20:19–20
- Hebrews 8:6–13
- Revelation 14:6–12

Doctrinal Note:

Exodus 31 explicitly addresses Israel. Seventh-day Adventist theology understands the Sabbath's enduring significance through its connection with Creation, God's moral law, and the new-covenant life of faith.

Question 7 — Which Day Is the Biblical Sabbath?

Answer:

The biblical Sabbath is Saturday, the seventh day of the week.

The New Testament confirms the distinction between the Sabbath and the first day of the week.

According to Luke 23:54–56, the women rested on the Sabbath following Jesus' crucifixion.

According to Luke 24:1, they came to the tomb on the first day of the week.

The sequence is clear:

1. Jesus was crucified and buried before the Sabbath.

2. The women rested on the Sabbath.

3. They came to the tomb on the first day of the week.

The first day follows the Sabbath. It is not the Sabbath itself.

In Jewish practice, the Sabbath begins at sunset on Friday and ends at sunset on Saturday.

Modern calendar arrangements do not change this biblical identification.

Bible References:

- Genesis 1:5
- Leviticus 23:32
- Mark 16:1–2

- Luke 23:54–56
- Luke 24:1
- John 20:1

Historical Note:

Jewish Sabbath observance has preserved the seventh-day identification from Friday sunset to Saturday sunset. Sunday is the first day in the biblical weekly sequence.

Question 8 — Did Jesus Christ Observe the Seventh-Day Sabbath?

Answer:

Yes.

Jesus observed the Sabbath.

Luke 4:16 records that He entered the synagogue on the Sabbath according to His custom.

The Gospels also describe His teaching and healing activities on that day.

Jesus opposed interpretations that transformed the Sabbath into a burden and prevented acts of mercy.

He demonstrated that doing good, healing the suffering, and relieving human distress were consistent with the Sabbath's purpose.

Jesus did not identify Sunday as a replacement Sabbath.

His example reveals the spiritual meaning of the seventh day and the proper attitude with which it should be observed.

Bible References:

- Luke 4:16–21
- Mark 1:21–28
- Mark 2:23–28
- Mark 3:1–6

- Luke 13:10–17
- John 5:1–18

Explanatory Note:

The controversies recorded in the Gospels concerned the proper observance of the Sabbath, particularly the legitimacy of acts of mercy. They do not record Jesus changing the Sabbath from Saturday to Sunday.

Question 9 — What Did Jesus Mean When He Said That the Sabbath Was Made for Man?

Answer:

Jesus declared:

> “And he said unto them, The sabbath was made for man, and not man for the sabbath:”

Mark 2:27 — KJV

This statement shows that the Sabbath was intended to benefit humanity.

It was not established as an instrument of oppression.

The context concerns a dispute about the disciples plucking grain on the Sabbath.

Jesus responds by recalling an incident from David's life and emphasizing the proper purpose of sacred institutions.

He also declares Himself Lord of the Sabbath.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, these teachings confirm both the value of the Sabbath and Christ's authority to explain its proper observance.

The Sabbath remains the seventh day, but its observance should be characterized by worship, rest, compassion, and service.

Bible References:

- 1 Samuel 21:1–6
- Matthew 12:1–8
- Mark 2:23–28
- Luke 6:1–5
- Matthew 11:28–30

Linguistic Note:

The Greek term anthrōpos, translated “man,” may refer to humanity generally. Jesus' statement presents the Sabbath as a gift intended for human well-being.

Question 10 — Did the Apostles Continue to Meet and Preach on the Sabbath?

Answer:

Yes. The Book of Acts records several occasions when the apostle Paul preached and taught on the Sabbath.

At Pisidian Antioch, Paul proclaimed the Gospel in the synagogue.

At Thessalonica, he reasoned from the Scriptures on three Sabbath days.

At Corinth, he taught in the synagogue every Sabbath.

Acts 16 also records Paul meeting a group gathered for prayer by a riverside on the Sabbath.

These accounts demonstrate that the seventh-day Sabbath remained an important occasion for apostolic preaching after Christ's resurrection.

They also show that the Sabbath continued to be recognized as a distinct day.

Bible References:

- Acts 13:14–44

- Acts 16:13–15
- Acts 17:1–4
- Acts 18:1–4
- Acts 20:7

Explanatory Note:

The Book of Acts provides historical evidence of Sabbath gatherings and missionary activity. The question of the Sabbath's obligation for Christians is addressed through the wider biblical teaching concerning Creation, the commandments, and the new covenant.

Question 11 — Did God Change the Sabbath From Saturday to Sunday?

Answer:

No biblical passage explicitly declares that God changed the Sabbath from Saturday to Sunday.

The New Testament clearly teaches that Jesus rose from the dead on the first day of the week.

It also records gatherings of believers associated with that day.

Acts 20:7 describes disciples gathered to break bread on the first day.

First Corinthians 16:2 gives instructions concerning setting aside contributions on that day.

However, neither passage declares that the first day has become the seventh-day Sabbath.

The resurrection of Jesus Christ is a central event of Christian faith, but the biblical accounts do not describe it as a transfer of the Sabbath commandment.

The distinction is essential:

- Saturday is the seventh-day Sabbath identified in Scripture.

- Sunday is the first day of the week, on which Jesus rose from the dead.
- The existence of Sunday worship does not make Sunday the seventh day.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, the fourth commandment continues to identify Saturday as God's holy Sabbath.

Bible References:

- Matthew 28:1–10
- Mark 16:1–9
- Luke 24:1–12
- John 20:1, 19
- Acts 20:7–12
- 1 Corinthians 16:1–2
- Revelation 1:10

Doctrinal Note:

Revelation 1:10 mentions the “Lord's day,” but the verse does not explicitly name Saturday or Sunday. It therefore cannot, by itself, establish that God transferred the Sabbath to Sunday.

Question 12 — Do Colossians 2:16–17, Romans 14:5–6, and Galatians 4:9–11 Abolish the Seventh-Day Sabbath?

Answer:

These passages address questions concerning religious observances, judgment among believers, and the danger of religious bondage.

They must be read within their respective contexts.

In Colossians 2, Paul warns against allowing others to judge believers concerning food, drink, festivals, new moons, and Sabbaths.

His argument emphasizes the sufficiency of Jesus Christ.

In Romans 14, Paul addresses disagreements among believers concerning food and the esteem given to particular days.

He calls for personal conviction and mutual respect rather than condemnation.

In Galatians 4, Paul expresses concern about observances associated with a return to spiritual bondage.

In Seventh-day Adventist interpretation, these passages do not constitute a divine command transferring the weekly Sabbath to Sunday or canceling the fourth commandment.

They address specific problems in the early Christian communities.

It is important to recognize that the expression concerning Sabbaths in Colossians 2 has a debated scope. The passage should not be made to say more than its context establishes.

Whatever conclusion is drawn about the obligations of the new covenant, none of these passages identifies Sunday as the seventh-day Sabbath.

Bible References:

- Romans 14:1–13
- Galatians 4:8–11
- Colossians 2:8–23
- Leviticus 23:1–44
- Hebrews 10:1–10

Doctrinal Note:

The Seventh-day Adventist interpretation maintains the continuity of the weekly Sabbath commandment. The meaning and scope of Paul's teaching about religious days should be studied carefully rather than used to redefine the identity of the seventh day.

Question 13 — What Does Hebrews 4 Teach About God's Sabbath Rest?

Answer:

Hebrews 4 presents God's rest as an important reality for believers.

The author refers to God's rest at Creation and recalls Israel's failure to enter the promised rest because of unbelief.

He then invites believers to enter God's rest through faith.

Hebrews 4:9 states:

> “There remaineth therefore a rest to the people of God.”

Hebrews 4:9 — KJV

The Greek word translated “rest” in this verse is sabbatismos.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, this passage supports the continuing spiritual significance of Sabbath rest.

The chapter also teaches that God's rest is connected with faith, obedience, and the fulfillment of His promises.

The spiritual meaning of rest does not change the identity of the seventh day established in Genesis.

The Sabbath points believers toward the Creator, dependence upon His grace, and the final rest He has promised.

Bible References:

- Genesis 2:2–3
- Psalm 95:7–11
- Hebrews 3:7–19
- Hebrews 4:1–11
- Matthew 11:28–30

Linguistic Note:

The Greek term sabbatismos appears in Hebrews 4:9. The passage connects divine rest with Creation, Israel's experience, and the

believer's hope. The Sabbath's spiritual meaning must be considered within that complete argument.

Question 14 — How Did Sunday Worship Develop in Christian History?

Answer:

The development of Sunday worship occurred progressively in Christian history.

The New Testament records that Jesus rose from the dead on the first day of the week.

It also mentions Christian gatherings associated with that day.

During the second century, historical testimonies show that some Christian communities regularly gathered on Sunday.

Justin Martyr, writing in the middle of the second century, describes Christian worship on Sunday.

This demonstrates that Sunday gatherings existed before Emperor Constantine.

In AD 321, Constantine issued a civil law establishing Sunday rest for certain activities.

His law strengthened the public importance of Sunday within the Roman Empire.

However, Constantine did not invent the practice of Christian Sunday worship.

Later church decisions also influenced the relationship between Sunday worship and Sabbath observance.

The important distinction is that the historical development of Sunday worship is not the same as a biblical commandment changing the Sabbath.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, the seventh day remained the day sanctified by God, regardless of later religious or civil practices.

Bible References:

- Matthew 28:1
- John 20:19
- Acts 20:7
- 1 Corinthians 16:2
- Revelation 1:10

Historical Overview

Period Historical Development

First century Jesus rises on the first day; the New Testament records certain first-day gatherings

Early second century Early Christian writings refer to gatherings associated with the Lord's Day

Approximately AD 155–160 Justin Martyr describes Christian worship on Sunday

AD 321 Constantine issues a civil law concerning Sunday rest

Fourth century Regional church councils address practices concerning Saturday and Sunday

Historical Note:

Sunday worship developed before Constantine and was strengthened by later civil and ecclesiastical measures.

These historical developments did not change Saturday into the first day or Sunday into the seventh day.

The biblical identification of the Sabbath remained unchanged.

Question 15 — What Is the Sabbath's Significance for Christians and the Hope of Christ's Return?

Answer:

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, the seventh-day Sabbath remains a day devoted to rest, worship, communion with God, and service to others.

It recalls four important truths.

First, God is the Creator of heaven and earth.

Second, human beings depend upon Him for life and spiritual renewal.

Third, genuine worship involves faithfulness, love, and obedience.

Fourth, believers look forward to the final fulfillment of God's promises.

The Sabbath should never be observed as a means of earning salvation.

Salvation is a gift of God's grace received through faith in Jesus Christ.

Sabbath observance is understood as a response of love and faithfulness to the Creator.

Seventh-day Adventists also connect the message of Revelation 14:6–12, which calls humanity to worship the Creator, with the language of the fourth commandment.

They understand the Sabbath as having particular significance in the final conflict concerning worship and allegiance to God.

Revelation 14 does not explicitly name the Sabbath, so this prophetic application rests upon comparing the passages rather than upon a direct mention of the day.

The essential principle remains that God's people are called to worship Him faithfully and place their trust in Jesus Christ.

Bible References:

- Genesis 2:1–3
- Exodus 20:8–11
- Isaiah 58:13–14
- Mark 2:27–28
- Hebrews 4:1–11
- Revelation 12:17
- Revelation 14:6–12

Doctrinal Note:

Seventh-day Adventist theology gives the seventh-day Sabbath a special place in its interpretation of end-time prophecy. This teaching will be developed in the chapters concerning biblical prophecy and the events preceding Christ's return.

Chapter Summary

The Sabbath is the seventh day of the week, Saturday.

God blessed and sanctified this day at Creation.

The fourth commandment identifies the same day and connects its observance with God's creative work.

Jesus observed the Sabbath, and the Book of Acts records Sabbath activities among the apostles.

Although Sunday worship developed in Christian history, the New Testament contains no explicit command transferring the holiness of the seventh day to the first.

Our study enables us to retain the following teachings:

1. The word Sabbath is associated with ceasing ordinary work and resting.

2. God blessed and sanctified the seventh day at Creation.

3. Divine rest marked the completion of God's creative work.

4. Israel knew and observed the Sabbath before the proclamation of the Ten Commandments at Sinai.

5. The fourth commandment identifies the seventh day as the Sabbath of the LORD.

6. The Sabbath was presented as a sign between God and Israel.

7. The biblical Sabbath is Saturday, the seventh day of the week.

8. Jesus Christ observed the Sabbath.

9. Jesus taught that the Sabbath was made for humanity and that doing good on that day was appropriate.

10. The Book of Acts records apostolic preaching and gatherings on the Sabbath.

11. No New Testament passage explicitly transfers the Sabbath from Saturday to Sunday.

12. The passages in Colossians 2, Romans 14, and Galatians 4 must be interpreted within their contexts; none identifies Sunday as the seventh day.

13. Hebrews 4 connects God's rest with Creation, faith, and the believer's hope.

14. Sunday worship developed historically, but its development did not change the biblical identity of the Sabbath.

15. In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, the Sabbath remains a sign of faithfulness to the Creator and possesses particular significance in the hope of Christ's return.

Doctrinal Conclusion

The biblical Sabbath is the seventh day of the week, Saturday.

According to Genesis 2:1–3, God blessed and sanctified this day at Creation.

The fourth commandment identifies it as the Sabbath of the LORD.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, it continues to possess four principal dimensions.

A Memorial of Creation

The Sabbath reminds humanity that God is the Creator of heaven, earth, and all life.

A Sign of Communion With God

It provides a sacred period for worship, gratitude, prayer, and fellowship with the Lord.

A Day of Rest and Compassion

It protects human dignity and encourages rest, mercy, and service.

A Sign of Faithfulness and Hope

It reminds believers of God's sovereignty and directs their attention toward the fulfillment of His promises.

The Sabbath must not become a source of spiritual pride or a means of earning salvation.

The foundation of salvation is Jesus Christ alone.

The believer's obedience is a response of faith, gratitude, and love.

The Essential Message:

God blessed and sanctified the seventh day, Saturday. Scripture does not record a divine command changing the Sabbath to Sunday. In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, the Sabbath remains a sacred day of rest, worship, and communion with the Creator, observed through faith and love rather than as a means of earning salvation.

Personal Reflection Questions

1. Have I understood that the Sabbath identified in Scripture is the seventh day, Saturday?

2. Why did God bless and sanctify the seventh day at Creation?

3. What is the relationship between the Sabbath of Genesis 2 and the fourth commandment?

4. What do Jesus' teachings and healings reveal about proper Sabbath observance?

5. What distinction does the New Testament establish between the Sabbath and the first day of the week?

6. Have I understood the difference between the biblical Sabbath and the historical development of Sunday worship?

7. How should I understand Colossians 2:16–17 and Romans 14:5–6 within their contexts?

8. Am I willing to study God's Word sincerely and follow what it teaches?

9. How can I share my understanding of the Sabbath with clarity, patience, and respect?

10. Does my relationship with God rest above all upon Jesus Christ and His saving grace?

Suggested Prayer

Lord my God,

I thank You for Your Word and for the truths You reveal to those who sincerely seek You.

You are the Creator of heaven, earth, and all life.

I acknowledge that my existence depends entirely upon You.

Thank You for blessing and sanctifying the seventh day at Creation.

Help me understand the meaning of Your holy Sabbath and the principles of rest, worship, and communion with You.

Grant me the wisdom to study the Scriptures faithfully and understand their teachings in context.

Protect me from religious pride, prejudice, and unjust condemnation of others.

May Your Holy Spirit enlighten my understanding and guide my decisions.

Teach me to devote time to You, seek Your presence, and show compassion toward my neighbors.

May my obedience always arise from love and gratitude rather than from the desire to earn salvation.

I place my trust in Jesus Christ, my Savior, who offers me forgiveness and eternal life.

Prepare me to remain faithful to Your Word until the glorious return of Your Son.

In the name of Jesus Christ, my Savior and Lord.

Amen.

CHAPTER 18 — BAPTISM: WHY AND HOW SHOULD WE PUBLICLY BECOME DISCIPLES OF JESUS CHRIST?

A Thematic Bible Study — King James Version (KJV)

Opening Scripture

> “He that believeth and is baptized shall be saved; but he that believeth not shall be damned.”

Mark 16:16 — KJV

Textual Note: Mark 16:9–20 is included in the King James Version, but its presence in the earliest recoverable text of Mark is disputed in textual criticism. The biblical teaching concerning baptism is also firmly established in Matthew 28:18–20, Acts 2:37–41, and Romans 6:3–4.

Introduction

In the preceding chapters, we discovered that salvation is a free gift from God, offered through grace and received by faith in Jesus Christ.

We also studied repentance, conversion, justification, sanctification, the new birth, and the importance of God's commandments in Christian life.

But when someone accepts Jesus Christ as Savior and Lord, an important question arises: How should that person publicly express this commitment?

The New Testament presents baptism as a fundamental step in Christian discipleship.

Jesus Himself was baptized by John the Baptist in the Jordan River. After His resurrection, He commanded His disciples to proclaim the Gospel, make disciples of all nations, and baptize them in the name of the Father, the Son, and the Holy Ghost.

Throughout the Book of Acts, those who receive the Gospel are repeatedly called to repentance, faith, and baptism.

The biblical accounts establish an important relationship between personal faith and baptism.

They also reveal the spiritual meaning of immersion: identification with the death, burial, and resurrection of Jesus Christ.

This chapter will examine fifteen questions concerning the origin, meaning, method, and importance of Christian baptism.

We will establish the biblical foundation for baptism by immersion following personal faith, while explaining its relationship to salvation, the Holy Spirit, the Church, and the Christian life.

Question 1 — What Is Baptism According to the Holy Scriptures?

Answer:

Christian baptism is a public act through which a believer identifies with Jesus Christ and the community of His disciples.

In the New Testament, baptism is closely associated with faith, repentance, forgiveness of sins, and the beginning of a new life.

Water is the visible element used in baptism, but the meaning of baptism extends beyond the physical act.

It expresses the believer's commitment to Jesus Christ and symbolizes participation in His death, burial, and resurrection.

The apostle Paul explains that believers are buried with Christ through baptism and are called to walk in newness of life.

Baptism is therefore not merely a religious ceremony.

It is a public testimony of faith, surrender, and belonging to Jesus Christ.

Bible References:

- Matthew 28:18–20
- Acts 2:37–41
- Acts 8:35–39
- Romans 6:3–4
- Galatians 3:26–28
- Colossians 2:11–12

Linguistic Note:

The Greek verb baptizō can describe dipping, immersing, or washing, depending on context. The New Testament's baptismal narratives and the symbolism of burial and resurrection provide the foundation for the Seventh-day Adventist practice of baptism by immersion.

Question 2 — What Is the Difference Between John's Baptism and Christian Baptism?

Answer:

John the Baptist carried out his ministry before the death and resurrection of Jesus Christ.

He called the people of Israel to repentance and prepared them for the coming Messiah.

His baptism was associated with repentance and the confession of sins.

John also announced that the One coming after him would baptize with the Holy Ghost.

Christian baptism, as proclaimed after Christ's resurrection, is directly connected with Jesus' completed redemptive work and the believer's identification with Him.

In Acts 19, Paul encountered certain disciples who had received John's baptism.

After explaining the relationship between John's ministry and Jesus Christ, Paul baptized them in the name of the Lord Jesus.

This account demonstrates the distinction between John's preparatory baptism and Christian baptism centered upon the risen Savior.

Bible References:

- Matthew 3:1–12
- Mark 1:4–8
- John 1:19–34
- Acts 18:24–26
- Acts 19:1–7

Historical Note:

John's ministry took place within a Jewish environment in which various practices of purification with water already existed. His baptism, however, possessed a distinctive prophetic purpose: preparing the people for the coming Messiah.

Question 3 — Why Was Jesus Christ Baptized Although He Had Never Sinned?

Answer:

The Gospels record that Jesus was baptized by John the Baptist in the Jordan River.

John initially hesitated because he recognized Jesus' spiritual superiority.

Jesus nevertheless instructed him to proceed, declaring that it was appropriate to fulfill all righteousness.

Jesus did not receive baptism because He needed forgiveness for personal sins.

The New Testament clearly teaches that He was without sin.

His baptism marked an important stage in the public manifestation of His mission.

The Gospel account also describes the descent of the Holy Spirit and the heavenly voice identifying Jesus as the beloved Son.

This event reveals His obedience to the Father and His identification with the humanity He came to save.

Bible References:

- Matthew 3:13–17
- Mark 1:9–11
- Luke 3:21–22
- John 1:29–34
- Hebrews 4:14–15
- 1 Peter 2:21–22

Explanatory Note:

Jesus' baptism had a unique significance connected with His messianic mission. Unlike repentant sinners, He did not need cleansing from personal transgression.

Question 4 — Did Jesus Christ Command His Disciples to Baptize New Believers?

Answer:

Yes.

After His resurrection, Jesus entrusted His disciples with the mission of proclaiming the Gospel and making disciples among all nations.

Matthew 28:18–20 includes baptism as part of this commission.

Jesus commanded His disciples to baptize in the name of the Father, the Son, and the Holy Ghost.

He also instructed them to teach new disciples to observe everything He had commanded.

Baptism is therefore connected with instruction, faith, and Christian discipleship.

It is not an isolated ceremony separated from a relationship with Jesus Christ.

The Book of Acts demonstrates that the apostles continued this mission after Pentecost.

Those who accepted the Gospel were regularly baptized as a public expression of their response to Christ.

Bible References:

- Matthew 28:18–20
- Acts 2:37–41
- Acts 8:12
- Acts 10:44–48
- Acts 16:25–34
- Acts 18:8

Doctrinal Note:

Matthew 28:19 provides the baptismal instruction in the name of the Father, the Son, and the Holy Ghost. Acts also describes baptism in the name of Jesus Christ, emphasizing allegiance to Him. Seventh-day Adventist baptism follows the instruction of Matthew 28:19.

Question 5 — What Is the Relationship Between Faith, Repentance, and Baptism?

Answer:

The New Testament repeatedly connects baptism with hearing the Gospel, believing in Jesus Christ, and repenting of sin.

On the day of Pentecost, Peter called his hearers to repent and be baptized.

In Acts 8, the Samaritans who believed Philip's preaching received baptism.

The Ethiopian official heard the Gospel concerning Jesus before receiving baptism.

The Philippian jailer also heard the message of salvation in Christ before his household was baptized.

These accounts demonstrate the importance of a response to the Gospel.

In the Seventh-day Adventist understanding, baptism follows a personal and conscious decision to accept Jesus Christ.

A person should understand the fundamental meaning of the Gospel and freely choose to follow the Savior.

Baptism is therefore connected with personal faith and repentance rather than merely with family membership or religious tradition.

Bible References:

- Mark 1:14–15
- Acts 2:37–41
- Acts 8:12
- Acts 8:35–39
- Acts 16:30–34
- Acts 18:8

Explanatory Note:

The Book of Acts often describes baptism soon after a person accepts the Gospel. Scripture does not establish one universal preparation period, but it does emphasize the importance of faith, repentance, and understanding.

Question 6 — Why Is Baptism Associated With the Death and Resurrection of Jesus Christ?

Answer:

In Romans 6, the apostle Paul explains that baptism identifies believers with the death and resurrection of Jesus Christ.

He uses the image of burial to describe the end of the believer's former way of life.

Christ's resurrection becomes the foundation of a new existence.

Through baptism, the believer publicly acknowledges that the old life dominated by sin must no longer govern the heart.

The Christian is called to walk in newness of life.

Baptism by immersion expresses this symbolism with particular clarity.

Going beneath the water represents burial with Christ.

Rising from the water represents the beginning of a new life through the power of His resurrection.

The meaning of baptism is therefore centered upon Jesus Christ, not merely upon the water.

Bible References:

- Romans 6:1–11
- Galatians 2:20
- Galatians 3:26–27
- Colossians 2:11–13
- 2 Corinthians 5:17

Explanatory Note:

The symbolism of burial and resurrection is central to Paul's teaching. Baptism by full immersion visibly expresses this biblical image.

Question 7 — Should Christian Baptism Be Administered by Immersion?

Answer:

Baptism by full immersion is the method practiced by the Seventh-day Adventist Church on the basis of its understanding of Scripture.

The Gospel accounts record that Jesus was baptized in the Jordan River and came up out of the water.

In Acts 8, Philip and the Ethiopian official went down into the water, and after the baptism they came up out of it.

Romans 6 associates baptism with burial and resurrection.

Colossians 2:12 uses the same symbolism.

These passages, considered together, provide strong biblical support for baptism by immersion.

Immersion portrays the believer's identification with the death, burial, and resurrection of Jesus Christ.

It expresses the surrender of the old life and the beginning of a new life in Him.

The Seventh-day Adventist Church therefore administers baptism by completely immersing the believer in water.

Bible References:

- Matthew 3:13–17
- John 3:22–23
- Acts 8:35–39
- Romans 6:3–4
- Colossians 2:12
- Titus 3:5

Linguistic Note:

The Greek verb baptizō, together with the New Testament baptismal narratives and Paul's symbolism of burial, supports immersion as the method adopted in Seventh-day Adventist practice.

The descriptions of entering and leaving the water do not individually record every movement involved, but the combined evidence supports the practice.

Question 8 — Should Infants Be Baptized?

Answer:

In Seventh-day Adventist biblical understanding, baptism should be administered to a person capable of personally responding to the Gospel through faith and repentance.

The New Testament repeatedly connects baptism with receiving the message of Jesus Christ.

Acts 8:12 describes men and women being baptized after believing Philip's preaching.

The accounts of household baptisms do not explicitly identify infants among those baptized.

For this reason, they do not provide direct evidence that infants who could not personally profess faith received baptism.

Jesus welcomed children and demonstrated His love for them.

However, the Gospel accounts do not record Him baptizing infants.

The Seventh-day Adventist Church therefore dedicates infants and children to God through prayer, while reserving baptism for those who can personally understand and accept the Gospel.

This does not require a person to reach a particular numerical age.

The important consideration is sufficient maturity to understand the commitment and freely profess faith in Jesus Christ.

Bible References:

- Genesis 17:9–14
- Matthew 19:13–15
- Acts 2:38–39
- Acts 8:12
- Acts 16:14–15
- Acts 16:30–34
- Colossians 2:11–12

Doctrinal Note:

The New Testament does not explicitly describe an infant receiving Christian baptism. Seventh-day Adventist practice therefore follows the pattern of baptism associated with personal faith and repentance.

Question 9 — Does Baptism Automatically Wash Away Sins?

Answer:

No. Water does not possess an independent power to forgive sins.

The New Testament closely associates baptism with forgiveness, cleansing, and salvation.

In Acts 2:38, Peter connects repentance and baptism with the remission of sins.

In Acts 22:16, Ananias calls Paul to be baptized and to call upon the name of the Lord.

However, Scripture also teaches that forgiveness rests upon the redemptive work of Jesus Christ and the grace of God.

Acts 10 records that Cornelius and those gathered with him received the Holy Spirit before their baptism in water.

This demonstrates that God's saving work cannot be reduced to a mechanical effect produced by a religious ceremony.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, baptism is a response of faith and obedience to Jesus Christ.

Its spiritual significance cannot be separated from repentance, faith, and the work of the Holy Spirit.

Bible References:

- Acts 2:37–41
- Acts 10:43–48
- Acts 22:12–16
- Ephesians 2:8–10
- Titus 3:4–7
- 1 Peter 3:18–22

Doctrinal Note:

Baptism is important because Jesus commanded it, but the water itself does not save. Forgiveness and spiritual renewal depend upon Jesus Christ.

Question 10 — Can a Person Be Saved Without Receiving Water Baptism?

Answer:

The New Testament presents baptism as a normal and important step of Christian obedience.

However, salvation rests upon Jesus Christ rather than upon human merit or the physical performance of a ceremony.

The account of the criminal crucified beside Jesus is particularly significant.

He acknowledged his wrongdoing, expressed faith in Jesus, and received a promise concerning Christ's kingdom.

The Gospel account does not record him receiving water baptism before his death.

This example shows that a genuine inability to receive baptism should not be confused with deliberately rejecting Christ's instruction.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, a person who has accepted Jesus Christ should seek baptism when it is possible.

However, God is not limited by circumstances that prevent someone from receiving the rite.

Bible References:

- Luke 23:39–43
- John 3:16–18
- Acts 10:43–48
- Romans 10:9–13
- Ephesians 2:8–10

Explanatory Note:

The criminal on the cross does not provide a reason to disregard baptism. His experience demonstrates that salvation ultimately depends upon the grace of Jesus Christ.

Question 11 — What Role Does the Holy Spirit Play in Christian Baptism?

Answer:

The Holy Spirit accomplishes the inward work of renewal that gives baptism its true spiritual significance.

Jesus taught Nicodemus the necessity of being born of water and of the Spirit.

The apostle Paul also connects spiritual renewal with the mercy of God and the work of the Holy Spirit.

The Book of Acts describes different circumstances concerning water baptism and the reception of the Holy Spirit.

At Pentecost, Peter connected repentance, baptism, and the gift of the Holy Spirit.

In the house of Cornelius, the Holy Spirit came upon the hearers before their water baptism.

In Samaria, believers received the Holy Spirit in an episode distinct from their baptism.

These accounts demonstrate that the Holy Spirit's work cannot be reduced to one automatic sequence.

Water baptism is the outward act.

Spiritual renewal is accomplished through God's power.

Bible References:

- John 3:5–8
- Acts 2:38–39
- Acts 8:12–17
- Acts 10:44–48
- 1 Corinthians 12:13
- Titus 3:5–6

Explanatory Note:

The Bible presents the Holy Spirit as essential to genuine spiritual transformation. The act of baptism must be accompanied by a sincere relationship with Jesus Christ and openness to the Spirit's work.

Question 12 — Does Baptism Mark Entrance Into the Church of Jesus Christ?

Answer:

Baptism is closely connected with becoming part of the community of Jesus Christ's disciples.

In Acts 2, those who accepted Peter's preaching were baptized and joined the community of believers.

They continued in the apostles' teaching, fellowship, breaking of bread, and prayers.

Baptism therefore has both a personal and a communal dimension.

The believer publicly identifies with Christ and joins a community called to live in faith, love, worship, and service.

In Seventh-day Adventist practice, baptism normally accompanies admission into church membership following a personal profession of faith.

However, belonging to a religious organization must not be confused with possessing a genuine saving relationship with Jesus Christ.

The Church is called to nurture believers in their continued spiritual growth.

Bible References:

- Matthew 28:18–20
- Acts 2:41–47
- Acts 8:12
- 1 Corinthians 12:12–27
- Ephesians 4:4–6
- Hebrews 10:23–25

Explanatory Note:

Christian community is important, but membership alone does not guarantee salvation. A living relationship with Jesus Christ remains essential.

Question 13 — Can a Person Who Has Already Been Baptized Receive Baptism Again?

Answer:

The New Testament emphasizes the unity of Christian baptism.

Ephesians 4:5 speaks of one Lord, one faith, and one baptism.

This teaching underscores the unity of Christian identity.

However, Acts 19 records that certain disciples who had received John's baptism were subsequently baptized in the name of the Lord Jesus.

This passage shows that Christian baptism may follow an earlier baptism whose meaning was different.

In Seventh-day Adventist practice, rebaptism may be considered in particular circumstances.

For example, a person who has profoundly abandoned the faith and later sincerely returns to Jesus Christ may request rebaptism as an expression of renewed commitment.

Rebaptism may also be considered when an earlier ceremony did not involve a personal profession of faith or did not correspond to the biblical understanding of Christian baptism.

However, Scripture does not require a person to be baptized again after every sin or period of spiritual weakness.

Repentance, confession, and renewed faith remain essential parts of Christian life.

Bible References:

- Acts 19:1–7
- Romans 6:3–4
- Ephesians 4:4–6
- 1 John 1:8–9
- Revelation 2:4–5

Doctrinal Note:

The Seventh-day Adventist Church permits rebaptism in certain circumstances. It is not treated as an automatic requirement after every spiritual failure.

Question 14 — How Should a Person Prepare for Baptism?

Answer:

Preparation for baptism should help a person understand the Gospel and make a free, informed decision to follow Jesus Christ.

The New Testament connects baptism with teaching, faith, and repentance.

A person preparing for baptism should therefore learn about Jesus Christ, His saving work, and the meaning of Christian commitment.

The candidate should understand that baptism is not a declaration of personal perfection.

It is a public expression of faith and the beginning of a life of continued growth in Christ.

In Seventh-day Adventist practice, baptismal preparation includes the study of Scripture and the fundamental teachings of Christian faith.

It also includes understanding the responsibilities of Christian life.

However, preparation must never create the impression that salvation can be earned through religious knowledge or performance.

The decision must be personal, sincere, and free from coercion.

Bible References:

- Matthew 28:18–20
- Acts 2:37–41
- Acts 8:26–39
- Acts 16:30–34
- Romans 10:9–13
- Ephesians 2:8–10

Practical Note:

Baptismal preparation should include the study of Scripture, salvation by grace, repentance, faith in Jesus Christ, the meaning of immersion, and the fundamental principles of Christian life.

Question 15 — How Should Christians Live After Baptism?

Answer:

Baptism is not the end of Christian life.

It marks a fundamental step in a relationship with Jesus Christ that must continue to develop.

After baptism, believers are called to remain faithful, study the Scriptures, pray, fellowship with other Christians, and practice love toward their neighbors.

The apostle Paul teaches that those who have been united with Christ in His death and resurrection should walk in newness of life.

This new life involves resisting sin and growing progressively in holiness.

However, baptized believers remain dependent upon divine grace.

When they fall into sin, they are called to repent and return to God.

Baptism does not automatically make a person perfect.

It expresses the commitment to follow Jesus Christ and live under His direction.

Bible References:

- Romans 6:1–14
- Acts 2:42–47
- Galatians 5:16–25
- Colossians 2:6–7
- 1 Peter 2:1–3
- 2 Peter 3:18

- 1 John 2:1–6

Explanatory Note:

Faithfulness after baptism involves more than the absence of visible wrongdoing. It also includes growth in love, humility, justice, repentance, and confidence in Jesus Christ.

Chapter Summary

Baptism occupies an essential place in Christian teaching and practice.

It is associated with faith, repentance, forgiveness, the new birth, and commitment to Jesus Christ.

Our study enables us to retain the following teachings:

1. Christian baptism is a visible act of identification with Jesus Christ and His community.

2. John's baptism prepared the people for the coming Messiah.

3. Jesus was baptized not because He had sinned, but as part of His mission and obedience to the Father.

4. Jesus commanded His disciples to baptize those who become His disciples.

5. The New Testament closely connects baptism with faith and repentance.

6. Baptism symbolizes identification with the death and resurrection of Jesus Christ.

7. Baptism by full immersion expresses the biblical symbolism of burial and resurrection and is the method practiced by Seventh-day Adventists.

8. In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, baptism follows a personal profession of faith rather than being administered to infants.

9. Baptism does not automatically produce salvation independently of grace and faith.

10. A genuine inability to receive water baptism does not necessarily exclude a person from salvation.

11. The Holy Spirit accomplishes the inward work of spiritual renewal.

12. Baptism is connected with joining the Christian community.

13. Rebaptism may be considered in certain circumstances.

14. Preparation for baptism should encourage a personal, free, and informed decision.

15. Christian life must continue to develop after baptism.

Doctrinal Conclusion

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, Christian baptism is administered by full immersion to a person who has personally accepted Jesus Christ as Savior and Lord.

It represents death to the former life dominated by sin and the beginning of a new existence in Christ.

It is also a public profession of faith and an important step in joining the Christian community.

Baptism must never be regarded as a means of earning salvation.

Water does not possess an independent power to forgive sins.

Forgiveness and new life rest upon the redemptive work of Jesus Christ and the grace of God.

Baptism expresses a spiritual reality that must be lived through faith, repentance, and communion with the Savior.

The Essential Message:

Biblical baptism is a public commitment to Jesus Christ, administered by immersion following a personal response of faith and repentance. It symbolizes the burial of the old life and the beginning of a new life in

Christ. Salvation comes through God's grace, not through the water itself.

Personal Reflection Questions

1. Have I understood the biblical meaning of Christian baptism?

2. What is the difference between John's baptism and the baptism practiced by Jesus' disciples?

3. Why did Jesus accept baptism although He was without sin?

4. Do I understand the relationship between baptism, faith, and repentance?

5. What does the image of burial and resurrection represent in Romans 6?

6. Have I understood the biblical reasons for baptism by immersion?

7. Do I regard baptism as merely a ceremony, or as the expression of a commitment to Jesus Christ?

8. Am I willing to make a personal and free decision concerning my relationship with God?

9. How can I develop my spiritual life after baptism?

10. Does my confidence in salvation rest upon Jesus Christ or upon the performance of a religious rite?

Suggested Prayer

Lord my God,

I thank You for Your love and for the salvation You freely offer me through Jesus Christ.

Thank You for His perfect life, His death upon the cross, and His glorious resurrection.

I acknowledge that I cannot save myself and that only Your grace can give me new life.

Help me understand the true meaning of baptism.

May this act never become for me a mere religious formality or a way of seeking human approval.

Give me sincere faith and a heart willing to repent.

Teach me to abandon whatever separates me from You and to walk according to Your will.

May Your Holy Spirit renew my thoughts, desires, and decisions.

If I am preparing for baptism, grant me the wisdom to make this commitment freely and with conviction.

If I have already been baptized, help me remain faithful to my promise to follow Jesus Christ.

When I experience difficulties, strengthen my faith.

When I fall, lead me to repentance and raise me up through Your grace.

May my life bear witness to Your love, justice, and mercy.

Prepare me for the glorious return of Jesus Christ and for eternal life in Your kingdom.

In the name of Jesus Christ, my Savior and Lord.

Amen.

CHAPTER 19 — PRAYER: HOW CAN WE COMMUNICATE WITH GOD AND UNDERSTAND HIS ANSWERS?

A Thematic Bible Study — King James Version (KJV)

Opening Scripture

> “Call unto me, and I will answer thee, and shew thee great and mighty things, which thou knowest not.”

Jeremiah 33:3 — KJV

Introduction

In the preceding chapters, we examined the importance of God's commandments, the seventh-day Sabbath, and baptism as a public expression of faith in Jesus Christ.

However, Christian life does not consist merely of understanding biblical doctrines or participating in religious ceremonies.

It requires a living and continuing relationship with God.

One of the most important expressions of that relationship is prayer.

Throughout the Holy Scriptures, prayer occupies a central place in the experience of God's people.

Abraham interceded for others. Moses sought God's guidance. Hannah presented her sorrow before the Lord. David expressed his gratitude, repentance, and confidence through prayer. Daniel remained faithful in prayer even when his life was threatened.

Jesus Christ Himself prayed regularly during His earthly ministry.

He prayed before important decisions, during moments of suffering, and in communion with His heavenly Father.

He also taught His disciples how to pray.

Yet many important questions remain.

What is prayer? Why should Christians pray if God already knows their needs? Does God hear every prayer? Why are some prayers apparently unanswered? What does it mean to pray according to God's will? How can believers recognize His guidance?

The Bible provides principles that help us understand these questions.

This chapter examines fifteen questions concerning the meaning, practice, conditions, and spiritual importance of prayer.

Our purpose is not merely to learn how to ask God for blessings, but to understand how prayer deepens faith, strengthens communion with Him, and transforms Christian life.

Question 1 — What Is Prayer According to the Holy Scriptures?

Answer:

Prayer is the act of communicating with God through worship, thanksgiving, confession, supplication, and intercession.

It is an expression of faith through which believers approach their Creator and heavenly Father.

Prayer is not limited to requesting material or spiritual blessings.

It also includes praising God for His character, thanking Him for His goodness, confessing sins, and seeking His guidance.

The Psalms demonstrate that prayer may express joy, sorrow, repentance, fear, gratitude, or confidence.

God invites His people to approach Him sincerely.

Through prayer, believers acknowledge their dependence upon Him and cultivate a personal relationship with their heavenly Father.

Prayer is therefore more than a religious obligation.

It is an essential expression of communion with God.

Bible References:

- Psalm 5:1–3
- Psalm 62:8
- Psalm 100:4–5
- Jeremiah 33:3
- Philippians 4:6–7
- Hebrews 4:14–16

Explanatory Note:

Biblical prayer includes both speaking to God and adopting a receptive attitude toward His guidance. Scripture, rather than private impressions alone, provides the foundation for understanding His revealed will.

Question 2 — Why Should We Pray if God Already Knows Our Needs?

Answer:

Jesus taught that the heavenly Father knows the needs of His children before they ask Him.

Prayer is therefore not necessary because God lacks information.

The purpose of prayer is deeper.

Through prayer, believers express trust, dependence, gratitude, and submission to God.

Prayer strengthens their relationship with Him and teaches them to recognize His goodness.

It also encourages believers to bring their concerns before God rather than relying exclusively upon their own abilities.

The fact that God knows our needs does not eliminate His invitation to pray.

Jesus explicitly taught His disciples to pray even while reminding them that their Father already knew what they needed.

Prayer is thus an act of relationship rather than an attempt to inform an uninformed God.

Bible References:

- Matthew 6:5–8
- Matthew 6:25–33
- Matthew 7:7–11
- Psalm 139:1–4
- Philippians 4:6–7
- 1 Peter 5:6–7

Doctrinal Note:

God's foreknowledge and His invitation to prayer are not contradictory. Prayer is one of the means through which believers experience dependence upon Him and participate in a living relationship with their Creator.

Question 3 — To Whom Should Christians Address Their Prayers?

Answer:

Jesus taught His disciples to address God as their heavenly Father.

In the Lord's Prayer, He began with the words:

> “After this manner therefore pray ye: Our Father which art in heaven, Hallowed be thy name.”

Matthew 6:9 — KJV

Christian prayer is founded upon the relationship established through Jesus Christ.

The New Testament teaches that believers have access to the Father through Christ and by the Holy Spirit.

Jesus is presented as the mediator between God and humanity.

The Holy Spirit also assists believers in their weakness and intercedes according to God's will.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, prayer is appropriately directed to God, commonly to the Father in the name of Jesus Christ, through the assistance of the Holy Spirit.

The essential principle is that Christian prayer rests upon God's grace and the mediation of Jesus Christ rather than upon human merit.

Bible References:

- Matthew 6:9–13
- John 14:13–14
- John 16:23–27
- Romans 8:26–27
- Ephesians 2:18
- 1 Timothy 2:5
- Hebrews 7:25

Doctrinal Note:

The New Testament especially emphasizes access to the Father through Jesus Christ. It also contains prayers addressed directly to Jesus, such as Acts 7:59. Christian prayer should therefore be understood within the broader biblical teaching concerning the Father, Son, and Holy Spirit.

Question 4 — How Did Jesus Christ Teach His Disciples to Pray?

Answer:

Jesus provided a model of prayer in Matthew 6:9–13.

This prayer is commonly known as the Lord's Prayer.

It begins by acknowledging God's holiness and heavenly authority.

It then expresses the desire that His kingdom come and His will be accomplished.

The prayer also includes requests for daily provision, forgiveness, protection from temptation, and deliverance from evil.

Its structure teaches several important principles.

First, prayer should give priority to God's glory.

Second, believers should submit their desires to His will.

Third, they may confidently present their daily needs before Him.

Fourth, prayer should be accompanied by a forgiving spirit.

Fifth, believers should seek God's help in resisting temptation and evil.

Jesus also warned against praying merely to impress others or using meaningless repetition.

The Lord's Prayer is therefore both a prayer believers may recite and a model that teaches the essential priorities of genuine communion with God.

Bible References:

- Matthew 6:5–15
- Luke 11:1–4
- Matthew 18:21–35
- Matthew 26:39
- Philippians 4:6

Explanatory Note:

The Lord's Prayer is not a magical formula. Jesus presented it as a model of sincere prayer characterized by reverence, dependence, forgiveness, and submission to God's will.

Question 5 — What Does It Mean to Pray in the Name of Jesus Christ?

Answer:

Jesus taught His disciples to ask the Father in His name.

Praying in the name of Jesus means approaching God through the authority, mediation, and saving work of Jesus Christ.

It expresses confidence in Him as Savior and Lord.

It does not mean that simply pronouncing the name of Jesus guarantees that every request will be granted.

The believer's desires must be considered in relation to Christ's character, teachings, and purposes.

Jesus connected prayer in His name with the glorification of the Father.

He also taught that His disciples should remain in Him and allow His words to remain in them.

Therefore, praying in Jesus' name involves more than a concluding expression.

It is an acknowledgment that our access to God rests upon Christ and that our requests should be consistent with His will.

Bible References:

- John 14:12–14
- John 15:7
- John 16:23–27
- Acts 4:10–12

- Colossians 3:17
- Hebrews 4:14–16

Explanatory Note:

The expression “in Jesus' name” should not be treated as a formula that obligates God to fulfill human desires. Its biblical meaning is inseparable from faith in Christ and submission to His authority.

Question 6 — What Conditions Does the Bible Associate With Effective Prayer?

Answer:

Scripture identifies several attitudes that should characterize those who approach God in prayer.

Faith is important because believers must trust God's existence, goodness, and promises.

Sincerity is also essential.

God does not encourage religious hypocrisy or prayer intended merely to impress others.

Repentance and a willingness to abandon sin are important aspects of genuine communion with Him.

The Bible also connects prayer with forgiveness, humility, and obedience.

However, these principles must not be understood as conditions through which human beings earn God's favor.

No believer approaches God because of personal perfection.

Christians approach Him through grace, trusting in Jesus Christ.

A sincere prayer may itself be the cry of a struggling sinner seeking forgiveness and restoration.

Effective prayer is therefore characterized by faith, humility, sincerity, repentance, and dependence upon God's mercy.

Bible References:

- Psalm 66:18–20
- Proverbs 28:9, 13
- Matthew 6:5–8
- Mark 11:24–26
- James 1:5–8
- James 5:16
- Hebrews 11:6
- 1 John 3:21–22

Doctrinal Note:

Biblical warnings against deliberately cherishing sin should not discourage repentant sinners from praying. God's mercy remains available to those who sincerely turn to Him.

Question 7 — Does God Hear the Prayers of Sinners?

Answer:

The Bible teaches that sin damages the relationship between humanity and God.

However, it also repeatedly reveals God's willingness to hear those who sincerely seek His mercy.

The tax collector in Jesus' parable prayed for forgiveness, acknowledging his sinful condition.

Jesus declared that he went home justified rather than the self-righteous Pharisee.

David also confessed his sins and sought God's mercy.

The promise of forgiveness is extended to those who acknowledge their wrongdoing and turn toward God.

Therefore, the statement that God opposes deliberate wickedness must not be interpreted as meaning that He refuses to hear a sinner

who sincerely repents.

Indeed, prayer is one of the ways a sinner may seek reconciliation with God.

The essential distinction is between stubbornly cherishing sin and humbly seeking divine forgiveness.

Bible References:

- Psalm 32:1–5
- Psalm 51:1–17
- Proverbs 28:13
- Isaiah 55:6–7
- Luke 18:9–14
- Acts 10:1–4
- 1 John 1:8–9

Explanatory Note:

John 9:31 records a statement made by a man healed by Jesus within a controversy. That statement should be interpreted in its narrative context rather than treated as proof that God never hears the prayer of a repentant sinner.

Question 8 — Why Are Some Prayers Apparently Unanswered?

Answer:

Many believers experience situations in which they pray sincerely but do not receive the answer they expected.

The Bible does not teach that every request will be fulfilled according to human expectations.

James warns that some requests arise from selfish desires.

Other prayers may concern matters whose consequences believers do not fully understand.

The apostle Paul prayed repeatedly for the removal of his “thorn in the flesh.”

God did not grant the request in the manner Paul desired.

Instead, Paul received assurance that divine grace was sufficient for him.

Jesus Himself prayed in Gethsemane that the cup of suffering might pass from Him, while submitting to His Father's will.

These examples show that faithful prayer does not guarantee the removal of every difficulty.

Sometimes the answer differs from the request.

At other times, the reason for an apparent delay remains unknown.

Christians are therefore invited to trust God's wisdom even when His purposes are not fully understood.

Bible References:

- Psalm 13:1–6
- Matthew 26:36–44
- Romans 8:26–28
- 2 Corinthians 12:7–10
- James 4:1–3
- 1 John 5:14–15

Doctrinal Note:

Scripture does not authorize believers to claim certainty about God's hidden reasons for every unanswered prayer. Faith includes trusting Him when an explanation has not been revealed.

Question 9 — What Does It Mean to Pray According to God's Will?

Answer:

The apostle John teaches that believers may have confidence when they ask according to God's will.

Praying according to His will means seeking what is consistent with His character, revealed purposes, and wisdom.

The Bible reveals many aspects of God's will.

He desires repentance, faith, holiness, love, justice, and the salvation of humanity.

Believers may confidently pray for spiritual growth, forgiveness, wisdom, and strength to obey Him.

However, not every personal decision or future circumstance is explicitly explained in Scripture.

In such situations, Christians should pray with humility, seek biblical principles, consider wise counsel, and avoid claiming certainty where God has not spoken.

Jesus provided the supreme example when He prayed in Gethsemane.

He expressed His desire while submitting Himself to the Father's will.

Prayer according to God's will therefore combines honest requests with trustful surrender.

Bible References:

- Matthew 6:10
- Matthew 26:39
- Romans 12:1–2
- Ephesians 5:15–17
- Colossians 1:9–12
- James 1:5

- 1 John 5:14–15

Explanatory Note:

Submitting to God's will does not mean that believers must suppress their feelings or avoid specific requests. Jesus Himself expressed His distress and desire while remaining obedient to the Father.

Question 10 — Why Should Christians Persevere in Prayer?

Answer:

Jesus encouraged His disciples to pray continually and not lose heart.

In Luke 18, He told the parable of a widow who persistently sought justice from a judge.

The lesson emphasizes perseverance and confidence in God's justice.

Jesus also taught His disciples to ask, seek, and knock.

These teachings encourage believers not to abandon their relationship with God when difficulties continue.

Perseverance in prayer does not mean attempting to force God to change His will.

Nor does it imply that repeating a request many times automatically makes it more effective.

Rather, persistent prayer expresses continuing faith, dependence, and trust.

Daniel's experience also illustrates faithful prayer amid opposition and uncertainty.

Christians are therefore called to remain steadfast in prayer while trusting God's wisdom concerning the outcome.

Bible References:

- Daniel 6:10–23
- Luke 11:5–13

- Luke 18:1–8
- Romans 12:12
- Ephesians 6:18
- Colossians 4:2
- 1 Thessalonians 5:16–18

Explanatory Note:

Perseverance should be distinguished from the meaningless repetition condemned by Jesus in Matthew 6:7. The former expresses enduring faith; the latter treats prayer as though the multiplication of words guarantees results.

Question 11 — What Is Intercessory Prayer, and Why Should We Pray for Others?

Answer:

Intercessory prayer consists of presenting the needs of other people before God.

The Bible contains many examples of believers interceding for others.

Abraham pleaded for the inhabitants of Sodom.

Moses interceded for Israel.

Daniel confessed the sins of his people and sought divine mercy.

The apostle Paul frequently prayed for the spiritual growth of Christian communities.

The New Testament also encourages believers to pray for all people, including those in positions of authority.

Jesus Himself prayed for His disciples and for those who would later believe through their testimony.

Intercessory prayer expresses love, compassion, and concern for others.

It reminds believers that Christian life is not centered exclusively upon personal needs.

However, intercession does not replace the unique mediatorial role of Jesus Christ in salvation.

Believers pray for one another while depending upon Christ as their Savior and heavenly mediator.

Bible References:

- Genesis 18:22–33
- Exodus 32:11–14
- Daniel 9:3–19
- John 17:6–26
- Ephesians 1:15–19
- 1 Timothy 2:1–6
- James 5:14–16

Doctrinal Note:

The Bible encourages living believers to pray for one another. Seventh-day Adventist theology distinguishes this practice from invoking the dead, in harmony with its understanding of the state of the dead and Christ's unique mediatorial ministry.

Question 12 — Should Christians Pray Privately, With Their Families, and in Public Worship?

Answer:

The Bible presents prayer in both personal and communal settings.

Jesus encouraged private prayer and warned against religious displays intended to attract human admiration.

He also participated in public worship and taught His disciples to pray together.

The early Christian community devoted itself to prayer.

Families may likewise cultivate spiritual life through worship, thanksgiving, and instruction in God's Word.

Private prayer provides an opportunity for personal confession, reflection, and communion with God.

Family prayer strengthens shared spiritual commitments.

Congregational prayer expresses the unity of believers and their common dependence upon the Lord.

These different forms of prayer complement one another.

No particular location possesses an independent power to make prayer effective.

God's people may approach Him wherever they are, with sincerity and reverence.

Bible References:

- Deuteronomy 6:4–9
- Daniel 6:10
- Matthew 6:5–6
- Matthew 18:19–20
- Mark 1:35
- Acts 1:12–14
- Acts 2:42
- Acts 12:5–12

Practical Note:

A regular devotional routine may include personal prayer, family worship, Scripture reading, thanksgiving, and intercession. Such practices should strengthen communion with God rather than become empty religious formalities.

Question 13 — Does the Bible Require a Particular Position, Place, or Time for Prayer?

Answer:

Scripture describes believers praying in different positions and circumstances.

Some prayed while kneeling.

Others stood, bowed, lifted their hands, or fell upon their faces.

Daniel prayed regularly at appointed times.

Jesus prayed early in the morning and also spent extended periods in prayer.

These examples demonstrate the importance of reverence, discipline, and communion with God.

However, the Bible does not establish one physical position as the only acceptable posture for every prayer.

The essential issue is the attitude of the heart.

Kneeling may express humility and worship.

Standing may also be appropriate in certain circumstances.

A believer may pray silently while traveling, working, suffering, or facing an emergency.

The biblical instruction to pray without ceasing encourages an enduring attitude of dependence upon God, not uninterrupted verbal prayer.

Bible References:

- 1 Kings 8:22–23, 54
- Psalm 95:6
- Daniel 6:10
- Mark 1:35
- Luke 18:13–14

- Luke 22:41
- 1 Timothy 2:8
- 1 Thessalonians 5:17

Explanatory Note:

The diversity of biblical examples indicates that sincerity, reverence, and faith are more important than treating a particular posture or location as a universal requirement.

Question 14 — How Can Christians Recognize God's Guidance in Response to Prayer?

Answer:

Christians often pray for direction concerning important decisions.

The Bible teaches that God provides wisdom and invites believers to trust Him.

However, recognizing His guidance requires discernment.

Scripture is the primary standard for evaluating religious teachings and spiritual claims.

God's guidance should not be interpreted as contradicting His revealed moral principles.

Prayer should therefore be accompanied by careful Bible study.

Wise counsel, thoughtful examination of circumstances, and responsible decision-making may also help believers discern a prudent course of action.

Nevertheless, circumstances alone do not necessarily reveal God's will.

An open opportunity is not always evidence of divine approval.

A difficult path is not always evidence of divine disapproval.

Believers should also be cautious about interpreting every strong emotion, dream, coincidence, or personal impression as a direct

message from God.

The Holy Spirit leads Christians toward truth, faithfulness, and Christlike character.

Therefore, discernment involves prayer, Scripture, humility, wisdom, and patience.

Bible References:

- Psalm 119:105
- Proverbs 3:5–7
- Proverbs 11:14
- Isaiah 8:20
- John 16:13–14
- Romans 12:2
- James 1:5
- 1 John 4:1

Doctrinal Note:

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, spiritual impressions and claimed revelations must be tested by Scripture. Prayer does not replace biblical study, sound judgment, or personal responsibility.

Question 15 — How Does Prayer Prepare Believers for Christian Faithfulness and the Return of Jesus Christ?

Answer:

Prayer is essential to the continuing spiritual life of believers.

Through prayer, Christians seek strength to resist temptation, wisdom to make faithful decisions, and courage to remain steadfast during difficulties.

Jesus encouraged His disciples to watch and pray.

He warned them about spiritual weakness and the dangers of temptation.

The New Testament also connects prayer with perseverance, thanksgiving, spiritual vigilance, and preparation for the fulfillment of God's promises.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, prayer has particular importance as believers anticipate the return of Jesus Christ.

However, preparation for Christ's coming is not accomplished through prayer alone.

It involves faith in Jesus Christ, obedience motivated by love, dependence upon the Holy Spirit, and a life of service.

Prayer strengthens this relationship.

It reminds believers that spiritual victory does not arise from human strength but from divine grace.

The Christian who prays sincerely is invited to remain watchful, hopeful, humble, and faithful.

Bible References:

- Matthew 24:42–44
- Matthew 26:40–41
- Luke 21:34–36
- Ephesians 6:10–18
- Philippians 4:6–9
- 1 Thessalonians 5:1–11, 16–18
- 1 Peter 4:7
- Revelation 22:17–20

Doctrinal Note:

Biblical watchfulness is not an invitation to speculate about the date of Christ's return. It is a call to remain spiritually prepared through faith, prayer, obedience, and confidence in God's promises.

Chapter Summary

Prayer is one of the essential foundations of Christian life.

It allows believers to express worship, gratitude, repentance, dependence, and confidence in God.

Jesus Christ taught His disciples to pray sincerely and to seek the Father's will.

Scripture also teaches that prayer must be understood in connection with faith, humility, repentance, perseverance, and the saving work of Jesus Christ.

Our study enables us to retain the following teachings:

1. Prayer is communication with God through worship, thanksgiving, confession, supplication, and intercession.

2. God already knows our needs, but prayer strengthens our relationship with Him.

3. Christians have access to the Father through Jesus Christ and by the Holy Spirit.

4. The Lord's Prayer provides a model of reverence, dependence, forgiveness, and submission.

5. Praying in Jesus' name involves confidence in His mediation and submission to His authority.

6. Effective prayer is associated with sincerity, faith, humility, repentance, and obedience.

7. God welcomes the sincere prayer of sinners who seek His mercy.

8. Some prayers are answered differently from what believers expect, and some apparent delays remain unexplained.

9. Prayer according to God's will combines sincere requests with trustful submission.

10. Perseverance in prayer expresses enduring faith rather than an attempt to control God.

11. Intercessory prayer expresses love and concern for others.

12. Private, family, and congregational prayers are complementary expressions of Christian communion.

13. The Bible records different postures, places, and times for prayer without imposing one universal physical form.

14. God's guidance should be discerned through Scripture, prayer, wisdom, and careful examination.

15. Prayer strengthens believers as they grow in faithfulness and anticipate the return of Jesus Christ.

Doctrinal Conclusion

Prayer is not merely a religious practice.

It is a vital expression of the relationship between God and His children.

The Holy Scriptures present prayer as a privilege made possible through the grace of God and the mediation of Jesus Christ.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, prayer possesses several essential dimensions.

A Relationship With the Heavenly Father

Prayer allows believers to approach God with reverence, confidence, gratitude, and love.

An Expression of Faith and Dependence

Through prayer, Christians acknowledge that their strength, wisdom, forgiveness, and salvation come from God.

A Means of Spiritual Growth

Prayer encourages repentance, humility, perseverance, obedience, and a deeper understanding of God's revealed will.

An Expression of Love for Others

Intercessory prayer develops compassion and concern for the spiritual and practical needs of other people.

A Source of Strength and Hope

Prayer helps believers remain faithful amid temptation, suffering, uncertainty, and the expectation of Christ's return.

Nevertheless, prayer must never be treated as a means of manipulating God.

Nor should its effectiveness be measured exclusively by the immediate fulfillment of personal requests.

The foundation of Christian confidence is not the perfection of human prayer but the goodness of God and the saving work of Jesus Christ.

The Essential Message:

Prayer is the privilege of communicating with God through Jesus Christ. It expresses faith, gratitude, repentance, worship, and dependence upon divine grace. God invites His children to pray sincerely, persevere faithfully, seek His will, and trust His wisdom even when His answers differ from their expectations.

Personal Reflection Questions

1. Do I understand prayer as a living relationship with God rather than merely a religious obligation?

2. Why should I pray when my heavenly Father already knows my needs?

3. What does the Lord's Prayer teach me about the priorities of Christian life?

4. Do I approach God with faith, humility, and sincere repentance?

5. What does it mean to pray in the name of Jesus Christ?

6. How do I respond when God does not answer my prayers in the manner I expected?

7. Am I willing to submit my personal desires to God's will?

8. Do I regularly pray for my family, my church, and the needs of others?

9. How can I strengthen my personal prayer life through Scripture, discipline, and spiritual reflection?

10. Does prayer help me remain faithful to Jesus Christ and prepare for His glorious return?

Suggested Prayer

Lord my God,

I come before You with gratitude, reverence, and humility.

You are my Creator, my heavenly Father, and the source of every good gift.

Thank You for loving me and inviting me to approach Your throne of grace through Jesus Christ.

I acknowledge that I cannot live the Christian life through my own strength.

I need Your wisdom, Your forgiveness, and the transforming power of Your Holy Spirit.

Teach me to pray with sincerity and faith.

Help me seek Your presence not only when I face difficulties but also in moments of joy, peace, and thanksgiving.

Forgive my sins and cleanse my heart from pride, selfishness, and unbelief.

Give me the courage to abandon what separates me from You.

When I do not understand Your answers, help me trust Your wisdom.

When I must wait, teach me patience.

When I suffer, strengthen my faith.

When I am tempted, help me remember Your promises and seek Your power.

Teach me to pray for others with genuine compassion.

Bless my family, my church, and those who are suffering or searching for hope.

Guide my decisions through Your Word.

Protect me from confusing my personal desires with Your divine will.

May my prayer life draw me closer to Jesus Christ and make me more loving, humble, obedient, and faithful.

Prepare my heart for the glorious return of my Savior.

Until that day, help me remain steadfast in faith, constant in prayer, and confident in Your grace.

In the name of Jesus Christ, my Savior and Lord.

Amen.

CHAPTER 20 — THE HOLY SPIRIT: WHO IS HE, AND HOW DOES HE TRANSFORM THE BELIEVER'S LIFE?

A Thematic Bible Study — King James Version (KJV)

Opening Scripture

> “But the Comforter, which is the Holy Ghost, whom the Father will send in my name, he shall teach you all things, and bring all things to your remembrance, whatsoever I have said unto you.”

John 14:26 — KJV

Introduction

In the previous chapter, we studied prayer as an essential expression of communion with God.

We discovered that believers are invited to approach their heavenly Father through Jesus Christ, trusting in His grace and seeking His will.

However, the Christian life involves more than human effort, religious knowledge, or outward obedience.

It requires the transforming power of God.

The Holy Scriptures reveal that the Holy Spirit plays an essential role in this transformation.

From the opening pages of Genesis to the final invitation of Revelation, the Spirit of God is presented as active in the accomplishment of the divine purpose.

He is associated with Creation, the inspiration of Scripture, the ministry of Jesus Christ, the proclamation of the Gospel, and the

spiritual renewal of believers.

Jesus promised His disciples that after His departure, the Father would send another Comforter.

This promise was fulfilled in a remarkable way at Pentecost, when the disciples received power to proclaim the Gospel.

Yet important questions remain.

Who is the Holy Spirit? Is He merely an impersonal force, or does Scripture present Him as a divine person? What is His relationship with the Father and the Son? How does He convict humanity of sin? What is the difference between the gifts and the fruit of the Spirit? Can a believer resist His influence?

This chapter examines fifteen questions concerning the identity, ministry, and transforming work of the Holy Spirit.

Our purpose is to understand what Scripture teaches and how believers may live in daily dependence upon God's Spirit.

Question 1 — Who Is the Holy Spirit According to the Bible?

Answer:

The Holy Spirit is presented in Scripture as the Spirit of God, actively involved in Creation, revelation, redemption, and the spiritual life of believers.

In the Old Testament, the Spirit of God is associated with divine activity and power.

Genesis 1:2 describes the Spirit of God moving upon the face of the waters.

The New Testament presents the Holy Spirit as the Comforter promised by Jesus Christ.

He teaches, guides, bears witness, and works within the lives of believers.

The Holy Spirit is not presented merely as an abstract religious influence.

Scripture attributes to Him actions associated with personal agency, including speaking, teaching, guiding, and interceding.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, the Holy Spirit is the third Person of the Godhead, fully divine and eternally united with the Father and the Son.

His ministry directs humanity toward Jesus Christ and the accomplishment of God's saving purpose.

Bible References:

- Genesis 1:1–2
- Psalm 139:7–10
- John 14:16–17, 26
- John 15:26
- John 16:13–15
- Acts 13:2–4
- Romans 8:26–27

Doctrinal Note:

The biblical terms translated “spirit” may refer to breath, wind, or spirit depending upon context. The doctrine of the Holy Spirit must therefore be established from the complete biblical witness rather than from the meaning of one word alone.

Question 2 — Is the Holy Spirit a Divine Person or Merely an Impersonal Power?

Answer:

The New Testament attributes several personal characteristics and actions to the Holy Spirit.

Jesus taught that the Holy Spirit would guide His disciples into truth.

He also declared that the Spirit would testify concerning Him.

In the Book of Acts, the Holy Spirit speaks and directs missionary activity.

The apostle Paul teaches that the Spirit distributes spiritual gifts according to His will.

Scripture also warns believers against grieving the Holy Spirit.

These descriptions go beyond the ordinary characteristics of an impersonal force.

They present the Spirit as acting intentionally and relationally.

The Bible also associates the Holy Spirit with divine knowledge and authority.

In Seventh-day Adventist theology, these passages support the understanding that the Holy Spirit is a divine Person rather than merely an impersonal manifestation of power.

Bible References:

- John 14:16–17
- John 16:7–15
- Acts 5:3–4
- Acts 13:2
- 1 Corinthians 2:10–11
- 1 Corinthians 12:11
- Ephesians 4:30

Explanatory Note:

The Bible does not present a systematic philosophical definition of personhood. The conclusion concerning the Holy Spirit's personality rests upon the combined testimony of His actions, relationships, and divine attributes.

Question 3 — What Is the Relationship Between the Holy Spirit, the Father, and Jesus Christ?

Answer:

The New Testament frequently mentions the Father, the Son, and the Holy Spirit together.

At the baptism of Jesus, the Son was baptized, the Spirit descended, and the Father's voice was heard from heaven.

After His resurrection, Jesus commanded His disciples to baptize in the name of the Father, the Son, and the Holy Ghost.

The apostolic writings also associate the three in the experience of Christian salvation and fellowship.

These passages distinguish the Father, the Son, and the Holy Spirit while presenting them as united in divine purpose.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, there is one God: Father, Son, and Holy Spirit, a unity of three coeternal Persons.

This understanding does not imply the existence of three independent gods.

It affirms the unity of the Godhead and the full divinity of the Father, Son, and Holy Spirit.

The Spirit's ministry is inseparable from the saving work of Jesus Christ and the love of the Father.

Bible References:

- Matthew 3:16–17
- Matthew 28:19
- John 14:16–17
- John 15:26
- 1 Corinthians 12:4–6
- 2 Corinthians 13:14
- Ephesians 4:4–6

Doctrinal Note:

The word Trinity is not itself found in the biblical text. Seventh-day Adventist theology uses this term to summarize its understanding of the combined biblical testimony concerning the Father, Son, and Holy Spirit.

Question 4 — Was the Holy Spirit Active Before the Coming of Jesus Christ?

Answer:

Yes.

The Holy Spirit was active long before the earthly ministry of Jesus Christ.

Genesis describes the Spirit of God in connection with Creation.

The Old Testament also records the Spirit empowering individuals for particular responsibilities.

Bezalel received divine wisdom and skill for the construction of the sanctuary.

The Spirit empowered judges and leaders in Israel.

The prophets spoke as they were moved by the Spirit of God.

David prayed that God would not take His Holy Spirit from him.

These accounts demonstrate that the Holy Spirit's work did not begin at Pentecost.

However, the New Testament presents Pentecost as a distinctive stage in the fulfillment of God's redemptive plan.

The Spirit who had been active throughout biblical history was poured out upon the Christian community in fulfillment of Christ's promise.

Bible References:

- Genesis 1:2
- Exodus 31:1–5

- Numbers 11:24–29
- Judges 6:34
- Psalm 51:10–12
- Isaiah 61:1
- 2 Peter 1:20–21

Historical and Doctrinal Note:

Pentecost marks an important new-covenant manifestation of the Spirit's ministry. It should not be interpreted as the first moment at which the Holy Spirit existed or acted.

Question 5 — What Did Jesus Christ Teach About the Coming of the Comforter?

Answer:

Before His crucifixion, Jesus promised His disciples that the Father would send another Comforter.

The Gospel of John records this promise in the context of Jesus' farewell instructions.

The Comforter would remain with the disciples and assist them after Jesus' departure.

He would teach them, remind them of Christ's words, and bear witness concerning Jesus.

He would also guide them into truth and glorify Christ.

Jesus taught that His departure would be followed by the coming of the Comforter in a new and significant way.

This promise assured the disciples that they would not be abandoned.

The Holy Spirit would continue God's work in their lives and empower them to fulfill their mission.

The promise also reveals that the Spirit's ministry is centered upon Jesus Christ rather than upon drawing attention to Himself.

Bible References:

- John 14:15–18
- John 14:25–27
- John 15:26–27
- John 16:5–15
- Acts 1:4–8

Linguistic Note:

The Greek word paraklētos, translated “Comforter” in the KJV, may convey the idea of a helper, advocate, or one called alongside another. Its meaning should be understood within Jesus' teaching in John 14–16.

Question 6 — What Happened at Pentecost, and Why Was It Important?

Answer:

After the resurrection and ascension of Jesus Christ, His disciples gathered in Jerusalem in obedience to His instructions.

On the day of Pentecost, the Holy Spirit came upon them in a remarkable manifestation.

Acts 2 describes a sound resembling a rushing mighty wind and appearances resembling divided tongues of fire.

The disciples were filled with the Holy Ghost and began speaking in other tongues as the Spirit enabled them.

People from different regions heard the message proclaimed in their own languages.

Peter explained the event in connection with the prophecy of Joel concerning the outpouring of God's Spirit.

He then proclaimed Jesus Christ as the crucified and risen Lord.

Many listeners responded with repentance and baptism.

Pentecost demonstrated that the proclamation of the Gospel would advance through the power of the Holy Spirit.

It also marked a decisive moment in the public mission of the Christian Church.

Bible References:

- Joel 2:28–32
- Luke 24:46–49
- Acts 1:4–8
- Acts 2:1–41
- Acts 4:29–31

Explanatory Note:

Pentecost was an established Jewish festival before the events recorded in Acts 2. The Christian significance of that day arises from the fulfillment of Christ's promise and the outpouring of the Holy Spirit.

Question 7 — How Does the Holy Spirit Convict People of Sin and Lead Them to Jesus Christ?

Answer:

Jesus taught that the Holy Spirit would convict the world concerning sin, righteousness, and judgment.

This ministry helps human beings recognize their need for salvation.

The Spirit works through the truth of God's Word to reveal sin and direct people toward Jesus Christ.

Conviction of sin is not intended merely to produce fear or despair.

Its purpose includes awakening the conscience and leading the sinner toward repentance and faith.

The Book of Acts describes listeners being deeply affected by Peter's proclamation of the Gospel.

They asked what they should do.

Peter called them to repent and be baptized in the name of Jesus Christ.

The Holy Spirit therefore plays an essential role in the process through which individuals recognize their spiritual condition and respond to God's invitation.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, genuine conviction must be distinguished from manipulation, emotional pressure, or merely external religious conformity.

Bible References:

- John 16:7–11
- Acts 2:36–41
- Acts 7:51
- Romans 2:4
- Romans 8:5–9
- 1 Corinthians 2:12–14
- Titus 3:3–7

Doctrinal Note:

The Holy Spirit's convicting work does not eliminate human responsibility. Scripture repeatedly calls individuals to respond through repentance, faith, and obedience.

Question 8 — What Does It Mean to Be Born of the Holy Spirit?

Answer:

Jesus taught Nicodemus that a person must be born again to enter the kingdom of God.

He explained the necessity of being born of water and of the Spirit.

This new birth is not a second physical birth.

It is a spiritual transformation accomplished through God's power.

The Holy Spirit renews the inner life and begins a process of transformation.

The believer receives a new orientation toward God, righteousness, and obedience.

The apostle Paul describes salvation in connection with the washing of regeneration and renewing of the Holy Ghost.

The new birth is therefore not merely a change in religious affiliation.

Nor is it simply an emotional experience.

It involves a genuine work of divine grace that produces a transformed relationship with God.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, this experience is closely connected with conversion, faith, repentance, and the continuing process of sanctification.

Bible References:

- John 3:1–8
- Ezekiel 36:25–27
- Romans 8:1–11
- 2 Corinthians 5:17
- Titus 3:4–7
- 1 Peter 1:22–23

Explanatory Note:

The new birth is attributed to God's transforming work. Baptism is an important outward expression of Christian commitment, but the physical ceremony must not be confused with an automatic guarantee of inward regeneration.

Question 9 — What Is the Difference Between the Fruit of the Spirit and the Gifts of the Spirit?

Answer:

The New Testament distinguishes between the fruit of the Spirit and spiritual gifts.

The fruit of the Spirit describes the character produced in a life increasingly directed by God's Spirit.

Paul identifies love, joy, peace, longsuffering, gentleness, goodness, faith, meekness, and temperance.

These qualities reflect the moral transformation expected in Christian life.

Spiritual gifts, by contrast, are abilities or ministries distributed by the Holy Spirit for the benefit of the Church.

They include various forms of teaching, service, leadership, encouragement, discernment, and other ministries.

The fruit of the Spirit concerns Christian character.

The gifts of the Spirit concern the diverse ways believers may serve.

A person may possess a visible religious ability without demonstrating mature Christian character.

For this reason, spiritual gifts should never be treated as proof of personal superiority.

The exercise of every gift must be governed by love.

Bible References:

- Romans 12:3–8
- 1 Corinthians 12:4–11
- 1 Corinthians 12:27–31
- 1 Corinthians 13:1–13
- Galatians 5:16–26

- Ephesians 4:11–16
- 1 Peter 4:10–11

Doctrinal Note:

The fruit of the Spirit and spiritual gifts are complementary but distinct. Christian maturity is not measured solely by extraordinary manifestations or public religious responsibilities.

Question 10 — Does Every Believer Receive the Same Spiritual Gifts?

Answer:

No.

The apostle Paul teaches that the Holy Spirit distributes different gifts among believers.

The Church is compared to a human body composed of many members.

Each member has a particular function, yet all belong to the same body.

This illustration demonstrates that diversity of service is consistent with spiritual unity.

Not every believer is called to the same ministry.

Some may teach, others encourage, serve, lead, or exercise other gifts.

The Spirit distributes these gifts according to His will.

Their purpose is not personal fame or competition.

They are given for the common good and the building up of the Church.

Believers should therefore recognize their responsibilities, develop their abilities, and serve with humility.

The possession of one gift does not make a person more valuable before God than another believer.

Bible References:

- Romans 12:3–8
- 1 Corinthians 12:4–31
- Ephesians 4:7–16
- 1 Peter 4:10–11

Explanatory Note:

Spiritual gifts should be evaluated according to their biblical purpose, their consistency with Scripture, and the character displayed in their exercise.

Question 11 — Are Speaking in Tongues and Miraculous Gifts Necessary Evidence of Receiving the Holy Spirit?

Answer:

The Book of Acts records occasions when believers spoke in tongues in connection with the reception of the Holy Spirit.

At Pentecost, the disciples proclaimed God's works in languages understood by people from different nations.

Acts 10 also records speaking in tongues among those who received the Holy Spirit in the household of Cornelius.

Acts 19 describes another occasion involving tongues and prophecy.

However, the New Testament does not teach that every believer must speak in tongues.

In 1 Corinthians 12, Paul explains that spiritual gifts are distributed differently among members of the Church.

His rhetorical questions indicate that not all believers possess the same gifts.

Paul also emphasizes the importance of intelligibility, order, and edification in congregational worship.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, speaking in tongues is not a universal requirement or an indispensable proof of salvation.

The presence of the Holy Spirit should also be recognized through faith in Jesus Christ, obedience to God's Word, spiritual growth, and the fruit of the Spirit.

Bible References:

- Acts 2:1–13
- Acts 10:44–48
- Acts 19:1–7
- 1 Corinthians 12:7–11
- 1 Corinthians 12:27–31
- 1 Corinthians 14:1–33
- Galatians 5:22–25

Doctrinal Note:

Christians differ in their interpretations of tongues and miraculous gifts. The Seventh-day Adventist position emphasizes the diversity of spiritual gifts and rejects the claim that every Spirit-filled believer must speak in tongues.

Question 12 — How Does the Holy Spirit Help Christians Understand the Bible?

Answer:

The Holy Scriptures teach that the prophets spoke as they were moved by the Holy Ghost.

The Spirit therefore played an essential role in the communication of God's revelation.

Jesus also promised that the Holy Spirit would teach His disciples and bring His words to their remembrance.

The apostle Paul explains that spiritual truths require spiritual discernment.

The Spirit helps believers understand, receive, and apply God's Word.

However, spiritual illumination does not eliminate the need for careful study.

The Bible should be interpreted with attention to language, context, literary form, and the relationship between passages.

Personal impressions must not be treated as possessing greater authority than Scripture.

The Holy Spirit does not authorize contradictory interpretations merely because individuals claim divine guidance.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, the Spirit who inspired Scripture also guides believers toward a faithful understanding of its message.

Bible References:

- Psalm 119:18
- John 14:26
- John 16:13–15
- Acts 17:10–12
- 1 Corinthians 2:9–14
- 2 Timothy 3:14–17
- 2 Peter 1:19–21

Explanatory Note:

The promise of the Spirit's guidance must be considered alongside the biblical call to test teachings, examine Scripture, and exercise discernment.

Question 13 — Can Believers Resist, Grieve, or Quench the Holy Spirit?

Answer:

Yes.

Scripture warns that human beings may resist the work of the Holy Spirit.

Stephen accused his hearers of resisting the Holy Ghost.

Paul warned believers not to grieve the Holy Spirit of God.

He also instructed Christians not to quench the Spirit.

These warnings demonstrate the seriousness of rejecting divine guidance.

Resistance may occur when individuals knowingly reject truth, persist in wrongdoing, or refuse the Spirit's convicting work.

Grieving the Spirit is also connected with conduct that contradicts Christian character.

However, believers should not interpret every spiritual struggle as evidence that God has abandoned them.

The Bible encourages repentance, confession, and renewed dependence upon divine grace.

The appropriate response to the Spirit's guidance is humility, faith, obedience, and a willingness to be transformed.

Bible References:

- Isaiah 63:10
- Acts 7:51
- Ephesians 4:25–32
- 1 Thessalonians 5:19–22
- Hebrews 3:7–15
- 1 John 1:8–9

Doctrinal Note:

The warnings concerning resistance to the Spirit should encourage sincere repentance rather than despair. The distinction between spiritual conviction and persistent rejection is important for understanding the Christian experience.

Question 14 — What Is the Sin Against the Holy Spirit?

Answer:

Jesus warned about blasphemy against the Holy Ghost.

The Gospel accounts place this warning in the context of religious leaders attributing His Spirit-empowered works to an evil source.

The warning therefore concerns a serious rejection and misrepresentation of God's work.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, the unpardonable sin is associated with persistent and deliberate resistance to the Holy Spirit's convicting influence.

The danger lies in continually rejecting the divine call to repentance until the heart becomes hardened.

This does not mean that God's mercy is insufficient to forgive a particular category of ordinary sins.

Rather, forgiveness is rejected when a person persistently refuses repentance and the work of the Spirit.

The biblical warning should not be used to terrify those who sincerely desire reconciliation with God.

A person who recognizes sin, seeks forgiveness, and desires to return to Christ should be encouraged by the promises of divine mercy.

Bible References:

- Matthew 12:22–32
- Mark 3:22–30

- Luke 12:10
- Acts 7:51
- Hebrews 3:7–15
- 1 John 1:8–9

Explanatory Note:

The immediate Gospel context concerns the attribution of Jesus' works to demonic power. The broader application to persistent resistance against the Spirit is a theological interpretation that should remain connected to this context.

Question 15 — How Can Christians Be Filled With the Holy Spirit and Remain Faithful Until Christ's Return?

Answer:

The New Testament encourages believers to live under the direction of the Holy Spirit.

Paul instructs Christians to be filled with the Spirit.

He also calls them to walk in the Spirit rather than fulfill the desires of the flesh.

A Spirit-directed life involves faith in Jesus Christ, prayer, study of Scripture, repentance, obedience, and love toward others.

The Holy Spirit develops Christian character and strengthens believers for service.

He also helps them remain faithful amid temptation and suffering.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, the Spirit's work is especially important as believers prepare for the return of Jesus Christ.

The prophetic Scriptures describe God's people as called to faithfulness, perseverance, and genuine worship.

The Holy Spirit prepares believers by directing them toward Christ, strengthening their confidence in God's promises, and producing the

character of Jesus in their lives.

However, being filled with the Spirit must not be confused with achieving personal perfection through human effort.

Christian growth remains dependent upon God's grace.

The believer's responsibility is to respond faithfully to the Spirit's guidance and remain in communion with Jesus Christ.

Bible References:

- Luke 11:9–13
- Acts 1:8
- Romans 8:1–17
- Galatians 5:16–26
- Ephesians 5:15–21
- Philippians 2:12–13
- Revelation 14:12
- Revelation 22:17

Doctrinal Note:

Seventh-day Adventist theology connects the latter-day proclamation of the Gospel with the work of the Holy Spirit. Detailed prophetic interpretations concerning the latter rain and the final events will be examined in the chapters devoted to biblical prophecy.

Chapter Summary

The Holy Spirit occupies an essential place in the biblical revelation of God's work.

He is associated with Creation, inspiration, redemption, spiritual renewal, and the mission of the Church.

Jesus Christ promised the Comforter to His disciples, and the Book of Acts records the remarkable fulfillment of that promise at Pentecost.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, the Holy Spirit is the third Person of the Godhead, fully divine and actively involved in the

salvation and transformation of believers.

Our study enables us to retain the following teachings:

1. The Holy Spirit is presented throughout Scripture as active in God's creative and redemptive work.

2. The Bible attributes personal actions and characteristics to the Holy Spirit.

3. The Father, Son, and Holy Spirit are distinguished and united in the biblical revelation of God.

4. The Holy Spirit was active before the earthly ministry of Jesus Christ.

5. Jesus promised the Comforter to guide and strengthen His disciples.

6. Pentecost marked a decisive outpouring of the Holy Spirit for the proclamation of the Gospel.

7. The Holy Spirit convicts humanity of sin and directs sinners toward Jesus Christ.

8. The new birth involves the transforming work of the Holy Spirit.

9. The fruit of the Spirit concerns Christian character, while spiritual gifts equip believers for service.

10. Spiritual gifts are distributed differently among believers for the common good.

11. Speaking in tongues is not presented as a universal requirement for receiving the Holy Spirit.

12. The Holy Spirit guides believers in understanding and applying the Holy Scriptures.

13. Human beings may resist, grieve, or quench the Spirit's influence.

14. The biblical warning concerning blasphemy against the Holy Spirit must be understood in its Gospel context.

15. The Holy Spirit strengthens believers for faithful Christian living and preparation for Christ's return.

Doctrinal Conclusion

The Holy Spirit is essential to the Christian understanding of God and salvation.

The Holy Scriptures present Him as active in Creation, revelation, redemption, and the spiritual transformation of humanity.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, the Holy Spirit is fully divine and eternally united with the Father and the Son.

His ministry may be understood through five principal dimensions.

The Spirit of Creation and Revelation

The Holy Spirit is associated with God's creative activity and the inspiration of the prophetic Scriptures.

The Comforter Promised by Jesus Christ

He teaches, guides, strengthens, and bears witness concerning the Savior.

The Agent of Spiritual Renewal

He convicts sinners, leads them toward repentance, and accomplishes the inward work of regeneration and sanctification.

The Giver of Spiritual Gifts

He equips believers for service and the building up of the Christian Church.

The Source of Spiritual Strength and Faithfulness

He develops Christlike character and prepares believers to remain faithful amid the challenges of Christian life.

The work of the Holy Spirit must never be separated from Jesus Christ.

His ministry directs attention toward the Savior and the fulfillment of God's redemptive purpose.

Likewise, spiritual gifts and extraordinary religious experiences must not replace faith, love, obedience, or the authority of Scripture.

The Essential Message:

The Holy Spirit is not merely an impersonal power. In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, He is the divine Comforter promised by Jesus Christ, active in Creation, revelation, salvation, and spiritual renewal. He convicts humanity of sin, guides believers into truth, distributes gifts for service, and develops the character of Christ in those who respond to His influence.

Personal Reflection Questions

1. What does the Bible reveal about the identity and divine nature of the Holy Spirit?

2. How do the teachings of Jesus help me understand the ministry of the Comforter?

3. Why was the outpouring of the Holy Spirit at Pentecost important for the Christian Church?

4. How does the Holy Spirit lead sinners toward repentance and faith in Jesus Christ?

5. Have I understood the difference between the new birth and an outward religious ceremony?

6. What is the difference between the fruit of the Spirit and spiritual gifts?

7. Am I using my abilities to serve others and glorify God rather than seek personal recognition?

8. How can I avoid resisting or grieving the Holy Spirit?

9. Do I test spiritual teachings and impressions according to the Holy Scriptures?

10. Am I willing to allow the Holy Spirit to transform my character and prepare me for the return of Jesus Christ?

Suggested Prayer

Lord my God,

I come before You with reverence, gratitude, and humility.

You are the Creator of heaven and earth, the source of life, truth, and salvation.

I thank You for sending Jesus Christ to reveal Your love and accomplish the work of redemption.

I also thank You for the promise and ministry of the Holy Spirit.

Without Your grace, I cannot overcome sin or live a life pleasing to You.

I need the transforming power of Your Spirit.

Open my understanding to the truths revealed in Your Holy Word.

Help me recognize my sins and respond sincerely to Your call to repentance.

Renew my thoughts, my desires, and my character.

Teach me to walk in the Spirit rather than follow the selfish inclinations of my heart.

Develop in me love, joy, peace, patience, kindness, goodness, faithfulness, gentleness, and self-control.

Give me wisdom to recognize the gifts You have entrusted to me.

Help me use them with humility for the benefit of others and the advancement of Your work.

Protect me from spiritual pride, deception, and the desire for human recognition.

When I am tempted, strengthen me.

When I fall, lead me back to repentance.

When I am discouraged, remind me of Your promises.

May the Holy Spirit guide me into a deeper relationship with Jesus Christ.

Prepare me to remain faithful to Your Word and steadfast in the hope of His glorious return.

Until that day, help me live through faith, love, obedience, and complete dependence upon Your grace.

In the name of Jesus Christ, my Savior and Lord.

Amen.

CHAPTER 21 — THE CHURCH: WHAT IS GOD'S TRUE CHURCH, AND WHAT IS ITS MISSION?

A Thematic Bible Study — King James Version (KJV)

Opening Scripture

> “Now ye are the body of Christ, and members in particular.”

1 Corinthians 12:27 — KJV

Introduction

In the preceding chapters, we examined prayer and the ministry of the Holy Spirit.

We discovered that Christian life depends upon communion with God and the transforming power of His Spirit.

However, Christianity is not presented in Scripture as an exclusively individual experience.

God calls believers into a community united by faith in Jesus Christ.

The New Testament identifies this community as the Church.

Jesus Christ declared that He would build His Church, and the gates of hell would not prevail against it.

After His resurrection, His disciples proclaimed the Gospel, baptized believers, and established Christian communities.

These communities gathered for worship, prayer, instruction, fellowship, and service.

Yet the subject of the Church raises important questions.

What is the Church according to Scripture? Who established it? Is the Church primarily a building, an institution, or a community of

believers? What is its relationship to Jesus Christ? Why are there so many Christian denominations? How can believers distinguish biblical truth from religious tradition?

The Bible also presents the Church as having a mission.

It is called to proclaim the Gospel, demonstrate God's love, preserve the apostolic teaching, and prepare humanity for the return of Jesus Christ.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, the Church has an important role in the proclamation of the everlasting Gospel and the messages of Revelation 14.

However, the biblical teaching concerning the Church must be examined carefully before considering its prophetic identity.

This chapter examines fifteen questions concerning the origin, nature, organization, unity, and mission of the Christian Church.

Our objective is to understand the Church according to Scripture and recognize the responsibilities of those who belong to Jesus Christ.

Question 1 — What Is the Church According to the Holy Scriptures?

Answer:

The Church is the community of people called by God to belong to Jesus Christ and live in fellowship with Him and one another.

The New Testament frequently uses the Greek word ekklēsia to describe an assembly or congregation.

In Christian usage, the term refers to believers gathered in relationship with Jesus Christ.

The Church is therefore not fundamentally a physical building.

Although Christians may meet in buildings dedicated to worship, the biblical Church consists of people rather than walls or religious structures.

The apostle Paul describes believers as the body of Christ.

This image emphasizes their spiritual relationship with Jesus and their mutual dependence upon one another.

The Church is also described as God's household and a spiritual temple.

These expressions demonstrate that Christian community is founded upon faith in Christ and the work of the Holy Spirit.

Bible References:

- Matthew 16:18
- Acts 2:41–47
- Romans 12:4–5
- 1 Corinthians 12:12–27
- Ephesians 2:19–22
- 1 Peter 2:4–10

Linguistic Note:

The Greek word ekklēsia can refer to an assembly in a general sense. Its theological significance in the New Testament comes from the identity of the community gathered around Jesus Christ, not merely from the word's etymology.

Question 2 — Who Established the Christian Church?

Answer:

Jesus Christ is the foundation and supreme authority of the Christian Church.

During His earthly ministry, He called disciples and prepared them to continue His work.

He declared that He would build His Church.

After His resurrection, He commissioned His followers to make disciples of all nations.

The Book of Acts records the development of the Christian community following the outpouring of the Holy Spirit at Pentecost.

The apostles preached Jesus Christ, taught His commandments, and established communities of believers.

However, the Church did not originate merely through human organization.

Its existence is rooted in God's redemptive purpose and the saving work of Jesus Christ.

The apostles served as foundational witnesses to Christ's resurrection and teachings.

The Church belongs to Christ because He is its Savior, Lord, and Head.

Bible References:

- Matthew 16:13–18
- Matthew 28:18–20
- Acts 1:6–8
- Acts 2:36–47
- 1 Corinthians 3:10–11
- Ephesians 2:19–22
- Colossians 1:18

Doctrinal Note:

Christians interpret Matthew 16:18 differently concerning Peter and the rock. Seventh-day Adventist theology emphasizes Jesus Christ as the ultimate foundation of the Church while recognizing the foundational apostolic witness.

Question 3 — Why Is Jesus Christ Called the Head of the Church?

Answer:

The New Testament identifies Jesus Christ as the Head of the Church.

This expression signifies His supreme authority, leadership, and relationship with believers.

Just as the human body depends upon its head, the Church depends upon Christ for spiritual life and direction.

The apostle Paul teaches that Christ is the Head of the body, the Church.

He also explains that Christ loved the Church and gave Himself for it.

The Church must therefore remain subject to the teachings and authority of Jesus Christ.

Human leaders may exercise responsibilities within the Christian community, but their authority is subordinate to Christ.

No human institution or religious office possesses the right to replace the Savior's supreme authority.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, Jesus Christ is the only ultimate Head of the universal Church.

Bible References:

- Matthew 28:18
- Ephesians 1:20–23
- Ephesians 4:11–16
- Ephesians 5:23–27
- Colossians 1:15–18
- Colossians 2:18–19

Explanatory Note:

The biblical teaching concerning Christ's headship does not eliminate legitimate church leadership. Rather, it establishes the principle that every human responsibility must remain accountable to Jesus Christ and His Word.

Question 4 — What Is the Difference Between the Universal Church and a Local Congregation?

Answer:

The New Testament uses the term Church in more than one context.

Sometimes it refers to the wider community of believers belonging to Jesus Christ.

At other times, it refers to a particular congregation gathered in a specific location.

Paul addressed churches in cities such as Corinth and Thessalonica.

He also referred to believers meeting in private homes.

These examples demonstrate that the Christian Church existed through identifiable local communities.

However, the spiritual unity of believers extends beyond one city, congregation, or geographical region.

The universal Church consists of those who truly belong to Jesus Christ.

A local congregation provides a setting for worship, instruction, fellowship, service, and mutual encouragement.

The two dimensions should not be separated.

Believers are called to participate in Christian community while recognizing that Christ's people are not confined to one physical gathering place.

Bible References:

- Acts 8:1
- Acts 11:22–26
- Romans 16:3–5
- 1 Corinthians 1:1–2
- 1 Corinthians 12:12–27
- Ephesians 4:4–6
- Colossians 4:15–16

Doctrinal Note:

Seventh-day Adventist theology distinguishes the universal Church of believers from the visible denominational organization. This distinction becomes especially important when examining the biblical concept of the remnant.

Question 5 — What Are the Essential Characteristics of a Biblical Christian Church?

Answer:

The New Testament identifies several characteristics that should distinguish a community of believers.

The Church is called to remain faithful to the teaching of Jesus Christ and His apostles.

It should proclaim the Gospel of salvation through grace and faith.

It should practice baptism, prayer, fellowship, and worship.

The Church must also demonstrate love, unity, holiness, compassion, and service.

Its members are called to care for one another and assist those in need.

The Holy Scriptures serve as the authoritative foundation for its teachings.

The Church should also exercise spiritual discernment and reject doctrines that contradict the Gospel.

However, the presence of sincere believers does not imply that every member or congregation is spiritually perfect.

The New Testament itself records serious problems within early Christian communities.

The biblical ideal is therefore a Church continually called to repentance, reform, faithfulness, and dependence upon Jesus Christ.

Bible References:

- Acts 2:42–47
- John 13:34–35
- John 17:20–23
- Galatians 1:6–9
- Ephesians 4:1–16
- 2 Timothy 3:14–17
- James 1:26–27
- Revelation 2–3

Explanatory Note:

The characteristics of a biblical Church should be evaluated through the complete teaching of Scripture. No single outward practice, considered in isolation, establishes the spiritual condition of an entire community.

Question 6 — Why Does the Church Need Spiritual Leadership and Organization?

Answer:

The New Testament demonstrates that Christian communities developed forms of leadership and organization.

The apostles appointed individuals to assist with practical responsibilities.

Elders were established in local congregations.

Paul instructed Timothy and Titus concerning the qualifications of church leaders.

Spiritual leadership was intended to promote sound teaching, unity, pastoral care, and faithful service.

The purpose of organization was not to create a religious hierarchy detached from the authority of Christ.

Rather, organization helped the Church fulfill its mission and care for its members.

Biblical leaders were called to demonstrate humility, integrity, self-control, and spiritual maturity.

Jesus warned His disciples against imitating oppressive forms of worldly authority.

Christian leadership must therefore be understood as service rather than domination.

Bible References:

- Matthew 20:25–28
- Acts 6:1–7
- Acts 14:21–23
- Acts 15:1–29
- 1 Timothy 3:1–13
- Titus 1:5–9
- 1 Peter 5:1–4

Doctrinal Note:

The New Testament provides principles of leadership and accountability, but Christians differ concerning the precise organizational structure these principles require. Seventh-day Adventist church organization seeks to apply them through representative governance and shared responsibility.

Question 7 — What Responsibilities Do Church Members Have Toward One Another?

Answer:

The Church is described as one body composed of many members.

Each believer has responsibilities toward the others.

Christians are called to love, encourage, support, and pray for one another.

They should also share their resources with those experiencing genuine need.

The New Testament emphasizes humility and mutual respect.

Believers are instructed to bear one another's burdens.

They are also called to exercise patience and forgiveness.

When disagreements arise, Christians should seek reconciliation rather than promote unnecessary division.

The exercise of spiritual gifts should contribute to the common good.

Church membership is therefore not merely a formal association with a religious institution.

It involves participation in a community where believers seek to reflect the character of Jesus Christ.

Bible References:

- John 13:34–35
- Romans 12:9–18
- 1 Corinthians 12:12–27
- Galatians 6:1–2
- Ephesians 4:25–32
- Hebrews 10:23–25
- James 2:14–17
- 1 Peter 4:8–11

Practical Note:

Mutual care includes spiritual encouragement and practical assistance. It should never be used to justify coercion, manipulation, or the concealment of harmful behavior.

Question 8 — What Is the Purpose of Worship and Fellowship in the Church?

Answer:

Christian worship is an expression of reverence, gratitude, faith, and devotion toward God.

The New Testament describes believers gathering for prayer, instruction, fellowship, and the breaking of bread.

These activities strengthened the spiritual life of the early Church.

Congregational worship provides opportunities to study Scripture, praise God, encourage one another, and participate in collective prayer.

Fellowship also helps believers develop relationships characterized by love and mutual responsibility.

However, genuine worship must extend beyond religious meetings.

Jesus taught that true worshippers worship the Father in spirit and in truth.

The apostle Paul encouraged believers to present their lives as a living sacrifice to God.

Christian worship therefore involves both gathered devotion and daily faithfulness.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, the seventh-day Sabbath provides a particularly important setting for communal worship and spiritual fellowship.

Bible References:

- John 4:21–24
- Acts 2:42–47
- Romans 12:1–2
- 1 Corinthians 14:26–33
- Colossians 3:16–17
- Hebrews 10:23–25
- Revelation 14:6–7

Doctrinal Note:

The Sabbath's relationship to worship has been examined in Chapter 17. This chapter focuses on the broader biblical purpose of Christian fellowship and congregational life.

Question 9 — How Should the Church Maintain Doctrinal Faithfulness?

Answer:

The Church is called to preserve and proclaim the truth revealed in God's Word.

The apostles repeatedly warned believers against false teaching.

Paul encouraged Timothy to continue in the Scriptures and to teach sound doctrine.

The Bereans were commended for examining the Scriptures to evaluate the apostolic message.

These examples demonstrate the importance of biblical investigation.

Doctrinal faithfulness requires careful attention to context, responsible interpretation, and willingness to correct error.

Religious tradition may preserve valuable historical practices, but it must not be treated as possessing authority above the Holy Scriptures.

The Church should also distinguish essential biblical teachings from human customs and speculative interpretations.

Faithfulness to truth must be accompanied by humility and love.

The purpose of doctrinal instruction is not merely to win arguments.

It is to lead people toward a deeper knowledge of God and a more faithful relationship with Jesus Christ.

Bible References:

- Isaiah 8:20
- Matthew 15:3–9
- Acts 17:10–12
- Galatians 1:6–9
- 1 Timothy 4:13–16
- 2 Timothy 3:14–17
- 2 Timothy 4:1–5
- 1 John 4:1

Explanatory Note:

Appealing to biblical authority does not eliminate interpretive disagreement. Responsible study requires attention to literary context, historical setting, language, and the broader witness of Scripture.

Question 10 — Why Are There So Many Christian Denominations?

Answer:

The existence of many Christian denominations reflects a complex history involving theology, culture, geography, institutional development, and religious reform.

The New Testament itself records disagreements among early Christians.

Some disputes concerned the relationship between Jewish practices and Gentile believers.

Others involved leadership, conduct, or false teaching.

As Christianity spread, different traditions and organizational structures developed.

Later historical divisions contributed to the formation of distinct Christian communions.

The Protestant Reformation and subsequent movements of renewal also influenced the development of modern denominations.

Not every difference among Christians concerns the same level of doctrinal importance.

Some disagreements involve central theological convictions, while others concern worship practices, governance, or tradition.

The Bible calls believers to pursue unity in truth and love.

However, genuine Christian unity should not require abandoning convictions sincerely grounded in Scripture.

Bible References:

- John 17:20–23
- Acts 15:1–29
- Romans 14:1–13
- 1 Corinthians 1:10–13
- 1 Corinthians 3:1–11
- Ephesians 4:1–6
- Philippians 2:1–5

Historical Note:

The history of Christian denominations cannot be explained by one event or one cause. A detailed historical examination requires distinguishing the early Church, later ecclesiastical developments, the Reformation, and modern Christian movements.

Question 11 — What Does the Bible Teach About Unity in the Church?

Answer:

Jesus prayed that His followers would be one.

He connected their unity with the witness they would bear before the world.

The apostle Paul likewise urged Christians to preserve the unity of the Spirit in the bond of peace.

Biblical unity is founded upon a shared relationship with Jesus Christ.

It includes faith, love, humility, mutual respect, and commitment to truth.

However, unity does not require every believer to possess identical abilities, responsibilities, or personal experiences.

The New Testament compares the Church to a body with many different members.

Unity therefore exists alongside diversity.

Christians are called to avoid pride, unnecessary division, and hostility.

At the same time, the New Testament warns against teachings that undermine the Gospel.

The Church must seek unity without treating truth as unimportant.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, authentic Christian unity is produced through the Holy Spirit and grounded in faithfulness to God's Word.

Bible References:

- John 13:34–35
- John 17:20–23
- Romans 12:4–10

- 1 Corinthians 12:12–27
- Ephesians 4:1–16
- Philippians 2:1–5
- Colossians 3:12–15

Doctrinal Note:

Christian unity should not be confused with uniformity or institutional control. Scripture emphasizes unity in Christ, mutual love, and faithfulness to divine truth.

Question 12 — What Is the Biblical Purpose of Church Discipline?

Answer:

The New Testament teaches that Christian communities have responsibilities concerning serious wrongdoing and persistent conduct contrary to the Gospel.

Jesus provided instructions for addressing offenses between believers.

Paul also instructed churches concerning situations requiring correction.

The purpose of biblical discipline is not humiliation or revenge.

It is intended to protect the community, uphold righteousness, and encourage repentance and restoration.

The apostle Paul urged spiritually mature believers to restore a person overtaken in a fault with gentleness.

Discipline should therefore be exercised with humility, fairness, patience, and love.

The Church must also recognize the limits of its authority.

No religious institution has the right to manipulate consciences or excuse abuse.

Serious harmful conduct may require protective measures and appropriate civil accountability.

Biblical discipline must never become a justification for coercion or the concealment of wrongdoing.

Bible References:

- Matthew 18:15–17
- 1 Corinthians 5:1–13
- 2 Corinthians 2:5–11
- Galatians 6:1–2
- 2 Thessalonians 3:14–15
- James 5:19–20

Practical Note:

Restoration is a central biblical objective, but restoration does not automatically remove the need for accountability, protection of vulnerable people, or appropriate consequences for serious misconduct.

Question 13 — What Mission Did Jesus Christ Entrust to His Church?

Answer:

Jesus commissioned His disciples to proclaim the Gospel and make disciples of all nations.

This mission includes teaching, baptism, and instruction in the commandments of Christ.

The Book of Acts records the expansion of the Gospel from Jerusalem to other regions.

The Holy Spirit empowered believers to bear witness concerning Jesus Christ.

The Church's mission therefore includes evangelism, biblical teaching, discipleship, and service.

It also includes demonstrating God's love through compassion, justice, and assistance to those in need.

The Gospel must be communicated faithfully and without coercion.

Christian mission is not intended to glorify a human institution.

Its central purpose is to direct people toward Jesus Christ and the salvation offered through Him.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, this mission includes the proclamation of the everlasting Gospel and the prophetic messages of Revelation 14.

Bible References:

- Matthew 24:14
- Matthew 28:18–20
- Mark 16:15
- Luke 24:46–49
- Acts 1:8
- Acts 4:29–33
- 2 Corinthians 5:17–21
- Revelation 14:6–12

Textual Note:

Mark 16:9–20 is included in the King James Version, but its textual history is disputed. The commission to proclaim the Gospel is independently established in Matthew 28:18–20, Luke 24:46–49, and Acts 1:8.

Question 14 — What Does the Bible Mean by the Remnant of God's People?

Answer:

The concept of a remnant appears throughout the Holy Scriptures.

In the Old Testament, the remnant often refers to those preserved by God's mercy or those who remain faithful amid widespread unfaithfulness and judgment.

The prophets describe God's preservation of a people who continue to trust Him.

The apostle Paul also uses the concept of a remnant in connection with divine grace.

In Revelation 12:17, the dragon is described as making war against the remnant of the woman's seed.

The passage identifies them as those who keep the commandments of God and have the testimony of Jesus Christ.

Revelation 14:12 likewise describes the patience of the saints, their obedience to God's commandments, and their faith in Jesus.

In Seventh-day Adventist prophetic interpretation, these passages are central to understanding the identity and mission of the end-time remnant.

The Adventist Church understands itself as called to proclaim the three angels' messages and invite humanity to worship the Creator.

However, the biblical concept of the remnant should not be reduced to the claim that every member of one denomination is automatically saved or that sincere Christians outside that denomination do not belong to Christ.

God alone knows the hearts of individuals.

Bible References:

- Isaiah 10:20–22
- Zephaniah 3:12–13
- Romans 9:27–29
- Romans 11:1–5
- Revelation 12:17

- Revelation 14:6–12
- Revelation 18:1–4

Doctrinal Note:

The identification of the end-time remnant with the Seventh-day Adventist movement is a specific prophetic interpretation. Revelation 12:17 does not explicitly name a modern denomination. The historical and prophetic arguments supporting this interpretation will be examined in later chapters.

Question 15 — How Should the Church Prepare the World for the Return of Jesus Christ?

Answer:

The New Testament presents the return of Jesus Christ as a central hope of the Christian faith.

The Church is called to proclaim this hope while remaining faithful to the Gospel.

Jesus instructed His disciples to watch and remain prepared.

He also declared that the Gospel of the kingdom would be preached throughout the world.

Christian preparation therefore includes faithful proclamation, spiritual vigilance, and practical obedience.

The Church should encourage believers to grow in faith, holiness, love, and service.

It should also warn against deception while avoiding unsupported speculation about prophetic dates.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, the Church has a special responsibility to proclaim the everlasting Gospel, call humanity to worship the Creator, and announce the messages of Revelation 14.

This mission should be carried out with biblical fidelity, compassion, and respect for freedom of conscience.

The ultimate objective is not the exaltation of a denomination.

It is the preparation of people to meet Jesus Christ.

Bible References:

- Matthew 24:14, 42–44
- Matthew 25:31–46
- Matthew 28:18–20
- 1 Thessalonians 4:13–18
- Titus 2:11–14
- 2 Peter 3:9–14
- Revelation 14:6–12
- Revelation 22:12–20

Doctrinal Note:

The Adventist understanding of the Church's final mission is connected with its interpretation of biblical prophecy. The specific prophetic foundations will be developed in subsequent chapters rather than assumed without examination.

Chapter Summary

The Church occupies an essential place in God's redemptive purpose.

It is the community of believers called to belong to Jesus Christ, grow in faith, and proclaim the Gospel.

The New Testament presents Jesus Christ as the foundation and supreme Head of the Church.

The Holy Spirit equips believers for worship, fellowship, service, and mission.

Our study enables us to retain the following teachings:

1. The Church is fundamentally a community of believers rather than a physical building.

2. Jesus Christ established His Church and remains its supreme foundation.

3. Christ is the Head of the Church, and every human leader remains accountable to Him.

4. The Church exists as both a worldwide community of believers and local congregations.

5. Biblical churches are called to faithfulness in doctrine, worship, love, service, and holiness.

6. Spiritual leadership and organization should promote faithful service and accountability.

7. Church members have responsibilities of love, encouragement, compassion, and mutual care.

8. Christian worship and fellowship strengthen believers in their relationship with God.

9. The Church must evaluate its teachings according to the Holy Scriptures.

10. Christian denominational diversity reflects a complex history of theological and institutional developments.

11. Biblical unity is grounded in Jesus Christ, truth, love, and the work of the Holy Spirit.

12. Church discipline should seek justice, repentance, protection, and restoration.

13. Jesus entrusted His Church with the mission of proclaiming the Gospel and making disciples.

14. The biblical remnant theme is important to Adventist prophetic interpretation, but denominational membership alone does not guarantee salvation.

15. The Church is called to prepare humanity for the return of Jesus Christ through faithful proclamation and Christian living.

Doctrinal Conclusion

The Church is not merely a human institution.

According to Scripture, it is the community of believers united through faith in Jesus Christ and called to participate in God's redemptive mission.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, the biblical teaching concerning the Church includes several essential dimensions.

A Community Founded Upon Jesus Christ

Christ is the foundation, Savior, and supreme Head of the Church.

Its teachings and practices must remain subject to His authority.

A Fellowship United by the Holy Spirit

The Church is composed of believers who are called to demonstrate love, humility, mutual responsibility, and spiritual unity.

A Community Guided by the Holy Scriptures

Biblical truth must remain the foundation of Christian teaching.

Tradition, institutional authority, and personal opinion must be evaluated according to God's Word.

A Community Called to Service

The Church exists not only for worship but also for compassion, instruction, discipleship, and assistance to those in need.

A Community Entrusted With a Prophetic Mission

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, the Church is called to proclaim the everlasting Gospel and the messages of Revelation 14 as part of the preparation for Christ's return.

This prophetic understanding must be presented with humility and supported through careful biblical study.

The spiritual identity of God's people cannot be reduced merely to a denominational name.

The essential question is whether individuals truly belong to Jesus Christ and respond faithfully to the light revealed in His Word.

The Essential Message:

The true Church belongs to Jesus Christ. It is a community of believers called to remain faithful to His Word, live in love and unity, serve humanity, and proclaim the Gospel. In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, the Church also has a prophetic responsibility to announce God's final message of hope and preparation for the return of Jesus Christ.

Personal Reflection Questions

1. Do I understand the Church primarily as a community belonging to Jesus Christ rather than merely a religious institution?

2. What does it mean for Jesus Christ to be the Head of the Church?

3. How can I contribute to the spiritual life and unity of my local congregation?

4. Am I willing to evaluate religious teachings according to the Holy Scriptures?

5. Do my relationships with other believers reflect humility, love, patience, and forgiveness?

6. How can the Church demonstrate God's compassion toward those who are suffering?

7. What responsibilities do Christian leaders have toward the people entrusted to their care?

8. How should believers respond when religious traditions appear to conflict with Scripture?

9. What does the biblical concept of the remnant teach me about faithfulness and humility?

10. Am I participating in the mission of proclaiming Jesus Christ and preparing others for His return?

Suggested Prayer

Lord my God,

I thank You for Your love and for the salvation You offer through Jesus Christ.

Thank You for calling believers into a community of faith, hope, and love.

I recognize that the Church belongs to Jesus Christ and that He alone is its supreme Head.

Help me understand the true meaning of Christian fellowship.

Teach me to love my brothers and sisters with sincerity, humility, and patience.

Remove from my heart pride, selfishness, jealousy, and the desire for human recognition.

Give me wisdom to distinguish biblical truth from human tradition.

Help me remain faithful to Your Holy Word.

Bless those who serve in positions of spiritual leadership.

Grant them integrity, humility, discernment, and a genuine spirit of service.

Protect Your Church from deception, division, abuse, and unfaithfulness.

Strengthen those who are discouraged.

Comfort those who suffer.

Restore those who have wandered from the path of faith.

Help me use the gifts and abilities You have entrusted to me for the benefit of others.

May my life contribute to the unity, holiness, and mission of Your people.

Give me courage to proclaim the Gospel with compassion and respect.

Teach me to defend truth without hatred and to remain firm in conviction without pride.

Prepare Your Church for the glorious return of Jesus Christ.

May Your Holy Spirit guide us into deeper faithfulness, genuine love, and complete dependence upon Your grace.

Until the day when Christ returns, help me remain steadfast in faith, active in service, and faithful to Your calling.

In the name of Jesus Christ, my Savior and Lord.

Amen.

CHAPTER 22 — SPIRITUAL GIFTS AND THE GIFT OF PROPHECY: HOW DOES GOD EQUIP AND GUIDE HIS CHURCH?

A Thematic Bible Study — King James Version (KJV)

Opening Scripture

> “But the manifestation of the Spirit is given to every man to profit withal.”

1 Corinthians 12:7 — KJV

Introduction

In the preceding chapter, we examined the nature, organization, and mission of the Christian Church.

We discovered that Jesus Christ is the Head of the Church and that believers are called to proclaim the Gospel, remain faithful to Scripture, and serve one another in love.

However, an important question arises.

How does God equip His people to fulfill this mission?

The New Testament teaches that the Holy Spirit distributes spiritual gifts among believers.

These gifts are not given for personal glory or spiritual competition.

They are intended to strengthen the Church, promote unity, and prepare believers for Christian service.

Among the gifts mentioned in Scripture is the gift of prophecy.

Throughout biblical history, God communicated His messages through prophets.

Moses, Samuel, Isaiah, Jeremiah, Daniel, and many others received divine messages intended to instruct, warn, encourage, or correct God's people.

The New Testament also records prophetic activity within the early Christian Church.

Yet the Bible repeatedly warns against false prophets and deceptive religious claims.

Therefore, the existence of a claimed prophetic gift does not automatically establish divine authority.

Every prophetic claim must be examined according to the Holy Scriptures.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, the gift of prophecy is particularly important because of its relationship to the prophetic identity and mission of the end-time Church.

The Adventist movement recognizes the ministry of Ellen G. White as a manifestation of this gift.

However, this conviction raises essential questions concerning biblical authority, spiritual discernment, and the relationship between prophetic writings and the canonical Scriptures.

This chapter examines fifteen questions concerning spiritual gifts, the biblical gift of prophecy, the tests of a true prophet, and the Adventist understanding of prophetic guidance.

Our objective is to distinguish clearly between what Scripture explicitly teaches and the doctrinal conclusions drawn from its interpretation.

Question 1 — What Are Spiritual Gifts According to the Holy Scriptures?

Answer:

Spiritual gifts are abilities, ministries, or manifestations granted by the Holy Spirit for the benefit of the Christian community.

The New Testament teaches that the Spirit distributes gifts among believers according to His will.

These gifts enable Christians to fulfill different responsibilities within the Church.

They may involve teaching, service, encouragement, leadership, discernment, prophecy, and other forms of ministry.

The apostle Paul compares the Church to a human body composed of many members.

Each member has a distinct function, yet all contribute to the well-being of the body.

Spiritual gifts therefore express both diversity and unity.

They are not intended to establish a hierarchy of personal worth.

Their purpose is to glorify God, strengthen believers, and advance the mission of Jesus Christ.

Bible References:

- Romans 12:3–8
- 1 Corinthians 12:4–11
- 1 Corinthians 12:27–31
- Ephesians 4:7–16
- 1 Peter 4:10–11

Explanatory Note:

The New Testament does not present spiritual gifts as rewards earned through human achievement. They are expressions of divine grace entrusted to believers for service.

Question 2 — Who Distributes Spiritual Gifts, and for What Purpose?

Answer:

The Holy Spirit distributes spiritual gifts among believers.

Paul explains that there are different gifts but the same Spirit.

He also teaches that the Spirit distributes these gifts according to His will.

Their primary purpose is the common good.

Spiritual gifts are intended to strengthen the Church, support its mission, and promote spiritual maturity.

The gifts should never become instruments of pride, manipulation, or competition.

The New Testament emphasizes that believers are stewards of the abilities entrusted to them.

Therefore, the exercise of a spiritual gift involves responsibility and accountability.

A gift must be used in harmony with the character of Jesus Christ and the teachings of Scripture.

Bible References:

- 1 Corinthians 12:4–11
- 1 Corinthians 12:18–27
- Ephesians 4:11–16
- Romans 12:6–8
- 1 Peter 4:10–11

Doctrinal Note:

The distribution of spiritual gifts does not imply that every believer receives the same ministry. The Spirit equips the Church through a diversity of gifts and responsibilities.

Question 3 — What Is the Difference Between Spiritual Gifts and the Fruit of the Spirit?

Answer:

Spiritual gifts and the fruit of the Spirit are related but distinct.

Spiritual gifts concern the different ways believers are equipped for ministry.

The fruit of the Spirit concerns the character produced through the transforming work of the Holy Spirit.

Paul identifies the fruit of the Spirit as love, joy, peace, longsuffering, gentleness, goodness, faith, meekness, and temperance.

These qualities should characterize the Christian life.

A believer may possess an impressive ability without demonstrating spiritual maturity.

For this reason, the apostle Paul places great emphasis upon love.

He teaches that extraordinary gifts lose their spiritual value when exercised without love.

Christian character must therefore govern the use of spiritual gifts.

Bible References:

- 1 Corinthians 12:27–31
- 1 Corinthians 13:1–13
- Galatians 5:16–26
- Ephesians 4:1–3
- Colossians 3:12–17

Explanatory Note:

The possession of a spiritual gift does not automatically demonstrate holiness or guarantee the correctness of every statement made by its recipient.

Question 4 — What Is the Biblical Gift of Prophecy?

Answer:

The gift of prophecy is a manifestation of the Holy Spirit through which God communicates messages intended to instruct, encourage, warn, or guide His people.

In biblical history, prophets sometimes announced future events.

However, prediction was not the only purpose of prophecy.

Prophets also called people to repentance, defended justice, explained God's covenant, and encouraged faithfulness.

The apostle Paul identifies prophecy among the spiritual gifts given to the Church.

He teaches that prophecy should contribute to edification, exhortation, and comfort.

Therefore, biblical prophecy should not be reduced to predicting the future.

Its central purpose is to communicate God's message faithfully and direct people toward His will.

Bible References:

- Numbers 12:6
- Deuteronomy 18:18–22
- Amos 3:7
- Acts 2:16–18
- 1 Corinthians 12:10
- 1 Corinthians 14:1–5

- 2 Peter 1:20–21

Linguistic Note:

The Greek term prophēteia refers to prophecy or prophetic speech. Its biblical meaning includes communication of a message attributed to divine revelation, not merely the prediction of future events.

Question 5 — How Did God Communicate With His Prophets?

Answer:

The Holy Scriptures describe several ways in which God communicated with His prophets.

Some received dreams.

Others experienced visions.

God also communicated through direct speech or other forms of revelation.

Moses occupied a distinctive position in the biblical account because of the unusual clarity of his communication with God.

The prophets were not presented as independent sources of divine authority.

They were called to communicate messages received from God.

However, prophetic revelation occurred through human individuals with particular historical, cultural, and linguistic backgrounds.

The biblical record therefore requires careful interpretation of the form and context of prophetic messages.

Bible References:

- Numbers 12:6–8
- 1 Samuel 3:1–21
- Isaiah 6:1–8
- Jeremiah 1:4–10
- Daniel 7:1–2

- Ezekiel 1:1–3
- Hebrews 1:1–2

Explanatory Note:

Dreams and visions appear in biblical accounts of revelation, but the Bible does not teach that every dream or extraordinary experience comes from God.

Question 6 — Did the Gift of Prophecy Continue in the New Testament Church?

Answer:

Yes.

The New Testament records prophetic activity after the resurrection and ascension of Jesus Christ.

The Book of Acts identifies prophets within the Christian community.

Agabus delivered prophetic messages concerning future events.

The daughters of Philip are also described as prophesying.

The apostle Paul included prophecy among the gifts distributed by the Holy Spirit.

He provided instructions concerning the orderly exercise and evaluation of prophetic messages in congregational worship.

These passages demonstrate that prophecy was not limited to the Old Testament period.

However, the continuation of prophecy within the apostolic Church does not automatically establish the authenticity of every later claim to prophetic authority.

Such claims must be examined according to biblical principles.

Bible References:

- Acts 2:16–18

- Acts 11:27–30
- Acts 13:1–3
- Acts 21:8–11
- 1 Corinthians 12:28–31
- 1 Corinthians 14:29–33
- Ephesians 4:11–13

Doctrinal Note:

Christians differ concerning whether all extraordinary spiritual gifts continue in the same manner throughout Church history. Seventh-day Adventist theology maintains that the Holy Spirit may continue to grant the gift of prophecy according to God's will.

Question 7 — Does the Bible Teach That the Gift of Prophecy Would Cease After the Apostolic Age?

Answer:

The New Testament does not explicitly identify the death of the last apostle as the moment when the gift of prophecy would cease.

Paul teaches that spiritual gifts contribute to the edification and maturity of the Church.

In 1 Corinthians 13, he explains that prophecies will fail and tongues will cease when the partial gives way to the perfect.

Christians interpret the timing and meaning of this passage differently.

Some understand it as indicating the eventual cessation of certain gifts.

Others understand it as referring to the final consummation of God's purposes.

Seventh-day Adventist theology holds that the gift of prophecy may continue beyond the apostolic period.

However, the possibility of continuing prophecy does not eliminate the need for careful examination.

Every claimed manifestation must be tested by Scripture.

Bible References:

- 1 Corinthians 12:27–31
- 1 Corinthians 13:8–13
- 1 Corinthians 14:1
- Ephesians 4:11–16
- 1 Thessalonians 5:19–22

Doctrinal Note:

The continuation of prophetic gifts is a subject of disagreement among Christian traditions. The Adventist position should be presented as a theological interpretation supported by its reading of these passages, not as an undisputed conclusion accepted by all Christians.

Question 8 — How Can We Distinguish a True Prophet From a False Prophet?

Answer:

The Bible repeatedly warns against false prophets.

Jesus declared that false prophets would arise and deceive many.

He instructed His followers to recognize them by their fruits.

The Old Testament also provides criteria for examining prophetic claims.

A message that encourages the worship of other gods must be rejected, even if accompanied by an extraordinary sign.

Deuteronomy 18 also addresses the failure of predictions presented as messages from the Lord.

The New Testament calls believers to test spiritual claims.

These principles indicate that prophetic authenticity must not be determined merely by miracles, emotional experiences, popularity, or personal charisma.

A claimed prophet must be evaluated according to the teachings of Scripture, faithfulness to God, the nature of the message, and the evidence associated with the ministry.

Bible References:

- Deuteronomy 13:1–5
- Deuteronomy 18:20–22
- Isaiah 8:20
- Matthew 7:15–23
- Matthew 24:23–25
- 1 Thessalonians 5:20–22
- 1 John 4:1–3

Explanatory Note:

Biblical tests should be applied carefully. Prophetic literature may contain conditional warnings, symbolic language, or promises whose fulfillment depends upon the response of the people addressed.

Question 9 — Must a True Prophet's Message Agree With the Holy Scriptures?

Answer:

Yes.

The Bible presents God's revealed truth as the standard by which religious claims must be evaluated.

Isaiah calls the people to examine teachings according to the law and the testimony.

The New Testament likewise encourages believers to test spiritual claims.

The Bereans examined the Scriptures to determine whether the apostolic message was consistent with God's Word.

A claimed prophetic message should not contradict the biblical revelation of God's character, the Gospel of Jesus Christ, or the moral principles established in Scripture.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, the canonical Scriptures are the supreme standard for testing prophetic claims.

Later prophetic writings must therefore be evaluated according to the Bible.

They must not replace Scripture or become an independent foundation for Christian doctrine.

Bible References:

- Deuteronomy 13:1–5
- Isaiah 8:20
- Acts 17:10–12
- Galatians 1:6–9
- 2 Timothy 3:14–17
- 2 Peter 1:19–21
- 1 John 4:1

Doctrinal Note:

The authority of Scripture is central to Seventh-day Adventist theology. The Church officially identifies the Bible as the standard by which all teaching and experience must be tested.

Question 10 — Are Miracles and Fulfilled Predictions Sufficient Proof of a True Prophet?

Answer:

No.

The Bible warns that extraordinary signs do not automatically establish the divine origin of a message.

Deuteronomy 13 describes a situation in which a sign or wonder occurs, yet the person presenting it encourages disobedience to God.

Such a message must be rejected.

Jesus also warned that false prophets could perform impressive signs.

Therefore, miracles must not be treated as the sole criterion of prophetic authenticity.

Fulfilled predictions may provide important evidence, but they must be evaluated in their biblical context.

Some prophecies are conditional.

Others employ symbolism or concern events whose fulfillment requires careful historical investigation.

The message, its theological content, and its relationship to God's revealed truth remain essential considerations.

Bible References:

- Deuteronomy 13:1–5
- Deuteronomy 18:20–22
- Jeremiah 18:7–10
- Matthew 7:21–23
- Matthew 24:24
- 2 Thessalonians 2:8–12
- Revelation 13:13–14

Explanatory Note:

A responsible evaluation of prophetic claims should distinguish verifiable historical evidence from later interpretations, unverified anecdotes, and statements taken out of context.

Question 11 — What Is the Relationship Between Prophetic Gifts and the Authority of the Bible?

Answer:

The Bible contains writings recognized by the Christian Church as canonical Scripture.

These writings provide the foundational testimony concerning God's revelation and the saving work of Jesus Christ.

The New Testament also records prophets whose messages were not incorporated into the biblical canon.

For example, Agabus exercised a prophetic ministry, but no canonical book bears his name.

This distinction demonstrates that the existence of a prophetic gift does not necessarily result in the production of a biblical book.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, the Bible remains the supreme and authoritative standard for faith and practice.

The Church recognizes the possibility of prophetic guidance while maintaining that such guidance must be tested by Scripture.

Therefore, the writings of a later religious figure should not be treated as replacing the biblical canon.

The proper relationship between Scripture and later prophetic claims requires careful theological discernment.

Bible References:

- Luke 24:25–27
- Acts 11:27–30
- Acts 21:8–11
- Ephesians 2:19–22
- 2 Timothy 3:14–17
- Hebrews 1:1–2
- 2 Peter 1:19–21

Doctrinal Note:

Seventh-day Adventists affirm the prophetic ministry of Ellen G. White while officially maintaining the Bible as the supreme standard for doctrine. The implications of this relationship should be explained without suggesting that her writings form an additional book of the biblical canon.

Question 12 — What Does Revelation Teach About the Testimony of Jesus and the Spirit of Prophecy?

Answer:

The Book of Revelation contains important references to the testimony of Jesus Christ.

Revelation 12:17 describes the remnant of the woman's seed as those who keep the commandments of God and have the testimony of Jesus Christ.

Revelation 19:10 states:

> “for the testimony of Jesus is the spirit of prophecy.”

Revelation 19:10 — KJV, concluding clause

These passages are central to Seventh-day Adventist interpretation of the prophetic identity of God's end-time people.

Adventist theology understands the testimony of Jesus in connection with the prophetic gift.

However, the meaning of the expression has been discussed among biblical interpreters.

Some emphasize the testimony given by Jesus.

Others emphasize testimony concerning Jesus or the prophetic witness associated with Him.

Revelation 22:8–9 also connects the language of prophetic testimony with the servants of God.

Therefore, the relationship between the testimony of Jesus and the gift of prophecy should be examined through the literary context of Revelation.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, these passages support the expectation that prophetic guidance may be present among God's end-time people.

Bible References:

- Revelation 1:1–3
- Revelation 12:17
- Revelation 14:12
- Revelation 19:10
- Revelation 22:8–9
- 1 Corinthians 12:10
- 1 Corinthians 14:1–5

Doctrinal Note:

Revelation does not explicitly identify Ellen G. White by name. The application of these passages to her ministry is part of Seventh-day Adventist prophetic interpretation and must be distinguished from the wording of the biblical text itself.

Question 13 — Who Was Ellen G. White, and Why Is Her Ministry Important to Seventh-day Adventists?

Answer:

Ellen Gould White (1827–1915) was an American Christian author and religious leader associated with the development of the Seventh-day Adventist movement.

Her ministry emerged within the nineteenth-century Adventist context following the disappointment experienced by Millerite believers in 1844.

She reported receiving visions and dreams that she understood as communications from God.

Over the course of her life, she wrote extensively concerning Christian faith, spiritual growth, education, health, family life, and the mission of the Church.

Her writings became influential in the development of Seventh-day Adventist institutions and religious identity.

Seventh-day Adventists recognize her ministry as a manifestation of the biblical gift of prophecy.

However, this recognition is a denominational conviction rather than a conclusion explicitly stated in Scripture.

Her writings must therefore be evaluated through biblical principles and responsible historical investigation.

The Adventist Church maintains that her ministry should direct believers toward Scripture and Jesus Christ.

Bible References for Evaluating the Claim:

- Joel 2:28–29
- Matthew 7:15–20
- Acts 2:16–18
- 1 Corinthians 12:10
- 1 Thessalonians 5:19–22
- Revelation 12:17
- Revelation 19:10

Historical Note:

The biblical passages listed above establish principles for examining prophetic claims; they do not directly identify Ellen G. White. Historical statements about her life, writings, and reported experiences require independent documentary verification before final publication.

Question 14 — How Should Christians Evaluate the Writings and Claimed Prophetic Ministry of Ellen G. White?

Answer:

A responsible evaluation should begin with the Holy Scriptures.

The Bible instructs believers to test spiritual claims rather than accept or reject them without examination.

This principle applies to every claimed prophetic ministry, including that of Ellen G. White.

The evaluation should consider several questions.

Are the teachings consistent with the biblical Gospel?

Do they direct people toward Jesus Christ?

How do they relate to the authority of Scripture?

Are historical claims and reported predictions accurately represented?

Have statements been examined in their original context?

The evaluation should also distinguish between a writer's own statements, later interpretations by followers, and official denominational teachings.

A quotation should not be judged solely from an isolated sentence when the surrounding context may affect its meaning.

Likewise, claims concerning fulfilled predictions, medical insights, or historical events should be supported by reliable evidence.

Seventh-day Adventists who accept Ellen G. White's prophetic ministry understand her writings as providing spiritual counsel and guidance while maintaining the Bible as the final standard of faith and doctrine.

Other Christians may reach different conclusions.

The appropriate response is careful investigation, biblical discernment, and respect for freedom of conscience.

Bible References:

- Deuteronomy 13:1–5
- Deuteronomy 18:20–22
- Isaiah 8:20
- Matthew 7:15–20
- Acts 17:10–12
- 1 Thessalonians 5:19–22
- 1 John 4:1–3

Methodological Note:

This chapter does not attempt to prove Ellen G. White's prophetic calling merely by citing passages about prophecy. Establishing or challenging that historical claim requires a separate examination of her writings, biography, reported predictions, and documentary evidence.

Question 15 — How Should Believers Respond to Spiritual Gifts and Prophetic Guidance Today?

Answer:

The New Testament encourages believers to recognize the work of the Holy Spirit while exercising discernment.

Paul instructs Christians not to despise prophesyings.

He also commands them to prove all things and hold fast that which is good.

These instructions establish a balance between openness and careful examination.

Believers should not automatically reject every spiritual claim merely because it appears unusual.

Neither should they accept a claim simply because it is accompanied by impressive experiences or strong emotions.

The Holy Scriptures remain the standard for evaluating religious teaching.

Spiritual gifts should contribute to the unity, maturity, and mission of the Church.

Their exercise must be characterized by humility, love, order, and accountability.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, the gift of prophecy should direct believers toward Jesus Christ, encourage faithfulness to Scripture, and strengthen the Church's mission.

However, no claimed spiritual gift should become a substitute for personal Bible study, prayer, responsible judgment, or faith in the saving work of Jesus Christ.

The ultimate purpose of spiritual gifts is to glorify God and prepare believers for faithful Christian service.

Bible References:

- Romans 12:3–8
- 1 Corinthians 12:4–11
- 1 Corinthians 13:1–13
- 1 Corinthians 14:26–33
- Ephesians 4:11–16
- 1 Thessalonians 5:19–22
- 1 John 4:1
- Revelation 22:17

Doctrinal Note:

Christian discernment requires both faith and examination. The command to test spiritual claims protects believers from deception while encouraging them to remain receptive to the genuine work of the Holy Spirit.

Chapter Summary

Spiritual gifts are an important part of the biblical teaching concerning the Church.

They are distributed by the Holy Spirit for the benefit of believers and the accomplishment of God's mission.

The gift of prophecy occupies a distinctive place among these gifts.

Throughout biblical history, God communicated through prophets who instructed, warned, encouraged, and called His people to faithfulness.

However, the Holy Scriptures repeatedly warn against false prophetic claims.

Our study enables us to retain the following teachings:

1. Spiritual gifts are manifestations of divine grace intended for Christian service.

2. The Holy Spirit distributes gifts according to His will for the common good.

3. Spiritual gifts concern ministry, while the fruit of the Spirit concerns Christian character.

4. Biblical prophecy includes instruction, warning, encouragement, and revelation.

5. God communicated with prophets through various means, including dreams and visions.

6. The New Testament records the exercise of prophetic gifts within the early Christian Church.

7. Christians differ concerning the continuation of prophecy after the apostolic period.

8. Scripture provides principles for distinguishing true prophets from false prophets.

9. Claimed prophetic messages must be evaluated according to God's revealed Word.

10. Miracles and fulfilled predictions are not sufficient by themselves to establish prophetic authenticity.

11. The existence of prophetic gifts does not imply that every prophetic message becomes part of the biblical canon.

12. Revelation connects the testimony of Jesus with the spirit of prophecy, a relationship important to Adventist interpretation.

13. Ellen G. White was an influential Adventist author whose ministry is recognized as prophetic by the Seventh-day Adventist Church.

14. Her writings and claimed prophetic ministry should be evaluated through Scripture and responsible historical investigation.

15. Spiritual gifts should be exercised with humility, love, biblical faithfulness, and discernment.

Doctrinal Conclusion

The Holy Scriptures present spiritual gifts as an essential provision for the Christian Church.

These gifts originate from the Holy Spirit and are intended to strengthen believers, promote unity, and support the proclamation of the Gospel.

Among them, the gift of prophecy occupies an important place.

The biblical prophets communicated divine messages that called people to repentance, encouraged faithfulness, and revealed aspects of God's redemptive purpose.

However, the Bible also warns against false prophets.

Therefore, prophetic claims must be examined carefully.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, the gift of prophecy remains relevant to the Church and is associated with the ministry of Ellen G.

White.

This understanding must be considered alongside several essential principles.

The Supremacy of the Holy Scriptures

The Bible remains the supreme standard for Christian faith, doctrine, and spiritual experience.

No later prophetic claim should replace or contradict its authority.

The Centrality of Jesus Christ

Genuine spiritual ministry should direct believers toward Jesus Christ and His saving work.

The Importance of Biblical Discernment

Spiritual claims must be tested according to Scripture, their content, and relevant evidence.

The Purpose of Spiritual Gifts

Gifts are intended for service, encouragement, unity, and the spiritual growth of the Church.

The Responsibility of Christian Believers

Christians are called to examine teachings carefully, remain humble, and exercise freedom of conscience.

The gift of prophecy should never become a means of spiritual domination or personal exaltation.

Its proper purpose is to strengthen faithfulness to God and support the mission of the Church.

The Essential Message:

God equips His Church through spiritual gifts distributed by the Holy Spirit. The gift of prophecy is presented in Scripture as a means of communicating divine messages for instruction, warning, and encouragement. Every claimed prophetic ministry must be tested

according to the Bible. In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, Ellen G. White's ministry represents a manifestation of this gift, while the Holy Scriptures remain the supreme standard of faith and doctrine.

Personal Reflection Questions

1. Do I understand the purpose of spiritual gifts in the Christian Church?

2. What is the difference between spiritual gifts and the fruit of the Spirit?

3. Why should spiritual gifts be exercised with humility and love?

4. What does the Bible teach about the purpose of prophecy?

5. How can I distinguish a genuine prophetic message from a false claim?

6. Why are miracles or extraordinary experiences insufficient by themselves to establish divine authority?

7. Do I recognize the Holy Scriptures as the supreme standard for evaluating religious teachings?

8. Have I carefully examined the biblical principles relevant to the Adventist understanding of the gift of prophecy?

9. Am I willing to investigate religious claims fairly, without prejudice or unquestioning acceptance?

10. How can I use the abilities God has entrusted to me for the spiritual benefit of others?

Suggested Prayer

Lord my God,

I thank You for Your love, wisdom, and faithfulness.

You are the source of every good and perfect gift.

Thank You for the Holy Spirit, who strengthens Your people and equips them for Christian service.

Help me understand the gifts You have entrusted to Your Church.

Teach me to recognize that these gifts are not given for personal glory but for the benefit of others.

Remove pride, selfishness, and the desire for human recognition from my heart.

Develop in me the fruit of Your Spirit.

May love, joy, peace, patience, kindness, goodness, faithfulness, gentleness, and self-control characterize my life.

Give me wisdom to examine spiritual teachings according to Your Holy Word.

Protect me from deception, superstition, and unquestioning dependence upon human authority.

Help me remain open to the genuine work of Your Spirit while exercising biblical discernment.

Teach me to distinguish truth from error with humility and fairness.

May every spiritual influence in my life direct me toward Jesus Christ.

Help me appreciate the importance of prophetic instruction without placing any human messenger above Your revealed Word.

Guide Your Church in faithfulness, unity, and service.

Strengthen those who teach, preach, encourage, and care for others.

Give me courage to use my own abilities for Your glory.

Prepare me to remain faithful amid the challenges of Christian life.

May Your Spirit guide me into a deeper understanding of Scripture and a closer relationship with my Savior.

Until the glorious return of Jesus Christ, help me remain steadfast in faith, discerning in judgment, and active in love.

In the name of Jesus Christ, my Savior and Lord.

Amen.

CHAPTER 23 — SANCTIFICATION AND CHRISTIAN GROWTH: HOW DOES GOD TRANSFORM THE LIFE OF A BELIEVER?

A Thematic Bible Study — King James Version (KJV)

Opening Scripture

> “And the very God of peace sanctify you wholly; and I pray God your whole spirit and soul and body be preserved blameless unto the coming of our Lord Jesus Christ.”

1 Thessalonians 5:23 — KJV

Introduction

In the preceding chapters, we examined the nature and mission of the Church, the gifts of the Holy Spirit, and the biblical gift of prophecy.

We discovered that God calls believers into a community of faith and equips them for Christian service.

However, the Christian experience involves more than receiving biblical knowledge, joining a congregation, or exercising spiritual gifts.

God also desires to transform the character and conduct of His children.

This transforming work is closely connected with the biblical doctrine of sanctification.

The Holy Scriptures teach that salvation is a gift of God's grace through faith in Jesus Christ.

Human beings cannot earn salvation through their own righteousness.

Nevertheless, the grace that forgives sinners also teaches them to live in holiness.

The apostle Paul declares that believers are created in Christ Jesus unto good works.

Jesus likewise teaches that those who abide in Him bear fruit.

Christian growth therefore involves a continuing relationship with the Savior.

It includes repentance, faith, obedience, prayer, Bible study, love, service, and dependence upon the Holy Spirit.

Yet several important questions arise.

What does sanctification mean? How does it differ from justification? Can believers become holy through their own efforts? What is the relationship between grace and obedience? Why do Christians continue to struggle with temptation? Does spiritual maturity mean sinless perfection? How can believers remain faithful until the return of Jesus Christ?

These questions must be answered carefully.

An unbalanced understanding of sanctification may lead either to legalism, in which individuals attempt to earn salvation through works, or to a distorted view of grace that minimizes the importance of Christian obedience.

The Bible presents a different path.

It teaches that salvation originates in God's grace and that genuine faith produces a transformed life.

This chapter examines fifteen questions concerning sanctification, spiritual growth, Christian character, and perseverance.

Our objective is to understand how God transforms believers through Jesus Christ and the Holy Spirit, while preserving the biblical assurance that salvation rests upon divine grace rather than human

merit.

Question 1 — What Is Sanctification According to the Holy Scriptures?

Answer:

Sanctification refers to being set apart for God and living in a manner consistent with His holy character and purposes.

In Scripture, holiness is associated with belonging to God.

Objects, places, and individuals may be described as holy because they are dedicated to Him.

In the Christian experience, sanctification also includes moral and spiritual transformation.

Believers are called to turn away from sin and grow in righteousness.

The New Testament presents sanctification as the work of God in the lives of those who belong to Jesus Christ.

It is not merely an outward change in religious behavior.

It involves the renewal of thoughts, desires, attitudes, and conduct.

The Holy Spirit plays an essential role in this transformation.

Sanctification therefore includes both the believer's consecration to God and the continuing development of a life that reflects the character of Jesus Christ.

Bible References:

- Leviticus 20:7–8
- John 17:17–19
- Romans 6:19–22
- 1 Corinthians 1:2, 30
- 1 Thessalonians 4:3–8
- 1 Thessalonians 5:23–24

- Hebrews 12:14

Linguistic Note:

The Greek words related to hagiasmos convey the ideas of holiness and sanctification. Biblical usage includes both consecration to God and the practical expression of holiness in Christian life.

Question 2 — What Is the Difference Between Justification and Sanctification?

Answer:

Justification and sanctification are closely related aspects of salvation, but they should not be confused.

Justification concerns the believer's acceptance before God through Jesus Christ.

The apostle Paul teaches that sinners are justified by faith apart from the works of the law.

This justification rests upon God's grace and the redeeming work of Jesus Christ.

Sanctification concerns the believer's consecration to God and transformation in Christian life.

The Holy Spirit works within believers to develop faithfulness, obedience, and Christlike character.

Justification must not be understood as a reward for successful sanctification.

Likewise, sanctification should not be treated as an optional addition to genuine faith.

The New Testament presents salvation as a work of divine grace that both reconciles sinners to God and renews their lives.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, justification and sanctification are distinct but inseparable dimensions of the saving

relationship with Jesus Christ.

Bible References:

- Romans 3:21–28
- Romans 5:1–2
- Romans 6:1–14
- 1 Corinthians 6:9–11
- Galatians 2:16–21
- Ephesians 2:8–10
- Titus 3:4–7

Doctrinal Note:

Christian traditions differ in the precise theological language used to describe justification and sanctification. This chapter follows the Adventist emphasis on salvation by grace through faith and the transforming work of the Holy Spirit.

Question 3 — Can Human Beings Sanctify Themselves Through Their Own Efforts?

Answer:

Human beings cannot produce genuine holiness independently of God's grace.

Jesus declared that His disciples could bear spiritual fruit only by abiding in Him.

The apostle Paul teaches that God works in believers both to will and to do according to His good pleasure.

The Holy Spirit renews the mind and empowers Christians to resist sinful desires.

However, the Bible also calls believers to respond actively to God's work.

Christians are instructed to present themselves to God, resist temptation, pursue holiness, and practice obedience.

These responsibilities do not imply that salvation is achieved through independent human strength.

Rather, they describe the believer's response to divine grace.

Sanctification involves dependence upon God and willing cooperation with His transforming work.

The power originates in God, while believers are called to respond through faith and obedience.

Bible References:

- John 15:1–8
- Romans 6:12–19
- Romans 8:1–14
- 2 Corinthians 3:17–18
- Galatians 5:16–25
- Philippians 2:12–13
- Hebrews 13:20–21

Explanatory Note:

The language of cooperation with divine grace must not be interpreted as suggesting that human effort contributes independent saving merit. Christian obedience is the fruit of God's work, not a substitute for it.

Question 4 — What Role Does the Holy Spirit Play in Sanctification?

Answer:

The Holy Spirit is central to the believer's spiritual transformation.

Jesus taught that the Spirit would guide His disciples into truth.

The apostle Paul explains that those who are led by the Spirit of God are His children.

The Spirit directs believers away from the domination of sinful desires and toward a life pleasing to God.

He develops spiritual fruit, strengthens faith, and renews the inner life.

Paul also teaches that believers are transformed as they behold the glory of the Lord.

This transformation is attributed to the work of the Spirit.

The Holy Spirit does not merely provide occasional emotional experiences.

His ministry involves the continuing formation of Christian character.

He leads believers toward repentance, faithfulness, love, and obedience.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, sanctification is impossible without the transforming presence and power of the Holy Spirit.

Bible References:

- John 14:16–17, 26
- John 16:13–15
- Romans 8:1–17
- 1 Corinthians 6:11
- 2 Corinthians 3:17–18
- Galatians 5:16–26
- 2 Thessalonians 2:13

Doctrinal Note:

The Spirit's transforming work must be distinguished from emotional intensity. Biblical evidence of spiritual growth includes increasing faith, love, obedience, humility, and Christlike character.

Question 5 — What Is the Relationship Between Sanctification and the Word of God?

Answer:

Jesus prayed that His disciples would be sanctified through the truth.

He identified God's Word as truth.

The Holy Scriptures reveal God's character, His commandments, His promises, and His plan of salvation.

Through Scripture, believers learn to recognize sin and understand the life to which God calls them.

The Bible also provides encouragement, correction, instruction, and hope.

The apostle Paul teaches that Scripture is profitable for doctrine, reproof, correction, and instruction in righteousness.

However, merely possessing biblical information does not automatically produce holiness.

God's Word must be received with faith and applied through the transforming work of the Holy Spirit.

Christian growth therefore requires both understanding and obedience.

Believers are invited to study Scripture carefully, meditate upon its teachings, and allow its principles to shape their decisions.

Bible References:

- Psalm 119:9–11
- Psalm 119:105
- John 17:17
- Romans 12:1–2
- 2 Timothy 3:14–17
- James 1:21–25

- 1 Peter 1:22–25

Explanatory Note:

Sanctification through truth does not mean that every interpretation presented by a religious teacher is automatically divine truth. Believers must examine Scripture in its context and exercise spiritual discernment.

Question 6 — How Are Grace, Faith, and Obedience Related in the Christian Life?

Answer:

The Bible teaches that salvation is a gift of God's grace received through faith.

It cannot be earned through human works.

Nevertheless, genuine faith produces a transformed life.

Paul explains that believers are created in Christ Jesus unto good works.

Jesus taught that love for Him is expressed through obedience to His commandments.

James also emphasizes that faith without works is dead.

These teachings are complementary when understood in their respective contexts.

Paul rejects the idea that sinners can earn justification through works of the law.

James rejects a merely verbal profession of faith that produces no practical expression of obedience and love.

Therefore, obedience is not the purchase price of salvation.

It is the fruit of a living relationship with Jesus Christ.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, God's commandments remain important expressions of His moral will, while salvation rests

entirely upon His grace through Jesus Christ.

Bible References:

- John 14:15
- Romans 3:27–31
- Romans 6:14–18
- Galatians 5:5–6
- Ephesians 2:8–10
- Titus 2:11–14
- James 2:14–26
- 1 John 5:2–3

Doctrinal Note:

Biblical obedience must not be confused with legalism. Legalism attempts to establish acceptance before God through human achievement. Gospel obedience flows from faith, gratitude, and the transforming work of grace.

Question 7 — Why Do Christians Continue to Experience Temptation After Conversion?

Answer:

Conversion does not eliminate every temptation or spiritual struggle.

The New Testament repeatedly warns believers against temptation and calls them to remain watchful.

Jesus Himself was tempted, yet without sin.

Therefore, the experience of temptation is not identical to committing sin.

James explains that temptation becomes spiritually destructive when sinful desire is embraced and allowed to develop.

The apostle Paul describes the conflict between the desires of the flesh and the guidance of the Spirit.

Believers are called to resist sinful desires through dependence upon God.

The Bible promises that God is faithful and provides a way to endure temptation.

Christian growth therefore includes learning to recognize temptation, seek divine strength, and make faithful choices.

The presence of spiritual struggle does not necessarily demonstrate the absence of genuine faith.

However, believers should not use the reality of temptation as an excuse for deliberate wrongdoing.

Bible References:

- Matthew 4:1–11
- Matthew 26:40–41
- Hebrews 4:14–16
- 1 Corinthians 10:12–13
- Galatians 5:16–17
- James 1:12–15
- 1 Peter 5:8–10

Explanatory Note:

Temptation and sin must be distinguished. The New Testament presents Jesus as tempted without sin, demonstrating that temptation itself does not necessarily constitute moral failure.

Question 8 — What Should a Christian Do After Falling Into Sin?

Answer:

The Bible does not encourage believers to deny their sins or abandon hope after failure.

The apostle John teaches that those who confess their sins may trust God's faithfulness and forgiveness.

He also identifies Jesus Christ as the advocate of believers who sin.

David's prayer of repentance demonstrates the importance of acknowledging wrongdoing and seeking a renewed heart.

Genuine repentance involves more than regret over consequences.

It includes recognizing sin, turning toward God, and seeking restoration.

Where wrongdoing has harmed others, repentance should also lead to appropriate responsibility and efforts toward restitution when possible.

The believer should not treat forgiveness as permission to continue deliberately in sin.

Neither should failure lead to the conclusion that God's mercy is no longer available.

Christian restoration rests upon the grace of God and the saving ministry of Jesus Christ.

Bible References:

- Psalm 32:1–5
- Psalm 51:1–17
- Proverbs 28:13
- Luke 15:11–24
- Romans 6:1–2
- 1 John 1:8–9
- 1 John 2:1–2

Practical Note:

Forgiveness does not necessarily eliminate the earthly consequences of harmful actions. Genuine repentance includes honesty, accountability, and concern for those affected.

Question 9 — What Does It Mean to Grow in Christian Maturity?

Answer:

Christian maturity refers to increasing stability, understanding, faithfulness, and Christlike character.

The New Testament compares spiritual development to growth from childhood toward adulthood.

New believers require instruction and encouragement.

As they grow, they are called to develop discernment and greater consistency in Christian living.

The apostle Peter instructs believers to grow in grace and in the knowledge of Jesus Christ.

Paul teaches that the Church should mature toward the fullness of Christ.

Christian maturity is therefore not measured merely by the number of years a person has belonged to a congregation.

Nor is it established solely by theological knowledge or religious responsibility.

It is demonstrated through faith, humility, love, discernment, perseverance, and responsible conduct.

Spiritual maturity remains a continuing process of dependence upon God's grace.

Bible References:

- 1 Corinthians 3:1–3
- Ephesians 4:11–16
- Philippians 3:12–16
- Colossians 1:9–12
- Hebrews 5:12–14

- 1 Peter 2:1–3
- 2 Peter 3:18

Doctrinal Note:

Spiritual maturity should not be confused with independence from God. The more believers grow in Christian understanding, the more they should recognize their continuing need for divine grace.

Question 10 — What Spiritual Disciplines Contribute to Christian Growth?

Answer:

The Bible presents several practices that strengthen the believer's relationship with God.

Prayer encourages communion with the heavenly Father.

Bible study provides instruction, correction, and spiritual nourishment.

Worship expresses reverence and gratitude.

Christian fellowship offers encouragement, accountability, and mutual support.

Service develops love and concern for others.

The New Testament also includes examples of fasting as an expression of spiritual devotion.

These practices do not earn salvation.

They provide opportunities for believers to seek God, receive His instruction, and respond to His grace.

However, spiritual disciplines may become empty formalities when performed merely to impress others or establish personal righteousness.

Jesus warned against hypocritical prayer and fasting.

The purpose of spiritual discipline is therefore not religious display but a deeper relationship with God.

Bible References:

- Psalm 1:1–3
- Matthew 6:5–18
- Mark 1:35
- Acts 2:42–47
- Romans 12:9–13
- Colossians 3:16–17
- Hebrews 10:23–25
- James 1:22–27

Practical Note:

A balanced Christian devotional life may include regular prayer, Scripture reading, worship, fellowship, and service. Such practices should be adapted responsibly to personal circumstances without becoming a measure of spiritual superiority.

Question 11 — How Does Love Demonstrate Genuine Sanctification?

Answer:

Jesus identified love as a defining characteristic of His disciples.

He taught that His followers should love one another as He had loved them.

The apostle Paul described love as greater than extraordinary spiritual gifts when those gifts are exercised without genuine concern for others.

The New Testament also teaches that love fulfills the moral purpose of God's commandments.

Genuine sanctification therefore produces more than external religious conformity.

It transforms the believer's relationship with other people.

Love is expressed through patience, kindness, forgiveness, truthfulness, compassion, and practical service.

However, biblical love should not be confused with approving every action or abandoning moral discernment.

Christian love is connected with truth and righteousness.

A sanctified life seeks to reflect both God's holiness and His compassion.

Bible References:

- Matthew 22:36–40
- John 13:34–35
- Romans 13:8–10
- 1 Corinthians 13:1–13
- Galatians 5:13–14, 22–23
- Ephesians 4:25–32
- 1 John 4:7–21

Doctrinal Note:

The biblical relationship between love and obedience should not be reduced to outward rule-keeping. Genuine love arises from a transformed heart and expresses itself in faithful conduct.

Question 12 — Does Sanctification Mean That Christians Become Sinlessly Perfect?

Answer:

The Bible calls believers to holiness and spiritual maturity.

Jesus instructed His disciples to be perfect as their heavenly Father is perfect.

However, the meaning of perfection must be understood within the context of each passage.

In Matthew 5, Jesus emphasizes complete and impartial love, including love for enemies.

The apostle Paul also speaks of pressing toward the goal of Christian maturity while acknowledging that he has not already attained it.

The apostle John warns against claiming to have no sin.

At the same time, Scripture does not encourage believers to accept deliberate sin as an unavoidable pattern of Christian life.

It calls them to resist temptation, confess wrongdoing, and grow in holiness.

In Seventh-day Adventist theology, sanctification involves the progressive transformation of character through God's grace.

Adventists have expressed differing emphases concerning the nature and extent of perfection before Christ's return.

Therefore, the biblical call to holiness should not be transformed into a claim that believers can establish their own sinlessness or become independent of Christ's righteousness.

The Christian's confidence remains in Jesus Christ.

Bible References:

- Matthew 5:43–48
- Romans 6:11–14
- Philippians 3:12–16
- Hebrews 12:1–14
- James 3:1–2
- 1 John 1:8–10
- 1 John 2:1–2
- 1 John 3:1–3

Doctrinal Note:

The interpretation of Christian perfection is debated within and beyond Adventist theology. This chapter emphasizes the clear biblical teachings of holiness, spiritual growth, repentance, and continuing dependence upon Jesus Christ without claiming more than the cited passages establish.

Question 13 — How Do Trials and Suffering Contribute to Spiritual Growth?

Answer:

The Bible teaches that trials may become occasions for the development of perseverance and faith.

James encourages believers to recognize that the testing of faith can produce patience.

Peter also describes faith as being tested through difficulties.

However, Scripture does not teach that every instance of suffering is a direct punishment from God.

Jesus rejected simplistic explanations that automatically connected personal suffering with individual sin.

The Christian response to suffering should therefore include compassion, prayer, practical assistance, and trust in God's promises.

Trials may reveal weaknesses and encourage deeper dependence upon God.

They may also strengthen perseverance and hope.

Nevertheless, suffering should never be romanticized or used to justify abuse, injustice, or preventable harm.

God's presence and grace remain important sources of strength during difficult circumstances.

Bible References:

- Job 1:20–22
- John 9:1–3
- Romans 5:1–5
- Romans 8:18–28
- 2 Corinthians 12:7–10
- James 1:2–4
- 1 Peter 1:6–9
- 1 Peter 5:6–10

Explanatory Note:

The biblical teaching that God can bring spiritual growth through suffering does not imply that all suffering is divinely caused or that believers should remain in dangerous circumstances.

Question 14 — How Does Sanctification Influence Daily Decisions and Christian Conduct?

Answer:

Sanctification affects the whole of Christian life.

The Bible calls believers to honor God through their thoughts, words, relationships, and actions.

Paul instructs Christians to present their bodies as living sacrifices and to be transformed by the renewing of their minds.

He also teaches that believers should do all things to the glory of God.

These principles apply to personal conduct, family relationships, work, recreation, stewardship, and service.

Christian choices should reflect honesty, self-control, compassion, purity, and responsibility.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, sanctification also influences health practices, Sabbath observance, stewardship, and other aspects

of practical Christian living.

However, the application of biblical principles should distinguish explicit commandments from denominational interpretations and individual matters of conscience.

The purpose of Christian conduct is not to establish personal superiority.

It is to glorify God and reflect the transforming influence of His grace.

Bible References:

- Romans 12:1–2
- 1 Corinthians 6:19–20
- 1 Corinthians 10:31
- Galatians 5:16–26
- Ephesians 4:17–32
- Colossians 3:12–24
- Titus 2:11–14
- 1 Peter 1:13–16

Doctrinal Note:

Practical standards of Christian conduct should be evaluated according to Scripture. Believers should avoid treating every cultural custom or personal preference as though it were an explicit divine commandment.

Question 15 — How Does Sanctification Prepare Believers for the Return of Jesus Christ?

Answer:

The New Testament connects Christian holiness with the hope of Christ's return.

The apostle Paul prayed that believers would be sanctified and preserved blameless unto the coming of Jesus Christ.

The apostle John teaches that those who possess the hope of seeing Christ purify themselves.

Peter also calls believers to holy conduct as they anticipate the fulfillment of God's promises.

These passages demonstrate that the expectation of Christ's return should influence Christian life.

However, preparation for the Second Coming must not be understood as an attempt to earn salvation through personal perfection.

The believer's hope rests upon Jesus Christ and His saving grace.

The Holy Spirit transforms those who remain in communion with Him.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, the final generation of believers is called to demonstrate faithfulness to God amid spiritual deception and opposition.

Revelation describes the saints in terms of perseverance, obedience to God's commandments, and faith in Jesus.

Yet the foundation of their victory remains the saving work of the Lamb.

Christian preparation therefore involves faith, repentance, obedience, perseverance, love, and complete dependence upon divine grace.

Bible References:

- John 15:1–8
- 1 Thessalonians 5:23–24
- Titus 2:11–14
- Hebrews 12:14
- 1 John 3:1–3
- 2 Peter 3:11–14
- Revelation 12:11
- Revelation 14:12

Doctrinal Note:

The Adventist interpretation of end-time sanctification should remain centered upon Jesus Christ. The biblical call to holiness does not authorize speculation concerning the spiritual status of particular individuals or claims of personal sinlessness.

Chapter Summary

Sanctification is an essential dimension of Christian life.

It involves consecration to God and the continuing transformation of the believer's character through divine grace.

The Holy Scriptures distinguish justification from sanctification while presenting both as aspects of salvation through Jesus Christ.

The Holy Spirit guides believers into truth, develops Christian character, and strengthens them to live faithfully.

Our study enables us to retain the following teachings:

1. Sanctification involves belonging to God and growing in holiness.

2. Justification concerns acceptance before God through Christ, while sanctification concerns consecration and transformation.

3. Genuine holiness cannot be produced independently of divine grace.

4. The Holy Spirit is central to the process of spiritual transformation.

5. God's Word instructs and guides believers in the path of sanctification.

6. Salvation is received by grace through faith, while obedience is the fruit of genuine faith.

7. Conversion does not eliminate temptation, but God provides strength to resist it.

8. Believers who fall into sin are called to repentance, confession, and restoration.

9. Christian maturity involves increasing faith, love, discernment, and Christlike character.

10. Prayer, Bible study, worship, fellowship, and service contribute to spiritual growth.

11. Genuine sanctification is expressed through love toward God and other people.

12. Biblical holiness should not be confused with claims of independent or self-achieved sinlessness.

13. Trials may strengthen faith and perseverance, although suffering should not automatically be attributed to personal sin.

14. Sanctification influences daily conduct and responsible Christian decision-making.

15. Christian holiness is connected with the hope of Christ's return and continuing dependence upon His grace.

Doctrinal Conclusion

Sanctification occupies an essential place in the biblical understanding of salvation.

The Holy Scriptures teach that sinners are reconciled to God through the saving work of Jesus Christ.

This reconciliation is not earned through human effort.

It is received through faith in God's grace.

However, the same grace that brings forgiveness also transforms the lives of believers.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, sanctification involves several important dimensions.

Consecration to God

Believers are called to belong to Jesus Christ and dedicate their lives to His service.

Transformation Through the Holy Spirit

The Holy Spirit renews the mind, develops Christian character, and strengthens believers to resist sin.

Growth Through the Word of God

The Holy Scriptures reveal God's will and provide instruction for faithful Christian living.

Obedience Motivated by Love

Genuine faith produces obedience as an expression of gratitude and devotion rather than an attempt to earn salvation.

Perseverance in Christian Hope

Believers are called to remain faithful while anticipating the glorious return of Jesus Christ.

Sanctification should never be separated from justification or the saving righteousness of Jesus Christ.

Neither should Christian holiness be reduced to outward conformity with religious customs.

The biblical objective is a transformed relationship with God that produces love, humility, faithfulness, and obedience.

The Essential Message:

Sanctification is the work of God's grace through which believers are consecrated to Him and progressively transformed into the likeness of Jesus Christ. It does not earn salvation but expresses the fruit of genuine faith. Through the Holy Spirit, the Word of God, and continuing communion with Christ, believers grow in holiness, love, and obedience while remaining completely dependent upon divine grace.

Personal Reflection Questions

1. Do I understand the difference between justification and sanctification?

2. Am I attempting to earn God's acceptance through my own efforts, or am I trusting in the righteousness of Jesus Christ?

3. How is the Holy Spirit transforming my thoughts, attitudes, and conduct?

4. Does my study of Scripture influence the decisions I make each day?

5. Do I view obedience as an expression of love and gratitude toward God?

6. How do I respond when I experience temptation or spiritual failure?

7. What spiritual habits could help me develop a deeper relationship with Jesus Christ?

8. Do my relationships with others demonstrate the love, patience, and humility of Christ?

9. Am I growing in Christian maturity while recognizing my continuing need for divine grace?

10. Does the hope of Christ's return inspire me to live faithfully and depend more completely upon Him?

Suggested Prayer

Lord my God,

I come before You with gratitude, humility, and faith.

You are holy, righteous, merciful, and full of love.

Thank You for the gift of salvation through Jesus Christ.

I acknowledge that I cannot earn Your favor through my own works.

My hope rests upon Your grace and the saving righteousness of my Savior.

Forgive my sins and cleanse my heart from everything that separates me from You.

Through the power of Your Holy Spirit, transform my thoughts, desires, words, and actions.

Teach me to love what is good and turn away from what is evil.

Help me study Your Word with sincerity and apply its teachings faithfully.

When I face temptation, give me strength to resist.

When I fall, lead me to genuine repentance and renewed confidence in Your mercy.

Remove pride, selfishness, bitterness, and hypocrisy from my heart.

Develop in me the character of Jesus Christ.

May love, patience, kindness, faithfulness, humility, and self-control become increasingly evident in my life.

Teach me to obey You through faith and gratitude rather than fear or the desire to earn salvation.

Help me serve others with compassion and integrity.

Strengthen my faith during trials and difficulties.

When I do not understand Your purposes, help me trust Your wisdom.

Protect me from spiritual pride and the belief that I can become righteous independently of You.

May every day bring me into deeper communion with Jesus Christ.

Prepare me for His glorious return.

Until that day, help me remain steadfast in faith, growing in holiness, and completely dependent upon Your grace.

In the name of Jesus Christ, my Savior and Lord.

Amen.

CHAPTER 24 — CHRISTIAN STEWARDSHIP, TITHES, AND OFFERINGS: HOW SHOULD BELIEVERS MANAGE WHAT GOD HAS ENTRUSTED TO THEM?

A Thematic Bible Study — King James Version (KJV)

Opening Scripture

> “The earth is the LORD's, and the fulness thereof; the world, and they that dwell therein.”

Psalm 24:1 — KJV

Introduction

In the preceding chapter, we examined sanctification and Christian growth.

We discovered that God's grace transforms not only the believer's spiritual understanding but also personal conduct, relationships, and daily decisions.

One important expression of this transformation is Christian stewardship.

The Holy Scriptures teach that God is the Creator and ultimate Owner of everything.

Human beings receive life, abilities, opportunities, possessions, and responsibilities from Him.

They are therefore called to manage these blessings faithfully.

Stewardship is not limited to money.

It includes the responsible use of time, physical strength, spiritual gifts, natural resources, and material possessions.

However, financial stewardship occupies an important place in Scripture.

The Bible repeatedly addresses generosity, honesty, wealth, poverty, greed, and responsibility toward those in need.

It also introduces the practice of tithing.

The Old Testament records the giving of a tenth in the experiences of Abraham and Jacob and later establishes detailed tithe regulations within the covenant life of Israel.

The New Testament emphasizes generosity, voluntary giving, care for the poor, and support for Gospel ministry.

Yet important questions arise.

What does it mean to be a steward of God? What is the tithe? Did tithing begin with the Mosaic law? What purposes did the tithe serve in ancient Israel? Did Jesus affirm the practice? Are Christians obligated to give ten percent of their income? What is the difference between tithes and offerings? How should churches administer donated resources?

These questions require careful examination.

A responsible Bible study must distinguish the historical practices of ancient Israel from the teachings given to the Christian Church.

It must also distinguish explicit biblical commands from the conclusions reached by particular Christian traditions.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, tithing remains an important expression of faithful stewardship and provides support for the proclamation of the Gospel.

However, this conviction must be explained through biblical reasoning rather than merely assumed.

This chapter examines fifteen questions concerning stewardship, tithes, offerings, generosity, and financial responsibility.

Our purpose is to understand how believers may honor God through faithful, responsible, and compassionate management of the resources entrusted to them.

Question 1 — What Is Christian Stewardship According to the Bible?

Answer:

Christian stewardship is the responsible management of the life, abilities, opportunities, and resources that God has entrusted to human beings.

The Bible teaches that God is the Creator and ultimate Owner of everything.

Human beings are therefore not independent owners in an absolute sense.

They receive blessings and responsibilities that should be managed in harmony with God's purposes.

The creation account presents humanity as responsible for caring for the earth.

The New Testament also describes believers as stewards of God's grace.

Christian stewardship includes the use of material possessions, time, spiritual gifts, physical abilities, and opportunities for service.

Its purpose is not merely efficient management.

It is an expression of faith, gratitude, accountability, and love toward God and other people.

Bible References:

- Genesis 1:26–28

- Genesis 2:15
- Psalm 24:1
- Psalm 50:10–12
- 1 Corinthians 4:1–2
- 1 Peter 4:10–11
- James 1:17

Doctrinal Note:

Stewardship includes more than financial giving. Seventh-day Adventist theology understands it as the faithful management of the whole life under God's authority.

Question 2 — Why Does the Bible Teach That Everything Belongs to God?

Answer:

The Holy Scriptures identify God as the Creator of heaven and earth.

Because He created all things, He possesses ultimate authority over them.

Psalm 24 declares that the earth and its fullness belong to the Lord.

David also acknowledged that the resources presented for the construction of the temple had first come from God.

This principle encourages humility.

Human beings may work, produce, earn, and possess property, but their lives and abilities ultimately depend upon the Creator.

The Bible does not deny legitimate personal ownership or the responsibility to provide for one's household.

Rather, it places human ownership within the larger framework of divine sovereignty.

Believers are therefore called to use their possessions responsibly, recognizing that they remain accountable to God.

Bible References:

- Genesis 1:1
- Deuteronomy 8:17–18
- Psalm 24:1–2
- Psalm 50:10–12
- 1 Chronicles 29:10–16
- Haggai 2:8
- James 1:17

Explanatory Note:

Recognizing God's ultimate ownership does not authorize religious leaders or institutions to claim unrestricted control over an individual's property. Biblical stewardship involves responsibility before God, not the surrender of personal conscience to human authority.

Question 3 — What Is the Tithe, and What Does the Word Mean?

Answer:

The word tithe refers to a tenth part.

In the Old Testament, tithing involved setting aside a tenth of specified agricultural produce, livestock, or other resources in particular contexts.

The Hebrew word maʿăśēr is associated with the concept of a tenth.

The Greek term dekátē likewise refers to a tenth.

The biblical practice of tithing appears in different historical settings.

Before the Mosaic law, Abraham gave a tenth of the spoils of battle to Melchizedek.

Jacob also made a vow concerning a tenth of what God would give him.

Later, the Mosaic law established regulations concerning tithes within Israel's religious and social life.

Therefore, the meaning of the tithe is straightforward, but its application requires attention to the covenant and historical context in which it appears.

Bible References:

- Genesis 14:18–20
- Genesis 28:20–22
- Leviticus 27:30–33
- Numbers 18:21–24
- Deuteronomy 14:22–29
- Hebrews 7:1–10

Linguistic Note:

The literal meaning of tithe is one-tenth. However, the meaning of the word alone does not establish which resources should be tithed or how ancient Israel's regulations apply to Christians today.

Question 4 — Did the Practice of Tithing Exist Before the Mosaic Law?

Answer:

Yes.

The Book of Genesis records two important references to tithing before the establishment of the Mosaic covenant.

Abraham gave Melchizedek a tenth of the spoils obtained after rescuing Lot.

Melchizedek is identified as king of Salem and priest of the most high God.

Jacob later promised that he would give God a tenth of all that God would give him.

These accounts demonstrate that the concept of giving a tenth existed before the Mosaic law.

However, the narratives do not provide a complete system of regulations concerning regular tithing.

Abraham's recorded tithe was connected with the spoils of a particular military victory.

Jacob's statement appears in the form of a vow.

Therefore, these examples establish the antiquity of tithing without independently proving every detail of a universal and permanent Christian obligation.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, these pre-Mosaic examples support the principle that tithing is not limited exclusively to the ceremonial regulations of ancient Israel.

Bible References:

- Genesis 14:14–24
- Genesis 28:20–22
- Hebrews 7:1–10

Doctrinal Note:

The Adventist conclusion that tithing remains applicable to Christians is a theological interpretation. The Genesis narratives themselves do not explicitly command all believers in every age to tithe their income.

Question 5 — How Was Tithing Regulated Under the Mosaic Law?

Answer:

The Mosaic law established detailed regulations concerning tithes within the covenant life of ancient Israel.

Leviticus describes a tenth of the produce of the land and certain livestock as belonging to the Lord.

Numbers explains that the Levites received tithes because they did not possess the same territorial inheritance as the other tribes.

The Levites were also instructed to give a tenth of what they received.

Deuteronomy describes tithing in connection with worship, communal celebration, and provision for vulnerable members of society.

These passages demonstrate that tithing served religious, economic, and social purposes.

The Old Testament contains more than one tithe-related instruction.

Interpreters differ concerning how the various regulations should be harmonized and whether they represent distinct tithes or different applications within Israel's agricultural cycle.

Therefore, the ancient system should not be simplified without examining the relevant passages.

Bible References:

- Leviticus 27:30–33
- Numbers 18:21–32
- Deuteronomy 12:5–19
- Deuteronomy 14:22–29
- Deuteronomy 26:12–15
- Nehemiah 10:35–39

Historical Note:

Ancient Israel's tithe regulations were closely connected with agricultural production, the Levitical system, worship, and social provision. Applying these regulations to modern monetary income requires theological interpretation rather than a simple repetition of the original economic arrangements.

Question 6 — What Was the Purpose of the Tithe in Ancient Israel?

Answer:

The tithe supported several important functions within Israel's covenant community.

A central purpose was to provide for the Levites, who performed responsibilities associated with the sanctuary and religious instruction.

The Levites did not receive the same territorial inheritance as the other tribes.

Tithing therefore contributed to their support.

Other tithe-related instructions were connected with worship and communal celebration before the Lord.

Deuteronomy also describes provision for Levites, strangers, fatherless children, and widows.

These regulations demonstrate that biblical stewardship included concern for both worship and human welfare.

The tithe was not merely an isolated financial transaction.

It formed part of a broader system of covenant responsibility.

Bible References:

- Numbers 18:20–32
- Deuteronomy 12:17–19
- Deuteronomy 14:22–29
- Deuteronomy 26:12–15
- Nehemiah 13:10–13
- Malachi 3:8–10

Explanatory Note:

The purposes of tithing varied according to the regulations being considered. A complete study must distinguish support for the Levites from provisions concerning worship celebrations and assistance to vulnerable people.

Question 7 — What Does Malachi Teach About Robbing God in Tithes and Offerings?

Answer:

The prophet Malachi confronted serious spiritual and covenant unfaithfulness among the people of Judah.

His message addressed corrupt worship, failures among religious leaders, and neglect of obligations toward God.

In Malachi 3, the prophet accused the people of withholding tithes and offerings.

He called them to bring the tithes into the storehouse so that there would be provision in God's house.

The passage also contains a promise of divine blessing.

However, this promise must be understood within its historical and covenant context.

Malachi was addressing a community living under the obligations of the Mosaic covenant.

The passage should not be used to guarantee that every modern believer who gives a tithe will become financially prosperous.

Nor should it be employed to threaten struggling individuals or manipulate them through fear.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, Malachi 3 reinforces the importance of faithfulness in returning tithes and giving offerings.

The broader biblical principle is that stewardship should be characterized by sincerity, responsibility, and trust in God.

Bible References:

- Malachi 1:6–14
- Malachi 2:1–9
- Malachi 3:6–12
- Deuteronomy 28:1–14
- Nehemiah 13:10–13

Doctrinal Note:

The application of Malachi 3:8–10 to Christian tithing is a denominational interpretation. Its original audience and covenant setting must remain clear.

Question 8 — Did Jesus Christ Teach Anything About Tithing?

Answer:

Yes.

Jesus referred to tithing in His criticism of certain religious leaders.

In Matthew 23:23, He acknowledged their practice of tithing while condemning their neglect of justice, mercy, and faith.

A parallel passage appears in Luke 11:42.

Jesus' teaching demonstrates that religious giving cannot substitute for moral faithfulness.

The Pharisees were careful about particular religious practices while neglecting matters of greater ethical importance.

Jesus exposed this imbalance.

However, the passages must be interpreted within the historical setting of His ministry among people living under the Mosaic covenant.

They do not provide a detailed explanation of how tithing should function in the later Christian Church.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, Jesus' words support the continuing importance of tithing while emphasizing that it must be accompanied by justice, mercy, and faith.

Other Christians understand these passages primarily as instructions addressed to religious leaders within the Old Testament covenant system.

Bible References:

- Matthew 23:23
- Luke 11:42
- Luke 18:9–14
- Matthew 6:1–4
- Matthew 22:37–40

Doctrinal Note:

Jesus' acknowledgment of tithing should not be separated from His central criticism of religious hypocrisy. Faithful giving must never replace love, justice, mercy, and sincere obedience.

Question 9 — Does the New Testament Command Christians to Give Ten Percent of Their Income?

Answer:

The New Testament clearly teaches that Christians should support Gospel ministry, practice generosity, and assist those in need.

However, its instructions concerning Christian giving generally emphasize willingness, proportionality, sincerity, and love.

Paul encouraged believers to set aside resources according to their prosperity.

He also taught that giving should not be motivated by compulsion.

The New Testament does not contain an explicit universal command addressed to all Christians requiring precisely ten percent of monetary income.

This fact is important for responsible biblical interpretation.

Some Christian traditions conclude that the Old Testament principle of tithing continues to provide a binding standard.

Others regard ten percent as a useful guideline rather than a universal command.

Still others emphasize voluntary giving without prescribing a fixed percentage.

Seventh-day Adventist theology teaches that believers should return a faithful tithe of one-tenth of their increase or income.

This practice is understood as an expression of stewardship and recognition of God's ownership.

The conclusion is based upon the Adventist interpretation of the broader biblical teaching rather than upon a single explicit New Testament command establishing the percentage.

Bible References:

- Matthew 23:23
- 1 Corinthians 9:7–14
- 1 Corinthians 16:1–2
- 2 Corinthians 8:1–15
- 2 Corinthians 9:6–12
- Hebrews 7:1–10

Doctrinal Note:

The distinction between an explicit biblical command and a theological application is essential. The Seventh-day Adventist position on the continuing obligation of tithing should be presented accurately without implying that every Christian tradition interprets the New Testament in the same way.

Question 10 — What Is the Difference Between Tithes and Offerings?

Answer:

The Bible distinguishes between tithes and various forms of offerings.

Under the Mosaic covenant, the tithe was associated with specific obligations concerning agricultural produce, livestock, and the support of religious and social responsibilities.

Offerings included different forms of gifts presented in worship and gratitude.

Some offerings were prescribed by law, while others were voluntary.

In the New Testament, Christian giving is frequently described in terms of generosity, willingness, and support for ministry and people in need.

In Seventh-day Adventist practice, the tithe is understood as a tenth returned to God, ordinarily through the Church's designated system for supporting Gospel ministry.

Offerings are understood as additional gifts given voluntarily for worship, mission, humanitarian service, and other religious purposes.

This distinction reflects Adventist stewardship theology.

However, the precise administrative separation between modern tithes and offerings is not laid out in the New Testament as a universal financial system.

Bible References:

- Exodus 35:20–29
- Leviticus 27:30–33
- Deuteronomy 16:16–17
- 1 Chronicles 29:1–9
- Mark 12:41–44
- 2 Corinthians 8:1–5

- 2 Corinthians 9:6–8

Explanatory Note:

Not every offering in the Old Testament was voluntary, and not every biblical gift was a tithe. The terminology must be interpreted according to the specific passage and covenant context.

Question 11 — How Should Christians Determine the Amount They Give?

Answer:

The New Testament emphasizes thoughtful, sincere, and responsible giving.

Paul instructed believers to set aside resources according to how they had prospered.

He also encouraged giving according to one's ability.

In his second letter to the Corinthians, he explained that God loves a cheerful giver.

These principles indicate that Christian giving should reflect gratitude, generosity, and responsible consideration of personal circumstances.

Believers should not give merely to gain public admiration or obtain promised material rewards.

Nor should giving be imposed through emotional manipulation.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, the tithe is calculated as ten percent of one's increase or income, while offerings are given additionally according to personal conviction and ability.

Practical questions may arise concerning gross or net income, business expenses, gifts, and irregular earnings.

The Bible does not provide a detailed modern accounting manual for every financial circumstance.

Believers should therefore act with integrity, consistency, and an informed conscience.

Bible References:

- Proverbs 3:9–10
- Matthew 6:1–4
- 1 Corinthians 16:1–2
- 2 Corinthians 8:11–15
- 2 Corinthians 9:6–8
- 1 Timothy 6:17–19

Practical Note:

Christians should avoid placing themselves or their dependents in preventable danger through financially irresponsible decisions. Biblical generosity must be practiced alongside the responsibility to care for one's household.

Question 12 — Should Tithes and Offerings Support Gospel Ministry?

Answer:

The New Testament teaches that those who proclaim the Gospel may receive material support from the Christian community.

Jesus instructed His disciples concerning provision for their missionary work.

Paul explained that those who minister in spiritual things may receive support for their material needs.

He also drew an analogy with the support provided to those who served in the temple.

However, Paul sometimes chose not to exercise this right in order to avoid creating obstacles to the Gospel.

These passages establish a biblical principle of supporting ministry.

They do not prescribe every detail of a modern denominational financial system.

In Seventh-day Adventist practice, tithe funds are principally directed toward supporting Gospel ministry through the Church's organized structure.

This application is based upon the denomination's understanding of the biblical principles of tithing and ministerial support.

The use of donated resources should be characterized by integrity, transparency, and accountability.

Bible References:

- Matthew 10:9–10
- Luke 10:7
- 1 Corinthians 9:7–18
- Galatians 6:6
- Philippians 4:10–19
- 1 Timothy 5:17–18

Doctrinal Note:

The New Testament supports the material provision of Gospel workers. The specific policy governing tithe distribution within a modern denomination is an administrative application of biblical principles, not an explicit New Testament financial regulation.

Question 13 — What Does the Bible Teach About Giving to the Poor and Helping Those in Need?

Answer:

The Holy Scriptures repeatedly emphasize compassion toward the poor and vulnerable.

The Old Testament contains commands concerning justice, generosity, and provision for those experiencing hardship.

Jesus taught His followers to care for the hungry, the thirsty, the stranger, and those in need.

The early Christian Church shared resources to assist members who lacked essential necessities.

Paul also organized collections for believers experiencing poverty.

James warned against a profession of faith that fails to provide practical assistance to people in need.

These passages demonstrate that biblical stewardship includes social responsibility.

Religious giving should not be restricted to institutional support while neglecting human suffering.

Christian generosity is an expression of love and obedience to God.

It should preserve the dignity of those receiving assistance and avoid using charity as a means of manipulation.

Bible References:

- Deuteronomy 15:7–11
- Proverbs 19:17
- Isaiah 58:6–10
- Matthew 25:31–46
- Acts 4:32–35
- Romans 15:25–27
- 2 Corinthians 8:13–15
- James 2:14–17

Doctrinal Note:

Support for Gospel ministry and assistance to the poor are both important biblical responsibilities. They should not be presented as mutually exclusive expressions of Christian stewardship.

Question 14 — How Should Churches Manage Tithes, Offerings, and Other Donated Resources?

Answer:

The Bible emphasizes honesty, accountability, and integrity in the management of resources.

The apostle Paul took precautions in administering financial gifts collected for believers in need.

He sought to avoid criticism concerning the handling of donated funds.

This example demonstrates the importance of responsible financial administration.

Churches should therefore maintain clear procedures for receiving, recording, safeguarding, and distributing resources.

Financial responsibilities should not be concentrated without appropriate oversight.

Leaders entrusted with funds should demonstrate integrity and accountability.

Donors should be able to understand the general purposes for which resources are collected and used.

The New Testament does not prescribe a single modern accounting system.

However, its ethical principles support transparency, responsible governance, and protection against misuse.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, stewardship responsibilities apply not only to individual believers but also to church institutions.

Bible References:

- Proverbs 11:1
- Proverbs 20:10

- Luke 16:10–12
- Acts 6:1–6
- 1 Corinthians 4:1–2
- 2 Corinthians 8:18–24
- 1 Peter 5:2–3

Practical Note:

Financial accountability may include accurate records, independent review, clear authorization procedures, appropriate reporting, and safeguards against conflicts of interest. These are practical applications of biblical integrity rather than detailed procedures explicitly prescribed in Scripture.

Question 15 — How Does Faithful Stewardship Prepare Believers for the Return of Jesus Christ?

Answer:

Jesus frequently used illustrations concerning stewardship and accountability.

In the parable of the talents, servants were entrusted with resources and later called to give an account of their management.

The lesson emphasizes responsibility, faithfulness, and the wise use of what has been entrusted.

Jesus also warned against greed and the belief that life consists in the abundance of possessions.

He taught His followers to seek first the kingdom of God.

The New Testament encourages believers to live with generosity, contentment, and hope.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, faithful stewardship is part of Christian preparation for the return of Jesus Christ.

It includes responsible use of time, health, abilities, possessions, and opportunities for service.

However, stewardship must not be presented as a means of purchasing salvation.

The believer's hope rests upon Jesus Christ and His saving grace.

Faithful stewardship is one expression of the transformed life that results from genuine faith.

Bible References:

- Matthew 6:19–34
- Matthew 24:45–51
- Matthew 25:14–30
- Luke 12:13–21
- Luke 16:10–13
- 1 Timothy 6:6–19
- Titus 2:11–14
- 1 Peter 4:7–11

Doctrinal Note:

Biblical stewardship should be understood as faithful service motivated by love and gratitude. It must not be reduced to financial contributions or treated as a guarantee of salvation.

Chapter Summary

Christian stewardship is an essential expression of faith and gratitude toward God.

The Holy Scriptures teach that God is the Creator and ultimate Owner of all things.

Human beings are called to manage responsibly the resources entrusted to them.

Tithing appears in the Old Testament before the Mosaic law and later becomes part of Israel's covenant system.

The New Testament emphasizes generous giving, support for Gospel ministry, and compassion toward those in need.

Our study enables us to retain the following teachings:

1. Christian stewardship involves the responsible management of life, abilities, time, and resources.

2. Everything ultimately belongs to God because He is the Creator.

3. The tithe means a tenth, but its application must be understood within biblical context.

4. Tithing existed before the Mosaic law in the experiences of Abraham and Jacob.

5. Ancient Israel possessed detailed tithe regulations connected with its covenant system.

6. Tithes supported religious service, worship, and certain social responsibilities.

7. Malachi called Israel to covenant faithfulness concerning tithes and offerings.

8. Jesus referred to tithing while emphasizing justice, mercy, and faith.

9. The New Testament teaches generous Christian giving without explicitly imposing a universal ten-percent income requirement.

10. Seventh-day Adventist theology distinguishes the tithe from additional voluntary offerings.

11. Christian giving should be sincere, responsible, proportional, and free from manipulation.

12. The New Testament supports the material provision of Gospel ministry.

13. Biblical stewardship includes compassion and practical assistance to those in need.

14. Churches must manage donated resources with integrity and accountability.

15. Faithful stewardship is an expression of Christian discipleship and preparation for Christ's return.

Doctrinal Conclusion

The biblical doctrine of stewardship begins with the recognition that God is the Creator and ultimate Owner of everything.

Human beings receive life, abilities, opportunities, and material resources from Him.

They are called to manage these blessings with faithfulness, gratitude, wisdom, and love.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, stewardship includes several important dimensions.

Recognition of God's Ownership

Believers acknowledge that their lives and possessions ultimately depend upon the Creator.

Faithful Management of Resources

Christian responsibility extends to time, health, abilities, finances, and opportunities for service.

The Practice of Tithing

Seventh-day Adventist theology teaches that returning one-tenth of one's increase or income is an enduring expression of faithful stewardship.

This conclusion is based upon the denomination's interpretation of the biblical teaching concerning tithes.

Generosity Through Offerings and Service

Believers are encouraged to give voluntarily and compassionately according to their means.

Integrity and Accountability

Both individuals and religious institutions are responsible for managing resources honestly.

Preparation for the Return of Jesus Christ

Faithful stewardship expresses a life transformed by God's grace and devoted to His purposes.

However, financial giving must never be treated as a means of earning salvation.

Nor should the biblical teaching concerning tithes be used to promise automatic wealth, impose fear, or manipulate believers.

The New Testament emphasizes generosity, sincerity, responsibility, and love.

The ultimate purpose of Christian stewardship is to honor God and serve others.

The Essential Message:

God is the Creator and ultimate Owner of everything. Christian stewardship calls believers to manage faithfully the life and resources entrusted to them. In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, returning a tenth of one's increase or income is an important expression of this responsibility, while offerings and acts of generosity provide additional opportunities for service. All giving should be motivated by faith, gratitude, love, and integrity rather than fear or the desire to earn salvation.

Personal Reflection Questions

1. Do I recognize God as the ultimate Owner of my life and possessions?

2. How faithfully am I managing the time, abilities, and opportunities entrusted to me?

3. What does the Bible teach about the meaning and historical practice of tithing?

4. Do I understand the difference between the tithe regulations of ancient Israel and the teachings concerning Christian giving in the New Testament?

5. Have I carefully examined the biblical foundations of the Seventh-day Adventist understanding of tithing?

6. Am I giving with sincerity, gratitude, and love rather than fear or pressure?

7. Do my financial decisions reflect honesty, responsibility, and concern for my household?

8. How can I contribute more effectively to the support of Gospel ministry and assistance to those in need?

9. Do I value transparency and accountability in the management of church resources?

10. Does my stewardship reflect a life devoted to Jesus Christ and the hope of His return?

Suggested Prayer

Lord my God,

I come before You with gratitude and humility.

You are the Creator of heaven and earth.

Everything I possess ultimately comes from Your goodness.

Thank You for the gift of life, for the abilities You have entrusted to me, and for the opportunities You provide each day.

Forgive me for the times I have acted selfishly or failed to recognize Your blessings.

Teach me to become a faithful steward.

Help me manage my time wisely, use my abilities responsibly, and care for the resources placed in my hands.

Give me wisdom in my financial decisions.

Protect my heart from greed, dishonesty, pride, and the desire for material recognition.

Teach me to give with sincerity, gratitude, and love.

Help me understand Your Word faithfully and distinguish Your commandments from human traditions.

May my generosity reflect a genuine concern for Your work and for those who are suffering.

Bless the poor, the hungry, the vulnerable, and those experiencing financial hardship.

Give me a compassionate heart and a willingness to help according to my ability.

Guide those who administer resources entrusted to Your Church.

Grant them integrity, wisdom, transparency, and accountability.

Help me remember that salvation cannot be purchased through money or religious works.

My hope rests entirely upon the grace of Jesus Christ.

May my stewardship become an expression of faith, gratitude, and obedience.

Prepare me to remain faithful in the responsibilities You have entrusted to me.

Until the glorious return of Jesus Christ, help me live with generosity, contentment, wisdom, and complete dependence upon You.

In the name of Jesus Christ, my Savior and Lord.

Amen.

CHAPTER 25 — CHRISTIAN HEALTH AND TEMPERANCE: HOW SHOULD BELIEVERS CARE FOR THE BODY GOD HAS GIVEN THEM?

A Thematic Bible Study — King James Version (KJV)

Opening Scripture

> “What? know ye not that your body is the temple of the Holy Ghost which is in you, which ye have of God, and ye are not your own?”

1 Corinthians 6:19 — KJV

Introduction

In the preceding chapter, we examined Christian stewardship, tithes, offerings, and the responsible management of the resources entrusted to believers.

We discovered that everything ultimately belongs to God and that Christians are called to manage His blessings with faithfulness, wisdom, gratitude, and love.

However, stewardship involves more than material possessions.

It also concerns the human body, physical abilities, mental well-being, daily habits, and the choices that influence health.

The Holy Scriptures present human life as a gift from God.

The creation account describes humanity as formed by the Creator and endowed with life through His power.

The New Testament teaches that believers should glorify God in their bodies.

The apostle Paul also encourages Christians to practice self-control and to avoid conduct that brings them under destructive domination.

These teachings establish important principles for Christian living.

Nevertheless, questions concerning health and diet require careful biblical interpretation.

The Book of Genesis describes the food provided to humanity at creation.

Later, the Old Testament distinguishes between clean and unclean animals.

The Mosaic law contains detailed regulations concerning food, ceremonial purity, and the life of Israel.

The New Testament includes passages concerning food, Christian liberty, conscience, and the relationship between Jewish and Gentile believers.

Christians interpret some of these passages differently.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, the biblical principles of healthful living, temperance, and the distinction between clean and unclean animals remain important for Christian conduct.

Adventists also emphasize abstinence from alcoholic beverages, tobacco, and harmful drugs, together with responsible attention to nutrition, rest, exercise, and other health practices.

However, not every modern health recommendation is an explicit biblical command.

It is therefore necessary to distinguish between direct scriptural teaching, theological interpretation, and practical conclusions informed by scientific evidence.

This chapter examines fifteen questions concerning the biblical foundations of health, diet, temperance, and responsible care of the body.

Our purpose is to understand how Christians can honor God through their daily habits without confusing healthful living with the means of salvation.

Question 1 — What Does the Bible Teach About the Origin and Value of the Human Body?

Answer:

The Bible teaches that human life originates with God.

According to Genesis, God formed man from the dust of the ground and breathed into his nostrils the breath of life.

Humanity was created in the image of God.

This gives human life a dignity that cannot be measured merely by physical strength, appearance, health, or productivity.

The human body is not presented as an insignificant object to be neglected or despised.

It forms part of the life God has given.

The New Testament also teaches that the body has significance in God's redemptive purpose.

Paul emphasizes that the body is for the Lord and that believers are called to glorify God in their bodies.

The biblical hope of resurrection further demonstrates that God's purpose includes the restoration of embodied human life.

Therefore, care for the body is an appropriate expression of gratitude toward the Creator.

However, physical health does not determine a person's spiritual worth or standing before God.

Bible References:

- Genesis 1:26–27
- Genesis 2:7
- Psalm 139:13–16
- 1 Corinthians 6:12–20
- Romans 12:1–2
- 1 Corinthians 15:42–54

Doctrinal Note:

Seventh-day Adventist theology emphasizes the unity of human life rather than viewing the body as an unimportant container for an independently immortal soul. The broader biblical teaching concerning human nature and the state of the dead is addressed in the chapters devoted to those subjects.

Question 2 — What Does It Mean That the Body Is the Temple of the Holy Spirit?

Answer:

The apostle Paul teaches that the believer's body is the temple of the Holy Spirit.

This statement appears in a passage addressing sexual immorality and the Christian's relationship with Jesus Christ.

Paul explains that believers belong to God and have been purchased through the saving work of Christ.

Therefore, their bodies should be used in ways that honor Him.

The immediate context concerns moral conduct, particularly sexual behavior.

However, the broader principle of glorifying God through bodily life also has implications for responsible Christian living.

The body should not be treated carelessly or used in ways that deliberately promote destructive habits.

Christians are called to exercise self-control and recognize their responsibility before God.

Nevertheless, this passage should not be presented as though Paul were directly giving a modern medical program.

Its primary emphasis is the believer's belonging to Christ and the moral significance of bodily conduct.

Bible References:

- 1 Corinthians 3:16–17
- 1 Corinthians 6:12–20
- Romans 6:12–13
- Romans 12:1–2
- 2 Corinthians 6:16–18

Contextual Note:

First Corinthians 3:16–17 primarily concerns the Church collectively as God's temple, while 1 Corinthians 6:19 addresses the believer's body in the context of sexual morality. Both passages should be interpreted according to their respective settings.

Question 3 — What Food Did God Originally Provide for Humanity?

Answer:

The creation account describes God providing seed-bearing plants and fruit-bearing trees for human food.

Genesis 1:29 presents this provision within the original created order.

Following the entrance of sin, Genesis 3:18 also refers to the eating of the herb of the field.

These passages are important to the biblical understanding of humanity's relationship with food and the natural world.

In Seventh-day Adventist theology, the original plant-based provision is often regarded as an ideal model of nutrition.

It emphasizes the value of foods obtained from plants and encourages thoughtful consideration of diet.

However, the Genesis account does not provide a complete modern nutritional plan.

It also does not establish that every Christian must follow a strictly vegetarian diet.

Later biblical passages explicitly permit the consumption of animal flesh in certain circumstances.

Therefore, the creation account should be understood as revealing God's original provision without ignoring subsequent biblical developments.

Bible References:

- Genesis 1:26–30
- Genesis 2:8–17
- Genesis 3:17–19
- Genesis 9:1–4
- Psalm 104:14–15

Doctrinal Note:

The Seventh-day Adventist preference for a balanced vegetarian diet is a health and theological application of biblical principles. Vegetarianism itself is not presented in the New Testament as a universal condition of salvation or Christian membership.

Question 4 — Did God Permit Human Beings to Eat Meat After the Flood?

Answer:

Yes.

After the Flood, God told Noah that living creatures could serve as food, just as green plants had previously been given.

Genesis 9:3 records this permission.

However, the following verse prohibits the consumption of flesh with its blood.

The account therefore presents both permission and restriction.

It is also important to recognize that the distinction between clean and unclean animals appears earlier in the narrative of Noah.

Genesis 7 refers to clean animals and animals that were not clean.

This demonstrates that the terminology existed before the legislation recorded in Leviticus.

However, Genesis does not provide a complete explanation of how the distinction applied to human diet before the Mosaic covenant.

In Seventh-day Adventist interpretation, the pre-Flood distinction supports the view that clean and unclean categories were not merely a later invention of Israelite ceremonial law.

Other interpreters emphasize that the specific dietary regulations are developed explicitly within the Mosaic covenant.

Both the permission to eat meat and the existence of clean and unclean categories must be considered when examining the biblical evidence.

Bible References:

- Genesis 7:1–3
- Genesis 8:20
- Genesis 9:1–4
- Leviticus 11:1–47
- Deuteronomy 14:3–21

Explanatory Note:

The presence of clean and unclean animals in Genesis does not, by itself, specify every dietary obligation applicable to Noah. The relationship between these categories and Christian diet requires interpretation of the broader biblical record.

Question 5 — What Is the Biblical Distinction Between Clean and Unclean Animals?

Answer:

The Old Testament distinguishes between animals classified as clean and those classified as unclean.

Leviticus 11 and Deuteronomy 14 contain detailed instructions concerning these categories.

Among land animals, the permitted categories generally include animals that both divide the hoof and chew the cud.

For creatures living in water, the law identifies fins and scales as the relevant characteristics.

The passages also distinguish among birds and other creatures.

These regulations formed part of Israel's covenant life and contributed to its distinctive religious identity.

They should not be interpreted merely as an ancient medical textbook.

Their biblical significance includes holiness, obedience, and separation within the covenant community.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, the distinction between clean and unclean animals remains relevant to Christian dietary practice.

Adventists commonly avoid foods classified as unclean in Leviticus 11.

Other Christian traditions understand these regulations as belonging to the Mosaic covenant and no longer binding upon Christians in the same manner.

The disagreement must be examined through both the Old and New Testaments.

Bible References:

- Leviticus 11:1–47
- Deuteronomy 14:3–21
- Genesis 7:1–3
- Isaiah 66:15–17
- Acts 10:9–16

Doctrinal Note:

The continuing application of Leviticus 11 to Christians is a distinctive Adventist interpretation shared by some other religious communities. It is not the universally accepted Christian understanding of New Testament dietary teaching.

Question 6 — Did Jesus Declare All Foods Clean?

Answer:

The question arises particularly from Mark 7.

In this passage, Jesus responded to criticism concerning His disciples' eating with unwashed hands.

The dispute concerned ritual handwashing traditions and the source of moral defilement.

Jesus emphasized that evil thoughts and actions proceed from the human heart.

The interpretation of Mark 7:19 is debated.

Many modern translations understand the concluding phrase as indicating that Jesus declared all foods clean.

Other interpreters emphasize the immediate context of handwashing and understand the passage as addressing ceremonial defilement rather than abolishing the distinction between clean and unclean

animals.

The King James Version renders the relevant expression differently from many modern translations.

Matthew 15 records a parallel discussion and concludes by emphasizing that eating with unwashed hands does not defile a person.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, Mark 7 primarily addresses human traditions concerning ceremonial washing and does not repeal the dietary distinctions of Leviticus 11.

Other Christian traditions interpret the passage as contributing to the New Testament's broader teaching concerning freedom from Mosaic food regulations.

The passage should therefore be studied carefully in its literary and linguistic context.

Bible References:

- Mark 7:1–23
- Matthew 15:1–20
- Leviticus 11:1–47
- Romans 14:14–20
- Colossians 2:16–17

Textual and Interpretive Note:

The Greek construction in Mark 7:19 permits an important interpretive discussion concerning the phrase often translated as declaring all foods clean. A responsible study should acknowledge this debate rather than claim that the wording is entirely undisputed.

Question 7 — What Was the Meaning of Peter's Vision in Acts 10?

Answer:

Acts 10 records a vision in which Peter saw a vessel containing various kinds of animals.

A voice instructed him to rise, kill, and eat.

Peter objected that he had never eaten anything common or unclean.

The voice responded that what God had cleansed should not be called common.

The vision occurred in the context of God's direction for Peter to visit Cornelius, a Gentile.

Peter initially struggled to understand its meaning.

Later, he explained that God had shown him not to call any person common or unclean.

The narrative therefore explicitly connects the vision with the acceptance of Gentiles into the Christian community.

In Seventh-day Adventist interpretation, this explanation is central.

The vision is understood primarily as correcting prejudice against Gentiles rather than authorizing the consumption of every animal.

Other Christian interpreters regard the vision as also reflecting the removal of dietary barriers between Jewish and Gentile believers.

The text clearly establishes the inclusion of Gentiles.

Whether it also carries broader dietary implications is a matter of theological interpretation.

Bible References:

- Acts 10:1–48
- Acts 11:1–18
- Acts 15:1–29

- Galatians 2:11–16
- Ephesians 2:11–22

Contextual Note:

Peter's own explanation in Acts 10:28 must receive serious attention. At the same time, the broader New Testament discussion concerning food and fellowship should not be ignored.

Question 8 — What Do Paul and the Jerusalem Council Teach About Christian Diet?

Answer:

The New Testament contains several important passages concerning food and Christian liberty.

In Acts 15, the Jerusalem Council addressed the obligations of Gentile believers.

The council instructed them to abstain from certain practices, including things polluted by idols, blood, things strangled, and fornication.

The precise relationship of these instructions to the Mosaic law has been interpreted differently.

Paul also addressed disputes concerning food in Romans 14 and 1 Corinthians 8–10.

He emphasized conscience, love, and concern for other believers.

He warned Christians against using their freedom in ways that harmed others spiritually.

First Timothy 4 addresses teachings that forbid marriage and command abstinence from foods God created to be received with thanksgiving.

These passages must be considered together rather than isolated from their contexts.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, they do not remove the distinction between clean and unclean animals.

Other Christian traditions understand them as evidence that Mosaic dietary restrictions are not universally binding under the new covenant.

The New Testament clearly emphasizes that food should not become a basis for spiritual pride or contempt toward other believers.

Bible References:

- Acts 15:19–29
- Romans 14:1–23
- 1 Corinthians 8:1–13
- 1 Corinthians 10:23–33
- Colossians 2:16–23
- 1 Timothy 4:1–5

Doctrinal Note:

The application of these passages is debated among Christian traditions. The Adventist dietary position should be presented as a reasoned interpretation rather than as the only possible reading acknowledged by biblical scholarship.

Question 9 — What Does the Bible Teach About Alcoholic Beverages?

Answer:

The Bible contains both warnings concerning alcohol and passages in which wine appears in ordinary social or religious settings.

Proverbs strongly warns against drunkenness and the destructive consequences of excessive drinking.

The New Testament explicitly condemns drunkenness and calls believers to sobriety and self-control.

Paul instructs Christians not to become drunk with wine but to be filled with the Spirit.

However, Scripture does not use every reference to wine in the same manner.

Some passages describe wine positively, while others warn against its misuse.

Therefore, it would be inaccurate to claim that every biblical occurrence of wine necessarily refers to unfermented grape juice.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, complete abstinence from alcoholic beverages is recommended as the safest and most responsible expression of Christian temperance.

This position also reflects concerns about addiction, impaired judgment, and preventable harm.

Other Christian traditions distinguish between moderate consumption and drunkenness.

The explicit biblical condemnation of drunkenness should be distinguished from the Adventist conclusion that total abstinence is the appropriate Christian practice.

Bible References:

- Proverbs 20:1
- Proverbs 23:29–35
- Ecclesiastes 9:7
- John 2:1–11
- Romans 13:13–14
- 1 Corinthians 6:9–11
- Ephesians 5:18
- 1 Timothy 5:23

Doctrinal Note:

Seventh-day Adventist teaching advocates abstinence from alcoholic beverages. This position is supported by biblical principles of sobriety, self-control, and responsible care of the body, while recognizing that Christians differ in their interpretation of passages concerning moderate consumption.

Question 10 — What Principles Apply to Tobacco, Recreational Drugs, and Other Harmful Substances?

Answer:

The Bible does not directly name tobacco or many modern psychoactive substances.

These products were not part of the biblical writers' immediate historical setting in the forms familiar today.

However, Scripture provides principles relevant to their use.

Christians are called to exercise self-control.

They are also instructed not to become enslaved by destructive practices.

Paul teaches that believers should glorify God in their bodies.

These principles encourage serious consideration of substances that may cause addiction, impair judgment, or produce significant harm.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, abstinence from tobacco and recreational misuse of drugs is an important expression of Christian temperance.

However, the responsible medical use of prescribed medications must be distinguished from substance misuse.

A medication may be necessary for treatment even when it carries risks that require professional supervision.

Christians should avoid stigmatizing individuals struggling with addiction.

Such individuals need compassion, appropriate treatment, and practical support.

Bible References:

- Romans 6:12–14
- Romans 12:1–2
- 1 Corinthians 6:12–20
- 1 Corinthians 10:31
- Galatians 5:19–23
- 1 Peter 5:8

Practical Note:

Modern medical evidence is needed to evaluate the specific risks of tobacco, drugs, and other substances. Biblical principles guide moral responsibility but should not be misrepresented as direct scientific descriptions of products unknown to the biblical authors.

Question 11 — What Is Temperance, and Why Is Self-Control Important?

Answer:

Temperance refers to moderation, restraint, and responsible self-control.

The New Testament identifies temperance as part of the fruit of the Spirit.

It also encourages believers to exercise discipline in their conduct.

Paul compares the Christian life to athletic training, emphasizing purpose and self-control.

Temperance involves more than avoiding particular foods or beverages.

It includes responsible behavior in eating, drinking, work, recreation, speech, emotions, and personal relationships.

Christian self-control should be guided by love, wisdom, and dependence upon the Holy Spirit.

It should not become an excuse for harshness, excessive restriction, or judgment of others.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, temperance includes abstaining from harmful substances and using beneficial things wisely.

The objective is to preserve health, maintain clear judgment, and support faithful Christian service.

Bible References:

- Proverbs 25:16
- Proverbs 25:28
- 1 Corinthians 9:24–27
- Galatians 5:22–23
- Philippians 4:5
- Titus 2:11–12
- 2 Peter 1:5–8

Linguistic Note:

The Greek word enkrateia, commonly translated as temperance or self-control, conveys the idea of mastery over one's desires and conduct. It should not be reduced exclusively to dietary restriction.

Question 12 — What Does the Bible Teach About Rest, Work, and Physical Activity?

Answer:

The Bible presents work and rest as important aspects of human life.

The creation account describes God placing humanity in the garden to dress and keep it.

The fourth commandment establishes a weekly rhythm of work and Sabbath rest.

Jesus also recognized the need for His disciples to withdraw from their activities and rest.

These passages demonstrate that human life should not be characterized by unending labor.

Rest provides an opportunity for renewal, worship, and attention to relationships.

The Bible also encourages diligence and responsible activity.

Paul uses athletic training as an illustration of spiritual discipline.

However, Scripture does not prescribe a modern exercise program or specific daily sleep requirements.

Such recommendations must be informed by appropriate health knowledge.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, balanced work, adequate rest, regular physical activity, and Sabbath observance contribute to a responsible Christian lifestyle.

Bible References:

- Genesis 2:1–3
- Genesis 2:15
- Exodus 20:8–11
- Psalm 127:1–2
- Mark 6:30–32
- 1 Corinthians 9:24–27
- 1 Timothy 4:7–8

Practical Note:

Adequate sleep, appropriate physical activity, and reasonable work schedules are important health considerations. Their specific requirements vary according to age, health, disability, occupation, and individual circumstances.

Question 13 — What Relationship Does the Bible Establish Between Physical, Mental, and Spiritual Well-Being?

Answer:

The Holy Scriptures recognize that human life involves physical, emotional, relational, and spiritual experiences.

The Psalms frequently describe sorrow, fear, discouragement, joy, and hope.

Proverbs also recognizes relationships between emotional experience and bodily well-being.

Jesus demonstrated compassion toward people experiencing sickness, grief, and distress.

The New Testament encourages believers to pray, support one another, and bring their concerns before God.

However, the Bible does not teach that every illness results from personal sin.

Jesus explicitly challenged such an assumption in His encounter with a man born blind.

Christians should therefore avoid judging a person's spirituality according to physical or mental health.

Prayer and faith may provide comfort and spiritual strength, but they should not be used to discourage appropriate medical or psychological care.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, responsible health ministry recognizes the importance of caring for the whole person.

Bible References:

- Psalm 42:1–11
- Psalm 103:1–5
- Proverbs 17:22
- Isaiah 41:10

- John 9:1–3
- Matthew 11:28–30
- Philippians 4:6–9
- James 5:13–16

Doctrinal Note:

Spiritual well-being and medical health are related aspects of human experience, but they are not interchangeable. Illness should never automatically be interpreted as evidence of weak faith or divine punishment.

Question 14 — What Are the Biblical Foundations of the Seventh-day Adventist Health Message?

Answer:

The Seventh-day Adventist health message draws upon several biblical themes.

These include the creation of human life, God's original provision of plant foods, the distinction between clean and unclean animals, the importance of temperance, and the call to glorify God in the body.

Adventists also emphasize the relationship between physical well-being and Christian service.

Historically, the denomination developed health institutions, educational programs, and lifestyle recommendations as part of its religious mission.

The Adventist health emphasis commonly includes nutritious food, physical activity, rest, abstinence from tobacco and alcohol, and responsible attention to mental and spiritual well-being.

Some Adventists practice vegetarianism, while others consume meat considered clean under their interpretation of biblical dietary laws.

It is important to distinguish the different foundations of these practices.

Some are based upon direct biblical teachings.

Others are theological applications of scriptural principles.

Still others depend upon medical and scientific evidence.

The writings of Ellen G. White also played an important historical role in the development of Adventist health teaching.

However, her writings should not be treated as replacements for the Bible or for responsible medical investigation.

Bible References:

- Genesis 1:29
- Genesis 7:1–3
- Leviticus 11:1–47
- Daniel 1:8–20
- Romans 12:1–2
- 1 Corinthians 6:19–20
- 1 Corinthians 10:31
- Galatians 5:22–23

Historical and Doctrinal Note:

The Adventist health message developed within a particular nineteenth-century religious and health-reform context. Claims concerning the medical benefits of specific practices or the historical role of Ellen G. White should be verified through reliable documentary and scientific sources before publication.

Question 15 — How Does Healthful Living Relate to Salvation and Preparation for Christ's Return?

Answer:

The New Testament teaches that salvation is received through God's grace by faith in Jesus Christ.

It is not earned through dietary restrictions, physical fitness, or personal health achievements.

However, the grace of God also calls believers to live responsibly.

Paul teaches that Christians should glorify God in whatever they do, including eating and drinking.

He also encourages believers to present their bodies as living sacrifices.

These principles indicate that daily habits may become expressions of faith and gratitude.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, healthful living supports Christian service and helps believers exercise responsible stewardship.

The denomination also connects temperance and spiritual vigilance with preparation for the return of Jesus Christ.

Nevertheless, physical health must not be confused with spiritual perfection.

A believer may experience serious illness despite living responsibly.

Likewise, a person with excellent physical health is not necessarily spiritually mature.

The Christian's hope rests upon the saving work of Jesus Christ.

Healthful living is therefore an expression of discipleship rather than a condition by which salvation is purchased.

Bible References:

- Romans 12:1–2
- Romans 14:17
- 1 Corinthians 6:19–20
- 1 Corinthians 10:31
- Ephesians 2:8–10

- Titus 2:11–14
- 1 Thessalonians 5:23–24
- Revelation 14:12

Doctrinal Note:

Christian health principles should be taught with compassion and balance. They must not be used to shame people because of illness, disability, body size, poverty, or circumstances beyond their control.

Chapter Summary

The Holy Scriptures present human life as a gift from God.

The body possesses dignity because humanity was created by the Creator and believers are called to glorify Him through their lives.

The Bible also contains teachings concerning food, temperance, self-control, and responsible conduct.

Some dietary instructions belong explicitly to the covenant life of ancient Israel.

Their application to Christians is interpreted differently among Christian traditions.

Seventh-day Adventist theology emphasizes healthful living as an important expression of stewardship and Christian discipleship.

Our study enables us to retain the following teachings:

1. Human life originates with God and possesses inherent dignity.

2. The believer's body belongs to God and should be used to glorify Him.

3. Genesis describes plant foods as God's original provision for humanity.

4. God permitted the consumption of meat after the Flood, while the narrative also recognizes clean and unclean animals.

5. The Mosaic law established detailed distinctions between clean and unclean animals.

6. Jesus' teaching in Mark 7 must be examined in the context of ceremonial handwashing and moral defilement.

7. Peter's vision in Acts 10 explicitly concerns the acceptance of Gentiles.

8. The New Testament emphasizes Christian liberty, conscience, love, and responsible conduct concerning food.

9. Scripture condemns drunkenness, while Seventh-day Adventist theology advocates complete abstinence from alcoholic beverages.

10. Biblical principles of self-control and responsible bodily care are relevant to tobacco and harmful substance use.

11. Temperance involves responsible self-control in every area of life.

12. Work, rest, and appropriate physical activity contribute to balanced Christian living.

13. Physical, emotional, and spiritual well-being deserve compassionate attention.

14. The Adventist health message combines biblical principles, theological interpretation, historical developments, and health knowledge.

15. Healthful living is an expression of Christian stewardship, not a means of earning salvation.

Doctrinal Conclusion

The biblical teaching concerning health begins with the recognition that human life is a gift from God.

The Creator formed humanity and entrusted human beings with responsibilities concerning their lives and the world around them.

The New Testament calls believers to glorify God in their bodies.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, Christian health and temperance involve several important dimensions.

Respect for the Gift of Life

Human life possesses dignity because it originates with God.

Believers should therefore treat themselves and others with respect and compassion.

Responsible Care of the Body

Christians are encouraged to develop habits that support physical, mental, and spiritual well-being.

Biblical Principles of Diet

Seventh-day Adventist theology maintains the relevance of the distinction between clean and unclean animals and encourages a balanced, nutritious diet.

This interpretation should be distinguished from the dietary positions held by other Christian traditions.

Temperance and Self-Control

Believers are called to exercise self-control and avoid practices that promote destructive dependence or unnecessary harm.

Balanced Christian Living

Work, rest, physical activity, worship, relationships, and service should be approached responsibly.

Health as an Expression of Stewardship

Care for the body is an expression of gratitude toward God rather than a means of earning divine acceptance.

Compassion Toward Those Who Suffer

Christians must not assume that illness, disability, or mental distress demonstrates spiritual failure.

The Church is called to provide encouragement, practical assistance, and compassionate support.

The Adventist health message should therefore be presented as an invitation to responsible Christian living.

It should not become a system of condemnation or spiritual superiority.

The Essential Message:

God is the Creator and Giver of human life. Christians are called to honor Him through responsible care of the body, temperance, and wise daily choices. Seventh-day Adventist theology emphasizes biblical dietary distinctions, abstinence from harmful substances, and balanced health practices as expressions of stewardship. However, healthful living does not earn salvation. The believer's hope remains entirely in the grace and saving work of Jesus Christ.

Personal Reflection Questions

1. Do I recognize my body and life as gifts entrusted to me by God?

2. How does the biblical teaching concerning the body as the temple of the Holy Spirit influence my daily decisions?

3. What does the creation account teach about God's original provision of food?

4. Have I carefully examined the biblical distinction between clean and unclean animals?

5. Do I understand the different Christian interpretations of Mark 7, Acts 10, and Romans 14?

6. How can I practice temperance and self-control without becoming judgmental toward others?

7. Are there habits in my life that may be harmful or unnecessarily controlling?

8. Am I maintaining a responsible balance between work, rest, worship, relationships, and physical activity?

9. Do I show compassion toward individuals experiencing illness, disability, addiction, or emotional distress?

10. Does my approach to health reflect gratitude toward God while preserving my confidence in salvation through Jesus Christ alone?

Suggested Prayer

Lord my God,

I come before You with gratitude and humility.

You are the Creator of heaven and earth and the Giver of every good gift.

Thank You for the life You have entrusted to me.

Thank You for my body, my mind, my abilities, and the opportunities You provide each day.

Help me recognize that my life belongs to You.

Teach me to care responsibly for the body You have given me.

Give me wisdom in my choices concerning food, rest, work, recreation, and daily habits.

Help me practice temperance and self-control.

Protect me from destructive habits and from anything that may bring me under harmful domination.

Guide me toward decisions that support my well-being and strengthen my ability to serve others.

Teach me to understand Your Holy Word faithfully.

Help me distinguish Your revealed commandments from human traditions and personal opinions.

Remove pride, harshness, and judgment from my heart.

May I never measure the spiritual worth of another person by physical appearance, health, or dietary practice.

Give me compassion for those who are sick, discouraged, struggling with addiction, or living with disabilities.

Bless those who provide medical care and support to people in need.

Grant them wisdom, patience, and integrity.

When I experience weakness or illness, help me seek appropriate care and remain confident in Your love.

Teach me to use my strength, time, and abilities for Your glory.

Above all, help me remember that my salvation rests upon Jesus Christ.

I cannot earn Your grace through my own efforts.

May every good choice become an expression of gratitude and faith rather than an attempt to purchase Your favor.

Prepare me for the glorious return of Jesus Christ.

Until that day, help me live with wisdom, moderation, compassion, and complete dependence upon You.

In the name of Jesus Christ, my Savior and Lord.

Amen.

CHAPTER 26 — CHRISTIAN LIFESTYLE AND MORAL CONDUCT: HOW SHOULD FOLLOWERS OF JESUS CHRIST LIVE IN THE WORLD?

A Thematic Bible Study — King James Version (KJV)

Opening Scripture

> “Whether therefore ye eat, or drink, or whatsoever ye do, do all to the glory of God.”

1 Corinthians 10:31 — KJV

Introduction

In the preceding chapters, we examined sanctification, Christian stewardship, and the biblical principles of health and temperance.

We discovered that the saving grace of God transforms not only religious beliefs but also the believer's daily conduct.

The Christian life is therefore more than an intellectual acceptance of biblical doctrines.

It involves a continuing relationship with Jesus Christ that influences thoughts, attitudes, relationships, responsibilities, and personal decisions.

The Holy Scriptures repeatedly call believers to live in a manner worthy of the Gospel.

Jesus taught His disciples to love God with all their hearts and to love their neighbors as themselves.

The apostle Paul encouraged Christians to present their bodies as living sacrifices and to be transformed by the renewing of their minds.

The apostle Peter likewise called believers to holiness in their conduct.

These teachings demonstrate that Christian discipleship affects every dimension of life.

However, important questions arise.

How should Christians relate to the surrounding world? What does biblical modesty mean? How should believers approach entertainment, clothing, speech, and personal appearance? What principles govern marriage and family life? How should Christians respond to conflict, injustice, and mistreatment? What responsibilities do believers have in their workplaces and communities?

These questions require careful examination.

Some biblical instructions address universal moral principles.

Others concern particular cultural circumstances within the ancient world.

A responsible study must distinguish between the enduring teaching of Scripture and applications shaped by history, culture, and denominational practice.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, Christian lifestyle is an expression of sanctification and faithfulness to Jesus Christ.

The Church encourages modesty, temperance, integrity, responsible recreation, purity, and respect for the dignity of others.

However, outward religious practices must never replace genuine faith, love, humility, and obedience.

This chapter examines fifteen questions concerning Christian lifestyle, moral conduct, family relationships, and responsibility toward society.

Our objective is to understand how followers of Jesus Christ may live faithfully in the world while reflecting His character through love,

truth, holiness, and service.

Question 1 — What Does It Mean to Live as a Disciple of Jesus Christ?

Answer:

A disciple of Jesus Christ is a person who follows Him, learns from His teachings, and seeks to live according to His example.

Jesus called His followers to deny themselves, take up their cross, and follow Him.

This invitation involves more than outward religious identification.

It requires faith, repentance, obedience, and a willingness to place Christ above competing loyalties.

The New Testament teaches that believers should walk as Jesus walked.

Christian discipleship therefore influences attitudes, choices, relationships, and responsibilities.

However, discipleship is not a means of earning salvation.

It is the response of faith to the grace of God.

The Holy Spirit enables believers to grow in love, humility, and obedience.

Bible References:

- Matthew 4:18–22
- Matthew 16:24–26
- Luke 9:23–25
- John 8:31–32
- John 13:34–35
- Romans 12:1–2
- 1 John 2:3–6

Doctrinal Note:

Christian discipleship involves a continuing relationship with Jesus Christ. Religious membership, outward conformity, or knowledge of doctrine cannot substitute for genuine faith and spiritual transformation.

Question 2 — How Should Christians Relate to the World Around Them?

Answer:

Jesus taught that His followers live in the world but do not belong to its rebellious system of values.

He prayed that His disciples would be protected from evil while remaining present in the world.

Christians are therefore not called to withdraw completely from society.

They are called to demonstrate God's character within it.

Jesus described His followers as the salt of the earth and the light of the world.

These images emphasize positive influence, moral integrity, and faithful witness.

The apostle Paul also instructed believers not to be conformed to the world but to be transformed by the renewing of their minds.

In this context, worldliness concerns attitudes and practices opposed to God's will.

It should not be reduced merely to differences in clothing, language, culture, or social customs.

Christian separation from evil must be accompanied by love and concern for other people.

Bible References:

- Matthew 5:13–16
- John 17:14–18
- Romans 12:1–2
- 1 Corinthians 5:9–13
- Philippians 2:14–16
- James 4:4
- 1 John 2:15–17

Explanatory Note:

Biblical warnings concerning the world should not be interpreted as commands to reject all cultural activities or avoid meaningful relationships with people who hold different beliefs.

Question 3 — What Principles Should Guide Christian Thoughts and Attitudes?

Answer:

The Bible teaches that moral conduct begins within the heart and mind.

Jesus explained that evil thoughts and actions proceed from within a person.

The apostle Paul encouraged believers to focus upon things that are true, honest, just, pure, lovely, and worthy of praise.

He also taught that Christians should develop the mind of Christ.

These passages emphasize the importance of spiritual discernment.

Christian growth involves examining motives, desires, attitudes, and patterns of thought.

Believers are called to reject hatred, envy, pride, bitterness, and selfish ambition.

They should cultivate humility, gratitude, compassion, and truthfulness.

However, experiencing an unwanted thought is not necessarily equivalent to deliberately choosing sin.

Christian responsibility involves how a person responds to thoughts and desires.

Bible References:

- Proverbs 4:23
- Matthew 5:21–28
- Matthew 15:18–20
- Romans 12:2
- 2 Corinthians 10:4–5
- Philippians 2:1–8
- Philippians 4:8–9
- Colossians 3:1–10

Practical Note:

Spiritual growth should not be confused with the expectation that believers will never experience intrusive thoughts, emotional distress, or mental health difficulties. Such experiences require understanding rather than condemnation.

Question 4 — What Does the Bible Teach About Christian Speech?

Answer:

The Holy Scriptures repeatedly emphasize the moral importance of words.

Jesus taught that human speech reveals the condition of the heart.

The apostle Paul instructed believers to avoid corrupt communication and speak words that contribute to the good of others.

James warned about the destructive power of the tongue.

Christian speech should therefore be characterized by honesty, kindness, wisdom, and self-control.

Believers should avoid slander, malicious gossip, deliberate deception, and unnecessary cruelty.

They are also called to speak truth with love.

However, kindness does not require silence in the presence of injustice or wrongdoing.

Christians may need to speak firmly when defending truth or protecting vulnerable people.

The biblical objective is speech that reflects both righteousness and compassion.

Bible References:

- Proverbs 12:18–22
- Proverbs 15:1–4
- Matthew 12:33–37
- Ephesians 4:25–32
- Colossians 4:5–6
- James 1:19–20
- James 3:1–12

Doctrinal Note:

Christian speech should not be evaluated merely by outward politeness. Truthfulness, justice, compassion, and responsible correction are also essential biblical principles.

Question 5 — What Does the Bible Teach About Modesty and Personal Appearance?

Answer:

The New Testament encourages believers to approach personal appearance with modesty, humility, and good judgment.

Paul instructed Christian women concerning modest apparel and emphasized good works.

Peter likewise encouraged an emphasis upon the inward character rather than excessive dependence upon outward adornment.

These passages arose within particular cultural settings and should be interpreted carefully.

Their enduring principles include humility, propriety, self-respect, and the priority of spiritual character.

The Bible does not provide a universal list of approved clothing styles for every culture and historical period.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, modesty is an important aspect of Christian lifestyle.

Adventist teaching has traditionally encouraged simplicity and restraint concerning clothing and personal adornment.

However, Christians differ concerning the application of passages about jewelry and ornamentation.

The essential biblical principle is that outward appearance should not become an expression of vanity, exploitation, or spiritual pride.

Bible References:

- 1 Samuel 16:7
- Proverbs 31:25–30
- 1 Timothy 2:9–10
- 1 Peter 3:1–5
- Romans 12:1–2

- 1 Corinthians 10:31

Doctrinal Note:

The Adventist emphasis on simplicity in dress and adornment represents an application of biblical principles. Specific rules concerning jewelry, cosmetics, or clothing styles should not be presented as explicit universal commands when the relevant passages do not establish them directly.

Question 6 — How Should Christians Choose Entertainment and Recreation?

Answer:

The Bible does not provide a detailed list of modern forms of entertainment.

However, it establishes principles that can guide Christian decisions.

Paul encouraged believers to focus upon what is true, pure, just, and worthy of praise.

He also taught that not everything permissible is beneficial.

Christian recreation should therefore be evaluated according to its influence upon character, relationships, responsibilities, and spiritual life.

Believers should consider whether an activity encourages cruelty, dishonesty, exploitation, destructive dependence, or other conduct contrary to biblical principles.

They should also recognize the legitimate value of rest, creativity, recreation, and healthy enjoyment.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, entertainment choices should support spiritual growth and responsible living.

However, personal preferences should not automatically be elevated to the status of divine commandments.

The Christian objective is to exercise discernment and glorify God through daily choices.

Bible References:

- Ecclesiastes 3:1–13
- Romans 12:1–2
- 1 Corinthians 6:12
- 1 Corinthians 10:23–31
- Philippians 4:8
- Colossians 3:17
- 1 Thessalonians 5:21–22

Practical Note:

The evaluation of entertainment should consider content, context, duration, personal vulnerability, and responsibilities. Different activities may have different effects upon different individuals.

Question 7 — What Does the Bible Teach About Marriage?

Answer:

The Bible presents marriage as a significant relationship involving commitment, faithfulness, and mutual responsibility.

Genesis describes the union of a man and a woman who become one flesh.

Jesus referred to this creation account when teaching concerning marriage.

The New Testament calls spouses to love, respect, and faithfulness.

Paul describes marital love in terms of Christ's self-giving love for the Church.

Marriage should therefore be characterized by care, trust, honesty, and responsibility.

It must not become an excuse for domination, cruelty, or abuse.

The New Testament also recognizes singleness as a legitimate Christian calling.

Marriage is not a requirement for salvation or spiritual maturity.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, marriage is a lifelong covenant established by God and intended to reflect love, fidelity, and mutual support.

Bible References:

- Genesis 2:18–24
- Matthew 19:3–9
- Mark 10:6–9
- 1 Corinthians 7:1–16
- Ephesians 5:21–33
- Colossians 3:18–19
- Hebrews 13:4

Doctrinal Note:

Christian traditions differ concerning divorce, remarriage, and certain aspects of marriage theology. The biblical teaching must be examined with attention to context and pastoral sensitivity, especially where abuse or serious harm is involved.

Question 8 — What Responsibilities Do Parents and Children Have Toward One Another?

Answer:

The Bible emphasizes love, respect, instruction, and responsibility within family relationships.

The fifth commandment instructs children to honor their father and mother.

The New Testament repeats this principle.

However, Scripture also places responsibilities upon parents.

Paul instructs fathers not to provoke their children to wrath but to nurture them in the instruction of the Lord.

Christian parenting should therefore involve guidance, patience, encouragement, and appropriate discipline.

It should not be characterized by cruelty, humiliation, or neglect.

Children are called to show respect and respond responsibly to parental instruction.

Nevertheless, honoring parents does not require participation in wrongdoing or submission to abuse.

Family relationships should reflect the dignity of every person.

Bible References:

- Exodus 20:12
- Deuteronomy 6:4–9
- Proverbs 22:6
- Ephesians 6:1–4
- Colossians 3:20–21
- 2 Timothy 1:5
- 2 Timothy 3:14–15

Practical Note:

Biblical family teaching must never be used to justify physical, emotional, or sexual abuse. Protecting children and vulnerable family members is consistent with the biblical principles of justice and love.

Question 9 — What Does the Bible Teach About Sexual Purity?

Answer:

The Holy Scriptures present sexual conduct as an important aspect of moral responsibility.

The Old and New Testaments contain teachings concerning marriage, fidelity, adultery, and sexual immorality.

Jesus emphasized that moral responsibility includes not only outward actions but also the intentions of the heart.

Paul instructed believers to avoid sexual immorality and honor God in their bodies.

Christian sexual ethics therefore involves faithfulness, respect, self-control, and responsibility.

Sexual relationships must never involve coercion, exploitation, or abuse.

The Bible also teaches that believers who have sinned may receive forgiveness and restoration through Jesus Christ.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, sexual intimacy belongs within the marriage covenant.

Other Christian traditions differ concerning certain applications of biblical sexual ethics.

The study of this subject should preserve both doctrinal clarity and compassion toward individuals.

Bible References:

- Genesis 2:24
- Exodus 20:14
- Matthew 5:27–30
- Matthew 19:4–6
- 1 Corinthians 6:12–20
- 1 Corinthians 7:1–9
- 1 Thessalonians 4:3–8
- Hebrews 13:4

Doctrinal Note:

Christian moral teaching must not be used to humiliate people or deny their dignity. Repentance, forgiveness, pastoral care, and protection from abuse remain essential biblical responsibilities.

Question 10 — How Should Christians Respond to Conflict, Anger, and Mistreatment?

Answer:

Jesus taught His followers to pursue reconciliation and love their enemies.

He warned against hatred and destructive anger.

The apostle Paul instructed believers not to repay evil for evil.

He also encouraged them to live peaceably with others whenever possible.

However, the Bible does not teach that victims must remain in dangerous circumstances or tolerate ongoing abuse.

Forgiveness and reconciliation are related but distinct.

Forgiveness may involve releasing personal vengeance.

Reconciliation ordinarily requires truthfulness, repentance, accountability, and appropriate changes in behavior.

Christian peacemaking should therefore be guided by justice, wisdom, and compassion.

Believers are called to avoid revenge while also protecting themselves and others from harm.

Bible References:

- Matthew 5:21–26
- Matthew 5:38–48
- Matthew 18:15–17
- Romans 12:17–21

- Ephesians 4:26–32
- Colossians 3:12–15
- James 1:19–20

Practical Note:

Biblical forgiveness should never be used to pressure a person to return to an abusive relationship or abandon appropriate legal and protective measures.

Question 11 — What Responsibilities Do Christians Have in Their Work and Financial Conduct?

Answer:

The Bible teaches that work should be approached with diligence, honesty, and responsibility.

The apostle Paul encouraged believers to perform their responsibilities sincerely, as serving the Lord.

The Scriptures also condemn dishonest business practices and exploitation.

Christian conduct in the workplace should therefore reflect integrity, fairness, and respect.

Believers should avoid theft, deception, corruption, and deliberate mistreatment of others.

Employers and those exercising authority have responsibilities toward workers.

The New Testament warns against unjust treatment and calls for fairness.

Christian stewardship also includes responsible management of income and resources.

However, the Bible does not teach that financial prosperity necessarily demonstrates divine approval.

Faithfulness may be expressed in many different economic circumstances.

Bible References:

- Proverbs 11:1
- Proverbs 16:11
- Proverbs 22:29
- Ephesians 4:28
- Ephesians 6:5–9
- Colossians 3:22–25
- Colossians 4:1
- James 5:1–6

Doctrinal Note:

Biblical instructions addressed to servants and masters arose within ancient social structures. They must not be used to justify slavery, exploitation, or the denial of fundamental human dignity.

Question 12 — How Should Christians Treat People Who Hold Different Beliefs?

Answer:

Jesus instructed His followers to love their neighbors.

He also taught them to love their enemies and pray for those who mistreated them.

The New Testament encourages believers to demonstrate gentleness, patience, and respect.

Peter instructed Christians to explain their hope with meekness and reverence.

These principles apply to relationships with people who hold different religious convictions.

Christians may firmly believe that certain teachings are true while recognizing the dignity and freedom of conscience of others.

The Gospel should be proclaimed through persuasion, faithful witness, and love rather than coercion.

Religious disagreement does not justify hatred, discrimination, or mistreatment.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, religious liberty is an important expression of the principle that faith must involve a free response to God.

Bible References:

- Matthew 5:43–48
- Matthew 7:12
- Luke 10:25–37
- Romans 12:14–21
- Colossians 4:5–6
- 1 Peter 3:15–16
- 1 John 4:7–21

Doctrinal Note:

Respect for freedom of conscience does not require Christians to abandon their convictions. It requires them to communicate those convictions without coercion or contempt.

Question 13 — What Does the Bible Teach About Christians and Civil Authorities?

Answer:

The New Testament teaches that Christians should generally respect legitimate civil authority and contribute responsibly to society.

Paul instructed believers to be subject to governing authorities.

Peter also encouraged respect for lawful institutions.

However, Scripture establishes an important limitation.

When human authorities command actions contrary to God's revealed will, believers must remain faithful to God.

The apostles expressed this principle when they declared that they ought to obey God rather than men.

Christian responsibility therefore includes respect for law, concern for justice, and obedience to conscience informed by Scripture.

Believers should avoid using religion as an excuse for dishonesty, violence, or unnecessary disorder.

At the same time, biblical faithfulness may require peaceful resistance to unjust demands.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, the relationship between religious liberty and civil authority becomes especially significant in the interpretation of end-time prophecy.

Bible References:

- Daniel 3:1–30
- Daniel 6:1–28
- Matthew 22:15–22
- Acts 4:18–20
- Acts 5:27–29
- Romans 13:1–7
- 1 Peter 2:13–17

Doctrinal Note:

Biblical submission to civil authority is not unlimited. The examples of Daniel and the apostles demonstrate that obedience to God may take precedence when authorities demand conduct contrary to divine commandments.

Question 14 — How Can Christians Practice Love, Justice, and Compassion in Society?

Answer:

The Bible repeatedly calls God's people to demonstrate justice and compassion.

The prophets condemned oppression, dishonesty, and neglect of vulnerable people.

Jesus identified love for God and neighbor as central commandments.

He also taught that acts of compassion toward those in need possess great moral significance.

The early Christian Church provided assistance to members experiencing hardship.

James emphasized that genuine religion includes care for orphans and widows.

Christian faith therefore has social implications.

Believers are called to assist those who suffer, defend human dignity, and act with integrity.

However, Christian compassion should not be reduced to political identification or institutional programs.

Its foundation is the character and teaching of Jesus Christ.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, service to humanity is an important part of the Church's mission.

Bible References:

- Isaiah 1:16–17
- Isaiah 58:6–10
- Micah 6:8
- Matthew 22:36–40
- Matthew 25:31–46

- Luke 10:25–37
- Acts 4:32–35
- James 1:26–27

Explanatory Note:

Biblical justice includes concern for honesty, fairness, protection of vulnerable people, and opposition to oppression. Christians may differ concerning particular social policies while sharing these moral responsibilities.

Question 15 — How Does Christian Lifestyle Prepare Believers for the Return of Jesus Christ?

Answer:

The New Testament connects Christian conduct with the hope of Christ's return.

Jesus instructed His disciples to remain watchful and faithful.

The apostle Paul encouraged believers to live soberly, righteously, and godly while awaiting the blessed hope.

Peter likewise called Christians to holiness and godliness as they anticipated the fulfillment of God's promises.

These passages demonstrate that the expectation of Christ's return should influence daily life.

However, Christian preparation is not merely a matter of outward religious conformity.

It involves faith in Jesus Christ, dependence upon the Holy Spirit, love, obedience, and perseverance.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, the final generation of believers is called to demonstrate faithfulness to God's commandments and faith in Jesus.

This conviction is connected with the prophetic messages of Revelation.

Nevertheless, Christian lifestyle must not be treated as a means of earning salvation.

The believer's hope remains in the grace and righteousness of Jesus Christ.

A faithful Christian life is the fruit of that saving relationship.

Bible References:

- Matthew 24:42–51
- Matthew 25:31–46
- Romans 13:11–14
- Titus 2:11–14
- 1 Peter 1:13–16
- 2 Peter 3:11–14
- Revelation 12:11
- Revelation 14:12

Doctrinal Note:

Adventist teachings concerning end-time faithfulness should remain centered upon Jesus Christ. External lifestyle practices do not automatically establish a person's spiritual condition or guarantee salvation.

Chapter Summary

Christian lifestyle is an expression of faith in Jesus Christ and the transforming work of the Holy Spirit.

The Bible teaches that believers are called to live in a manner consistent with the Gospel.

This calling influences thoughts, speech, relationships, work, recreation, and responsibility toward society.

However, Christian conduct must remain grounded in grace rather than legalism.

Our study enables us to retain the following teachings:

1. Christian discipleship involves following Jesus Christ through faith, obedience, and spiritual growth.

2. Believers are called to live in the world without adopting values contrary to God's will.

3. Christian transformation begins with the renewal of thoughts, motives, and attitudes.

4. Speech should reflect truthfulness, kindness, wisdom, and self-control.

5. Biblical modesty emphasizes humility, propriety, and the priority of spiritual character.

6. Entertainment and recreation should be evaluated according to their influence upon Christian life.

7. Marriage involves commitment, faithfulness, love, and mutual responsibility.

8. Parents and children are called to relationships characterized by respect, guidance, and care.

9. Christian sexual ethics emphasizes faithfulness, purity, responsibility, and respect for human dignity.

10. Believers should pursue peace and forgiveness while maintaining justice and appropriate protection from harm.

11. Christian work and financial conduct should demonstrate honesty, diligence, and fairness.

12. Followers of Jesus Christ should respect people who hold different religious convictions.

13. Christians are called to respect legitimate civil authority while remaining faithful to God.

14. Biblical love includes justice, compassion, and practical assistance to those in need.

15. Christian lifestyle is connected with preparation for Christ's return but does not earn salvation.

Doctrinal Conclusion

The Christian life is not limited to worship services, doctrinal knowledge, or religious identification.

The Holy Scriptures teach that genuine faith influences the whole person.

Thoughts, attitudes, relationships, conduct, and responsibilities are all affected by the transforming grace of God.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, Christian lifestyle includes several essential dimensions.

A Life Centered Upon Jesus Christ

Believers are called to follow the teachings and example of the Savior.

Transformation Through the Holy Spirit

Christian character develops through the continuing work of divine grace.

Holiness in Daily Conduct

Faith should influence speech, relationships, work, recreation, and personal decisions.

Modesty and Temperance

Christians are encouraged to exercise humility, self-control, and responsible judgment.

Faithfulness in Marriage and Family Life

Relationships should reflect love, respect, responsibility, and protection of human dignity.

Compassion and Justice

Believers are called to demonstrate practical concern for others and oppose mistreatment.

Respect for Freedom of Conscience

Christian witness should be characterized by persuasion, truth, and love rather than coercion.

Preparation for Christ's Return

The hope of the Second Coming encourages believers to live faithfully while remaining dependent upon Jesus Christ.

However, Christian lifestyle must never become a system of spiritual superiority.

The believer's acceptance before God rests upon divine grace.

Good works and faithful conduct are the fruit of genuine faith, not the price of salvation.

The Essential Message:

Christian lifestyle is the practical expression of a living relationship with Jesus Christ. Through the Holy Spirit, believers are called to demonstrate holiness, love, honesty, modesty, self-control, compassion, and responsibility in every area of life. Seventh-day Adventist theology emphasizes these principles as part of Christian discipleship and preparation for Christ's return. Yet salvation remains entirely a gift of God's grace through faith in Jesus Christ.

Personal Reflection Questions

1. Does my daily conduct reflect a genuine relationship with Jesus Christ?

2. How are my thoughts and attitudes being transformed through the Holy Spirit?

3. Do my words demonstrate truthfulness, kindness, and self-control?

4. Am I allowing biblical principles to guide my choices concerning appearance, entertainment, and recreation?

5. Do my family relationships reflect love, respect, patience, and responsibility?

6. How do I respond to conflict, criticism, and mistreatment?

7. Does my conduct at work or in financial matters demonstrate honesty and integrity?

8. Do I respect the dignity and freedom of conscience of people who hold different beliefs?

9. Am I demonstrating compassion toward those who are suffering or experiencing injustice?

10. Does the hope of Jesus Christ's return inspire me to live faithfully while trusting completely in His grace?

Suggested Prayer

Lord my God,

I come before You with gratitude, humility, and faith.

Thank You for the gift of salvation through Jesus Christ.

Thank You for calling me to follow Him and live according to Your Holy Word.

I recognize that my faith should influence every area of my life.

Transform my thoughts, attitudes, words, and actions through the power of Your Holy Spirit.

Teach me to love You with all my heart and to love my neighbor as myself.

Remove pride, selfishness, jealousy, bitterness, and dishonesty from my heart.

Give me wisdom in my daily decisions.

Help me choose what is good, honorable, and pleasing to You.

Guide my speech so that my words may encourage, comfort, and strengthen others.

Teach me to practice modesty, temperance, humility, and self-control.

Bless my family relationships.

Help me demonstrate patience, respect, faithfulness, and genuine love.

When conflict arises, give me wisdom to seek peace without abandoning truth or justice.

Protect me from the desire for revenge.

Teach me to forgive while exercising responsible judgment.

Help me remain honest in my work and faithful in my responsibilities.

Give me compassion for those who are poor, discouraged, oppressed, or suffering.

May I never use religion as an excuse for pride, discrimination, or mistreatment.

Teach me to respect the dignity and freedom of conscience of every person.

Strengthen my courage to remain faithful to Your commandments when I face opposition.

Above all, keep my heart centered upon Jesus Christ.

I acknowledge that I cannot earn salvation through my own conduct.

My hope rests entirely upon Your grace and the righteousness of my Savior.

Prepare me for the glorious return of Jesus Christ.

Until that day, help me live with holiness, love, wisdom, compassion, and complete dependence upon You.

In the name of Jesus Christ, my Savior and Lord.

Amen.

CHAPTER 27 — MISSION AND EVANGELISM: WHY AND HOW SHOULD WE PROCLAIM THE GOSPEL TO THE WORLD?

A Thematic Bible Study — King James Version (KJV)

Opening Scripture

> “And he said unto them, Go ye into all the world, and preach the gospel to every creature.”

Mark 16:15 — KJV

Introduction

In the preceding chapter, we examined Christian lifestyle and moral conduct.

We discovered that genuine faith in Jesus Christ influences every dimension of the believer's life.

Christian discipleship involves love, obedience, integrity, compassion, and faithful service.

However, the Christian life is not intended to remain a private experience.

Jesus Christ entrusted His followers with a mission.

They were called to proclaim the Gospel, make disciples, teach His commandments, and bear witness to His saving work.

This mission extends beyond national, cultural, linguistic, and social boundaries.

The Holy Scriptures present God's concern for humanity from the earliest chapters of Genesis.

After the entrance of sin, God revealed His purpose to overcome evil and restore the broken relationship between Himself and humanity.

Through Abraham, God promised that all families of the earth would receive a blessing.

The prophets announced God's desire that the nations should know Him.

Jesus Christ fulfilled the divine promise of salvation through His life, death, and resurrection.

Before His ascension, He commissioned His disciples to proclaim the Gospel throughout the world.

The Book of Acts records the expansion of this mission through the power of the Holy Spirit.

Yet important questions remain.

What is the Gospel? Why must it be proclaimed? Who is responsible for evangelism? What role does the Holy Spirit play? How should Christians communicate the message to people of different backgrounds? What is the relationship between evangelism, baptism, discipleship, and Christian service?

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, the Church's mission also includes the proclamation of the three angels' messages of Revelation 14.

These messages emphasize the everlasting Gospel, worship of the Creator, the judgment, faithfulness to God's commandments, and preparation for the return of Jesus Christ.

Their interpretation occupies a central place in Adventist prophetic theology.

However, evangelism must never become an instrument of manipulation, coercion, or religious superiority.

The Gospel is an invitation to receive the grace of God through Jesus Christ.

Christian witness should therefore be characterized by truthfulness, compassion, humility, and respect for freedom of conscience.

This chapter examines fifteen questions concerning the biblical foundation, purpose, methods, and prophetic significance of Christian mission.

Our objective is to understand why the Gospel must be proclaimed and how believers may participate faithfully in the mission entrusted to the Church.

Question 1 — What Is the Gospel According to the Holy Scriptures?

Answer:

The word Gospel means good news.

In the New Testament, the Gospel centers upon Jesus Christ and the salvation God provides through Him.

The apostle Paul summarizes the Gospel by emphasizing that Christ died for our sins, was buried, and rose again according to the Scriptures.

The Gospel therefore announces God's saving action in human history.

It reveals His love, grace, righteousness, mercy, and faithfulness.

Through Jesus Christ, sinners are invited to receive forgiveness, reconciliation, and eternal life.

The Gospel also calls people to repentance and faith.

It is not merely a system of moral instructions or religious ceremonies.

It is the good news of what God has accomplished through Jesus Christ and the new life made possible through Him.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, the everlasting Gospel proclaimed in Revelation 14 is the same saving message centered upon Jesus Christ.

The prophetic messages associated with it must therefore remain connected with His redemptive work.

Bible References:

- Mark 1:14–15
- John 3:16–17
- Romans 1:16–17
- Romans 3:21–26
- 1 Corinthians 15:1–8
- Ephesians 2:8–10
- Revelation 14:6–7

Doctrinal Note:

The Gospel must remain centered upon Jesus Christ. Prophetic interpretation, denominational identity, and moral instruction should never replace the saving message of His life, death, resurrection, and promised return.

Question 2 — Why Does God Desire the Gospel to Reach Every Nation?

Answer:

The Bible presents God's saving purpose as extending beyond one nation or ethnic group.

God promised Abraham that all families of the earth would be blessed through him.

The Old Testament prophets anticipated a time when the nations would recognize the Lord.

Jesus declared that God loved the world and sent His Son so that believers might receive eternal life.

The apostle Paul taught that the Gospel is the power of God unto salvation for everyone who believes.

These passages demonstrate the universal scope of God's invitation.

No people should be considered unworthy of hearing the Gospel because of nationality, language, social status, or cultural background.

The mission of the Church reflects God's love for humanity.

Christian evangelism should therefore reject racial prejudice, cultural arrogance, and discrimination.

Its purpose is to communicate the saving message of Jesus Christ to all people.

Bible References:

- Genesis 12:1–3
- Isaiah 49:5–6
- Isaiah 56:6–8
- John 3:16–17
- Acts 10:34–35
- Romans 1:16
- Galatians 3:26–29
- Revelation 7:9–10

Explanatory Note:

The universal scope of the Gospel does not mean that every person must adopt the culture of the missionary. Christian witness should distinguish biblical teaching from cultural customs.

Question 3 — What Mission Did Jesus Christ Entrust to His Disciples?

Answer:

Before His ascension, Jesus commanded His disciples to proclaim the Gospel and make disciples among all nations.

Matthew 28 emphasizes baptism and teaching.

The disciples were instructed to teach believers to observe everything Jesus had commanded.

Acts 1 emphasizes the role of the Holy Spirit in empowering Christian witness.

The mission therefore includes more than the communication of religious information.

It involves proclaiming Jesus Christ, inviting people to faith, baptizing those who respond, and teaching them to live as His disciples.

Christian mission is both evangelistic and educational.

The objective is not simply to increase the number of people associated with a religious institution.

It is to lead individuals into a genuine relationship with Jesus Christ.

Bible References:

- Matthew 28:18–20
- Mark 16:15
- Luke 24:44–49
- John 20:21–23
- Acts 1:6–8
- Acts 2:37–42

Textual Note:

The longer ending of Mark, including Mark 16:15, is present in the King James Version but absent from some of the earliest surviving Greek manuscripts. The Great Commission is also clearly taught in Matthew 28, Luke 24, and Acts 1, independently of this textual question.

Question 4 — Who Is Responsible for Proclaiming the Gospel?

Answer:

The New Testament presents Christian witness as a responsibility shared by the Church.

Jesus commissioned His disciples to proclaim the Gospel.

The apostles exercised a distinctive foundational ministry, but the spread of Christianity was not limited to them.

The Book of Acts records believers proclaiming the Word after persecution scattered the Christian community.

The apostle Peter instructed Christians to be ready to explain the hope within them.

Paul also taught that the Holy Spirit distributes different gifts for the benefit of the Church.

Therefore, not every believer exercises the same ministry.

Some preach publicly.

Others teach, encourage, serve, provide hospitality, support missionary work, or communicate their faith through personal relationships.

Christian mission is a shared responsibility expressed through diverse gifts and opportunities.

Bible References:

- Matthew 5:13–16
- Acts 8:1–4
- Romans 12:3–8
- 1 Corinthians 12:4–11
- Ephesians 4:11–16
- 1 Peter 3:15–16

- 1 Peter 4:10–11

Doctrinal Note:

The biblical call to witness does not require every believer to become a professional preacher. Christians participate in mission according to their gifts, circumstances, and opportunities.

Question 5 — Why Is the Holy Spirit Essential to Evangelism?

Answer:

Jesus instructed His disciples to wait for the promised power of the Holy Spirit.

He declared that they would receive power and become His witnesses.

The Book of Acts demonstrates the importance of this promise.

At Pentecost, the disciples proclaimed the mighty works of God to people from different linguistic backgrounds.

The Holy Spirit strengthened their courage and guided the expansion of the Church.

Jesus also taught that the Spirit would convict the world concerning sin, righteousness, and judgment.

These passages demonstrate that genuine evangelism depends upon divine power rather than human eloquence alone.

Christians may explain Scripture, answer questions, and communicate their testimony.

However, they cannot produce genuine conversion through pressure or manipulation.

The transformation of the heart is the work of God.

Bible References:

- John 14:16–17, 26
- John 16:7–15

- Acts 1:8
- Acts 2:1–41
- Acts 4:29–31
- 1 Corinthians 2:1–5
- 1 Thessalonians 1:4–5

Doctrinal Note:

Dependence upon the Holy Spirit does not eliminate the need for careful preparation, accurate teaching, or responsible communication. Divine power and faithful human service are not presented as opposites.

Question 6 — How Did the Early Christian Church Proclaim the Gospel?

Answer:

The Book of Acts describes several methods of evangelism.

The apostles preached publicly in Jerusalem.

Believers also shared their faith through personal conversations.

Philip explained Scripture to an Ethiopian official.

Paul taught in synagogues, homes, and public gathering places.

He adapted his communication to different audiences while preserving the central message of Jesus Christ.

The early Church also demonstrated its faith through fellowship, generosity, and care for those in need.

These examples show that evangelism was not limited to one method.

Public preaching, personal Bible study, hospitality, conversation, teaching, and practical service all contributed to the spread of Christianity.

The effectiveness of Christian mission depended upon faithfulness to the Gospel and the work of the Holy Spirit.

Bible References:

- Acts 2:14–47
- Acts 5:42
- Acts 8:26–40
- Acts 10:24–48
- Acts 16:13–15
- Acts 17:16–34
- Acts 18:1–11
- Acts 20:20–21

Historical Note:

The New Testament describes evangelistic practices within the social and cultural conditions of the first century. Modern methods should be evaluated according to biblical principles rather than assumed to be identical to ancient practices.

Question 7 — What Is the Relationship Between Evangelism and Personal Testimony?

Answer:

Personal testimony is an important form of Christian witness.

The Bible records individuals sharing what they had experienced through their encounters with God.

After Jesus healed a man who had been possessed by demons, He instructed him to tell others what the Lord had done for him.

The Samaritan woman also invited people from her community to consider Jesus.

The apostles testified concerning what they had seen and heard.

These examples demonstrate that personal experience can encourage others to examine the Gospel.

However, testimony should not replace Scripture.

Individual experiences may be misunderstood or interpreted incorrectly.

Christian witness should therefore distinguish personal experience from biblical teaching.

A faithful testimony points people toward Jesus Christ rather than glorifying the speaker.

Bible References:

- Mark 5:18–20
- John 4:28–42
- Acts 4:18–20
- Acts 22:1–21
- Acts 26:1–29
- 1 Peter 3:15–16
- Revelation 12:11

Practical Note:

A personal testimony should be truthful, respectful, and appropriate to the audience. Christians should avoid exaggerating experiences or presenting unverified claims as established facts.

Question 8 — Why Must Evangelism Be Accompanied by Love and Compassion?

Answer:

Jesus demonstrated compassion toward people experiencing suffering, rejection, and spiritual confusion.

He taught His disciples to love one another and identified love as a distinguishing mark of genuine discipleship.

The apostle Paul explained that even extraordinary spiritual gifts lose their value when exercised without love.

Christian evangelism must therefore reflect the character of Jesus Christ.

The Gospel should not be communicated through humiliation, threats, deception, or manipulation.

Believers are called to speak the truth in love.

They should also recognize the physical, emotional, and social needs of those they serve.

Practical compassion does not replace the proclamation of the Gospel.

Rather, it demonstrates the love that the Gospel announces.

Bible References:

- Matthew 9:35–38
- Matthew 14:13–21
- John 13:34–35
- 1 Corinthians 13:1–13
- Ephesians 4:15
- Colossians 4:5–6
- James 2:14–17
- 1 John 3:16–18

Doctrinal Note:

Christian service should not be conditional upon a person's willingness to adopt a particular religious belief. Compassion reflects God's love and respects human dignity.

Question 9 — How Should Christians Communicate the Gospel Across Different Cultures?

Answer:

The New Testament demonstrates that the Gospel was proclaimed among people from different nations, languages, and cultural backgrounds.

At Pentecost, people heard the message in their own languages.

Paul adapted his approach when speaking to different audiences.

In Athens, he referred to aspects of the surrounding culture while presenting the biblical message concerning God and the resurrection.

These examples support thoughtful communication.

Christians should seek to understand the language, history, concerns, and circumstances of those they address.

However, cultural sensitivity does not require changing the essential message of salvation through Jesus Christ.

The challenge is to communicate biblical truth clearly without confusing it with the missionary's personal cultural preferences.

In Seventh-day Adventist mission, the worldwide proclamation of the Gospel includes the use of many languages and methods of communication.

Bible References:

- Acts 2:5–12
- Acts 10:34–35
- Acts 15:1–29
- Acts 17:22–34
- 1 Corinthians 9:19–23
- Galatians 3:26–29
- Revelation 7:9–10

Practical Note:

Faithful translation, cultural understanding, and respectful dialogue are important. Missionary work should not become an instrument of cultural domination.

Question 10 — What Is the Relationship Between Evangelism, Baptism, and Discipleship?

Answer:

Jesus connected the making of disciples with baptism and teaching.

The Book of Acts records people responding to the Gospel through repentance, faith, and baptism.

However, baptism is not presented as the end of Christian growth.

New believers are called to continue learning and living according to the teachings of Jesus Christ.

The early Church devoted itself to the apostles' doctrine, fellowship, breaking of bread, and prayers.

These practices demonstrate the importance of continuing spiritual instruction.

Evangelism should therefore include responsible preparation for baptism and ongoing discipleship afterward.

The objective is not merely a public religious ceremony.

It is a continuing relationship with Jesus Christ expressed through faith, obedience, worship, and Christian fellowship.

Bible References:

- Matthew 28:18–20
- Acts 2:37–42
- Acts 8:26–39
- Acts 16:25–34
- Romans 6:3–11
- Colossians 2:6–7
- Hebrews 10:23–25

Doctrinal Note:

Seventh-day Adventist practice emphasizes biblical instruction before baptism and continued spiritual growth afterward. Baptism must be approached as a response of faith rather than a means of increasing institutional statistics.

Question 11 — What Is the Everlasting Gospel Mentioned in Revelation 14?

Answer:

Revelation 14 describes an angel flying in the midst of heaven with the everlasting Gospel to proclaim to those who dwell on the earth.

The message is directed to every nation, kindred, tongue, and people.

This universal proclamation is connected with the call to fear God, give glory to Him, and worship the Creator.

The passage also announces the arrival of the hour of God's judgment.

The expression everlasting Gospel emphasizes the enduring significance of God's saving message.

The Gospel announced in Revelation must not be separated from Jesus Christ, whose saving work is central to the entire New Testament.

In Seventh-day Adventist interpretation, Revelation 14:6–12 describes a special end-time proclamation entrusted to God's people.

This proclamation includes the everlasting Gospel and prophetic warnings concerning worship, judgment, and religious allegiance.

Other Christian traditions interpret the symbolic angels and their messages differently.

The Adventist understanding should therefore be explained through careful examination of Revelation and its biblical context.

Bible References:

- Matthew 24:14

- Romans 1:16–17
- 1 Corinthians 15:1–8
- Revelation 1:1–6
- Revelation 5:6–14
- Revelation 14:6–12

Doctrinal Note:

The angels of Revelation 14 appear within an apocalyptic vision. Seventh-day Adventists understand their messages as a worldwide proclamation carried forward through God's people, rather than as a description limited to three visible angels speaking in the sky.

Question 12 — What Is the Meaning of the First Angel's Message?

Answer:

The first angel's message is recorded in Revelation 14:6–7.

It announces the everlasting Gospel and calls humanity to fear God, give Him glory, and worship the Creator.

It also declares that the hour of His judgment has come.

The call to fear God should be understood in the biblical sense of reverence, faithfulness, and recognition of divine authority.

The command to worship the Creator recalls the biblical teaching concerning creation.

The language of heaven, earth, sea, and the fountains of waters also invites comparison with the creation and Sabbath themes of the Old Testament.

In Seventh-day Adventist interpretation, the first angel's message is closely connected with the doctrine of the heavenly judgment and the continuing significance of the seventh-day Sabbath.

Adventists understand the announcement of the judgment hour within their historicist interpretation of Daniel and Revelation, including the

prophetic significance assigned to 1844.

However, Revelation 14:7 does not itself state the date 1844.

That conclusion depends upon a broader interpretive framework involving Daniel 8 and 9.

The first angel's message therefore calls believers to proclaim the Gospel, honor God, and worship Him as Creator.

Bible References:

- Genesis 1:1
- Exodus 20:8–11
- Ecclesiastes 12:13–14
- Daniel 7:9–14
- Daniel 8:14
- Acts 17:24–31
- Revelation 14:6–7

Doctrinal Note:

The Adventist connection between the judgment hour, the Sabbath, and the year 1844 is a distinctive prophetic interpretation. Its detailed biblical and historical arguments should be examined in the chapters devoted to Daniel, the heavenly sanctuary, and the investigative judgment.

Question 13 — What Is the Meaning of the Second Angel's Message?

Answer:

The second angel's message announces the fall of Babylon.

In Revelation, Babylon functions as an important symbol associated with opposition to God, spiritual corruption, and deceptive religious influence.

The imagery draws upon Old Testament descriptions of ancient Babylon and its judgment.

Revelation later develops the symbol through the vision of Babylon the great.

In Seventh-day Adventist interpretation, spiritual Babylon represents religious systems that depart from biblical truth and participate in forms of religious deception.

The second angel's message is therefore understood as a warning against spiritual confusion and unfaithfulness to God.

However, this interpretation should not be used to condemn every individual associated with a particular religious community.

Revelation 18 includes a call for God's people to come out of Babylon.

This indicates that the biblical narrative itself recognizes God's people within the sphere symbolized by Babylon.

Christian witness must therefore distinguish the criticism of religious systems and teachings from judgments concerning the sincerity or salvation of individuals.

Bible References:

- Isaiah 21:9
- Jeremiah 51:6–9
- Daniel 4:28–37
- Revelation 14:8
- Revelation 17:1–6
- Revelation 18:1–5

Doctrinal Note:

The application of symbolic Babylon to particular religious institutions is part of Adventist historicist interpretation and is contested by other Christian traditions. Such interpretations should be presented carefully, without hostility toward individuals or unsupported accusations.

Question 14 — What Is the Meaning of the Third Angel's Message?

Answer:

The third angel's message is recorded in Revelation 14:9–12.

It contains a solemn warning concerning worship of the beast and its image and the reception of its mark.

The passage emphasizes the seriousness of religious allegiance and the consequences of opposition to God.

It concludes with a description of the saints who keep the commandments of God and the faith of Jesus.

In Seventh-day Adventist interpretation, this message concerns the final conflict over worship and obedience.

Adventists connect the mark of the beast with an anticipated end-time enforcement of Sunday observance in opposition to the biblical seventh-day Sabbath.

This conclusion is developed through a historicist interpretation of Revelation 13 and 14, together with the denomination's understanding of religious authority and the commandments of God.

However, Revelation 14 does not explicitly use the words Sunday law or identify a particular modern statute.

The interpretation requires a broader argument that must be examined carefully.

It is also important to distinguish present religious practice from the anticipated final crisis described in Adventist eschatology.

Adventist teaching does not require the conclusion that every Christian who presently worships on Sunday has knowingly received the mark of the beast.

The third angel's message should be proclaimed with seriousness, biblical accuracy, and compassion.

Bible References:

- Exodus 20:8–11
- Daniel 7:25
- Revelation 12:17
- Revelation 13:1–18
- Revelation 14:9–12
- Revelation 15:1–4
- Revelation 18:1–5

Doctrinal Note:

The Adventist interpretation of the beast, its image, and its mark is not universally accepted among Christians. The detailed identification of these symbols belongs in a separate prophetic study and should not be treated as self-evident from a single passage.

Question 15 — How Should the Church Fulfill Its Mission Before the Return of Jesus Christ?

Answer:

Jesus taught that the Gospel of the kingdom would be preached throughout the world as a witness to all nations.

He also instructed His disciples to remain watchful and faithful.

The New Testament presents Christian mission as a continuing responsibility until the fulfillment of God's purposes.

The Church is called to proclaim Jesus Christ, teach the Holy Scriptures, make disciples, and demonstrate practical love.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, the final proclamation includes the three angels' messages of Revelation 14.

This mission emphasizes the everlasting Gospel, worship of the Creator, the judgment, faithfulness to God's commandments, and preparation for the Second Coming.

However, the urgency of Christian mission must not justify coercion, deception, or exaggerated predictions concerning the timing of Christ's return.

Jesus taught that the exact day and hour are not known to human beings.

The Church should therefore proclaim the Gospel faithfully without attempting to establish dates that Scripture does not reveal.

Believers are called to remain spiritually prepared and actively engaged in service.

The ultimate success of God's saving purpose rests upon His power and faithfulness.

Bible References:

- Matthew 24:14
- Matthew 24:36–44
- Matthew 28:18–20
- Acts 1:6–8
- Romans 10:13–17
- 2 Corinthians 5:18–21
- Revelation 14:6–12
- Revelation 22:17

Doctrinal Note:

Christian mission should combine doctrinal faithfulness, responsible prophetic interpretation, compassion, and respect for freedom of conscience. The urgency of the Gospel does not authorize religious manipulation or speculative date-setting.

Chapter Summary

The mission of the Christian Church originates in the saving purpose of God.

The Gospel announces the life, death, resurrection, and saving work of Jesus Christ.

Before His ascension, Jesus commissioned His disciples to proclaim this message throughout the world.

The Holy Spirit empowers believers to participate in the mission through diverse gifts and opportunities.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, the Church's end-time mission includes the proclamation of the three angels' messages of Revelation 14.

Our study enables us to retain the following teachings:

1. The Gospel is the good news of salvation through Jesus Christ.

2. God's saving purpose extends to every nation, language, and people.

3. Jesus commissioned His disciples to proclaim the Gospel and make disciples.

4. Christian mission is a responsibility shared by the Church through diverse spiritual gifts.

5. The Holy Spirit empowers and guides genuine evangelism.

6. The early Church used public preaching, personal testimony, teaching, hospitality, and service.

7. Personal testimony can support evangelism but must remain faithful to Scripture.

8. Christian mission should be characterized by love, compassion, and respect.

9. The Gospel should be communicated clearly across cultural and linguistic boundaries.

10. Evangelism includes baptism, biblical instruction, and continuing discipleship.

11. Revelation 14 presents the everlasting Gospel within a worldwide prophetic proclamation.

12. The first angel's message calls humanity to honor God, recognize His judgment, and worship the Creator.

13. The second angel's message warns against spiritual Babylon and religious unfaithfulness.

14. The third angel's message warns against false worship and emphasizes faithfulness to God's commandments and the faith of Jesus.

15. The Church is called to proclaim the Gospel faithfully while awaiting the return of Jesus Christ.

Doctrinal Conclusion

The proclamation of the Gospel is an essential responsibility of the Christian Church.

Jesus Christ entrusted His followers with the mission of making disciples among all nations.

This mission is rooted in God's love for humanity and His desire to reconcile sinners to Himself.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, Christian mission includes several essential dimensions.

The Centrality of Jesus Christ

The Gospel must proclaim the saving work of Jesus Christ through His life, death, resurrection, and promised return.

The Universal Scope of Salvation

God's invitation extends to people of every nation, language, culture, and social background.

The Power of the Holy Spirit

Genuine evangelism depends upon the guidance and transforming work of the Holy Spirit.

Biblical Teaching and Discipleship

The mission of the Church includes instruction in Scripture, baptism, fellowship, and continuing spiritual growth.

Compassionate Christian Service

The Gospel should be demonstrated through love, generosity, justice, and practical concern for others.

The Three Angels' Messages

Seventh-day Adventist theology identifies Revelation 14:6–12 as a central expression of the Church's end-time proclamation.

These messages emphasize the everlasting Gospel, worship of the Creator, the judgment, warnings against religious deception, and faithfulness to God's commandments.

Respect for Freedom of Conscience

Christian witness must rely upon truth, persuasion, and love rather than coercion.

Preparation for Christ's Return

Believers are called to remain faithful, proclaim the Gospel, and await the Second Coming with hope.

The mission of the Church should never be reduced to institutional expansion or religious competition.

Its ultimate purpose is to lead people toward Jesus Christ and the salvation offered through Him.

The Essential Message:

Jesus Christ entrusted His Church with the mission of proclaiming the Gospel to the whole world. Through the power of the Holy Spirit, believers are called to make disciples, teach the Scriptures, demonstrate Christian love, and invite people to receive salvation through Christ. In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, this mission includes the proclamation of the three angels' messages of Revelation 14, calling humanity to worship the Creator, recognize the judgment, reject religious deception, and remain faithful to God while awaiting the return of Jesus Christ.

Personal Reflection Questions

1. Do I understand the Gospel as the good news of salvation through Jesus Christ?

2. Why does God desire His saving message to reach every nation and people?

3. How can I participate in the mission entrusted to the Christian Church?

4. Am I depending upon the Holy Spirit rather than merely upon human ability?

5. Does my personal testimony direct others toward Jesus Christ and the Holy Scriptures?

6. Do I communicate my faith with love, humility, and respect for freedom of conscience?

7. Am I willing to share the Gospel with people from different cultural and religious backgrounds?

8. Do I understand the biblical foundations and Adventist interpretation of the three angels' messages?

9. Does my approach to prophecy remain centered upon the everlasting Gospel and the saving work of Jesus Christ?

10. Am I faithfully preparing for Christ's return while helping others understand His invitation to salvation?

Suggested Prayer

Lord my God,

I come before You with gratitude, humility, and faith.

Thank You for the gift of salvation through Jesus Christ.

Thank You for revealing Your love through His life, death, and resurrection.

I recognize that the Gospel is the good news of Your saving grace.

Forgive me for the times I have neglected opportunities to share Your love with others.

Give me a heart that reflects the compassion of Jesus Christ.

Help me recognize the spiritual and practical needs of those around me.

Teach me to proclaim Your Word faithfully and accurately.

May I never use religion as a means of pride, manipulation, or condemnation.

Fill me with Your Holy Spirit.

Give me wisdom, courage, patience, and humility.

Help me communicate the Gospel clearly to people from different backgrounds and cultures.

Guide my words so that they may encourage others to seek the truth.

May my actions demonstrate the love that I profess.

Help me serve those who are suffering, discouraged, or in need.

Strengthen Your Church in its mission throughout the world.

Bless those who preach, teach, translate Scripture, provide humanitarian assistance, and support the work of evangelism.

Give me understanding as I study the prophetic messages of Daniel and Revelation.

Help me distinguish the clear teaching of Scripture from human speculation.

Keep my faith centered upon Jesus Christ.

May the everlasting Gospel remain the foundation of every message I share.

Prepare me to remain faithful amid the challenges of Christian life.

Until the glorious return of Jesus Christ, help me proclaim Your truth with love, serve others with compassion, and trust completely in Your saving grace.

In the name of Jesus Christ, my Savior and Lord.

Amen.

CHAPTER 28 — THE ANGELS: WHO ARE THEY AND WHAT IS THEIR MISSION IN THE PLAN OF GOD?

A Thematic Bible Study — King James Version (KJV)

Opening Scripture

> “Are they not all ministering spirits, sent forth to minister for them who shall be heirs of salvation?”

Hebrews 1:14 — KJV

Introduction

Throughout the Holy Scriptures, angels appear at significant moments in the history of God's dealings with humanity.

They announce divine messages, protect God's servants, execute judgments, worship before His throne, and participate in events connected with the plan of salvation.

From the Book of Genesis to the Book of Revelation, the Bible presents angels as real spiritual beings who serve under the authority of God.

An angel announced the birth of Jesus Christ to Mary.

A multitude of heavenly beings praised God at the birth of the Savior.

Angels ministered to Jesus after His temptation in the wilderness.

An angel strengthened Him during His suffering in Gethsemane.

Angels also announced His resurrection and His promised return.

The Book of Revelation describes angels participating in the unfolding of prophetic events and the final triumph of God's kingdom.

Nevertheless, the subject of angels raises important questions.

Who are angels? Were they created? Are they immortal? Do they possess intelligence and freedom of choice? What is the difference between angels, cherubim, and seraphim? Who is Michael the archangel? Can angels protect believers? Should Christians pray to angels? What is the relationship between faithful angels and Satan's rebellion?

These questions require careful biblical examination.

Popular religious traditions frequently present angels in ways that go beyond the information provided in Scripture.

Some portray angels as deceased human beings who have entered heaven.

Others assign personal guardian angels to every individual or encourage believers to seek direct communication with angelic beings.

The Bible, however, must remain the primary authority for understanding the nature and ministry of angels.

In Seventh-day Adventist theology, the subject of angels is closely connected with the great controversy between Christ and Satan.

The rebellion of Satan, the existence of fallen angels, and the ministry of loyal heavenly beings form part of the broader biblical narrative concerning sin, redemption, judgment, and restoration.

Yet the distinction between explicit biblical teaching and theological interpretation must be preserved.

This chapter examines fifteen questions concerning angels, their characteristics, their ministry, and their role in the plan of salvation.

Our purpose is to understand what the Holy Scriptures reveal about heavenly beings while directing our worship, trust, and hope toward God alone.

Question 1 — What Are Angels According to the Holy Scriptures?

Answer:

Angels are spiritual beings who serve God and carry out His purposes.

The Bible describes them as messengers, ministers, and servants of the Lord.

The word angel is closely associated with the idea of a messenger.

In Scripture, the term may sometimes refer to a human messenger, but it frequently identifies heavenly beings who act under divine authority.

Hebrews describes angels as ministering spirits sent forth to serve those who will inherit salvation.

The Psalms portray angels as powerful servants who obey God's commandments.

Angels are not presented as independent divine beings.

They operate under the authority of the Creator.

Although Scripture describes angels as possessing remarkable abilities, they remain distinct from God.

Their ministry is directed toward the accomplishment of His will.

Bible References:

- Psalm 103:19–21
- Psalm 104:4
- Daniel 7:9–10
- Luke 1:19
- Hebrews 1:7, 14
- Revelation 5:11–12
- Revelation 22:8–9

Linguistic Note:

The Hebrew word mal'ākh and the Greek word angelos both carry the basic meaning of messenger. Their meaning in a particular passage depends upon whether the context identifies a human or heavenly messenger.

Question 2 — Were Angels Created by God?

Answer:

The Bible teaches that all created things owe their existence to God.

The apostle Paul declares that all things in heaven and earth, visible and invisible, were created through Jesus Christ and for Him.

This includes heavenly orders described as thrones, dominions, principalities, and powers.

Psalm 148 calls upon angels and heavenly hosts to praise the Lord and declares that God commanded and they were created.

These passages support the conclusion that angels are created beings.

They did not exist independently of God.

Nor do they possess the eternal, self-existent nature of the Creator.

Scripture does not specify the precise moment when angels were created.

The Book of Job describes heavenly beings rejoicing when God established the foundations of the earth.

This suggests that heavenly beings were already present during the events described.

However, the Bible does not provide a complete chronological account of angelic creation.

Bible References:

- Job 38:4–7
- Psalm 148:1–5
- John 1:1–3

- Colossians 1:15–17
- Nehemiah 9:6
- Revelation 4:11

Doctrinal Note:

The conclusion that angels are created beings is firmly supported by Scripture. The exact timing and detailed circumstances of their creation are not explicitly revealed.

Question 3 — What Characteristics and Abilities Do Angels Possess?

Answer:

The Bible presents angels as intelligent, powerful, and active spiritual beings.

They communicate messages, exercise judgment, worship God, and respond to divine instructions.

Some biblical narratives describe angels appearing in human form.

Other passages portray heavenly beings in visions involving extraordinary appearances.

Angels are associated with great strength and the ability to accomplish tasks beyond ordinary human capacity.

However, they are not omnipotent, omniscient, or omnipresent.

These attributes belong to God alone.

The Bible also indicates that angels possess knowledge and awareness, yet their knowledge is limited.

Jesus taught that the angels of heaven did not know the day and hour of His return.

Peter likewise describes angels as desiring to examine matters concerning salvation.

Therefore, angels are powerful but finite beings.

Their abilities must never be confused with the unlimited power of God.

Bible References:

- Genesis 18:1–8
- Genesis 19:1–3
- Psalm 103:20
- Daniel 9:20–23
- Matthew 24:36
- Luke 1:11–20
- 1 Peter 1:10–12
- 2 Peter 2:11

Explanatory Note:

Biblical descriptions of angelic appearances vary. They should not be combined into a single imagined physical appearance that Scripture never explicitly establishes.

Question 4 — What Is the Difference Between Angels, Cherubim, and Seraphim?

Answer:

The Bible refers to several kinds or descriptions of heavenly beings.

Cherubim appear in the Book of Genesis, where they guard the way to the tree of life after humanity's expulsion from Eden.

They are also associated with the sanctuary and the symbolic representation of God's throne.

Ezekiel describes extraordinary living creatures associated with divine visions.

Seraphim appear prominently in Isaiah's vision of the Lord seated upon His throne.

They proclaim God's holiness and participate in the prophet's cleansing and commission.

These passages reveal different descriptions and functions among heavenly beings.

However, Scripture does not provide a complete classification of all heavenly orders.

The precise relationship between ordinary angelic messengers, cherubim, seraphim, and the living creatures described in Revelation remains a subject of interpretation.

Christians should therefore avoid constructing elaborate angelic hierarchies beyond what Scripture reveals.

Bible References:

- Genesis 3:24
- Exodus 25:17–22
- Isaiah 6:1–7
- Ezekiel 1:4–28
- Ezekiel 10:1–22
- Revelation 4:6–11

Doctrinal Note:

Cherubim and seraphim are clearly described in Scripture, but the Bible does not present a comprehensive system explaining every rank or category of heavenly beings.

Question 5 — Who Is Gabriel, and What Role Does He Play in the Bible?

Answer:

Gabriel is a heavenly messenger specifically named in the books of Daniel and Luke.

In Daniel, Gabriel is instructed to help the prophet understand a vision.

He later appears in connection with an explanation concerning prophetic time.

In the Gospel of Luke, Gabriel announces the future birth of John the Baptist to Zacharias.

He also announces to Mary that she will give birth to Jesus Christ.

Gabriel identifies himself as one who stands in the presence of God.

These passages demonstrate his important role as a messenger of divine revelation.

However, Scripture does not explicitly identify Gabriel as an archangel.

Nor does it provide a complete account of his position within the heavenly host.

Gabriel's ministry directs attention toward God's purposes and the fulfillment of His promises.

Bible References:

- Daniel 8:15–17
- Daniel 9:20–23
- Luke 1:5–20
- Luke 1:26–38

Explanatory Note:

Although Gabriel is frequently called an archangel in religious tradition, the canonical biblical passages that name him do not explicitly assign him that title.

Question 6 — Who Is Michael the Archangel?

Answer:

Michael is an important figure in several biblical passages.

In Daniel, he is described as one of the chief princes and as the great prince who stands for God's people.

The Book of Jude refers to Michael as the archangel.

Revelation describes Michael and his angels fighting against the dragon and his angels.

These passages associate Michael with heavenly leadership, protection of God's people, and conflict against Satan.

In Seventh-day Adventist theology, Michael is understood as a title identifying Jesus Christ in His role as commander of the heavenly host.

This interpretation is based upon comparisons among passages concerning Michael, the voice of the archangel, the resurrection, and Christ's authority.

However, the Bible does not contain a direct statement saying, “Michael is Jesus Christ.”

Other Christian traditions understand Michael as a created archangel distinct from Jesus.

The Adventist identification is therefore a theological conclusion derived from a particular reading of several biblical passages.

Importantly, Adventist theology does not teach that Jesus Christ is a created angel.

It affirms His eternal divinity.

Bible References:

- Daniel 10:13, 21
- Daniel 12:1
- John 5:25–29
- 1 Thessalonians 4:16
- Jude 9
- Revelation 12:7–9

Doctrinal Note:

The identification of Michael with Jesus Christ is an Adventist interpretation and is disputed among Christian traditions. It must not be confused with the claim that Christ is a created being.

Question 7 — What Is the Relationship Between Angels and the Worship of God?

Answer:

The Bible repeatedly describes angels worshiping and praising God.

Isaiah saw seraphim proclaiming the holiness of the Lord.

The Book of Revelation presents heavenly beings worshiping God and the Lamb.

These scenes emphasize the majesty and sovereignty of the Creator.

However, angels are never presented as legitimate substitutes for God in worship.

When John attempted to worship an angel, he was instructed not to do so.

The angel identified himself as a fellow servant and directed worship toward God.

This distinction is essential.

Angels may serve as messengers and ministers, but they are not objects of divine worship.

Christian faith should therefore direct prayer, adoration, and ultimate trust toward God.

Bible References:

- Isaiah 6:1–3
- Luke 2:8–14
- Hebrews 1:4–14
- Revelation 4:6–11

- Revelation 5:11–14
- Revelation 19:9–10
- Revelation 22:8–9

Doctrinal Note:

The biblical prohibition against worshiping angels does not deny their importance. It establishes the proper distinction between created servants and the Creator.

Question 8 — Do Angels Protect and Assist God's People?

Answer:

The Bible records several occasions when angels protected or assisted God's servants.

An angel delivered Peter from prison.

An angel protected Daniel in the lions' den.

The Psalms describe divine protection associated with the ministry of angels.

Hebrews identifies angels as ministering spirits sent to serve those who will inherit salvation.

These passages demonstrate that God may use angels in His providential care.

However, the Bible does not promise that every believer will always be protected from physical danger or suffering.

Faithful servants of God have experienced persecution, imprisonment, illness, and death.

Therefore, angelic protection should not be interpreted as a guarantee of immunity from hardship.

Christians are encouraged to trust God's wisdom and providence rather than attempt to control angelic activity.

Bible References:

- Psalm 34:7
- Psalm 91:9–12
- Daniel 6:19–23
- Acts 5:17–20
- Acts 12:5–11
- Hebrews 1:14
- Hebrews 11:35–40

Explanatory Note:

Biblical promises of divine protection must be interpreted alongside passages describing the suffering of faithful believers. Trust in God does not eliminate the reality of trials.

Question 9 — Does Every Believer Have a Personal Guardian Angel?

Answer:

The Bible teaches that angels participate in God's care for His people.

Jesus referred to the angels of little ones who behold the face of His Father in heaven.

Psalm 91 describes angelic protection for those who trust in God.

Hebrews also describes angels as ministering spirits serving the heirs of salvation.

These passages provide a biblical foundation for believing that God uses angels to care for human beings.

However, Scripture does not explicitly state that every individual is permanently assigned one particular guardian angel.

Nor does it provide instructions for discovering the name or identity of such an angel.

Some Christian traditions teach a more developed doctrine of individual guardian angels.

Seventh-day Adventist teaching emphasizes the ministry of heavenly angels in protecting and assisting God's people.

Nevertheless, claims about the precise number or permanent assignment of angels should not exceed the information revealed in Scripture.

Bible References:

- Psalm 34:7
- Psalm 91:11–12
- Matthew 18:10
- Acts 12:13–15
- Hebrews 1:14

Doctrinal Note:

The ministry of protective angels is biblical. The claim that each believer has exactly one permanently assigned angel is not explicitly established by Scripture.

Question 10 — Can Angels Communicate Messages From God to Human Beings?

Answer:

Yes.

The Bible records numerous occasions when angels communicated divine messages.

An angel announced the birth of Samson.

Gabriel explained prophetic matters to Daniel.

Angels announced the births of John the Baptist and Jesus Christ.

An angel also directed Philip toward an encounter with an Ethiopian official.

These examples demonstrate that God has used angels to communicate His purposes.

However, Scripture also warns believers to exercise discernment concerning spiritual messages.

Paul declared that even an angel from heaven must not be accepted if the message contradicts the Gospel already proclaimed.

Therefore, an extraordinary spiritual experience does not automatically establish divine authority.

Christian believers must examine religious claims according to the Holy Scriptures.

The Bible does not instruct Christians to seek angelic appearances as a necessary part of spiritual life.

Bible References:

- Judges 13:2–21
- Daniel 8:15–19
- Daniel 9:20–23
- Luke 1:11–38
- Acts 8:26
- Galatians 1:6–9
- 1 John 4:1

Doctrinal Note:

The possibility of angelic communication does not authorize unquestioning acceptance of modern supernatural claims. Biblical teaching remains the standard for evaluating religious messages.

Question 11 — What Role Did Angels Play in the Life and Ministry of Jesus Christ?

Answer:

Angels participated in several important events associated with the earthly ministry of Jesus Christ.

Gabriel announced His birth to Mary.

An angel informed Joseph concerning the circumstances of Mary's pregnancy.

A multitude of heavenly beings praised God when Jesus was born.

After His temptation in the wilderness, angels ministered to Him.

During His suffering in Gethsemane, an angel strengthened Him.

Angels also appeared in connection with the announcement of His resurrection.

These events demonstrate the involvement of heavenly beings in the unfolding of the plan of salvation.

However, the saving work itself belongs uniquely to Jesus Christ.

Angels did not accomplish the atonement.

They served God's purposes while the Son of God fulfilled His redemptive mission.

Bible References:

- Matthew 1:18–25
- Luke 1:26–38
- Luke 2:8–14
- Matthew 4:11
- Luke 22:39–43
- Matthew 28:1–7
- Luke 24:1–7

Textual Note:

Luke 22:43, which describes an angel strengthening Jesus in Gethsemane, is included in the King James Version. Its presence in the earliest textual tradition is debated because some ancient manuscripts omit the verse.

Question 12 — What Does the Bible Teach About Satan and the Fallen Angels?

Answer:

The New Testament teaches that some angels sinned and became associated with rebellion against God.

Jesus spoke of the devil and his angels.

Peter and Jude refer to angels who sinned and did not remain within their proper position.

Revelation describes the dragon and his angels in conflict with Michael and his angels.

The dragon is identified as the Devil and Satan.

These passages support the biblical teaching that spiritual evil includes personal beings opposed to God.

In Seventh-day Adventist theology, Satan's rebellion is understood as originating in heaven before the fall of humanity.

Adventists also interpret Isaiah 14 and Ezekiel 28 as containing imagery that extends beyond the historical kings directly addressed and illuminates the pride and fall of Satan.

However, the immediate contexts of those chapters concern the king of Babylon and the ruler of Tyre.

Their application to Satan is therefore a theological interpretation rather than the explicit historical subject of each passage.

The Bible teaches that Satan and the fallen angels are ultimately subject to divine judgment.

Bible References:

- Isaiah 14:4–15
- Ezekiel 28:11–19
- Matthew 25:41
- Luke 10:17–20
- 2 Peter 2:4
- Jude 6
- Revelation 12:7–12

Doctrinal Note:

The rebellion of Satan and the existence of fallen angels are important elements of Adventist great-controversy theology. Interpretations of Isaiah 14 and Ezekiel 28 must distinguish the original prophetic oracles from their proposed wider spiritual application.

Question 13 — Can Fallen Angels Deceive Human Beings?

Answer:

The Bible warns that spiritual deception is a serious reality.

Paul teaches that Satan can transform himself into an angel of light.

He also warns concerning deceptive religious messages and false apostles.

The New Testament instructs believers to test the spirits and examine claims of spiritual authority.

These teachings demonstrate that supernatural appearances or extraordinary experiences do not automatically prove that a message comes from God.

Christian discernment requires careful attention to the Gospel and the teachings of Scripture.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, spiritual deception becomes especially significant in the final conflict described in Revelation.

However, believers should avoid attributing every unusual event, illness, emotional experience, or unexplained occurrence to demonic activity.

The Bible calls Christians to vigilance and faith rather than superstition or uncontrolled fear.

Bible References:

- Matthew 24:4–5, 23–26
- 2 Corinthians 11:13–15
- Galatians 1:6–9
- 1 Timothy 4:1
- 1 John 4:1–6
- Revelation 13:11–14
- Revelation 16:13–14

Practical Note:

Claims of supernatural activity should be evaluated carefully. Medical, psychological, and ordinary explanations should not be dismissed merely because an experience appears unusual.

Question 14 — What Role Will Angels Play in the Second Coming and Final Judgment?

Answer:

The Bible connects angels with the return of Jesus Christ and the fulfillment of God's final purposes.

Jesus taught that the Son of man would come in glory with His angels.

He also described angels participating in the gathering of God's elect.

Paul refers to the Lord's return with the voice of the archangel and the trumpet of God.

The Book of Revelation presents angels participating in judgments and events associated with the final conflict.

These passages emphasize the majesty and authority of Jesus Christ.

Angels serve under His command.

They do not replace Him as Savior, Judge, or King.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, angels participate in the final events leading to the restoration of God's kingdom.

Their ministry demonstrates that the plan of salvation concerns both humanity and the heavenly realm.

Bible References:

- Matthew 13:36–43
- Matthew 24:29–31
- Matthew 25:31–32
- 1 Thessalonians 4:13–18
- 2 Thessalonians 1:6–10
- Revelation 7:1–3
- Revelation 8:1–6
- Revelation 15:1–8

Doctrinal Note:

The symbolic descriptions of angels in apocalyptic prophecy require careful interpretation. The Bible clearly associates angels with Christ's return, but not every detail of their participation is fully explained.

Question 15 — What Can Christians Learn From the Ministry of Angels?

Answer:

The ministry of angels provides several important lessons for Christian life.

First, it reveals the majesty and authority of God.

Even powerful heavenly beings serve under His command.

Second, it demonstrates the importance of obedience.

Faithful angels are described as servants who accomplish God's will.

Third, angelic ministry illustrates God's concern for His people.

The Bible records divine assistance and protection through heavenly messengers.

Fourth, the rebellion of fallen angels warns against pride and opposition to God.

Finally, the worship of heavenly beings directs attention toward the Creator and the Lamb.

Christians should therefore respond to the biblical teaching concerning angels with gratitude, reverence, discernment, and trust in God.

They should not attempt to worship angels, seek unauthorized communication with them, or place their confidence in spiritual beings rather than Jesus Christ.

The ultimate focus of Christian faith remains the Savior.

Bible References:

- Psalm 103:19–21
- Hebrews 1:13–14
- Hebrews 2:1–4
- Colossians 2:18–19
- Revelation 5:11–14
- Revelation 19:9–10
- Revelation 22:8–9

Doctrinal Note:

A biblical understanding of angels should strengthen faith in God's providence and sovereignty. It should not encourage speculation, superstition, or spiritual practices that Scripture does not authorize.

Chapter Summary

The Holy Scriptures present angels as created spiritual beings who serve God and participate in the accomplishment of His purposes.

They worship before His throne, communicate divine messages, assist His servants, and participate in events associated with salvation and judgment.

The Bible also teaches that some angels rebelled against God and became associated with Satan.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, the ministry of angels forms part of the broader great controversy between Christ and Satan.

Our study enables us to retain the following teachings:

1. Angels are spiritual beings who serve as messengers and ministers of God.

2. Angels were created by God and are not self-existent divine beings.

3. Angels possess intelligence and power, but their abilities and knowledge are limited.

4. Scripture describes cherubim, seraphim, and other heavenly beings without providing a complete angelic hierarchy.

5. Gabriel is a named heavenly messenger associated with important divine announcements.

6. Michael the archangel is associated with heavenly leadership and protection; Seventh-day Adventists identify Michael with Jesus Christ in His role as commander of the heavenly host.

7. Angels worship God and must not themselves become objects of worship.

8. God may use angels to protect and assist His people.

9. Scripture supports angelic care but does not explicitly establish that each believer has one permanently assigned guardian angel.

10. Angels have communicated divine messages throughout biblical history.

11. Angels participated in important events surrounding the earthly ministry of Jesus Christ.

12. The Bible teaches that Satan and fallen angels rebelled against God.

13. Fallen angels may participate in spiritual deception, making biblical discernment essential.

14. Angels are associated with the Second Coming and the fulfillment of God's final purposes.

15. The ministry of angels should strengthen trust in God rather than encourage speculation or angel worship.

Doctrinal Conclusion

The biblical teaching concerning angels reveals an important dimension of God's government and the plan of salvation.

Angels are created spiritual beings who serve under divine authority.

Their ministry demonstrates God's power, wisdom, and concern for His creation.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, the doctrine of angels includes several important dimensions.

Angels as Created Servants of God

Angels owe their existence to the Creator and carry out His commands.

Heavenly Worship

Faithful angels worship God and the Lamb, demonstrating the proper object of religious devotion.

Divine Communication

God has used angels to reveal messages and accomplish specific purposes throughout biblical history.

Protection and Assistance

Angels participate in God's providential care for His people, although believers are not promised freedom from every form of suffering.

The Great Controversy

The rebellion of Satan and the existence of fallen angels form part of the biblical conflict between good and evil.

The Ministry of Jesus Christ

Angels served God's purposes during the earthly ministry of Jesus, while the saving work belongs uniquely to Christ.

The Final Events

Angels participate in events connected with the Second Coming, judgment, and the fulfillment of God's kingdom.

Worship and Spiritual Discernment

Christians are called to worship God alone and evaluate spiritual claims according to Scripture.

The biblical teaching concerning angels should not become a source of superstition.

Nor should it encourage attempts to communicate with spiritual beings independently of God's revealed will.

The ultimate purpose of this doctrine is to direct believers toward the sovereignty, grace, and saving power of Jesus Christ.

The Essential Message:

Angels are created spiritual beings who serve God and participate in His purposes. They worship before His throne, communicate divine messages, assist His people, and take part in events connected with salvation and judgment. The Bible also reveals the rebellion of Satan

and fallen angels. In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, these teachings form part of the great controversy between Christ and Satan. Nevertheless, angels are servants, not saviors. Christian worship, trust, and hope must remain centered upon God and Jesus Christ.

Personal Reflection Questions

1. What does the Bible teach about the origin and nature of angels?

2. Why is it important to distinguish created angels from the eternal Creator?

3. What can I learn from the obedience and worship of faithful angels?

4. How should I understand the biblical roles of Gabriel and Michael?

5. Why must Christians avoid worshiping angels or seeking unauthorized communication with them?

6. How does the ministry of angels demonstrate God's concern for His people?

7. What does Scripture clearly teach about Satan and the fallen angels?

8. How can I evaluate claims of supernatural experiences according to the Bible?

9. What role will angels play in the events associated with the return of Jesus Christ?

10. Does my understanding of angels strengthen my faith in God rather than distract my attention from Jesus Christ?

Suggested Prayer

Lord my God,

I come before You with reverence, gratitude, and faith.

You are the Creator of heaven and earth.

All things owe their existence to Your power and wisdom.

Thank You for revealing through Your Holy Word the ministry of the heavenly angels.

Thank You for the care You demonstrate toward Your people.

I acknowledge that angels are Your servants and that all worship belongs to You alone.

Protect me from superstition, spiritual pride, and the desire to seek extraordinary experiences apart from Your will.

Teach me to understand Your Word faithfully.

Give me wisdom to distinguish biblical truth from human speculation.

Strengthen my faith when I face uncertainty, temptation, or danger.

Help me remember that Your power is greater than every force opposed to Your kingdom.

Protect me from spiritual deception.

Guide my thoughts and decisions through Your Holy Spirit.

May I never place my trust in created beings rather than in Jesus Christ.

Teach me to follow the example of faithful service and obedience demonstrated by the heavenly host.

Give me humility, courage, and perseverance.

Thank You for sending Jesus Christ to accomplish the work of salvation.

I recognize that no angel can replace His saving sacrifice.

My hope rests entirely upon His grace and righteousness.

Prepare me for His glorious return.

Until that day, help me remain faithful, watchful, and confident in Your promises.

May my life bring honor and glory to You alone.

In the name of Jesus Christ, my Savior and Lord.

Amen.

CHAPTER 29 — THE ORIGIN OF EVIL AND THE GREAT CONTROVERSY: WHY DID SIN ARISE IN GOD'S UNIVERSE?

A Thematic Bible Study — King James Version (KJV)

Opening Scripture

> “He that committeth sin is of the devil; for the devil sinneth from the beginning. For this purpose the Son of God was manifested, that he might destroy the works of the devil.”

1 John 3:8 — KJV

Introduction

In the preceding chapter, we examined the nature and ministry of angels.

We discovered that the Holy Scriptures describe angels as created spiritual beings who serve God, communicate His messages, protect His people, and participate in the fulfillment of His purposes.

We also learned that Scripture distinguishes between faithful angels and those who rebelled against God.

This distinction introduces one of the most profound questions in biblical theology:

If God is perfectly good, why does evil exist?

The Bible teaches that God is holy, righteous, loving, and just.

It also declares that His creation was originally good.

Nevertheless, the world is filled with suffering, violence, injustice, sickness, death, and moral corruption.

Human history demonstrates the destructive consequences of sin.

The Holy Scriptures explain that evil is connected with rebellion against God.

They identify Satan as the devil, the deceiver, the tempter, and the adversary of God's purposes.

The Book of Genesis describes the temptation and disobedience of the first human beings.

The New Testament presents Jesus Christ as the One who came to destroy the works of the devil and deliver humanity from sin and death.

The Book of Revelation portrays a conflict involving the dragon, the heavenly host, the people of God, and the final triumph of Christ.

In Seventh-day Adventist theology, these biblical teachings are brought together within the doctrine known as the Great Controversy.

This doctrine understands human history as part of a larger conflict between Christ and Satan concerning God's character, His government, His law, and the allegiance of created beings.

The controversy began with rebellion against God, extended to the earth through human sin, and will ultimately end with the complete destruction of evil.

However, several aspects of this interpretation require careful attention.

The Bible does not present every detail of the origin of evil in one continuous historical account.

Some passages used in great-controversy theology originally address historical kings or employ apocalyptic symbolism.

Therefore, a responsible study must distinguish explicit biblical statements from theological conclusions reached by comparing different passages.

This chapter examines fifteen questions concerning the origin of evil, the rebellion of Satan, human freedom, the entrance of sin, the character of God, the saving work of Jesus Christ, and the final defeat of evil.

Our purpose is to understand the biblical foundations of the great controversy while recognizing the limits of what Scripture reveals.

Question 1 — Did God Create Evil When He Created the Universe?

Answer:

The Bible presents God as the Creator of all things.

The creation account repeatedly describes His works as good.

At the conclusion of the sixth day, God declared His creation to be very good.

Scripture also teaches that God is righteous, holy, and without moral corruption.

James explains that God does not tempt anyone with evil.

These passages provide a foundation for distinguishing God's creative activity from the moral rebellion that later appeared among His creatures.

However, the Bible does not explain every philosophical question concerning why God permitted the possibility of evil.

Isaiah 45:7, in the King James Version, uses the word evil in a passage contrasting peace with calamity or disaster. The context concerns God's sovereignty over historical events, not a declaration that He is the author of moral wickedness.

The biblical narrative therefore presents God as good and righteous while identifying sin with the disobedience of created beings.

Bible References:

- Genesis 1:1–31
- Deuteronomy 32:3–4
- Psalm 5:4–5
- Isaiah 45:5–7
- Habakkuk 1:12–13
- James 1:13–17
- 1 John 1:5

Doctrinal Note:

Seventh-day Adventist theology teaches that God did not create moral evil as an expression of His character. The existence of evil is understood in connection with the misuse of freedom by created beings. This explanation is a theological synthesis rather than a complete philosophical solution to the problem of evil.

Question 2 — What Is Sin According to the Holy Scriptures?

Answer:

The Bible describes sin in several complementary ways.

John identifies sin with transgression of the law.

Paul teaches that all have sinned and come short of the glory of God.

James explains that failing to do what one knows to be right is also sin.

The New Testament further connects sin with unbelief, unrighteousness, selfish desire, and rebellion against God.

Sin is therefore more than an isolated violation of a rule.

It includes attitudes, desires, choices, and actions contrary to God's character and revealed will.

The Bible also presents sin as a power that enslaves humanity and produces death.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, sin involves rebellion against God's moral government and His law of love.

However, the biblical teaching concerning sin must not be reduced exclusively to outward behavior.

Jesus emphasized the importance of the heart and its motives.

Bible References:

- Genesis 4:6–7
- Psalm 51:1–5
- Matthew 5:21–28
- Romans 3:23
- Romans 6:12–23
- James 4:17
- 1 John 3:4
- 1 John 5:17

Linguistic Note:

Biblical terminology for sin includes ideas of missing the mark, wrongdoing, lawlessness, and rebellion. No single English definition captures every dimension of the biblical concept.

Question 3 — Who Is Satan, and What Does His Name Mean?

Answer:

The Bible identifies Satan as an adversary who opposes God's purposes and seeks to deceive humanity.

The term Satan is associated with the Hebrew concept of an adversary or accuser.

The word devil is related to the Greek term diabolos, which conveys the idea of a slanderer or accuser.

In the Book of Job, Satan appears as an accuser who challenges Job's faithfulness.

In the Gospels, he tempts Jesus Christ.

Jesus describes the devil as a liar and a murderer.

The Book of Revelation identifies the dragon as the Devil and Satan, who deceives the whole world.

These passages portray Satan as a personal spiritual adversary rather than merely an abstract symbol of human wrongdoing.

Nevertheless, Satan is not equal to God.

He is neither omnipotent nor sovereign over the universe.

His power is limited, and Scripture announces his ultimate defeat.

Bible References:

- Job 1:6–12
- Job 2:1–7
- Zechariah 3:1–5
- Matthew 4:1–11
- John 8:44
- 1 Peter 5:8–9
- Revelation 12:9–10
- Revelation 20:10

Doctrinal Note:

The biblical conflict between God and Satan is not a struggle between two equal divine powers. God remains the sovereign Creator, while Satan is a finite adversary whose rebellion will ultimately fail.

Question 4 — What Does the Bible Reveal About the Original Condition of Satan?

Answer:

The New Testament teaches that the devil sinned and that some angels rebelled against God.

However, it does not provide a complete biography of Satan before his rebellion.

Two Old Testament passages are frequently examined in connection with his original condition.

Isaiah 14 contains a poetic oracle against the king of Babylon.

It describes the fall of one who sought to exalt himself.

Ezekiel 28 addresses the ruler and king of Tyre and uses extraordinary imagery concerning beauty, pride, and downfall.

In Seventh-day Adventist theology, these passages are understood as having a broader spiritual application to Satan's original position and rebellion.

The description of an anointed cherub in Ezekiel 28 is particularly significant within this interpretation.

However, the immediate historical subjects of these passages are the rulers of Babylon and Tyre.

The identification of their descriptions with Satan is therefore a theological interpretation rather than an explicit statement made by the texts.

Scripture clearly teaches the existence of Satan and fallen angels.

It does not disclose every detail concerning Satan's original identity or heavenly position.

Bible References:

- Isaiah 14:4–15
- Ezekiel 28:11–19
- Luke 10:18
- John 8:44
- 2 Peter 2:4
- Jude 6

- Revelation 12:7–9

Contextual Note:

Isaiah 14 and Ezekiel 28 should first be interpreted within their historical and literary settings. Their application to Satan must be presented as a broader theological reading, not as the direct historical meaning of the entire passage.

Question 5 — How Did Pride and Rebellion Become Associated With Satan?

Answer:

The Bible repeatedly identifies pride as a destructive moral attitude.

Proverbs teaches that pride precedes destruction.

The New Testament also associates pride with the condemnation of the devil.

Paul warns that a newly converted person should not be appointed hastily to spiritual leadership, lest pride lead to condemnation.

Isaiah 14 portrays a ruler seeking to exalt himself above his proper position.

Ezekiel 28 describes a ruler whose heart was lifted up because of his beauty.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, these descriptions illuminate the pride and self-exaltation associated with Satan's rebellion.

The great-controversy framework understands this rebellion as a rejection of God's authority and character.

Nevertheless, Scripture does not provide a detailed chronological explanation of every stage of Satan's fall.

The central biblical lesson is clear: pride and rebellion stand in opposition to humility, obedience, and trust in God.

Bible References:

- Proverbs 16:18
- Isaiah 14:12–15
- Ezekiel 28:15–17
- John 8:44
- 1 Timothy 3:6
- James 4:6–10
- 1 John 3:8

Doctrinal Note:

The specific sequence by which pride developed into Satan's rebellion is not fully revealed. Adventist explanations should distinguish biblical statements from inferred details.

Question 6 — Was There a Conflict in Heaven?

Answer:

Revelation 12 describes a war in heaven.

Michael and his angels fight against the dragon and his angels.

The dragon is defeated and cast out.

The passage identifies the dragon as the Devil and Satan.

This vision clearly portrays a conflict involving heavenly beings.

However, the chronology and symbolic meaning of Revelation 12 are interpreted differently among Christians.

Some understand the passage primarily as referring to a primordial heavenly rebellion.

Others connect it especially with the victory of Christ through His death, resurrection, and exaltation.

Still others understand the chapter as presenting several stages of the conflict through apocalyptic imagery.

In Seventh-day Adventist theology, the war in heaven is connected with Satan's original rebellion and the continuing controversy between Christ and Satan.

The passage also emphasizes the victory accomplished through the blood of the Lamb.

Therefore, the conflict must not be interpreted apart from the saving work of Jesus Christ.

Bible References:

- Luke 10:18
- John 12:31–33
- Colossians 2:13–15
- Revelation 12:1–12
- Revelation 20:1–10

Prophetic Note:

Revelation 12 uses symbolic apocalyptic language. The identification of the dragon as Satan is explicit, but the precise chronological relationship between the heavenly conflict and Christ's earthly ministry remains a matter of interpretation.

Question 7 — Why Did God Permit Created Beings to Exercise Freedom of Choice?

Answer:

The Bible portrays human beings as morally responsible creatures who can respond to God's commands.

In Eden, Adam and Eve received instructions and faced the possibility of disobedience.

Moses later called Israel to choose life through faithfulness to God.

Joshua invited the people to decide whom they would serve.

Jesus also lamented the unwillingness of some people to respond to His invitation.

These passages demonstrate the significance of human response and moral responsibility.

In Seventh-day Adventist theology, freedom of choice is understood as an important expression of God's love.

Genuine love and obedience are not viewed as meaningful if produced solely through coercion.

Within this framework, God permitted created beings to exercise freedom even though rebellion was possible.

However, Scripture does not present a complete philosophical explanation of how divine foreknowledge, providence, and creaturely freedom interact.

Christians differ in their understanding of these questions.

The biblical emphasis remains upon God's righteousness and the responsibility of created beings.

Bible References:

- Genesis 2:15–17
- Deuteronomy 30:15–20
- Joshua 24:14–15
- Isaiah 1:18–20
- Matthew 23:37
- John 7:17
- Revelation 22:17

Doctrinal Note:

The Adventist explanation of the origin of evil places considerable emphasis upon meaningful creaturely freedom. Other Christian theological traditions understand the relationship between freedom and divine sovereignty differently.

Question 8 — How Did Sin Enter the Human World?

Answer:

Genesis 3 describes the temptation and disobedience of the first human beings.

The serpent questioned God's instruction and challenged the consequences of disobedience.

Eve ate the forbidden fruit and gave some to Adam, who also ate.

Their actions violated God's command.

The narrative then describes shame, fear, broken relationships, and expulsion from the garden.

The New Testament identifies the serpent with Satan in Revelation 12.

Paul teaches that sin entered the world through one man and death through sin.

These passages establish a biblical connection between human disobedience and the condition of the fallen world.

The Genesis narrative also demonstrates the deceptive character of temptation.

The serpent encouraged distrust of God's word and presented disobedience as a path toward greater knowledge and independence.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, the temptation in Eden represents the extension of the great controversy to humanity.

Bible References:

- Genesis 2:15–17
- Genesis 3:1–24
- Romans 5:12–21
- 1 Corinthians 15:21–22
- 2 Corinthians 11:3
- Revelation 12:9

Contextual Note:

Genesis 3 identifies the tempter as the serpent. The explicit identification of the ancient serpent with Satan appears in Revelation 12:9 and 20:2.

Question 9 — What Were the Consequences of the Fall for Humanity and Creation?

Answer:

The entrance of sin produced profound consequences.

Genesis describes fear, shame, conflict, suffering, and separation from the tree of life.

Human relationships were damaged.

The ground became associated with painful labor and difficulty.

Death became part of the human condition.

Paul teaches that the creation is subject to frustration and groans while awaiting redemption.

The New Testament also describes humanity as subject to sin and death.

These passages reveal that the consequences of rebellion extend beyond isolated moral actions.

Sin affects human relationships, social structures, and the created order.

However, Scripture does not authorize the conclusion that every individual illness or tragedy results from a particular personal sin.

Jesus rejected such an assumption in His discussion of the man born blind.

The fallen condition of the world must therefore be distinguished from judgments concerning individual suffering.

Bible References:

- Genesis 3:7–24
- Genesis 4:1–16
- Romans 5:12–21
- Romans 8:18–25
- 1 Corinthians 15:21–26
- John 9:1–3
- Revelation 21:1–5

Doctrinal Note:

The Bible connects sin with suffering and death at the level of the fallen human condition. It does not teach that every person who suffers has committed a particular sin responsible for that suffering.

Question 10 — Why Did God Not Immediately Destroy Satan and End the Rebellion?

Answer:

The Bible does not provide a single direct explanation answering every aspect of this question.

It teaches that God is patient, righteous, and just.

It also reveals that He permits evil to continue for a time while working toward its final defeat.

Jesus' parable of the wheat and the tares illustrates a situation in which premature destruction could harm what is good.

However, the parable directly concerns the kingdom and the final separation of the righteous and wicked; it is not an explicit account of why Satan was originally spared.

In Seventh-day Adventist theology, God's patience is understood within the great-controversy framework.

The continued existence of evil is interpreted as allowing the consequences of rebellion and the character of God's government to

become evident before the universe.

This explanation emphasizes the vindication of God's character and the lasting resolution of the conflict.

Nevertheless, the Bible does not explicitly state every element of this reasoning.

Christians should therefore avoid claiming more certainty than Scripture provides.

The central biblical assurance is that God has not abandoned His creation and that evil will not continue forever.

Bible References:

- Exodus 34:6–7
- Psalm 89:14
- Matthew 13:24–30, 36–43
- Romans 2:4
- Romans 3:25–26
- 2 Peter 3:9
- Revelation 20:7–15

Doctrinal Note:

The explanation that God allowed evil to develop so that created beings could understand its consequences is a characteristic Adventist theological synthesis. It should not be presented as a direct quotation or explicit explanation from a single biblical passage.

Question 11 — How Does Satan Attempt to Deceive and Tempt Humanity?

Answer:

The Bible describes Satan as a deceiver, tempter, and accuser.

In Genesis 3, the serpent questions God's word and misrepresents the consequences of disobedience.

In the wilderness, Satan attempts to tempt Jesus by appealing to physical need, presumption, and worldly authority.

The New Testament warns that Satan may disguise deception under the appearance of righteousness.

He is also described as the accuser of God's people.

These passages reveal several recurring features of spiritual deception.

They include the distortion of truth, the encouragement of distrust, the misuse of Scripture, and the promotion of attitudes contrary to God's will.

However, the Bible also teaches that human beings remain responsible for their choices.

James explains that temptation may arise through a person's own desires.

Christians should therefore avoid attributing every sinful thought or action exclusively to direct demonic influence.

The appropriate response is faith, discernment, prayer, and obedience to God.

Bible References:

- Genesis 3:1–6
- Matthew 4:1–11
- John 8:44
- 2 Corinthians 11:13–15
- Ephesians 6:10–18
- James 1:12–15
- 1 Peter 5:8–9
- Revelation 12:10

Practical Note:

Spiritual vigilance should not become fear of hidden demonic activity in every circumstance. The New Testament emphasizes trust in God, resistance to temptation, and the believer's dependence upon Christ.

Question 12 — How Did Jesus Christ Confront and Defeat Satan?

Answer:

The New Testament presents Jesus Christ as the central figure in God's victory over sin and evil.

During His earthly ministry, Jesus resisted Satan's temptations.

He demonstrated authority over demonic powers and proclaimed the kingdom of God.

Through His death and resurrection, Christ accomplished the saving work necessary for humanity's redemption.

Hebrews teaches that through death Jesus acted to destroy the power of the devil over death.

Paul describes Christ's victory over hostile powers.

John declares that the Son of God appeared to destroy the works of the devil.

These passages demonstrate that the conflict is not ultimately resolved through human strength.

Victory comes through Jesus Christ.

In Seventh-day Adventist theology, the cross also reveals God's character of love and exposes the destructive nature of Satan's rebellion.

The saving work of Jesus Christ is therefore central to the great controversy.

His victory provides forgiveness, reconciliation, and the assurance of evil's final defeat.

Bible References:

- Matthew 4:1–11
- Luke 10:17–20
- John 12:31–33
- Romans 5:6–11
- Colossians 2:13–15
- Hebrews 2:14–18
- 1 John 3:8
- Revelation 12:10–11

Doctrinal Note:

The cross is central to the biblical message of salvation. Adventist great-controversy theology additionally emphasizes its significance in revealing God's character before the universe. This broader interpretation should remain grounded in the explicit saving work of Christ.

Question 13 — What Role Does God's Law Play in the Great Controversy?

Answer:

The Bible presents God's commandments as expressions of His will and moral authority.

Jesus taught that love for God and love for neighbor summarize the great commandments.

Paul describes the law as holy, just, and good.

The New Testament also teaches that salvation is received through grace rather than earned through obedience to the law.

These teachings establish an important distinction between the role of God's commandments and the means of salvation.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, the great controversy involves questions concerning God's authority, His character, and the enduring significance of His moral law.

The denomination places particular emphasis upon the Ten Commandments and the seventh-day Sabbath.

Revelation describes God's faithful people as those who keep His commandments and the faith of Jesus.

However, the Bible does not present every detail of the heavenly rebellion as a direct dispute over the Ten Commandments.

That connection is part of the Adventist theological framework.

The essential biblical principle is that genuine obedience flows from faith and love rather than from an attempt to earn salvation.

Bible References:

- Exodus 20:1–17
- Psalm 19:7–11
- Matthew 22:36–40
- John 14:15
- Romans 3:20–31
- Romans 7:12
- Ephesians 2:8–10
- Revelation 14:12

Doctrinal Note:

The Adventist connection between the great controversy, the moral law, and the Sabbath should be developed through careful biblical argument. The distinction between salvation by grace and obedience as the fruit of faith must remain clear.

Question 14 — How Can Believers Remain Faithful During the Conflict Between Good and Evil?

Answer:

The New Testament teaches that believers face spiritual opposition.

Paul describes the Christian struggle as involving spiritual powers rather than merely human adversaries.

He encourages Christians to put on the whole armor of God.

This imagery includes truth, righteousness, faith, salvation, the Word of God, and prayer.

James instructs believers to submit themselves to God and resist the devil.

Peter likewise encourages vigilance and steadfast faith.

Revelation describes victory through the blood of the Lamb and the word of faithful testimony.

These passages demonstrate that Christian perseverance depends upon God's power.

Believers are not instructed to overcome Satan through superstition, magical practices, or confidence in their own strength.

They are called to trust Jesus Christ, study Scripture, pray, resist temptation, and remain faithful.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, perseverance becomes especially important in the final events described in biblical prophecy.

However, Christian faithfulness should not be characterized by panic or obsessive fear.

The believer's confidence rests in the victory of Jesus Christ.

Bible References:

- Matthew 6:9–13
- John 16:33

- Romans 8:31–39
- Ephesians 6:10–18
- James 4:7–10
- 1 Peter 5:8–10
- 1 John 4:4
- Revelation 12:11
- Revelation 14:12

Practical Note:

Spiritual vigilance should strengthen responsible living, courage, and peace. It should not encourage isolation, suspicion of others, or the rejection of appropriate medical and psychological care.

Question 15 — How Will the Great Controversy End?

Answer:

The Bible teaches that evil will not continue forever.

The New Testament announces the final victory of Jesus Christ.

Paul explains that Christ will reign until every enemy has been placed under His feet.

The last enemy to be destroyed is death.

Revelation describes the final judgment, the defeat of Satan, and the destruction of death and hell.

It then presents a new heaven and a new earth.

God dwells with His people, and suffering, death, sorrow, and pain are removed.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, these events form the conclusion of the great controversy.

The denomination teaches that Satan and the wicked will ultimately be destroyed rather than preserved in endless conscious torment.

This understanding is connected with the doctrines of the millennium, final judgment, and conditional immortality.

Other Christian traditions interpret the final punishment passages differently.

The detailed arguments concerning these doctrines belong in the chapters devoted to the millennium, judgment, and final restoration.

The central biblical promise is that God will bring evil to an end and establish His righteous kingdom.

The universe will no longer be subject to sin and death.

Bible References:

- Isaiah 65:17–25
- Nahum 1:9
- 1 Corinthians 15:20–28
- 2 Peter 3:10–13
- Revelation 20:1–15
- Revelation 21:1–8
- Revelation 22:1–5

Doctrinal Note:

The final destruction of evil is a central biblical hope. Seventh-day Adventist teaching concerning the ultimate annihilation of the wicked is a particular interpretation of the relevant judgment passages and differs from the traditional doctrine of eternal conscious punishment.

Chapter Summary

The Holy Scriptures present God as holy, righteous, loving, and the Creator of all things.

They also reveal the existence of sin, Satan, fallen angels, and human rebellion.

The Bible does not provide a complete philosophical explanation of the origin of evil.

However, it identifies sin with rebellion against God and presents Jesus Christ as the Savior who defeats the works of the devil.

In Seventh-day Adventist theology, these teachings form the foundation of the great controversy between Christ and Satan.

Our study enables us to retain the following teachings:

1. God created all things good and is not the author of moral wickedness.

2. Sin includes lawlessness, unrighteousness, rebellion, and the rejection of God's will.

3. Satan is a personal spiritual adversary who opposes God's purposes.

4. The Bible teaches that Satan and fallen angels rebelled, but it does not reveal every detail of their original condition.

5. Pride and self-exaltation are associated with rebellion against God.

6. Revelation 12 describes a heavenly conflict involving Michael, the dragon, and their angels.

7. Human beings are morally responsible for their response to God's revealed will.

8. Sin entered the human world through the disobedience described in Genesis 3.

9. The consequences of sin include broken relationships, suffering, and death.

10. Scripture reveals God's patience and justice, although it does not explain every reason for His temporary permission of evil.

11. Satan employs deception, temptation, accusation, and the distortion of truth.

12. Jesus Christ confronted Satan and accomplished the decisive victory through His saving work.

13. God's commandments express His moral authority, while salvation remains a gift of grace.

14. Believers overcome through faith in Christ, the Word of God, prayer, and perseverance.

15. The great controversy will end with the final defeat of evil and the restoration of God's creation.

Doctrinal Conclusion

The biblical teaching concerning the origin of evil addresses one of the most profound questions of human existence.

How can suffering, rebellion, and death exist in a universe created by a perfectly good God?

The Holy Scriptures do not answer every philosophical question.

However, they reveal essential truths concerning God's character, the reality of sin, the activity of Satan, and the saving work of Jesus Christ.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, these teachings are brought together within the doctrine of the great controversy.

The Goodness of God's Creation

God created the universe according to His wisdom and righteousness.

Evil is not presented as an expression of His moral character.

The Rebellion of Satan

Scripture reveals that Satan and fallen angels oppose God.

Adventist theology understands this rebellion as the beginning of the great controversy.

Freedom and Moral Responsibility

Created beings are accountable for their response to God's will.

The Adventist framework emphasizes meaningful freedom as an important dimension of divine love.

The Entrance of Sin Into Humanity

The disobedience of Adam and Eve brought sin and death into the human world.

The Character and Government of God

The great controversy concerns God's righteousness, love, authority, and the moral principles of His government.

The Victory of Jesus Christ

Through His life, death, and resurrection, Jesus Christ accomplished the decisive saving work that defeats the power of sin and Satan.

The Perseverance of God's People

Believers are called to remain faithful through trust in Christ, obedience to God's Word, prayer, and dependence upon the Holy Spirit.

The Final Destruction of Evil

The conflict will not continue forever.

God will judge evil, defeat Satan, destroy death, and establish a renewed creation.

However, the doctrine of the great controversy must remain centered upon Jesus Christ.

It should not encourage speculative reconstructions of heavenly events that Scripture does not reveal.

Nor should it lead believers to interpret every difficulty as a direct supernatural attack.

The Bible calls Christians to faith, discernment, courage, and hope.

The final outcome of the conflict rests upon the power and righteousness of God.

The Essential Message:

God is holy, loving, and righteous. Evil entered the experience of created beings through rebellion against His will. The Bible identifies Satan as the adversary and deceiver, while presenting humanity as affected by sin and death. In Seventh-day Adventist theology, these realities form part of the great controversy between Christ and Satan. Through His life, death, and resurrection, Jesus Christ has accomplished the decisive victory over evil. The conflict will ultimately end when God destroys sin and death and establishes His everlasting kingdom of righteousness and peace.

Personal Reflection Questions

1. What does the Bible teach about the goodness and righteousness of God's character?

2. How does Scripture define sin and explain its consequences?

3. What do the biblical names and descriptions of Satan reveal about his activity?

4. Why must I distinguish the original contexts of Isaiah 14 and Ezekiel 28 from their wider Adventist interpretation?

5. What does Revelation 12 teach about the conflict involving Michael and the dragon?

6. How does the biblical teaching concerning moral responsibility influence my personal decisions?

7. What lessons can I learn from the temptation and fall of Adam and Eve?

8. How does the cross of Jesus Christ reveal God's love and provide victory over sin?

9. Am I relying upon Scripture, prayer, and faith in Christ when facing temptation and spiritual opposition?

10. How does the promise of the final destruction of evil strengthen my hope in the return of Jesus Christ?

Suggested Prayer

Lord my God,

I come before You with reverence, gratitude, and humility.

You are the Creator of heaven and earth.

Your character is holy, righteous, loving, and just.

Thank You for revealing Your goodness through Your Holy Word.

I recognize that the world is affected by sin, suffering, deception, and death.

At times, I struggle to understand why evil has been permitted to continue.

Help me trust Your wisdom even when I cannot understand every mystery.

Teach me to recognize the destructive nature of sin.

Protect my heart from pride, selfishness, rebellion, and distrust of Your Word.

Give me wisdom to distinguish truth from deception.

Help me resist temptation through the power of Your Holy Spirit.

When I fall into sin, lead me to genuine repentance and renewed faith in Jesus Christ.

Thank You for sending Your Son into the world.

Thank You for His perfect life, His sacrifice upon the cross, and His glorious resurrection.

I acknowledge that my victory over sin cannot come through my own strength.

My hope rests entirely upon the saving grace of Jesus Christ.

Strengthen my faith when I face suffering, uncertainty, or opposition.

Help me remain faithful without becoming fearful or suspicious of others.

Teach me to love my neighbors and demonstrate Your character through compassion and truth.

Give me understanding as I study the prophecies of Daniel and Revelation.

May I never confuse human speculation with the clear teaching of Scripture.

Keep my attention centered upon Jesus Christ and His promises.

Thank You for the assurance that evil will not continue forever.

Thank You for the promise of a new heaven and a new earth where righteousness dwells.

Prepare me for the glorious return of Jesus Christ.

Until that day, help me live with faith, obedience, courage, humility, and complete dependence upon You.

In the name of Jesus Christ, my Savior and Lord.

Amen.

CHAPTER 30 — SPIRITUAL WARFARE AND THE ARMOR OF GOD: HOW CAN CHRISTIANS RESIST SATAN AND REMAIN FAITHFUL?

A Thematic Bible Study — King James Version (KJV)

Opening Scripture

> “Put on the whole armour of God, that ye may be able to stand against the wiles of the devil.”

Ephesians 6:11 — KJV

Introduction

In the preceding chapter, we examined the origin of evil and the great controversy between Christ and Satan.

We discovered that the Holy Scriptures present God as holy, righteous, loving, and the Creator of all things.

We also learned that sin is associated with rebellion against God and that Satan is described as the adversary, deceiver, and accuser.

The Bible teaches that Jesus Christ has accomplished the decisive victory over sin and the powers of evil through His life, death, and resurrection.

Nevertheless, believers continue to face temptation, deception, suffering, and opposition.

This reality introduces an important aspect of Christian discipleship: spiritual warfare.

The expression spiritual warfare refers to the believer's struggle against sin, temptation, deception, and spiritual forces opposed to God.

The apostle Paul describes this struggle in his letter to the Ephesians.

He instructs Christians to be strong in the Lord and in the power of His might.

He then presents the armor of God as an illustration of the spiritual resources necessary for faithful Christian living.

This armor includes truth, righteousness, the Gospel of peace, faith, salvation, the Word of God, and prayer.

The biblical teaching concerning spiritual warfare is not intended to create fear or fascination with Satan.

Its purpose is to encourage confidence in God, spiritual discernment, perseverance, and dependence upon Jesus Christ.

Several questions require careful examination.

What is the nature of spiritual warfare? How does Satan tempt and deceive human beings? What is the difference between temptation and sin? How can believers resist the devil? What does each part of the armor of God represent? What role do prayer and Scripture play? How should Christians understand demonic activity and spiritual deception?

These questions are particularly important because some religious teachings concerning spiritual warfare go beyond what Scripture explicitly reveals.

The Bible does not encourage Christians to interpret every illness, emotional difficulty, disagreement, or unfortunate event as a direct demonic attack.

Nor does it instruct believers to pursue sensational experiences or speculative confrontations with spiritual beings.

Instead, Scripture emphasizes faith in Jesus Christ, obedience to God's Word, prayer, righteousness, love, and perseverance.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, spiritual warfare forms part of the great controversy between Christ and Satan.

The conflict involves the character of God, the truth of His Word, the obedience of believers, and the final triumph of Jesus Christ.

Adventist theology also places particular emphasis upon spiritual deception in the final events described in Daniel and Revelation.

However, interpretations of these prophecies must be distinguished from the explicit teachings of the biblical text.

This chapter examines fifteen questions concerning spiritual warfare and the armor of God.

Our objective is to understand how Christians may remain faithful through the power of the Holy Spirit while placing their confidence entirely in the victory of Jesus Christ.

Question 1 — What Is Spiritual Warfare According to the Bible?

Answer:

The New Testament teaches that Christian life involves spiritual opposition.

The apostle Paul explains that the believer's struggle is not merely against human beings but also involves spiritual powers associated with evil.

He therefore instructs Christians to put on the whole armor of God.

The language of warfare illustrates the seriousness of temptation, deception, and opposition to God's purposes.

However, the weapons described in Ephesians 6 are primarily spiritual and moral.

They include truth, righteousness, faith, salvation, Scripture, and prayer.

The Bible does not present Christian spiritual warfare as a justification for physical violence against people who hold different beliefs.

Instead, believers are called to resist evil while demonstrating love toward others.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, spiritual warfare is part of the broader conflict between Christ and Satan.

The believer participates in this conflict through faithfulness to Jesus Christ and resistance to sin.

Bible References:

- Romans 7:21–25
- Romans 8:1–14
- 2 Corinthians 10:3–5
- Ephesians 6:10–18
- 1 Peter 5:8–10
- Revelation 12:10–12

Doctrinal Note:

Spiritual warfare should not be confused with hostility toward human beings. The New Testament identifies spiritual opposition while commanding Christians to practice love, patience, and peace.

Question 2 — Why Must Christians Depend Upon God's Strength Rather Than Their Own?

Answer:

The Bible teaches that human beings possess moral responsibility but cannot overcome sin through unaided human strength.

Jesus told His disciples that apart from Him they could do nothing.

Paul described the Christian life as one sustained by the power of God.

In Ephesians 6, believers are instructed to be strong in the Lord and in the power of His might.

This command places the foundation of spiritual perseverance in divine strength.

Christian confidence should therefore rest upon God's promises rather than personal determination alone.

Prayer, Scripture, obedience, and spiritual discipline are important.

However, these practices do not independently produce salvation or guarantee freedom from every struggle.

They are means through which believers express faith and dependence upon God.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, victory over temptation is possible through the grace of Christ and the transforming power of the Holy Spirit.

Nevertheless, spiritual growth should not be confused with self-sufficiency or the belief that Christians can become independent of divine grace.

Bible References:

- Psalm 46:1
- John 15:1–5
- Romans 8:1–14
- 2 Corinthians 12:7–10
- Ephesians 3:14–21
- Ephesians 6:10
- Philippians 4:13
- Hebrews 4:14–16

Doctrinal Note:

Dependence upon God is central to Christian spiritual warfare. Religious discipline becomes spiritually dangerous when it produces pride or the belief that salvation can be earned through personal effort.

Question 3 — How Does Satan Attempt to Tempt and Deceive Believers?

Answer:

The Bible presents Satan as a tempter and deceiver.

In Genesis 3, the serpent questioned God's command and misrepresented the consequences of disobedience.

In Matthew 4, Satan tempted Jesus by appealing to physical need, presumption, and worldly power.

The New Testament also warns that deception may appear under the disguise of righteousness.

These passages reveal that spiritual temptation may involve distorted truth, misplaced desires, pride, fear, and distrust of God.

However, Scripture does not teach that every temptation comes through a direct personal intervention by Satan.

James explains that temptation may also arise through human desires.

Paul describes a struggle involving the flesh and the Spirit.

Therefore, believers must recognize both spiritual opposition and their own moral responsibility.

The appropriate response includes faith, discernment, prayer, and obedience to God's Word.

Bible References:

- Genesis 3:1–6
- Matthew 4:1–11

- John 8:44
- 2 Corinthians 11:13–15
- Galatians 5:16–25
- James 1:12–15
- 1 Peter 5:8–9
- Revelation 12:9

Contextual Note:

The Bible identifies Satan as a deceiver, but it does not authorize attributing every negative thought, personal disagreement, or difficult circumstance to demonic activity.

Question 4 — What Is the Difference Between Temptation and Sin?

Answer:

Temptation is an enticement or pressure toward wrongdoing.

Sin involves a response contrary to God's will.

The Bible teaches that Jesus Christ experienced temptation yet remained without sin.

This distinction is important because the experience of temptation does not automatically mean that a person has committed a sinful act.

James describes a process in which desire, when embraced and allowed to develop, gives rise to sin.

Jesus also taught that deliberate sinful intentions may possess moral significance even before they become outward actions.

Therefore, the distinction between temptation and sin must not be reduced merely to the difference between thoughts and physical behavior.

The believer's response, intention, and consent are important.

Christians are encouraged to resist temptation through faith, prayer, and dependence upon God.

They should also remember that God's grace remains available when they fall.

Confession and repentance lead believers back to the mercy of Jesus Christ.

Bible References:

- Matthew 4:1–11
- Matthew 5:21–28
- 1 Corinthians 10:12–13
- Hebrews 2:17–18
- Hebrews 4:14–16
- James 1:12–15
- 1 John 1:8–9

Practical Note:

Unwanted intrusive thoughts, emotional distress, and mental health symptoms should not automatically be treated as deliberate sin. Spiritual counsel should be compassionate and should not replace appropriate professional care.

Question 5 — What Does the Bible Mean by the Whole Armor of God?

Answer:

The apostle Paul uses the image of armor to explain how believers may stand firm against spiritual opposition.

In Ephesians 6, the armor includes the belt of truth, the breastplate of righteousness, the preparation of the Gospel of peace, the shield of faith, the helmet of salvation, and the sword of the Spirit.

Prayer accompanies the entire description.

The imagery resembles the equipment of a soldier, but its meaning is spiritual.

Paul does not instruct Christians to attack human enemies.

He calls them to remain steadfast in the Lord.

The repeated emphasis upon standing demonstrates the importance of perseverance.

The armor is described as belonging to God.

This indicates that spiritual protection ultimately depends upon His provision.

Several elements also recall Old Testament descriptions of God's own righteousness and saving activity.

The armor therefore represents a life sustained by divine truth, grace, and power.

Bible References:

- Isaiah 11:1–5
- Isaiah 52:7
- Isaiah 59:15–17
- Romans 13:11–14
- 2 Corinthians 6:4–7
- Ephesians 6:10–18
- 1 Thessalonians 5:8

Linguistic and Historical Note:

Paul's imagery reflects familiar military equipment in the ancient world while drawing upon Old Testament descriptions of divine righteousness and salvation. The passage should be interpreted as a theological metaphor rather than instructions for physical combat.

Question 6 — What Does the Belt of Truth Represent?

Answer:

The first element of the armor is truth.

Paul instructs believers to stand with their loins girded about with truth.

In biblical teaching, truth is closely associated with God's character, His Word, and Jesus Christ.

Jesus declared Himself to be the way, the truth, and the life.

He also prayed that His disciples would be sanctified through God's truth.

Christian truthfulness involves more than possessing correct religious information.

It includes honesty, integrity, faithfulness, and a willingness to reject deception.

Believers must therefore examine teachings carefully and avoid deliberate falsehood.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, commitment to biblical truth is especially important in the context of spiritual deception and prophetic conflict.

However, the pursuit of truth must remain accompanied by humility and love.

Bible References:

- Psalm 119:142, 160
- Proverbs 12:22
- John 14:6
- John 17:17
- Ephesians 4:15, 25
- Ephesians 6:14

- 2 Thessalonians 2:9–12

Doctrinal Note:

The belt of truth should not be reduced to denominational identification. Biblical truth includes faithfulness to Jesus Christ, honesty in conduct, and responsible interpretation of Scripture.

Question 7 — What Does the Breastplate of Righteousness Represent?

Answer:

The breastplate of righteousness is the second element of the armor.

In the Old Testament, righteousness is associated with God's justice, faithfulness, and saving action.

Isaiah describes the Lord as putting on righteousness as a breastplate.

The New Testament teaches that believers receive righteousness through faith in Jesus Christ.

It also calls them to live righteously.

These two dimensions should be distinguished.

Christians are justified by God's grace through faith.

They are also called to demonstrate the transforming results of that grace in their conduct.

The breastplate of righteousness may therefore be understood in relation to both God's saving provision and the believer's commitment to righteous living.

However, personal obedience must never replace the righteousness of Jesus Christ as the foundation of salvation.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, righteousness by faith is central to victory in the Christian life.

Bible References:

- Isaiah 59:17
- Romans 3:21–26
- Romans 5:1–11
- Romans 6:12–19
- 2 Corinthians 5:21
- Ephesians 4:22–24
- Ephesians 6:14
- Philippians 3:7–11

Doctrinal Note:

The righteousness of Christ is the foundation of the believer's acceptance before God. A transformed life is the fruit of salvation, not its purchase price.

Question 8 — What Does the Gospel of Peace Mean in the Armor of God?

Answer:

Paul describes the believer's feet as prepared with the Gospel of peace.

The imagery emphasizes readiness and stability.

The Gospel announces reconciliation with God through Jesus Christ.

Paul teaches that believers who are justified by faith have peace with God through the Lord Jesus Christ.

The New Testament also calls Christians to pursue peace with others.

Therefore, the Gospel of peace includes both the saving message of reconciliation and its practical influence upon Christian conduct.

Believers are called to remain prepared to proclaim the Gospel.

They should also demonstrate its character through patience, compassion, and peacemaking.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, the proclamation of the everlasting Gospel is central to the Church's mission.

However, evangelism should not be characterized by hostility, manipulation, or coercion.

The message of peace must be communicated in a manner consistent with the character of Jesus Christ.

Bible References:

- Isaiah 52:7
- Matthew 5:9
- John 14:27
- Romans 5:1
- Romans 10:13–17
- Ephesians 2:13–18
- Ephesians 6:15
- Colossians 1:19–23

Doctrinal Note:

The Gospel of peace is not merely a command to avoid disagreement. It concerns reconciliation through Christ and the responsibility to communicate truth with love.

Question 9 — What Is the Shield of Faith, and How Does It Protect Believers?

Answer:

Paul instructs believers to take the shield of faith.

He explains that this shield enables them to withstand the fiery darts of the wicked.

The imagery suggests protection against spiritual attacks, temptations, accusations, and deception.

Biblical faith involves trust in God and confidence in His promises.

Hebrews describes faith in connection with assurance concerning things hoped for and conviction concerning things not seen.

The Bible also teaches that faith is strengthened through hearing God's Word.

Therefore, the shield of faith represents dependence upon God's faithfulness rather than confidence in human ability.

However, faith should not be treated as a guarantee that believers will never experience suffering, doubt, or hardship.

The heroes of faith described in Hebrews 11 include individuals who experienced persecution and death.

Faith enables believers to trust God amid difficulty.

It does not provide absolute immunity from trials.

Bible References:

- Genesis 15:6
- Psalm 28:7
- Romans 10:17
- Ephesians 2:8–10
- Ephesians 6:16
- Hebrews 11:1–40
- 1 Peter 1:6–9
- 1 John 5:4–5

Practical Note:

Experiencing fear, uncertainty, or emotional distress does not necessarily demonstrate an absence of faith. Biblical faith can coexist with suffering and the need for encouragement.

Question 10 — What Does the Helmet of Salvation Represent?

Answer:

The helmet of salvation represents the importance of God's saving work in the believer's spiritual perseverance.

In Isaiah, the Lord is described as wearing a helmet of salvation.

Paul uses similar imagery when encouraging Christians to remain spiritually prepared.

Salvation is accomplished through Jesus Christ.

Believers are called to place their hope in His saving grace.

The helmet imagery may therefore emphasize the protection and assurance associated with salvation.

Christian confidence should not rest upon perfect personal performance.

It should rest upon the promises of God and the completed saving work of Jesus Christ.

The New Testament also encourages believers to persevere in faith.

This perseverance is not an attempt to earn salvation.

It is the continuing response of trust in the Savior.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, the assurance of salvation must remain connected with faith in Christ rather than dependence upon human merit.

Bible References:

- Isaiah 59:17
- John 3:16–17
- Romans 5:1–11
- Romans 8:31–39
- Ephesians 2:8–10

- Ephesians 6:17
- 1 Thessalonians 5:8–11
- 1 John 5:11–13

Doctrinal Note:

Christian assurance is grounded in Jesus Christ. It should not be confused with spiritual presumption or with the belief that salvation is earned through flawless personal conduct.

Question 11 — What Is the Sword of the Spirit, Which Is the Word of God?

Answer:

Paul identifies the sword of the Spirit with the Word of God.

This is the principal explicitly offensive weapon in the armor imagery.

However, its use is spiritual rather than physical.

The Bible demonstrates the importance of God's Word in resisting temptation.

When Jesus was tempted in the wilderness, He responded by citing Scripture.

The New Testament also describes the Word of God as living and powerful.

Scripture provides instruction, correction, encouragement, and guidance.

Nevertheless, the Bible must be interpreted responsibly.

Satan himself quoted Scripture during the temptation of Jesus.

This demonstrates that biblical words may be misused when separated from their proper meaning.

Christians should therefore study the context of biblical passages and seek to understand their intended teaching.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, Scripture is the supreme written authority for Christian doctrine and conduct.

The sword of the Spirit should be used to defend truth and encourage faith, not to humiliate or attack people.

Bible References:

- Deuteronomy 8:3
- Psalm 119:9–11
- Matthew 4:1–11
- John 17:17
- 2 Timothy 3:14–17
- Hebrews 4:12–13
- Ephesians 6:17
- 2 Peter 1:19–21

Contextual Note:

The use of Scripture in spiritual warfare requires faithful interpretation. Isolated verses should not be treated as magical formulas or used without regard for their historical and literary contexts.

Question 12 — Why Are Prayer and Watchfulness Essential in Spiritual Warfare?

Answer:

After describing the armor of God, Paul encourages believers to pray always with perseverance.

Prayer is therefore closely connected with the entire passage.

Jesus taught His disciples to pray that they would not enter into temptation.

In Gethsemane, He instructed them to watch and pray.

The New Testament also encourages believers to bring their concerns before God with thanksgiving.

Prayer expresses dependence upon God.

It provides an opportunity for confession, gratitude, petition, and spiritual communion.

Watchfulness involves attentiveness to temptation, moral responsibility, and the believer's continuing need for grace.

However, prayer should not be treated as a mechanical technique that guarantees a particular outcome.

God's answers may differ from human expectations.

Christian prayer is grounded in trust in the wisdom and character of the heavenly Father.

Bible References:

- Matthew 6:5–13
- Matthew 26:36–46
- Luke 22:39–46
- Ephesians 6:18–20
- Philippians 4:6–7
- Colossians 4:2–4
- 1 Thessalonians 5:16–18
- Hebrews 4:14–16

Doctrinal Note:

Prayer is an essential expression of faith, but it should not be presented as a substitute for responsible action, medical care, reconciliation, or other appropriate forms of assistance.

Question 13 — How Should Christians Respond to Demonic Activity and Claims of Spiritual Possession?

Answer:

The Gospels record occasions when Jesus Christ confronted evil spirits and delivered individuals from demonic oppression.

The Book of Acts also describes encounters involving spiritual powers.

These passages demonstrate the authority of Jesus Christ over evil.

However, the Bible does not provide a complete modern diagnostic system for identifying demonic activity.

Physical illness, mental health conditions, neurological symptoms, trauma, and unusual behavior should not automatically be interpreted as evidence of possession.

Christians should respond to suffering individuals with compassion, dignity, and responsible care.

Prayer and pastoral support may be appropriate expressions of faith.

However, they should not replace medical or psychological evaluation when needed.

No person should be subjected to coercion, humiliation, violence, or dangerous practices under the claim of spiritual deliverance.

The New Testament directs believers toward the authority of Jesus Christ rather than sensationalism or fear.

Bible References:

- Mark 1:21–28
- Mark 5:1–20
- Luke 9:37–43
- Acts 16:16–18
- Acts 19:11–20
- James 5:13–16

- 1 John 4:1–6

Practical and Doctrinal Note:

The biblical accounts of demonic activity should be taken seriously within their literary and theological contexts. Nevertheless, modern claims concerning possession require great caution. Medical and psychological conditions must not be dismissed or treated through harmful religious practices.

Question 14 — How Can Christians Recognize and Resist Spiritual Deception in the Last Days?

Answer:

Jesus warned His disciples concerning false prophets, false messiahs, and deceptive signs.

The apostle Paul also described religious deception associated with opposition to God.

John instructed believers to test the spirits.

The Book of Revelation portrays deceptive powers influencing humanity through signs and false worship.

These passages demonstrate the importance of spiritual discernment.

Believers should examine religious claims according to Scripture and the Gospel of Jesus Christ.

Extraordinary experiences, persuasive personalities, and apparent miracles do not automatically establish divine authority.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, spiritual deception becomes particularly significant during the final events described in Daniel and Revelation.

Adventist theology connects these warnings with the great controversy, the commandments of God, and the final conflict over worship.

However, specific identifications of prophetic symbols require careful interpretation.

Christians should avoid unsupported accusations, sensational predictions, and attempts to identify every contemporary event as a direct fulfillment of prophecy.

Faithfulness requires truth, humility, patience, and confidence in Jesus Christ.

Bible References:

- Matthew 7:15–23
- Matthew 24:4–5, 23–26
- Acts 17:10–12
- 2 Thessalonians 2:1–12
- 1 John 4:1–6
- Revelation 12:17
- Revelation 13:11–18
- Revelation 14:6–12
- Revelation 16:13–14

Prophetic Note:

The Adventist interpretation of end-time deception is part of its historicist understanding of prophecy. Such interpretations should be distinguished from explicit biblical statements and presented without hostility toward people of other religious traditions.

Question 15 — How Can Believers Experience Victory Through Jesus Christ?

Answer:

The New Testament teaches that victory over sin and evil is grounded in Jesus Christ.

Paul declares that God gives victory through the Lord Jesus Christ.

He also teaches that believers are more than conquerors through Him who loved them.

John explains that the Son of God appeared to destroy the works of the devil.

Revelation describes faithful believers overcoming through the blood of the Lamb and the word of their testimony.

These passages place the foundation of Christian victory in the saving work of Christ.

Believers are called to respond through faith, repentance, obedience, perseverance, and dependence upon the Holy Spirit.

However, Christian victory does not mean that believers will never experience temptation, weakness, suffering, or spiritual struggle.

The New Testament repeatedly encourages perseverance precisely because trials remain part of Christian life.

When believers sin, they are called to confess and return to the grace of God.

The ultimate victory over Satan and death will be fully manifested through the final triumph of Jesus Christ.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, this hope is closely connected with the Second Coming, the final judgment, and the restoration of God's creation.

Bible References:

- John 16:33
- Romans 8:31–39
- 1 Corinthians 15:54–58
- 2 Corinthians 12:7–10
- Philippians 1:6
- Hebrews 12:1–3
- 1 John 1:8–9

- 1 John 3:8
- Revelation 12:11
- Revelation 21:1–5

Doctrinal Note:

Christian victory is not spiritual self-sufficiency. It is the continuing experience of God's grace and the ultimate assurance that Jesus Christ will bring sin, Satan, and death to an end.

Chapter Summary

The Holy Scriptures teach that believers face temptation, deception, and spiritual opposition.

However, they also reveal that Jesus Christ has accomplished the decisive victory over the powers of evil.

The apostle Paul describes the armor of God as the spiritual resources necessary for faithful Christian living.

This armor includes truth, righteousness, the Gospel of peace, faith, salvation, the Word of God, and prayer.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, spiritual warfare forms part of the great controversy between Christ and Satan.

Our study enables us to retain the following teachings:

1. Spiritual warfare concerns the believer's struggle against sin, deception, temptation, and spiritual opposition.

2. Christians must depend upon God's strength rather than their own abilities.

3. Satan employs temptation and deception, while human beings remain responsible for their moral choices.

4. Temptation does not automatically constitute sin; the believer's response is important.

5. The armor of God represents the spiritual resources provided by God for Christian perseverance.

6. The belt of truth emphasizes faithfulness to God's Word and honesty in conduct.

7. The breastplate of righteousness points toward God's saving righteousness and its transforming influence.

8. The Gospel of peace prepares believers to remain steadfast and proclaim reconciliation through Jesus Christ.

9. The shield of faith represents trust in God's promises amid temptation and difficulty.

10. The helmet of salvation emphasizes confidence in the saving grace of Jesus Christ.

11. The sword of the Spirit is the Word of God, which must be studied and applied faithfully.

12. Prayer and watchfulness express dependence upon God and strengthen Christian perseverance.

13. Biblical accounts of demonic activity must be approached with discernment, compassion, and responsible care.

14. Spiritual deception requires careful examination of religious claims according to Scripture.

15. Christian victory rests upon the saving work of Jesus Christ and will be fully manifested in His final triumph.

Doctrinal Conclusion

Spiritual warfare is an important dimension of Christian discipleship.

The Bible teaches that believers face temptation, deception, and spiritual opposition.

However, Scripture does not direct Christians toward fear or fascination with Satan.

Instead, it calls them to remain strong in the Lord and in the power of His might.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, spiritual warfare includes several essential dimensions.

Dependence Upon Jesus Christ

The believer's strength comes from the Savior, who has already accomplished the decisive victory over evil.

The Authority of God's Word

Scripture provides the foundation for spiritual discernment, moral instruction, and resistance to deception.

Righteousness by Faith

Christians are accepted by God through His grace and are called to demonstrate the transforming fruit of salvation.

Faith and Perseverance

Believers are encouraged to trust God's promises even amid suffering, uncertainty, and temptation.

Prayer and Watchfulness

Continual dependence upon God strengthens the Christian's spiritual life.

The Work of the Holy Spirit

The Holy Spirit guides believers into truth and produces the fruit of Christian character.

Discernment Concerning Spiritual Deception

Religious claims must be evaluated carefully according to Scripture and the Gospel of Jesus Christ.

Faithfulness in the Great Controversy

The believer is called to remain faithful to God amid the conflict between truth and deception.

The Final Victory of Christ

The ultimate defeat of Satan and evil is assured through the saving work and final triumph of Jesus Christ.

The biblical teaching concerning spiritual warfare must never become an excuse for fear, violence, coercion, or the rejection of appropriate medical and psychological care.

Its purpose is to encourage faith, obedience, love, courage, and perseverance.

The Essential Message:

Christians face temptation, deception, and spiritual opposition, but they are not called to fight through their own strength. God provides the spiritual armor necessary for faithful living: truth, righteousness, the Gospel of peace, faith, salvation, His Word, and prayer. In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, this struggle forms part of the great controversy between Christ and Satan. Nevertheless, the believer's confidence must remain centered upon Jesus Christ, whose saving work guarantees the ultimate defeat of sin and evil.

Personal Reflection Questions

1. What does the Bible teach about the nature of spiritual warfare?

2. Am I depending upon God's strength rather than merely upon my own determination?

3. How can I recognize temptation and respond faithfully to God's Word?

4. Do I understand the difference between experiencing temptation and deliberately choosing sin?

5. What does each part of the armor of God teach me about Christian life?

6. Am I allowing biblical truth and the righteousness of Christ to guide my decisions?

7. Does my faith remain centered upon God's promises when I face difficulty?

8. How can I strengthen my prayer life and study of the Holy Scriptures?

9. Am I exercising discernment without becoming fearful, suspicious, or judgmental toward others?

10. Does my understanding of spiritual warfare lead me toward greater trust in the victory of Jesus Christ?

Suggested Prayer

Lord my God,

I come before You with humility, gratitude, and faith.

You are my Creator, my Redeemer, and my heavenly Father.

Thank You for the victory accomplished through Jesus Christ.

Thank You for revealing Your truth through the Holy Scriptures.

I recognize that the Christian life involves temptation, struggle, and spiritual opposition.

I also acknowledge that I cannot overcome sin through my own strength.

Teach me to depend completely upon Your grace.

Clothe me with the whole armor of God.

Help me remain faithful to Your truth.

May righteousness guide my conduct.

Prepare my heart to proclaim the Gospel of peace.

Strengthen my faith when I face doubt, fear, or uncertainty.

Keep my hope centered upon the salvation provided through Jesus Christ.

Teach me to study and understand Your Word faithfully.

Protect me from deception, pride, and the misuse of Scripture.

Give me wisdom to recognize temptation and courage to resist it.

When I fall, lead me to repentance and restore my confidence in Your mercy.

Fill me with Your Holy Spirit.

Develop within me love, joy, peace, patience, kindness, goodness, faithfulness, gentleness, and self-control.

Help me remain watchful without becoming fearful.

May I never interpret every difficulty as evidence of demonic activity.

Give me compassion for those who suffer physically, emotionally, or spiritually.

Teach me to encourage others rather than condemn them.

Protect me from religious manipulation and false teachings.

Guide me to examine every spiritual claim according to Your Holy Word.

Above all, keep my heart fixed upon Jesus Christ.

He is my Savior, my Advocate, and my hope.

I trust in His sacrifice, His resurrection, and His promise to return.

Thank You for the assurance that evil will not continue forever.

Prepare me for the glorious return of Jesus Christ.

Until that day, help me stand firm in faith, walk in truth, demonstrate love, and remain completely dependent upon You.

In the name of Jesus Christ, my Savior and Lord.

Amen.

CHAPTER 31 — DEATH AND THE STATE OF THE DEAD: WHAT HAPPENS WHEN A PERSON DIES?

A Thematic Bible Study — King James Version (KJV)

Opening Scripture

> “For the living know that they shall die: but the dead know not any thing, neither have they any more a reward; for the memory of them is forgotten.”

Ecclesiastes 9:5 — KJV

Introduction

In the preceding chapter, we examined spiritual warfare and the armor of God.

We discovered that believers are called to resist temptation, remain faithful to Scripture, and depend upon the victory of Jesus Christ.

We also learned that the Bible warns against spiritual deception and directs Christians toward faith, discernment, and trust in God.

These teachings introduce another important subject: the condition of human beings after death.

Throughout history, people have asked profound questions concerning death and the possibility of life beyond the grave.

What happens when a person dies?

Does the soul continue to live consciously after the body has died?

Can the dead communicate with the living?

Do the righteous immediately enter heaven?

What is the relationship between death, resurrection, judgment, and eternal life?

These questions have influenced religious beliefs, philosophical discussions, cultural traditions, and personal experiences of grief.

The Holy Scriptures address death from several perspectives.

Genesis describes the creation of humanity from the dust of the ground and the breath of life given by God.

The Old Testament frequently associates death with the return of the body to the dust.

Ecclesiastes describes the dead as having no further participation in the activities of life under the sun.

The Psalms contain reflections concerning mortality, the grave, and the hope of divine deliverance.

Jesus Christ compared death to sleep when speaking about Lazarus.

The apostle Paul connected the Christian hope with the resurrection of the dead at the return of Jesus Christ.

The Book of Revelation describes the resurrection, final judgment, and ultimate destruction of death.

However, some biblical passages have been interpreted differently among Christian traditions.

The account of the rich man and Lazarus, Jesus' promise to the repentant criminal on the cross, Paul's desire to depart and be with Christ, and the souls beneath the altar in Revelation are especially important.

A responsible study must examine these passages within their literary and theological contexts.

In Seventh-day Adventist theology, human beings are understood as unified living persons rather than bodies containing naturally immortal, independently conscious souls.

Death is described as an unconscious sleep until the resurrection.

Immortality is understood as a gift granted through Jesus Christ rather than an inherent possession of humanity.

This interpretation is often called conditional immortality or Christian mortalism.

Other Christian traditions teach that the soul or an intermediate aspect of personal existence remains conscious between death and resurrection.

These differences should be acknowledged and examined fairly.

The purpose of this chapter is not merely to describe death.

It is to understand the biblical hope that God has provided through Jesus Christ.

The Christian's ultimate confidence rests not in human immortality but in the Savior who conquered death and promises resurrection and eternal life.

Question 1 — How Does the Bible Describe the Creation of Human Life?

Answer:

Genesis 2:7 describes God forming man from the dust of the ground and breathing into his nostrils the breath of life.

The result was a living soul.

This passage presents human life as the result of God's creative action.

The body formed from the dust and the breath of life together constitute the living human being described in the narrative.

The Hebrew expression translated as living soul is related to the word nephesh.

This term can refer to a living being, person, life, or creature, depending upon its context.

It does not always identify an immaterial entity capable of existing consciously apart from the body.

Genesis also uses related terminology for living animals.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, these passages support the teaching that a human being is a unified living person.

Humanity does not possess natural immortality independently of God.

However, other Christian traditions understand Genesis 2:7 within a broader theological framework that includes a distinction between the material body and an immaterial soul.

The passage itself should be examined carefully before drawing conclusions concerning the intermediate state after death.

Bible References:

- Genesis 1:26–27
- Genesis 2:7
- Genesis 2:19
- Genesis 7:21–22
- Job 33:4
- Psalm 104:29–30
- Acts 17:24–28

Linguistic Note:

The Hebrew word nephesh has a range of meanings. Translating it as soul does not automatically establish the Greek philosophical concept of an inherently immortal soul.

Question 2 — What Does the Bible Teach About the Nature of the Human Soul?

Answer:

The word soul appears frequently throughout the Bible.

However, its meaning varies according to context.

In the Old Testament, the Hebrew word nephesh may refer to a person, a living creature, life itself, or the inner experience of an individual.

In the New Testament, the Greek word psychē also has a range of meanings, including life, person, and soul.

Jesus taught that whoever seeks to save his life will lose it, while whoever loses his life for His sake will find it.

The Greek word translated as life in such passages is often psychē.

These examples demonstrate that the biblical vocabulary concerning the soul cannot be reduced to one technical definition in every passage.

Ezekiel declares that the soul that sins shall die.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, this statement supports the mortality of the human person.

Other Christian traditions interpret the passage as referring to the person subject to divine judgment rather than as a direct denial of conscious existence after bodily death.

The biblical evidence must therefore be considered as a whole.

Bible References:

- Genesis 2:7
- Leviticus 17:11
- Ezekiel 18:4, 20
- Matthew 10:28

- Matthew 16:24–26
- Luke 12:19–20
- Acts 2:41
- 1 Peter 3:20

Doctrinal Note:

Seventh-day Adventist theology understands the soul primarily as the living person. Other Christian traditions distinguish between the soul and body while also affirming the importance of bodily resurrection.

Question 3 — What Is the Difference Between the Breath of Life and the Spirit?

Answer:

The Bible uses several terms associated with breath, wind, and spirit.

In the Old Testament, the Hebrew word ruach may refer to wind, breath, spirit, or the activity of God's Spirit.

The meaning depends upon the context.

Ecclesiastes describes death as the return of the dust to the earth and the spirit to God who gave it.

Psalm 104 connects the withdrawal of breath with death and the return of creatures to the dust.

James teaches that the body without the spirit is dead.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, the spirit that returns to God at death is understood as the life principle or breath of life received from the Creator.

It is not regarded as an independently conscious human personality continuing its ordinary mental activities after death.

Other Christian traditions interpret the spirit as an immaterial aspect of the person that may continue consciously after bodily death.

The biblical terminology itself is broad.

Therefore, the meaning of the spirit in a particular passage must be determined from the surrounding context.

Bible References:

- Genesis 2:7
- Job 27:3
- Job 34:14–15
- Psalm 104:29–30
- Ecclesiastes 12:7
- Luke 23:46
- Acts 7:59
- James 2:26

Linguistic Note:

The Hebrew ruach and Greek pneuma can refer to breath, wind, or spirit. Their use does not automatically establish whether a deceased human being experiences consciousness apart from the body.

Question 4 — What Happens to the Human Body at Death?

Answer:

The Bible teaches that human beings are mortal and that their bodies return to the dust.

After the fall, God declared that Adam would return to the ground from which he had been taken.

Ecclesiastes similarly describes the dust returning to the earth.

The physical body is subject to weakness, aging, and death.

The New Testament also teaches that the present mortal body is subject to corruption.

However, bodily death is not presented as the final destiny of those who belong to Jesus Christ.

Paul explains that the resurrection will involve a transformation from corruption to incorruption and from mortality to immortality.

The Christian hope therefore includes the restoration and transformation of embodied human life.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, the complete human person dies and awaits resurrection.

Other Christian traditions also affirm bodily resurrection but understand an intermediate conscious existence between death and resurrection.

The common biblical foundation is that the resurrection is essential to the final victory over death.

Bible References:

- Genesis 3:19
- Job 14:10–12
- Psalm 90:3–12
- Ecclesiastes 3:19–21
- Ecclesiastes 12:7
- Romans 8:10–11
- 1 Corinthians 15:42–54

Doctrinal Note:

The biblical promise of resurrection should not be confused with the mere survival of an immaterial soul. The New Testament emphasizes the transformation and restoration of human life through God's power.

Question 5 — Are the Dead Conscious of What Happens Among the Living?

Answer:

Ecclesiastes 9 describes the dead as knowing nothing and having no further participation in the activities carried out under the sun.

The Psalms also associate death with silence and the cessation of ordinary human activity.

Psalm 146 explains that when a person's breath departs, his thoughts perish.

These passages are central to the Seventh-day Adventist understanding of death as an unconscious state.

However, their literary contexts require attention.

Ecclesiastes frequently examines human existence from the perspective of life under the sun.

Some Christian interpreters therefore understand its statements as describing the dead person's lack of participation in earthly affairs rather than providing a complete account of the intermediate state.

Other passages, including Luke 16, Luke 23, and Philippians 1, are interpreted by many Christians as indicating conscious existence after death.

The Adventist position is that the clearest descriptions of death, together with the biblical emphasis upon resurrection, support unconsciousness until Christ restores life.

This conclusion is part of a broader theological interpretation of Scripture.

Bible References:

- Job 14:10–12, 21
- Psalm 6:5
- Psalm 115:17
- Psalm 146:3–4
- Ecclesiastes 9:5–10
- John 11:11–14
- 1 Thessalonians 4:13–18

Contextual Note:

Ecclesiastes 9 is an important passage concerning death, but its language must be considered within the book's larger reflection on mortality and human existence.

Question 6 — Why Does the Bible Frequently Compare Death to Sleep?

Answer:

The Bible repeatedly uses sleep as an image of death.

Daniel describes those who sleep in the dust of the earth as awakening to different destinies.

Jesus referred to Lazarus as sleeping and then explained that Lazarus was dead.

Paul also used the language of sleep when discussing believers who had died before the return of Jesus Christ.

The imagery emphasizes the temporary nature of death in relation to God's power to raise the dead.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, the comparison supports the teaching that the dead remain unconscious until the resurrection.

Other Christian traditions understand sleep primarily as a metaphor for the body's condition or the temporary character of death, without necessarily denying consciousness in an intermediate state.

The metaphor alone does not resolve every theological question.

However, the repeated connection between sleep and awakening strongly emphasizes the central importance of resurrection.

Bible References:

- Deuteronomy 31:16
- Job 14:10–12
- Daniel 12:2

- Matthew 9:23–26
- John 11:11–14
- Acts 7:59–60
- 1 Corinthians 15:18–20
- 1 Thessalonians 4:13–16

Doctrinal Note:

The sleep metaphor is central to Adventist teaching concerning the state of the dead. Other Christians accept the same biblical imagery while interpreting the intermediate state differently.

Question 7 — What Does the Resurrection of Lazarus Teach About Death?

Answer:

John 11 records the sickness, death, and resurrection of Lazarus.

When Jesus learned of Lazarus's condition, He referred to his death as sleep.

The disciples initially misunderstood the expression.

Jesus then explained plainly that Lazarus was dead.

When Jesus arrived at Bethany, Lazarus had already been in the tomb for four days.

Martha expressed her belief that her brother would rise again at the resurrection on the last day.

Jesus responded by declaring Himself to be the resurrection and the life.

He then called Lazarus from the tomb.

This event demonstrates the authority of Jesus Christ over death.

It also reveals the importance of the future resurrection in Jewish and early Christian hope.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, the account supports the belief that Lazarus had been unconscious in death and was restored to life by Christ.

However, the narrative does not explicitly describe Lazarus's subjective experience during the four days.

The absence of such a description should not be presented as direct proof of every detail of the intermediate state.

Bible References:

- John 5:25–29
- John 6:39–40
- John 11:1–44
- Romans 8:11
- 1 Corinthians 15:20–23

Explanatory Note:

The central purpose of John 11 is to reveal Jesus Christ as the resurrection and the life. The passage should not be reduced exclusively to a debate about consciousness after death.

Question 8 — Does the Bible Teach That Human Beings Are Naturally Immortal?

Answer:

The Bible describes God as possessing immortality.

Paul declares that God alone has immortality in the sense expressed by 1 Timothy 6:16.

The New Testament also teaches that eternal life is a gift received through Jesus Christ.

Romans contrasts the wages of sin, which is death, with the gift of eternal life through the Savior.

In 1 Corinthians 15, Paul explains that mortality must put on immortality at the resurrection.

These passages are central to the Seventh-day Adventist doctrine of conditional immortality.

According to this understanding, human beings do not possess immortality as an inherent and indestructible quality.

Eternal life is granted through Jesus Christ.

Other Christian traditions distinguish between God's essential immortality and the continuing existence of a created human soul.

They therefore do not regard 1 Timothy 6:16 as excluding every form of conscious existence after bodily death.

The biblical distinction between God's self-existent life and humanity's dependence upon Him is nevertheless fundamental.

Bible References:

- Genesis 3:22–24
- Psalm 90:1–2
- Romans 2:6–7
- Romans 6:23
- 1 Corinthians 15:51–54
- 1 Timothy 6:13–16
- 2 Timothy 1:9–10
- 1 John 5:11–13

Doctrinal Note:

Conditional immortality is a distinctive emphasis of Seventh-day Adventist theology. The interpretation of passages concerning the soul, eternal life, and final punishment differs among Christian traditions.

Question 9 — What Did Jesus Mean When He Promised Paradise to the Repentant Criminal?

Answer:

Luke 23 records a conversation between Jesus and one of the criminals crucified beside Him.

The criminal asked Jesus to remember him when He came into His kingdom.

Jesus responded with a promise concerning paradise.

In the King James Version, the verse reads:

> “And Jesus said unto him, Verily I say unto thee, To day shalt thou be with me in paradise.”

Luke 23:43 — KJV

Many Christians understand this statement as promising that the repentant criminal would be with Christ in paradise on the day of his death.

Seventh-day Adventists interpret the statement differently.

They emphasize that the earliest Greek manuscripts did not contain modern punctuation.

They understand Jesus' words as an assurance given that day concerning a future entrance into paradise.

In this interpretation, the sense is that Jesus was making the promise on that very day, rather than declaring that the criminal would enter paradise immediately.

Adventists also compare the passage with John 20:17, where the resurrected Jesus tells Mary that He has not yet ascended to His Father.

However, the placement of the comma in Luke 23:43 is debated.

The usual Greek construction is commonly understood as supporting the traditional reading.

Therefore, the Adventist punctuation is an interpretive choice and should not be presented as an uncontested grammatical fact.

The central teaching remains that salvation and the hope of paradise are found through Jesus Christ.

Bible References:

- Luke 23:39–43
- John 14:1–3
- John 20:11–17
- 1 Corinthians 15:20–23
- Revelation 2:7
- Revelation 22:1–5

Textual and Linguistic Note:

Ancient Greek manuscripts generally lacked modern punctuation. This permits discussion of punctuation, but it does not make every proposed reading equally likely. The Adventist interpretation of Luke 23:43 should be identified as a minority reading within broader Christian scholarship.

Question 10 — What Does the Parable of the Rich Man and Lazarus Teach?

Answer:

Luke 16 records Jesus' account of a rich man and a poor man named Lazarus.

After their deaths, the rich man is portrayed in torment, while Lazarus is comforted in Abraham's bosom.

The account includes a conversation concerning suffering, repentance, and the testimony of Moses and the prophets.

Many Christian traditions understand the passage as supporting conscious existence after death.

Some interpret it as a literal description of the intermediate state, while others recognize parabolic features but still see implications for postmortem consciousness.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, the account is treated as a parable or illustrative narrative rather than a literal map of the condition of the dead.

Adventists emphasize its moral lessons concerning wealth, compassion, repentance, and the sufficiency of Scripture.

The narrative's vivid imagery includes details that are difficult to reconcile with a straightforward literal description of heaven and hell.

However, identifying a passage as a parable does not automatically establish that every element lacks theological significance.

The interpretation must consider Jesus' purpose and the wider biblical teaching.

The central warning is that people must respond faithfully to God's revealed truth during their present lives.

Bible References:

- Luke 16:19–31
- Luke 12:13–21
- Luke 16:1–18
- Ecclesiastes 9:5–10
- John 5:28–29
- Revelation 20:11–15

Contextual Note:

The rich man and Lazarus account must be examined within Luke 16, including Jesus' teaching concerning wealth, faithfulness, and the authority of Scripture. Its relationship to the intermediate state remains debated.

Question 11 — What Did Paul Mean When He Desired to Depart and Be With Christ?

Answer:

In Philippians 1, Paul expresses his desire to depart and be with Christ.

He also explains that remaining alive would benefit the believers he served.

In 2 Corinthians 5, Paul uses the imagery of being at home or absent from the body and expresses his desire to be present with the Lord.

Many Christians interpret these passages as teaching that believers enter conscious fellowship with Christ immediately after death.

Seventh-day Adventists understand them in connection with the resurrection hope.

According to the Adventist interpretation, the deceased believer experiences no conscious passage of time between death and resurrection.

Consequently, the next conscious experience after death would be the presence of Christ at the resurrection.

Adventists also emphasize Paul's teaching in 1 Corinthians 15 and 1 Thessalonians 4 concerning the future resurrection.

However, Philippians 1 and 2 Corinthians 5 do not explicitly describe an unconscious interval.

The Adventist explanation is therefore a theological synthesis rather than the immediate and undisputed meaning of those passages.

The essential biblical hope is that believers ultimately belong to Christ and will share in His victory over death.

Bible References:

- John 14:1–3
- Romans 8:38–39
- 1 Corinthians 15:20–23
- 2 Corinthians 5:1–10
- Philippians 1:20–26
- Philippians 3:20–21
- 1 Thessalonians 4:13–18

Doctrinal Note:

The interpretation of Philippians 1:23 and 2 Corinthians 5:8 is a major point of disagreement between conditionalist and traditional intermediate-state theology. Both perspectives affirm the ultimate hope of fellowship with Jesus Christ.

Question 12 — Can the Dead Communicate With the Living?

Answer:

The Old Testament explicitly prohibits attempts to consult the dead through mediums and related practices.

Deuteronomy identifies such practices as contrary to God's instructions for Israel.

Isaiah directs people toward God's law and testimony rather than those who claim to communicate with the dead.

The account of Saul and the medium at Endor is especially important.

The narrative describes Saul seeking guidance through a forbidden practice after becoming estranged from God.

Christian traditions interpret the appearance described in 1 Samuel 28 differently.

Some understand the narrative as an exceptional appearance of Samuel permitted by God.

Others interpret it as a deceptive spiritual manifestation.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, the dead are unconscious and therefore cannot communicate with the living.

Consequently, claimed communications from deceased persons are understood as deception, fraud, misinterpretation, or potentially demonic activity.

However, not every unusual experience should automatically be classified as supernatural.

Experiences associated with grief, dreams, memory, or psychological distress may have ordinary explanations.

The biblical instruction remains clear: believers should not seek spiritual guidance through attempts to contact the dead.

Bible References:

- Leviticus 19:31
- Deuteronomy 18:9–14
- 1 Samuel 28:3–25
- Isaiah 8:19–20
- Ecclesiastes 9:5–10
- 2 Corinthians 11:13–15
- 1 John 4:1

Doctrinal Note:

The prohibition against consulting the dead is explicit in Scripture. The precise explanation of every reported spiritual manifestation is not. Christians should avoid both forbidden occult practices and unsupported accusations concerning personal experiences.

Question 13 — What Is the Meaning of the Souls Under the Altar in Revelation?

Answer:

Revelation 6 describes souls beneath the altar crying out for divine justice.

They are identified as those who had been slain because of the Word of God and their testimony.

The passage appears within an apocalyptic vision containing symbolic imagery.

Many Christian interpreters understand the souls as representing deceased martyrs who remain conscious in God's presence.

In Seventh-day Adventist interpretation, the passage is understood symbolically.

The cry for justice is compared with the blood of Abel, which God described as crying from the ground.

Within this reading, the imagery represents the appeal for divine vindication arising from the suffering and death of faithful witnesses.

The passage is not treated as a literal description of disembodied souls physically located beneath a heavenly altar.

However, the symbolic nature of Revelation does not by itself settle every question concerning the intermediate state.

The passage must be interpreted within the broader biblical teaching about martyrdom, judgment, resurrection, and God's justice.

Its central message is that God has not forgotten those who suffer and die because of their faithfulness.

Bible References:

- Genesis 4:8–10
- Hebrews 11:4

- Revelation 6:9–11
- Revelation 7:9–17
- Revelation 12:11
- Revelation 20:4–6

Prophetic Note:

Revelation uses symbols, visions, and dramatic imagery. The souls beneath the altar are interpreted differently among Christian traditions, and their significance should not be reduced to an isolated argument concerning consciousness after death.

Question 14 — When Will the Righteous Dead Be Raised to Life?

Answer:

The New Testament repeatedly connects the resurrection of believers with the return of Jesus Christ.

Jesus declared that those in the graves would hear His voice and come forth.

He also promised to raise believers at the last day.

Paul explained that Christ is the firstfruits of those who have fallen asleep.

He then connected the resurrection of those who belong to Christ with His coming.

In 1 Thessalonians 4, Paul teaches that the dead in Christ will rise first when the Lord descends from heaven.

The living believers will then be caught up together with them to meet the Lord.

These passages provide a central foundation for the Christian hope of resurrection.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, the righteous dead remain unconscious until this event.

At Christ's return, they are raised to immortal life.

Other Christian traditions also affirm the future bodily resurrection but understand believers as conscious with Christ during the intermediate state.

The resurrection remains essential in both perspectives.

Bible References:

- Daniel 12:2
- John 5:28–29
- John 6:39–40
- John 11:23–26
- 1 Corinthians 15:20–23
- 1 Corinthians 15:51–54
- 1 Thessalonians 4:13–18
- Philippians 3:20–21

Doctrinal Note:

The future resurrection of believers is a central New Testament teaching shared across major Christian traditions. The principal disagreement concerns the condition of believers between death and resurrection.

Question 15 — How Does the Biblical Hope of Resurrection Overcome the Fear of Death?

Answer:

The Bible acknowledges death as a painful and serious reality.

Jesus Himself wept at the tomb of Lazarus.

The New Testament does not command believers to deny grief or pretend that death is insignificant.

Instead, it offers hope through the resurrection of Jesus Christ.

Paul teaches that Christ has been raised from the dead and that His resurrection guarantees the future resurrection of those who belong to Him.

He describes death as the last enemy to be destroyed.

The Book of Revelation promises a renewed creation in which death, sorrow, crying, and pain will no longer exist.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, this hope is especially meaningful because the dead are understood as resting unconsciously until the resurrection.

Death does not represent the final destruction of God's promises.

The believer's future rests in the power of Jesus Christ to restore life.

Christians are therefore encouraged to grieve with hope.

They may acknowledge sorrow while trusting the Savior who conquered the grave.

The final victory belongs to Jesus Christ, who promises eternal life and the restoration of God's creation.

Bible References:

- Psalm 23:1–6
- John 11:25–26, 35
- John 14:1–3
- Romans 8:31–39
- 1 Corinthians 15:20–28
- 1 Corinthians 15:51–58
- 1 Thessalonians 4:13–18
- Revelation 21:1–5

Pastoral Note:

Biblical hope does not eliminate the natural experience of grief. Christians should support those who mourn with compassion, patience, practical assistance, and the promises of Scripture.

Chapter Summary

The Holy Scriptures present human life as a gift from God.

The creation account describes humanity as formed from the dust of the ground and animated by the breath of life.

The Bible also teaches that death is a reality associated with the fallen human condition.

Throughout Scripture, death is frequently compared to sleep.

The New Testament places the Christian hope upon the resurrection of Jesus Christ and the promised resurrection of believers.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, the dead remain unconscious until the resurrection.

Immortality is a gift received through Jesus Christ rather than an inherent possession of human beings.

Our study enables us to retain the following teachings:

1. Human life originates with God, who formed humanity from the dust and gave the breath of life.

2. The biblical word soul has several meanings and does not always refer to an independently conscious immaterial entity.

3. The biblical terms for breath and spirit must be interpreted according to their contexts.

4. The human body returns to the dust at death, while the Christian hope includes bodily resurrection.

5. Ecclesiastes and the Psalms contain important descriptions of the dead as no longer participating in ordinary earthly life.

6. The Bible frequently compares death to sleep and connects awakening with resurrection.

7. The resurrection of Lazarus demonstrates the authority of Jesus Christ over death.

8. The New Testament presents immortality and eternal life as dependent upon God and His saving work.

9. Jesus' promise to the repentant criminal in Luke 23:43 is interpreted differently among Christian traditions.

10. The account of the rich man and Lazarus must be studied within its literary and moral context.

11. Paul's desire to be with Christ is central to debates concerning the intermediate state.

12. Scripture prohibits attempts to consult the dead for spiritual guidance.

13. The souls beneath the altar in Revelation are part of an apocalyptic vision concerning martyrdom and divine justice.

14. The New Testament clearly connects the resurrection of believers with the return of Jesus Christ.

15. The Christian hope rests upon Christ's victory over death and the promise of eternal life.

Doctrinal Conclusion

The biblical teaching concerning death addresses one of the most important questions of human existence.

What happens when life ends?

The Holy Scriptures reveal that human life originates with God and remains dependent upon His power.

They describe death as the return of the body to the dust and repeatedly connect the Christian hope with resurrection.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, these teachings support the doctrine of the unconscious state of the dead.

The Unity of Human Life

Humanity is understood as a unified living existence created by God.

The biblical language concerning soul and spirit must be examined according to context.

The Reality of Human Mortality

Human beings are mortal and subject to death.

Immortality is not understood as an inherent human possession.

Death as a Sleep

The Bible frequently compares death to sleep.

Seventh-day Adventists understand this imagery as supporting unconsciousness until resurrection.

The Authority of Jesus Christ Over Death

The resurrection of Lazarus and the resurrection of Jesus Christ demonstrate divine power over the grave.

The Importance of Biblical Interpretation

Passages such as Luke 16, Luke 23:43, Philippians 1, 2 Corinthians 5, and Revelation 6 require careful examination.

Different Christian traditions interpret their implications for the intermediate state differently.

The Prohibition Against Consulting the Dead

Scripture directs believers away from attempts to communicate with the dead and toward God's revealed Word.

The Promise of Resurrection

The righteous dead will be raised through the power of Jesus Christ.

The resurrection is central to the Christian hope.

The Final Destruction of Death

God promises a renewed creation in which death, suffering, and sorrow will no longer exist.

The biblical teaching concerning the state of the dead should not be used to produce fear or religious hostility.

Its purpose is to strengthen confidence in Jesus Christ.

The Savior who conquered death has promised eternal life to those who believe in Him.

The Essential Message:

Human life is a gift from God, and death is an enemy that entered the human experience through sin. The Bible frequently describes death as sleep and places the Christian hope upon the resurrection. Seventh-day Adventist theology teaches that the dead remain unconscious until Jesus Christ raises them to life and grants immortality. Other Christian traditions understand the intermediate state differently, but the New Testament clearly proclaims that Jesus Christ has conquered death and will ultimately restore His people to everlasting life.

Personal Reflection Questions

1. What does Genesis 2:7 teach about the origin and nature of human life?

2. How should I understand the biblical meanings of soul, spirit, and breath?

3. What does the Bible teach about the condition of the body after death?

4. Why does Scripture frequently compare death to sleep?

5. What does the resurrection of Lazarus reveal about the power of Jesus Christ?

6. How does the biblical teaching concerning immortality influence my understanding of eternal life?

7. Have I carefully examined the different interpretations of Luke 23:43, Luke 16, and Philippians 1?

8. Why does Scripture prohibit attempts to communicate with the dead?

9. What does 1 Thessalonians 4:13–18 teach about the resurrection at Christ's return?

10. How does the promise of resurrection strengthen my faith and comfort me when facing death or grief?

Suggested Prayer

Lord my God,

I come before You with humility, gratitude, and faith.

You are the Creator of heaven and earth.

You are the Giver of life and the source of every good gift.

Thank You for creating humanity and revealing Your love through the Holy Scriptures.

I recognize that human life is fragile and that death is a painful reality in this fallen world.

At times, I struggle with questions concerning mortality, suffering, and the loss of loved ones.

Help me understand Your Word faithfully.

Teach me to distinguish biblical truth from human traditions and speculation.

Give me wisdom as I study the nature of humanity, the soul, the spirit, and the condition of the dead.

Protect me from spiritual deception.

Help me place my trust in Your promises rather than in fear or uncertainty.

Thank You for sending Jesus Christ into the world.

Thank You for His perfect life, His sacrifice upon the cross, and His glorious resurrection.

I acknowledge that He alone is the resurrection and the life.

When I face grief, strengthen my heart with the hope of His return.

Comfort those who have lost loved ones.

Give them peace, patience, and the assurance of Your love.

Help me show compassion toward those who mourn.

May I never use religious teaching to increase their suffering.

Teach me to live faithfully during the time You have entrusted to me.

Help me value every day as an opportunity to love, serve, and glorify You.

Keep my faith centered upon Jesus Christ.

I trust in His promise to raise the dead and grant eternal life.

Thank You for the assurance that death will not reign forever.

Thank You for the promise of a new heaven and a new earth where sorrow, crying, pain, and death will be no more.

Prepare me for the glorious return of Jesus Christ.

Until that day, help me live with faith, courage, compassion, and complete dependence upon You.

In the name of Jesus Christ, my Savior and Lord.

Amen.

CHAPTER 32 — THE RESURRECTION OF THE DEAD: HOW WILL GOD RESTORE LIFE TO THOSE WHO HAVE DIED?

A Thematic Bible Study — King James Version (KJV)

Opening Scripture

> “Jesus said unto her, I am the resurrection, and the life: he that believeth in me, though he were dead, yet shall he live:”

John 11:25 — KJV

Introduction

In the preceding chapter, we examined death and the state of the dead.

We discovered that the Holy Scriptures present human life as a gift from God and repeatedly describe death through the imagery of sleep.

We also examined the Seventh-day Adventist understanding that the dead remain unconscious until the resurrection, while acknowledging the different interpretations held by other Christian traditions.

However, the biblical message does not end with death.

The Holy Scriptures proclaim a greater hope: the resurrection of the dead.

The resurrection is one of the central doctrines of Christianity.

It reveals God's power over death and demonstrates that the grave does not have the final word concerning human existence.

The Old Testament contains promises and expectations concerning the restoration of life.

The prophet Daniel describes a future awakening of those who sleep in the dust of the earth.

Jesus Christ taught that the dead would hear His voice and come forth.

He demonstrated His authority over death by raising individuals during His earthly ministry.

Most importantly, the New Testament proclaims that Jesus Himself rose from the dead.

His resurrection forms the foundation of the Christian hope.

The apostle Paul explains that if Christ has not been raised, Christian faith is empty.

But because Christ has risen, believers may look forward to their own resurrection.

The Bible also teaches that the resurrection is connected with judgment, the return of Jesus Christ, and the final restoration of God's creation.

Nevertheless, important questions remain.

What is resurrection? Is it different from the immortality of the soul? Why is the resurrection of Jesus Christ essential? What kind of body will the redeemed receive? Will both the righteous and the wicked be raised? What is the meaning of the first resurrection in Revelation 20? When will the resurrection take place? What is the relationship between resurrection, judgment, and eternal life?

In Seventh-day Adventist theology, the resurrection is closely connected with conditional immortality and the doctrine of the unconscious state of the dead.

Adventists understand the resurrection of the righteous as taking place at the Second Coming of Jesus Christ.

They also interpret Revelation 20 as describing a later resurrection of the wicked, associated with the conclusion of the millennium and the

final judgment.

Other Christian traditions interpret some of these prophetic passages differently.

Therefore, careful distinction must be maintained between the explicit teachings of Scripture and particular eschatological interpretations.

This chapter examines fifteen questions concerning the biblical doctrine of resurrection.

Our objective is to understand how the resurrection reveals God's saving power, establishes the Christian hope, and points toward the final victory of Jesus Christ over death.

Question 1 — What Does the Bible Mean by the Resurrection of the Dead?

Answer:

The resurrection of the dead refers to God's act of restoring life to those who have died.

The biblical teaching of resurrection goes beyond the idea that some immaterial aspect of a person continues to exist after bodily death.

It concerns the restoration of human life through divine power.

In the Old Testament, the prophet Daniel describes those who sleep in the dust of the earth awakening.

Jesus taught that those in the graves would hear His voice and come forth.

The apostle Paul explained that the dead would be raised and that the bodies of the redeemed would be transformed.

These passages demonstrate that resurrection is a divine act.

Human beings do not possess the power to restore themselves from death.

The resurrection depends entirely upon God, who is the source of life.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, resurrection restores the complete human person to conscious life.

Other Christian traditions affirm bodily resurrection while also teaching conscious existence of the soul during the intermediate state.

Despite these differences, the future resurrection remains a foundational Christian doctrine.

Bible References:

- Job 19:25–27
- Isaiah 26:19
- Daniel 12:2
- John 5:28–29
- John 6:39–40
- Acts 24:14–15
- 1 Corinthians 15:12–23

Doctrinal Note:

Resurrection should not be confused with reincarnation or with the mere continuation of an immaterial soul. The biblical doctrine concerns God's restoration and transformation of human life.

Question 2 — Was the Hope of Resurrection Revealed in the Old Testament?

Answer:

Yes.

Although the Old Testament develops the subject progressively, several passages express confidence in God's power over death.

Isaiah declares that the dead shall live and that those who dwell in the dust shall awaken.

Daniel speaks of a future resurrection involving different destinies.

The Book of Job contains a declaration of hope in a living Redeemer, although the interpretation of its precise relationship to bodily resurrection is debated.

The Psalms also express confidence that God will not abandon His faithful servants to the power of death.

These passages demonstrate that the hope of divine deliverance from death did not originate only in the New Testament.

However, the Old Testament does not present the resurrection doctrine with equal clarity in every book.

Some passages concern national restoration, deliverance from danger, or confidence in God's continuing care.

For example, Ezekiel's vision of the dry bones directly illustrates the restoration of Israel from national despair and exile.

It also provides powerful imagery of God's ability to restore life, but its immediate purpose is not a detailed description of the final bodily resurrection.

The New Testament develops the resurrection hope more fully through Jesus Christ.

Bible References:

- Job 19:25–27
- Psalm 16:8–11
- Psalm 49:14–15
- Isaiah 25:8
- Isaiah 26:19
- Ezekiel 37:1–14
- Daniel 12:1–3

Contextual Note:

Old Testament passages must be examined within their original literary and historical contexts. Not every image of restoration or awakening is necessarily a direct prediction of the final resurrection.

Question 3 — How Did Jesus Christ Demonstrate His Power Over Death?

Answer:

During His earthly ministry, Jesus Christ demonstrated authority over death.

The Gospels record several occasions when He restored deceased individuals to life.

He raised the daughter of Jairus.

He restored the son of a widow at Nain.

He also raised Lazarus after he had been in the tomb for four days.

These miracles revealed His divine authority and compassion.

They also provided visible demonstrations of the power that will accomplish the future resurrection.

In John 11, Jesus declared that He is the resurrection and the life.

This statement places the Christian hope in His person and authority.

However, the individuals raised during Jesus' earthly ministry returned to ordinary mortal life.

Their restoration was different from the glorified, immortal resurrection promised to the redeemed at Christ's return.

The miracles therefore served as signs pointing toward a greater future victory over death.

Bible References:

- Matthew 9:18–26

- Luke 7:11–17
- Luke 8:40–56
- John 5:21–29
- John 11:1–44
- Acts 10:38–43

Doctrinal Note:

The raising of Lazarus and other individuals was a restoration to mortal life. The final resurrection of the redeemed involves transformation into incorruptible life.

Question 4 — Why Is the Resurrection of Jesus Christ Essential to Christianity?

Answer:

The resurrection of Jesus Christ is central to the Gospel.

The New Testament teaches that Jesus died for our sins, was buried, and rose again according to the Scriptures.

The apostles proclaimed His resurrection as evidence of God's saving action.

Paul explained that if Christ had not risen, Christian preaching and faith would be empty.

He also taught that without the resurrection, believers would remain without the assurance of victory over sin and death.

The resurrection demonstrates that death could not permanently hold Jesus Christ.

It confirms His victory and establishes the foundation of the future resurrection of believers.

The New Testament presents the risen Christ as living, exalted, and actively ministering on behalf of His people.

Christian hope therefore does not depend upon philosophical speculation about life after death.

It rests upon the saving work of Jesus Christ.

In Seventh-day Adventist theology, the resurrection of Christ is inseparable from His atoning sacrifice, heavenly ministry, Second Coming, and final restoration of creation.

Bible References:

- Matthew 28:1–10
- Luke 24:1–12
- John 20:1–29
- Acts 2:22–36
- Romans 4:23–25
- Romans 6:4–11
- 1 Corinthians 15:1–20
- Revelation 1:17–18

Doctrinal Note:

The bodily resurrection of Jesus Christ is a foundational teaching shared by historic Christian traditions. It must not be reduced merely to a symbolic expression of renewed hope.

Question 5 — What Evidence Did the Apostles Present Concerning Christ's Resurrection?

Answer:

The New Testament records that Jesus appeared to His disciples after His resurrection.

The Gospel accounts describe the empty tomb and encounters with the risen Christ.

Luke records that Jesus presented Himself alive through convincing demonstrations and taught His followers concerning the Scriptures.

John describes Thomas encountering the risen Savior.

Paul lists appearances of Christ to Peter, the twelve, a large group of believers, James, the apostles, and finally himself.

These testimonies formed an important part of early Christian preaching.

The apostles proclaimed that God had raised Jesus from the dead.

They regarded themselves as witnesses of His resurrection.

However, the biblical accounts should be studied responsibly.

The Gospels present different selections and arrangements of resurrection events.

These differences should not be ignored or artificially harmonized without examination.

The central shared testimony is that Jesus Christ was crucified, buried, and proclaimed risen by His followers.

Christian faith receives the apostolic testimony preserved in Scripture.

Bible References:

- Matthew 28:1–20
- Luke 24:13–49
- John 20:19–29
- John 21:1–14
- Acts 1:1–11
- Acts 2:22–32
- Acts 10:39–43
- 1 Corinthians 15:3–8

Historical Note:

The New Testament provides multiple accounts and early proclamations concerning the resurrection. Their historical interpretation is a subject of scholarly discussion, while the Christian doctrine rests upon the apostolic testimony to the risen Christ.

Question 6 — What Does It Mean That Christ Is the Firstfruits of Those Who Sleep?

Answer:

Paul describes Jesus Christ as the firstfruits of those who have fallen asleep.

The imagery comes from the agricultural practice of presenting the first portion of a harvest.

The firstfruits signified the beginning of a greater harvest to follow.

In 1 Corinthians 15, Paul applies this image to the resurrection.

Christ's resurrection is the foundation and guarantee of the future resurrection of those who belong to Him.

The passage connects His resurrection with the restoration of life to believers at His coming.

However, the term firstfruits does not necessarily mean that no individual had ever been restored to life before Jesus.

The Old Testament and Gospels record earlier resurrections.

Christ's resurrection is unique because it establishes the definitive victory over death and the promise of immortal life.

He is not merely another person temporarily restored to mortal existence.

He is the risen Savior through whom the future resurrection becomes possible.

Bible References:

- Leviticus 23:9–14
- John 11:25–26
- Acts 26:22–23
- Romans 6:9–10
- 1 Corinthians 15:20–23
- Colossians 1:18
- Revelation 1:17–18

Explanatory Note:

The term firstfruits emphasizes Christ's representative and foundational role in the resurrection harvest. It should not be interpreted without considering earlier biblical accounts of people restored to life.

Question 7 — Who Will Be Raised From the Dead?

Answer:

The Bible teaches that resurrection is not limited to the righteous.

Jesus declared that those in the graves would hear His voice and come forth.

He distinguished between the resurrection of life and the resurrection of judgment.

Daniel also described an awakening involving everlasting life and shame.

Paul affirmed a resurrection of both the just and the unjust.

These passages establish the broad biblical teaching that God will raise the dead for the fulfillment of His purposes.

However, Scripture distinguishes between the destinies of those who belong to Christ and those who remain under judgment.

The righteous receive eternal life through Jesus Christ.

The wicked face divine judgment.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, the resurrection of the righteous and the resurrection of the wicked occur at different stages of the final events.

Adventists connect the resurrection of the righteous with Christ's Second Coming and the resurrection of the wicked with the conclusion of the millennium.

Other Christian traditions interpret the chronology differently.

The fundamental teaching is that all humanity remains accountable to God.

Bible References:

- Daniel 12:2
- John 5:28–29
- Acts 24:14–15
- Romans 14:10–12
- 1 Corinthians 15:20–23
- Revelation 20:4–15

Doctrinal Note:

The resurrection of both the righteous and the wicked is clearly taught in Scripture. The precise chronology of the two resurrections is interpreted differently among Christian traditions.

Question 8 — When Will the Righteous Dead Be Raised?

Answer:

The New Testament repeatedly connects the resurrection of believers with the return of Jesus Christ.

Jesus promised to raise those who believe in Him at the last day.

Paul taught that those who belong to Christ would be raised at His coming.

In 1 Thessalonians 4, the apostle describes the Lord descending from heaven.

He explains that the dead in Christ will rise first.

The living believers will then be caught up together with them to meet the Lord.

These passages provide a clear biblical foundation for connecting the resurrection of believers with the Second Coming.

In Seventh-day Adventist theology, this event marks the resurrection of the righteous dead to immortal life.

Adventists understand the deceased righteous as resting unconsciously until that moment.

Other Christian traditions also affirm the resurrection at Christ's return while teaching conscious fellowship with Christ during the intermediate state.

The future resurrection remains central in both interpretations.

Bible References:

- John 6:39–40, 44, 54
- John 11:23–26
- 1 Corinthians 15:20–23
- 1 Corinthians 15:51–54
- Philippians 3:20–21
- 1 Thessalonians 4:13–18

Doctrinal Note:

The connection between Christ's return and the resurrection of believers is explicit in the New Testament. The condition of the dead before that event remains a separate theological question.

Question 9 — What Kind of Body Will the Righteous Receive at the Resurrection?

Answer:

The apostle Paul provides an extensive discussion of the resurrection body in 1 Corinthians 15.

He contrasts the present mortal condition with the transformed existence promised through Christ.

The present body is subject to corruption, weakness, and death.

The resurrection body is described as incorruptible, glorious, and powerful.

Paul also contrasts the natural body with the spiritual body.

The expression spiritual body should not automatically be understood as a body without reality or substance.

In Paul's argument, it describes a transformed mode of embodied existence associated with the power of God's Spirit.

The resurrection of Jesus provides an important foundation for understanding this transformation.

The risen Christ was recognizable and interacted with His disciples.

Nevertheless, His resurrected existence also displayed characteristics beyond ordinary mortal life.

The Bible does not reveal every physical detail of the glorified body.

Its central promise is that the redeemed will be transformed and made fit for everlasting life.

Bible References:

- Luke 24:36–43
- John 20:19–29
- Romans 8:10–11, 23
- 1 Corinthians 15:35–49

- 1 Corinthians 15:50–54
- Philippians 3:20–21
- 1 John 3:1–3

Doctrinal Note:

The resurrection body is transformed and incorruptible. Scripture does not provide a complete biological or physical explanation of its nature, and speculative descriptions should be avoided.

Question 10 — What Will Happen to Believers Who Are Alive When Jesus Returns?

Answer:

The New Testament teaches that believers who are alive at Christ's return will experience transformation.

Paul explains that not all believers will sleep, but all will be changed.

This transformation will occur in connection with the resurrection and the final victory over mortality.

In 1 Thessalonians 4, Paul describes the living believers being caught up together with the resurrected righteous to meet the Lord.

The passage emphasizes reunion with Christ and with believers who have died.

It concludes with the assurance that God's people will always be with the Lord.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, the righteous living are transformed into immortality at the Second Coming.

They join the resurrected righteous and are gathered to Christ.

This event is understood as visible, glorious, and worldwide rather than a secret disappearance of believers.

Other Christian traditions interpret the sequence of end-time events differently.

The central biblical teaching is that Christ will gather His people and grant them victory over death.

Bible References:

- Matthew 24:29–31
- John 14:1–3
- 1 Corinthians 15:50–54
- Philippians 3:20–21
- 1 Thessalonians 4:13–18
- 2 Thessalonians 1:6–10

Doctrinal Note:

The transformation of living believers at Christ's return is clearly taught in Scripture. The detailed chronology of the gathering of believers is interpreted differently within Christian eschatology.

Question 11 — What Is the First Resurrection Mentioned in Revelation 20?

Answer:

Revelation 20 describes individuals who live and reign with Christ for a thousand years.

The passage identifies their participation as the first resurrection.

It also declares that those who share in the first resurrection are blessed and holy.

The second death has no power over them.

In Seventh-day Adventist interpretation, the first resurrection is the resurrection of the righteous at the Second Coming of Jesus Christ.

This event marks the beginning of the millennium.

Adventists connect Revelation 20 with the resurrection passages in John 5, 1 Corinthians 15, and 1 Thessalonians 4.

However, Revelation 20 is an apocalyptic passage containing symbolic imagery.

Christian traditions interpret the millennium and the first resurrection differently.

Premillennial interpretations generally understand the passage as describing a resurrection associated with Christ's reign.

Amillennial interpretations often understand the first resurrection in a spiritual or heavenly sense.

The Adventist interpretation belongs to a particular premillennial framework.

Its details should be examined within the broader study of Revelation.

Bible References:

- John 5:28–29
- 1 Corinthians 15:20–23
- 1 Thessalonians 4:13–18
- Revelation 20:1–6

Prophetic Note:

The identification of the first resurrection with the bodily resurrection of the righteous at Christ's return is central to Adventist eschatology. Other Christian interpretations of Revelation 20 should be acknowledged when presenting the doctrine.

Question 12 — What Is the Second Resurrection, and When Will It Occur?

Answer:

Revelation 20 states that the rest of the dead did not live again until the thousand years were finished.

The chapter later describes the dead standing before God for judgment.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, these passages describe a second resurrection involving the wicked at the conclusion of the millennium.

This interpretation distinguishes the resurrection of the righteous at Christ's return from the later resurrection of the wicked.

The second resurrection is associated with the final judgment and the destruction of evil.

However, Revelation 20 does not explicitly use the phrase second resurrection.

The expression is a theological description derived from the sequence presented in the chapter.

Christian traditions interpret the millennium, the resurrection, and the final judgment differently.

Therefore, the Adventist chronology should be presented as an interpretation of the apocalyptic text.

The central biblical principle is that God's judgment will be righteous and that evil will ultimately be defeated.

Bible References:

- Daniel 12:2
- John 5:28–29
- Acts 24:15
- Revelation 20:4–15
- Revelation 21:1–8

Doctrinal Note:

The term second resurrection is commonly used in Adventist theology but is not an explicit phrase in Revelation 20. It refers to the Adventist understanding of the resurrection of the wicked after the millennium.

Question 13 — What Is the Relationship Between Resurrection and Divine Judgment?

Answer:

The Bible connects resurrection with accountability before God.

Jesus spoke of a resurrection of life and a resurrection of judgment.

Daniel described different destinies following the awakening of the dead.

Paul taught that God will judge the world in righteousness through Jesus Christ.

The Book of Revelation describes a final judgment involving the dead and the books associated with divine judgment.

These passages demonstrate that resurrection is connected with the fulfillment of God's justice.

However, the relationship between resurrection and judgment must be considered carefully.

The New Testament teaches that salvation is received through faith in Jesus Christ.

It also teaches that human actions reveal the reality of faith and are relevant to divine judgment.

In Seventh-day Adventist theology, judgment includes several stages, including the pre-Advent judgment, the millennial judgment, and the final executive judgment.

These distinctions depend upon the denomination's broader interpretation of Daniel and Revelation.

They should not be treated as explicit chronological statements contained in every resurrection passage.

The central biblical assurance is that God judges with righteousness and that salvation is found through Jesus Christ.

Bible References:

- Daniel 7:9–14
- Daniel 12:1–3
- John 5:24–29
- Acts 17:30–31
- Romans 2:5–16
- Romans 8:1–4
- 2 Corinthians 5:10
- Revelation 20:11–15

Doctrinal Note:

Adventist teaching concerning the stages of judgment is a theological synthesis of several prophetic passages. The doctrine of salvation by grace through faith must remain central.

Question 14 — How Does the Resurrection Relate to Immortality and Eternal Life?

Answer:

The New Testament teaches that eternal life is a gift from God through Jesus Christ.

Paul explains that the wages of sin is death, but the gift of God is eternal life through the Savior.

In 1 Corinthians 15, he describes the transformation of mortal humanity into immortality.

The passage connects this transformation with the resurrection and the final victory over death.

In Seventh-day Adventist theology, these teachings support conditional immortality.

Human beings are not regarded as naturally immortal.

Immortality is granted through Jesus Christ.

The righteous receive incorruptible life at the resurrection.

Other Christian traditions distinguish between the immortality or continuing existence of the soul and the future glorification of the body.

They therefore understand the relationship between resurrection and immortality differently.

Nevertheless, the New Testament consistently presents eternal life as dependent upon God's saving action.

No created being possesses eternal life independently of the Creator.

Bible References:

- John 3:16
- John 5:24–29
- John 6:39–40
- Romans 6:23
- 1 Corinthians 15:50–54
- 1 Timothy 6:13–16
- 2 Timothy 1:9–10
- 1 John 5:11–13

Doctrinal Note:

Conditional immortality is a distinctive emphasis of Seventh-day Adventist theology. The promise of eternal life through Jesus Christ is shared broadly across Christian traditions.

Question 15 — How Does the Promise of Resurrection Transform the Christian's Understanding of Death and Hope?

Answer:

The promise of resurrection provides a foundation for Christian hope.

The Bible acknowledges the pain of death and the reality of grief.

Jesus wept at the tomb of Lazarus.

Paul encouraged believers not to grieve as those who have no hope.

He did not prohibit sorrow.

Instead, he directed attention toward the resurrection of Jesus Christ and the future resurrection of believers.

The resurrection demonstrates that death will not have the final word.

The New Testament describes death as the last enemy to be destroyed.

Revelation promises a new heaven and a new earth where death, sorrow, crying, and pain will no longer exist.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, the resurrection is especially significant because it marks the restoration of conscious life to those who have died in Christ.

The believer's confidence rests upon God's power to raise the dead.

This hope should influence Christian living.

It encourages faithfulness, compassion, perseverance, and a willingness to comfort those who mourn.

The resurrection is not merely a doctrine concerning the distant future.

It is a promise that gives meaning to present faith and service.

Bible References:

- John 11:25–26, 35
- John 14:1–3
- Romans 8:18–25
- 1 Corinthians 15:54–58
- 1 Thessalonians 4:13–18
- 1 Peter 1:3–9
- Revelation 21:1–5
- Revelation 22:1–5

Pastoral Note:

The hope of resurrection does not eliminate grief or require believers to suppress sorrow. Christian compassion includes listening, practical assistance, and patient support for those who have experienced loss.

Chapter Summary

The resurrection of the dead is one of the foundational doctrines of Christianity.

The Holy Scriptures reveal that God possesses the power to restore life and that Jesus Christ has conquered death through His resurrection.

The New Testament connects the future resurrection of believers with the Second Coming of Jesus Christ.

It also teaches that the redeemed will receive transformed, incorruptible bodies.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, the righteous are raised at Christ's return, while the wicked are raised after the millennium for the final judgment.

Our study enables us to retain the following teachings:

1. Resurrection is God's act of restoring life to those who have died.

2. The Old Testament contains promises and expectations concerning resurrection.

3. Jesus demonstrated His authority over death by restoring deceased individuals to life.

4. The resurrection of Jesus Christ is essential to the Christian Gospel.

5. The apostles proclaimed the resurrection of Christ as a central element of their testimony.

6. Christ is the firstfruits of those who sleep, guaranteeing the future resurrection of His people.

7. Scripture teaches a resurrection involving both the righteous and the wicked.

8. The New Testament connects the resurrection of believers with the Second Coming of Jesus Christ.

9. The redeemed will receive transformed and incorruptible bodies.

10. Believers who are alive at Christ's return will be transformed and gathered to Him.

11. Revelation 20 describes a first resurrection associated with blessing and freedom from the second death.

12. Seventh-day Adventist theology understands the resurrection of the wicked as occurring after the millennium.

13. Resurrection is connected with divine judgment and the fulfillment of God's righteousness.

14. Eternal life and immortality are gifts dependent upon God's saving work through Jesus Christ.

15. The promise of resurrection provides hope, comfort, and assurance of the final victory over death.

Doctrinal Conclusion

The resurrection of the dead reveals the power, faithfulness, and saving purpose of God.

Human beings are mortal and subject to death.

However, the Holy Scriptures proclaim that death is not the final destiny of those who belong to Jesus Christ.

The Savior who rose from the grave has promised to restore life to His people.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, the doctrine of resurrection includes several essential dimensions.

The Power of God Over Death

Resurrection is accomplished through divine power rather than through any inherent ability possessed by human beings.

The Resurrection of Jesus Christ

The resurrection of Christ is the foundation of Christian faith and the guarantee of the future resurrection of believers.

The Hope of the Old Testament

The prophets revealed God's promise to overcome death and restore life.

The Resurrection of the Righteous

The righteous dead will be raised at the return of Jesus Christ.

The Transformation of the Living

Believers who are alive at Christ's return will be transformed into immortality.

The Glorified Resurrection Body

The redeemed will receive incorruptible bodies suitable for everlasting life.

The First Resurrection

In Adventist interpretation, the first resurrection described in Revelation 20 is associated with the resurrection of the righteous at the Second Coming.

The Resurrection of the Wicked

Adventist theology understands the resurrection of the wicked as taking place after the millennium, before the final judgment.

Resurrection and Divine Judgment

God will judge humanity with righteousness, and His saving purposes will be fully accomplished.

The Final Destruction of Death

The Bible promises that death itself will ultimately be destroyed.

The resurrection doctrine should not be reduced to speculation concerning prophetic chronology.

Its central purpose is to direct faith toward Jesus Christ.

He is the resurrection and the life.

Through Him, believers receive forgiveness, hope, and the promise of eternal life.

The Essential Message:

The resurrection of the dead is the great Christian hope founded upon the victory of Jesus Christ over death. Through His saving power, the righteous will be raised to incorruptible life, and believers who are alive at His return will be transformed. Seventh-day Adventist theology understands the resurrection of the righteous as occurring at Christ's Second Coming and the resurrection of the wicked as taking place after the millennium. The final outcome of God's plan is the defeat of sin and death and the restoration of everlasting life through Jesus Christ.

Personal Reflection Questions

1. What does the Bible mean by the resurrection of the dead?

2. How did the Old Testament reveal the hope of resurrection?

3. What do the resurrections performed by Jesus teach about His divine authority?

4. Why is the resurrection of Jesus Christ essential to the Christian Gospel?

5. What does Paul mean when he describes Christ as the firstfruits of those who sleep?

6. What does Scripture teach about the resurrection of the righteous and the wicked?

7. How does 1 Corinthians 15 describe the transformation of the resurrection body?

8. What is the relationship between the Second Coming of Jesus Christ and the resurrection of believers?

9. How should I understand the first resurrection and the later resurrection described in Adventist interpretation of Revelation 20?

10. How does the promise of resurrection strengthen my faith and influence the way I live today?

Suggested Prayer

Lord my God,

I come before You with gratitude, humility, and hope.

You are the Creator of heaven and earth.

You are the source of life and the One who possesses power over death.

Thank You for revealing Your promises through the Holy Scriptures.

Thank You for the hope of resurrection.

I recognize that human life is fragile and that death brings sorrow into our world.

At times, I struggle with fear, uncertainty, and the pain of losing those I love.

Help me remember that death does not have the final word.

Thank You for sending Jesus Christ into the world.

Thank You for His perfect life, His sacrifice upon the cross, and His glorious resurrection.

I acknowledge that He is the resurrection and the life.

Strengthen my confidence in His promises.

Teach me to study Your Word carefully and faithfully.

Give me wisdom to understand the biblical teaching concerning resurrection, immortality, judgment, and eternal life.

Protect me from speculation and interpretations that go beyond what Scripture reveals.

Help me distinguish Your clear promises from human assumptions.

When I face suffering, strengthen my hope.

When I experience grief, comfort my heart.

When others mourn, help me demonstrate compassion, patience, and practical love.

Teach me to live each day in the light of eternity.

May the promise of resurrection encourage me to remain faithful to Jesus Christ.

Help me use my time, abilities, and opportunities in service to others.

Thank You for the assurance that the dead in Christ will rise.

Thank You for the promise that mortality will put on immortality.

Thank You for the hope of reunion with the redeemed in Your everlasting kingdom.

Above all, thank You for the victory of Jesus Christ over sin and death.

Prepare me for His glorious return.

Until that day, help me live with faith, obedience, love, courage, and complete dependence upon Your saving grace.

I look forward to the day when death, sorrow, crying, and pain will be no more.

May all honor, glory, and praise belong to You forever.

In the name of Jesus Christ, my Savior and Lord.

Amen.

CHAPTER 33 — THE MILLENNIUM: WHAT WILL HAPPEN DURING THE THOUSAND YEARS OF REVELATION 20?

A Thematic Bible Study — King James Version (KJV)

Opening Scripture

> “And I saw thrones, and they sat upon them, and judgment was given unto them: and I saw the souls of them that were beheaded for the witness of Jesus, and for the word of God, and which had not worshipped the beast, neither his image, neither had received his mark upon their foreheads, or in their hands; and they lived and reigned with Christ a thousand years.”

Revelation 20:4 — KJV

Introduction

In the preceding chapter, we studied the resurrection of the dead.

We discovered that Jesus Christ is the resurrection and the life, that the righteous will be raised through His power, and that the Scriptures also speak of a resurrection associated with judgment.

These teachings lead us to one of the most significant prophetic subjects in the Book of Revelation: the millennium.

The word millennium refers to a period of one thousand years.

Although the term itself does not appear in the King James Version, Revelation 20 repeatedly describes a thousand-year period associated with the restraint of Satan, the reign of Christ, the participation of the saints in judgment, and events preceding the final destruction of evil.

This passage has generated considerable discussion throughout Christian history.

Will Jesus Christ reign upon the present earth during the millennium?

Will the righteous be in heaven?

What will happen to the wicked?

Will Satan continue to deceive the nations?

What does it mean that Satan will be bound?

Why will he be released after the thousand years?

What is the relationship between the millennium, the resurrection, the final judgment, and the new earth?

The answers depend partly upon how Revelation 20 is interpreted in relation to the rest of Scripture.

Christian traditions have developed several major approaches.

Premillennialism generally teaches that Christ's return precedes a future millennial reign.

Amillennialism commonly understands the thousand years symbolically, representing the present reign of Christ and His people, with the final resurrection and judgment occurring at His return.

Postmillennialism generally anticipates a period of widespread Gospel influence or righteousness before Christ's return, though its interpretations vary.

Seventh-day Adventists hold a distinctive premillennial interpretation.

According to this understanding, the millennium begins with the Second Coming of Jesus Christ.

The righteous dead are raised, and the righteous living are transformed.

Together, they are taken to be with Christ.

The wicked living perish in connection with the events of His coming, while the wicked dead remain in their graves.

The earth is left desolate, and Satan is confined to its devastated condition, unable to deceive the nations.

During the thousand years, the redeemed participate with Christ in a work of judgment.

At the conclusion of the millennium, the wicked are raised, Satan resumes his deceptive activity, and the final judgment and destruction of evil take place.

God then establishes the new heaven and new earth.

This interpretation brings together passages from Revelation, Jeremiah, Isaiah, the Gospels, and the writings of Paul.

However, not every detail is explicitly stated in Revelation 20 itself.

Some conclusions depend upon the Adventist historicist and premillennial understanding of biblical prophecy.

Our study must therefore distinguish what Scripture directly declares from the conclusions reached by comparing passages.

The central purpose of this chapter is not to encourage speculation concerning future events.

It is to reveal the justice of God, the victory of Jesus Christ, the final defeat of Satan, and the glorious hope of a restored creation.

Question 1 — What Is the Millennium According to the Holy Scriptures?

Answer:

The millennium is the thousand-year period described in Revelation 20.

The chapter mentions the thousand years repeatedly.

During this period, Satan is bound, certain faithful people live and reign with Christ, and judgment is given to those seated upon thrones.

The passage also distinguishes the first resurrection from the later events associated with the rest of the dead.

At the conclusion of the thousand years, Satan is released and gathers the nations for a final rebellion.

The chapter then describes the defeat of evil and the final judgment.

The expression one thousand years is therefore an explicit feature of Revelation 20.

However, Christians disagree about whether the period should be understood as exactly one thousand calendar years or as a symbolic representation of a complete period determined by God.

Seventh-day Adventists understand the millennium as a future period of one thousand years beginning at the Second Coming.

This interpretation belongs to their broader understanding of biblical prophecy.

Bible References:

- Revelation 19:11–21
- Revelation 20:1–10
- 1 Corinthians 15:20–28
- 2 Peter 3:7–13

Linguistic Note:

The word millennium comes from Latin terminology meaning one thousand years. Revelation 20 uses the Greek expression chilia etē, meaning a thousand years.

Question 2 — When Will the Millennium Begin?

Answer:

Revelation 20 describes the binding of Satan and the reign of the saints for a thousand years.

However, the chapter does not contain a direct sentence stating that the millennium begins at the Second Coming.

Seventh-day Adventists establish this chronology by comparing Revelation 19 and 20 with other passages concerning Christ's return and the resurrection.

Revelation 19 portrays the triumphant appearance of the heavenly Rider who judges and makes war in righteousness.

Revelation 20 then describes Satan's restraint and the reign of the saints.

Adventists understand these events as forming a chronological sequence.

They also connect the first resurrection in Revelation 20 with the resurrection of believers described in 1 Thessalonians 4.

According to this interpretation, the millennium begins when Jesus Christ returns and raises the righteous dead.

Other Christian interpreters understand Revelation 20 as recapitulating or revisiting events already portrayed in earlier visions.

They therefore do not necessarily regard Revelation 19 and 20 as a strictly consecutive chronology.

The Adventist position should be presented as a reasoned prophetic interpretation.

Bible References:

- Matthew 24:29–31
- John 14:1–3

- 1 Corinthians 15:20–23
- 1 Thessalonians 4:13–18
- Revelation 19:11–21
- Revelation 20:1–6

Prophetic Note:

The timing of the millennium depends significantly upon the interpretation of Revelation's literary structure. Adventists understand the thousand years as beginning after Christ's visible return.

Question 3 — What Will Happen to the Righteous Dead at the Beginning of the Millennium?

Answer:

The New Testament teaches that the dead in Christ will rise at His coming.

Paul explains that the Lord will descend from heaven and that the dead in Christ will rise first.

He also describes the resurrection body as incorruptible and glorious.

In Revelation 20, those who participate in the first resurrection are described as blessed and holy.

The second death has no power over them.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, these passages describe the same resurrection event.

The righteous dead are raised to immortal life at the Second Coming.

They join the righteous living and enter the presence of Jesus Christ.

However, Revelation 20 does not explicitly identify every participant in the first resurrection using the exact terminology of 1 Thessalonians 4.

The connection is made through comparison of the passages.

Other Christian traditions interpret the first resurrection differently, including as a heavenly or spiritual participation in Christ's reign.

The central biblical assurance remains that those who belong to Christ will share in His victory over death.

Bible References:

- Daniel 12:2
- John 5:28–29
- John 6:39–40
- 1 Corinthians 15:20–23
- 1 Corinthians 15:51–54
- 1 Thessalonians 4:13–18
- Revelation 20:4–6

Doctrinal Note:

The resurrection of believers at Christ's return is explicitly taught in the New Testament. Its identification with the first resurrection of Revelation 20 is part of the Adventist millennial interpretation.

Question 4 — What Will Happen to the Righteous Living When Jesus Returns?

Answer:

Paul teaches that believers who are alive at the return of Jesus Christ will be transformed.

Their mortal bodies will be changed into an incorruptible condition.

In 1 Thessalonians 4, the living righteous are described as being caught up together with the resurrected believers to meet the Lord.

Jesus also promised His disciples that He would return and receive them unto Himself.

These passages emphasize reunion with Christ.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, the righteous living will not experience death at that moment.

They will be transformed and gathered with the resurrected righteous.

Together, they will be taken to heaven to reign with Jesus Christ during the millennium.

The belief that the redeemed spend the millennium in heaven is developed by comparing Christ's promise in John 14, the gathering described in 1 Thessalonians 4, and the reign of the saints in Revelation 20.

However, Revelation 20 itself does not explicitly identify the geographical location of the saints' thrones.

Other Christian traditions interpret the location of the millennial reign differently.

Bible References:

- John 14:1–3
- Matthew 24:30–31
- 1 Corinthians 15:51–54
- Philippians 3:20–21
- 1 Thessalonians 4:13–18
- Revelation 20:4–6

Doctrinal Note:

The transformation of living believers is an explicit New Testament promise. The conclusion that the redeemed spend the millennium in heaven is part of the Adventist synthesis of several passages.

Question 5 — What Will Happen to the Wicked Living at the Second Coming?

Answer:

The New Testament describes the return of Jesus Christ as an event involving both salvation and judgment.

Paul teaches that Christ will be revealed from heaven and that those who oppose God will face divine judgment.

Second Thessalonians also describes the destruction of the lawless one through the manifestation of Christ's coming.

Revelation 19 portrays the defeat of the powers assembled against the heavenly Rider.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, these passages indicate that the wicked living will perish at the Second Coming.

Their destruction, together with the resurrection and gathering of the righteous, leaves no living human population upon the earth during the millennium.

However, Revelation 19 uses apocalyptic imagery, and Christian interpreters differ concerning its relationship to Revelation 20.

Some premillennial traditions anticipate surviving nations or mortal inhabitants during a future earthly reign.

The Adventist interpretation should therefore be identified as one particular understanding of the prophetic sequence.

The biblical emphasis is that Christ's return will reveal divine justice and bring decisive judgment upon evil.

Bible References:

- Isaiah 11:1–5
- Matthew 24:37–41
- Luke 17:26–30
- 2 Thessalonians 1:6–10
- 2 Thessalonians 2:8
- Revelation 6:14–17
- Revelation 19:11–21

Prophetic Note:

The conclusion that no wicked human beings remain alive during the millennium depends upon the Adventist interpretation of the Second Coming and its consequences.

Question 6 — What Will Be the Condition of the Earth During the Millennium?

Answer:

Seventh-day Adventists understand the earth as desolate and uninhabited by living human beings during the thousand years.

This conclusion is developed by comparing several biblical passages.

Jeremiah 4 describes a devastated land using language reminiscent of creation before its ordering.

The prophet sees the earth as without form and void, the heavens without light, and cities broken down.

The immediate context concerns divine judgment associated with Judah and Jerusalem.

Adventist interpretation sees the imagery as also illustrating the condition of the earth following the judgments associated with Christ's return.

Isaiah 24 similarly describes widespread devastation and judgment.

However, neither Jeremiah 4 nor Isaiah 24 explicitly identifies its scene as the thousand years of Revelation 20.

Their application to the millennial earth is therefore a theological interpretation.

Within the Adventist framework, the earth becomes the place of Satan's confinement during the millennium.

It remains devastated until the final events leading to the new creation.

Bible References:

- Genesis 1:2
- Isaiah 24:1–23
- Jeremiah 4:19–28
- Zephaniah 1:14–18
- Revelation 19:17–21
- Revelation 20:1–3
- Revelation 21:1–5

Contextual Note:

Jeremiah 4 originally addresses judgment upon Judah. Its application to a future desolate earth during the millennium is a distinctive Adventist interpretation and should not replace the passage's immediate historical meaning.

Question 7 — What Does It Mean That Satan Will Be Bound for a Thousand Years?

Answer:

Revelation 20 describes an angel descending from heaven with the key of the bottomless pit and a great chain.

The angel binds the dragon, identified as the Devil and Satan, for a thousand years.

The passage explains the purpose of this restraint: Satan is prevented from deceiving the nations until the thousand years are completed.

The imagery is apocalyptic.

The chain and the bottomless pit are interpreted differently among Christians.

Seventh-day Adventists understand Satan's binding primarily as a restriction of circumstances.

According to this view, Satan remains upon the desolate earth, with no living human population available for deception.

His confinement is therefore understood as a consequence of the conditions produced by the Second Coming.

Other Christian traditions understand the binding as a limitation upon Satan's activity during the present Gospel age.

Still others interpret it as a future restriction preceding a reign of Christ upon the earth.

The explicit biblical teaching is that Satan's deceptive activity will be restrained for the period described.

The precise nature of the restraint is interpreted within broader theological frameworks.

Bible References:

- Luke 10:17–20
- John 12:31–33
- Colossians 2:13–15
- Revelation 12:7–12
- Revelation 20:1–3

Doctrinal Note:

The Adventist understanding of Satan's binding is circumstantial rather than a literal physical chain. Revelation itself identifies the restraint's purpose as preventing deception of the nations.

Question 8 — What Is the Bottomless Pit Mentioned in Revelation 20?

Answer:

The King James Version uses the expression bottomless pit in Revelation 20.

The underlying Greek word is abyssos, associated with the idea of an abyss or deep place.

The term also appears in other New Testament passages.

In Revelation, it is associated with spiritual confinement, judgment, and the activity of evil powers.

Seventh-day Adventists connect the abyss of Revelation 20 with the devastated condition of the earth during the millennium.

They also compare the imagery with Genesis 1:2 and Jeremiah 4:23.

However, the biblical texts do not explicitly state that the abyss of Revelation 20 is geographically identical to the surface of the desolate earth.

This identification is an interpretive conclusion.

Other Christian traditions understand the abyss as a spiritual place of confinement or as a symbol of divine restraint.

The essential point is that Satan's activity remains subject to God's authority.

He cannot act independently of the limits established by divine judgment.

Bible References:

- Genesis 1:2
- Jeremiah 4:23
- Luke 8:26–33
- Romans 10:6–7
- Revelation 9:1–11
- Revelation 11:7
- Revelation 17:8
- Revelation 20:1–3

Linguistic Note:

The Greek abyssos does not by itself identify a specific geographical location. Its interpretation depends upon the literary and prophetic context.

Question 9 — What Will the Redeemed Do During the Thousand Years?

Answer:

Revelation 20 describes the saints living and reigning with Christ for a thousand years.

The passage also states that judgment is given to those seated upon thrones.

Paul teaches that the saints will judge the world and that they will judge angels.

These statements provide a foundation for understanding the redeemed as participating in God's judicial purposes.

In Seventh-day Adventist theology, the millennium includes a period of review or examination of divine judgment.

The redeemed are understood as having an opportunity to understand the righteousness of God's decisions concerning those who are not saved and the fallen angels.

This understanding emphasizes the transparency and justice of God's government.

However, Scripture does not provide a detailed description of the procedures, questions, or records involved in this millennial judgment.

The Adventist explanation is a theological synthesis of Revelation 20 and 1 Corinthians 6.

The central biblical teaching is that the redeemed will share in Christ's reign and that divine judgment will be righteous.

Bible References:

- Daniel 7:9–10, 22
- Matthew 19:27–29
- 1 Corinthians 6:1–3
- 2 Timothy 2:11–12

- Revelation 3:21
- Revelation 20:4–6

Doctrinal Note:

The participation of the saints in judgment is biblical. The detailed Adventist explanation of the millennium as a period of reviewing God's judgments goes beyond the explicit procedural information provided in the text.

Question 10 — Why Is the Millennial Judgment Important in Seventh-day Adventist Theology?

Answer:

The Bible repeatedly affirms that God is righteous and just.

Abraham appealed to the justice of the Judge of all the earth.

The Psalms describe righteousness and judgment as foundations of God's throne.

Revelation portrays heavenly beings praising God because His judgments are true and righteous.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, the millennial judgment demonstrates the fairness and transparency of God's decisions.

The redeemed are understood as participating in an examination that confirms the justice of God.

This interpretation belongs to the larger great-controversy framework, in which God's character and government are ultimately vindicated.

However, the Bible does not explicitly state that God needs created beings to verify His judgments before He can execute them.

The Adventist explanation concerns the revelation and acknowledgment of divine justice, not a limitation upon God's knowledge or authority.

Christians should therefore distinguish the biblical affirmation of God's righteousness from theological descriptions of how that righteousness will be demonstrated during the millennium.

Bible References:

- Genesis 18:25
- Psalm 89:14
- Romans 2:5–11
- Romans 3:25–26
- 1 Corinthians 6:2–3
- Revelation 15:3–4
- Revelation 16:5–7
- Revelation 20:4

Doctrinal Note:

The millennial judgment is understood in Adventist theology as part of the public vindication of God's justice. Its specific procedures are not fully described in Scripture.

Question 11 — What Happens to the Wicked Dead During the Millennium?

Answer:

Revelation 20:5 states that the rest of the dead did not live again until the thousand years were finished.

In Seventh-day Adventist interpretation, the rest of the dead are understood as the wicked who did not participate in the first resurrection.

According to this view, they remain dead throughout the millennium.

They do not participate in the reign of Christ and the redeemed.

At the conclusion of the thousand years, they are raised in connection with the final events described later in Revelation 20.

However, interpretations differ concerning the meaning of the first resurrection and the identity of the rest of the dead.

Some Christian traditions understand the passage within a symbolic or nonchronological framework.

The Adventist conclusion depends upon interpreting Revelation 20 as describing two distinct bodily resurrections separated by the millennium.

The central biblical principle is that resurrection, judgment, and eternal destiny remain under God's authority.

Bible References:

- Daniel 12:2
- John 5:28–29
- Acts 24:15
- Revelation 20:4–6
- Revelation 20:11–15

Prophetic Note:

The identification of the rest of the dead as the wicked awaiting a later bodily resurrection is central to Adventist premillennial theology.

Question 12 — What Will Happen When the Thousand Years Are Finished?

Answer:

Revelation 20 declares that Satan will be released from his confinement after the thousand years.

He then goes out to deceive the nations and gathers them for battle.

The passage describes a final rebellion against the camp of the saints and the beloved city.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, Satan's release becomes possible because the wicked are raised from the dead.

Once living human beings are again present, he resumes his deceptive activity.

Adventists also connect these events with the descent of the New Jerusalem described in Revelation 21.

However, Revelation 20 does not explicitly state in a single sentence that Satan's release is caused by the resurrection of the wicked.

Nor does it explicitly describe the descent of the New Jerusalem before the attack.

These conclusions arise from the Adventist synthesis of the prophetic sequence.

The explicit biblical teaching is that Satan's final deception ends in defeat.

God will not permit rebellion to continue forever.

Bible References:

- Revelation 20:3
- Revelation 20:5
- Revelation 20:7–10
- Revelation 20:11–15
- Revelation 21:1–3

Doctrinal Note:

The Adventist sequence connecting the resurrection of the wicked, Satan's release, and the descent of the New Jerusalem is an interpretation formed by comparing Revelation 20 and 21.

Question 13 — What Is the Final Rebellion of Gog and Magog?

Answer:

Revelation 20 describes Satan gathering the nations from the four quarters of the earth.

The passage refers to Gog and Magog.

These names also appear in Ezekiel 38 and 39, where they are associated with an enemy force opposing God's people.

In Revelation, the names are used within an apocalyptic vision of final opposition to God.

The gathered nations surround the camp of the saints and the beloved city.

However, their rebellion is unsuccessful.

Fire comes down from heaven and destroys them.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, this event represents the final attempt by Satan and the resurrected wicked to overthrow God's government.

The attack demonstrates the continued rebellion of those who oppose God.

Other Christian interpretations differ concerning the relationship between Ezekiel's prophecy and Revelation 20.

The passage should not be used to identify contemporary nations or ethnic groups as inevitable enemies of God.

Its central purpose is to portray the final defeat of evil.

Bible References:

- Ezekiel 38:1–23
- Ezekiel 39:1–29
- Revelation 16:13–16
- Revelation 19:19–21
- Revelation 20:7–10

Prophetic Note:

Gog and Magog function as prophetic names within the final-conflict imagery of Revelation. Their identification with particular modern nations is not established by the text.

Question 14 — What Is the Final Judgment and the Second Death?

Answer:

Revelation 20 describes a great white throne and the dead standing before God.

The books are opened, and judgment takes place.

The chapter also describes death and hell being cast into the lake of fire.

This is identified as the second death.

The Bible therefore distinguishes ordinary physical death from the final judgment associated with the second death.

In Seventh-day Adventist theology, the second death is understood as the final and irreversible destruction of the wicked.

Adventists reject the doctrine of eternal conscious torment and teach that sin and sinners will ultimately cease to exist.

They understand this outcome as the complete destruction of evil.

Other Christian traditions interpret the lake of fire and final punishment differently.

Some teach eternal conscious punishment, while others defend conditional immortality or additional interpretations.

The relevant passages must be examined carefully, including their symbolic language and descriptions of divine judgment.

The essential biblical teaching is that God's final judgment will be righteous and that evil will not triumph.

Bible References:

- Malachi 4:1–3
- Matthew 10:28
- Matthew 25:31–46
- Romans 6:23
- 2 Thessalonians 1:6–10
- Revelation 20:11–15
- Revelation 21:8

Doctrinal Note:

The final destruction of the wicked is a distinctive Adventist interpretation of the second death. Christian traditions differ concerning whether final punishment involves annihilation or eternal conscious existence.

Question 15 — What Will Happen After the Millennium and the Final Destruction of Evil?

Answer:

The Book of Revelation concludes with a vision of a new heaven and a new earth.

John describes the holy city, New Jerusalem, coming down from God.

The passage announces that God will dwell with His people.

Death, sorrow, crying, and pain will no longer exist.

The curse is removed, and the servants of God serve and worship Him.

These promises reveal the final purpose of redemption.

God does not merely defeat Satan.

He restores creation and establishes an everlasting kingdom of righteousness and peace.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, the new earth is established after the millennium, the final judgment, and the destruction of evil.

The redeemed will enjoy eternal life in God's restored creation.

Other Christian traditions differ concerning the sequence of events preceding the new creation.

Nevertheless, the promise of a renewed heaven and earth is central to biblical hope.

The ultimate focus of the millennium should therefore remain upon the final triumph of Jesus Christ.

The conflict between good and evil will end.

God's people will dwell in His presence forever.

Bible References:

- Isaiah 65:17–25
- Isaiah 66:22–23
- Romans 8:18–25
- 2 Peter 3:10–13
- Revelation 21:1–8
- Revelation 21:22–27
- Revelation 22:1–5

Doctrinal Note:

The new creation is a central biblical promise. The precise sequence of the millennium and final judgment is interpreted differently, but the final restoration of God's people remains a shared Christian hope.

Chapter Summary

The millennium is the thousand-year period described in Revelation 20.

The chapter associates this period with Satan's restraint, the reign of Christ and His saints, judgment, and events leading to the final defeat of evil.

Seventh-day Adventists understand the millennium as a future period beginning with the Second Coming of Jesus Christ.

During this period, the redeemed reign with Christ in heaven, the earth remains desolate, and Satan is unable to deceive humanity.

At the conclusion of the millennium, the wicked are raised, Satan resumes his deception, and the final judgment brings evil to an end.

Our study enables us to retain the following teachings:

1. The millennium is the thousand-year period described in Revelation 20.

2. Seventh-day Adventists understand the millennium as beginning at the Second Coming of Jesus Christ.

3. The righteous dead are raised at Christ's return and share in His victory over death.

4. The righteous living are transformed and gathered to Jesus Christ.

5. Adventist theology teaches that the wicked living perish in connection with Christ's return.

6. The earth is understood as desolate and without living human inhabitants during the millennium.

7. Satan is bound for a thousand years and prevented from deceiving the nations.

8. Adventists interpret the abyss as representing Satan's confinement to the devastated earth.

9. The redeemed reign with Christ and participate in judgment.

10. The millennial judgment is understood as revealing the righteousness and transparency of God's decisions.

11. The wicked dead remain in their graves throughout the millennium in the Adventist interpretation.

12. At the conclusion of the thousand years, Satan is released and resumes his deceptive activity.

13. Gog and Magog symbolize the final rebellion against God and His people.

14. The final judgment and second death bring the conflict with evil to its conclusion.

15. God establishes a new heaven and a new earth where righteousness, peace, and eternal life prevail.

Doctrinal Conclusion

The millennium occupies an important place in the prophetic teachings of Revelation.

It is connected with the reign of Jesus Christ, the restraint of Satan, the participation of the saints in judgment, and the final destruction of evil.

In Seventh-day Adventist theology, the millennium forms a significant stage in the conclusion of the great controversy between Christ and Satan.

The Second Coming of Jesus Christ

The Adventist interpretation places the beginning of the millennium at Christ's visible and glorious return.

The Resurrection of the Righteous

The righteous dead are raised, and the righteous living are transformed.

The Gathering of the Redeemed

God's people are taken to be with Jesus Christ.

The Desolation of the Earth

The earth remains devastated and without living human inhabitants during the thousand years.

The Binding of Satan

Satan is restrained from deceiving the nations.

In Adventist understanding, this restraint results from the absence of living human beings upon the earth.

The Reign of Christ and the Saints

The redeemed participate in the reign of Jesus Christ.

The Millennial Judgment

The saints participate in judgment, understood in Adventist theology as confirming the justice of God's decisions.

The Resurrection of the Wicked

At the conclusion of the millennium, the wicked are raised according to the Adventist interpretation.

The Final Rebellion

Satan gathers the nations in a final attempt to oppose God.

The Final Judgment and Second Death

God brings evil to its ultimate end.

The New Heaven and the New Earth

The redeemed dwell forever in God's restored creation.

Although the millennium involves important prophetic questions, the purpose of the biblical teaching is not to encourage speculation or fear.

The central message concerns the sovereignty of God, the justice of His judgments, and the complete victory of Jesus Christ.

The final outcome is not uncertainty.

It is the establishment of God's everlasting kingdom.

The Essential Message:

The millennium is the thousand-year period described in Revelation 20. Seventh-day Adventist theology understands it as beginning with the Second Coming of Jesus Christ, when the righteous are raised or transformed and gathered to Him. During the millennium, the redeemed reign with Christ, while Satan is restrained from deceiving humanity. At its conclusion, the final resurrection, judgment, and destruction of evil lead to the establishment of the new heaven and new earth. The ultimate purpose of these events is the complete victory of Jesus Christ and the everlasting restoration of God's creation.

Personal Reflection Questions

1. What does Revelation 20 explicitly teach concerning the thousand years?

2. Why do Seventh-day Adventists connect the beginning of the millennium with the Second Coming of Jesus Christ?

3. What is the relationship between the first resurrection and the reign of Christ?

4. What does the Bible teach about the transformation and gathering of the righteous at Christ's return?

5. How is the condition of the earth during the millennium understood in Adventist theology?

6. What does it mean that Satan will be bound and prevented from deceiving the nations?

7. What can I learn from the biblical teaching that the saints will participate in judgment?

8. Why is it important to distinguish the immediate context of Jeremiah 4 from its broader Adventist application?

9. What does the final defeat of Satan reveal about God's justice and sovereignty?

10. How does the promise of the new heaven and new earth strengthen my faith and influence my life today?

Suggested Prayer

Lord my God,

I come before You with reverence, gratitude, and hope.

You are the Creator of heaven and earth.

You are holy, righteous, loving, and just.

Thank You for revealing Your purposes through the Holy Scriptures.

Thank You for the promise that Jesus Christ will return in glory.

I recognize that many prophetic events remain difficult for human understanding.

Give me wisdom to study Your Word carefully.

Help me distinguish the clear teachings of Scripture from interpretations and human speculation.

Teach me to approach the prophecies of Daniel and Revelation with humility and faith.

Thank You for the promise of resurrection and eternal life through Jesus Christ.

Thank You for the assurance that death and evil will not reign forever.

I acknowledge that Your judgments are righteous.

Help me trust Your wisdom even when I cannot understand every detail of Your plans.

Protect me from fear, pride, and the temptation to use prophecy to condemn others.

Teach me to demonstrate Your love through compassion, patience, and truth.

Strengthen my faith in the saving work of Jesus Christ.

May my confidence rest upon His sacrifice, His resurrection, and His promised return.

Prepare my heart for the glorious day when He gathers His people.

Help me remain faithful in my daily responsibilities.

Give me courage to resist temptation and wisdom to recognize deception.

May I live with the hope of Your everlasting kingdom.

Thank You for the promise that Satan and evil will ultimately be defeated.

Thank You for the assurance that sorrow, suffering, and death will come to an end.

I look forward to the new heaven and the new earth.

I long for the day when Your people will dwell in Your presence forever.

Until that day, help me live with faith, obedience, humility, and love.

May my life bring honor and glory to You alone.

In the name of Jesus Christ, my Savior and Lord.

Amen.

CHAPTER 34 — THE SECOND COMING OF JESUS CHRIST: HOW WILL THE SAVIOR RETURN IN HIS GLORY?

A Thematic Bible Study — King James Version (KJV)

Opening Scripture

> “And if I go and prepare a place for you, I will come again, and receive you unto myself; that where I am, there ye may be also.”

John 14:3 — KJV

Introduction

The Second Coming of Jesus Christ is one of the greatest promises recorded in the Holy Scriptures.

From the Old Testament prophecies to the closing chapters of Revelation, the Bible directs humanity toward the final triumph of God's kingdom.

Jesus Christ came into the world to reveal the Father, proclaim the Gospel, and accomplish the work of salvation through His death and resurrection.

Before returning to heaven, He promised His disciples that He would come again.

This promise became a foundation of Christian hope.

The apostles proclaimed that the same Jesus who ascended into heaven would return.

They taught that His coming would bring resurrection, transformation, judgment, and the fulfillment of God's saving purposes.

The Book of Revelation concludes with Christ's declaration that He is coming quickly.

However, the Second Coming has also been the subject of considerable misunderstanding.

Some interpret Christ's return as a secret event.

Others associate it with the establishment of a political kingdom or with a gradual transformation of human society.

Still others attempt to determine the exact date of His appearing.

The Holy Scriptures provide important principles for evaluating these teachings.

They describe Christ's return as personal, visible, glorious, and accompanied by heavenly manifestations.

They also warn believers against deception, false messiahs, and attempts to predict the precise time of His coming.

In Seventh-day Adventist theology, the Second Coming is understood as a literal, worldwide, visible, and audible event.

It marks the resurrection of the righteous dead, the transformation of the righteous living, and the gathering of God's redeemed people.

The wicked living face the judgment associated with Christ's appearing.

The Second Coming also introduces the events connected with the millennium, which we examined in the preceding chapter.

The central question is therefore not merely when Jesus Christ will return.

It is whether humanity is spiritually prepared to meet Him.

This chapter examines fifteen questions concerning the biblical promise of Christ's return, its nature, the events associated with it, and the Christian responsibility to remain faithful.

Our objective is to understand the Second Coming through the testimony of Scripture and to strengthen our hope in Jesus Christ.

Question 1 — Did Jesus Christ Personally Promise That He Would Return?

Answer:

Yes. Jesus Christ explicitly promised His disciples that He would come again.

In John 14, He comforted His followers by explaining that He was going to prepare a place for them.

He assured them that He would return and receive them unto Himself.

This promise demonstrates that Christ's departure was not the conclusion of His relationship with His people.

His saving mission includes their final gathering into His presence.

Jesus also spoke about the coming of the Son of man in glory.

He connected His return with the gathering of the elect and the fulfillment of divine judgment.

The promise of His coming is therefore an essential part of His teaching.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, this promise refers to a future, personal, and literal return of Jesus Christ.

It is not merely a symbol of spiritual influence or religious progress.

The Savior who ascended into heaven will return to complete the redemption of His people.

Bible References:

- Matthew 16:27
- Matthew 24:29–31
- Matthew 25:31–34

- John 14:1–3
- John 17:24
- Revelation 22:12, 20

Doctrinal Note:

The Second Coming is a personal promise of Jesus Christ. Its fulfillment should not be reduced to the believer's death, the spread of Christianity, or a purely symbolic experience.

Question 2 — What Did the Angels Declare When Jesus Ascended Into Heaven?

Answer:

Acts 1 describes the ascension of Jesus Christ.

After speaking with His disciples, Jesus was taken up, and a cloud received Him out of their sight.

Two men in white apparel appeared and addressed the disciples.

They declared that Jesus would return in a manner corresponding to His departure.

The passage identifies the returning Savior as the same Jesus who had been taken into heaven.

This statement establishes continuity between the historical Jesus, the risen Christ, and the returning Lord.

The disciples were not instructed to remain permanently looking toward the sky.

They were called to continue the mission entrusted to them.

The promise of Christ's return therefore provided both hope and motivation for faithful service.

In Seventh-day Adventist theology, Acts 1:9–11 supports the literal and personal nature of the Second Coming.

The return of Jesus will be an actual divine intervention in human history.

Bible References:

- Luke 24:50–53
- Acts 1:6–11
- Acts 3:19–21
- Hebrews 9:27–28
- Revelation 1:7

Contextual Note:

Acts 1 emphasizes both the certainty of Christ's return and the responsibility of His followers to continue witnessing until that event.

Question 3 — Will the Second Coming of Jesus Christ Be Visible to Humanity?

Answer:

The Bible describes the Second Coming as a visible manifestation of Jesus Christ.

Revelation declares that every eye shall see Him.

Jesus compared His coming to lightning shining across the sky.

He also warned His followers against claims that the Messiah could be found secretly in a particular location.

These teachings oppose the idea that the final appearing of Jesus Christ will be hidden from the world.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, Christ's return will be universally visible.

It will not occur as an invisible spiritual event known only to a small group.

The imagery of lightning emphasizes the unmistakable character of His appearing.

The declaration that every eye shall see Him establishes the worldwide significance of the event.

The precise physical manner in which every human being will witness His appearing is not explained in detail.

The biblical emphasis is upon the public revelation of the returning Savior.

Bible References:

- Matthew 24:23–27
- Matthew 24:30
- Mark 13:24–27
- Acts 1:9–11
- Revelation 1:7

Doctrinal Note:

Seventh-day Adventists reject the doctrine of a secret, invisible return of Christ preceding His public appearing. The biblical descriptions emphasize visibility and worldwide recognition.

Question 4 — Will the Return of Jesus Christ Be Audible and Glorious?

Answer:

The New Testament describes Christ's return as accompanied by extraordinary heavenly manifestations.

Paul teaches that the Lord will descend from heaven with a shout, the voice of the archangel, and the trumpet of God.

Jesus describes His coming with power and great glory.

The Gospel of Matthew also associates the gathering of the elect with a great sound of a trumpet.

These passages portray the Second Coming as a majestic event.

It is not presented as a quiet or secret occurrence.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, the audible manifestations associated with Christ's return confirm its public and unmistakable nature.

The glory of Jesus Christ reveals His divine authority and victory.

The Savior who once came in humility will return as the triumphant King.

Bible References:

- Matthew 24:29–31
- Matthew 25:31
- 1 Corinthians 15:51–52
- 1 Thessalonians 4:16–17
- 2 Thessalonians 1:7–10
- Revelation 19:11–16

Doctrinal Note:

The audible and glorious character of the Second Coming is central to Adventist eschatology. These passages are understood as describing a real future event rather than a purely inward religious experience.

Question 5 — What Role Will the Angels Play at the Second Coming?

Answer:

The Bible teaches that angels will accompany Jesus Christ at His return.

Jesus declared that the Son of man would come in His glory with the holy angels.

He also described the angels gathering His elect from the four winds.

These passages demonstrate that the Second Coming involves the heavenly host.

Angels are presented as servants of God who participate in the fulfillment of His purposes.

Their ministry at Christ's return includes the gathering of God's people.

The Gospel of Matthew also uses angelic imagery in passages concerning divine judgment.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, the angels participate in the glorious gathering of the redeemed at the Second Coming.

However, salvation itself is accomplished through Jesus Christ.

Angels do not replace the Savior or become objects of worship.

The central figure of the Second Coming remains the Lord Jesus Christ.

Bible References:

- Matthew 13:39–43
- Matthew 16:27
- Matthew 24:30–31
- Matthew 25:31
- Mark 8:38
- 2 Thessalonians 1:7
- Hebrews 1:13–14

Doctrinal Note:

Angels accompany Christ and carry out divine commands, but the authority and glory of the Second Coming belong to Jesus Christ.

Question 6 — Can Human Beings Know the Exact Date of Christ's Return?

Answer:

Jesus explicitly warned against attempts to determine the precise time of His return.

In Matthew 24, He declared that no one knows the day and hour.

In Acts 1, He told His disciples that it was not for them to know the times or seasons placed under the Father's authority.

These statements establish a clear limitation upon human knowledge.

Although Scripture provides prophetic signs and calls believers to watchfulness, it does not authorize the announcement of an exact date for the Second Coming.

Throughout history, various individuals and religious movements have attempted to predict Christ's return.

Such predictions have repeatedly produced disappointment and confusion.

Seventh-day Adventist history includes the Millerite movement and the disappointment of October 22, 1844.

The Seventh-day Adventist Church subsequently distinguished its understanding of the prophetic significance of 1844 from the mistaken expectation that Christ would return on that date.

Modern Adventist teaching rejects the setting of dates for the Second Coming.

Believers are called to remain spiritually prepared at all times.

Bible References:

- Matthew 24:36–44
- Matthew 25:1–13
- Mark 13:32–37
- Acts 1:6–8
- 1 Thessalonians 5:1–6
- 2 Peter 3:8–10

Historical and Doctrinal Note:

The Millerite expectation of Christ's return in 1844 was not fulfilled. Adventists later developed their sanctuary interpretation of that date, while maintaining that Scripture does not reveal the exact time of the Second Coming.

Question 7 — What Signs Did Jesus Give Concerning the End of the Age?

Answer:

Jesus described several conditions that would characterize the period preceding the end.

These include religious deception, wars, famines, earthquakes, persecution, lawlessness, and the proclamation of the Gospel.

He also warned that false messiahs and false prophets would attempt to deceive people.

The Gospel of Matthew connects the worldwide proclamation of the Gospel with the coming of the end.

However, Jesus cautioned His disciples against assuming that every troubling event immediately signified the final moment.

He taught that certain events would occur without the end necessarily arriving at once.

Therefore, biblical signs must be interpreted carefully.

Wars, natural disasters, and social difficulties have occurred throughout human history.

They should not automatically be treated as proof that Christ will return within a particular number of days or years.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, these signs form part of the broader prophetic picture of the last days.

They encourage watchfulness, faithfulness, and commitment to the Gospel.

Bible References:

- Matthew 24:3–14
- Matthew 24:23–31
- Mark 13:3–13
- Luke 21:7–28
- 2 Timothy 3:1–5
- 2 Peter 3:3–13

Prophetic Note:

The signs of the times should encourage spiritual preparation rather than sensational predictions. Their interpretation must respect the historical and literary contexts of biblical prophecy.

Question 8 — What Is the Relationship Between the Three Angels' Messages and the Second Coming?

Answer:

Revelation 14 describes three angels proclaiming messages of worldwide significance.

The first announces the everlasting Gospel and calls humanity to worship the Creator.

The second announces the fall of Babylon.

The third warns against worshiping the beast and receiving its mark.

The chapter then describes the perseverance of the saints and presents imagery of the harvest of the earth.

In Seventh-day Adventist theology, the three angels' messages represent God's final worldwide appeal before the Second Coming.

They emphasize the everlasting Gospel, true worship, obedience to God's commandments, faith in Jesus Christ, and separation from religious deception.

The Adventist Church understands its mission as participating in the proclamation of these messages.

However, the identification of the prophetic symbols and their relationship to specific historical institutions depend upon Adventist historicist interpretation.

These interpretations should be explained carefully rather than assumed without biblical argument.

The central purpose of the messages is to call humanity to faithfulness to God and readiness for Christ's return.

Bible References:

- Matthew 24:14
- Revelation 12:17
- Revelation 13:11–18
- Revelation 14:6–16
- Revelation 18:1–4
- Revelation 22:12–14

Doctrinal Note:

The three angels' messages are central to the Seventh-day Adventist understanding of its prophetic mission. Their proclamation must remain Christ-centered and grounded in the everlasting Gospel.

Question 9 — What Will Happen to the Righteous Dead When Jesus Returns?

Answer:

The New Testament teaches that the righteous dead will be raised at the return of Jesus Christ.

Paul explains that the Lord will descend from heaven and that the dead in Christ will rise first.

In 1 Corinthians 15, he describes the transformation of the resurrection body from corruption to incorruption.

Jesus also promised to raise believers at the last day.

These passages establish the resurrection as a central event associated with the Second Coming.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, the righteous dead remain unconscious until Christ calls them from their graves.

At His return, they are restored to life and receive immortality.

Their resurrection demonstrates the final victory of Jesus Christ over the grave.

The resurrection is therefore not a secondary event.

It is an essential fulfillment of the Christian hope.

Bible References:

- Daniel 12:2
- John 5:28–29
- John 6:39–40
- John 11:25–26
- 1 Corinthians 15:20–23
- 1 Corinthians 15:51–54
- 1 Thessalonians 4:13–18

Doctrinal Note:

The resurrection of the righteous at Christ's return is central to Adventist teaching and is explicitly connected with His coming in the writings of Paul.

Question 10 — What Will Happen to the Righteous Who Are Alive at Christ's Return?

Answer:

Paul teaches that believers who remain alive at the Second Coming will experience a miraculous transformation.

Their mortal bodies will become incorruptible.

They will be gathered together with the resurrected righteous to meet Jesus Christ.

This event fulfills the promise that God's people will be with the Lord.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, the righteous living will not need to experience death at the moment of Christ's return.

They will be transformed through divine power.

Together with the resurrected righteous, they will be taken to be with Christ.

The transformation is not accomplished through human ability or spiritual achievement.

It is a gift of God through Jesus Christ.

The final hope of believers is therefore not merely survival in the present world.

It is complete redemption and everlasting fellowship with the Savior.

Bible References:

- John 14:1–3
- Romans 8:18–25
- 1 Corinthians 15:51–54
- Philippians 3:20–21
- 1 Thessalonians 4:13–18
- 1 John 3:1–3

Doctrinal Note:

The transformation of the righteous living at Christ's return is a direct New Testament teaching. Adventists understand this event as occurring during the visible and glorious Second Coming.

Question 11 — What Will Happen to the Wicked Living at the Second Coming?

Answer:

The Bible presents the Second Coming as an event involving both salvation and judgment.

Paul describes the revelation of Jesus Christ from heaven as bringing judgment upon those who reject God and oppose His Gospel.

He also describes the destruction of the lawless one through the manifestation of Christ's coming.

Revelation 19 portrays the defeat of the powers assembled against the heavenly Rider.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, the wicked living will perish at the Second Coming.

The righteous are gathered to Christ, while the wicked experience the consequences of divine judgment.

This understanding is connected with the Adventist interpretation of the millennium.

According to that interpretation, the earth is left without living human inhabitants during the thousand years.

However, Christian traditions differ concerning the sequence of end-time judgments and the condition of humanity during the millennium.

The central biblical teaching is that Christ's return will reveal divine justice and bring decisive judgment upon evil.

Bible References:

- Isaiah 11:1–5
- Matthew 24:37–41
- Luke 17:26–30
- 2 Thessalonians 1:6–10

- 2 Thessalonians 2:8
- Revelation 6:14–17
- Revelation 19:11–21

Prophetic Note:

The destruction of the wicked living at Christ's return is part of the Adventist premillennial interpretation. The biblical passages should be examined within their prophetic contexts.

Question 12 — Will Jesus Establish His Millennial Kingdom on the Present Earth at His Return?

Answer:

The Bible teaches that Jesus Christ will return in glory and gather His people.

It also describes a thousand-year reign in Revelation 20.

However, Christian traditions differ concerning the location and nature of that reign.

Some premillennial interpretations teach that Christ will establish an earthly kingdom during the millennium.

Seventh-day Adventists understand the redeemed as spending the thousand years with Christ in heaven.

This interpretation draws upon Jesus' promise to prepare a place for His followers, Paul's description of believers meeting Christ, and Revelation's portrayal of the saints reigning with Him.

Adventists understand the earth as desolate during this period.

The new earth is established after the millennium and the final destruction of evil.

These conclusions form part of the Adventist synthesis of John 14, 1 Thessalonians 4, Revelation 20, and Revelation 21.

The essential promise is that Christ will receive His people and establish His everlasting kingdom.

Bible References:

- John 14:1–3
- 1 Thessalonians 4:13–18
- Revelation 20:1–6
- Revelation 20:11–15
- Revelation 21:1–5
- Revelation 22:1–5

Doctrinal Note:

The Adventist understanding of the heavenly millennium differs from interpretations that anticipate a millennial kingdom inhabited by mortal nations on the present earth.

Question 13 — How Can Christians Recognize False Claims Concerning the Return of Jesus?

Answer:

Jesus warned that false messiahs and false prophets would arise.

He specifically cautioned His followers against claims that the Messiah could be found secretly in the desert or in hidden chambers.

He also warned that deceptive signs could be used to mislead people.

The New Testament therefore calls believers to exercise spiritual discernment.

Claims concerning Christ's return must be examined according to Scripture.

No person should be accepted as the returning Christ merely because of extraordinary experiences, persuasive speech, or apparent miracles.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, the biblical characteristics of the Second Coming provide important safeguards against deception.

Christ's return will be personal, visible, glorious, and accompanied by the resurrection and gathering of the redeemed.

It will not depend upon private announcements or hidden manifestations.

The believer's protection is found in faithfulness to Scripture and confidence in Jesus Christ.

Bible References:

- Matthew 7:15–23
- Matthew 24:4–5
- Matthew 24:23–27
- Mark 13:21–23
- 2 Thessalonians 2:8–12
- 1 John 4:1–6
- Revelation 16:13–14

Practical Note:

Christians should reject sensational predictions, manipulative religious claims, and attempts to produce fear through unsupported interpretations of current events.

Question 14 — How Should Christians Prepare for the Second Coming?

Answer:

Jesus repeatedly instructed His followers to watch and remain ready.

The parable of the ten virgins emphasizes the importance of spiritual preparation.

The parable of the talents highlights faithful stewardship and responsibility.

The New Testament also encourages holiness, love, perseverance, and active service.

Preparation for Christ's return does not mean attempting to earn salvation through religious performance.

Salvation is received by grace through faith in Jesus Christ.

However, genuine faith produces a transformed life.

Christians are called to repent, trust the Savior, obey God's Word, and demonstrate love toward others.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, preparation also includes faithfulness to God's commandments, dependence upon the Holy Spirit, and participation in the proclamation of the everlasting Gospel.

The Christian should not abandon ordinary responsibilities because of expectations concerning the end.

Instead, the hope of Christ's return should encourage responsible living, compassion, honesty, and faithful service.

Bible References:

- Matthew 24:42–51
- Matthew 25:1–30
- Luke 12:35–48
- John 14:15
- Ephesians 2:8–10
- Titus 2:11–14
- 2 Peter 3:11–14
- Revelation 14:12

Doctrinal Note:

Preparation for the Second Coming is the fruit of salvation through Christ, not a means of purchasing salvation. Watchfulness should produce faithful living rather than fear or neglect of daily responsibilities.

Question 15 — Why Is the Second Coming Called the Blessed Hope of Christians?

Answer:

The apostle Paul describes the appearing of Jesus Christ as the blessed hope.

This expression reflects the central place of Christ's return in Christian expectation.

The Second Coming brings the fulfillment of promises concerning resurrection, transformation, reunion, judgment, and everlasting life.

For believers who have suffered, it represents the assurance that evil and death will not reign forever.

For those who mourn, it offers the hope of resurrection and reunion in Christ.

For the faithful, it is the promise of eternal fellowship with the Savior.

The Book of Revelation concludes with the assurance that Jesus Christ is coming.

The response of faith is an expression of longing for His return.

In Seventh-day Adventist theology, the Second Coming is the culmination of the Church's earthly hope and a decisive stage in the final resolution of the great controversy.

The Christian's confidence does not rest upon knowing the date of Christ's return.

It rests upon the faithfulness of the One who made the promise.

Jesus Christ will return.

His people are called to live in readiness, faith, and hope.

Bible References:

- John 14:1–3
- Romans 8:18–25

- 1 Corinthians 15:51–58
- 1 Thessalonians 4:13–18
- Titus 2:11–14
- Hebrews 9:27–28
- 2 Peter 3:13
- Revelation 21:1–5
- Revelation 22:12, 20

Doctrinal Note:

The Second Coming is the blessed hope because it centers upon the return of Jesus Christ and the fulfillment of God's saving promises. It should inspire assurance, perseverance, and faithful service.

Chapter Summary

The Second Coming of Jesus Christ is one of the central promises of the Holy Scriptures.

Jesus personally promised to return and receive His followers.

The angels confirmed this promise at His ascension.

The New Testament describes His coming as visible, glorious, and accompanied by heavenly manifestations.

It also connects His return with the resurrection of the righteous, the transformation of living believers, and divine judgment.

In Seventh-day Adventist theology, the Second Coming is a literal, personal, worldwide, visible, and audible event.

Our study enables us to retain the following teachings:

1. Jesus Christ personally promised that He would return.

2. The angels confirmed that the same Jesus who ascended into heaven would come again.

3. The Second Coming will be visible and worldwide.

4. Christ's return will be glorious and accompanied by audible heavenly manifestations.

5. The holy angels will accompany Jesus and participate in gathering His people.

6. Scripture does not reveal the exact date of the Second Coming.

7. Jesus described signs that call believers to watchfulness and spiritual preparation.

8. The three angels' messages form an essential part of the Adventist understanding of the final Gospel proclamation.

9. The righteous dead will be raised at Christ's return.

10. The righteous living will be transformed and gathered to the Savior.

11. The wicked living will face divine judgment at Christ's appearing.

12. Adventist theology teaches that the redeemed will spend the millennium with Christ in heaven.

13. False claims concerning Christ's return must be tested according to Scripture.

14. Preparation involves faith in Jesus Christ, repentance, obedience, watchfulness, and faithful service.

15. The Second Coming is the blessed hope of believers and the assurance of God's final victory.

Doctrinal Conclusion

The Second Coming of Jesus Christ occupies a central place in biblical prophecy and Christian hope.

It represents the fulfillment of the Savior's promise to return and receive His people.

In Seventh-day Adventist theology, the Second Coming includes several essential characteristics.

A Personal Return

The same Jesus Christ who ascended into heaven will return.

A Literal Event

The Second Coming is an actual future event rather than a merely symbolic experience.

A Visible Manifestation

The Bible declares that every eye shall see Him.

A Glorious Appearing

Christ will return with power and great glory.

An Audible Event

His coming will be accompanied by heavenly manifestations, including the trumpet of God.

The Gathering of the Redeemed

The angels will participate in gathering God's faithful people.

The Resurrection of the Righteous

The dead in Christ will rise to immortal life.

The Transformation of the Living

The righteous living will receive incorruptible bodies.

Divine Judgment

Christ's return will reveal the justice of God and bring judgment upon evil.

The Beginning of the Millennium

In Adventist interpretation, the Second Coming introduces the thousand years described in Revelation 20.

The Rejection of Date-Setting

Scripture does not authorize human beings to announce the precise time of Christ's return.

The Call to Spiritual Preparation

Believers are called to remain faithful through the grace of Jesus Christ and the power of the Holy Spirit.

The Blessed Hope

The Second Coming is the assurance that God's promises will be fulfilled.

The biblical teaching concerning Christ's return should not produce fear, speculation, or hostility toward others.

Its purpose is to strengthen faith, encourage repentance, inspire faithful service, and direct the believer's attention toward Jesus Christ.

The Savior who died and rose again will return in glory.

His people will be gathered into His presence.

Death and evil will ultimately be defeated.

God's everlasting kingdom will be established.

The Essential Message:

Jesus Christ has promised to return, and the Holy Scriptures describe His coming as personal, visible, glorious, and worldwide. At His return, the righteous dead will be raised, the righteous living will be transformed, and God's people will be gathered to the Savior. Seventh-day Adventist theology understands this event as the beginning of the millennium and a decisive stage in the final resolution of the great controversy. Although no human being knows the exact date, Christians are called to remain spiritually prepared through faith in Jesus Christ, obedience to God's Word, and faithful service. The Second Coming is the blessed hope of all who trust in the Savior.

Personal Reflection Questions

1. What did Jesus Christ promise His disciples concerning His return?

2. How does Acts 1:9–11 describe the nature of the Second Coming?

3. What biblical evidence demonstrates that Christ's return will be visible and glorious?

4. Why is the Second Coming incompatible with claims of a secret or hidden manifestation of Christ?

5. What does the Bible teach about the impossibility of determining the exact date of Christ's return?

6. How should I interpret the signs of the times without becoming fearful or speculative?

7. What is the relationship between the three angels' messages and the Adventist mission?

8. What will happen to the righteous dead and the righteous living when Jesus returns?

9. How can I prepare spiritually for Christ's return while remaining faithful in my daily responsibilities?

10. Why does the promise of the Second Coming strengthen my hope, courage, and commitment to Jesus Christ?

Suggested Prayer

Lord my God,

I come before You with gratitude, reverence, and hope.

You are the Creator of heaven and earth.

You are holy, righteous, loving, and faithful.

Thank You for revealing Your promises through the Holy Scriptures.

Thank You for sending Jesus Christ into the world to accomplish the work of salvation.

Thank You for His perfect life, His sacrifice upon the cross, and His glorious resurrection.

Above all, thank You for His promise to return.

I believe that Jesus Christ will come again in power and great glory.

Help me keep this blessed hope alive in my heart.

Teach me to study Your Word faithfully.

Give me wisdom to understand the prophecies concerning the last days.

Protect me from deception, sensational predictions, and the temptation to determine what You have not revealed.

Help me distinguish the clear teachings of Scripture from human speculation.

May I never allow fear to replace faith.

Prepare my heart for the glorious return of Jesus Christ.

Lead me to genuine repentance and complete trust in His saving grace.

Help me obey Your Word because I love You.

Fill me with Your Holy Spirit.

Develop within me patience, humility, faithfulness, compassion, and love.

Teach me to remain watchful without neglecting my daily responsibilities.

Help me serve my family, my neighbors, and those who are in need.

Give me courage to share the everlasting Gospel with kindness and truth.

May my life reflect the character of Jesus Christ.

When I experience suffering, strengthen my hope.

When I face uncertainty, remind me of Your promises.

When I mourn the loss of loved ones, comfort me with the assurance of resurrection.

Thank You for the promise that the dead in Christ will rise.

Thank You for the assurance that the righteous living will be transformed.

Thank You for the hope of everlasting fellowship with the Savior.

I look forward to the day when Jesus Christ will return and gather His people.

Until that glorious moment, help me remain faithful, humble, obedient, and completely dependent upon Your grace.

May my heart continually respond to the promise of Your Son's return.

Even so, come, Lord Jesus.

In the name of Jesus Christ, my Savior and Lord.

Amen.

CHAPTER 35 — THE FINAL JUDGMENT AND THE DESTRUCTION OF EVIL: HOW WILL GOD BRING SIN TO AN END?

A Thematic Bible Study — King James Version (KJV)

Opening Scripture

> “And I saw a great white throne, and him that sat on it, from whose face the earth and the heaven fled away; and there was found no place for them.”

Revelation 20:11 — KJV

Introduction

In the preceding chapters, we examined the resurrection of the dead, the millennium, and the glorious Second Coming of Jesus Christ.

We discovered that the Holy Scriptures proclaim the final victory of Jesus Christ over death and that God has promised everlasting life to those who believe in His Son.

We also examined the thousand years described in Revelation 20 and the events associated with the conclusion of the great controversy between Christ and Satan.

These teachings lead us to another essential subject: the final judgment and the destruction of evil.

Throughout human history, injustice, suffering, violence, deception, and death have raised difficult questions concerning the character and government of God.

Why does God permit evil to continue?

Will every act of injustice receive a righteous judgment?

What will happen to those who persistently reject His grace?

Will Satan continue to exist forever?

What is the meaning of the lake of fire?

What does the Bible teach about the second death?

Will the wicked suffer consciously throughout eternity, or will they ultimately be destroyed?

How can God's final judgment be reconciled with His love and mercy?

The Holy Scriptures address these questions through the teachings of the prophets, Jesus Christ, the apostles, and the Book of Revelation.

The Bible presents God as holy, righteous, merciful, and just.

It teaches that human beings are accountable for their choices and that divine judgment will ultimately reveal the righteousness of God's decisions.

At the same time, Scripture declares that God does not delight in the death of the wicked.

He calls humanity to repentance and offers salvation through Jesus Christ.

The New Testament teaches that salvation is a gift of grace received through faith.

It also affirms that human actions will be considered in judgment.

These teachings are not contradictory.

Good works do not purchase salvation, but they reveal the character and direction of a person's life.

In Seventh-day Adventist theology, the final judgment forms part of the conclusion of the great controversy between Christ and Satan.

Adventists distinguish several aspects of divine judgment, including the pre-Advent judgment, the millennial judgment, and the final execution of judgment.

They understand the final destruction of the wicked as complete and irreversible.

According to this interpretation, the wicked do not possess inherent immortality and will not experience endless conscious torment.

Instead, the second death represents the final destruction of sin and those who remain identified with it.

Other Christian traditions interpret the biblical descriptions of final punishment differently.

Some teach eternal conscious punishment.

Others defend conditional immortality or alternative understandings of the final judgment.

A responsible Bible study must examine these differences carefully and distinguish explicit biblical statements from theological conclusions.

This chapter will investigate fifteen questions concerning the final judgment, the second death, the lake of fire, the destruction of Satan, and the complete elimination of evil.

Our objective is to understand how God's justice and mercy are revealed through Jesus Christ and how the final judgment prepares the way for the restoration of His creation.

Question 1 — Why Does the Bible Teach That God Will Judge the World?

Answer:

The Bible teaches that God is righteous and that His judgments are consistent with His holy character.

Abraham recognized God as the Judge of all the earth.

The Psalms describe righteousness and judgment as foundations of His government.

The apostle Paul declared that God has appointed a day in which He will judge the world in righteousness through Jesus Christ.

Divine judgment demonstrates that human actions possess moral significance.

It also affirms that evil, injustice, and rebellion will not continue without accountability.

However, judgment should not be understood merely as punishment.

The biblical concept also includes vindication, deliverance, and the restoration of justice.

For God's faithful people, judgment is connected with the promise that righteousness will ultimately prevail.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, divine judgment also reveals the justice of God's government in the context of the great controversy.

God's decisions are understood as consistent with His love, truth, and righteousness.

Bible References:

- Genesis 18:25
- Psalm 9:7–8
- Psalm 89:14
- Ecclesiastes 12:13–14
- Acts 17:30–31
- Romans 2:5–11
- Revelation 15:3–4

Doctrinal Note:

Biblical judgment includes both accountability and vindication. God's justice must be understood in harmony with His mercy and the salvation offered through Jesus Christ.

Question 2 — Who Has Been Appointed to Exercise Divine Judgment?

Answer:

The New Testament teaches that God has entrusted judgment to Jesus Christ.

Jesus declared that the Father has committed judgment to the Son.

Paul explained that God will judge the world through the One whom He has appointed.

The same Savior who died for humanity and rose from the dead is therefore presented as the righteous Judge.

This teaching is significant because Christ understands the human condition.

He experienced temptation, suffering, rejection, and death without committing sin.

His judgment is not based upon ignorance or injustice.

It is exercised in perfect harmony with the Father's will.

The Bible also describes the participation of the saints in judgment.

However, this participation does not replace Christ's supreme authority.

In Seventh-day Adventist theology, Jesus Christ is both Savior, heavenly High Priest, and Judge.

The believer's confidence rests upon His righteousness and saving grace.

Bible References:

- John 5:22–29
- Acts 10:42–43
- Acts 17:30–31
- Romans 2:16
- 2 Corinthians 5:10
- Hebrews 4:14–16
- Revelation 19:11–16

Doctrinal Note:

Jesus Christ is central to both salvation and judgment. His role as Judge should not be separated from His sacrificial love and His ministry as Savior.

Question 3 — On What Basis Will Human Beings Be Judged?

Answer:

The Bible teaches that God judges with righteousness and impartiality.

Human beings are accountable for their actions, words, intentions, and response to divine truth.

Ecclesiastes declares that God will bring every work into judgment.

Jesus taught that people would give account for their words.

Paul explained that God judges the secrets of human beings through Jesus Christ.

The Book of Revelation describes judgment according to works recorded in the books.

However, the New Testament also teaches that salvation is received by grace through faith, not earned through human works.

These teachings must be understood together.

Works reveal the reality of faith and the moral direction of a person's life.

They do not replace the saving righteousness of Jesus Christ.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, God's commandments express His moral will and provide an important standard of judgment.

Nevertheless, the foundation of salvation remains the grace of God through Jesus Christ.

Bible References:

- Ecclesiastes 12:13–14
- Matthew 12:36–37
- Romans 2:6–16
- Romans 3:21–26
- 2 Corinthians 5:10
- Ephesians 2:8–10
- James 2:14–26
- Revelation 20:12–13

Doctrinal Note:

The Bible teaches judgment according to works and salvation by grace through faith. Works serve as evidence of a person's life and response to God, not as a means of purchasing salvation.

Question 4 — What Is the Great White Throne Judgment?

Answer:

Revelation 20 describes a great white throne and the One seated upon it.

The dead are portrayed standing before God.

Books are opened, and another book, identified as the book of life, is also opened.

The dead are judged according to their works.

This vision emphasizes the authority, righteousness, and finality of divine judgment.

The great white throne represents the supreme judicial authority of God.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, this judgment takes place after the millennium and is associated with the resurrection of the wicked.

It leads to the final execution of judgment and the second death.

However, Revelation is an apocalyptic book containing symbolic imagery.

The vision should not automatically be interpreted as a literal description of every physical detail of a heavenly courtroom.

Other Christian traditions interpret the timing and scope of the great white throne judgment differently.

The central biblical message is that God will bring human history to a righteous conclusion.

Bible References:

- Daniel 7:9–10
- John 5:28–29
- Acts 17:30–31
- Revelation 20:11–15
- Revelation 21:1–8

Prophetic Note:

The Adventist identification of the great white throne judgment with events following the millennium depends upon its interpretation of Revelation 20 as a chronological prophetic sequence.

Question 5 — What Is the Book of Life Mentioned in Scripture?

Answer:

The Bible refers to a divine book associated with those who belong to God.

Moses spoke of God's book when interceding for Israel.

Daniel described a time of deliverance for those found written in the book.

Jesus told His disciples to rejoice because their names were written in heaven.

The Book of Revelation refers repeatedly to the book of life.

These passages emphasize God's knowledge of His people and the assurance of salvation.

The book of life should not be understood as suggesting that God requires written records because His knowledge is incomplete.

The imagery communicates divine remembrance, accountability, and belonging.

In Revelation 20, the book of life is associated with the final judgment.

In Seventh-day Adventist theology, it plays an important role in the understanding of divine judgment and the final destiny of humanity.

However, the Bible does not explain every detail concerning the nature or organization of the heavenly records.

The essential question is whether a person belongs to Jesus Christ through faith.

Bible References:

- Exodus 32:31–33
- Psalm 69:28
- Daniel 12:1

- Luke 10:20
- Philippians 4:3
- Revelation 3:5
- Revelation 20:12, 15
- Revelation 21:27

Doctrinal Note:

The book of life represents divine recognition and the assurance of belonging to God. Speculative descriptions of heavenly recordkeeping should be avoided.

Question 6 — What Is the Difference Between the First Death and the Second Death?

Answer:

The Bible describes ordinary human death as a reality affecting humanity in the present fallen world.

The New Testament also speaks of a second death.

Revelation identifies the lake of fire with the second death.

It declares that those who participate in the first resurrection are beyond the power of the second death.

The first death is the mortality experienced in the present human condition.

The second death is associated with final judgment.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, the first death is temporary because God has promised resurrection.

The second death is final and irreversible.

It represents the complete destruction of the wicked after divine judgment.

Other Christian traditions interpret the second death differently.

Some understand it as eternal separation from God involving conscious punishment.

The Adventist interpretation emphasizes that the final outcome of sin is death rather than endless conscious existence in suffering.

The biblical distinction between the two deaths must be examined within the wider teaching of Revelation.

Bible References:

- Genesis 3:19
- Romans 5:12
- Romans 6:23
- 1 Corinthians 15:20–26
- Revelation 2:11
- Revelation 20:6
- Revelation 20:14–15
- Revelation 21:8

Doctrinal Note:

The second death is explicitly named in Revelation. Its precise nature is interpreted differently among Christian traditions, with Adventists understanding it as final destruction.

Question 7 — What Does the Bible Mean by the Lake of Fire?

Answer:

The Book of Revelation describes the lake of fire in connection with the final defeat of evil.

The beast and false prophet are cast into the lake of fire in Revelation 19.

Revelation 20 describes the devil being cast into the lake of fire.

The chapter also associates the lake of fire with the second death.

The imagery communicates the seriousness and finality of divine judgment.

However, Revelation uses apocalyptic language.

The symbols must be interpreted within the broader biblical context.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, the lake of fire represents the final destruction of the wicked and the complete elimination of sin.

Other Christian traditions understand the imagery as describing eternal conscious punishment.

Some interpreters also distinguish the fate of Satan and the symbolic powers from the fate of human beings.

The biblical texts must therefore be examined carefully rather than assuming that every image has a simple literal meaning.

The central teaching is that evil will face decisive divine judgment.

Bible References:

- Matthew 13:40–43
- Matthew 25:41
- 2 Peter 3:7–13
- Revelation 19:19–21
- Revelation 20:7–15
- Revelation 21:8

Prophetic Note:

The lake of fire is part of Revelation's final-judgment imagery. Its relationship to the second death is explicit, while the nature and duration of punishment remain debated among Christian interpreters.

Question 8 — Does the Bible Teach Eternal Conscious Torment or the Final Destruction of the Wicked?

Answer:

This question has been debated throughout Christian history.

Several biblical passages describe the punishment of the wicked using expressions such as everlasting fire, eternal punishment, destruction, and the second death.

Matthew 25 speaks of everlasting punishment.

Mark 9 contains warnings concerning unquenchable fire.

Revelation 14 describes the smoke of torment ascending forever and ever.

Revelation 20 uses language concerning torment associated with the devil, the beast, and the false prophet.

Many Christian traditions interpret these passages as teaching eternal conscious punishment.

Seventh-day Adventists understand the final punishment of the wicked as complete and irreversible destruction.

They emphasize passages declaring that the wages of sin is death, that the wicked will perish, and that the wicked will become ashes.

In this interpretation, the punishment is everlasting in its result rather than in the continuous conscious experience of those punished.

However, this conclusion requires interpretation of passages that appear to describe ongoing torment.

The Adventist position should therefore be presented as a theological argument rather than as an uncontested reading of every relevant text.

The essential biblical principle is that God will judge evil with righteousness.

Bible References:

- Psalm 37:9–20
- Malachi 4:1–3
- Matthew 10:28

- Matthew 25:41–46
- Mark 9:43–48
- Romans 6:23
- 2 Thessalonians 1:6–10
- Revelation 14:9–11
- Revelation 20:10–15

Doctrinal Note:

Seventh-day Adventists teach conditional immortality and the final annihilation of the wicked. Eternal conscious punishment remains the traditional position of many Christian denominations. Both interpretations must account for the full range of biblical passages.

Question 9 — What Is the Meaning of Everlasting Fire and Unquenchable Fire?

Answer:

The Bible uses the expressions everlasting fire and unquenchable fire in passages concerning divine judgment.

Jesus spoke of everlasting fire prepared for the devil and his angels.

He also warned concerning fire that is not quenched.

The Old Testament uses similar language when describing judgments upon cities and nations.

Jeremiah warned that God would kindle a fire in Jerusalem that would not be quenched.

The historical city did not continue burning forever.

This observation is important in the Adventist interpretation.

Seventh-day Adventists understand unquenchable fire as fire that cannot be extinguished before accomplishing its purpose.

They understand everlasting fire as producing permanent consequences.

However, other Christian interpreters argue that certain New Testament passages describe punishment continuing eternally.

The interpretation therefore depends upon the immediate context and the broader theological framework.

A responsible study must distinguish the duration of a fire, the duration of its consequences, and the nature of the punishment being described.

Bible References:

- Isaiah 34:8–10
- Jeremiah 17:27
- Matthew 3:11–12
- Matthew 18:8–9
- Matthew 25:41
- Mark 9:43–48
- Jude 7

Linguistic and Contextual Note:

The Greek adjective aiōnios, often translated as eternal or everlasting, must be interpreted according to context. The Adventist argument emphasizes the permanence of the punishment's result, while other interpreters understand the relevant passages as describing punishment of unending duration.

Question 10 — What Will Ultimately Happen to Satan?

Answer:

The Bible teaches that Satan is the adversary and deceiver who opposes God's purposes.

However, his power is limited.

Jesus Christ accomplished the decisive victory over evil through His death and resurrection.

Revelation describes Satan's final rebellion and defeat.

The devil is cast into the lake of fire.

In Seventh-day Adventist theology, Satan will ultimately be destroyed.

Adventists understand this outcome as the complete end of his existence and influence.

They also interpret Ezekiel 28 as containing imagery that can be applied typologically to Satan's fall and final destruction.

However, Ezekiel 28 directly addresses the ruler of Tyre in its historical setting.

Its application to Satan is a theological interpretation.

Furthermore, Revelation 20:10 describes the devil's torment using language of continuing duration.

Adventist teaching concerning Satan's final destruction must therefore explain this passage rather than disregard it.

Other Christian traditions understand Satan's final punishment as eternal conscious torment.

The central biblical assurance is that Satan will be defeated permanently and will never again threaten God's redeemed creation.

Bible References:

- Genesis 3:14–15
- John 12:31–33
- Hebrews 2:14–15
- 1 John 3:8
- Revelation 12:7–12
- Revelation 20:7–10
- Revelation 21:1–5

Doctrinal Note:

The final defeat of Satan is explicitly taught in Scripture. His annihilation is the Adventist interpretation, while other Christian traditions understand Revelation 20:10 as describing eternal conscious punishment.

Question 11 — Does God Take Pleasure in the Destruction of the Wicked?

Answer:

The Bible reveals that God is righteous and that He judges evil.

However, it also teaches that He does not delight in the death of the wicked.

Through the prophet Ezekiel, God called the people to turn from their evil ways and live.

The New Testament declares that God desires repentance and offers salvation through Jesus Christ.

Jesus came to seek and save the lost.

These passages demonstrate that divine judgment must be understood in relation to God's love and mercy.

God's willingness to forgive does not mean that evil is morally insignificant.

Neither does His justice mean that He delights in human suffering.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, the final destruction of the wicked is a tragic but necessary conclusion to persistent rebellion against God.

The opportunity for salvation is offered through Jesus Christ.

The final judgment reveals both the seriousness of sin and the righteousness of God's decisions.

Christians should therefore proclaim the Gospel with compassion rather than using judgment to threaten or humiliate others.

Bible References:

- Ezekiel 18:23, 30–32
- Ezekiel 33:11
- Luke 19:10
- John 3:16–17
- Romans 2:4
- 1 Timothy 2:3–6
- 2 Peter 3:9

Doctrinal Note:

God's judgment must be considered together with His revealed desire for repentance and salvation. Biblical warnings should be communicated with compassion and seriousness.

Question 12 — How Does the Final Judgment Reveal the Justice and Love of God?

Answer:

The Bible presents divine justice and divine love as harmonious aspects of God's character.

The Psalms describe God's throne as established upon righteousness and judgment.

The New Testament reveals God's love through the sacrifice of Jesus Christ.

Paul explains that God's saving work demonstrates His righteousness while providing justification to those who believe in Jesus.

The final judgment reveals that God does not ignore evil.

It also demonstrates that salvation is offered through grace.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, the final judgment contributes to the universal recognition of God's justice.

The great controversy is understood as involving accusations against God's character and government.

Its conclusion demonstrates that His decisions are righteous.

However, the Bible does not provide a complete philosophical explanation of every divine decision.

Believers are called to trust God's revealed character.

The cross of Jesus Christ remains the supreme demonstration of His love and saving righteousness.

Bible References:

- Genesis 18:25
- Psalm 89:14
- Isaiah 45:21–23
- John 3:16–17
- Romans 3:21–26
- Philippians 2:9–11
- Revelation 15:3–4
- Revelation 19:1–2

Doctrinal Note:

The Adventist great-controversy framework emphasizes the vindication of God's character. This is a theological synthesis grounded in biblical themes of divine justice, love, and the final defeat of evil.

Question 13 — What Does the Bible Mean When It Says That Every Knee Shall Bow?

Answer:

The Bible declares that every knee shall bow before God.

Isaiah presents this declaration in connection with the uniqueness and sovereignty of the Lord.

Paul applies similar language to Jesus Christ.

He explains that every knee will bow and every tongue confess that Jesus Christ is Lord.

These passages reveal the universal acknowledgment of divine authority.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, the final judgment will demonstrate the righteousness of God so clearly that His justice will be universally acknowledged.

However, the biblical declaration does not necessarily mean that every individual will be saved.

Christian traditions differ concerning the relationship between universal acknowledgment, final judgment, and salvation.

Some interpret the confession as willing worship by the redeemed and compelled acknowledgment by those under judgment.

Others understand the language differently.

The central teaching is that the authority of Jesus Christ will ultimately be recognized.

No rebellion can permanently overthrow God's government.

Bible References:

- Isaiah 45:22–25
- Romans 14:10–12
- Philippians 2:9–11
- Revelation 5:11–14
- Revelation 15:3–4

Doctrinal Note:

Universal acknowledgment of Christ's lordship should not automatically be equated with universal salvation. The interpretation must consider passages concerning judgment and final destiny.

Question 14 — Will Sin, Suffering, and Death Ever Return After the Final Judgment?

Answer:

The Bible promises a future in which death, sorrow, crying, and pain will no longer exist.

Revelation describes the removal of the curse and the restoration of fellowship between God and His people.

The prophet Nahum declares that affliction will not rise up a second time.

In its immediate historical context, this statement concerns God's judgment against Nineveh.

Seventh-day Adventists also apply its language to the final and permanent defeat of evil.

This broader application should be distinguished from the passage's original historical meaning.

The New Testament provides a direct foundation for the promise that death will ultimately be destroyed.

Paul identifies death as the last enemy.

Revelation declares that death and hell are cast into the lake of fire.

The new creation is described as a place where the former suffering has passed away.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, sin will never again arise to threaten God's universe.

The redeemed will live forever in a creation completely restored through Jesus Christ.

Bible References:

- Nahum 1:9
- Isaiah 25:8
- Romans 8:18–25
- 1 Corinthians 15:24–28
- Revelation 20:14
- Revelation 21:1–5
- Revelation 22:1–5

Contextual Note:

Nahum 1:9 directly concerns divine judgment in its historical setting. Its application to the eternal prevention of sin is part of the broader Adventist theological interpretation.

Question 15 — How Should the Reality of Final Judgment Influence Christian Life Today?

Answer:

The Bible teaches that the reality of divine judgment should encourage repentance, faithfulness, humility, and love.

Jesus called people to repent and believe the Gospel.

Paul taught that God's kindness leads toward repentance.

The New Testament also encourages believers to live holy and responsible lives in anticipation of God's promised future.

However, Christian preparation for judgment must not become an attempt to earn salvation.

Salvation is received through the grace of Jesus Christ.

The believer's confidence rests upon His sacrifice and righteousness.

Good works are the fruit of a living faith.

The final judgment should also encourage compassion toward others.

Christians are called to proclaim the Gospel, serve those in need, practice justice, and demonstrate the character of Jesus Christ.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, the final judgment gives urgency to the proclamation of the everlasting Gospel and the three angels' messages.

Nevertheless, the Gospel must remain a message of hope and salvation rather than manipulation through fear.

The Christian's central responsibility is to trust Jesus Christ and live faithfully through the power of the Holy Spirit.

Bible References:

- Matthew 25:31–46
- Mark 1:14–15
- John 3:16–18
- Romans 2:4
- Romans 8:1–4
- Ephesians 2:8–10
- Titus 2:11–14
- 2 Peter 3:11–14
- Revelation 14:6–12

Doctrinal Note:

The final judgment should inspire repentance, faith, and responsible Christian living. Fear should never replace confidence in the saving grace of Jesus Christ.

Chapter Summary

The Holy Scriptures teach that God will bring human history to a righteous conclusion.

The final judgment reveals divine justice, establishes accountability, and brings evil to its ultimate defeat.

Jesus Christ is central to this judgment.

He is both Savior and Judge.

The Bible also describes the book of life, the great white throne, the lake of fire, and the second death.

In Seventh-day Adventist theology, the final judgment results in the complete destruction of sin, Satan, and the wicked.

The universe is then restored through God's creative power.

Our study enables us to retain the following teachings:

1. God will judge the world because He is righteous and just.

2. Jesus Christ has been appointed to exercise divine judgment.

3. Human beings are judged according to their works, while salvation remains a gift of grace through faith.

4. The great white throne judgment reveals the final authority and righteousness of God.

5. The book of life represents divine recognition of those who belong to God.

6. The second death is associated with the final judgment and the lake of fire.

7. The lake of fire represents the final defeat and judgment of evil.

8. Seventh-day Adventists understand the final punishment of the wicked as complete and irreversible destruction.

9. The expressions everlasting fire and unquenchable fire require careful interpretation within their biblical contexts.

10. Satan will ultimately be defeated and will never again threaten God's redeemed creation.

11. God does not delight in the death of the wicked but calls humanity to repentance.

12. The final judgment reveals the harmony of God's justice and love.

13. Every knee will ultimately acknowledge the authority of Jesus Christ.

14. God promises a restored creation in which death, suffering, and evil will no longer exist.

15. The reality of judgment should encourage repentance, faith, humility, compassion, and faithful Christian living.

Doctrinal Conclusion

The final judgment and destruction of evil represent the conclusion of the great controversy between Christ and Satan.

Throughout human history, sin has produced suffering, injustice, deception, and death.

However, the Holy Scriptures declare that evil will not continue forever.

God will bring His saving purposes to completion through Jesus Christ.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, the final judgment includes several essential dimensions.

The Righteousness of God

God judges with perfect justice and impartiality.

The Authority of Jesus Christ

The Savior is also the righteous Judge of humanity.

Salvation Through Grace

Human beings are saved through faith in Jesus Christ rather than through personal merit.

Judgment According to Works

Human actions reveal the character and direction of a person's response to God.

The Great White Throne

Revelation portrays the final authority of divine judgment.

The Book of Life

The book of life is associated with those who belong to God.

The Second Death

Adventists understand the second death as final and irreversible destruction.

The Lake of Fire

The lake of fire represents the final judgment and destruction of evil in Adventist interpretation.

The Destruction of the Wicked

Seventh-day Adventist theology teaches that the wicked will ultimately cease to exist rather than experience endless conscious torment.

The Final Defeat of Satan

Satan's rebellion will be permanently defeated.

The Vindication of God's Character

The conclusion of the great controversy reveals the righteousness, justice, and love of God.

The End of Sin and Death

God promises that suffering, sorrow, and death will no longer exist.

The Restoration of Creation

The final judgment prepares the way for the new heaven and the new earth.

The biblical teaching concerning final judgment must be approached with reverence and humility.

It should not be used to produce hatred, fear, or religious hostility.

Its purpose is to reveal the seriousness of sin, the righteousness of God, and the greatness of salvation through Jesus Christ.

The final word of Scripture is not the triumph of evil.

It is the victory of God.

The Essential Message:

The Holy Scriptures teach that God will bring sin, Satan, and evil to a final judgment through Jesus Christ. The great white throne, the book of life, and the second death reveal the seriousness and finality of divine judgment. Seventh-day Adventist theology understands the punishment of the wicked as complete and irreversible destruction rather than eternal conscious torment. Although Christian traditions interpret the nature of final punishment differently, the Bible proclaims that God's justice will prevail, evil will be defeated, and His redeemed people will dwell forever in a restored creation. The believer's confidence rests entirely upon the saving grace and victory of Jesus Christ.

Personal Reflection Questions

1. Why does the Bible teach that God will judge the world?

2. What does Scripture reveal about Jesus Christ as Savior and Judge?

3. How can I understand judgment according to works while maintaining salvation by grace through faith?

4. What does the great white throne judgment reveal about God's authority and righteousness?

5. What is the biblical significance of the book of life?

6. How does Revelation distinguish the first death from the second death?

7. What biblical arguments support the Adventist teaching concerning the final destruction of the wicked?

8. Why is it important to examine passages concerning everlasting fire and eternal punishment within their contexts?

9. How does the final defeat of Satan reveal the justice and sovereignty of God?

10. How should the reality of divine judgment influence my faith, conduct, compassion, and relationship with Jesus Christ?

Suggested Prayer

Lord my God,

I come before You with reverence, humility, and gratitude.

You are the Creator of heaven and earth.

You are holy, righteous, merciful, and just.

Thank You for revealing Your character through the Holy Scriptures.

Thank You for Your patience toward humanity and Your willingness to forgive those who repent.

I recognize that sin has brought suffering, injustice, and death into the world.

I also acknowledge that I am dependent upon Your mercy and grace.

Forgive my sins and cleanse my heart through Jesus Christ.

Thank You for sending Your Son to accomplish the work of salvation.

Thank You for His sacrifice upon the cross and His glorious resurrection.

I believe that Jesus Christ is my Savior, my Advocate, and the righteous Judge.

Help me place my confidence entirely upon His righteousness.

Teach me to understand Your judgments with humility.

Give me wisdom to study the biblical teachings concerning the great white throne, the book of life, the second death, and the final

destruction of evil.

Protect me from speculation and interpretations that go beyond what Your Word reveals.

Help me distinguish Your clear teachings from human assumptions.

May I never use the doctrine of judgment to condemn others or produce fear.

Instead, fill my heart with compassion for those who have not yet accepted Your grace.

Give me courage to proclaim the everlasting Gospel with kindness and truth.

Teach me to demonstrate justice, mercy, humility, and love in my daily life.

Help me remain faithful when I face temptation.

When I fall, lead me to repentance and restore my confidence in Your forgiveness.

Thank You for the assurance that evil will not reign forever.

Thank You for the promise that Satan will be defeated.

Thank You for the hope that suffering, sorrow, and death will ultimately disappear.

I look forward to the day when Your righteousness will fill the restored creation.

Prepare me for the glorious return of Jesus Christ.

Until that day, help me live with faith, obedience, compassion, and complete dependence upon Your saving grace.

May my life bring honor and glory to Your holy name.

In the name of Jesus Christ, my Savior and Lord.

Amen.

CHAPTER 36 — THE NEW HEAVEN AND THE NEW EARTH: WHAT WILL ETERNAL LIFE BE LIKE IN GOD'S RESTORED CREATION?

A Thematic Bible Study — King James Version (KJV)

Opening Scripture

> “And God shall wipe away all tears from their eyes; and there shall be no more death, neither sorrow, nor crying, neither shall there be any more pain: for the former things are passed away.”

Revelation 21:4 — KJV

Introduction

In the preceding chapter, we examined the final judgment and the destruction of evil.

We discovered that the Holy Scriptures proclaim the ultimate victory of God over sin, Satan, suffering, and death.

The Bible teaches that divine judgment will reveal God's righteousness and bring the rebellion against His government to its conclusion.

However, the plan of redemption does not end with the destruction of evil.

God has promised something far greater: the complete restoration of His creation and everlasting fellowship with His redeemed people.

The opening chapters of Genesis describe a world created by God and declared very good.

Humanity was created in the image of God and entrusted with responsibility for the earth.

The Garden of Eden was a place of life, beauty, abundance, and communion with the Creator.

Sin disrupted this harmony.

The human family became subject to suffering, separation, mortality, and death.

The ground was affected by the consequences of sin, and humanity lost access to the tree of life.

Yet God's original purpose was not abandoned.

Throughout Scripture, the Lord revealed His intention to redeem humanity and restore His creation.

The prophet Isaiah described new heavens and a new earth.

Jesus promised His followers a place in His Father's house.

The apostle Peter anticipated new heavens and a new earth in which righteousness dwells.

The apostle Paul described creation awaiting liberation from corruption.

Finally, the Book of Revelation presents the New Jerusalem, the river of life, the tree of life, and the everlasting presence of God among His people.

The biblical hope is therefore more than an escape from suffering.

It is the restoration of life under the perfect government of God.

But important questions remain.

Will the new earth be a real place?

Will the redeemed possess glorified bodies?

Will they recognize one another?

What will happen to the memories of suffering?

What is the New Jerusalem?

Will the redeemed continue to worship, learn, and serve?

What does the Bible teach about the tree of life?

Will sin ever return?

What does it mean that God will dwell with humanity?

In Seventh-day Adventist theology, the new earth is understood as the eternal home of the redeemed after the millennium, final judgment, and destruction of evil.

The restored earth will be free from sin, death, suffering, and corruption.

The redeemed will enjoy eternal life in the presence of God and Jesus Christ.

Adventists understand this future as a real, restored creation rather than a merely spiritual or symbolic existence.

Other Christian traditions share the biblical hope of a new creation but differ concerning certain details and the sequence of end-time events.

This chapter examines fifteen questions concerning the new heaven, the new earth, the New Jerusalem, and eternal life.

Our objective is to understand the biblical promises faithfully, distinguish revealed truth from speculation, and strengthen our hope in the everlasting kingdom of God.

Question 1 — Did God Originally Create the Earth to Be a Place of Life and Happiness?

Answer:

The Book of Genesis teaches that God created the heavens and the earth.

After completing His creative work, God declared that everything He had made was very good.

Human beings were created in His image and entrusted with responsibility for the earth.

God placed the first human beings in the Garden of Eden, where He provided food, meaningful activity, and fellowship with Himself.

The creation account presents human life as part of God's good purpose.

Suffering, rebellion, and death are not described as the intended fulfillment of humanity's existence.

The entrance of sin disrupted the relationship between God, humanity, and creation.

Nevertheless, the Bible presents God's redemptive purpose as directed toward the restoration of what sin has damaged.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, the new earth fulfills God's original intention that humanity should live in righteousness, peace, and communion with its Creator.

The final restoration is not merely a return to the beginning.

It also includes the completed victory of Jesus Christ and the everlasting security of the redeemed.

Bible References:

- Genesis 1:26–31
- Genesis 2:8–17
- Genesis 3:17–24
- Psalm 115:16
- Isaiah 45:18
- Romans 8:19–23
- Revelation 21:1–5

Doctrinal Note:

The biblical hope of restoration is connected with God's original creative purpose. The new earth represents the fulfillment of redemption through Jesus Christ.

Question 2 — What Does the Bible Mean by a New Heaven and a New Earth?

Answer:

The expression new heaven and new earth appears in both the Old and New Testaments.

Isaiah describes God's promise to create new heavens and a new earth.

Peter anticipates new heavens and a new earth in which righteousness dwells.

Revelation presents John's vision of the first heaven and first earth passing away and a new heaven and new earth appearing.

These passages communicate a profound transformation of the present order.

The present creation is marked by suffering, corruption, and death.

The promised creation will be characterized by righteousness and everlasting fellowship with God.

Christians differ concerning whether the new creation involves the complete replacement of the present physical universe or its radical renewal and transformation.

The biblical texts emphasize the certainty of God's creative action rather than explaining every physical process.

In Seventh-day Adventist theology, the earth is restored after the final destruction of evil.

It becomes the eternal home of the redeemed.

The central promise is that God will establish a creation no longer subject to sin and death.

Bible References:

- Isaiah 65:17–25
- Isaiah 66:22–23
- Romans 8:19–23
- 2 Peter 3:10–13
- Revelation 21:1–5

Contextual Note:

Isaiah 65 includes imagery of longevity and death, while Revelation 21 explicitly declares that death will be no more. These passages should be read according to their respective prophetic contexts rather than assuming that every detail describes the same stage of fulfillment.

Question 3 — When Will the New Earth Be Established?

Answer:

Revelation 20 describes the final judgment and the lake of fire.

Revelation 21 then introduces the vision of a new heaven and a new earth.

In Seventh-day Adventist interpretation, this sequence indicates that the new earth will be established after the millennium, the final resurrection of the wicked, and the destruction of evil.

The redeemed will then live forever in God's restored creation.

Peter also connects the day of divine judgment with the expectation of new heavens and a new earth.

However, Christian traditions differ concerning the chronological relationship between the millennium, final judgment, and new creation.

Some interpret Revelation 20 and 21 as a consecutive sequence.

Others understand parts of Revelation as presenting overlapping visions of God's final victory.

The Adventist position is therefore a particular prophetic interpretation.

The explicit biblical assurance is that God will bring the present fallen order to an end and establish a creation in which righteousness dwells.

Bible References:

- Isaiah 65:17
- 1 Corinthians 15:24–28
- 2 Peter 3:7–13
- Revelation 20:7–15
- Revelation 21:1–5
- Revelation 22:1–5

Prophetic Note:

The placement of the new earth after the millennium is central to Adventist eschatology. The promise of God's final restoration is broader than any single interpretation of the millennial chronology.

Question 4 — What Is the New Jerusalem Described in Revelation?

Answer:

Revelation 21 describes the holy city, New Jerusalem, coming down from God out of heaven.

The city is portrayed as prepared like a bride adorned for her husband.

The vision includes magnificent walls, gates, foundations, precious stones, and streets described in terms of pure gold.

These details communicate beauty, holiness, security, and divine glory.

The city also bears symbolic associations with the twelve tribes of Israel and the twelve apostles.

This imagery emphasizes the unity and fulfillment of God's redemptive purposes.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, the New Jerusalem is the real dwelling place of the redeemed in God's restored creation.

At the same time, the apocalyptic language of Revelation should be interpreted carefully.

Its measurements, materials, and symbolic numbers should not automatically be treated as a complete architectural blueprint.

The most important characteristic of the city is not its physical splendor.

It is the presence of God and the Lamb.

Bible References:

- Isaiah 54:11–14
- Hebrews 11:8–10
- Hebrews 12:22–24
- Revelation 3:12
- Revelation 21:2, 9–27
- Revelation 22:1–5

Doctrinal Note:

The New Jerusalem represents the dwelling of God with His redeemed people. Its apocalyptic imagery communicates theological truths that should not be reduced to speculative architectural calculations.

Question 5 — Will God Personally Dwell With His Redeemed People?

Answer:

One of the greatest promises of Revelation is that God will dwell with His people.

Revelation 21 announces the tabernacle of God with humanity.

This promise fulfills a theme extending throughout Scripture.

In Eden, God communicated with the first human beings.

Through the sanctuary, He revealed His desire to dwell among Israel.

In Jesus Christ, God came into the world and lived among humanity.

The New Testament also describes believers as the dwelling place of the Holy Spirit.

In the new creation, the relationship between God and His redeemed people reaches its promised fulfillment.

Revelation declares that God's servants will see His face.

This imagery communicates direct fellowship, belonging, and the removal of the separation produced by sin.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, the redeemed will enjoy everlasting communion with the Father and Jesus Christ.

The greatest blessing of eternal life is therefore not material abundance.

It is the presence of God Himself.

Bible References:

- Genesis 3:8–9
- Exodus 25:8
- Leviticus 26:11–12
- John 1:14

- John 17:24
- 1 Corinthians 3:16
- Revelation 21:3, 22–23
- Revelation 22:3–5

Doctrinal Note:

The presence of God is the central blessing of the new creation. All other promises must be understood in relation to everlasting fellowship with Him.

Question 6 — Will Death, Sorrow, Pain, and Suffering Exist on the New Earth?

Answer:

Revelation 21 provides a direct and comforting promise.

God will wipe away every tear, and death, sorrow, crying, and pain will no longer exist.

The passage declares that the former things have passed away.

This promise represents the complete reversal of the suffering associated with the fallen world.

The Bible identifies death as an enemy.

Paul teaches that death will ultimately be destroyed.

The new creation therefore represents a condition in which the consequences of sin no longer govern human existence.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, the redeemed will live in perfect health and freedom from suffering.

The restoration is complete and permanent.

However, Scripture does not explain every detail concerning how God will heal the emotional memories of suffering.

The promise should be received according to its central meaning: sorrow and death will no longer have power over God's people.

Bible References:

- Isaiah 25:8
- Isaiah 35:5–10
- Isaiah 65:17–19
- 1 Corinthians 15:24–26
- Revelation 7:16–17
- Revelation 21:3–5
- Revelation 22:3

Pastoral Note:

The promise of a future without suffering does not minimize present grief. It offers hope while encouraging believers to care compassionately for those who suffer today.

Question 7 — Will the Redeemed Possess Real and Glorified Bodies?

Answer:

The New Testament teaches that the redeemed will experience bodily resurrection and transformation.

Paul describes the resurrection body as incorruptible, glorious, and powerful.

He explains that mortality will put on immortality.

The risen Jesus Christ provides the foundation for understanding this promise.

After His resurrection, He appeared to His disciples and demonstrated the reality of His risen existence.

The New Testament also teaches that Christ will transform the bodies of His people.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, eternal life will be experienced by complete, glorified human beings.

The redeemed will not exist merely as disembodied spirits.

They will possess transformed bodies free from corruption and death.

However, the Bible does not reveal every physical characteristic of these bodies.

Questions concerning exact appearance, age, or biological processes remain beyond what Scripture explicitly teaches.

The central promise is that the redeemed will be made fit for everlasting life in God's restored creation.

Bible References:

- Luke 24:36–43
- John 20:19–29
- Romans 8:10–11, 23
- 1 Corinthians 15:35–54
- Philippians 3:20–21
- 1 John 3:1–3

Doctrinal Note:

The biblical hope is bodily resurrection and glorification. Speculative descriptions of the physical characteristics of the redeemed should be avoided.

Question 8 — Will the Redeemed Recognize Their Loved Ones in Eternal Life?

Answer:

The Bible does not provide a direct and comprehensive description of personal recognition in the new earth.

However, several passages offer reasons for hope.

After His resurrection, Jesus was recognized by His disciples, although recognition was not immediate in every encounter.

Paul describes believers being gathered together with those who have died in Christ.

He also speaks of knowing more fully in the future.

These passages suggest continuity of personal identity and relationship.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, the redeemed will retain their individual identity and enjoy meaningful fellowship with one another.

The hope of reunion is closely connected with the resurrection and gathering of God's people.

Nevertheless, Scripture does not explain every detail of personal relationships in eternity.

It would therefore be unwise to make absolute claims concerning matters that have not been clearly revealed.

The Christian's confidence rests upon the goodness of God and the promise that His restored creation will be free from sorrow.

Bible References:

- Matthew 17:1–8
- Luke 24:13–35
- John 20:11–29
- 1 Corinthians 13:12
- 1 Thessalonians 4:13–18
- Revelation 21:3–5

Pastoral Note:

The hope of reunion can comfort those who mourn, but the Bible does not provide detailed answers to every question concerning relationships in the new creation.

Question 9 — What Will Happen to the Memories of Sin and Suffering?

Answer:

Isaiah describes a future in which former troubles will be forgotten and the former things will not come into remembrance.

Revelation promises the complete removal of sorrow, crying, and pain.

These passages emphasize that the suffering of the fallen world will no longer dominate human existence.

However, the Bible does not explicitly explain whether every memory of earthly suffering will be erased.

Some Christian interpreters understand the language as describing the removal of grief and the power of painful memories rather than the destruction of all historical knowledge.

In Seventh-day Adventist theology, the redeemed will understand God's justice and love more fully.

The history of redemption will reveal the greatness of Christ's sacrifice.

Nevertheless, the emotional consequences of sin will no longer produce suffering.

The promise is not that God's people will become unaware of His saving work.

It is that the former world of sorrow will have passed away.

Bible References:

- Isaiah 65:16–19
- John 20:24–29
- 1 Corinthians 13:12
- Revelation 5:6–14
- Revelation 7:13–17

- Revelation 21:3–5

Contextual Note:

The expression concerning former things not being remembered should not be used to construct a detailed theory of memory loss in eternity. Scripture emphasizes the removal of suffering and the completeness of God's restoration.

Question 10 — What Is the River of Life Mentioned in Revelation?

Answer:

Revelation 22 describes a pure river of water of life proceeding from the throne of God and of the Lamb.

The imagery recalls the life-giving waters associated with God's presence in the Old Testament.

Ezekiel describes water flowing from the sanctuary and bringing life and healing.

The Psalms also use river imagery to describe the blessings of God's presence.

In Revelation, the river of life communicates the abundance, purity, and sustaining power of divine life.

It is associated with the throne of God and the Lamb.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, the river belongs to the restored creation and reflects the everlasting life provided by God.

However, Revelation's symbolic language should be respected.

The passage's primary purpose is not to provide a scientific description of the river.

It is to reveal that eternal life flows from the presence and authority of God.

Bible References:

- Psalm 36:7–9
- Psalm 46:4
- Ezekiel 47:1–12
- John 4:10–14
- John 7:37–39
- Revelation 21:6
- Revelation 22:1–2, 17

Doctrinal Note:

The river of life is part of Revelation's vision of the new creation. It symbolizes the abundance and permanence of life received from God.

Question 11 — What Is the Tree of Life, and Why Will It Appear Again?

Answer:

The tree of life first appears in Genesis.

It was located in the Garden of Eden.

After humanity's fall into sin, access to the tree was restricted.

Genesis connects this restriction with the prevention of fallen humanity living forever in its sinful condition.

In Revelation 22, the tree of life appears again in the restored creation.

It is described as bearing twelve kinds of fruit and yielding fruit regularly.

Its leaves are associated with the healing of the nations.

This imagery establishes an important connection between the beginning and conclusion of Scripture.

Humanity lost access to the tree of life through sin.

Through the redemptive work of Jesus Christ, the redeemed receive the promise of restored access.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, the tree of life belongs to the eternal home of the redeemed.

However, the Bible does not explain the precise biological function of its fruit or leaves.

The expression concerning healing should not be interpreted as proof that disease will continue in the new earth.

Revelation explicitly teaches that the curse will be removed.

Bible References:

- Genesis 2:8–9
- Genesis 3:22–24
- Proverbs 3:18
- Ezekiel 47:12
- Revelation 2:7
- Revelation 22:1–3, 14

Doctrinal Note:

The return of the tree of life symbolizes the restoration of access to everlasting life through God's saving work. The details of its fruit and leaves should not become the basis for unsupported speculation.

Question 12 — Will the Redeemed Work, Learn, Worship, and Enjoy Meaningful Activity?

Answer:

The Bible presents eternal life as active fellowship with God rather than meaningless inactivity.

Isaiah describes a future involving building, planting, and enjoying the work of one's hands.

Revelation declares that God's servants will serve Him and reign forever.

These passages suggest purposeful existence in the restored creation.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, the redeemed will enjoy meaningful activity, learning, worship, and fellowship.

Their service will no longer be burdened by sin, exploitation, exhaustion, or death.

However, the precise nature of work and learning in eternity is not fully explained.

Isaiah 65 also contains imagery that requires careful contextual interpretation.

Not every detail can be transferred without qualification into the deathless condition described in Revelation 21.

The essential biblical teaching is that eternal life will be full of purpose, joy, and communion with God.

The redeemed will not be condemned to inactivity.

They will participate in the blessings of God's everlasting kingdom.

Bible References:

- Isaiah 65:17–25
- Matthew 25:21–23
- Luke 19:15–19
- 1 Corinthians 13:12
- Revelation 7:9–17
- Revelation 22:3–5

Doctrinal Note:

Scripture supports the expectation of purposeful service in eternity. Detailed descriptions of occupations, educational activities, or social structures remain matters of inference rather than explicit revelation.

Question 13 — Will the Sabbath Continue to Have Significance in the New Earth?

Answer:

Isaiah 66 describes worship before God from one Sabbath to another in connection with the promise of the new heavens and new earth.

This passage is especially important in Seventh-day Adventist theology.

Adventists understand the Sabbath as a memorial of creation and a sign of God's sanctifying relationship with His people.

They also regard the Sabbath as retaining significance in the restored creation.

The connection between creation, redemption, and the new earth is central to this understanding.

However, Isaiah 66 uses prophetic language within a context that also includes references to new moons, offerings, and judgment.

Christian traditions differ concerning how these elements should be applied to the final state.

Many Christians understand the passage as depicting continual worship rather than establishing a specific weekly observance in eternity.

The Adventist interpretation emphasizes the continuity of God's creation memorial.

The central promise is that the redeemed will worship the Creator in His everlasting kingdom.

Bible References:

- Genesis 2:1–3
- Exodus 20:8–11
- Isaiah 56:1–7
- Isaiah 66:22–23

- Mark 2:27–28
- Hebrews 4:1–11
- Revelation 14:6–7
- Revelation 22:3–5

Doctrinal Note:

The continuation of Sabbath worship in the new earth is a distinctive Adventist interpretation of Isaiah 66:22–23. The passage should be studied in its full prophetic context.

Question 14 — Will Sin, Satan, and Death Ever Threaten God's Creation Again?

Answer:

The Bible promises the ultimate defeat of sin and death.

Paul identifies death as the last enemy to be destroyed.

Revelation describes the final judgment, the removal of the curse, and the establishment of a new creation.

The redeemed will live in God's presence without suffering or death.

In Seventh-day Adventist theology, the great controversy between Christ and Satan will end permanently.

Sin will never again arise to threaten the harmony of God's universe.

Adventists sometimes connect this conclusion with Nahum's declaration that affliction will not rise up a second time.

However, Nahum's immediate historical context concerns divine judgment upon Nineveh.

Its application to the eternal prevention of sin is a broader theological interpretation.

The strongest direct foundation for the permanence of God's restored kingdom is found in the New Testament's promises concerning the destruction of death, the removal of the curse, and the everlasting

reign of God.

The Christian hope is therefore secure.

Evil will not have the final word.

Bible References:

- Nahum 1:9
- Daniel 7:13–14, 27
- 1 Corinthians 15:24–28
- 2 Peter 3:13
- Revelation 20:10–15
- Revelation 21:1–5, 27
- Revelation 22:3–5

Doctrinal Note:

The permanent victory of God over evil is central to biblical eschatology. The Adventist great-controversy framework emphasizes that the restored creation will never again experience rebellion and sin.

Question 15 — How Can a Person Receive the Promise of Eternal Life in God's Kingdom?

Answer:

The Bible teaches that eternal life is a gift from God through Jesus Christ.

Human beings cannot purchase salvation through good works, religious achievements, or personal merit.

Jesus declared that God loved the world and gave His only begotten Son so that those who believe in Him should not perish but have everlasting life.

Paul taught that salvation is by grace through faith.

The New Testament also calls people to repentance, faith, baptism, obedience, and a transformed life.

These responses do not replace the grace of God.

They express the believer's relationship with Jesus Christ.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, genuine faith produces obedience to God's commandments and perseverance through the power of the Holy Spirit.

However, obedience is the fruit of salvation rather than its purchase price.

The promise of the new earth is therefore an invitation to trust the Savior.

God calls humanity to receive forgiveness, experience spiritual renewal, and prepare for everlasting fellowship with Him.

The final appeal of Revelation invites those who are thirsty to receive the water of life freely.

Bible References:

- John 3:16–17
- John 5:24
- John 14:1–6
- Romans 6:23
- Ephesians 2:8–10
- Titus 3:3–7
- 1 John 5:11–13
- Revelation 21:6–7
- Revelation 22:14, 17

Doctrinal Note:

Eternal life is received through the saving grace of Jesus Christ. Faith, repentance, obedience, and Christian growth belong to the believer's response to that grace.

Chapter Summary

The Holy Scriptures reveal that God's plan of redemption will culminate in the establishment of a new heaven and a new earth.

The restored creation will be free from sin, death, suffering, and corruption.

The New Jerusalem will be associated with God's everlasting presence among His people.

The redeemed will possess glorified bodies and enjoy eternal fellowship with Jesus Christ.

The river of life and the tree of life symbolize the fullness of divine blessing and restored access to everlasting life.

In Seventh-day Adventist theology, the new earth is the eternal home of the redeemed after the millennium and final destruction of evil.

Our study enables us to retain the following teachings:

1. God originally created the earth as a good place for human life and fellowship with Him.

2. The new heaven and new earth represent the complete restoration of creation through divine power.

3. Adventist theology places the establishment of the new earth after the millennium and final judgment.

4. The New Jerusalem is the holy city associated with God's everlasting presence among the redeemed.

5. The greatest blessing of the new creation is direct fellowship with God and Jesus Christ.

6. Death, sorrow, crying, pain, and suffering will no longer exist.

7. The redeemed will possess glorified and incorruptible bodies.

8. Scripture provides grounds for hope concerning personal recognition and fellowship, without explaining every detail.

9. The former world of suffering will no longer dominate the experience of God's people.

10. The river of life represents the abundance and permanence of life received from God.

11. The tree of life symbolizes restored access to the blessings of everlasting life.

12. Eternal life will involve meaningful service, worship, and fellowship rather than inactivity.

13. Seventh-day Adventists understand the Sabbath as continuing to have significance in the restored creation.

14. Sin, Satan, suffering, and death will never again threaten God's everlasting kingdom.

15. Eternal life is a gift of grace received through faith in Jesus Christ.

Doctrinal Conclusion

The new heaven and the new earth represent the glorious fulfillment of God's redemptive purpose.

The Bible begins with the creation of a good world and concludes with the promise of a restored creation.

Between these two events lies the history of humanity's fall, the suffering produced by sin, and the saving work of Jesus Christ.

Through His sacrifice, resurrection, heavenly ministry, and final victory, God brings the plan of redemption to completion.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, the new earth reveals several essential truths.

The Fulfillment of God's Original Purpose

The Creator restores His creation and fulfills His intention that humanity should live in righteousness and peace.

The Complete Victory of Jesus Christ

The Savior who conquered sin and death establishes His everlasting kingdom.

The Restoration of Human Life

The redeemed receive glorified bodies and everlasting life.

The New Jerusalem

The holy city represents the beauty, security, and holiness of God's restored dwelling among His people.

The Presence of God

The greatest blessing of eternity is direct fellowship with the Father and Jesus Christ.

The End of Suffering

Death, sorrow, crying, pain, and the curse will no longer exist.

The River and Tree of Life

The restored creation includes the biblical imagery of divine life, abundance, and healing.

Meaningful Eternal Existence

The redeemed will enjoy purposeful service, worship, fellowship, and the blessings of God's kingdom.

The Continuity of Worship

Seventh-day Adventists understand Sabbath worship as retaining significance in the new earth.

The Permanent Destruction of Evil

Sin and death will never again threaten God's creation.

Salvation Through Jesus Christ

The promise of eternal life is received through God's grace rather than human merit.

The biblical description of the new earth should inspire hope rather than speculation.

Although Scripture reveals extraordinary promises, it does not provide an exhaustive description of eternity.

Believers should therefore avoid inventing details concerning the physical, social, or scientific conditions of the restored creation.

The essential truth is clear.

God will dwell with His people.

Jesus Christ will reign forever.

Death will be destroyed.

The curse will be removed.

The redeemed will enjoy everlasting life in the presence of their Creator.

The Essential Message:

The Holy Scriptures promise a new heaven and a new earth in which righteousness, peace, and everlasting life will prevail. Through the victory of Jesus Christ, God will restore His creation and dwell forever with His redeemed people. Death, suffering, sorrow, and sin will be eliminated. The New Jerusalem, the river of life, and the tree of life reveal the beauty and abundance of God's eternal kingdom. Seventh-day Adventist theology understands the new earth as the everlasting home of the redeemed after the millennium and final judgment. The greatest promise of eternity is not merely a perfect environment but unbroken fellowship with God and Jesus Christ, through whom eternal life is freely given.

Personal Reflection Questions

1. What does the original creation account reveal about God's purpose for humanity?

2. How do Isaiah, Peter, and Revelation describe the promise of a new heaven and a new earth?

3. Why is the presence of God the greatest blessing of eternal life?

4. What does Revelation 21:4 teach about the final removal of suffering and death?

5. How does the biblical promise of glorified bodies influence my understanding of eternal life?

6. What can the New Jerusalem teach me about God's holiness, beauty, and faithfulness?

7. What is the significance of the river of life and the tree of life in Revelation 22?

8. Why should I distinguish the Bible's explicit promises from speculation concerning life in eternity?

9. How does the assurance that evil will never again threaten God's kingdom strengthen my faith?

10. How can I respond today to God's invitation to receive eternal life through Jesus Christ?

Suggested Prayer

Lord my God,

I come before You with gratitude, reverence, and hope.

You are the Creator of heaven and earth.

You are the source of life, righteousness, beauty, and love.

Thank You for creating humanity and revealing Your wonderful purposes through the Holy Scriptures.

Although sin has brought suffering, sorrow, and death into the world, I thank You that Your plan of redemption will not fail.

Thank You for sending Jesus Christ to accomplish the work of salvation.

Thank You for His sacrifice upon the cross, His glorious resurrection, and His promise to return.

I believe that through Him, You will restore Your creation and establish Your everlasting kingdom.

Help me understand Your promises faithfully.

Give me wisdom to study the new heaven, the new earth, and the New Jerusalem without going beyond what Scripture reveals.

Protect me from speculation and human imagination that might obscure the beauty of Your Word.

Teach me to trust Your goodness even when I cannot understand every detail of eternity.

Thank You for the promise that death will be no more.

Thank You for the assurance that sorrow, crying, and pain will disappear.

Thank You for the hope that Your redeemed people will live forever in Your presence.

When I face suffering, strengthen my faith.

When I experience grief, comfort my heart.

When I become discouraged by the injustice and difficulties of this world, remind me that Your kingdom will endure forever.

Help me live today as a citizen of Your heavenly kingdom.

Teach me to love others with patience and compassion.

Help me practice justice, kindness, humility, and faithfulness.

Give me courage to share the everlasting Gospel.

May my life reflect the character of Jesus Christ.

Thank You for the promise of the river of life and the tree of life.

Thank You for the assurance that Your servants will serve You and see Your face.

Above all, thank You for the promise of everlasting fellowship with You.

I do not seek eternal life merely for freedom from suffering.

I desire to know You, love You, worship You, and dwell in Your presence forever.

Prepare me for the glorious return of Jesus Christ.

Strengthen my faith in His saving grace.

Help me remain faithful until the day when all Your promises are fulfilled.

I look forward to the new heaven and the new earth, where righteousness dwells and Your love reigns forever.

May all honor, glory, and praise belong to You throughout eternity.

In the name of Jesus Christ, my Savior and Lord.

Amen.

CHAPTER 37 — THE THREE ANGELS' MESSAGES: GOD'S FINAL CALL TO HUMANITY

A Thematic Bible Study — King James Version (KJV)

Opening Scripture

> “And I saw another angel fly in the midst of heaven, having the everlasting gospel to preach unto them that dwell on the earth, and to every nation, and kindred, and tongue, and people,”

Revelation 14:6 — KJV

Introduction

The Book of Revelation presents a great conflict between the kingdom of God and the powers of evil.

Throughout its prophetic visions, the reader encounters symbols of heavenly worship, spiritual warfare, persecution, judgment, redemption, and the ultimate victory of Jesus Christ.

At the center of this prophetic message stands a solemn and universal appeal recorded in Revelation 14:6–12.

This passage is commonly known as the Three Angels' Messages.

The first angel proclaims the everlasting Gospel and announces the hour of God's judgment. He calls humanity to fear God, give Him glory, and worship the Creator.

The second angel announces the fall of Babylon.

The third angel warns against worshiping the beast and its image and against receiving its mark.

The passage concludes by identifying the perseverance of the saints, who keep the commandments of God and the faith of Jesus.

Immediately afterward, Revelation presents the harvest of the earth.

These messages therefore occupy a significant place within the book's portrayal of the final conflict between true worship and rebellion against God.

They are not isolated statements.

Their meaning is connected with the wider testimony of Scripture, particularly the prophecies of Daniel, the teachings of Jesus Christ, the apostolic writings, and the surrounding chapters of Revelation.

For Seventh-day Adventists, the Three Angels' Messages constitute a central expression of the Church's identity and mission.

Adventists understand these messages as a final worldwide proclamation calling humanity to accept the everlasting Gospel, recognize God's judgment, worship the Creator, reject religious deception, and remain faithful to Jesus Christ.

This interpretation is closely connected with the Adventist historicist approach to biblical prophecy.

It also involves distinctive understandings of the heavenly sanctuary, the judgment beginning in 1844, the Sabbath, Babylon, the beast, and the mark of the beast.

However, these subjects require careful study.

Some elements are explicitly stated in Revelation 14.

Other conclusions are developed by comparing multiple biblical passages and interpreting prophetic symbols within a particular historical framework.

A responsible Bible study must distinguish these categories.

It must also recognize that other Christian traditions interpret Revelation's symbols differently.

Above all, the Three Angels' Messages must never be separated from their opening proclamation: the everlasting Gospel.

The message of Revelation is not fundamentally an invitation to fear human institutions or speculate about political events.

It is a call to recognize the authority of God, receive salvation through Jesus Christ, and remain faithful to Him.

This chapter examines fifteen questions concerning the Three Angels' Messages, their biblical foundations, their prophetic significance, and their relevance to Christian life.

Our objective is to understand their meaning through Scripture and discover how they direct humanity toward Jesus Christ and His everlasting kingdom.

Question 1 — What Are the Three Angels' Messages, and Where Are They Found in the Bible?

Answer:

The Three Angels' Messages are recorded in Revelation 14:6–12.

The passage describes three angels delivering successive proclamations.

The first angel announces the everlasting Gospel, the hour of God's judgment, and the call to worship the Creator.

The second angel announces the fall of Babylon.

The third angel warns against worshiping the beast, its image, and receiving its mark.

The passage concludes with a description of the saints who persevere in faithfulness to God.

These messages appear in a chapter that also portrays the Lamb with His people and later describes the harvest of the earth.

Their placement gives them an important relationship to the themes of salvation, worship, judgment, and the final outcome of the conflict between good and evil.

In Seventh-day Adventist theology, the three angels symbolize a worldwide proclamation entrusted to God's people.

The angels themselves are part of John's prophetic vision.

The interpretation that they represent the Church's final missionary proclamation is a theological application of the passage.

The messages call humanity to recognize the authority of God and respond faithfully to the everlasting Gospel.

Bible References:

- Daniel 7:9–14
- Matthew 24:14
- Revelation 12:17
- Revelation 13:1–18
- Revelation 14:1–16
- Revelation 18:1–4

Doctrinal Note:

Revelation explicitly portrays three angels proclaiming messages. Seventh-day Adventists understand their proclamations as representing a final worldwide mission carried forward by God's people.

Question 2 — Why Does the First Angel Begin With the Everlasting Gospel?

Answer:

The first angel's message begins with the everlasting Gospel.

This order is essential.

The Gospel is the good news that God has acted through Jesus Christ to save humanity from sin and death.

The New Testament teaches that Jesus died for our sins, was buried, and rose again.

Salvation is offered through God's grace and received by faith.

The Gospel reveals both the love and righteousness of God.

It also calls human beings to repentance and a transformed life.

The expression everlasting Gospel emphasizes the enduring character of God's saving purpose.

The message proclaimed in Revelation 14 is therefore not a different Gospel from the one preached by the apostles.

It is the same saving message presented within the context of divine judgment and the final conflict over worship.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, every aspect of the Three Angels' Messages must remain centered upon Jesus Christ.

Warnings concerning Babylon, the beast, and its mark should never obscure the invitation to receive salvation through the Savior.

Bible References:

- Genesis 3:14–15
- Isaiah 53:4–12
- John 3:16–17
- Romans 1:16–17
- Romans 3:21–26
- 1 Corinthians 15:1–4
- Ephesians 2:8–10
- Revelation 14:6

Doctrinal Note:

The everlasting Gospel is the foundation of the Three Angels' Messages. Biblical prophecy must be interpreted in harmony with salvation through Jesus Christ.

Question 3 — Why Must the Everlasting Gospel Be Proclaimed to Every Nation, Kindred, Tongue, and People?

Answer:

Revelation 14 describes the everlasting Gospel as a message intended for the inhabitants of the earth.

Its proclamation includes every nation, kindred, tongue, and people.

This universal language emphasizes that God's invitation to salvation is not limited to one nationality, ethnicity, language, or social group.

The New Testament teaches that God shows no partiality.

Jesus commanded His disciples to make disciples of all nations.

He also declared that the Gospel of the kingdom would be preached throughout the world.

The mission of the Church is therefore universal.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, the worldwide proclamation of the Three Angels' Messages fulfills an important aspect of Christ's missionary commission.

The message must be communicated through preaching, teaching, personal testimony, literature, media, and compassionate service.

However, the universal scope of the Gospel does not authorize religious coercion.

Christian witness should respect human dignity and freedom of conscience.

The purpose of proclamation is to invite people to respond freely to the saving grace of Jesus Christ.

Bible References:

- Isaiah 49:6
- Matthew 24:14
- Matthew 28:18–20

- Acts 1:8
- Acts 10:34–35
- Galatians 3:26–29
- Revelation 7:9–10
- Revelation 14:6

Missionary Note:

The universal Gospel calls Christians to communicate with clarity, compassion, cultural sensitivity, and respect for the freedom of others.

Question 4 — What Does It Mean to Fear God and Give Glory to Him?

Answer:

The first angel calls humanity to fear God and give Him glory.

In biblical language, the fear of God frequently refers to reverence, awe, respect, and recognition of divine authority.

It is associated with wisdom, obedience, and the rejection of evil.

The call to give God glory directs attention toward His character and rightful sovereignty.

The New Testament also teaches that believers should glorify God through their conduct.

Paul instructed Christians to glorify God in their bodies and to do all things to His glory.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, this appeal includes spiritual faithfulness, moral integrity, responsible stewardship, and care for physical health.

However, Revelation 14 does not provide a detailed health program or lifestyle code.

Such applications are developed by comparing its language with broader biblical teachings.

The central meaning is that God deserves the highest allegiance and worship.

Human beings are called to honor Him in faith, character, and daily life.

Bible References:

- Deuteronomy 10:12–13
- Psalm 111:10
- Proverbs 1:7
- Ecclesiastes 12:13–14
- 1 Corinthians 6:19–20
- 1 Corinthians 10:31
- 1 Peter 2:12
- Revelation 14:7

Doctrinal Note:

The fear of God is not merely terror of punishment. In its positive biblical sense, it involves reverence, trust, obedience, and recognition of God's holiness.

Question 5 — What Is the Meaning of the Announcement That the Hour of God's Judgment Has Come?

Answer:

The first angel announces that the hour of God's judgment has come.

This declaration connects the Gospel proclamation with divine accountability.

The Bible teaches that God will judge the world in righteousness through Jesus Christ.

Daniel 7 presents a heavenly judgment scene involving thrones, books, and the Son of man.

Revelation repeatedly emphasizes that God's judgments are true and righteous.

In Seventh-day Adventist theology, Revelation 14:7 is connected with the pre-Advent judgment.

Adventists understand Daniel 8:14, together with their interpretation of the prophetic time periods and heavenly sanctuary, as pointing to a phase of Christ's heavenly ministry beginning in 1844.

According to this interpretation, the judgment announcement in Revelation 14 has particular significance for the period preceding the Second Coming.

However, Revelation 14:7 does not explicitly mention the year 1844.

The date is derived from the Adventist interpretation of Daniel 8 and 9 and the year-day principle applied to prophetic periods.

Other Christian traditions do not generally accept this chronology.

The central biblical teaching is that God judges righteously and that humanity is called to respond to His Gospel.

Bible References:

- Ecclesiastes 12:13–14
- Daniel 7:9–14
- Daniel 8:13–14
- Daniel 9:24–27
- Acts 17:30–31
- Hebrews 9:23–28
- Revelation 14:6–7
- Revelation 20:11–15

Historical and Doctrinal Note:

The identification of 1844 as the beginning of the pre-Advent judgment is distinctive to Seventh-day Adventist theology. It is not an explicitly stated date in Revelation 14 and requires separate

examination of the Adventist interpretation of Daniel.

Question 6 — Why Does the First Angel Call Humanity to Worship the Creator?

Answer:

The first angel calls humanity to worship the One who made heaven, earth, the sea, and the fountains of waters.

This language recalls the biblical teaching of creation.

Genesis presents God as the Creator of heaven and earth.

The fourth commandment also identifies God as the Creator of heaven, earth, and sea.

The similarity between Revelation 14:7 and Exodus 20:11 is especially significant in Seventh-day Adventist theology.

Adventists understand the call to worship the Creator as closely connected with the seventh-day Sabbath.

The Sabbath commemorates God's creative work and expresses recognition of His authority.

However, Revelation 14:7 does not explicitly mention the word Sabbath.

The connection is established through comparison with Genesis 2, Exodus 20, and other biblical passages.

Other Christian traditions understand the call primarily as an appeal to worship the true God rather than idols or created powers.

The central teaching is that worship belongs to the Creator rather than to human institutions or false objects of devotion.

Bible References:

- Genesis 1:1
- Genesis 2:1–3
- Exodus 20:8–11

- Psalm 95:1–7
- Isaiah 40:25–28
- Acts 14:14–17
- Revelation 4:11
- Revelation 14:7

Doctrinal Note:

The relationship between the Creator language of Revelation 14:7 and the seventh-day Sabbath is a central Adventist interpretation. The passage itself explicitly calls for worship of the Creator.

Question 7 — What Does the Second Angel Mean When He Announces That Babylon Is Fallen?

Answer:

The second angel announces the fall of Babylon.

The name Babylon has a significant history in Scripture.

In the Old Testament, Babylon was a powerful empire associated with conquest, idolatry, and the captivity of God's people.

The Book of Daniel describes Babylon's political and religious authority.

In Revelation, Babylon becomes a symbolic name associated with spiritual corruption, false worship, and opposition to God.

Revelation 17 and 18 develop this imagery through the description of a woman and a great city.

In Seventh-day Adventist interpretation, Babylon represents systems of religious confusion and apostasy that depart from biblical truth.

Adventists have historically applied this symbol to aspects of the papal religious system and to Protestant bodies understood as participating in similar forms of religious error.

However, these identifications are theological interpretations of prophetic symbols.

They should not be presented as direct statements naming modern denominations in Revelation.

Nor should criticism of religious institutions be confused with condemnation of their individual members.

The Bible's warning calls people to examine their beliefs and worship in the light of God's Word.

Bible References:

- Genesis 11:1–9
- Daniel 1:1–7
- Daniel 3:1–18
- Daniel 4:28–37
- Jeremiah 50:1–8
- Revelation 14:8
- Revelation 17:1–18
- Revelation 18:1–5

Historical and Prophetic Note:

The identification of apocalyptic Babylon with particular historical Christian institutions belongs to the Adventist historicist tradition. Revelation itself employs symbolic imagery that has been interpreted differently across Christian history.

Question 8 — What Does the Wine of Babylon's Fornication Represent?

Answer:

Revelation 14 describes Babylon as making the nations drink of the wine of her fornication.

The imagery continues in Revelation 17 and 18.

In biblical prophecy, spiritual unfaithfulness is sometimes described through the language of adultery or fornication.

The prophets used similar imagery to condemn idolatry and covenant unfaithfulness.

In Revelation, the wine is associated with Babylon's corrupting influence upon the nations.

Seventh-day Adventists understand this symbolism as referring to false religious teachings and practices that lead humanity away from biblical truth.

Within Adventist interpretation, these teachings may include errors concerning worship, divine authority, the Sabbath, and the condition of the dead.

However, Revelation 14:8 does not provide an explicit list of individual doctrines represented by the wine.

Such identifications arise through broader theological comparison.

The warning should encourage careful biblical study rather than contempt toward people who hold different beliefs.

The essential issue is faithfulness to God and rejection of spiritual deception.

Bible References:

- Jeremiah 3:6–10
- Jeremiah 51:6–9
- Ezekiel 16:15–32
- Hosea 2:1–13
- Revelation 14:8
- Revelation 17:1–6
- Revelation 18:1–5

Doctrinal Note:

The identification of Babylon's wine with specific religious doctrines is an Adventist theological application. The explicit imagery concerns spiritual corruption and the misleading influence of Babylon upon the nations.

Question 9 — Who Is the Beast Mentioned in the Third Angel's Message?

Answer:

The third angel warns against worshiping the beast and its image.

To understand this warning, Revelation 14 must be studied together with Revelation 13.

Revelation 13 describes a beast rising from the sea and another beast rising from the earth.

These symbols are associated with political and religious authority, persecution, deception, and demands for worship.

The imagery also has important connections with Daniel 7, where beasts symbolize kingdoms.

In Seventh-day Adventist historicist interpretation, the sea beast of Revelation 13 represents the papal system as a historical religious-political power.

The earth beast is commonly identified with the United States in its prophetic development.

These identifications are based upon the Adventist reading of prophetic characteristics, historical developments, and symbolic time periods.

Other Christian traditions interpret these beasts differently.

Some associate them primarily with the Roman Empire and its imperial cult.

Others understand them as future political powers or recurring systems of oppressive authority.

The Bible's central warning concerns the danger of giving divine allegiance to powers that oppose God.

This distinction is essential.

Criticism of a prophetic system must not become hostility toward Catholics, Protestants, Americans, or any other group of people.

Bible References:

- Daniel 7:1–8, 17–25
- Daniel 8:9–12
- 2 Thessalonians 2:1–12
- Revelation 12:13–17
- Revelation 13:1–18
- Revelation 14:9–12
- Revelation 17:7–14

Historical and Prophetic Note:

The Adventist identifications of the two beasts are not explicitly named in Revelation. They are conclusions of a historicist interpretation and must be evaluated through biblical context and historical evidence.

Question 10 — What Is the Image of the Beast?

Answer:

Revelation 13 describes the second beast causing the inhabitants of the earth to make an image to the first beast.

The passage also describes the image receiving authority and becoming associated with enforced worship.

The imagery suggests a reproduction or representation of the authority exercised by the first beast.

In Seventh-day Adventist theology, the image of the beast is understood as a future alliance or development in which religious authority influences civil power to enforce religious observance.

Adventists have historically associated this prospect with forms of church-state cooperation that restrict religious liberty.

The interpretation draws upon the relationship between the two beasts in Revelation 13.

However, the text does not explicitly identify a particular modern law, organization, or government action as the completed image of the beast.

Claims concerning specific current events should therefore be made cautiously and supported by evidence.

The biblical principle is that genuine worship cannot be produced through coercion.

Faithfulness to God involves conscience, truth, and willing allegiance.

Bible References:

- Daniel 3:1–18
- Matthew 22:15–22
- Acts 4:18–20
- Acts 5:27–29
- Revelation 13:11–17
- Revelation 14:9–12

Doctrinal Note:

The Adventist interpretation connects the image of the beast with coercive religious authority. Revelation's explicit warning concerns enforced worship and allegiance contrary to God.

Question 11 — What Is the Mark of the Beast?

Answer:

Revelation 13 describes a mark associated with the beast's authority.

The mark is connected with the right hand or forehead and with restrictions upon buying and selling.

Revelation 14 warns against receiving the mark.

The passage presents the mark within a larger conflict concerning worship and allegiance.

In Seventh-day Adventist theology, the mark of the beast is understood as a future sign of allegiance to religious authority in opposition to God's commandments.

Adventists have historically connected this issue with the enforcement of Sunday observance in place of the seventh-day Sabbath.

According to this interpretation, the decisive issue concerns conscious allegiance under conditions in which religious observance is coercively imposed.

However, Revelation does not explicitly identify the mark as Sunday worship.

That identification depends upon the Adventist interpretation of Daniel 7, Revelation 13, the Sabbath commandment, and the historical development of Christian worship.

It is also important to state that Seventh-day Adventist teaching does not regard every person who presently worships on Sunday as having received the mark of the beast.

The prophetic warning concerns a future conflict of conscience and allegiance as understood within Adventist eschatology.

Other Christian traditions interpret the mark as a symbol of loyalty to evil, a reference to ancient imperial worship, or a future form of political or religious identification.

The central biblical question is whether human allegiance belongs to God or to powers opposing Him.

Bible References:

- Exodus 20:8–11
- Deuteronomy 6:4–9
- Daniel 7:25
- Revelation 7:1–4
- Revelation 13:11–18
- Revelation 14:9–12
- Revelation 16:1–2

Doctrinal Note:

The identification of the mark of the beast with enforced Sunday observance is a distinctive Adventist interpretation, not an explicit definition in Revelation. It must never be used to declare that all Sunday-observing Christians have already received the mark.

Question 12 — What Is the Difference Between the Seal of God and the Mark of the Beast?

Answer:

Revelation describes servants of God receiving a seal upon their foreheads.

It also describes the followers of the beast receiving its mark.

These images form part of Revelation's contrast between allegiance to God and allegiance to opposing powers.

The seal of God signifies belonging to Him and receiving His protection within the prophetic vision.

The mark of the beast signifies identification with the authority and worship demanded by the beast.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, the seal of God is closely connected with the Sabbath because the fourth commandment identifies the Creator and His authority.

Adventists also emphasize the sealing work of the Holy Spirit and the transformation of the believer's character.

However, Revelation 7 does not explicitly define the seal as the Sabbath.

The New Testament directly associates sealing with the Holy Spirit.

Therefore, the Adventist connection between the final seal and Sabbath faithfulness is a theological synthesis rather than a definition contained in a single verse.

The central biblical contrast concerns the identity, loyalty, and worship of God's people.

Bible References:

- Exodus 20:8–11
- Ezekiel 9:1–6
- Ezekiel 20:12, 20
- Ephesians 1:13–14
- Ephesians 4:30
- Revelation 7:1–4
- Revelation 13:16–17
- Revelation 14:1, 9–12

Doctrinal Note:

The New Testament explicitly associates believers' sealing with the Holy Spirit. The identification of the Sabbath as a distinguishing sign in the final sealing is an Adventist prophetic interpretation.

Question 13 — What Does Revelation Mean by the Patience of the Saints?

Answer:

Revelation 14:12 identifies the patience of the saints.

The passage describes those who keep the commandments of God and the faith of Jesus.

The word patience communicates endurance, perseverance, and steadfastness under difficulty.

Throughout the New Testament, believers are encouraged to remain faithful despite persecution, suffering, and opposition.

The saints are not described as people who save themselves through their own strength.

Their perseverance is connected with faith in Jesus Christ.

The phrase faith of Jesus has been understood in different ways, including faith directed toward Jesus and faithfulness associated with Him.

In Seventh-day Adventist theology, Revelation 14:12 expresses the characteristics of God's end-time people.

They remain loyal to God's commandments and continue to trust in Jesus Christ.

Adventists understand this description as including faithfulness to the seventh-day Sabbath.

However, the passage does not identify the Sabbath separately by name.

Its broader emphasis is perseverance in obedience and faith.

Bible References:

- Matthew 24:12–13
- John 14:15

- Romans 5:1–5
- Hebrews 10:35–39
- James 1:2–4
- Revelation 12:17
- Revelation 13:10
- Revelation 14:12

Linguistic and Doctrinal Note:

The Greek expression translated as patience conveys steadfast endurance. The phrase faith of Jesus has grammatical and theological interpretations that should be considered within the context of Revelation.

Question 14 — How Are the Three Angels' Messages Connected With the Final Harvest of the Earth?

Answer:

After the Three Angels' Messages, Revelation 14 presents two harvest scenes.

The first involves one like the Son of man seated upon a cloud.

The second portrays the gathering of the vine of the earth and the imagery of divine wrath.

These visions communicate the certainty of God's final intervention and judgment.

In Seventh-day Adventist interpretation, the sequence connects the final Gospel proclamation with the Second Coming of Jesus Christ and the separation of the righteous from the wicked.

The messages are therefore understood as a final call to repentance and faithfulness before the close of human probation and the fulfillment of divine judgment.

However, the exact relationship between the two harvest scenes and the chronological details of final events are interpreted differently

among Christian traditions.

The passage's imagery should not be used to predict a specific date.

Its central purpose is to demonstrate that the response to God's Gospel has eternal significance.

The call to worship the Creator, reject deception, and remain faithful to Jesus Christ is therefore urgent.

Bible References:

- Joel 3:12–16
- Matthew 13:24–30, 36–43
- Matthew 24:14, 29–31
- Revelation 14:6–20
- Revelation 19:11–21
- Revelation 22:12–14

Prophetic Note:

The Adventist interpretation connects the Three Angels' Messages with the final worldwide proclamation preceding the Second Coming. The harvest imagery expresses divine judgment and the completion of God's purposes.

Question 15 — How Should Christians Respond to the Three Angels' Messages Today?

Answer:

The Three Angels' Messages call humanity to respond to God with faith, reverence, worship, and perseverance.

Their first and most important invitation is to receive the everlasting Gospel.

A faithful response begins with repentance and trust in Jesus Christ.

The messages also encourage careful examination of religious teachings in the light of Scripture.

They call believers to recognize God's authority, reject deception, and remain faithful despite opposition.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, responding to these messages includes accepting the biblical Sabbath, recognizing the significance of divine judgment, and participating in the proclamation of the everlasting Gospel.

However, these commitments must be expressed through the character of Jesus Christ.

The message should not produce spiritual pride, hostility, or contempt toward other Christians.

The New Testament teaches that truth must be spoken in love.

Christian witness should respect freedom of conscience and demonstrate compassion toward all people.

The final call of Revelation is not merely to identify prophetic symbols.

It is to worship God, follow the Lamb, and receive the water of life freely.

The believer's ultimate security is found in Jesus Christ.

Bible References:

- Micah 6:8
- Matthew 22:36–40
- John 3:16–17
- John 14:15
- Ephesians 2:8–10
- Ephesians 4:14–16
- 1 Peter 3:15–16
- Revelation 14:6–12
- Revelation 22:17

Practical Note:

The Three Angels' Messages should be proclaimed with biblical accuracy, humility, love, and respect for religious liberty. Their purpose is to direct people toward Jesus Christ, not to encourage hostility toward individuals or religious communities.

Chapter Summary

The Three Angels' Messages are recorded in Revelation 14:6–12.

They proclaim the everlasting Gospel, announce the hour of God's judgment, call humanity to worship the Creator, warn against Babylon and the beast, and describe the perseverance of God's faithful people.

In Seventh-day Adventist theology, these messages constitute a central expression of the Church's worldwide mission.

They are interpreted within a historicist framework that connects biblical prophecy with the heavenly sanctuary, the Sabbath, the history of Christianity, and the final conflict over worship.

Our study enables us to retain the following teachings:

1. The Three Angels' Messages are found in Revelation 14:6–12.

2. The everlasting Gospel is the foundation of the messages and centers upon salvation through Jesus Christ.

3. The messages are intended for every nation, kindred, tongue, and people.

4. The call to fear God and give Him glory emphasizes reverence, obedience, and recognition of divine authority.

5. The announcement of the hour of judgment is connected in Adventist theology with the pre-Advent judgment.

6. The call to worship the Creator has a significant relationship to the Sabbath in Adventist interpretation.

7. Babylon symbolizes spiritual corruption and opposition to God's truth.

8. Babylon's wine represents corrupting religious influence, interpreted by Adventists as including false doctrines.

9. The beast symbolizes authority opposed to God, with specific historical identifications in Adventist historicist interpretation.

10. The image of the beast is understood by Adventists as a future form of coercive religious authority.

11. The mark of the beast is connected in Adventist theology with enforced Sunday observance in a future conflict of conscience.

12. The seal of God signifies belonging to Him, while Adventists connect the final sealing with Sabbath faithfulness.

13. The patience of the saints describes perseverance in God's commandments and faith in Jesus Christ.

14. The final harvest of Revelation 14 connects the messages with divine judgment and the completion of God's purposes.

15. Christians are called to respond through faith, obedience, humility, love, and faithful proclamation of the everlasting Gospel.

Doctrinal Conclusion

The Three Angels' Messages occupy a central place in the prophetic teachings of Revelation.

They reveal the seriousness of the final conflict between worship of the Creator and allegiance to powers opposed to Him.

They also demonstrate the continuing mercy of God.

Before the final judgment, the Gospel is proclaimed to humanity.

The divine warning is accompanied by an invitation to salvation.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, the messages contain several essential dimensions.

The Everlasting Gospel

Salvation is offered through the life, death, resurrection, and saving ministry of Jesus Christ.

The Universal Mission

God's message is intended for every nation, language, and people.

The Fear of God

Humanity is called to reverence, obedience, and recognition of God's authority.

The Hour of Judgment

Adventist theology connects this announcement with the pre-Advent judgment and the heavenly ministry of Jesus Christ.

Worship of the Creator

The call to worship God is associated with creation and, in Adventist interpretation, the seventh-day Sabbath.

The Fall of Babylon

Babylon symbolizes spiritual corruption and departure from divine truth.

The Warning Against False Worship

The third angel warns against allegiance to the beast and its image.

The Mark of the Beast

Adventists understand the mark as a future sign of allegiance to coercive religious authority, particularly in relation to enforced Sunday observance.

The Seal of God

God's people belong to Him and are called to remain faithful through the Holy Spirit.

The Patience of the Saints

The faithful persevere in obedience to God's commandments and faith in Jesus Christ.

The Final Harvest

The messages are associated with the completion of God's saving purposes and the final judgment.

The Mission of God's People

Believers are called to proclaim the Gospel with biblical fidelity, compassion, and respect for freedom of conscience.

These teachings should never be separated from the person and saving work of Jesus Christ.

Prophecy without the Gospel can become speculation.

Warnings without compassion can become intimidation.

Doctrinal conviction without humility can become spiritual pride.

The Three Angels' Messages must therefore be understood as a Christ-centered proclamation.

Their purpose is to invite humanity to worship the Creator, reject deception, receive salvation, and remain faithful to Jesus Christ.

The Essential Message:

The Three Angels' Messages of Revelation 14:6–12 proclaim God's final appeal to humanity through the everlasting Gospel. They announce divine judgment, call all people to worship the Creator, warn against spiritual corruption and false worship, and identify the perseverance of those who remain faithful to God and Jesus Christ. Seventh-day Adventist theology understands these messages as a worldwide prophetic mission involving the heavenly judgment, the Sabbath, religious liberty, and the final conflict over allegiance. Although several prophetic identifications are distinctive Adventist interpretations, the central biblical invitation is clear: receive the Gospel of Jesus Christ, worship God faithfully, reject deception, and

remain steadfast in faith and love.

Personal Reflection Questions

1. Why is the everlasting Gospel the foundation of the Three Angels' Messages?

2. What does Revelation 14 teach about the universal scope of God's final invitation?

3. How should I understand the biblical call to fear God and give Him glory?

4. What is the relationship between divine judgment and the saving grace of Jesus Christ?

5. Why do Seventh-day Adventists connect the call to worship the Creator with the seventh-day Sabbath?

6. What does the symbol of Babylon teach about the danger of spiritual corruption and religious deception?

7. Why is it important to distinguish the biblical descriptions of the beast from particular historical interpretations?

8. How can I understand the Adventist teaching concerning the mark of the beast without judging or condemning individuals who worship differently?

9. What does the patience of the saints teach me about obedience, perseverance, and faith in Jesus Christ?

10. How can I participate in proclaiming the everlasting Gospel with truth, humility, compassion, and respect for freedom of conscience?

Suggested Prayer

Lord my God,

I come before You with reverence, gratitude, and humility.

You are the Creator of heaven and earth.

You are holy, righteous, merciful, and just.

Thank You for revealing Your love and saving purposes through the Holy Scriptures.

Thank You for the everlasting Gospel.

Thank You for sending Jesus Christ into the world to save humanity from sin and death.

I acknowledge that salvation is found through His sacrifice, resurrection, and saving grace.

Help me place my confidence entirely in Him.

As I study the Three Angels' Messages, give me wisdom and understanding.

Teach me to examine the prophecies of Daniel and Revelation carefully.

Help me distinguish the explicit teachings of Scripture from interpretations and human assumptions.

Protect me from pride, fear, sensationalism, and the desire to condemn others.

May the prophetic messages lead me closer to Jesus Christ.

Teach me to fear You with reverence and love.

Help me glorify You through my thoughts, words, and actions.

Strengthen my desire to worship You as the Creator of heaven and earth.

Give me courage to remain faithful to Your commandments.

Fill my heart with the faith and love of Jesus Christ.

When I encounter religious confusion, guide me through Your Word and the Holy Spirit.

Help me recognize deception without developing hatred toward those who believe differently.

Teach me to respect the conscience and dignity of every human being.

May I never use biblical prophecy to humiliate, threaten, or mistreat others.

Instead, help me proclaim Your truth with compassion and humility.

Give me a heart for those who have not yet understood the Gospel.

Help me participate faithfully in the mission of sharing Your Word.

May my testimony be sincere, my conduct honorable, and my service motivated by love.

Strengthen me when I face difficulties or opposition.

Teach me the patience of the saints.

Help me persevere in faith and obedience through the power of Your Spirit.

Thank You for the promise that Jesus Christ will return.

Thank You for the assurance that Your kingdom will triumph over evil.

Prepare my heart for the fulfillment of Your promises.

Until that glorious day, help me remain faithful to the everlasting Gospel and the saving grace of Jesus Christ.

May all honor, glory, and praise belong to You forever.

In the name of Jesus Christ, my Savior and Lord.

Amen.

CHAPTER 38 — THE REMNANT CHURCH: WHO ARE GOD'S FAITHFUL PEOPLE IN THE LAST DAYS?

A Thematic Bible Study — King James Version (KJV)

Opening Scripture

> “And the dragon was wroth with the woman, and went to make war with the remnant of her seed, which keep the commandments of God, and have the testimony of Jesus Christ.”

Revelation 12:17 — KJV

Introduction

Throughout the Holy Scriptures, God reveals His desire to save humanity and establish a people who will reflect His character.

From the calling of Abraham to the establishment of Israel, from the ministry of Jesus Christ to the mission of the early Church, the Bible describes a divine purpose extending across generations.

God calls people to faith, repentance, obedience, and fellowship with Him.

However, biblical history also reveals repeated experiences of spiritual decline.

At different moments, individuals and communities have turned away from God's commandments, embraced idolatry, or rejected His messengers.

Yet even during periods of widespread unfaithfulness, the Scriptures describe people who remain loyal to God.

These faithful individuals are sometimes called the remnant.

The concept appears in the writings of the prophets and continues into the New Testament.

Isaiah speaks of a remnant that returns to God.

Paul refers to a remnant according to the election of grace.

The Book of Revelation describes the remnant of the woman's seed, against whom the dragon makes war.

Revelation 12:17 identifies two important characteristics of this group: they keep the commandments of God and have the testimony of Jesus Christ.

Revelation 14:12 presents a closely related description of the saints who persevere in obedience and faith.

These passages have special significance in Seventh-day Adventist theology.

Adventists understand the remnant as a faithful end-time community called to proclaim the Three Angels' Messages, uphold the commandments of God, maintain faith in Jesus Christ, and bear witness to the prophetic testimony.

The Seventh-day Adventist Church identifies its movement with this prophetic mission.

However, several important questions must be considered.

Does the Bible teach that God has always preserved a faithful remnant?

Does the remnant represent a particular denomination or a broader community of believers?

What does the woman of Revelation 12 symbolize?

Who is the dragon?

What does it mean to keep God's commandments?

What is the testimony of Jesus Christ?

How is the testimony of Jesus related to the spirit of prophecy?

Does membership in a religious organization guarantee salvation?

Can sincere followers of Jesus Christ be found outside the Seventh-day Adventist Church?

What responsibilities accompany the claim to participate in God's final mission?

These questions must be examined with biblical accuracy, humility, and respect for the wider Christian community.

A distinction must be maintained between what Scripture explicitly states and what Seventh-day Adventist theology concludes through its historicist interpretation of prophecy.

The purpose of this chapter is not to encourage denominational superiority.

It is to examine the biblical characteristics of God's faithful people and understand the responsibility of those who seek to follow Jesus Christ in the last days.

Question 1 — What Does the Word Remnant Mean in the Bible?

Answer:

The word remnant generally refers to what remains of a larger group.

In the Old Testament, the concept frequently describes survivors of judgment, people preserved through hardship, or those who remain faithful to God.

The prophets used remnant language in connection with Israel and Judah.

Isaiah described a remnant returning to the mighty God.

Micah spoke of God's gathering and restoration of His people.

The remnant theme therefore includes both divine preservation and human response.

In the New Testament, Paul refers to a remnant according to the election of grace.

This demonstrates that the concept cannot be reduced merely to outward religious achievement.

God's grace remains fundamental.

In Revelation 12, the remnant appears in the context of spiritual conflict.

The dragon directs his hostility against those associated with the woman.

Seventh-day Adventists understand this group as God's faithful people during the final period of earth's history.

The essential biblical principle is that God remains faithful to His promises and preserves people who trust Him.

Bible References:

- Isaiah 10:20–22
- Isaiah 11:11–16
- Jeremiah 23:3–6
- Micah 2:12–13
- Romans 9:27–29
- Romans 11:1–6
- Revelation 12:17

Linguistic Note:

The Greek expression translated as remnant in Revelation 12:17 refers to the remaining ones. Its theological significance must be determined from the surrounding passage rather than from the word alone.

Question 2 — Has God Always Preserved a Faithful Remnant Throughout History?

Answer:

The Bible provides several examples of individuals and groups who remained faithful during periods of widespread disobedience.

Noah responded to God's warning in a generation characterized by corruption.

Elijah believed that he alone remained faithful, but God revealed that others had not bowed to Baal.

During the Babylonian captivity, Daniel and his companions remained loyal to God despite pressure to compromise.

After the exile, a remnant returned to Jerusalem and participated in the restoration of the community.

Paul later referred to the seven thousand preserved during Elijah's time as evidence of God's gracious preservation of a faithful remnant.

These examples demonstrate that God has not abandoned His purposes when many turn away from Him.

However, the biblical remnant is not always identical in composition, historical circumstances, or covenant role.

The concept should not be used to assume that one modern organization possesses every characteristic of every remnant described in Scripture.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, these historical examples establish a pattern of divine faithfulness that helps illuminate Revelation 12.

Bible References:

- Genesis 6:5–9
- 1 Kings 19:9–18
- Daniel 1:8–21

- Daniel 3:13–28
- Ezra 9:8–9
- Isaiah 1:9
- Romans 11:1–6

Contextual Note:

The remnant theme develops across different biblical covenants and historical settings. Its continuity should be recognized without erasing the distinctions between those settings.

Question 3 — Who Is the Woman Described in Revelation 12?

Answer:

Revelation 12 describes a woman clothed with the sun, with the moon under her feet and a crown of twelve stars.

She gives birth to a male child who is destined to rule the nations.

The dragon attempts to destroy the child.

The child is caught up unto God and His throne.

The woman later experiences persecution and receives divine protection.

In biblical prophecy, the imagery of a woman can represent a covenant community.

The Old Testament sometimes portrays Israel using marital imagery.

The New Testament describes the Church in relation to Christ as a bride.

Seventh-day Adventists understand the woman of Revelation 12 as representing God's faithful people across the history of redemption, including faithful Israel and the Christian Church.

The male child is understood as Jesus Christ.

However, Revelation 12 does not explicitly define every symbol.

Christian interpreters have also understood the woman as representing Israel, Mary, the Church, or a combination of these referents.

The Adventist interpretation emphasizes the continuity of God's faithful community before and after the earthly ministry of Christ.

Bible References:

- Genesis 37:9–11
- Isaiah 54:1–8
- Jeremiah 3:14–20
- Hosea 2:14–23
- Ephesians 5:25–32
- Revelation 12:1–6
- Revelation 19:7–9

Prophetic Note:

The identification of the woman as God's covenant people is a major Christian interpretation. Adventists apply this symbolism to the historical continuity of God's faithful community.

Question 4 — Who Is the Dragon, and Why Does He Persecute the Woman?

Answer:

Revelation 12 explicitly identifies the great dragon as the Devil and Satan.

The chapter portrays a conflict between the dragon and the heavenly powers.

After being cast down, the dragon directs his hostility against the woman and her offspring.

The imagery describes the continuing opposition of Satan to God's saving purposes.

The dragon's attempt to destroy the male child is understood by many Christian interpreters as reflecting Satan's opposition to Jesus Christ.

His later persecution of the woman represents hostility toward God's people.

In Seventh-day Adventist theology, Revelation 12 forms a central part of the great-controversy framework.

The conflict between Christ and Satan extends from heaven into human history.

However, the passage should not be interpreted as suggesting that Satan possesses power equal to God.

The dragon is a defeated adversary whose activity remains limited by divine sovereignty.

The victory belongs to Jesus Christ.

Bible References:

- Genesis 3:14–15
- John 12:31–33
- Hebrews 2:14–15
- 1 John 3:8
- Revelation 12:3–12
- Revelation 12:13–17
- Revelation 20:7–10

Doctrinal Note:

Revelation explicitly identifies the dragon as Satan. The broader historical application of his persecution is developed through interpretation of the chapter's prophetic imagery.

Question 5 — What Does Revelation Teach About the Persecution of God's Faithful People?

Answer:

Revelation 12 describes the woman fleeing into the wilderness, where she receives divine protection.

The chapter refers to a period of one thousand two hundred and sixty days.

It also uses the expression a time, and times, and half a time.

Similar prophetic periods appear in Daniel and Revelation.

Seventh-day Adventists interpret these periods through the historicist year-day principle.

They commonly understand the 1,260 prophetic days as representing 1,260 years of religious oppression, traditionally associated with the period from AD 538 to 1798.

Within this interpretation, the woman represents God's faithful people preserved during centuries of persecution.

However, Revelation 12 does not explicitly identify these calendar years.

The historical application depends upon Adventist prophetic chronology and its interpretation of religious and political developments.

Other Christian traditions understand the period as a literal duration, a symbolic period of suffering, or a reference to events in the ancient world.

The central biblical teaching is that God's people may experience persecution, but their ultimate hope rests upon His protection and victory.

Bible References:

- Daniel 7:21–25

- Daniel 12:7
- Matthew 24:9–13
- John 16:1–4
- Revelation 11:2–3
- Revelation 12:6, 13–16
- Revelation 13:5–7

Historical and Prophetic Note:

The AD 538–1798 chronology is characteristic of Adventist historicism. It is not explicitly stated in Revelation and requires historical and interpretive arguments that should be examined independently.

Question 6 — What Are the Identifying Characteristics of the Remnant in Revelation 12:17?

Answer:

Revelation 12:17 describes the remnant of the woman's seed through two principal characteristics.

They keep the commandments of God.

They also have the testimony of Jesus Christ.

These characteristics emphasize obedience and relationship with Jesus.

Revelation 14:12 provides a related description of the saints who keep God's commandments and the faith of Jesus.

Seventh-day Adventists understand these passages as describing God's faithful end-time people.

They emphasize obedience to the Ten Commandments, including the seventh-day Sabbath, and the continuing significance of the prophetic testimony.

However, Revelation 12:17 does not explicitly name a modern denomination.

The identification of the Seventh-day Adventist movement with the remnant is a theological interpretation based upon its understanding of prophetic history and mission.

The passage itself directs attention toward faithfulness to God and Jesus Christ.

These characteristics must be expressed through humility, love, and genuine discipleship.

Bible References:

- Exodus 20:1–17
- John 14:15
- John 15:9–14
- 1 John 2:3–6
- 1 John 5:2–3
- Revelation 12:17
- Revelation 14:12

Doctrinal Note:

Revelation explicitly identifies commandments and the testimony of Jesus as characteristics of the remnant. Its application to a particular contemporary denomination is a further interpretive conclusion.

Question 7 — Why Are the Commandments of God Important in the Identity of the Remnant?

Answer:

The Bible presents God's commandments as expressions of His moral will.

Jesus taught that love for God and love for one's neighbor summarize the great principles of the law.

He also connected love for Him with obedience to His commandments.

The apostle John emphasized that genuine knowledge of God is demonstrated through obedience.

In Revelation, keeping God's commandments is associated with the faithfulness of the saints.

Seventh-day Adventists understand the Ten Commandments as continuing expressions of God's moral law.

They emphasize the fourth commandment because it identifies the seventh day as the Sabbath and recalls God's creative authority.

However, the New Testament also teaches that salvation is not earned through obedience.

Human beings are justified by God's grace through faith in Jesus Christ.

The remnant's obedience should therefore be understood as the fruit of saving faith.

Commandment keeping without love, humility, or dependence upon Christ would misrepresent the character of God.

Bible References:

- Exodus 20:1–17
- Deuteronomy 6:4–6
- Matthew 22:36–40
- John 14:15
- Romans 3:21–31
- Ephesians 2:8–10
- 1 John 5:2–3
- Revelation 14:12

Doctrinal Note:

Adventists regard Sabbath observance as an important expression of commandment keeping. The broader biblical teaching requires that obedience remain grounded in grace and love.

Question 8 — What Is the Testimony of Jesus Christ?

Answer:

Revelation 12:17 states that the remnant has the testimony of Jesus Christ.

The expression also appears elsewhere in Revelation.

Its meaning has been discussed by biblical scholars and Christian interpreters.

It may refer to testimony about Jesus, testimony given by Jesus, or the prophetic witness associated with Him.

Revelation 19:10 connects the testimony of Jesus with the spirit of prophecy.

In Seventh-day Adventist theology, this connection is understood as evidence that the prophetic gift remains significant among God's end-time people.

Adventists associate this gift with the ministry and writings of Ellen G. White.

However, Revelation 12:17 does not explicitly identify Ellen G. White or any other postbiblical individual.

The application of the passage to her ministry depends upon the Adventist understanding of spiritual gifts and the interpretation of Revelation 19:10.

The central biblical principle is that the testimony concerning Jesus Christ must remain faithful to the Gospel and the Holy Scriptures.

Bible References:

- John 5:39
- John 15:26–27
- Acts 1:8
- 1 Corinthians 12:4–11
- Revelation 1:1–2, 9

- Revelation 12:17
- Revelation 19:10
- Revelation 22:8–9

Linguistic and Doctrinal Note:

The expression testimony of Jesus permits discussion concerning whether Jesus is the source or subject of the testimony. The Adventist application to the prophetic gift is a theological interpretation, not an explicit naming of a modern prophet.

Question 9 — What Does Revelation Mean by the Spirit of Prophecy?

Answer:

Revelation 19:10 declares that the testimony of Jesus is the spirit of prophecy.

The passage occurs when John attempts to worship an angel and is instructed to worship God instead.

The angel identifies himself as a fellow servant associated with those who possess the testimony of Jesus.

The expression connects prophetic witness with Jesus Christ.

The New Testament also teaches that the Holy Spirit distributes spiritual gifts, including prophecy.

Paul instructed believers not to despise prophesying, while also requiring discernment.

In Seventh-day Adventist theology, the spirit of prophecy is understood as the continuing manifestation of the prophetic gift under the guidance of the Holy Spirit.

Adventists believe that this gift was manifested in the ministry of Ellen G. White.

However, Christian traditions differ concerning whether and how prophetic gifts continue after the apostolic period.

The Bible requires spiritual claims to be tested.

No claimed prophetic message should replace the authority of Scripture or contradict the Gospel of Jesus Christ.

Bible References:

- Joel 2:28–29
- Acts 2:16–18
- 1 Corinthians 12:7–11
- 1 Corinthians 14:1–5
- 1 Thessalonians 5:19–22
- 1 John 4:1–3
- Revelation 19:10
- Revelation 22:8–9

Doctrinal Note:

The Adventist identification of Ellen G. White's ministry with the prophetic gift requires evaluation of her teachings and ministry. Revelation 19:10 alone does not establish the authenticity of any particular prophetic claimant.

Question 10 — What Is the Relationship Between the Remnant and the Three Angels' Messages?

Answer:

Revelation 12 describes the remnant as faithful to God's commandments and the testimony of Jesus.

Revelation 14 presents the Three Angels' Messages and identifies the patience of the saints.

The themes of obedience, faithfulness, worship, judgment, and testimony connect these passages.

In Seventh-day Adventist theology, the remnant is understood as a community called to proclaim the Three Angels' Messages.

This mission includes announcing the everlasting Gospel, calling humanity to worship the Creator, warning against spiritual deception, and encouraging perseverance in Jesus Christ.

Adventists understand their worldwide missionary work as participating in this prophetic proclamation.

However, Revelation does not explicitly state that the remnant of chapter 12 is identical with one named modern religious organization.

The connection between the remnant and the Three Angels' Messages is established through theological comparison.

The central responsibility of God's people is to proclaim Jesus Christ faithfully.

Their mission must reflect His character through truth, compassion, and love.

Bible References:

- Matthew 24:14
- Matthew 28:18–20
- Acts 1:8
- Revelation 12:17
- Revelation 14:6–12
- Revelation 18:1–4
- Revelation 22:17

Missionary Note:

The Adventist understanding of remnant mission centers upon the worldwide proclamation of Revelation 14. Its practical expression should remain Christ-centered and respectful of freedom of conscience.

Question 11 — Does the Bible Teach That Salvation Is Limited to One Religious Denomination?

Answer:

The New Testament teaches that salvation is found through Jesus Christ.

Peter declared that salvation is found in no other name.

Jesus identified Himself as the way, the truth, and the life.

Paul taught that salvation is received by grace through faith.

These passages establish Christ as the foundation of salvation.

They do not teach that membership in a particular modern denomination automatically guarantees eternal life.

Nor do they establish that every person outside a particular organization is necessarily lost.

In Seventh-day Adventist theology, the Church understands itself as participating in a distinctive prophetic mission.

However, Adventists also recognize that sincere followers of Jesus Christ exist in many Christian communities.

The final judgment belongs to God.

Human beings cannot fully know another person's heart, understanding, or response to divine truth.

The biblical call is therefore to remain faithful to Christ, share the Gospel, and avoid claiming authority to determine the eternal destiny of others.

Bible References:

- John 3:16–17
- John 10:14–16
- John 14:6
- Acts 4:10–12

- Acts 10:34–35
- Romans 2:14–16
- Ephesians 2:8–10
- 2 Timothy 2:19

Doctrinal Note:

A distinctive understanding of prophetic mission must not be confused with the claim that denominational membership itself saves a person.

Question 12 — Can God's Faithful People Be Found Outside the Visible Remnant Movement?

Answer:

The Bible reveals that God's knowledge of His people is greater than human understanding.

During Elijah's time, the prophet believed that he was alone in faithfulness.

God revealed that thousands had not bowed to Baal.

Jesus also spoke of other sheep who were not of the immediate fold addressed in His teaching.

In Revelation 18, a heavenly voice calls God's people to come out of Babylon.

Within the Adventist interpretation, this passage indicates that sincere believers may be found within religious communities regarded as participating in Babylon's spiritual confusion.

Therefore, the Adventist understanding of the remnant does not require the conclusion that all sincere believers already belong to the Seventh-day Adventist Church.

God calls people according to the truth they receive and the response of their hearts.

However, the application of Revelation 18 to particular modern denominations remains an interpretive conclusion.

The essential principle is that God knows those who belong to Him.

Christians should communicate their convictions with humility rather than judging the spiritual condition of others.

Bible References:

- 1 Kings 19:14–18
- John 10:14–16
- Acts 10:34–35
- Romans 11:1–6
- 2 Timothy 2:19
- Revelation 18:1–4

Pastoral Note:

The existence of sincere believers in different communities should encourage humility, mutual respect, and faithful witness rather than religious hostility.

Question 13 — How Does the Remnant Relate to Religious Liberty and Freedom of Conscience?

Answer:

The Bible presents genuine worship as a response of faith and allegiance to God.

Jesus called people to follow Him, but His ministry did not establish salvation through religious coercion.

The apostles demonstrated that obedience to God may require resistance to commands that contradict divine authority.

Revelation 13 describes a prophetic system that uses coercion to enforce worship.

In Seventh-day Adventist theology, this passage forms an important foundation for the defense of religious liberty.

Adventists understand the final conflict as involving conscience, worship, and the misuse of political authority for religious purposes.

Therefore, the remnant's mission should include respect for freedom of conscience.

The right to worship according to conviction must not be limited to those who share Adventist beliefs.

It also applies to people of other Christian traditions, other religions, and those who profess no religion.

The Gospel must be proclaimed through persuasion, testimony, and love rather than intimidation or force.

Bible References:

- Joshua 24:14–15
- Matthew 22:15–22
- Luke 9:51–56
- John 18:33–37
- Acts 4:18–20
- Acts 5:27–29
- Revelation 13:11–17
- Revelation 14:6–12

Practical Note:

A faithful Christian witness should defend religious liberty consistently, including the freedom of those who disagree with one's own beliefs.

Question 14 — What Spiritual Dangers Must Those Who Identify With the Remnant Avoid?

Answer:

The Bible repeatedly warns against spiritual pride, hypocrisy, self-righteousness, and the misuse of religious knowledge.

Jesus criticized those who emphasized outward religious observance while neglecting justice, mercy, and faithfulness.

Paul taught that knowledge without love can produce pride.

He also warned believers against judging others arrogantly.

These teachings are especially important for any community that understands itself as possessing a distinctive religious mission.

In Seventh-day Adventist theology, the remnant identity should encourage humility and responsibility rather than superiority.

Knowledge of biblical prophecy does not replace conversion.

Observance of religious practices does not excuse unkindness.

Confidence in doctrinal teaching does not authorize contempt toward other Christians.

The remnant must demonstrate the character of Jesus Christ.

Its members are called to repentance, compassion, integrity, faith, and love.

A community that proclaims God's commandments must also reflect the moral principles those commandments express.

Bible References:

- Micah 6:8
- Matthew 7:1–5
- Matthew 23:23–28
- Luke 18:9–14
- Romans 12:3–10

- 1 Corinthians 8:1–3
- 1 Corinthians 13:1–13
- James 2:1–13

Spiritual Note:

A claim to prophetic identity carries moral responsibility. The authenticity of Christian witness is inseparable from humility, compassion, and faithfulness to Jesus Christ.

Question 15 — How Can a Christian Participate Faithfully in God's End-Time Mission?

Answer:

Jesus Christ commissioned His disciples to proclaim the Gospel and make disciples of all nations.

He promised the presence and power of the Holy Spirit.

The New Testament teaches that every believer has a role in the life and mission of the Church.

Some teach, preach, or evangelize.

Others serve through hospitality, encouragement, generosity, practical assistance, and personal testimony.

The purpose of Christian mission is to direct people toward Jesus Christ.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, participation in God's end-time mission includes proclaiming the Three Angels' Messages, upholding biblical truth, defending religious liberty, and demonstrating the love of Christ.

However, faithful mission requires more than public proclamation.

It includes personal conversion, prayer, Bible study, ethical conduct, compassion for the vulnerable, and respect for others.

The believer must avoid presenting prophecy as a tool for fear or hostility.

The Gospel should be communicated with clarity, kindness, and confidence in God's grace.

The ultimate goal is not merely to expand an institution.

It is to help people know Jesus Christ and prepare for His everlasting kingdom.

Bible References:

- Matthew 5:13–16
- Matthew 22:36–40
- Matthew 28:18–20
- Acts 1:8
- Romans 12:4–13
- 1 Corinthians 12:4–27
- Ephesians 4:11–16
- 1 Peter 3:15–16
- Revelation 14:6–12
- Revelation 22:17

Missionary Note:

Participation in God's mission should be measured not only by doctrinal proclamation but also by faithfulness to Christ, love for others, and responsible Christian service.

Chapter Summary

The Bible presents the remnant as people preserved by God's grace and called to remain faithful to Him.

The remnant theme appears throughout the Old Testament and continues into the New Testament.

Revelation 12 describes the conflict between the dragon and the woman and identifies the remnant through obedience to God's

commandments and possession of the testimony of Jesus Christ.

Seventh-day Adventists understand this prophecy as having particular significance for God's faithful people in the last days.

They identify their movement with the mission of proclaiming the Three Angels' Messages.

However, Scripture does not explicitly name a modern denomination as the remnant.

The Adventist identification is a theological conclusion based upon its interpretation of prophecy, history, and mission.

Our study enables us to retain the following teachings:

1. The biblical remnant refers to those who remain or are preserved within a larger group.

2. God has preserved faithful people throughout biblical history.

3. The woman of Revelation 12 is understood by Adventists as representing God's covenant people.

4. Revelation explicitly identifies the dragon as Satan.

5. The persecution of the woman is interpreted within Adventist theology through historicist prophetic chronology.

6. Revelation 12:17 identifies the remnant through God's commandments and the testimony of Jesus Christ.

7. Obedience to God's commandments must remain grounded in salvation by grace through faith.

8. The testimony of Jesus is connected with prophetic witness and the revelation of Jesus Christ.

9. Adventists understand the spirit of prophecy as a continuing spiritual gift associated with the ministry of Ellen G. White.

10. The remnant's mission is connected in Adventist theology with the proclamation of the Three Angels' Messages.

11. Salvation is found through Jesus Christ, not through membership in a particular denomination.

12. Sincere followers of God may be found outside the visible Adventist movement.

13. God's faithful people should defend religious liberty and freedom of conscience.

14. Those who identify with the remnant must reject spiritual pride, hypocrisy, and hostility.

15. Every Christian is called to participate in God's mission through faith, love, truth, and faithful service.

Doctrinal Conclusion

The biblical doctrine of the remnant reveals God's continuing faithfulness to His people.

Throughout history, the Lord has preserved those who trust Him even during periods of spiritual decline and persecution.

The Book of Revelation presents this theme within the great conflict between Christ and Satan.

Revelation 12:17 describes the remnant as keeping God's commandments and possessing the testimony of Jesus Christ.

In Seventh-day Adventist theology, this passage forms part of a broader understanding of the Church's prophetic identity and mission.

God's Faithfulness Throughout History

God has preserved faithful individuals and communities despite opposition and spiritual decline.

The Woman of Revelation 12

Adventists understand the woman as representing God's faithful covenant people throughout the history of redemption.

The Conflict With the Dragon

Satan opposes God's saving purposes and directs hostility toward those who remain faithful to Christ.

The Commandments of God

The remnant is called to obedience grounded in love and saving faith.

The Testimony of Jesus

The testimony of Jesus directs attention toward His revelation, His Gospel, and the prophetic witness associated with Him.

The Spirit of Prophecy

Adventists understand the prophetic gift as continuing within God's people and associate it with the ministry of Ellen G. White.

The Three Angels' Messages

The remnant's mission is understood as proclaiming the everlasting Gospel and the prophetic appeals of Revelation 14.

Salvation Through Jesus Christ

No religious organization can replace the saving grace of Jesus Christ.

God's People Beyond Denominational Boundaries

God knows those who belong to Him, including sincere believers outside the Adventist movement.

Religious Liberty

Faithful witness must respect freedom of conscience and reject coercion.

Humility and Christian Character

The remnant identity should produce responsibility, compassion, and faithfulness rather than superiority.

Worldwide Mission

God's people are called to proclaim the Gospel through word, conduct, and service.

The doctrine of the remnant must always be interpreted in the light of the character of Jesus Christ.

A community cannot demonstrate faithfulness to God through religious pride or hostility toward others.

The commandments of God call believers to love.

The testimony of Jesus directs attention toward the Savior.

The everlasting Gospel announces salvation through grace.

The mission of God's people is therefore both doctrinal and spiritual.

It involves fidelity to Scripture, dependence upon the Holy Spirit, respect for human dignity, and active love toward others.

The Essential Message:

The Holy Scriptures reveal that God preserves faithful people throughout history and calls them to remain loyal to Him. Revelation 12:17 describes the remnant as those who keep the commandments of God and possess the testimony of Jesus Christ. Seventh-day Adventist theology understands this passage as describing a distinctive end-time mission connected with the Three Angels' Messages, the Sabbath, and the prophetic gift. However, the Bible does not explicitly identify a modern denomination by name, and salvation is found only through Jesus Christ. The authentic response to the remnant message is faith, obedience, humility, love, respect for conscience, and faithful participation in the proclamation of the everlasting Gospel.

Personal Reflection Questions

1. What does the biblical concept of the remnant reveal about God's faithfulness?

2. How do the experiences of Noah, Elijah, Daniel, and other faithful believers illustrate the remnant theme?

3. What does Revelation 12 teach about the conflict between the dragon and the woman?

4. Why is it important to distinguish Revelation's explicit statements from historical interpretations of its symbols?

5. What do the commandments of God and the testimony of Jesus reveal about the character of the remnant?

6. How should the prophetic gift be evaluated according to the Holy Scriptures?

7. Why must salvation through Jesus Christ remain distinct from membership in a particular denomination?

8. How should Christians treat sincere believers who belong to different religious communities?

9. What spiritual dangers can arise when a community believes it has a distinctive prophetic mission?

10. How can I participate faithfully in God's mission through humility, love, biblical truth, and service?

Suggested Prayer

Lord my God,

I come before You with reverence, gratitude, and humility.

You are the Creator of heaven and earth.

You are faithful to Your promises and righteous in all Your ways.

Thank You for preserving Your people throughout the history of redemption.

Thank You for revealing Your truth through the Holy Scriptures.

Thank You for sending Jesus Christ to save humanity from sin and death.

I acknowledge that salvation is found through Him alone.

Help me place my confidence entirely in His grace and righteousness.

As I study the biblical teaching concerning the remnant, give me wisdom and understanding.

Teach me to examine the prophecies of Daniel and Revelation carefully.

Help me distinguish the clear teachings of Scripture from interpretations and human assumptions.

Protect me from spiritual pride and the temptation to consider myself superior to others.

May my knowledge of biblical truth produce humility rather than arrogance.

Teach me to keep Your commandments through love and faith.

Fill my heart with the testimony of Jesus Christ.

Guide me through the power of Your Holy Spirit.

Help me recognize the importance of spiritual gifts while testing every teaching according to Your Word.

Give me respect and compassion for sincere believers who understand Scripture differently.

May I never judge another person's eternal destiny.

Teach me to defend freedom of conscience and the dignity of every human being.

Help me reject coercion, hostility, and religious intolerance.

Strengthen my faith when I face difficulties.

Give me courage to remain faithful when obedience requires sacrifice.

Teach me to demonstrate the character of Jesus Christ in my daily life.

Help me serve those who are suffering.

Give me compassion for the poor, the lonely, and the discouraged.

May my words bring encouragement and my actions reveal Your love.

Thank You for entrusting the Gospel to Your people.

Help me participate faithfully in its proclamation.

May I share Your truth with clarity, patience, humility, and kindness.

Prepare my heart for the glorious return of Jesus Christ.

Until that day, help me remain faithful to Your Word and completely dependent upon Your grace.

May my life bring honor and glory to You alone.

In the name of Jesus Christ, my Savior and Lord.

Amen.

CHAPTER 39 — THE HEAVENLY SANCTUARY AND CHRIST'S FINAL MINISTRY: WHAT IS JESUS DOING FOR HUMANITY TODAY?

A Thematic Bible Study — King James Version (KJV)

Opening Scripture

> “Now of the things which we have spoken this is the sum: We have such an high priest, who is set on the right hand of the throne of the Majesty in the heavens;”

Hebrews 8:1 — KJV

Introduction

The Christian faith is founded upon the life, death, resurrection, and heavenly ministry of Jesus Christ.

The Holy Scriptures teach that Jesus came into the world to reveal the Father, redeem humanity from sin, and reconcile sinners to God.

Through His sacrifice upon the cross, He accomplished the decisive work of atonement.

Through His resurrection, He demonstrated His victory over death.

Following His ascension, Jesus entered heaven, where the New Testament presents Him as the exalted Lord, the mediator of the new covenant, and the great High Priest of His people.

But what does the Bible teach concerning His present ministry?

What is the heavenly sanctuary?

Why did God instruct Moses to construct an earthly sanctuary?

What was the purpose of the sacrifices and priestly ceremonies?

How did the earthly sanctuary point toward Jesus Christ?

What is the significance of the Day of Atonement?

What does Daniel mean when he declares that the sanctuary will be cleansed after 2,300 evenings and mornings?

Why do Seventh-day Adventists associate this prophecy with the year 1844?

And how should Christians understand the relationship between Christ's heavenly ministry, divine judgment, and the assurance of salvation?

These questions occupy an important place in biblical theology.

They are also central to the distinctive doctrinal identity of the Seventh-day Adventist Church.

The sanctuary system described in Exodus, Leviticus, and Numbers provides a significant background for understanding the ministry of Jesus Christ.

The Epistle to the Hebrews explains that the earthly sanctuary and its priestly services anticipated greater realities fulfilled in Christ.

Jesus is presented as the perfect High Priest who entered heaven itself and appears in the presence of God on behalf of His people.

Unlike the repeated sacrifices offered under the old covenant, His sacrifice was offered once for all.

The heavenly ministry of Christ is therefore inseparable from the sufficiency of His death upon the cross.

In Seventh-day Adventist theology, the sanctuary doctrine also includes a distinctive interpretation of Daniel 8:14.

Adventists understand the 2,300 prophetic evenings and mornings as representing 2,300 years.

Using their interpretation of Daniel 8 and 9, they calculate the conclusion of this period as occurring in 1844.

They believe that this date marks the beginning of the final phase of Christ's heavenly ministry, commonly called the investigative or pre-Advent judgment.

However, these conclusions are not accepted by all Christian traditions.

Many biblical scholars interpret Daniel 8 within the historical context of the persecution associated with Antiochus IV Epiphanes and the desecration of the Jerusalem temple.

Other interpreters apply the prophecy to different historical or eschatological events.

A responsible study must therefore distinguish the explicit New Testament teaching concerning Christ's heavenly priesthood from the additional prophetic conclusions developed within Adventist historicism.

Above all, the sanctuary doctrine must direct attention toward Jesus Christ.

The purpose of studying the heavenly sanctuary is not to create uncertainty concerning salvation.

It is to understand more deeply the saving work of the One who died for humanity and now ministers as the believer's heavenly High Priest.

This chapter examines fifteen questions concerning the earthly sanctuary, the heavenly sanctuary, Christ's priesthood, the Day of Atonement, Daniel's prophecy, and the final judgment.

Our objective is to strengthen faith in Jesus Christ through careful study of the Holy Scriptures.

Question 1 — Why Did God Command Moses to Build a Sanctuary?

Answer:

After delivering the Israelites from Egypt, God instructed Moses to construct a sanctuary.

The purpose of this sanctuary was expressed in God's desire to dwell among His people.

The sanctuary represented the divine presence within the covenant community.

It also provided a place for worship, sacrifice, priestly ministry, and instruction concerning holiness.

The sanctuary was not intended to suggest that God could be confined within a physical building.

The Scriptures repeatedly affirm that the Creator of heaven and earth cannot be contained by human structures.

Rather, the sanctuary served as a visible expression of God's covenant relationship with Israel.

Its ceremonies taught important lessons concerning sin, forgiveness, mediation, holiness, and reconciliation.

The New Testament later interprets the sanctuary system in relation to Jesus Christ.

In Seventh-day Adventist theology, the earthly sanctuary is understood as a divinely appointed teaching system that illustrates the plan of salvation.

Its services direct attention toward the sacrifice and heavenly ministry of the Savior.

Bible References:

- Exodus 25:8–9
- Exodus 29:42–46

- Exodus 40:33–38
- Leviticus 16:1–34
- 1 Kings 8:27–30
- Psalm 77:13
- Hebrews 8:1–5
- Hebrews 9:1–12

Contextual Note:

The earthly sanctuary belonged to Israel's covenant worship. Its relationship to Christ is developed especially in the Epistle to the Hebrews.

Question 2 — What Were the Principal Parts of the Earthly Sanctuary?

Answer:

The sanctuary constructed under Moses included a courtyard and a sacred tent divided into two principal compartments.

The first compartment was called the Holy Place.

It contained the lampstand, the table associated with the bread of the Presence, and the altar of incense.

The second compartment was called the Most Holy Place.

It contained the ark of the covenant.

The ark was associated with the testimony of God's covenant and the mercy seat.

In the courtyard stood the altar of burnt offering and the basin used for priestly washing.

These elements formed part of the worship system prescribed for Israel.

The arrangement distinguished different degrees of access to the sacred space.

Ordinary Israelites did not enter the sanctuary compartments to perform priestly duties.

Priests ministered in the first compartment, while the high priest entered the Most Holy Place on the annual Day of Atonement.

The New Testament uses these arrangements to explain the significance of Christ's priestly ministry.

In Seventh-day Adventist theology, the two compartments also provide a framework for understanding two phases of Christ's heavenly ministry.

However, the New Testament's use of sanctuary imagery must be examined carefully before concluding that every earthly architectural distinction corresponds to a chronological phase in heaven.

Bible References:

- Exodus 25:10–40
- Exodus 26:1–37
- Exodus 27:1–8
- Exodus 30:1–10, 17–21
- Exodus 40:1–33
- Hebrews 9:1–7

Doctrinal Note:

The two-compartment structure of the earthly sanctuary is explicitly biblical. Its application to distinct chronological phases of Christ's heavenly ministry is a characteristic Adventist interpretation.

Question 3 — What Was the Purpose of the Sacrificial System?

Answer:

The sacrificial system taught Israel about the seriousness of sin and the necessity of atonement.

The Book of Leviticus describes various offerings associated with worship, thanksgiving, purification, and restoration of covenant relationships.

The shedding of blood held particular significance within the system of atonement.

However, the sacrifices were not independent sources of salvation.

The New Testament teaches that the blood of animals could not ultimately remove sin.

The sacrificial system pointed beyond itself to the saving work of Jesus Christ.

John the Baptist identified Jesus as the Lamb of God who takes away the sin of the world.

The apostle Peter described Christ's redeeming sacrifice using the imagery of a spotless lamb.

The Epistle to the Hebrews explains that Jesus offered Himself as the decisive sacrifice.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, the sanctuary sacrifices revealed the cost of sin and anticipated the perfect sacrifice of Christ.

The believer's forgiveness rests upon Jesus, not upon the repetition of ancient ceremonial offerings.

Bible References:

- Leviticus 1:1–17
- Leviticus 4:1–35
- Leviticus 17:11
- Isaiah 53:4–12
- John 1:29
- 1 Peter 1:18–21
- Hebrews 9:11–15
- Hebrews 10:1–14

Doctrinal Note:

The sacrificial system finds its fulfillment in Jesus Christ. His sacrifice is sufficient and does not need to be repeated.

Question 4 — What Was the Role of the Priests and the High Priest?

Answer:

The priests of Israel were responsible for administering the sanctuary services according to the instructions given through Moses.

Their duties included presenting offerings, maintaining the sacred services, and teaching the people concerning God's law.

The high priest held a distinctive role.

On the annual Day of Atonement, he entered the Most Holy Place to perform ceremonies associated with the purification of the sanctuary and the people.

The priesthood therefore involved mediation, holiness, and responsibility before God.

However, the earthly priests were imperfect human beings.

They were subject to weakness and sin.

The Epistle to the Hebrews contrasts their limitations with the perfection of Jesus Christ.

Jesus is described as a merciful and faithful High Priest.

He is without sin and possesses an enduring priesthood.

His ministry does not depend upon an endless succession of human priests.

He lives forever and intercedes for those who come to God through Him.

Bible References:

- Exodus 28:1–43

- Leviticus 8:1–36
- Leviticus 16:1–34
- Numbers 18:1–7
- Hebrews 4:14–16
- Hebrews 5:1–10
- Hebrews 7:23–28

Doctrinal Note:

The priestly ministry of Jesus Christ fulfills and surpasses the earthly priesthood. His mediation is sufficient because of His sinless life, perfect sacrifice, and everlasting priesthood.

Question 5 — What Does the Bible Teach About the Heavenly Sanctuary?

Answer:

The Epistle to the Hebrews teaches that Jesus ministers in heaven.

It describes Him as a minister of the sanctuary and of the true tabernacle, which the Lord pitched and not man.

Hebrews also states that the earthly priests served according to a copy and shadow of heavenly things.

The Book of Revelation contains visions involving heavenly temple imagery, including the altar, incense, and the ark of the covenant.

These passages provide a biblical foundation for speaking of a heavenly sanctuary.

However, they do not give a complete architectural description of heaven.

The language of the sanctuary communicates divine presence, worship, priestly ministry, and the fulfillment of God's saving purposes.

In Seventh-day Adventist theology, the heavenly sanctuary is understood as a real heavenly reality in which Christ ministers on behalf of humanity.

Other Christian interpreters emphasize that Hebrews presents the heavenly sanctuary primarily through theological imagery fulfilled in Christ's access to God's presence.

The essential biblical teaching is that Jesus Christ has entered heaven itself and ministers before God for His people.

Bible References:

- Exodus 25:8–9, 40
- Psalm 11:4
- Hebrews 8:1–5
- Hebrews 9:11–12
- Hebrews 9:23–24
- Revelation 8:3–5
- Revelation 11:19
- Revelation 15:5–8

Doctrinal Note:

Christ's heavenly priesthood is explicitly taught in Hebrews. The precise spatial arrangement and chronology of heavenly sanctuary activities remain subjects of theological interpretation.

Question 6 — How Is Jesus Christ Our Great High Priest?

Answer:

The Epistle to the Hebrews identifies Jesus Christ as the great High Priest who has passed into the heavens.

Unlike the earthly priests, Jesus is without sin.

He understands human weakness because He experienced temptation and suffering.

Yet He remained faithful to the Father.

His priesthood is associated with the order of Melchizedek rather than the hereditary priesthood of Aaron.

Hebrews emphasizes that Christ's priesthood is permanent.

He is able to save completely those who come to God through Him because He continually lives to make intercession for them.

His priestly ministry is inseparable from His once-for-all sacrifice.

Jesus does not repeatedly offer Himself.

His death upon the cross was sufficient.

In Seventh-day Adventist theology, Christ's heavenly priesthood includes mediation, intercession, and the final work of judgment.

The believer is therefore invited to approach God with confidence through Jesus Christ.

Bible References:

- Psalm 110:1–4
- Hebrews 2:14–18
- Hebrews 4:14–16
- Hebrews 5:5–10
- Hebrews 6:19–20
- Hebrews 7:11–28
- Hebrews 9:24–28
- Hebrews 10:11–14

Doctrinal Note:

Jesus is the perfect High Priest whose sacrifice was completed once for all. His continuing heavenly ministry does not imply that His sacrifice was incomplete.

Question 7 — What Is the Meaning of Christ's Intercession for Believers?

Answer:

The New Testament teaches that Jesus Christ intercedes for His people.

Paul describes Christ as the One who died, rose again, and is at the right hand of God making intercession.

Hebrews declares that He continually lives to intercede for those who come to God through Him.

The apostle John also presents Jesus Christ as an advocate with the Father.

These passages reveal the believer's continuing dependence upon the Savior.

Christ's intercession does not mean that the Father is unwilling to forgive until Jesus persuades Him.

The New Testament teaches that the Father Himself loves humanity and sent His Son for its salvation.

The ministry of Christ expresses the united saving purpose of the Father and the Son.

In Seventh-day Adventist understanding, intercession includes Christ's representation of believers before God throughout His heavenly ministry.

The central assurance is that Christians have a living Savior who understands their weaknesses and provides access to divine grace.

Bible References:

- John 3:16–17
- John 16:26–27
- Romans 8:31–39
- 1 Timothy 2:5–6

- Hebrews 4:14–16
- Hebrews 7:25
- Hebrews 9:24
- 1 John 2:1–2

Pastoral Note:

Christ's intercession should strengthen confidence in God's mercy. It should not be presented as a conflict between a reluctant Father and a compassionate Son.

Question 8 — What Was the Day of Atonement in Ancient Israel?

Answer:

The Day of Atonement was one of the most solemn occasions in Israel's religious calendar.

Leviticus 16 describes the ceremonies associated with this annual observance.

The high priest performed special rites involving sacrificial blood, the Most Holy Place, and the purification of the sanctuary.

Two goats were selected.

One was designated for the Lord and used in the sacrificial service.

The other was associated with Azazel and sent into the wilderness after the prescribed ritual.

The people were instructed to humble themselves before God.

The Day of Atonement therefore emphasized purification, repentance, holiness, and the restoration of covenant order.

The meaning of the Azazel ritual has been debated.

Some interpreters understand Azazel as a wilderness figure or demonic being.

Others understand the term differently.

Seventh-day Adventists traditionally interpret the live goat as representing Satan, who ultimately bears responsibility for the evil he has instigated.

However, this interpretation must not be confused with the saving sacrifice of Jesus Christ.

Only Christ provides atonement for human sin.

The Adventist application of the Day of Atonement to the final heavenly judgment is a further theological interpretation.

Bible References:

- Leviticus 16:1–34
- Leviticus 23:26–32
- Numbers 29:7–11
- Hebrews 9:1–14
- Hebrews 9:23–28
- Hebrews 10:1–14

Historical and Doctrinal Note:

The Day of Atonement was an annual purification rite in Israel. Its relationship to Christ is developed in Hebrews, while the Adventist identification of the live goat with Satan is a distinctive interpretation.

Question 9 — How Did the Day of Atonement Point Toward the Ministry of Jesus Christ?

Answer:

The Epistle to the Hebrews interprets the sanctuary system as anticipating the greater priestly work of Jesus Christ.

The earthly high priest entered the inner sanctuary with sacrificial blood.

Jesus entered heaven through the efficacy of His own sacrifice.

Hebrews emphasizes that His offering was made once for all.

This contrast is essential.

The earthly sanctuary required repeated ceremonies.

Christ's sacrifice possesses permanent saving value.

His heavenly ministry demonstrates the continuing effectiveness of that completed sacrifice.

In Seventh-day Adventist theology, the annual Day of Atonement also foreshadows a final phase of Christ's heavenly ministry involving judgment and the ultimate removal of sin.

Adventists connect this phase with the cleansing of the sanctuary described in Daniel 8:14.

However, Hebrews does not explicitly state that Christ began a new heavenly phase in 1844.

Many Christian interpreters understand the Day of Atonement typology as fulfilled decisively through Christ's death, resurrection, and entrance into God's presence.

The common biblical foundation is the superiority of Jesus Christ and the sufficiency of His saving work.

Bible References:

- Leviticus 16:15–22
- Isaiah 53:10–12
- Romans 3:23–26
- Hebrews 8:1–6
- Hebrews 9:7–14
- Hebrews 9:23–28
- Hebrews 10:1–22

Doctrinal Note:

The New Testament explicitly presents Jesus as the fulfillment of the priestly and sacrificial system. The Adventist division of His heavenly ministry into distinct prophetic phases is an additional interpretive conclusion.

Question 10 — What Does Daniel 8:14 Say About the 2,300 Evenings and Mornings?

Answer:

Daniel 8 records a prophetic vision involving a ram, a goat, a little horn, and the sanctuary.

The vision includes the removal of the regular offering, the trampling of the sanctuary, and a question concerning the duration of these events.

Daniel 8:14 provides the answer.

The King James Version states:

> “And he said unto me, Unto two thousand and three hundred days; then shall the sanctuary be cleansed.”

The Hebrew expression underlying the KJV's days is literally associated with evenings and mornings.

Its interpretation has been debated.

Some interpreters understand the period as 2,300 days.

Others understand the expression in relation to the daily sacrificial cycle.

Seventh-day Adventists apply the year-day principle and interpret the period as 2,300 prophetic years.

They connect its conclusion with the beginning of the final phase of Christ's heavenly ministry.

However, the immediate context of Daniel 8 concerns the sanctuary and the oppressive activity of the little horn.

Many historical-critical and other Christian interpreters associate the prophecy with the desecration and restoration of the Jerusalem temple during the second century BC.

The Adventist interpretation must therefore be understood as a historicist reading that extends the prophecy beyond that historical setting.

Bible References:

- Daniel 8:1–14
- Daniel 8:15–27
- Numbers 14:34
- Ezekiel 4:4–6
- Hebrews 9:23–28

Linguistic and Prophetic Note:

Daniel 8:14 does not explicitly identify the beginning of the 2,300-period chronology. The calculation of 1844 depends upon additional interpretive connections and the application of the year-day principle.

Question 11 — Why Do Seventh-day Adventists Connect Daniel 8:14 With the Year 1844?

Answer:

Seventh-day Adventists understand the 2,300 evenings and mornings of Daniel 8:14 as representing 2,300 years.

They connect this prophecy with the seventy weeks described in Daniel 9.

Within the Adventist interpretation, the seventy weeks form the opening portion of the longer prophetic period.

The starting point is identified with the decree associated with the restoration of Jerusalem, commonly dated to 457 BC.

Using this chronological framework, Adventists calculate the conclusion of the 2,300 years as AD 1844.

This interpretation emerged from the broader Millerite prophetic movement of the nineteenth century.

William Miller and his associates expected the prophecy to culminate in the return of Jesus Christ.

When Christ did not return in 1844, the movement experienced what became known as the Great Disappointment.

Early Sabbatarian Adventists subsequently concluded that the date referred not to Christ's return to earth but to a transition in His heavenly sanctuary ministry.

This interpretation became foundational to Seventh-day Adventist theology.

However, the Bible does not explicitly state that Daniel 8:14 begins in 457 BC or ends in 1844.

Those dates depend upon the historicist linkage between Daniel 8 and 9 and the interpretation of the relevant decrees.

Other Christian scholars reject this connection or understand the prophecies differently.

The historical fact of the Millerite disappointment should therefore be distinguished from the theological explanation Adventists developed afterward.

Bible References:

- Ezra 7:11–26
- Daniel 8:13–14
- Daniel 8:26–27
- Daniel 9:20–27

- Numbers 14:34
- Ezekiel 4:4–6
- Hebrews 9:23–28

Historical Note:

The Adventist calculation proceeds from 457 BC to AD 1844 without a year zero. The date is a result of a particular prophetic chronology rather than a year explicitly named in Scripture.

Question 12 — What Is the Investigative or Pre-Advent Judgment?

Answer:

Seventh-day Adventist theology teaches that a phase of divine judgment occurs before the Second Coming of Jesus Christ.

This teaching is commonly called the investigative judgment or pre-Advent judgment.

Adventists connect it with the heavenly judgment scene of Daniel 7, the cleansing of the sanctuary in Daniel 8:14, and the announcement of judgment in Revelation 14:7.

According to this understanding, the judgment reveals who has genuinely responded to God's saving grace through Jesus Christ.

It is also understood as demonstrating the justice of God's decisions before the heavenly universe.

The doctrine does not teach that God must investigate records because He lacks knowledge.

Rather, Adventist theology presents the judgment as a revelation of divine justice.

However, the expression investigative judgment does not appear in the Bible.

The precise chronology beginning in 1844 is also not explicitly stated in the New Testament.

Many Christian traditions understand judgment passages differently and do not accept a distinct investigative phase beginning in the nineteenth century.

The essential biblical teaching is that God judges righteously and that Jesus Christ is the believer's Savior and advocate.

Bible References:

- Daniel 7:9–14
- Daniel 8:13–14
- Ecclesiastes 12:13–14
- Matthew 22:1–14
- Acts 17:30–31
- Romans 8:31–39
- 2 Corinthians 5:10
- Revelation 14:6–7
- Revelation 20:11–15

Doctrinal Note:

The investigative judgment is a distinctive Seventh-day Adventist doctrine. Its chronology and theological structure arise from an interpretation combining several biblical passages rather than from one explicit statement.

Question 13 — Does the Investigative Judgment Mean That Believers Must Live in Fear of Losing Salvation?

Answer:

The New Testament presents salvation as a gift of God's grace through Jesus Christ.

Paul teaches that believers are justified through faith.

He also declares that there is no condemnation for those who are in Christ Jesus.

The Epistle to the Hebrews invites Christians to approach the throne of grace with confidence.

These promises provide a foundation for Christian assurance.

At the same time, Scripture calls believers to perseverance, repentance, holiness, and faithfulness.

The Bible warns against deliberate rejection of God's grace.

In Seventh-day Adventist theology, the pre-Advent judgment is understood as revealing the reality of a person's relationship with Christ.

It is not intended to suggest that believers must earn salvation through perfect performance.

Jesus Christ remains the foundation of their hope.

Nevertheless, presentations of the investigative judgment have sometimes produced anxiety when they emphasize human shortcomings without adequately explaining the sufficiency of Christ's grace.

A biblically balanced approach must preserve both the seriousness of discipleship and the assurance offered through the Savior.

The believer's confidence rests upon Jesus Christ, not upon personal merit.

Bible References:

- John 5:24
- John 10:27–29
- Romans 5:1–11
- Romans 8:1–4, 31–39
- Ephesians 2:8–10
- Hebrews 4:14–16

- Hebrews 7:25
- Hebrews 10:19–23
- 1 John 2:1–2
- 1 John 5:11–13

Pastoral Note:

The doctrine of judgment should encourage faithfulness without undermining the Gospel's assurance. Christian hope is grounded in the righteousness and intercession of Jesus Christ.

Question 14 — What Is the Relationship Between Christ's Heavenly Ministry and the Close of Probation?

Answer:

The Bible teaches that the present life is a time in which humanity is called to respond to God's grace.

Jesus and the apostles proclaimed repentance and faith.

The New Testament also describes a future judgment and the final appearing of Christ.

Revelation 22 contains a solemn declaration concerning the condition of the unjust and the righteous, followed by Christ's announcement that He is coming.

In Seventh-day Adventist theology, the close of probation refers to the point at which the opportunity for humanity to change its final allegiance comes to an end before the Second Coming.

Adventists connect this concept with the completion of Christ's heavenly ministry, the final judgment, and the events described in Revelation.

However, the expression close of probation is a theological term rather than a direct biblical phrase.

Scripture does not provide a precise date for such an event.

Nor does it authorize human beings to determine the moment at which a particular person's opportunity for salvation has ended.

The appropriate Christian response is to accept God's grace today and remain faithful to Jesus Christ.

The doctrine should encourage spiritual readiness rather than speculation about hidden heavenly decisions.

Bible References:

- Isaiah 55:6–7
- Matthew 24:36–44
- Luke 13:22–30
- 2 Corinthians 6:1–2
- Hebrews 3:7–15
- Hebrews 9:27–28
- Revelation 15:5–8
- Revelation 22:11–12

Doctrinal Note:

The close of probation is an Adventist eschatological concept developed from several biblical passages. The exact timing is not revealed, and the doctrine must not be used to declare that specific living individuals are beyond God's mercy.

Question 15 — How Should the Heavenly Ministry of Jesus Christ Influence Christian Life Today?

Answer:

The heavenly ministry of Jesus Christ provides assurance that the risen Savior remains actively involved in the salvation of His people.

He is not absent or indifferent.

The New Testament presents Him as the exalted Lord, the mediator of the new covenant, and the great High Priest.

Because of His saving work, believers are invited to approach God with confidence.

They are also called to persevere in faith, practice love, and live in obedience to God's Word.

The sanctuary doctrine should encourage prayer, repentance, gratitude, and a deeper understanding of Christ's sacrifice.

In Seventh-day Adventist theology, it also provides a framework for understanding the final judgment and the Church's prophetic mission.

However, prophetic chronology must never become more important than the person of Jesus Christ.

The purpose of biblical study is not merely to identify dates, symbols, or historical developments.

It is to know the Savior and respond to His grace.

Christians should therefore approach the sanctuary teachings with humility.

They should distinguish explicit biblical truths from theological interpretations and treat those who disagree with respect.

The central assurance is that Jesus Christ is able to save those who come to God through Him.

Bible References:

- John 14:1–6
- Romans 8:31–39
- 2 Corinthians 5:17–21
- Ephesians 2:8–10
- Hebrews 4:14–16
- Hebrews 7:25
- Hebrews 10:19–25
- Hebrews 12:1–3

- 1 John 2:1–2
- Revelation 14:6–12

Practical Note:

The study of the heavenly sanctuary should deepen confidence in Jesus Christ, encourage faithful Christian living, and strengthen hope in His promised return.

Chapter Summary

The sanctuary occupies an important place in the biblical revelation of God's saving purposes.

The earthly sanctuary provided Israel with a visible system of worship, sacrifice, priestly ministry, and instruction concerning holiness.

The New Testament presents Jesus Christ as the fulfillment of the sacrificial and priestly system.

His sacrifice was offered once for all.

He now ministers as the believer's great High Priest in heaven.

Seventh-day Adventist theology connects the heavenly sanctuary with Daniel 8:14, the year 1844, and the investigative judgment.

These distinctive interpretations must be distinguished from the explicit New Testament teaching concerning Christ's priesthood and intercession.

Our study enables us to retain the following teachings:

1. God commanded Moses to build a sanctuary as a sign of His desire to dwell among His people.

2. The earthly sanctuary included a courtyard, a Holy Place, and a Most Holy Place.

3. The sacrificial system taught the seriousness of sin and anticipated the sacrifice of Jesus Christ.

4. The earthly priests and high priest performed ministries that pointed toward greater realities fulfilled in Christ.

5. The New Testament teaches that Jesus Christ ministers in heaven itself.

6. Jesus is the perfect and everlasting High Priest of His people.

7. Christ's intercession provides believers with continuing access to God's grace.

8. The Day of Atonement was an annual occasion of purification, repentance, and covenant restoration.

9. The sanctuary services find their decisive fulfillment in the sacrifice and priestly ministry of Jesus Christ.

10. Daniel 8:14 describes 2,300 evenings and mornings in connection with the sanctuary.

11. Seventh-day Adventists interpret the prophetic period as concluding in 1844.

12. The investigative judgment is a distinctive Adventist interpretation of the heavenly judgment passages.

13. The doctrine of judgment must remain consistent with salvation by grace and assurance through Jesus Christ.

14. Adventists understand the close of probation as the conclusion of humanity's opportunity to respond before Christ's return.

15. The heavenly ministry of Jesus should inspire faith, prayer, obedience, humility, and confidence in God's saving grace.

Doctrinal Conclusion

The heavenly sanctuary and the priestly ministry of Jesus Christ reveal the continuing significance of the plan of salvation.

The earthly sanctuary taught Israel about sin, holiness, sacrifice, mediation, and reconciliation.

Its ceremonies anticipated the saving work of Jesus Christ.

Through His death upon the cross, the Savior offered the perfect sacrifice.

Through His resurrection and ascension, He entered heaven as the victorious Lord and great High Priest.

The Epistle to the Hebrews emphasizes that His sacrifice is sufficient and His priesthood everlasting.

In Seventh-day Adventist theology, the sanctuary doctrine also provides a framework for understanding the final judgment and the prophetic mission of the Church.

The Earthly Sanctuary

God established the sanctuary as a place of worship and instruction concerning His covenant relationship with Israel.

The Sacrificial System

The sacrifices anticipated the saving work of Jesus Christ.

The Earthly Priesthood

The priests and high priest served as ministers within the covenant worship system.

The Heavenly Sanctuary

The New Testament presents Christ as ministering in the heavenly reality to which the earthly sanctuary pointed.

Jesus Christ as High Priest

The Savior possesses a perfect and enduring priesthood.

The Sufficiency of Christ's Sacrifice

Jesus offered Himself once for all, accomplishing the decisive work of atonement.

The Intercession of Christ

Believers have access to God's grace through the living Savior.

The Day of Atonement

The annual purification ceremonies provide important background for understanding biblical atonement.

The Prophecy of Daniel 8:14

The 2,300 evenings and mornings are interpreted differently among Christian traditions.

The Year 1844

Seventh-day Adventists understand 1844 as marking the beginning of the final phase of Christ's heavenly ministry.

The Investigative Judgment

Adventists teach that a pre-Advent judgment reveals the righteousness of God's decisions.

The Close of Probation

Adventist theology understands human history as moving toward the completion of Christ's heavenly ministry and the final resolution of the great controversy.

The Assurance of Salvation

The believer's confidence rests upon the grace, righteousness, sacrifice, and intercession of Jesus Christ.

The Christian's Responsibility

The sanctuary doctrine should encourage repentance, prayer, obedience, love, and faithful service.

The study of the sanctuary must never obscure the central message of the Gospel.

Jesus Christ is the Lamb of God.

He is the great High Priest.

He is the mediator of the new covenant.

He is the righteous Judge.

He is the coming King.

The heavenly sanctuary directs attention toward His completed sacrifice, His continuing ministry, and His final victory.

Although Christians differ concerning the interpretation of Daniel's prophetic chronology, the New Testament clearly teaches that Jesus Christ lives and intercedes for His people.

This truth provides a foundation for confidence, perseverance, and hope.

The Essential Message:

The Holy Scriptures teach that the earthly sanctuary and its priestly services pointed toward the saving work of Jesus Christ. Through His once-for-all sacrifice, the Savior accomplished the decisive work of atonement, and through His heavenly priesthood He continues to minister on behalf of believers. Seventh-day Adventist theology connects Daniel 8:14 with the year 1844 and understands that date as the beginning of the investigative or pre-Advent judgment. These chronological conclusions are distinctive interpretations that must be distinguished from the explicit biblical teaching concerning Christ's heavenly ministry. The central assurance remains unchanged: Jesus Christ is the perfect High Priest, the mediator of the new covenant, and the Savior who is able to save those who come to God through Him.

Personal Reflection Questions

1. Why did God command Moses to construct the earthly sanctuary?

2. What lessons concerning sin, forgiveness, holiness, and reconciliation were taught through the sacrificial system?

3. How does the Epistle to the Hebrews explain the superiority of Jesus Christ over the earthly priesthood?

4. Why is it important to understand that Christ's sacrifice was offered once for all?

5. What does the Bible explicitly teach concerning the heavenly sanctuary and Christ's intercession?

6. How did the Day of Atonement function within Israel's covenant worship?

7. What interpretive steps lead Seventh-day Adventists to connect Daniel 8:14 with the year 1844?

8. Why must the investigative judgment be distinguished from the explicit New Testament teaching concerning Christ's heavenly priesthood?

9. How can I maintain assurance of salvation while taking biblical warnings concerning judgment and perseverance seriously?

10. How should the heavenly ministry of Jesus Christ influence my prayer life, obedience, faith, and relationship with God?

Suggested Prayer

Lord my God,

I come before You with reverence, humility, and gratitude.

You are holy, righteous, merciful, and faithful.

Thank You for revealing Your saving purposes through the Holy Scriptures.

Thank You for the lessons taught through the earthly sanctuary.

Thank You for showing humanity the seriousness of sin and the greatness of Your mercy.

Above all, thank You for sending Jesus Christ into the world.

I acknowledge Him as the Lamb of God who takes away the sin of the world.

Thank You for His perfect life, His sacrifice upon the cross, and His glorious resurrection.

Thank You that His sacrifice was offered once for all.

I place my confidence not in my own righteousness but in His saving grace.

Thank You for revealing Jesus Christ as my great High Priest.

Thank You that He understands human weakness and temptation.

Thank You that He lives and intercedes for those who come to You through Him.

Help me approach Your throne of grace with confidence and humility.

Forgive my sins and cleanse my heart.

Strengthen my faith when I experience doubt.

Restore my hope when I become discouraged.

As I study the heavenly sanctuary, give me wisdom and understanding.

Teach me to examine the prophecies of Daniel and Revelation carefully.

Help me distinguish the clear teachings of Scripture from interpretations and human assumptions.

Protect me from pride, fear, speculation, and the temptation to judge others.

May the study of prophecy always lead me closer to Jesus Christ.

Help me understand the seriousness of divine judgment without losing confidence in Your mercy.

Teach me to live faithfully through the power of the Holy Spirit.

Give me a heart that loves Your commandments and delights in Your truth.

Help me practice justice, compassion, humility, and forgiveness.

May my faith be expressed through love and faithful service.

Thank You for the promise that Jesus Christ will return.

Thank You for the assurance that Your plan of redemption will be completed.

Prepare my heart for that glorious day.

Until then, help me remain steadfast in faith, constant in prayer, and completely dependent upon the grace of my Savior.

May my life bring honor and glory to Your holy name.

In the name of Jesus Christ, my great High Priest, Savior, and Lord.

Amen.

CHAPTER 40 — THE SEVEN LAST PLAGUES: GOD'S FINAL JUDGMENTS BEFORE THE SECOND COMING

A Thematic Bible Study — King James Version (KJV)

Opening Scripture

> “And I saw another sign in heaven, great and marvellous, seven angels having the seven last plagues; for in them is filled up the wrath of God.”

Revelation 15:1 — KJV

Introduction

The Holy Scriptures reveal that human history is moving toward the fulfillment of God's eternal purposes.

The Bible presents a world affected by sin, rebellion, injustice, suffering, and death. Yet it also announces that evil will not continue forever.

God has promised to bring the great controversy between good and evil to its conclusion.

The Book of Revelation describes this final victory through a series of prophetic visions involving heavenly worship, divine judgment, spiritual conflict, and the return of Jesus Christ.

Among its most solemn passages are Revelation chapters 15 and 16, which describe the seven last plagues.

These judgments are presented as the final outpouring of divine wrath upon a rebellious world.

They follow the prophetic warnings associated with the Three Angels' Messages and are closely connected with the conflict over worship and allegiance described in Revelation 13 and 14.

The first plague affects those who bear the mark of the beast and worship its image.

The second and third plagues involve the sea and the waters.

The fourth plague concerns the sun.

The fifth brings darkness upon the kingdom of the beast.

The sixth describes the drying up of the Euphrates, the gathering of the kings of the earth, and the place called Armageddon.

The seventh culminates in a great earthquake, the fall of Babylon, and extraordinary disturbances in the natural world.

These visions raise important questions.

Why does God permit such judgments?

Are the plagues literal, symbolic, or a combination of both?

When will they occur?

Will God's faithful people suffer during this period?

What does the drying up of the Euphrates mean?

Who are the kings of the east?

What is Armageddon?

How are the plagues connected with the fall of Babylon?

And what relationship do they have to the Second Coming of Jesus Christ?

Seventh-day Adventist theology interprets the seven last plagues as future judgments occurring after the close of human probation and before the visible return of Christ.

Adventists understand the plagues as demonstrating the consequences of humanity's final rebellion against God.

They also teach that God's faithful people will be preserved through this period, although they may experience persecution, hardship, and distress.

This interpretation is connected with the Adventist understanding of the heavenly sanctuary, the investigative judgment, the Three Angels' Messages, and the final conflict over worship.

However, not all Christian traditions interpret Revelation 15 and 16 in the same way.

Some understand the plagues primarily as future literal judgments.

Others interpret them symbolically as manifestations of divine judgment throughout history.

Still others connect them with events surrounding the Roman Empire or understand them as recurring patterns culminating in the final judgment.

A careful Bible study must therefore distinguish between the explicit statements of Revelation and the theological conclusions drawn from them.

It must also avoid sensationalism, unsupported predictions, and attempts to identify every prophetic symbol with a contemporary political event.

The central purpose of these passages is not to encourage fear or speculation.

It is to reveal the seriousness of rebellion against God, the righteousness of divine judgment, the necessity of faithfulness, and the certainty of Christ's final victory.

This chapter examines fifteen questions concerning the seven last plagues, their biblical meaning, and their significance for Christian faith.

Question 1 — What Are the Seven Last Plagues, and Where Are They Described?

Answer:

The seven last plagues are described principally in Revelation chapters 15 and 16.

Revelation 15 introduces seven angels who possess the seven last plagues.

Revelation 16 describes the successive pouring out of seven bowls or vials containing the wrath of God.

The judgments affect different aspects of the created world and the rebellious powers opposing God.

The seven plagues are presented in the following sequence:

1. A grievous sore upon those who have the mark of the beast and worship its image.

2. The sea becoming as the blood of a dead man.

3. The rivers and fountains of waters becoming blood.

4. The sun scorching people with great heat.

5. Darkness upon the seat or kingdom of the beast.

6. The drying up of the Euphrates and the gathering associated with Armageddon.

7. A heavenly declaration of completion, accompanied by a great earthquake, the judgment of Babylon, and destructive hail.

The expression last plagues indicates their relationship to the completion of divine wrath.

In Seventh-day Adventist interpretation, they constitute a final series of judgments immediately preceding Christ's return.

However, Revelation does not provide a calendar date for their beginning.

The passage should be studied within the broader structure of the book rather than treated as an isolated prediction.

Bible References:

- Exodus 7:14–25
- Exodus 9:8–12
- Revelation 14:9–12
- Revelation 15:1–8
- Revelation 16:1–21
- Revelation 19:11–21

Doctrinal Note:

The existence and sequence of the seven plagues are explicit in Revelation 15–16. Their precise chronology in relation to other end-time events is a matter of interpretation.

Question 2 — Why Are These Judgments Called the Last Plagues?

Answer:

Revelation 15:1 identifies the plagues as the last because the wrath of God is completed in them.

The description indicates a climactic expression of divine judgment.

Throughout Scripture, God is portrayed as patient and merciful.

He repeatedly calls humanity to repentance.

The prophets warned Israel and the surrounding nations before announcing judgment.

Jesus also called people to repentance and faith.

The Book of Revelation itself contains appeals to worship God, reject deception, and remain faithful to Jesus Christ.

The seven last plagues appear after these solemn warnings within the book's prophetic presentation.

In Seventh-day Adventist theology, they are understood as the final judgments upon those who persistently reject God's grace and align themselves with the powers opposed to Him.

Their designation as last distinguishes them from earlier judgments and emphasizes the approaching completion of the conflict.

However, the term does not by itself explain every detail of their timing or physical nature.

The central teaching is that divine judgment will bring the reign of evil to an end.

Bible References:

- Exodus 34:6–7
- Ezekiel 18:23, 30–32
- Romans 2:4–11
- 2 Peter 3:9–13
- Revelation 14:6–12
- Revelation 15:1
- Revelation 16:1
- Revelation 21:1–5

Contextual Note:

The finality of these judgments should be understood alongside the Bible's repeated emphasis upon God's patience and desire for repentance.

Question 3 — What Does the Bible Mean by the Wrath of God?

Answer:

The wrath of God is a biblical expression associated with His righteous opposition to sin, evil, injustice, and rebellion.

Divine wrath should not be confused with uncontrolled human anger.

The Scriptures portray God as holy, just, merciful, and patient.

His judgments are not arbitrary expressions of cruelty.

They reveal His opposition to evil and His commitment to righteousness.

Romans teaches that God's wrath is revealed against ungodliness and unrighteousness.

Revelation presents heavenly voices affirming the justice of God's judgments.

At the same time, the Bible teaches that God takes no pleasure in the death of the wicked.

He calls people to turn from evil and live.

In Seventh-day Adventist theology, divine wrath is understood within the larger conflict between Christ and Satan.

God's final judgments expose the consequences of rebellion and bring evil to its conclusion.

However, Christians differ concerning the precise relationship between divine action, permitted consequences, and the symbolic imagery of judgment.

The central biblical truth is that God judges with righteousness and remains consistent with His holy character.

Bible References:

- Exodus 34:6–7
- Psalm 103:8–13
- Ezekiel 18:23, 32
- Romans 1:18–25
- Romans 2:5–11
- Revelation 15:3–4
- Revelation 16:5–7

- Revelation 19:1–2

Doctrinal Note:

Divine wrath must be interpreted in harmony with God's justice, holiness, mercy, and love. It should not be represented as irrational anger or pleasure in human suffering.

Question 4 — When Will the Seven Last Plagues Occur?

Answer:

Revelation 15 and 16 present the plagues within the book's visions of final judgment.

Their relationship to the preceding chapters is significant.

Revelation 14 contains the Three Angels' Messages, including warnings against the beast and its mark.

Revelation 15 introduces those who have obtained victory over the beast, its image, and the number of its name.

The plagues then fall upon the rebellious world.

In Seventh-day Adventist theology, this sequence is understood to indicate that the plagues occur after the final decision of humanity concerning allegiance to God.

Adventists connect this period with the close of probation, understood as the conclusion of Christ's intercessory ministry before His return.

According to this interpretation, the plagues precede the visible Second Coming.

However, Revelation does not explicitly use the phrase close of probation in chapters 15 or 16.

Nor does it provide a date for the beginning of the plagues.

Other Christian interpretations differ concerning their chronological placement.

The essential biblical message is that divine judgment is certain and that believers should remain spiritually prepared.

Bible References:

- Matthew 24:36–44
- Hebrews 9:27–28
- Revelation 14:6–20
- Revelation 15:1–8
- Revelation 16:1–21
- Revelation 19:11–21
- Revelation 22:11–12

Prophetic Note:

The placement of the plagues after the close of probation is a characteristic Adventist interpretation. Scripture does not authorize predictions of the date when these judgments will begin.

Question 5 — What Is the First Plague, and Who Is Affected by It?

Answer:

The first plague is described in Revelation 16:2.

It consists of a grievous and painful sore affecting those who have the mark of the beast and worship its image.

The language recalls the plague of boils that afflicted Egypt during the Exodus.

The first plague is directly connected with the conflict over worship described in Revelation 13 and 14.

Those affected are identified through their allegiance to the beast.

In Seventh-day Adventist theology, this judgment is understood as falling upon those who have knowingly chosen the authority represented by the beast in the final conflict.

Adventists interpret the mark of the beast within their broader prophetic understanding of enforced religious observance.

However, Revelation 16:2 does not identify a particular modern denomination, medical condition, or contemporary population.

The nature of the sore is not explained in medical terms.

It would therefore be inappropriate to identify present-day diseases as the first plague without compelling biblical grounds.

The central message is that allegiance to powers opposed to God carries serious consequences.

Bible References:

- Exodus 9:8–12
- Deuteronomy 28:27, 35
- Revelation 13:11–18
- Revelation 14:9–12
- Revelation 16:1–2

Doctrinal Note:

The first plague is explicitly directed against those associated with the beast's mark and worship. Identifying the mark with particular future religious legislation belongs to Adventist prophetic interpretation.

Question 6 — What Happens During the Second and Third Plagues?

Answer:

The second plague affects the sea.

Revelation describes the sea becoming as the blood of a dead man, with living creatures in the sea dying.

The third plague affects the rivers and fountains of waters.

These waters also become blood.

The imagery recalls the transformation of the waters of Egypt during the ministry of Moses.

In Revelation, the judgments affect essential sources of life and sustenance.

Water is necessary for human survival and the existence of living creatures.

The imagery therefore communicates the severity of divine judgment.

After the third plague, Revelation records a heavenly declaration affirming the righteousness of God.

The judgment is connected with the shedding of the blood of saints and prophets.

This connection emphasizes divine justice in response to persecution.

Seventh-day Adventists generally understand these plagues as future judgments with real consequences for the earth.

However, the text does not explain the physical mechanisms involved.

Some interpreters regard the blood imagery as symbolic.

Others understand it as describing literal transformations.

The central theological emphasis is that God judges the persecution of His people and vindicates His righteousness.

Bible References:

- Exodus 7:14–25
- Psalm 78:43–44
- Isaiah 49:25–26
- Revelation 6:9–11
- Revelation 16:3–7
- Revelation 18:20–24

Contextual Note:

The second and third plagues use imagery associated with the Exodus. The degree to which these descriptions are literal or symbolic is debated among Christian interpreters.

Question 7 — What Is the Meaning of the Fourth Plague Involving the Sun?

Answer:

The fourth plague is described in Revelation 16:8–9.

The fourth angel pours out his vial upon the sun.

The sun is given power to scorch people with fire.

The passage emphasizes the intensity of the suffering.

It also records the response of those affected.

Instead of repenting and giving glory to God, they blaspheme His name.

This response is an important part of the vision.

The judgment reveals the continuing rebellion of those who have rejected divine authority.

The imagery also recalls biblical passages in which the sun is associated with divine judgment and cosmic disturbance.

In Seventh-day Adventist interpretation, the fourth plague is understood as a future judgment occurring during the final crisis.

However, Revelation does not identify the plague with any particular modern environmental event.

The text should not be used to claim that an ordinary heat wave, solar disturbance, or climate event is necessarily the fulfillment of this prophecy.

The central lesson is the seriousness of persistent rebellion against God.

Bible References:

- Deuteronomy 28:22
- Isaiah 24:4–6
- Malachi 4:1–2
- Luke 21:25–28
- Revelation 8:12
- Revelation 16:8–9

Practical Note:

The fourth plague should not be used to dismiss contemporary environmental concerns or to interpret every natural disaster as a direct act of divine punishment.

Question 8 — What Is the Fifth Plague, and Why Does Darkness Fall Upon the Beast's Kingdom?

Answer:

The fifth plague is described in Revelation 16:10–11.

The fifth angel pours out his vial upon the seat of the beast.

The beast's kingdom becomes full of darkness.

Those affected experience suffering and continue to blaspheme God.

The imagery recalls the plague of darkness that fell upon Egypt before the Exodus.

In Revelation, darkness may also communicate judgment, confusion, and the collapse of apparent authority.

The plague is directed specifically toward the kingdom of the beast.

This connects the judgment with the religious and political opposition to God described earlier in Revelation.

In Seventh-day Adventist theology, the fifth plague is understood as exposing the powerlessness of the final rebellious system.

The authority that demanded worship is unable to protect its followers from divine judgment.

However, Revelation does not explain whether the darkness is entirely physical, symbolic, or both.

The central teaching is that powers opposed to God cannot provide ultimate security.

Bible References:

- Exodus 10:21–23
- Isaiah 8:19–22
- Joel 2:1–2
- Matthew 24:29
- Revelation 13:1–18
- Revelation 16:10–11

Doctrinal Note:

The darkness upon the beast's kingdom signifies divine judgment against the power opposing God. Its precise physical nature is not fully explained in the text.

Question 9 — What Does the Drying Up of the Euphrates Mean in the Sixth Plague?

Answer:

Revelation 16:12 describes the sixth angel pouring out his vial upon the great river Euphrates.

The water of the river is dried up to prepare the way for the kings of the east.

The Euphrates held major historical significance in the ancient Near East.

It was associated with Mesopotamia and the territory of Babylon.

The Old Testament describes the fall of Babylon within a historical context involving the power of the Medes and Persians.

Revelation uses Babylonian imagery extensively to describe the final opposition to God.

In Seventh-day Adventist theology, the drying up of the Euphrates is commonly interpreted symbolically.

Adventists understand it as representing the withdrawal of support from end-time Babylon.

Within this interpretation, the nations and peoples that supported the rebellious religious system eventually recognize its deception.

However, Revelation 16:12 does not explicitly define the Euphrates as the withdrawal of popular support.

That conclusion is drawn through comparison with Revelation 17:15–17 and the historical background of Babylon.

Other Christian traditions interpret the river literally or connect it with future military events.

The passage should therefore be studied with attention to its symbolism and historical background.

Bible References:

- Isaiah 44:27–28
- Isaiah 45:1–3
- Jeremiah 50:33–38
- Jeremiah 51:36
- Daniel 5:1–31
- Revelation 16:12
- Revelation 17:15–17

Historical and Prophetic Note:

The Adventist interpretation of the Euphrates as the withdrawal of support from Babylon is a symbolic reading. The text itself describes

the drying of the river and preparation for the kings of the east.

Question 10 — Who Are the Kings of the East?

Answer:

Revelation 16:12 refers to the kings of the east.

The King James Version uses the expression the kings of the east, while the underlying Greek refers to the direction of the rising of the sun.

The passage does not explicitly identify these kings by name.

In the Old Testament, eastern rulers played an important role in the fall of ancient Babylon.

Cyrus, king of Persia, was described as an instrument of God's purposes.

Some Christian interpreters understand the kings of the east in Revelation as future political or military powers.

Others interpret the expression symbolically.

In Seventh-day Adventist theology, the kings of the east are frequently associated with the deliverance brought by Jesus Christ and the heavenly powers accompanying Him.

This interpretation draws upon the historical deliverance from Babylon and the imagery of Christ's return.

However, Revelation 16:12 does not explicitly identify the kings as Jesus and His angels.

The interpretation therefore requires careful comparison with other passages.

The central lesson is that the final power of Babylon will not prevent the fulfillment of God's saving purposes.

Bible References:

- Isaiah 41:2–4

- Isaiah 44:28
- Isaiah 45:1–7
- Daniel 5:28–31
- Matthew 24:27
- Revelation 16:12
- Revelation 19:11–16

Prophetic Note:

The identification of the kings of the east with Christ and the heavenly armies is an Adventist interpretive tradition, not an explicit definition in Revelation 16.

Question 11 — What Is Armageddon, and What Does the Bible Reveal About the Final Battle?

Answer:

Revelation 16:16 identifies the gathering place of the kings as Armageddon.

The name appears only once in the Bible.

Its precise linguistic derivation has been debated.

A common explanation connects it with the Hebrew expression meaning mountain of Megiddo.

Megiddo was an important location in ancient Israel associated with military conflicts.

However, the historical city of Megiddo was situated near a plain rather than upon a prominent mountain bearing that name.

This has led scholars to propose different explanations of the symbolism.

Revelation 16 describes unclean spirits gathering the kings of the earth to the battle of the great day of God Almighty.

The conflict is therefore presented as more than an ordinary military confrontation.

It involves deception, allegiance, and opposition to God.

In Seventh-day Adventist theology, Armageddon represents the final worldwide conflict between the powers of evil and the kingdom of God.

Adventists generally emphasize its spiritual and cosmic dimensions rather than restricting it to a conventional battle in the Middle East.

Other Christian traditions interpret the event differently, including literal geographical and military scenarios.

The passage's central assurance is that God's final victory is certain.

Bible References:

- Judges 5:19–21
- 2 Kings 23:29–30
- Zechariah 12:9–11
- Joel 3:9–16
- Revelation 16:13–16
- Revelation 17:12–14
- Revelation 19:11–21

Linguistic and Prophetic Note:

The exact origin and meaning of Armageddon remain debated. Revelation emphasizes the gathering of rebellious powers for divine judgment rather than providing a detailed modern military map.

Question 12 — Who Are the Three Unclean Spirits Like Frogs?

Answer:

Revelation 16:13–14 describes three unclean spirits like frogs emerging from the mouths of the dragon, the beast, and the false prophet.

The passage identifies them as spirits of devils working miracles.

Their purpose is to gather the kings of the earth and the whole world to the final battle.

The imagery emphasizes deception and the use of supernatural signs to influence humanity.

The dragon is explicitly identified elsewhere in Revelation as Satan.

The beast and false prophet are associated with the powers opposing God in the book's prophetic visions.

In Seventh-day Adventist theology, the three unclean spirits are commonly understood as representing a final worldwide deception involving spiritualism and the cooperation of religious and political powers.

Some Adventist interpretations associate the dragon, beast, and false prophet with distinct religious systems or movements.

However, Revelation 16 does not explicitly name modern denominations or political organizations in this passage.

Such identifications depend upon a broader prophetic framework.

The central biblical warning concerns deceptive spiritual influences that lead humanity into opposition against God.

Bible References:

- Exodus 8:1–15
- Matthew 24:23–26

- 2 Corinthians 11:13–15
- 2 Thessalonians 2:8–12
- 1 Timothy 4:1–2
- Revelation 12:9
- Revelation 13:11–15
- Revelation 16:13–14

Doctrinal Note:

The passage explicitly describes demonic deception and the gathering of the world's rulers. Specific identifications of the three powers with contemporary religious institutions are interpretive conclusions.

Question 13 — What Happens During the Seventh and Final Plague?

Answer:

The seventh plague is described in Revelation 16:17–21.

The seventh angel pours out his vial into the air.

A great voice comes from the heavenly temple and declares:

> “It is done.”

The passage then describes extraordinary disturbances.

There are voices, thunderings, and lightnings.

A great earthquake occurs.

The great city is divided, and the cities of the nations fall.

Babylon comes into remembrance before God and receives the cup of His judgment.

The islands flee away, the mountains are not found, and great hail falls upon humanity.

These images communicate the overwhelming and climactic character of divine judgment.

The declaration It is done emphasizes the completion of God's purposes within the vision.

In Seventh-day Adventist theology, the seventh plague is understood as immediately preceding or accompanying the final deliverance of God's people and the visible return of Christ.

However, Revelation 16 does not provide a complete chronological explanation of every event.

Its imagery should be compared carefully with the Second Coming scenes elsewhere in Revelation.

The essential teaching is that the rebellious world order will not endure.

God's judgment will bring the power of Babylon to its conclusion.

Bible References:

- Isaiah 24:17–23
- Haggai 2:6–7
- Matthew 24:29–31
- Revelation 6:12–17
- Revelation 16:17–21
- Revelation 18:1–24
- Revelation 19:11–21

Prophetic Note:

The seventh plague is explicitly described as a climactic judgment. Its detailed relationship to the visible appearing of Christ is interpreted differently among Christian traditions.

Question 14 — Will God's Faithful People Be Protected During the Seven Last Plagues?

Answer:

The Bible contains many promises concerning God's care for His people during periods of danger and suffering.

Psalm 91 describes divine protection amid pestilence and destruction.

The Book of Daniel recounts God's preservation of faithful believers during severe trials.

Revelation describes servants of God receiving His seal.

It also portrays those who overcome the beast standing in victory before God.

In Seventh-day Adventist theology, these passages support the belief that God's faithful people will be preserved through the seven last plagues.

Adventists understand the final crisis as a period of extraordinary distress in which believers may experience persecution, hardship, and threats to their lives.

However, they teach that the plagues themselves are directed against the rebellious powers and their followers.

The Bible does not explicitly provide a detailed account of how every faithful believer will experience each plague.

Nor should promises of divine protection be interpreted as guarantees that Christians will never experience suffering in the present world.

The New Testament repeatedly acknowledges that faithful believers may face persecution.

The central assurance is that God will not abandon His people and that their final salvation is secure through Jesus Christ.

Bible References:

- Psalm 46:1–11
- Psalm 91:1–16
- Isaiah 33:15–17
- Daniel 3:16–28
- Daniel 12:1–3
- Matthew 24:21–22
- Revelation 7:1–4
- Revelation 15:2–4
- Revelation 16:1–21

Pastoral Note:

The promise of God's final deliverance should strengthen trust without encouraging reckless behavior or the assumption that every present hardship is evidence of divine displeasure.

Question 15 — How Should Christians Prepare for the Final Judgments and the Return of Jesus Christ?

Answer:

Jesus repeatedly called His followers to remain watchful and spiritually prepared.

He warned against attempts to predict the exact time of His return.

The New Testament teaches that readiness involves faith, repentance, perseverance, holiness, and love.

Christians are called to trust in the saving grace of Jesus Christ.

They are also called to remain faithful to God's Word and resist deception.

In Seventh-day Adventist theology, preparation for the final crisis includes understanding the Three Angels' Messages, keeping God's commandments, maintaining faith in Jesus Christ, and depending upon the Holy Spirit.

However, spiritual preparation must not be confused with fear-driven speculation.

The Bible does not command believers to identify every current disaster as a prophetic fulfillment.

Nor does it encourage withdrawal from responsibilities toward family, community, or society.

Christian readiness includes compassionate service, honest conduct, prayer, Bible study, and respect for others.

The believer's ultimate security is not found in perfect knowledge of prophetic events.

It is found in Jesus Christ.

The final judgments remind humanity that history is accountable to God and that His kingdom will prevail.

Bible References:

- Micah 6:8
- Matthew 24:36–44
- Matthew 25:1–13
- Luke 21:34–36
- Romans 13:11–14
- Ephesians 6:10–18
- 1 Thessalonians 5:1–11
- 2 Peter 3:10–14
- Revelation 14:12
- Revelation 16:15
- Revelation 22:12–17

Practical Note:

Preparation for Christ's return is primarily spiritual and ethical. It involves trust in His grace, faithful discipleship, and loving service rather than attempts to predict dates or interpret every crisis as a prophetic sign.

Chapter Summary

The seven last plagues are described in Revelation chapters 15 and 16.

They represent a climactic series of divine judgments associated with the final conflict between God and the powers of evil.

The visions employ imagery recalling the plagues of Egypt and the prophetic judgments of the Old Testament.

In Seventh-day Adventist theology, the plagues are understood as future judgments occurring after the close of probation and before the visible return of Jesus Christ.

They reveal the consequences of humanity's final rebellion and demonstrate the righteousness of God.

The chapter also emphasizes divine protection, the danger of spiritual deception, and the certainty of Christ's victory.

Our study enables us to retain the following teachings:

1. The seven last plagues are described principally in Revelation 15 and 16.

2. They are called the last plagues because they complete the outpouring of divine wrath within Revelation's vision.

3. The wrath of God expresses His righteous opposition to evil and must be understood in harmony with His justice and mercy.

4. Seventh-day Adventists understand the plagues as occurring after the close of probation and before the Second Coming.

5. The first plague affects those who have the mark of the beast and worship its image.

6. The second and third plagues affect the sea, rivers, and fountains of waters.

7. The fourth plague involves the sun scorching humanity with great heat.

8. The fifth plague brings darkness upon the kingdom of the beast.

9. The sixth plague describes the drying up of the Euphrates, interpreted symbolically in Adventist theology.

10. The kings of the east are associated in some Adventist interpretations with divine deliverance through Jesus Christ.

11. Armageddon represents the gathering of rebellious powers for the final conflict and judgment.

12. The three unclean spirits symbolize demonic deception influencing the rulers of the earth.

13. The seventh plague announces the completion of judgment and the collapse of Babylon's power.

14. Adventists understand God's faithful people as ultimately protected and delivered during the final crisis.

15. Christians should prepare through faith in Jesus Christ, prayer, obedience, perseverance, humility, and loving service.

Doctrinal Conclusion

The seven last plagues reveal the solemn reality of divine judgment and the certainty of God's final victory over evil.

The Bible presents a world in which humanity has repeatedly resisted divine truth.

Yet throughout history, God has extended mercy and called people to repentance.

The Book of Revelation continues this appeal through the everlasting Gospel and the Three Angels' Messages.

The seven last plagues appear within the prophetic presentation of the final consequences of rebellion against God.

In Seventh-day Adventist theology, these judgments form an important part of the events immediately preceding the Second Coming of Jesus Christ.

The Righteousness of God

Divine judgment reveals God's opposition to evil and His commitment to justice.

The Completion of Divine Wrath

The seven plagues represent the final outpouring of judgment within Revelation's prophetic vision.

The First Plague

A grievous sore affects those associated with the beast's mark and worship.

The Second and Third Plagues

The sea and sources of fresh water are affected by judgments described through the imagery of blood.

The Fourth Plague

The sun becomes an instrument of severe judgment.

The Fifth Plague

Darkness falls upon the kingdom of the beast, revealing the vulnerability of rebellious authority.

The Sixth Plague

The Euphrates is dried up, and the powers of the earth are gathered for the final conflict.

Armageddon

The final gathering reveals the opposition of rebellious powers to God and His purposes.

Spiritual Deception

The three unclean spirits demonstrate the danger of deceptive supernatural influences.

The Seventh Plague

The final judgment is accompanied by extraordinary disturbances and the fall of Babylon.

The Protection of God's People

Adventist theology emphasizes God's preservation and ultimate deliverance of those who remain faithful to Him.

The Return of Jesus Christ

The final judgments are connected with the approaching fulfillment of Christ's promised victory.

The Christian's Preparation

Believers are called to faith, repentance, obedience, spiritual vigilance, and love.

The Centrality of the Gospel

The study of final judgment must remain grounded in salvation through Jesus Christ.

The seven last plagues should never be presented merely as a collection of terrifying events.

They belong to Revelation's larger proclamation of God's justice, mercy, and ultimate victory.

Their purpose is not to encourage speculation about contemporary disasters or political developments.

They remind humanity that evil will not continue indefinitely.

God's judgments are righteous.

His promises are trustworthy.

His people are called to remain faithful.

And Jesus Christ will establish His everlasting kingdom.

The Essential Message:

The Holy Scriptures describe seven last plagues in Revelation 15 and 16 as climactic judgments associated with the final defeat of evil. These judgments affect those aligned with the rebellious powers represented by the beast and Babylon. Seventh-day Adventist theology understands the plagues as future events occurring after the close of probation and before the visible return of Jesus Christ. The sixth plague is connected with the gathering at Armageddon, while the seventh announces the completion of judgment and the fall of Babylon. Although Christians differ concerning the literal, symbolic, and chronological interpretation of these visions, the central biblical message is clear: God will judge evil righteously, preserve the ultimate hope of His faithful people, and bring His saving purposes to completion through Jesus Christ.

Personal Reflection Questions

1. What does Revelation 15 teach about the character and purpose of the seven last plagues?

2. How can I understand the wrath of God in harmony with His justice, mercy, and love?

3. Why is it important to distinguish the explicit biblical description of the plagues from interpretations concerning their timing?

4. What relationship exists between the first plague and the conflict over worship described in Revelation 13 and 14?

5. What lessons can be learned from the similarities between the plagues of Egypt and the seven last plagues?

6. Why should I avoid identifying contemporary natural disasters as specific prophetic fulfillments without sufficient biblical evidence?

7. What does the sixth plague teach about deception, human allegiance, and the final conflict?

8. How should I understand Armageddon without reducing it to unsupported political or military predictions?

9. What promises of divine faithfulness can strengthen believers during times of persecution and suffering?

10. How can I prepare for the return of Jesus Christ through faith, prayer, obedience, humility, and loving service?

Suggested Prayer

Lord my God,

I come before You with reverence, humility, and gratitude.

You are the Creator of heaven and earth.

You are holy, righteous, merciful, and faithful.

Your judgments are true, and Your love endures forever.

Thank You for revealing Your purposes through the Holy Scriptures.

Thank You for warning humanity about the consequences of sin and rebellion.

Above all, thank You for sending Jesus Christ into the world to save sinners.

I acknowledge that my salvation rests entirely upon His grace and saving work.

Thank You for His sacrifice upon the cross, His resurrection, and His continuing ministry as my heavenly High Priest.

As I study the seven last plagues, give me wisdom and understanding.

Help me interpret the prophecies of Revelation carefully and faithfully.

Teach me to distinguish the clear teachings of Your Word from speculation and human assumptions.

Protect me from fear, sensationalism, and spiritual pride.

May the study of divine judgment lead me toward repentance and a deeper relationship with Jesus Christ.

Help me understand Your righteousness without forgetting Your mercy.

Teach me to trust Your character even when I cannot fully understand Your judgments.

Strengthen my faith during times of uncertainty.

When I witness suffering and injustice in the world, remind me that You have not abandoned humanity.

Give me compassion for those who suffer.

Help me comfort the discouraged, assist the vulnerable, and serve those in need.

May I never use biblical prophecy to frighten, condemn, or mistreat others.

Instead, teach me to proclaim Your truth with humility, kindness, and love.

Protect my heart from spiritual deception.

Help me remain faithful to Your commandments through the power of the Holy Spirit.

Strengthen my confidence in Jesus Christ.

When difficulties arise, remind me that my security is found in Him.

Prepare my heart for His glorious return.

Help me live each day with spiritual vigilance, integrity, patience, and hope.

Thank You for the promise that evil will not reign forever.

Thank You for the assurance that Your kingdom will triumph.

Thank You for the glorious hope of the new heaven and the new earth.

Until that day, help me remain faithful to the everlasting Gospel.

May my life bring honor and glory to Your holy name.

In the name of Jesus Christ, my Savior, High Priest, and coming King.

Amen.

CHAPTER 41 — THE TIME OF TROUBLE AND GOD'S FINAL DELIVERANCE: HOW WILL THE FAITHFUL STAND IN THE LAST CRISIS?

A Thematic Bible Study — King James Version (KJV)

Opening Scripture

> “And at that time shall Michael stand up, the great prince which standeth for the children of thy people: and there shall be a time of trouble, such as never was since there was a nation even to that same time: and at that time thy people shall be delivered, every one that shall be found written in the book.”

Daniel 12:1 — KJV

Introduction

The Bible presents human history as a conflict between the purposes of God and the rebellion of evil.

Throughout Scripture, God's people encounter trials, persecution, uncertainty, and suffering.

Noah lived during a time of widespread corruption. Israel experienced oppression in Egypt. Daniel and his companions faced threats because of their loyalty to God. The early Christians endured persecution because of their faith in Jesus Christ.

Yet the biblical testimony repeatedly reveals that God remains faithful to His people.

He does not promise that believers will never experience suffering.

He promises that His saving purposes will ultimately prevail.

The prophetic books of Daniel and Revelation describe a final period of extraordinary distress associated with the culmination of the conflict between good and evil.

Daniel 12:1 announces a time of trouble unlike any previously experienced.

Jesus also speaks of great tribulation in His prophetic discourse.

Revelation describes a conflict involving worship, deception, persecution, divine judgment, and the final deliverance of God's people.

These passages have particular importance in Seventh-day Adventist theology.

Adventists understand the final time of trouble as a future period occurring near the conclusion of human history.

Their interpretation distinguishes between a broader final crisis involving persecution and a particularly severe period following the close of probation.

This latter period is often associated with the expression the time of Jacob's trouble, drawn from Jeremiah 30:7.

According to Adventist theology, God's faithful people will experience profound distress, but they will not be abandoned by their Savior.

The final crisis will reveal the difference between outward religious profession and genuine faith in Jesus Christ.

However, the Bible does not present every detail of this future period in a single chronological narrative.

The Adventist understanding is developed by combining passages from Daniel, Jeremiah, Matthew, Revelation, and other biblical books.

Other Christian traditions interpret these passages differently.

Some connect the great tribulation primarily with events surrounding the destruction of Jerusalem in AD 70.

Others understand it as a future period of intense persecution.

Still others interpret the language as describing recurring suffering throughout the history of the Church.

A responsible study must therefore distinguish between explicit biblical statements and theological interpretations of their timing and fulfillment.

It is also essential to recognize the pastoral purpose of biblical prophecy.

God does not reveal the certainty of His victory to produce panic among believers.

He calls His people to trust Him.

Christian preparation for the final crisis does not consist primarily of accumulating information about political events or attempting to predict dates.

It consists of developing a living relationship with Jesus Christ, studying His Word, practicing obedience through faith, and cultivating a character shaped by the Holy Spirit.

The final hope of God's people is not their own strength.

It is the faithfulness of their Redeemer.

This chapter examines fifteen questions concerning the final time of trouble, the experience of God's faithful people, the meaning of Jacob's trouble, divine protection, and the promised deliverance through Jesus Christ.

Question 1 — What Does the Bible Mean by the Time of Trouble?

Answer:

The expression time of trouble appears in Daniel 12:1.

The prophet describes a period of extraordinary distress associated with the intervention of Michael and the deliverance of God's people.

The passage emphasizes both the severity of the crisis and the certainty of divine deliverance.

The Hebrew Scriptures frequently describe trouble as a time of distress, oppression, danger, or anguish.

However, Daniel 12:1 presents a crisis of exceptional significance.

Its context includes the conclusion of prophetic conflict and the promise of resurrection in Daniel 12:2.

This connection gives the passage an eschatological dimension.

In Seventh-day Adventist theology, the time of trouble is understood as a final crisis immediately preceding the Second Coming of Jesus Christ.

Adventists connect it with the conflict over worship described in Revelation 13 and 14.

They also distinguish the final period of distress from the ordinary suffering experienced by Christians throughout history.

However, Daniel 12:1 does not provide a complete chronological sequence of the events involved.

The central teaching is that God's people may face severe opposition, but their ultimate deliverance rests in His power.

Bible References:

- Psalm 46:1–3
- Jeremiah 30:5–7

- Daniel 12:1–3
- Matthew 24:21–22
- Revelation 7:13–17
- Revelation 13:11–17

Doctrinal Note:

The extraordinary time of trouble is explicitly described in Daniel 12:1. Its detailed placement within an Adventist end-time chronology is a theological interpretation.

Question 2 — Who Is Michael, the Great Prince, Mentioned in Daniel 12:1?

Answer:

Daniel 12:1 identifies Michael as the great prince who stands for the children of God's people.

Michael also appears in Daniel 10, Jude, and Revelation 12.

In Daniel, he is associated with heavenly conflict and the defense of God's people.

Jude identifies Michael as the archangel.

Revelation describes Michael and his angels fighting against the dragon and his angels.

In Seventh-day Adventist theology, Michael is understood as a title or designation for Jesus Christ in His role as the heavenly commander and defender of God's people.

Adventists do not understand this identification to mean that Jesus is a created being.

They affirm His eternal deity.

The identification is based upon comparisons involving Michael's authority, heavenly leadership, and association with the resurrection and deliverance of God's people.

However, Scripture does not explicitly state that Michael is Jesus Christ.

Many Christian interpreters regard Michael as a distinct angelic being.

The Adventist identification is therefore a theological conclusion rather than an explicit biblical definition.

The essential message of Daniel 12:1 is that God's people are not left without heavenly defense.

Bible References:

- Daniel 10:13, 21
- Daniel 12:1–2
- John 5:25–29
- 1 Thessalonians 4:16–17
- Jude 1:9
- Revelation 12:7–12

Doctrinal Note:

The identification of Michael with Jesus Christ is characteristic of Adventist interpretation. The passage itself identifies Michael as the great prince who stands for God's people.

Question 3 — How Is the Time of Trouble Connected With the Great Tribulation Described by Jesus?

Answer:

In Matthew 24, Jesus warns His disciples concerning coming deception, persecution, suffering, and great tribulation.

His discourse includes warnings related to the destruction of Jerusalem and descriptions associated with His future coming.

This combination has produced different interpretations of the chapter.

Some Christian scholars understand much of the discourse as referring to the events surrounding Jerusalem's destruction in AD 70.

Others interpret significant portions as referring to the final crisis before Christ's return.

Still others recognize both historical and future dimensions.

Seventh-day Adventists generally understand Matthew 24 as having an initial historical application and a broader prophetic significance for the end of human history.

They connect the great tribulation with the long history of persecution and the final crisis preceding Christ's return.

Daniel 12:1 and Matthew 24:21 share language emphasizing extraordinary distress.

However, their relationship must be studied within their respective contexts.

The central message of Jesus' teaching is that His followers should remain faithful, resist deception, and trust His promises.

Bible References:

- Daniel 12:1
- Matthew 24:4–14
- Matthew 24:15–22
- Matthew 24:23–31
- Luke 21:20–28
- John 16:33
- Revelation 7:13–17

Contextual Note:

The relationship between the destruction of Jerusalem, the great tribulation, and the final time of trouble is interpreted differently among Christian traditions.

Question 4 — What Is the Time of Jacob's Trouble?

Answer:

Jeremiah 30:7 describes a day of exceptional distress for Jacob.

The passage also declares that Jacob will be saved out of it.

In its original historical and literary context, Jeremiah 30 forms part of God's promises concerning the restoration of Israel and Judah.

The prophet announces hope beyond captivity, suffering, and national distress.

The expression Jacob's trouble therefore belongs first to the prophetic message of restoration.

Seventh-day Adventist theology applies this language typologically to the final experience of God's faithful people.

Within this interpretation, the end-time remnant will pass through a period of intense spiritual anguish while awaiting divine deliverance.

Adventists connect this experience with Jacob's struggle at Peniel in Genesis 32.

Jacob feared the approach of Esau and wrestled through the night, seeking God's blessing.

His experience becomes an illustration of earnest prayer, repentance, dependence upon God, and perseverance.

However, Jeremiah 30:7 does not explicitly identify the final crisis described in Revelation.

The Adventist application is typological and theological.

The central lesson is that God's people may experience deep distress while remaining dependent upon His promise of deliverance.

Bible References:

- Genesis 32:22–32
- Jeremiah 30:1–11

- Hosea 12:3–6
- Daniel 12:1
- Luke 18:1–8
- Revelation 7:13–17

Historical and Doctrinal Note:

Jeremiah's original context concerns Israel and Judah. Its application to the final experience of Christians is a further interpretive step.

Question 5 — What Is the Relationship Between the Close of Probation and the Final Time of Trouble?

Answer:

The Bible teaches that humanity is called to respond to God's grace through repentance and faith.

It also presents a future judgment in which the final destiny of human beings is revealed.

Revelation 22:11 contains a solemn declaration concerning the condition of the unjust and the righteous.

This passage appears near the conclusion of Revelation, shortly before Christ's announcement of His coming.

In Seventh-day Adventist theology, the close of probation refers to the conclusion of the period during which human beings may change their final allegiance.

Adventists understand this event as preceding the seven last plagues and the final phase of the time of trouble.

They also connect it with the completion of Christ's heavenly ministry.

According to this interpretation, the final crisis occurs after humanity's ultimate decisions have been made.

However, Scripture does not provide a specific date for the close of probation.

Nor does Revelation 22:11 explicitly describe the entire chronological framework developed in Adventist theology.

The Bible also does not authorize Christians to declare that a particular living individual is beyond the reach of God's mercy.

The appropriate response is to accept the Gospel today and remain faithful to Jesus Christ.

Bible References:

- Isaiah 55:6–7
- 2 Corinthians 6:1–2
- Hebrews 3:7–15
- Hebrews 9:27–28
- Revelation 15:1–8
- Revelation 16:1–21
- Revelation 22:11–12

Doctrinal Note:

The close of probation is an Adventist theological concept developed through comparison of several passages. Its exact timing is not revealed in Scripture.

Question 6 — What Role Will Worship and Allegiance Play in the Final Crisis?

Answer:

Revelation 13 describes a conflict involving religious authority, deception, and enforced worship.

The chapter portrays powers demanding allegiance and restricting those who refuse to comply.

Revelation 14 responds with a call to worship the Creator and remain faithful to God's commandments and the faith of Jesus.

These passages emphasize the importance of worship and loyalty.

In Seventh-day Adventist theology, the final crisis centers upon allegiance to God's authority rather than to human religious systems.

Adventists connect this conflict with the Sabbath commandment and their interpretation of the mark of the beast.

They understand the final test as involving coercive religious observance.

However, Revelation 13 does not explicitly identify the mark of the beast as Sunday worship.

That conclusion arises from the Adventist interpretation of Daniel 7, Revelation 13 and 14, and the biblical Sabbath.

The passage's explicit warning concerns worship demanded by powers opposed to God.

The Christian response must remain grounded in faith, conscience, obedience, and love.

Bible References:

- Exodus 20:1–17
- Daniel 3:1–18
- Matthew 4:8–10
- John 4:23–24
- Revelation 13:11–18
- Revelation 14:6–12

Doctrinal Note:

The centrality of worship is explicit in Revelation. The identification of the final conflict with particular forms of Sabbath or Sunday legislation is a distinctive Adventist interpretation.

Question 7 — Will God's Faithful People Experience Persecution During the Final Crisis?

Answer:

The Bible repeatedly teaches that faithfulness to God may lead to opposition and persecution.

Daniel's companions faced the threat of death because they refused to worship an image.

Daniel himself was condemned because he continued to pray to God.

Jesus warned His followers that they would experience hatred and persecution.

The Book of Revelation describes conflict against those who remain faithful to God's commandments and the testimony of Jesus.

Revelation 13 portrays coercive powers threatening those who refuse to worship the image of the beast.

In Seventh-day Adventist theology, these passages indicate that God's faithful people will experience intense persecution during the final crisis.

However, Scripture does not provide a detailed description of the experiences of every believer.

Nor does it authorize speculation about the actions of specific contemporary individuals or governments without evidence.

The central biblical teaching is that loyalty to God may require courage and perseverance.

Believers are called to resist evil without abandoning love, compassion, and respect for human dignity.

Bible References:

- Daniel 3:13–28
- Daniel 6:6–23

- Matthew 5:10–12
- Matthew 10:16–22
- John 15:18–21
- 2 Timothy 3:12
- Revelation 12:17
- Revelation 13:11–17

Pastoral Note:

Biblical warnings about persecution should encourage faithfulness and solidarity with those who suffer, not hostility or suspicion toward entire religious or political communities.

Question 8 — What Is the Seal of God, and How Is It Connected With the Final Crisis?

Answer:

Revelation 7 describes angels holding back destructive winds until the servants of God are sealed in their foreheads.

The seal indicates that these servants belong to God.

Revelation 14 also describes the Lamb's followers bearing His Father's name in their foreheads.

The imagery emphasizes identity, allegiance, and relationship with God.

The New Testament elsewhere associates sealing with the Holy Spirit.

Paul teaches that believers are sealed with the Holy Spirit of promise.

In Seventh-day Adventist theology, the final sealing is connected with the believer's settled loyalty to God.

Adventists associate the Sabbath with this loyalty because the fourth commandment identifies God as the Creator.

However, Revelation 7 does not explicitly define the seal as the Sabbath.

The relationship is established through comparison with Exodus, Ezekiel, and other passages.

The central biblical teaching is that God's people belong to Him and are called to remain faithful.

The sealing imagery should strengthen trust in divine grace rather than encourage claims of spiritual superiority.

Bible References:

- Exodus 20:8–11
- Ezekiel 9:1–6
- Ezekiel 20:12, 20
- Ephesians 1:13–14
- Ephesians 4:30
- Revelation 7:1–4
- Revelation 14:1–5

Doctrinal Note:

The New Testament explicitly connects spiritual sealing with the Holy Spirit. The identification of Sabbath faithfulness as a distinguishing feature of the final seal is an Adventist prophetic interpretation.

Question 9 — What Does It Mean to Stand Without an Intercessor During the Final Time of Trouble?

Answer:

The Epistle to the Hebrews teaches that Jesus Christ is the believer's great High Priest.

He intercedes for those who come to God through Him.

His priestly ministry is founded upon His perfect sacrifice.

In Seventh-day Adventist theology, the final time of trouble follows the completion of Christ's heavenly intercessory ministry.

Adventists sometimes describe this period as a time when God's faithful people will stand without an intercessor.

This expression requires careful explanation.

It does not mean that believers become independent of Christ or cease to depend upon His righteousness.

Nor does it mean that His sacrifice loses its saving power.

Within Adventist theology, the expression refers to the completion of the mediatorial phase of His heavenly ministry after the final decisions concerning human allegiance have been made.

The faithful remain entirely dependent upon the grace and righteousness of Jesus Christ.

However, the New Testament does not explicitly state that believers will experience a future period described in these precise terms.

The concept belongs to the Adventist synthesis of sanctuary theology and eschatology.

The central biblical assurance remains that salvation is possible only through Jesus Christ.

Bible References:

- John 15:1–5
- Romans 8:31–39
- Hebrews 4:14–16
- Hebrews 7:25
- Hebrews 9:24–28
- Hebrews 10:11–23
- Revelation 15:5–8
- Revelation 22:11–12

Doctrinal Note:

The expression standing without an intercessor is characteristic of Adventist eschatology. It must never be interpreted as teaching salvation through human perfection apart from Christ.

Question 10 — What Can Christians Learn From Jacob's Struggle at Peniel?

Answer:

Genesis 32 describes Jacob's experience before his reunion with Esau.

Jacob feared the consequences of his earlier actions and the possibility of conflict with his brother.

During the night, he wrestled with a mysterious man.

The narrative concludes with Jacob receiving a blessing and a new name.

The prophet Hosea later refers to Jacob's struggle in connection with prayer and supplication.

The experience illustrates the importance of repentance, perseverance, and dependence upon God.

Jacob did not obtain security through superior physical strength.

His hope rested upon divine mercy.

In Seventh-day Adventist theology, Jacob's struggle is understood as a type of the final spiritual anguish of God's people.

The faithful are portrayed as persevering in prayer and trusting God's promises during severe distress.

However, the original narrative concerns Jacob's personal experience and the continuation of God's covenant purposes.

Its application to the end-time crisis is typological.

The spiritual lesson remains valuable: believers should seek God earnestly and trust His faithfulness even when circumstances appear

overwhelming.

Bible References:

- Genesis 32:3–32
- Psalm 34:17–19
- Psalm 50:15
- Hosea 12:3–6
- Luke 18:1–8
- Hebrews 11:21
- James 5:16–18

Spiritual Note:

Jacob's experience teaches perseverance and dependence upon divine mercy. It should not be used to suggest that anxiety or spiritual anguish is necessary evidence of genuine salvation.

Question 11 — What Promises of Protection Does God Give His Faithful People?

Answer:

The Scriptures contain numerous promises of God's presence during danger and suffering.

Psalm 46 describes God as a refuge and strength.

Psalm 91 portrays divine protection amid pestilence, danger, and destruction.

Isaiah speaks of God's care for those who trust Him.

Daniel 12:1 announces the deliverance of God's people during the extraordinary time of trouble.

These passages provide hope and encouragement.

However, the Bible also records the suffering and martyrdom of faithful believers.

Stephen was killed because of his testimony.

The apostles experienced persecution.

Revelation acknowledges the suffering of the saints.

Therefore, divine protection must not be interpreted as a universal promise that Christians will never experience physical harm.

In Seventh-day Adventist theology, God's final deliverance is understood as certain even when believers experience severe distress before Christ's return.

The greatest promise is not the absence of every earthly danger.

It is that God will fulfill His saving purposes and grant eternal life through Jesus Christ.

Bible References:

- Psalm 46:1–11
- Psalm 91:1–16
- Isaiah 41:10–13
- Isaiah 43:1–3
- Daniel 12:1–3
- Matthew 10:28–31
- Romans 8:35–39
- Revelation 7:13–17

Pastoral Note:

God's promises should encourage trust without implying that those who suffer illness, violence, or loss have lacked sufficient faith.

Question 12 — How Are the Seven Last Plagues Connected With the Time of Trouble?

Answer:

Revelation 15 and 16 describe the seven last plagues.

These judgments occur within the book's portrayal of the final conflict between God and the powers of evil.

The plagues affect those associated with the beast and Babylon.

The sixth plague includes the gathering of the kings of the earth for the final conflict.

The seventh culminates in extraordinary disturbances and the judgment of Babylon.

In Seventh-day Adventist theology, the seven last plagues are understood as occurring during the final time of trouble after the close of probation.

Adventists believe that God's faithful people remain on earth during this period but are not the objects of the plagues directed against the rebellious world.

They may nevertheless experience fear, hardship, persecution, and distress.

However, Revelation does not explicitly present a complete narrative identifying the experiences of every faithful believer during each plague.

The Adventist chronology is developed through comparison with Daniel 12 and other prophetic passages.

The central biblical message is that divine judgment will bring rebellion to its conclusion and that God's people have hope in His final victory.

Bible References:

- Daniel 12:1
- Revelation 7:1–4
- Revelation 14:9–12
- Revelation 15:1–8
- Revelation 16:1–21
- Revelation 19:11–21

Prophetic Note:

The connection between the seven last plagues and the final time of trouble is central to Adventist eschatology. The detailed chronology remains an interpretation of multiple passages.

Question 13 — What Does the Bible Teach About God's Final Deliverance?

Answer:

Daniel 12:1 promises deliverance for God's people.

The passage identifies those whose names are found written in the book.

The following verse speaks of resurrection, with some awakening to everlasting life and others to shame and everlasting contempt.

The New Testament develops the hope of resurrection and final salvation through Jesus Christ.

Jesus promised to return and receive His followers.

Paul taught that the dead in Christ will rise and that living believers will be gathered to meet the Lord.

Revelation describes the final defeat of evil and the establishment of God's everlasting kingdom.

In Seventh-day Adventist theology, the final deliverance occurs through the intervention of Jesus Christ at His Second Coming.

Adventists connect this event with the conclusion of the time of trouble and the resurrection of the righteous.

However, the precise sequence of every prophetic event is interpreted differently among Christian traditions.

The essential biblical assurance is that the final destiny of God's people rests upon the saving power of Jesus Christ.

Bible References:

- Daniel 12:1–3
- John 5:28–29
- John 14:1–3
- 1 Corinthians 15:51–57
- 1 Thessalonians 4:13–18
- Revelation 19:11–21
- Revelation 21:1–5

Doctrinal Note:

The promise of divine deliverance is explicit in Daniel 12. Its detailed integration with the Second Coming and resurrection belongs to broader Christian eschatology.

Question 14 — How Can Christians Develop the Faith and Character Needed to Endure Trials?

Answer:

The New Testament teaches that Christian endurance grows through faith, dependence upon God, and the transforming work of the Holy Spirit.

Jesus instructed His disciples to abide in Him.

Paul described the importance of prayer, perseverance, and the armor of God.

James taught that trials can develop patience.

Peter encouraged believers to remain steadfast in faith despite suffering.

These teachings reveal that spiritual preparation is not primarily a matter of predicting future events.

It involves developing a living relationship with Jesus Christ.

Prayer strengthens dependence upon God.

Bible study provides knowledge of His promises.

Obedience expresses love and faithfulness.

Christian fellowship provides encouragement and mutual support.

Compassionate service develops practical love.

In Seventh-day Adventist theology, these qualities are essential for those who expect to face the final crisis.

However, believers should not assume that they must achieve spiritual perfection through their own efforts.

Christian growth remains dependent upon divine grace.

The purpose of preparation is to deepen trust in Jesus Christ and cultivate faithfulness in daily life.

Bible References:

- John 15:1–10
- Romans 5:1–5
- Galatians 5:22–25
- Ephesians 6:10–18
- Philippians 1:6
- Philippians 2:12–13
- James 1:2–4
- 1 Peter 1:3–9
- 2 Peter 1:3–11

Practical Note:

Spiritual preparation should encourage healthy Christian growth, not fear-driven perfectionism or constant anxiety about future events.

Question 15 — What Is the Central Message of Hope in the Time of Trouble?

Answer:

The central message of the final time of trouble is that God remains faithful to His people.

Daniel 12:1 does not end with the announcement of distress.

It announces deliverance.

Jesus also promised His followers that He would return.

The New Testament teaches that nothing can separate believers from the love of God in Christ Jesus.

Revelation concludes with the victory of God, the destruction of evil, and the creation of a new heaven and a new earth.

These promises place the final crisis within the larger story of redemption.

The last word does not belong to persecution.

It does not belong to the beast, Babylon, or Satan.

It belongs to Jesus Christ.

In Seventh-day Adventist theology, the time of trouble is a solemn period of final testing and divine deliverance.

Yet the believer's confidence must remain grounded in Christ rather than in personal strength.

The Christian hope is not merely survival through a future crisis.

It is eternal life in the presence of God.

Therefore, the appropriate response is faith, perseverance, obedience, humility, and love.

Bible References:

- Psalm 46:1–11

- Isaiah 43:1–3
- Daniel 12:1–3
- John 14:1–3
- Romans 8:31–39
- 1 Thessalonians 4:13–18
- Revelation 7:13–17
- Revelation 21:1–5
- Revelation 22:12–17

Spiritual Note:

The final crisis must be understood in the light of Christ's victory. Biblical prophecy calls believers to hope and faithfulness rather than despair.

Chapter Summary

The Bible describes a time of extraordinary trouble associated with the final conflict between good and evil.

Daniel 12:1 announces both the severity of the crisis and the certainty of God's deliverance.

Jesus warned His followers concerning tribulation, deception, and persecution.

Revelation portrays the final conflict over worship and allegiance, the seven last plagues, and the ultimate victory of Jesus Christ.

In Seventh-day Adventist theology, these passages are connected within a prophetic framework involving the close of probation, the time of Jacob's trouble, the final sealing, the seven last plagues, and the Second Coming.

Several aspects of this framework are distinctive interpretations rather than explicit statements contained in a single biblical passage.

Our study enables us to retain the following teachings:

1. Daniel 12:1 describes an extraordinary time of trouble and promises the deliverance of God's people.

2. Michael is identified in Adventist theology with Jesus Christ, although other Christian traditions understand him as a distinct angelic being.

3. The great tribulation described by Jesus has been interpreted in both historical and future contexts.

4. Jeremiah's expression Jacob's trouble is applied typologically by Adventists to the final spiritual distress of God's people.

5. Adventists understand the close of probation as preceding the final phase of the time of trouble.

6. The final conflict over worship and allegiance is central to the Adventist interpretation of Revelation 13 and 14.

7. God's faithful people may experience persecution because of their loyalty to Him.

8. The seal of God signifies belonging to Him and is connected with Sabbath faithfulness in Adventist theology.

9. The expression standing without an intercessor belongs to Adventist sanctuary theology and must not imply salvation apart from Christ.

10. Jacob's struggle at Peniel illustrates repentance, perseverance, prayer, and dependence upon divine mercy.

11. God's promises of protection provide hope without guaranteeing freedom from every earthly suffering.

12. Adventists understand the seven last plagues as occurring during the final time of trouble.

13. God's final deliverance is associated with the victorious return of Jesus Christ.

14. Christian preparation involves prayer, Bible study, obedience, perseverance, love, and dependence upon the Holy Spirit.

15. The central message of the final crisis is the faithfulness of God and the certainty of salvation through Jesus Christ.

Doctrinal Conclusion

The doctrine of the final time of trouble reveals the seriousness of the conflict between good and evil.

The Scriptures describe a world in which humanity is called to choose between faithfulness to God and allegiance to powers opposed to Him.

Daniel 12:1 announces a period of extraordinary distress.

Yet the same passage promises deliverance.

This combination of warning and hope is essential to understanding biblical prophecy.

The Final Time of Trouble

The Bible describes an extraordinary period of distress associated with God's final intervention.

Michael, the Great Prince

Michael stands for God's people. Seventh-day Adventists identify Him with Jesus Christ in His role as heavenly defender.

The Great Tribulation

Jesus warned His followers concerning persecution, deception, and severe suffering.

The Time of Jacob's Trouble

Adventists apply Jacob's experience of spiritual struggle to the final anguish of God's faithful people.

The Close of Probation

Adventist theology understands the final crisis as following the completion of humanity's opportunity to change its ultimate allegiance.

The Conflict Over Worship

Revelation emphasizes the importance of faithfulness to God in the face of coercive religious authority.

The Seal of God

God's people belong to Him and are called to remain faithful through the power of the Holy Spirit.

Christ's Saving Grace

The faithful remain entirely dependent upon the righteousness and saving work of Jesus Christ.

The Seven Last Plagues

Adventists understand these judgments as occurring during the final period of distress.

The Promises of Divine Protection

God remains faithful to His people even when they experience suffering.

The Final Deliverance

Jesus Christ will bring the conflict to its conclusion and fulfill His promises of salvation.

The Christian's Preparation

Believers are called to develop faith, perseverance, humility, love, and dependence upon God.

The Hope of Eternal Life

The final goal of redemption is everlasting fellowship with God in His restored creation.

The doctrine of the time of trouble must never be separated from the Gospel.

It should not produce spiritual arrogance.

It should not encourage hostility toward people of different beliefs.

It should not become an excuse for unsupported predictions or fear-driven speculation.

Instead, it should strengthen the believer's relationship with Jesus Christ.

The Scriptures reveal a Savior who understands suffering.

He endured rejection, persecution, and death.

Through His resurrection, He conquered the grave.

Through His heavenly ministry, He continues to provide the assurance of salvation.

Through His promised return, He will bring the reign of evil to its end.

The final crisis therefore does not eliminate Christian hope.

It demonstrates the importance of placing that hope entirely in Jesus Christ.

The Essential Message:

The Holy Scriptures describe a time of extraordinary trouble associated with the final conflict between good and evil. Daniel 12:1 promises that God's people will be delivered, while the New Testament calls believers to perseverance, faithfulness, and hope in Jesus Christ. Seventh-day Adventist theology connects the final time of trouble with the close of probation, Jacob's struggle, the seal of God, the seven last plagues, and the Second Coming. These connections form a distinctive prophetic interpretation that must be distinguished from the explicit statements of individual passages. The central biblical assurance is that God's faithful people are not abandoned: their salvation rests upon the grace, righteousness, and victorious power of Jesus Christ.

Personal Reflection Questions

1. What does Daniel 12:1 teach about the relationship between extraordinary distress and divine deliverance?

2. Why is it important to distinguish the biblical description of Michael from theological interpretations concerning His identity?

3. How should I understand the relationship between Jesus' warnings about tribulation and the final crisis described in Revelation?

4. What spiritual lessons can I learn from Jacob's struggle at Peniel?

5. Why should the doctrine of the close of probation never be used to declare that a particular living person is beyond God's mercy?

6. How can I remain faithful to God while respecting the religious liberty and conscience of others?

7. What does the seal of God teach about belonging to Him and depending upon the Holy Spirit?

8. How can I understand Christ's completed heavenly ministry without losing confidence in His saving grace?

9. What practical habits can strengthen my faith, patience, compassion, and spiritual perseverance today?

10. Why should the final time of trouble strengthen my hope in Jesus Christ rather than fill my heart with fear?

Suggested Prayer

Lord my God,

I come before You with reverence, gratitude, and humility.

You are the Creator of heaven and earth.

You are holy, righteous, merciful, and faithful.

Your promises are trustworthy, and Your love endures forever.

Thank You for revealing Your saving purposes through the Holy Scriptures.

Thank You for the assurance that evil will not reign forever.

Thank You for the promise that Jesus Christ will return in glory.

Above all, thank You for the gift of salvation through Your Son.

I acknowledge that my hope rests entirely upon His grace and righteousness.

Thank You for His sacrifice upon the cross.

Thank You for His resurrection and victory over death.

Thank You for His continuing ministry as my heavenly High Priest.

As I study the final time of trouble, give me wisdom and understanding.

Help me examine the prophecies of Daniel and Revelation carefully.

Teach me to distinguish the clear teachings of Scripture from human interpretations and speculation.

Protect my heart from unnecessary fear and anxiety.

May the study of prophecy strengthen my trust in You.

When I encounter uncertainty, remind me of Your faithfulness.

When I experience suffering, help me remember that You have not abandoned me.

When my faith is tested, give me courage to persevere.

Teach me to pray with sincerity and confidence.

Help me follow the example of Jacob by seeking Your mercy and trusting Your promises.

Forgive my sins and transform my character through the Holy Spirit.

Strengthen my love for Your Word.

Help me obey Your commandments through faith and gratitude.

May my obedience never become a source of spiritual pride.

Teach me humility, compassion, patience, and kindness.

Give me respect for the conscience and dignity of every human being.

May I never use biblical prophecy to condemn or mistreat others.

Instead, help me proclaim Your truth with love.

Strengthen those who are suffering persecution because of their faith.

Comfort those who are afraid.

Encourage those who are discouraged.

Help me serve the vulnerable and care for those in need.

Prepare my heart for the glorious return of Jesus Christ.

Teach me to live faithfully today rather than becoming consumed with predictions about tomorrow.

May my confidence remain in the Savior who has conquered sin and death.

Thank You for the promise of resurrection.

Thank You for the hope of eternal life.

Thank You for the assurance that Your kingdom will triumph.

Until the day when Jesus Christ appears in glory, help me remain steadfast in faith, constant in prayer, and faithful in love.

May my life bring honor and glory to Your holy name.

In the name of Jesus Christ, my Savior, Defender, and coming King.

Amen.

GENERAL CONCLUSION — FROM REVELATION TO HOPE

At the end of these forty-one studies, one conviction runs through our entire journey: the Holy Scriptures bear witness to God and present Jesus Christ as the center of the plan of salvation.

The Bible reveals the eternal Creator, the dignity of human beings made in His image, the seriousness of sin, and the love of God calling humanity to reconciliation. It teaches that salvation cannot be purchased by works or earned by observing a religious practice. It is received by God's grace through faith in Jesus Christ. A life of obedience, repentance, service, and sanctification flows from that grace; it is not its price.

God's commandments reveal His will and direct us toward love for God and our neighbor. Within the doctrinal understanding adopted in this book, the seventh-day Sabbath, Saturday, remains the biblical day set apart for rest and worship in remembrance of Creation. This conviction should be lived out faithfully, without contempt for those who understand the matter differently.

The study of the Church's life reminds us that spiritual gifts, prayer, responsible stewardship of resources, health, moral conduct, and evangelism are intended for service and witness. The Church is called to proclaim truth with love, help those who suffer, and respect freedom of conscience.

The final chapters have examined death, resurrection, the millennium, judgment, the three angels' messages, the heavenly sanctuary, the seven last plagues, and the time of trouble. These subjects involve prophetic interpretations distinctive to Seventh-day Adventist theology. They should be studied seriously, distinguishing direct statements of Scripture from conclusions reached by comparing several passages. Prophecies are not given to foster fear or

speculation, but to call us to watchfulness, faithfulness, and hope.

The final word of biblical history is neither sin, nor death, nor distress. It is God's victory and the restoration of His creation. The promise of Jesus Christ's return and that of a renewed earth give Christian life its horizon of hope.

The journey of this book therefore does not end with its final page. It invites every reader to continue studying the Bible personally, to test the teachings received in the light of the texts, to pray sincerely, and to put understood truth into practice.

May our knowledge lead to humility, our faith to love, our hope to perseverance, and our expectation of Christ's return to a life of faithful service.

“Even so, come, Lord Jesus.” — Revelation 22:20 (KJV).